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I.1 A Piece of Lava on the Moon

It would be easier to convince most people to consider themselves a piece of lava on the moon than a self.

Those who are not in agreement with their self in this sense will not understand any comprehensive philosophy nor to they need to. Nature, whose machine they are, will lead them without their participation in everything they must do. To philosophize, one must be independent, and independence is granted only by one's self. We should not desire to see without eyes, but neither should we assert that it is only the eye that sees.

J. G. FICHTE

Julius Evola, who was a close student of German philosophy, took up this theme, when he claimed that most people are not the active agent of their lives, but they are “lived” by larger forces. Yet, we are constantly surprised by how often this proves true. While few people believe they

are pieces of lava on the moon, there are large numbers of people who readily believe they are pieces of earth matter, or thinking meat, or electro-chemical processes, or the result of some sort of mechanical evolution. There is a remarkable ability to deny or avoid the self.

As Johannes Tauler wrote: “If I were a king and did not know it, I would not be a king.” So, if I am a Self and do not know it, I am not a Self. So, keeping in mind the identity of Knowledge and Being, I am a Self if and only if I know myself as a Self.

Posted on 2010-06-16 by Cologero

1.2 Philosophic Idealism

It is easy to be unaware that up until World War II, idealism was the dominant philosophical position of Europe. In the 18th and 19th century, the Germans — particularly Kant, Hegel, Fichte, Schelling, Schopenhauer — took the leading role in its development. Later, the Britons such as Green, Bradley, Bosanquet, Collingwood took it in their own direction. In France, it usually went by the name of personalism or spiritualism. In Italy, while Evola was a young man, philosophy was dominated by the idealists Benedetto Croce and Giovanni Gentile. It’s hard to believe that at their peak, they were world-renowned philosophers. Although friends and collaborators, they split over the question of Fascism. Gentile was for a while the education minister and his philosophical system was very influential in moulding the intellectual roots of Fascism.

Yet idealism was not a modern development; the mainstream of Western philosophy is the history of idealistic thought. When the European orientalists began studying, translating, and cataloguing the early Indo-Europeans systems of the Vedas, its compatibility with idealism was noted. So, idealism can rightly be seen as “our” tradition and competitors such as nominalism, positivism, and materialism are more like a persistent anti-

tradition. I would recommend the short book *Nobilitas* by Alexander Jacob for a summary of this tradition from Plato until World War II. Ironically, Prof. Jacob is an Indian who is keeping the Western philosophical tradition alive, when Europeans are abandoning it.

Evola was heir to this tradition and his intellectual development took place in the milieu of Italian idealism in the 1920s. In order to study idealism thoroughly, Evola learned German so he could read the philosophical sources in their original language. Out of his studies, he created his own system which he named “magical idealism”. In *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*, Evola ties together the main elements of his system. One can perhaps recognize Schopenhauer when Evola speaks of in the world as will and representation, or Stirner in the idea of the Absolute Ego, and Plotinus in the idea of privation and the evil of matter.

But Evola was not content in outlining an abstract intellectual system. Ultimately, there can be no system per se, since what is important is the will and the development of its freedom to create, remake, and define the world. This means that without having made the effort at self-transformation through the various phases of consciousness, then his system cannot be properly comprehended. So ultimately, Evola’s system cannot be reduced to a set of propositions to learn and memorize. Nor is there any technique, drug, or practice that will develop the will and lead to higher stages of consciousness.

In our day, when “tough minded” thinkers are drawn to science and materialism (the neo-Darwinist Richard Dawkins was recently “voted” the most intelligent man in Britain), the claims of idealism can seem incredible. Since Evola simply assumes a basic familiarity with this tradition, it may be difficult sometimes to see what he is getting at. For those new to idealism, I would recommend *The Philosophy of Schopenhauer* by Bryan Magee for a clear overview of the presuppositions and methods of idealism. Whether or not Evola adds to this tradition in a coherent and constructive way is for each man — who has made the requisite effort —

to decide.

Posted on 2008-06-08 by Cologero

* * *

Jason-Adam on 2013-03-25 at 09:16 said:

Does Gornahoor still stand by this ?

Cologero on 2013-03-25 at 13:21 said:

Granted, Jason-Adam, that was an early post and it probably would not be written the same way today. In the inquisition, the inquisitor would pick out sentences that required explanation or justification. It seems fair enough. So, instead of a vague question, which sentences would you like explained? Most of it is bland and refers to historical movements or facts. Is there a factual error?

The intent was to relate it to Evola's method in particular. Is that paragraph perhaps problematic?

Jason-Adam on 2013-03-25 at 13:49 said:

The words idealism and realism can be construed differently – as Platonism can be described as both by different authors.....so when you describe idealism as our tradition and realism as the anti-tradition....what do you mean ? by realism do you mean Plato ?

idealism not a modern development.....by idealism do you mean the doctrine that earthly forms are merely reflections of heavenly realities or do you mean the system derived from Kant ?

Cologero on 2013-03-25 at 21:21 said:

A reader should make a good faith effort to read an article in the best possible light. In that case the article is clear enough, although perhaps I would now describe "positivism and materialism" as the anti-tradition to make it clearer. I am somewhat satisfied with the wikipedia definition of Idealism¹ as:

idealism is the group of philosophies which assert that reality, or reality as we can know it, is fundamentally mental, mentally constructed, or otherwise immaterial.

¹<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Idealism>

The intent is not to define that tradition exactly, but rather to put Evola's philosophy of Magical Idealism within it. That is worth commenting on. Perhaps it should be read in conjunction with *The Great Divide and our Ownmost*².

Obscure Lifeform on 2014-12-05 at 19:21 said:

The term 'realism' only has a relative or contingent meaning. Idealism and materialism are properly speaking the two sides of the Cartesian equation of 'subject' and 'object'. For Descartes what constitutes the 'objectivity' of an object is the capacity to be measured, quantified and mechanized by a human 'subject'. Most materialists after Descartes were usually just mechanical scientists who accepted Cartesian objectivity as the appropriate manner of describing scientific activity and its primacy as regards knowledge. Kant on the other hand locates objectivity in self-consciousness, which for him means moral behavior; thus the Cartesian 'subject' is primary since objectivity is derived from self-reference. Kant also lays out the new meanings for terms like 'realism', 'idealism', 'transcendental' etc. which are understood in these ways by all academics after him. Also, after Kant we see an obsession with applying these labels anachronistically to many diverse thinkers and doctrines of the past. This 'categorizing' tendency brings one on to Hegel and all later thinkers who generalize and filter the past for their own ends or as Hegel writes; "Thinking is generalizing".

Realism in the medieval sense stands in contrasting relation to nominalism. The realist asserts that universal essences (Platonic ideas) are real or fundamentally real and knowable; Thomism is a realist doctrine which asserts that universal essence are real and knowable, but only within the confines of personal experience, hence Thomas is often labelled a 'moderate realist' or 'Aristotelian realist', platonic realism would be exemplified by the neoplatonists and medieval Augustinians. An important Platonist who also wrote at the end of the medieval era was Denis the Carthusian of the 15th century; he produced commentaries and histories of medieval thought, often blaming the downfall of medieval intellectuality on Duns Scotus and William of Ockham. Denis admired Thomas Aquinas, but was avowedly a disciple of Henry of Ghent and Pseudo-Dionysius.

Nominalists on the other hand believe that only the particular essences of individual substances are knowable or real, thus psychologizing all general concepts. For the nominalist, everything is in reality absolutely particular. I'm sure you can see how this leads to pure quantification and Descartes' thought.

Cologero on 2014-12-21 at 11:44 said:

I'm not quite sure of your intent, Obscure Lifeform; I presume you are clarifying some classifications. If so, I would add this:

²<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=2244>

The theory [of the Scholastics] is described not as idealism, but as realism; but this does not imply that they are in conflict with the doctrine of Augustine; it means rather that the ideal principles possess real validity, that as ideas they subsist in the Divine mind before the things corresponding to them are called into existence, while, as forms and essences, they really exist in nature and are not really products of our thinking.

Source: Idealism <http://www.newadvent.org/cathen/07634a.htm>

I don't think I understand how "knowing" could be separate from the personal experience of knowing.

1.3 Knowledge and Love

Originally published in 2006.

Jack and Jill were playing and fetching water one day, when Jack had this sudden realization:

"I love you", he said to Jill.

This is the essence of metaphysical intuition, not in the sense of a gut feeling or hunch, but of a direct and positive realization. Direct because it is not mediated — it is an immediate realization. Positive because it is absolutely certain knowledge. Note, too, that this example demonstrates that knowledge = being. Jack's knowledge of his love is identical with a change of his being from "not loving" to "loving".

Notice how the "modern" mind looks at knowledge:

I think I love you.

This is Jack the philosopher. It's an interesting theory, but Jill is not impressed.

I believe I love you.

Jack may have reasonable grounds for his faith, but Jill has her doubts.

I get this funny feeling in my stomach when I'm with you.	No, Jack, that feeling is not your stomach. Don't confuse lust with love.
My E-17 neuron in the left cortex has released 7 mg of endorphins.	The materialist. What Jack calls "love" is simply an electrochemical event in his brain. "Love" is folk psychology and such talk will give way to sci- entific descriptions just as astrology has yielded to astronomy.
You remind me of my mother.	Does anyone still read Freud? Did anyone truly believe it?
You look like sound ge- netic material.	Of course, the biologist tells us the selfish genes want to reproduce, even if only half of them get a chance. "Actually, Jill, Judy over on yonder hill has good genes, too, but her father won't let me near her." And Jack came tumbling down. Won- der why?
I don't want a power re- lationship.	"Sensitive" Jack has been reading postmodern literature on "love" as a disguise for patriarchal oppression of women. This is what we mean by "mediated".

Posted on 2011-04-11 by Cologero

* * *

Zmaj on 2011-04-12 at 00:58 said:

One more:

"I love you Jill, by the will of my will" – Jack the magus. Will it last?

1.4 The Philosophy of the Future

The heart has its reasons that reason does not know.

BLAISE PASCAL

Evola and Gentile During **Julius Evola's** youth, **Giovanni Gentile** was the grey eminence of philosophy in Italy, not just in a university setting, but also close to the seat of political power. He was the epitome of the cultured European, incorporating the whole of philosophy, art, literature, and history into his comprehensive system, which he named "actualism". So Evola's attack on Gentile was an attack on the Italian political, intellectual, and educational edifice. Gentile never responded personally to Evola's critique, but instead allowed his student **Ugo Spirito** to address the issues raised by Evola. But the first issue to consider is the fundamental aim of philosophy, and this is where the two minds differ. Gentile's first political post was the Minister of Education, which he used to reform the Italian school system. Evola's goal was much higher:

If Gentile could truly name the I as the "pure act" of his rationalism, then he would appear not as the university professor, whose "actualism" has the reform of the educational system as its goal, but rather as that cosmic centrality that the esoteric reveals in the types of the rishi, the yogi, Christ, and the Buddha.

So Evola's real objection is that Gentile sells himself short; the I, in its self-actualization, should have as its goal to become a rishi, yogi, Christ, or Buddha. This, then, is the logical development of actualism that Gentile somehow missed. While Evola's system has some defects, the goal is worthy.

To describe that goal, Evola has to incorporate elements of Oriental thought, for example, if Atman is Brahman, then how does that affect philosophy? The influence of Friedrich Nietzsche is also strong, since it is now impossible to be a philosopher without dealing with his withering critique of the decadence of Western thought and spirituality. This we will address in the next section.

Ultimately, Evola never developed the philosophy of magical idealism, certainly not to the point of developing more Christs and Buddhas. Even

during the fifties and sixties, when allegedly there was a stream of young men who consulted with him, no one arose to carry on that philosophy. By then, I suppose, idealism was a non-starter as the basis for a philosophical system, and people were looking for less abstractions, turning instead to political and religious solutions to the problems posed.

Evola himself, having first promoted a philosophy of action, resorted to passivity as in the aristocrat of the soul and riding the tiger. Of course, while every Tom, Dick, and Harry nowadays claim to be an aristocrat of the soul, the rishis are still hard to find.

The Philosopher of the Future If magical idealism is not the philosophy of the future, then we are still waiting for the philosopher of the future. Those with a sound intellect should aspire to this, and not be content with the comfortable life of writing clever and erudite journal papers. Aside from Kant, the great philosophers developed their view of life in their twenties. So start now, you can always revise it.

Now there are three claimants to the knowledge of ultimate reality: the *Priest*, the *Philosopher*, and the *Prophet*. Borrowing an insight from **Valentin Tomberg**, we can say that the philosopher works in the day through the light of reason, the prophet in the night through direct illumination from God, and the priest is the mediator between the light and the darkness. The philosopher of the future will probably be in tension with the other types, while still needing to incorporate their insights.

The philosopher must first deal with facts, then an understanding of the facts, and finally indicate how that affects our lives. The fundamental facts have been summarized by **Arthur Schopenhauer**: the world as will and idea. Here we find the Traditional doctrine of the two worlds of being and becoming³. The “world” referred to is that of becoming, and the “idea” is the world of being. Here are some examples.

³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=7147>

Plato, and the lineage following him, called the will “eros”, i.e., the drive or “love” of wisdom. Wisdom, for him, is to know the world of being. For Nietzsche, this overvaluing of the “other” world in Plato and in the Christianity which built on Platonic ideas, led man away from his true calling of being fully loyal to the earth. There is no other worldly afterlife beyond this world, but only its endless repetition. The Will to Power replaced eros. In denying the world of being, Nietzsche denies God, or better, God, for him, is yet to come.

As a Traditional thinker, Evola opposed Nietzsche’s biologism, while incorporating his more important insights. While not denying the world of being, he changed man’s relationship to it. First of all, he retained Nietzsche’s emphasis on will and action; this, as we have seen, brought him into conflict with Rene Guenon. Now action can be understood in two ways. The conventional way is to see it as “horizontal”, i.e., as activity wholly in the world of becoming. A deeper way is to understand it “vertically”, i.e., as the actualization of potentialities. In this way, Evola can claim that it is insufficient to *know the truth*, one must also *will the truth*. This implies absolute freedom.

The philosopher of the future can build on this. A rishi, or a seer, is more like a prophet than a philosopher. Hence, he must learn to think with his heart as well as with his head. If the goal of philosophy is to bring God’s presence into the world, then he must learn to do that himself. To be free means to have no sufficient reason outside oneself, so the philosopher must be free. Since for God, essence and existence coincide. Hence, the philosopher of the future must actualize all his possibilities. Now we mean the philosopher is God-like in the relative, not the absolute sense. How that is so, will be the task of this philosopher to explain.

The Religion of the Future The religion of the future will be based on gnosis. This is not a new religion, but rather a deeper understanding of what religion is and means. In other words, it is the actualization of

religious or spiritual understanding. This is reflected in various states of consciousness, both psychological and spiritual. I am not making this up and have amply documented how this has always been the case.

There are two false claimants to the religion of the future: one is to alter it to bring it into conformism with modernity, the other is to repeat the religious forms of the past. Now there is no problem with the second option for those who are satisfied with it. But the prophet of the future will write a large book on the phenomenology of the soul.

2018 Postscript In a recently published collection of letters between **Wolfgang Smith** and Fr. **Malachi Martin**, there is this intriguing comment from Prof. Smith:

If the Greek Fathers could integrate Plato and Neoplatonism into the Christian worldview, and St. Thomas Aquinas could do the same for Aristotle, why should it not be possible, in our day, to correct and somehow “Christianize” Hegel, let us say, or Schelling, or even Nietzsche? Is there not in each of these German “Titans” a certain spark of truth that needs to be brought out, to be “liberated”?

That would be a good task for a young scholar. The starting point, of course, would be **Jacob Boehme**, the father of German Idealism. Also, **Vladimir Solovyov**, who has already adapted Schelling into his system.

Posted on 2014-06-26 by Cologero

* * *

seeker on 2014-06-26 at 13:25 said:

You bring to mind Fr. Seraphim Rose's book (Orthodoxy and the Religion of the Future)? He gave the term a decidedly pejorative connotation, referring specifically to New Age syncretism,

one of the false claimants, “bringing it into conformism with modernity”. But he was also critical of Hinduism, saying that the yogis experience during meditation are mere psychic phenomena and not real spiritual knowledge.

The book was obviously not meant for the “rishi, yogi, Christ, or Buddha”. In this letter he refers to the Kali Yuga by name, which leads me to believe there is more to his thought than one would gather from the above mentioned book.

<https://sites.google.com/site/phoenixlxineohp2/lettertoareaderofreneguenon>

Ash on 2014-06-27 at 00:31 said:

Concerning the relationship of the philosopher to gnosis: would such a person have already attained such a high state of existence themselves? Or would they be showing the way as travelers themselves? I suppose two tests for such a philosopher would be a) are they practicing a living exoteric tradition, and b) are they old enough to have gained wisdom over time. So anyone starting now in their twenties ought to be preparing themselves for that.

Cologero on 2014-06-27 at 00:44 said:

Seeker, I have not read that particular book, but I had previously read the letter you linked to. Obviously, I am being a bit tongue in cheek and am not advocating anything like New Age ... actually quite the opposite if read carefully. Don't forget that Fr Rose also warned against “super-correctness”⁴, and we have been criticized many times by the super-correct. The problem today is one of a worldview. There was an earlier time when men could think with their heart and were acutely aware of the reality of the other world of being. But now, such a mentality is utterly alien to most men, so an intellectual conversion of some sort is necessary. So the way forward is actually a recovery, but at a deeper level. That is because a man who has had to work for something appreciates it more than the man for whom it came without effort.

I have been planning a post on the mental and spiritual states of the yogis, but much preparation is required. Ultimately, it will be up to the prophet of the future to make such distinctions. Now Fr Rose was totally into Guenon before he was not, so it is legitimate to speak to the former class of men as well as to the post-Guenon men. Careful readers will need to sort it out.

Cologero on 2014-06-27 at 07:45 said:

As I pointed out, Ash, most great philosophers developed their philosophy in their youth ... I suppose we can find examples and counter-examples. But the philosopher is a just “lover of wisdom” and so is not necessarily “wise”. There are ultimate facts and the philosopher tries

⁴http://orthodoxinfo.com/ecumenism/fsr_63.aspx

to understand them in the light of his own reason. The best are not daunted by the complexity and enigmas of reality. In our time, there are new forms of escapism, even more insidious than the decadent Christianity that Nietzsche or Evola opposed.

These forms of escapism are obvious enough to name. First are the so-called “new atheists”, who believe science and a narrowly conceived rationality can account for all of reality. The other is new age political correctness which through shaming and self-deception tries to enforce a worldview involving beliefs that no well-bred and healthy-minded man could have believed in previous eras.

So, this imaginary philosopher would have to challenge those forms of escapism and describe a worldview in which the quest for gnosis “makes sense”. So, yes, a man in his twenties ought to be preparing for that, “as if”, before his mind stagnates.

Mr Zero on 2014-07-02 at 14:18 said:

Cologero I am surprised at the mistake you've made in this article: “Evola himself, having first promoted a philosophy of action, resorted to passivity as in the aristocrat of the soul and riding the tiger.” But *Ride the Tiger* contains an action-based philosophy; the crux of it is knowing oneself and then testing oneself through experiment & rupture (particularly in the chapters 10 Invulnerability & 11 Acting Without Desire). In other words the sort of Left Hand Path he previously advocated in Yoga of Power.

Cologero on 2014-07-05 at 13:11 said:

Perhaps, Mr Zero, you are correct that my language was somewhat strong and misleading, and I do not want to leave the impression that there is no value in those later works. But I had in mind a particular context, and my comment needs to be taken within it. The fact is that essays in Magical Idealism (which incorporates the Yoga of Power) has as its aim the creation of rishis, yogis, etc. That is why he includes the Three Trials, which is really out of place in a book of philosophy since it should depend on discourse and the light of reason alone. The takeaway is that magical idealism cannot be understood without performing the concomitant spiritual exercises.

Evola never, as you correctly point out, abandoned that as *rhetoric*. My point is that he was never able to complete that project beyond rhetoric into being, even though he seems to have had the opportunity. Instead, as we see from his correspondence with Guenon over the years, he was always pursuing marginal hermetic figures, and never developed magical idealism as a spiritual movement in itself; hence no rishis, yogis, Buddhas, or Christs ever arose out of it.

Mr Zero on 2014-07-06 at 20:31 said:

Cologero thank you for showing the connection of his concept of the trial with his earlier philosophical period, something I hadn't realized before.

When I read your answer, especially “no rishis, yogis, Buddhas, or Christs ever arose out of it” the first thing I thought was – how does he know? How could any of us know? We would only know if the Buddhas chose to show themselves. They might not want to. It doesn’t necessarily follow that once a Buddha attains enlightenment he will want to manifest into history. I’m not arguing either way, just pointing out the difficulty in this kind of statement.

From what I understand Evola’s vision of awakened ones manifesting into history took the form of an initiatic military order more than anything. Sedgwick and Goodricke-Clarke link this to influence over terrorist groups in Italy, but there isn’t much available in English to clarify the specifics. In any case it doesn’t reflect well on his position at all.

1.5 The God of the Metaphysicians

Even as regards those truths about God which human reason could have discovered, it was necessary that man should be taught by a divine revelation; because the truth about God such as reason could discover, would only be known by a few, and that after a long time, and with the admixture of many errors.

Summa Theologiae, I.I.I

Any “dualism”, whether of the theological order like that attributed to the Manicheans, or of the philosophical order like that of Descartes, is a radically false conception.

RENE GUENON

It is said that St Jerome was severely chastised for preferring to read the pagan philosophers rather than Sacred Scriptures⁵. So it is with some caution that I turn to the pagans, not to commend them, but rather because such writings have been a great part of my

⁵<http://catholicharboroffaithandmorals.com/St.%20Jerome.html>



own personal equation. In particular, I am interested in those systems that assume the intelligibility of the world through thought. These have been known as “Absolute Idealism” or “Monism”. We prefer the first term, not always used in the strict sense; moreover, they have more of a “family resemblance” and not a totally common teaching. In short, it represents the Platonic thread in philosophy rather than the Aristotelean. **Joseph Marechal**, in *Studies of the Psychology of the Mystics*, compares it to a strict monotheism as the foundation of a certain type of mysticism.

It is easy to forget that up until a century again, it comprised what was properly called philosophy for educated men. Other systems of thought, e.g., materialism, naturalism, etc., are not really philosophies since they deny the primacy of thought. From Plato and Plotinus, it was revived with the German thinkers. The British then adapted their own version, e.g., with T H Green, Francis Bradley, Bosanquet, etc. A century ago, it was dominated by the Italians Benedetto Croce and Giovanni Gentile. Julius Evola, who learned German in order to study the German idealists, was also an Absolute Idealist. Even Rene Guenon, although he disdained profane philosophy, had points in common with such systems.

The neglect of Absolute Idealism has allowed inferior ideologies to take hold among the educated classes. Often, the only alternative to such ideologies are crudely expressed dogmas of the exoteric religions, which seem incredible to most educated folk. Hence, such writings have a three-fold purpose for us.

- Idealism provides an intellectually sophisticated alternative to naturalism, materialism, and modernism.
- It is a “halfway house” between atheism and theism.

- It provides a safeguard against anthropomorphic and other misconceptions about God. Some idealists identify the Absolute with God, while others do not.

Surprised by Joy C S Lewis was one such person who journeyed from atheism to Absolute Idealism to theism, which he described in *Surprised by Joy*. *The Magdalen Metaphysicals* describes the intellectual climate at Oxford during Lewis' time there.

The Vindication A recent promoter of Absolute Idealism was **Timothy Sprigge**. He provides an updated defense of it in the *Vindication of Absolute Idealism*. In *James and Bradley* and the *God of Metaphysics*, Sprigge provides a helpful survey of rationalist and idealist philosophies. In the latter book, he outlines how such a metaphysical system might relate to religion. Unfortunately, I cannot review that chapter here. However, those who have a religious sensibility, but are turned off by the various alternatives available, may gain something from such an abstract presentation.

Self-Realization Following Bradley, Sprigge claims that self-realization is the goal of life. Of course, that makes sense if we interpret that in Guenon's notion of the actualization of all of man's possibilities, including the transcendent possibilities. Ultimately, that is, self-realization is the realization of the Self.

Panpsychism Sprigge defends panpsychism, which is the view that the world consists of experiences. For him, there is no dead, or unexperienced, matter, everything is alive. A more recent example, using a different argument, is *Mind and Cosmos* by **Thomas Nagel**, which is reviewed here⁶.

⁶<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8373>

Thus, life, consciousness, and thought do not arise from matter, since the psyche is a fundamental component of the cosmos. Guenon makes a similar claim, since he includes life as one of the irreducible elements of the world.

Infinite Minds In *Infinite Minds: A Philosophical Cosmology*, **John Leslie** derives a system from Plato's idea of the Good. **Hugh Rice**, in *God and Goodness*, develops that idea more fully. He claims that the Scientific Outlook and Objective Values prove the existence of God. Rather than oppose God to Science, Rice claims that the scientific outlook requires three beliefs, which transcend the objects of scientific study:

1. A belief in order
2. A belief in rationality
3. A belief in intelligibility

Then, he demonstrates that there is objective value in the world. From that, he concludes that since it is good for the world to exist, then it necessarily exists.

Leslie builds on Plato, Spinoza, Bradley, and others, to create an idealist system. Interestingly, he acknowledges the problem I mentioned at the top: how can you make such metaphysical ideas comprehensible to the modern mind?

Trying to introduce ideas like these in the twenty first century and in the West, one never knows where to start. The points I want to make could seem entirely natural to a traditionally educated Hindu, or to Hegelians such as Bradley, or to a physicist such as David Bohm, who speculated that all the parts of our universe form a collective mind of some sort; yet they can easily be dismissed as preposterous, for all kinds of powerful reasons. ... One

has to paint a huge picture at speed, conscious that every brush-stroke can earn raised eyebrows, incredulous stares, or worse. One has to do this because the elements in the picture make sense only when seen as a whole. From which it follows, unfortunately, that whatever one begins with can look outlandish.

Leslie identifies the things in the world as “the structures of various thoughts in the divine mind”. He goes on to claim that “when God contemplates various physical possibilities in full detail they do not remain merely possible... they are genuinely real, existent, actualized, non-fictitious.”

Readers here will recognize these as Guenon’s “possibilities of manifestation”, which, in Medieval metaphysics, are ideas in the Divine Mind. So what goes around, comes around. Unfortunately, the work is marred by an inadequate understanding of metaphysical Infinity. For this, a reading of Guenon will go a long way to correct.

To get back to the main point, which is that the world exists because it is good for it to exist. This recalls Bonaventure’s journey to God, which surpasses Being to reach the Good. Bonaventure claimed that it is better for something to exist than not to exist. Here Leslie and Rice seem to be in agreement with Bonaventure.

Nevertheless, for many that proposition may not be so obvious. For example, the Buddha claimed that all life is suffering and Schopenhauer asserted that it would be better not to exist. In our own time, abortion and euthanasia are promoted on the grounds that it would be better for some lives not to exist. This topic deserves extended treatment, but in the meantime, meditate on the Wheel of Fortune Arcanum in the Tarot.

The Idealist View of Life That is the title of a book by the Indian philosopher **Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan**. Radhakrishnan reframes Indian thought in the terms of Western systems of Absolute Idealism. He does that more thoroughly in the two volumes of *Indian Philosophy*,

quoting Bradley, Gentile, inter alia. In the previous century, European scholars tried to grasp Hindu philosophy in Western terms. Radhakrishnan turns the tables, evaluating Western philosophy in how well it corresponds to Indian thought. His student, **T R V Murti**, did the same for Buddhism in *The Central Philosophy of Buddhism*.

Guenon recommended the study of Eastern thought as the preliminary stage in the recovery of Tradition in the West. Thinkers like Radhakrishnan, Murti, Aurobindo Ghose, and others, may be a good place to start.

Takeaway Obviously, there are many important topics that had to be excluded in this short survey. Some, including Marechal's work on mysticism⁷ and Nagel's on the philosophy of science⁸, will appear in upcoming posts. However, there is plenty of material to get started on an understanding of the Absolute, the infinite, cosmic Order, Intelligibility, and Rationality, the Objective Value of Existence, and the goal of Self-Realization.

Posted on 2015-11-03 by Cologero

* * *

themaelstromscup on 2015-11-04 at 12:47 said:

I may suggest *The Elements of Metaphysics* by Paul Deussen, which is available for free on Google Books. Duessen was a follower of Kant and Schopenhauer, as well as an early Sanskrit scholar and friend of Nietzsche. There's much to be learned from Schopenhauer if one disregards his pessimism, which wasn't a logical consequence of his system and is easily disentangled therefrom. The aforementioned book is a veritable catechism of Transcendental Idealism informed by Greek, Christian, and Indian Tradition.

Cologero on 2015-11-04 at 17:25 said:

⁷<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8467>

⁸<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5088>

@Maelstrom,

My intent was to focus on recent philosophers writing in English. Nevertheless, I welcome your suggestion.

aegishjalmer on 2015-11-04 at 19:48 said:

This post makes me think of a few other points.

First of all, on the problems of explaining and justifying Idealism, and even philosophy or religion to people today: I think of Hilaire Belloc and his book *Heresy* in which he concludes that modernity is the realm of the half educated, where the masses have been brought up at the expense of the top, which has been brought down. Guenon puts it similarly in the *Reign of Quantity* where he speaks of the dynamic of blocking the supernatural and opening up the subnatural, while Nietzsche speaks of people not being able to think properly, think things through.

When you consider the conditions under which people are born, the propaganda, false education and spurious myths, and centuries of decline in various ways (Evola), in which the struggles of Europe via war (etc) leave nowhere to start, you can see why Guenon recommended the East as a starting point, rather like the Pauline idea of the Gentiles being grafted onto the tree of Israel.

Recently this occurred to me as being an essential part of spiritual growth, and I bought a few kindle books on this exact thing. They look at what a normal human life should be from the point of view of Tradition. I had the distinct intuition that a large part of our problem today is that we have half conscious instincts and spiritual needs that feed on traditional archetypes but are blocked and distorted through ignorance (which amounts to saying the normal human condition of the fall has become modernity's life and is affirmed and justified by it in a negative response to God's grace, although perhaps it has to do with how Tradition in the West has developed historically as well), or need proper forms in order to work at all, rather like Jung and his view of dry river beds needing new streams to flow through them (see his essay *Wotan*). The books were:

1. The four aims of life in the Tradition of Ancient India by Alain Danielou
2. The Four Goals of Life: a survival guide for the Kali Yuga by Cynkay Morningsong

David Ravel on 2015-11-05 at 15:03 said:

Since I am not very well versed in those thinker, I hope this question is not ill-received.

I always thought that Idealism, when speaking of Plato, was actually a bad translation: it came from the translation of *ousias* into *idea*, which gave rise to a misconception because in actuality, Plato is a realist (*ousia* being real), not an idealist (*ousia* being in the mind (*ideation*) of the subject) such as Kant.

When we speak of idealism here, do we speak of Kant or of Plato ? If we speak of both, how do they relate since Kant is an inversion of Plato in the subject/object relationship ?

I am confused a bit by all those distinctions. What are we speaking about here when we speak of absolute idealism ? Thank you.

Cologero on 2015-11-05 at 17:54 said:

@David, as I mentioned: "These have been known as "Absolute Idealism" or "Monism". We prefer the first term, *not always used in the strict sense*"

I am not interested in picky philosophical disputes. The point is that reason and thinking have been the foundation of Western philosophy until recently. By the way, I never mentioned Kant, who was not an "Absolute" idealist. For Plato, the Absolute was the Good.

When I get to the review of Marechal's book on the mystical states associated with various philosophies, the purpose may become clearer.

Cassiodorus on 2015-11-05 at 23:56 said:

According to Guenon, following Shankara, the fundamental distinction is between Atma and Maya, or the Absolute and the relative. On this view, the personal God who creates and sustains the universe is on the "maya side" of the Absolute/relative divide. But, as I understand it, the classical theist does not admit of this "maya in Divinis" doctrine, insisting that the fundamental distinction is between the Creator and the created. I think Christianity may be compatible with a qualified nondualism like that of the kind espoused by Ramanuja, but I think the unqualified nondualist traditions are basically patronizing to theists.

obscure on 2015-11-06 at 00:53 said:

Cassiodorus,

One of the fundamental distinctions in Aquinas and the other schoolmen is between the imperfect infinity of matter and the perfect infinity of God. This imperfect infinity of matter ('indefiniteness' if you prefer) consists of its being simply determinable and only possessing determination in complexity, whereas God possesses determination simply (self-determination, *aseitas*). Matter is like a subject without any subjectivity except insofar as it is determined as an object of God. I doubt I needed to even write this much nor shall I add any further explanation since I assume that any competent reader understands all that follows.

Cassiodorus on 2015-11-06 at 10:30 said:

Obscure, I appreciate your input. I also apologize if my comments betoken an "incompetence". I only desire to understand. For the record, I came to the Christian position by way of the Perennialist writers. I've often wondered why Guenon and Schuon never cited figures such as Ramanuja and Madhva. Are their objections to Advaita without merit?

David Ravel on 2015-11-06 at 11:51 said:

@Cologero

My goal was not to start a philosophical debate, but rather to understand where I should look into. You did not mention Kant, but others did in other occasion, which lead to my confusion. I'm trying to learn.

Cologero on 2015-11-06 at 20:13 said:

I'm not necessarily recommending any of these sites, but they may be of interest for further research.

Vivekananda wrote this short piece on Paul Deussen. Vivekananda was the major influence on Radhakrishnan. Guenon did not approve of V for some reason. Nevertheless, his book on Jnana Yoga brings up many of the same themes that interested Guenon.

The Swedish philosopher Janolof Bengtsson creates an interesting blend of absolute idealism, tradition, and paleoconservative authors like Russel Kirk and Irving Babbitt. An example is *The Case for Idealism*. He writes:

what I mean when I speak about and defend idealism – as I do when I speak in terms of Western philosophy, trying to remedy the lamentable situation – is also an idealism of this original, metaphysical, spiritual and, as it were, uncompromising variety. An idealism that is defined by the affirmation of this absolute truth about God-Being.

In *Idealism as Alternative to Modernity*, he writes:

The optimal resources for the formulation of the idealist contribution to an alternative modernity therefore seem to me to be those of personal idealism or personal **absolute idealism** in its most advanced forms. And as I always point out – both because of the way in which I myself became an idealist and for the sake of corroborating my argument for the universality of these issues – there are from the beginning, despite, or beyond, the obvious difficulties of translation and interpretation, *striking similarities with the Western debates between absolute and personal idealists in the Vedanta tradition in the East*.

It may not be widely known that Anthroposophy sees its roots in Plato, Aristotle, and Thomas Aquinas. Its goal is to unite the Platonic and Aristotelian streams of thought.

Here is an homage to Timothy Sprigge: Timothy Sprigge: The Last Idealist. Read it with caution since Sprigge held non-traditional ideas. Nevertheless, his main influence – Spinoza, Schopenhauer, and Santayana – were coincidentally important to my own early development.

David Ravel on 2015-11-07 at 08:40 said:

@Cologero

Thank you for those suggestions.

You said earlier that you focused on English philosophers. What would you suggest in French regarding idealism ?

Cologero on 2015-11-07 at 09:36 said:

Oh là là, M. Ravel, you've hit upon a favorite topic of mine!

There is Émile Boutroux, often quoted by Evola. Not to overlook the more famous Henri Bergson, who was a favorite of Valentin Tomberg.

In France, that type of philosophy went by the name of "philosophy of spirit" or "spiritualism" (nothing to do with seances as it might mean in English).

The main figures are Louis Lavelle and Rene Le Senne.

I assume you know of Maurice Blondel? (whose philosophy of action was known to Evola).

Finally, Lucien Laberthonniere. He insisted that ideas "must be lived", not just thought about. In Christian Realism and Greek Idealism (*Realisme chretien et idealisme grec*), he addresses your initial question. He understands "idealism" as the intellectualistic heritage of Greek thought, including both Plato and Aristotle (although he finds shortcomings in that tradition). You see that is also how I have been using the term.

I don't know why the way of thinking represented by the philosophies of spirit and action has been so neglected.

David Ravel on 2015-11-07 at 13:40 said:

@Cologero

I must say that I know very little of contemporary philosophy. Younger, I had read Nietzsche and Schopenhauer, and was content with that. After reading the 'traditionalists', I only read medieval philosophy and Plato/Aristotle.

I must say that now I've also read Kant, Husserl, Ricoeur and a few others, but I had stopped at Kant regarding any kind of idealism, which I thought was very shortcoming (not including the works of Evola on the matter).

I will read those authors you suggested, especially those french since it is my mother tongue.

Thank you.

Mark Citadel on 2015-11-08 at 13:10 said:

I really connect with what you're saying here about the intelligibility of the world, for it was through such arguments that I actually came to Christianity. How do you think one can reconcile mysticism in Christianity with the very logical approach to the world common to Catholic apologetics in particular? Can we successfully marry the intelligible and the mystical?

Cologero on 2015-11-08 at 16:50 said:

As Guenon put it, "mystical experience" may be super-rational, but certainly not irrational. A follow up to this post will be a review of Joseph Marechal's *Psychology of the Mystics*. He shows how one's worldview relates to the experience of the world. Specifically, he will contrast Absolute Idealism with Theism.

Then, of course, there is Bonaventure's *Journey of the Soul to God*, in six stages. An early stage is the realization of the intelligibility of the world.

Olavsson on 2015-11-15 at 12:45 said:

Re: Mysticism:

From certain reflections by Guenon that I read rather recently, it would seem that his attitude to mysticism was sceptical. He gives the impression of not having regarded mystical experience very highly. (I refer to the first two chapters of 'Perspectives on Initiation'. He admitted that it had its place within Tradition as a whole, and might be a spiritual path suited to the nature and possibilities of a particular type of man, but that ultimately, it is a 'passive' approach to spirituality deprived of the properly initiatic elements that would constitute a certain method for actively overcoming the mortal human condition through the interior realization of higher states. But as far as I can see, this need not necessarily imply that all of the 'mysticist' features must definitely be excluded, only that an exclusively mystical approach is insufficient and has serious limitations in the case of one specifically aiming for gnosis. (Speaking only for myself, I have great respect for some historical mystics.) The same, of course, is true for the strictly rational and intellectual approach, whether we think of theology or philosophy. This point has been stressed more than once in articles on this site. Rather than simply rejecting such approaches, the esoteric path would integrate in order to surpass. Every faculty and function of the being should, then, be ordered into proper alignment so as to fully serve the spiritual work that is our one absolute purpose in this life, so that all levels of inner activity initially infected by a profane condition are progressively 'sacralized' and mastered in an elevated expression.

I shouldn't forget to thank Cologero for the recommendation of these useful philosophers. They are noted down for future research.

Re: Murti's 'The Central Philosophy of Buddhism': Seeing that the author is a Hindu and not one initiated into actual Buddhist schools (unless I'm very mistaken), would you say that his work offers an understanding of Madhyamika that most contemporary Buddhist-adherents of

Madhyamika would see as objective and traditional? All the nuances of the various interpretations and approaches to Mahayana philosophy and metaphysics are still unclear to me. It is a diverse tradition.

A quick thought on 'panpsychism': If not integrated into a vertical metaphysical order, such a concept may easily just get stuck on the level of maya-samsara or the pantheist mentality.

[Cologero quote:] "Nevertheless, for many that proposition may not be so obvious. For example, the Buddha claimed that all life is suffering and Schopenhauer asserted that it would be better not to exist." [...]

Depends upon the context in which life is evaluated. For an existing being, which is a manifested positive, if I may put it that way, the confrontation with nothingness, non-being, the negative hole in being, the unconscious, the dissolution into lower darkness, has always been cause for much instinctive anguish, perhaps the primordial anguish itself. From this point of view, it is clearly better to be, rather than lose oneself in what is less real. However, existence and life itself becomes the object of privation, of negativity, the negation of what is more Real, when compared to the Absolute, the Unconditioned, the Unborn principle. It is when the emanation from that Origin, the positive creative downward flow causing the perpetual cyclical movement of the cosmic 'samsara', is opposed in order to move against the stream as an active return to the Origin, that the natural cycle of conditioned existence becomes the enemy, the problem. That life must necessarily have suffering as an inherent component is inevitable, independently of whether one subscribes to Buddhist views specifically. Every being that is limited by external conditions, that is in need of things, and subject to change, will eventually experience suffering as a consequence of these conditions. That life as such implies suffering seems to be beyond reasonable dispute. The question is rather whether this fact must lead us to conclude that life is bad or even evil (as some gnostics believed), instead of being a positive creative reality that due to its inevitable relativity, limited conditions and multiplicity of possibilities must have as one of its consequences suffering, and yes, even evil. That these conditioned modes of existence equal suffering is a good motivation for heroic spiritual struggle aimed at transcendental freedom, but obviously there is more to the cosmic manifestation than that alone. The very possibility of attaining within life the supreme awakening into illumination and liberation, affirmed by the Buddha, should perhaps make us realize that life, even if ordinarily trapping us in a circle leading away from this supreme state rather than towards it, also is what we choose to make of it. Those who desperately resign in front of life and take their own lives, for example, perhaps in the hope that they will achieve a nothingness that is preferable to the suffering of existence, would be wiser to welcome their suffering as an invitation to transcend their miserable condition by entering the ascending path in life, which is one of the possible ways to actively give form to life determined by a superior principle. Then the blindfold of illusions will fall away, and we will no longer be subject to slavish reactions following from relying upon ever-changing impressions of relative conditions, but will have elevated the centre of our existence to the highest Truth

without which life is indeed meaningless.

Cologero on 2015-11-18 at 18:26 said:

“Mysticism” has a range of meanings, but I would agree with the formulation you made. In the upcoming post on the psychology of mysticism, the texts I am relying on confirm what you said about it. Of course, Guenon was a jnani, so “knowledge”, or “realization”, is what counts, not some beautiful or unusual experiences.

The thing about Murti is that he was familiar with Guenon. His conclusion that the Madhyamika may be more suitable as the universal vehicle for tradition instead of the Vedanta is certainly worth considering. He wrote:

Mahayana absolutism and the Advaita Vedanta are valuable as providing the basis on which a world-culture can be built. It is only absolutism that can make for the fundamental unity of existence and at the same time allow for differences. Catholicity of outlook and tolerance of differences are their very soul; both insist on the universality of the Real and transcendence of the ego-centric standpoint. The Vedanta, however, is traditional in outlook and is bound to the authority of the Veda, and perhaps it presupposes a specific milieu in which alone it can thrive. The Mahayana is quite liberal, and it has proved its capacity to accommodate itself to various religious and social structure, to revitalise and absorb them.

Your paragraph on suffering proves – perhaps inadvertently – the point. In the realm of Thought, the cosmos seems perfectly ordered and rational. However, for the Will, it is much more problematic as it encounters obstacles and faces up to its own weaknesses. The Will is individualized.

Max on 2016-06-29 at 12:29 said:

I took hold of this line, that in order to see the world as not just random happenings “one has to paint a huge picture at speed”. This comes down to conceptions. If someone is not able to see that for themselves, it is very difficult to paint that picture for them. One can help by pointing in the right direction, but having someone explain it by a sort of step by step process does not really do it in the end, since it has to be seen as a whole. To a large extent this comes down to one's capacity to dwell on large or multiple things simultaneously. The better one is able to do this the more sense things will make. I am not sure to what degree this is by nature, but it should at least be possible to improve upon it by training. For example I read about someone who was intrigued by other people saying they could dream in colour although he could not. By

determination and effort he then managed to reach the same degree of “visualization-power”. So an improvement in conceptual areas like this is definitely possible, but it does not come by itself, meaning that someone who is perfectly happy with regarding the world as some random hell will not get out of that view unless they actually wish to do so. Most people make up their mind about something and then by solidification becomes impossible to reach no matter how many indications to the contrary. In the actual world of conflicting wills this then translates into a kind of hell since everyone is determined to concede nothing to anyone else, and holds firm that they alone are correct.

However if there is no purpose, why is it so important to hold on to ones own opinions in the first place? Could they not just vote on which opinion is correct and then stick to it? It seems as if they have already tried that approach but it does not work out very well since they take some kind of pride in always having different opinions, which means that the natural distribution, in a mechanical fashion, always tends towards the greatest diversity, while at the same time resulting in the largest possible number of people feeling oppressed by the other half. I always wondered why in almost every “free election”, the margin for victory is just a few points, rather than say 90-10. This just shows that what is debated has nothing to do with reality, since if the right answer was immediately obvious to everyone, we would not need to vote in the first place. What this means is that when people think we need to vote on something, that means that they do not understand the issue, and if they do not understand it, they should have no say in it, demonstrating how the very idea of voting is a joke from the beginning. In a responsible society the options should rather be something like this: either I understand something in which case I would not agree to merely “vote on it”, or I do not understand it in which case I would not agree to vote on it for fear of messing up.

1.6 Matter and Subtle Bodies

The purely biological or scientific standpoint falls short in psychology because it is intellectual only. But the psychic phenomenon cannot be grasped in its totality by the intellect, for it consists not only of meaning but also of value, and this depends on the intensity of the accompanying feeling-tones. The affective value gives the measure of the intensity of an idea, and the intensity in its turn expresses that idea’s energetic tension, its effective potential.

CARL JUNG, *Aion*

The common illusion of many is the claim that they respect “facts”. Facts are value-neutral because they are grasped by the intellect which presumably judges impartially. However, facts involving humans elicit a meaning, to which a value is attached. Then a positive valuation is pursued and a negative one is eschewed. Hence, the valuation is accompanied with a more or less strong emotion.

Few are able to separate the intellectual content of a fact from its meaning and valuation. The result is usually a strong negative emotion like anger, fear, worry, depression, etc., which is falsely attributed to the “fact”. They fail to see that the meaning they believe they see out there is entirely subjective. So they fail to understand the real reason for their upset. Often it is because they only see the past thereby missing the experience of the present.

To sum up: *Thought* leads to *Feelings* leads to *Will*. If your thoughts are incorrect, you will feel bad and do the wrong thing.

Naturalism Naturalism is the theory that all existence can be explained in terms of the motion of particles. These theories go at least as far back as the Pre-Socratics and is still popular today among the educated. For example, see the physicist Sabine Hossenfelder⁹ discuss free will. She adds the wrinkle of differential equations which presumes that reality is continuous.

Motion requires time and space. So naturalism admits three preconditions for manifestation—space, time and matter—but denies two others: form and psyche (or life, consciousness, intellect).

One Plato fixed things by understanding the missing two. There are no things without a form to distinguish them. The accidental arrangements of matter or particles cannot create a new form. Rather, matter participates in a form. Hence he was led to believe in a realm of Forms or

⁹https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zpU_e3jh_FY

Ideas. The highest of the Ideas is the idea of the One, which is also the greatest good.

Things have more being, or power, as they participate in the One. That is, the oneness is essential to the thing. Natural kinds like a tree, a squirrel or a human being have a natural unity. However, humans are internally divided, being inconsistent from day to day; they make and break promises, change their minds, are full of doubts, and so on. Said differently, they do not possess a true Self which would give unity to their being. As a person works to become more unified in consciousness, he becomes more like the One, i.e., he has “more being”.

Artifacts, on the other hand, do not have an inner unity. Rather, their unity is imposed “from the outside”, i.e., by a human designer. Automobiles, can openers, toilets, and androids are artifacts.

Subtle Matter Traditional teachings recognize several levels of being, from prime matter to more subtle levels, such as the astral or ethereal levels. Wolfgang Smith recognizes that physicists have discovered a level above prime matter, populated with subatomic and atomic particles, but below the corporeal level of macroscopic objects; they are intimately related, yet independent. On the one hand, it is certainly possible to conceive of a physical world devoid of any actual corporeal things, and on the other to conceive of corporeal objects apart from the physical level. For example, the “resurrection body”, for all appearances, looks like a physical body, yet does not follow the laws of physics.

Such subtle realms used to be part of common knowledge, but not so much today. “Only matter is real,” they say. But now what matter “is” is not so clear. Matter is equivalent to energy, being condensed energy, yet there is no non-circular definition of energy.

If we turn to quantum mechanics, then according to Schrödinger’s equation, matter is ultimately in a state of indeterminacy; that is, it is nothing in particular. But that is what the ancients believed, even without

the famous equation. How it becomes specific macroscopic things is rather unclear (the so-called measurement problem).

General Relativity does not help much, since it denies any force called “gravity”. Rather, massive objects distort the geometry of the universe by creating holes in a fourth spatial dimension. No one can see that dimension, so that a straight line path in that geometry falsely appears to be attracted to such objects. So, what is the point of mass, if masses don’t exert forces on each other? The universe is just lumpy, and we experience those lumps as masses.

The Planetary Spheres In our vanity, we presume that the ancients mistakenly believed that the earth was surrounded by the planetary spheres. But is that false or are we blinded by science? Actually, physics doesn’t suffer at all if we assume that the planets revolve around the Sun or the Earth, although it could get mathematically messy. Einstein himself conceded that no theory or observation could resolve the question.

Nevertheless, Dante was one such ancient who actually described his journey through the planetary spheres. He certainly was not describing a space journey in a rocket ship or flying saucers, although it involved a flight. Dante flies in his ethereal body, which is naturally attracted to God when freed from the physical body. In a sense, then, Dante was having an “out of body experience”, although he experienced much more and in greater depth, than what is often described today in such experiences.

So we can speculate that the prime elements are not merely symbols for the physical states of matter, but actually represent different states of being:

- **Earth:** physical body
- **Water:** life body
- **Fire:** astral body

- **Air:** intellectual soul
- **Ether:** spiritual body

Posted on 2020-11-05 by Cologero

1.7 Three Saturnine Philosophers

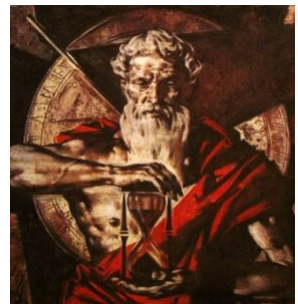
Not to laugh, not to cry, not to curse, but to understand.

BARUCH SPINOZA

Saturn is the outermost or highest planet in the cosmic order, and so is nearest to the divine source of being and closest to the angelic hierarchy. Therefore, Saturn is associated with the loftiest contemplations. Saturnians are inspired students and contemplators of highest truths. To be melancholy was a sign of genius; the ‘gifts’ of Saturn, the numbering and measuring studies attributed to the melancholic, were to be cultivated as the highest kind of learning which brought man nearest to the divine.

When I was a teenager in Stoneham, a suburb of Boston, the only bookstore in town was at the drugstore. There you could find comics, magazines, and a couple of book racks. One had self-help books from Parker Publishing, and the other rack was full of Dover reprints. There were books on mathematics, science, cryptography, logic, and philosophy; at least, those were the books that interested me.

I still have many of those books. Although I liked the philosophers of logic, science, and positivism, the most influential philosophers were Spinoza, Schopenhauer, and Santayana. They were not as simple as the others, so they required some penetration to reach them. I called them the three “esses”.



What follows are the impressions left by these thinkers. I am writing from memory, so it may not be a precise summary of their philosophies in an academic. Yet the traces they left in my mind still linger. All three followed the jnani path throughout their lives, while I took some time out to follow the path of the householder. So there was a time before, then a long period of intellectual darkness, and then the light shines again.

Essence and Presence The temptation is to believe that you understand a philosopher when you can reduce him to some preconceived categories. I claim, instead, that it is necessary to wrestle with the ideas and grasp what issues are at stake. **Baruch Spinoza's** *Ethics* is an intellectual tour de force; the effort to present a system of thought like a textbook of geometry required tremendous organization and effort. Here, we can only present his main points.

God First of all, he conceives of the Whole, which he calls God. As the Whole, it cannot be dependent on anything else. Moreover, it is necessary, infinite, and self-caused. As such, he is not deviating from the classical understanding of God. Since God is infinite, there cannot be two gods.

He refers to God as a substance, the only substance, in fact, and the only substance that can even be conceived. Sometimes he refers to “God or Nature”, which some interpret as pantheism. But Nature is not the physical or material world, as we understand it. Rather Nature is the opposite pole to God. Envision a vertical axis with God as essence as the north pole and Nature as the south pole. All that means is that, for God, essence and existence are the same, again a tradi-



tional understanding.

Attributes An attribute is anything that can be predicated of a substance. Since God is the only substance, He has attributes, which express His essence. Spinoza claims that there is no limit to the number of God's attributes, although he identifies just two. Following Rene Descartes, these are:

1. **Extension:** This attribute applies to bodies and includes its size, shape, place.
2. **Thought:** This attribute applies to minds and includes all conscious experiences including sense data, emotions, images, thoughts, and so on.

In order to avoid Cartesian dualism, Spinoza claims that God or Nature can be understood under either attribute. Thus, one can understand Nature by means of matter or by thought.

Extension and Thought can best be understood as states of the Being, similar to the metaphysical distinction between the Gross and Subtle Bodies. By the Law of Correspondence, what happens at one attribute happens at the other level; the relationship, however, is not causal. As a practical matter, one may be preferable to another, depending on circumstances.

For example, consider a children's birthday party. A scientist, considering it strictly from the material point of view (Extension), will measure energy consumption and expenditure, gather auditory data, and so on. Although he can verify that the Laws of the Conservation of matter, energy, and momentum have not been violated, he will not "know" that he was observing a birthday party. Nevertheless, there are people, even educated people, who remain convinced that the world can be understood as merely the movement of atoms. String theory will never be able to predict nor to explain such a party.

The mothers and children, on the other hand, will experience various emotions and sensory stimuli. The mothers feel pride at their children and the children experience joy. They will not have violated any laws of physics at the party.

There is yet a higher way to understand things and events, but that will come later.

Modes and the Unity of Being Since God is the only substance, individual things are merely modes, which can appear as bodies or as minds. A mode has less reality than God, who alone is full real.

Spinoza here is remarkably close to Traditional metaphysics such as that described by **Shankara**. He is actually closer here to **Ibn Arabi**'s understanding of the Unity of Being. Since God is Being itself, individuals do not possess full reality; only God is fully real. Ibn Arabi was a Sufi and this is Sufi metaphysics (or, at least, that of one of its schools).

There is no place here to resolve the relationship between Being and individual beings.

The Degrees of Knowledge Like all Tradition, Spinoza identified three degrees of knowledge:

1. **Opinion:** This is our knowledge of the objects of sense and theories derived from them. This includes scientific theories.
2. **Reason:** This includes knowledge derived from thinking and logic.
3. **Intuition:** This is a direct, unmediated knowledge. Since the Whole has no parts, it cannot be fully known through reason. Instead, one must understand the Whole, or God, directly without the intervention of thought.

Sub specie aeternitatis To circle back to the birthday party, Spinoza claims to know things “*sub specie aeternitatis*”, that is, from the perspective of eternity. This is more than a philosophical theory, since Spinoza is claiming to understand things from God’s perspective. In effect, he claims to be a prophet of God.

Conatus A mode strives to persevere in being. This striving, or inner drive, is called Conatus.

Hence, physical objects do not “follow rules” or laws, rather they act out of inner necessity. Ideally, this is also true for Minds. The will is not free insofar as it is determined by some motive. In most cases, a person is unaware of the true causes of his actions. In other words, he does not know himself.

In particular, the human being is driven by emotions. These can be active or passive. This is described in Wikipedia:

the most important distinction is that between “active” feelings and “passive” feelings (or “passions”). Man, according to Spinoza, is active or free in so far as any experience is the outcome solely of his own nature; he is passive, or a bondsman, in so far as any experience is due to other causes besides his own nature. The active feelings are all of them forms of self-realisation, of heightened activity, of strength of mind, and are therefore always pleasurable. It is the passive feelings (or “passions”) which are responsible for all the ills of life, for they are induced largely by things outside us and frequently cause that lowered vitality which means pain.

When a Man is free, his actions arise from his own essence; he has transcended his passive feelings. For him, morality is no longer a matter of following rules. Rather comes from within. Of course, this requires a process of the purification of the mind, will, and emotions.

The Love of God For Spinoza, the intellectual love of God combines the highest form of knowledge with the greatest emotion. In effect, this is God contemplating himself in the being. Our love for God, therefore, is God's love for humanity.

Salvation therefore consists in a constant and eternal love of God. This is the most elevated and desirable state, and is the goal of the *Ethics*.

To be continued.

Posted on 2021-04-07 by Cologero

1.8 The Emptiness of Meaning

What is life? Its opposite is petrification, the immobile duration of the identical. Therefore, for life to exist, it is necessary to have a sequential change of non-identical states.

PAVEL FLORENSKY

In *The Meaning of Idealism*, **Pavel Florensky** develops some useful insights based on Porphyry's scheme of the spheres of being. There are four of them:

1. **Ideas:** The universal concepts that express the One and the Many.
2. **Things:** The appearance of ideas in the world.
3. **Concepts:** The knowability of things.
4. **Terms:** The expressibility of the concepts in language.

Differing philosophical solutions to the problem of universals can be described with this schema. For example, Platonic realism accepts all

four spheres while total nihilism rejects them all. Aristotelianism admits 2, 3, and 4; the Ideas exist in the Thing, not independently.

In our day, Platonic realism is pejoratively dismissed as “essentialism”. The dominant doctrine is nominalism, which denies (1) universal ideas, (2) their appearance in the world, and therefore (3) their knowability. Rather, what we know as ideas are the (4) “words” or terms that we use to describe things and events; they have no existences beyond our sense experience. Hence, knowledge is merely conventional — i.e., general consensus — not real.

That is why there is so much emphasis over words, why there is social pressure to use the “correct” word (not the most real word, but the one that is socially acceptable). For nominalism, only power is real and the control of words is tantamount to the control of the ideas that may be expressed.

Since materiality is the principle of multiplicity, nominalism renames it “diversity”. Since it cannot admit the existence of the transcendent One, the principle of Unity is the general agreement to use the same “words” as descriptors of reality. That is why nominalists all sound alike, even repeating the same phrases over and over. That is also why their method is coercion rather than rational arguments.

This represents the end of a civilization. Everything is reduced to matter, dead matter.¹⁰

Posted on 2022-03-26 by Cologero

¹⁰This is the prolegomenon to a full review of the book. [It seems that such review was never done.]

2.1 Naïve Set Theory

California has revamped its math education program by eliminating accelerated learning programs. The assumption is that anyone can learn math. A good way to test this is Naïve Set Theory. This requires no math knowledge: just the ability to count and to reason logically. A “set” is defined by the everyday understanding of the term and does not rely on abstruse concepts in mathematical logic. Hence, it can be used, in principle, for self study.

Because of its informal method, this class is typically offered by the philosophy, rather than the mathematics, department at universities. When I took it, about two dozen students showed up on the first day, possibly, I presume, because it was labeled Introduction to Logic.

Students kept dropping out until there were just three of use left. I finished with a perfect score on all the tests, because such knowledge is certain and never forgotten. The other two students were women, which demonstrates that women are capable to think logically, even if they some-

times choose not to. But those who could not think logically – or chose not to – included pre-law, political science, and journalist majors among those I recognized. That explains much.

Mathematics is intermediate between metaphysics and physics, yet is neither. There have been several mathematicians who have been great metaphysicians, and physicists who have been great mathematicians, but no one, as far as I can recall, has been all three.

The first thing to learn is that logic does not operate in a vacuum. It requires self-evident truths called “axioms” to get started. To deny an axiom makes the project impossible or results in a contradiction. This is good practice in learning to think in terms of principles rather than in terms of individual things. Understanding the set means understanding all the individuals belonging to the set.

A tricky point is to show that a set actually exists, so that sets are not merely thought experiments. Once that has been accomplished, useful manipulations of sets can begin. I don’t want to summarize them here.

Infinite Sets The most fascination result has to do with the notion of infinity, since it can be more deeply understood with the tools learned. Everyone knows the distinction between ordinal and cardinal numbers, even if you hadn’t thought of it before. Ordinal numbers are first, second, third, etc., which show order; cardinal numbers are 1, 2, 3, etc., which are used for counting. It is easy to see that the natural numbers have infinite cardinality; this is called “countably infinite”, since they can in principle be counted. However, what is not so obvious is that there are even higher degrees of infinity, called appropriately, uncountably infinite. There is then a dizzying array of infinities but not “highest” infinity. That infinity is “outside the system” altogether.

A surprising result is that every set can be ordered. Clearly, countably infinite sets can be ordered; there is always a lowest natural number, be it 1, 23, or whatever. That is not so for the real numbers. Ask yourself what is

the first real number after 1.0 and you can convince yourself. Nevertheless, it can be proved that there is an unknown order to the real numbers, but its exact nature is unknown. Albert Einstein famously said, “God does not play dice,” when confronted by the random patterns of quantum experiments. He meant that there must be a deeper theory that explains those seemingly random patterns. That assumption is that the deeper order must be computable, but that is not necessarily true. Rather, God – the True Infinity above all the infinities – knows the hidden order. We counter Einstein with this thought:

God works in mysterious ways.

Other Logics Although formal logic of the type described here is necessary, it is not sufficient to explain the world. Set theory, is nominalist rather than realist. That is, there can be a set of unrelated elements like cabbages and kings. A realist set would only contain individual things that share the same divine idea.

Moreover, our human and spiritual lives depend on an even higher form of logic. Organic logic and Moral logic will be discussed in a future post.

Reference *Naive Set Theory* by **Paul Halmos**

Posted on 2021-05-23 by Cologero

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Hugo Smith on 2021-05-27 at 19:21 said:
Could a realist universal set defy Russel's Paradox and contain itself?

Cologero on 2021-05-27 at 19:58 said:
No, because a set is always in thought and is never in being. So there is no set that you can see, feel, hear, or touch.

Hugo Smith on 2021-05-28 at 15:58 said:

Then are you saying there is no such thing as a realist set? Aren't some categories essential?

Sensitive Ears on 2021-06-06 at 17:40 said:

"There is always a numerous host of the stupid and the weak, and in a republican constitution it is easy for them to suppress and exclude the men of ability, so that they may not be outflanked by them. They are fifty to one; and here all have equal rights at the start."

"The ancient Masters

who understood the way of the Tao,

did not educate people, but made them forget."

The greatest generations lived without advanced mathematics. The question is, when people are liberated from accelerated math, what will fill that empty space in their minds? Resentment? Boredom? Video games? Critical Race Theory? Piety?

Cologero on 2021-06-07 at 22:46 said:

Hnh? Of course, the greatest generations knew advanced math. The Egyptians knew trigonometry; that is how the recovered land boundaries after Nile floods receded. Euclid knew geometry, not to mention Pythagoras. Eratosthenes knew prime numbers. Ancient India was rich in mathematics, inventing decimal numbers among other accomplishments. Arabs knew about algebra. Mathematics form two of the seven liberal arts. I could go on.

What people need "liberation" from maths? It was always for the few, and maths are so important that Plato required knowledge before being admitted to his School.

Of course, numbers, as with Pythagoras had mystical connotations. What I want to recover is that mystical dimension, to rescue maths from mechanical manipulation of symbols in order to reach the the hidden metaphysical meaning behind maths. Maths is the dividing line between metaphysics and manifestation, so its importance cannot be overstated.

Perhaps if you filled your mind with mathematics, you would write more coherent comments – not to mention factually correct comments.

2.2 Infinity, the Absolute, the Self

There are two approaches to understand logical systems:

- **Axiomatic:** A formal symbolic system with definitions and axioms. The semantic meanings of the symbols are not necessary to

understand the system; theorems are proved just by the manipulation of symbols.

- **Naïve:** The semantic meaning of the symbols are understood in their everyday meaning.

The Axiomatic method is used by mathematicians and analytic philosophers. The Naïve method is used by metaphysicians and Hermetists, for who the meaning (semantics) is more important. Hence they can use the principle of analogy to derive higher principles than what the axioms alone can prove. There are three levels of logic, each dealing with a different subject matter.

1. **Predicate of Formal Logic:** This deals with logical relationships, inferences, properties, numbers, sets, infinity, order, and so on. As such, it is confined to mental concepts, not to physical or existing things. For the metaphysician, its goal is an understanding of infinity.
2. **Modal or Organic Logic:** This deals with necessity, possibility, contingency, which means it needs to account for existing things, not merely ideas and concepts. Its goal is knowledge of the Totality.
3. **Deontic or Moral Logic:** This deals with obligation, permissibility, prohibition, commands, promises, and so on. As such, it needs to account for action in the world. Its goal is the I or Self.

Logic begins in the domain of intellectuality, but may be alchemically transformed into spirituality. Valentin Tomberg, in the Letter on the Fool, describes this process:

in the domain of the individual's inner life, it is analogous to the work of spiritual alchemy which operates on the historical plane.

This means to say that the individual soul begins initially with the experience of the separation and opposition of the spiritual and intellectual elements within it, then advances to—or resigns itself to—parallelism, i.e., a kind of “peaceful coexistence” of these two elements within it. Subsequently it arrives at cooperation between spirituality and intellectuality which, proving to be fruitful, eventually becomes the complete fusion of these two elements in a third element: the “philosopher’s stone” of the spiritual alchemy of Hermeticism. The beginning of this final stage is announced by the fact that logic becomes transformed from formal logic, passing through the intermediary stage of organic logic, into moral logic.

We dealt with Predicate logic in *Naïve Set Theory*¹. Now we deal with Organic and Moral logic. This will show that the world process can be understood on four levels:

1. What is a possibility of manifestation
2. What is necessary in the world
3. What is commanded by God
4. What is willed by God

Modal or Organic Logic Modal logic deals with the following modes of being:

- Necessary: What is necessary
- Possible: What is possible
- Impossible: what cannot be manifested

¹See Section 2.1 in this book.

- **Contingent:** what depends on something else (compossible)

As such, these all deal with the possibilities of manifestation, i.e., the Infinity of God as the beyond all the infinities of formal logic. The “impossible” are possibilities of non-manifestation. Contingent things are possibilities that can manifest only under specific conditions. In philosophical terms, necessary things must exist in all possible worlds. Better said from the metaphysical point of view, it exists in all degrees of existence.

Modal logic discovers necessary connections among the things of the world. A system can be built up through ever increasing levels of abstraction, so that more is known from fewer and fewer principles. Ultimately, this leads to an understanding of the Absolute. In these systems of Absolute Idealism, the whole is greater than its parts. For example, the community is greater than any individual.

Deontic logic also comprises mereology, which is the study of how parts are related to the whole and systems theory, which studies how systems contribute to the whole.

Deontic or Moral Logic Deontic logic deals with moral agents acting in the world. Their acts fall into four categories of what is:

- **Obligatory:** actions that are commanded or obligatory
- **Permissible:** actions that are permitted
- **Prohibited:** actions that are prohibited
- **Facultative:** actions that are morally indifferent

Tomberg illustrates how an axiom transforms through the degrees of logic:

- For formal logic, it is an axiom the whole is greater than its parts. That is because it deals with quantities, so it is true within that domain.
- Organic logic deals with functions, not quantities. Hence, although the heart is quantitatively a small part of the body, its function is necessary for the body to exist as a whole. This requires a new axiom: the part can be equal to the whole.
- Moral logic deals with values, hence the axiom is transformed to: the part can be greater than the whole. Hence, it is immoral to sacrifice one man for the good of the whole.

Morality cannot be reduced to a mechanical process of reasoning, which is the goal of deontic logic. For it to be transformed into moral logic, one must live a life of prayer and meditation. One discovers the axioms that make moral logic even possible. Tomberg points to Rene Descartes and Immanuel Kant as discoverers of those axioms.

Descartes Tomberg looks past the logical, philosophical, and psychological criticisms of Descartes in order to get at Descartes' actual experience, which is beyond such critiques. That is the awareness of the Transcendent Self that transcends both Thought and Extension. In other words, he came to the self-realization as the "thinker of thoughts", leading to complete certainty of the "I AM". The axiom, then, is:

- The Reality of the Self

Kant Kant elucidated the following three additional axioms, without which, there is no possibility of moral action:

- The Reality of God or infinite perfectibility

- The Reality of Moral Freedom or morality as such
- The Reality of the immortality of the soul or the possibility of infinite perfecting

Posted on 2021-06-03 by Cologero

Traditional Philosophy

3.1 The School of Athens

Platonism and Aristotelianism In the first millennium of Christianity thinking, Platonism was the predominant philosophical stream that nourished its spiritual practice and theology. In the West the Cathedral of Chartres was the centre for Platonic thinking under the Cistercians, a role it played up until around the year 1200. At that time, the Aristotelian schools began to develop in Paris under the leadership of the Dominicans; that outlook then came to dominate Western thought.

For the Platonist, the sensible world is the reflection of the intelligible world, man's true home. The manifest world should lead us to the realm of ideas. That is why Plato is pointing upwards in Raphael's *The School of Athens*. Aristotle, Plato's pupil, emphasizes knowledge of the sensible world, hence is portrayed pointing down.

Rudolph Steiner makes this comment about these two streams of thought.

Aristotle's view of the world is not really in conflict with that of

Plato. The difference lies more in the way in which the interests of the two men are concentrated on different sides of reality (the world of ideas and that of the senses). For Plato the sense-world is merely a preliminary stage for reaching the world of ideas; the former has meaning only in so far as it helps us to reach the latter. The opposite is the case with Aristotle. He wants to explain the sense-world, and seeks the explanation in the ideas. We can say that substantially the two philosophers are of the same view, only their interest is centred on the two opposing sides.

Yet, in spite of this deep spirituality affinity between the two philosophers, their respective interests affect their attitude toward the world. For their followers, this difference is reflected in their activity in the world. Goethe explains the differences between the two ways of thinking.

Plato stand in relation to the world as a spirit pleased to dwell here for a while. He is not so much concerned with learning about it — for he has always accepted its existence — as he is with imparting to it in a friendly way what it so sorely needs. So he penetrates to the depths more to fill them with his being than to investigate them. Is it to the heights that he ascends with longing to participate again in his origin. All that he says refers to an eternal Unity — Good, True, Beautiful — and he strives to kindle every human heart with love for it, while the details of earthly knowledge melt, we could even say vaporize, in his method, in his delivery.

Aristotle, on the other hand, stands in relation to the world like man as master-builder. After all, he *is* here, and is to work and create. He investigates the soil, but only until he finds the ground he needs. From there to the centre of the earth, all else is a matter of indifference to him. Once in his place, he draws an enormous circle for the foundation of his building, collects materials from all directions, organises them, piles them in orderly fashion atop one another, and in this way ascends to the heights, much like

a pyramid; Plato ascends like an obelisk; indeed, like an aspiring flame.

As it is the task of the Hermeticist to reconcile opposites, we join with Goethe when he concludes:

Indeed, just as do various people, so also do the centuries divide themselves in their veneration of Plato and Aristotle, now peacefully, now in vigorous conflict. It can be seen as a great advantage for our century that they are equally esteemed, just as in his time Raphael, in the so-called *School of Athens*, was mindful of both and placed them beside one another.

Note: Acknowledgment to *The Golden Age of Chartres* by Rene Querido for source material.

Posted on 2010-05-01 by Cologero

3.2 Order and the Soul

Picking up on the theme of Order and Chaos from the previous post, I thought it might be of interest to explicate Plato's concept of an ordered soul in *The Republic*.

For Plato, the soul (*psyche*) is composed of three main faculties – the *epithumetikon*, the *thumoeides*, and the *logistikon*.

The *epithumetikon* is literally the 'little desirer' and is "concerned with eating, drinking, sex, and all their followers." This is often translated as the appetitive faculty.

The *thumoeides* is a higher faculty than the *epithumetikon*, as it is "always wholly set on mastery, victory, and good reputation." Whereas the 'little desirer' wants material things and physical pleasures, the *thumoeides* (sometimes translated as the 'spirited' faculty though this is potentially

misleading given that Spirit has different meanings in different contexts) desires immaterial qualities.

Both *epithumetikon* and *thumomeides* are derived from *thumos*, which in Homeric times referred to the motive force in man, and which is traditionally associated with the chest (hence the naming of the thymus gland.) Plato says that these faculties correspond to “money and opinion.”¹

The third and highest faculty is the *logistikon*, which derives from *logos*. This faculty desires learning and wisdom, which ultimately lead to the Absolute. Though Plato does not say so explicitly, we can reasonably infer that the *logistikon* comprises the two higher types of consciousness of which he writes later on. The first is *dianoia*, which is discursive reasoning and is related to mathematics. The second and higher faculty is *nous*, which is direct perception of true reality. These later became *ratio* and *intellectus* in the philosophy of the Middle Ages.

Different types of men are ruled by different parts of the soul. A man governed by the appetitive faculty will be primarily concerned with mundane affairs and satisfying as many of his desires as he is able. There are many men like this.

A man governed by the *thumoeides* will be more concerned with honor and mastery and fame, whether in his own eyes or merely in the eyes of others. Depending on what kind of honor he desires, such a man might be a wealthy businessman, or a famous actor, or a courageous soldier. These men are rarer.

According to Plato, the philosopher must be ruled by the *logistikon* and its desire for learning and wisdom, and must properly order his soul so that the two lower faculties of the soul are ruled by this desire, rather

¹If we were to transpose these terms into yogic terminology, we might look at the similarities between the tripartite soul and the three *gunas*, and locate the *epithumetikon* in the region of the genitals and stomach, and the *thumoeides* in the chest, considered the seat of courage as in one who ‘has great heart.’

than obscuring or obstructing it. This proper ordering of the soul is called *sophrosune*, translated as self-control or moderation. Plato calls it a kind of harmony between all the parts of the soul, which “*becomes entirely one from the many*, moderate and harmonized. Then, and only then, he acts.”

Therefore, when all the soul follows the philosophic and is not factious, the result is that each part may, so far as other things are concerned, mind its own business and be just and, in particular, enjoy its own pleasures, the best pleasures, and, to the greatest possible extent, the truest pleasures.

Note that Plato does not call for the suppression of the lower faculties. The proper order of the soul is not a tyranny, but a monarchy.

This proper ordering of the soul is the precondition for the practice of philosophy; that is, awakening the *nous* and attaining true *gnosis*. And this proper ordering cannot be achieved without taking up the ancient maxim *Know Thyself*.

Posted on 2011-09-21 by Will

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Graham on 2011-09-21 at 16:11 said:

It's good to see you back. I find it strange that the governing virtue *sophrosune* (harmony of soul) is translated as moderation or self-control, concepts which seem rather restricted. Isn't justice the virtue of man as such, and moderation the virtue special to the lowest part of the soul?

Evagrius Ponticus said that the conscious state of the just man was *apatheia*, or detachment. This state he held to be prerequisite for contemplation. I appreciate what you're doing with Plato, Will, since it's essential to reconstructing a Western esotericism.

Will on 2011-09-23 at 06:48 said:

Graham, Thank you for your kind words. I agree that 'moderation' is a bad translation of *sophrosune*, and 'self-control' is not much better. Like *arete* – 'excellence' or 'virtue' – it has no exact English equivalent.

I'm not sure how Plato's system or terminology fits in with later Christian writers such as the one you mention, who I am not familiar with. However, in regard to justice as the virtue of man as such, Plato would say that only the philosopher – by which he means something more akin to *jnani* than any modern sense of the word 'philosopher' – is truly just, because only he perceives reality as it is.

One could make a case for Plato's agreement with the notion that *apatheia* is a prerequisite for contemplation, or the practice of philosophy, insofar as he writes of the need to govern the passions of the lower parts of the soul. But, on the other hand, he writes of the philosopher as having a deep love of learning and an insatiable appetite for wisdom and truth, which suggests that he is not entirely without *pathos*, but rather guided by one dominant drive.

I think a key aspect of *sophrosune* is that the soul becomes unified and capable of acting as a unity, i.e. the philosopher is not pulled to and fro by conflicting desires and drives. Gurdjieff also stressed the importance of achieving this state. But *sophrosune* is a means, not an end. For Plato, the aspiring philosopher harmonizes his soul so as to be able to practice philosophy – to search for wisdom and truth with the entirety of his being.

This is consistent with Traditional teachings, such as the Buddhist story of the man who asks a teacher what he has to do to attain enlightenment. The teacher holds the man under water until he is about to drown, then finally lets him up for air and tells him that when he wants enlightenment as badly as he wanted to breathe just now, he'll attain it.

3.3 Esoteric Paganism

The revelation given to the *rishis* or seers of ancient India was that the empirical ego is not the real self. Of course, the pagan revivalists ignore this and content themselves with putting up statues of Hindu gods, rather than engaging in the difficult process of detaching from the empirical self. For men today, that is the opposite of salvation, for what they want is for the empirical ego to be made more comfortable and to achieve satisfaction. Because of technology, the illusion that such an outcome may be permanently possible takes root. Many illnesses can be cured or at least treated effectively. The effects of old age are diminished because

the body has not undergone a lifetime of hard labour in most cases and chronic conditions can be managed. Finally, Death, which came at random among all age groups, is relegated more and more to the end of a longish life. Thus men today keep sickness, old age, and death out of their conscious thoughts for the most part.

Buddha, following and developing the Vedic tradition, saw things in their full impact. **Valentin Tomberg** wrote:

A Buddha is one who is fully awakened. ... All human beings know about the facts of birth, sickness, old age, and death, and yet live as if they knew nothing of them. But Gautama Buddha became completely awake to these facts, awake to their range and significance right down to their ultimate consequences. ... The Buddhas of the past were fully awake to the reality of the Fall into sin, and to the sorrows of mankind and of the world which is sunken in error, suffering, and death.

So Tomberg points to three great revelations. The ideal of the pagan world was the Wise Man, Sage, or the Philosopher, as the one who remembers, i.e., the one who overcomes forgetting. The Buddhas are fully Awakened Ones who overcome sleep. Yet the noble path revealed by the Buddha could not overcome death. So that brings us to the Christian revelation which we will try to understand in its inner, or esoteric, nature.

Philosophy in the Hellenic World Philosophy used to be regarded as a way of life leading to Wisdom; no professor of philosophy today can be regarded as “wise” in any sense. Plato, Aristotle, and the Stoics were all considered to have parts of the true philosophy. This is not unlike the six philosophical schools of Hinduism, just that, unfortunately, it was not formulated so precisely.

“Sham” philosophy was the pseudo-philosophy of the sophists, epicureans, materialists, atheists, etc. When St. Paul criticizes philosophy or

the traditions of men (Colossians 2:8²), that is what he had in mind.

Academics are fond of saying that the early Christians “used” Greek philosophy to express their teaching as it was the most sophisticated thought available to them. That gives them permission to then force Christian teaching onto all sorts of ludicrous ideologies, or better said, “sham philosophies.” Of course, the real situation is quite different. They saw pagan Hellenic philosophy as containing essential truths. It was never part of Christian teaching to create a new metaphysical system. **Vladimir Solovyov** explains:

The great fathers of the ancient Church affirmed that even before Christ’s incarnation, the same divine Reason that was revealed in Him enlightened with the eternal truth the inspired wise men of paganism, these *Christians before Christ*.

Although the close inner connection between Alexandrian theosophy and the Christian doctrine is one of the firmly established theses of Western scholarship, for one reason or another, this perfectly correct thesis does not enjoy common acknowledgement in our theological literature.

Solovyov promised to write about the revelations of **Thoth** or **Hermes Trismegistus** in its relation to Christian doctrines.

Unfortunately, he never got around to it, but that task has since been accomplished by Valentin Tomberg in his meditations.

Exoteric and Esoteric Philosophy The Church Fathers continued to call their own teachings “philosophy”, although they emphasized that true philosophy must be “lived”. What the means can be found in the *Philokalia*. Because of this they drew the following distinction:

²<http://www.biblegateway.com/passage/?search=Colossians+2%3A8&version=DRA>

- Exoteric philosophy comprised ancient Greek philosophy
- Esoteric philosophy is identical with the Christian religion

So from their point of view the Christian religion was entirely esoteric, and was actually the inner aspect of Hellenic philosophy as exoteric. With this understanding the *Philokalia* and Dante become much clearer. We have alluded to Augustine's insight that the external Logos of the pagans was the same as the inner Logos, born again in the soul, of the Christians.

This has been lost, as Christianity became more exoteric. The path to Wisdom, or the Love of God, was grounded in three factors:

1. Divine revelation, keeping in mind that there were four levels of interpretation, from the literal to the esoteric
2. Sacred Tradition
3. Inner experience, which lifts one above the senses and above reason

Without point (3), there is only an exoteric teaching. More has been lost over time. The Roman Church was based on (1) and (2), although there is a continuous history of saints and mystics who understood (3); their writings should be read often. The Reformation insisted on point (1) alone, and even worse, accepted only the literal level of interpretation.

For references on this topic, please see *The Hellenic-Christian Philosophical Tradition*³, by **Constantine Cavarnos**.

Posted on 2014-03-03 by Cologero

* * *

³<http://ibmgs.org/ancientphil.html>

Constantine Aetos on 2014-03-03 at 13:54 said:

"This has been lost, as Christianity became more exoteric. The path to Wisdom, or the Love of God, was grounded in three factors."

And that is why Eastern Orthodoxy is the only column left in Christendom.

Michael on 2014-03-03 at 18:25 said:

Cologero, do you think that Guenon drew too sharp a distinction between initiation and mysticism? In Christianity is true mysticism and initiation one and the same?

Paulo on 2014-03-03 at 23:36 said:

"Yet the noble path revealed by the Buddha could not overcome death."

You say this because the Buddha could not explain death, could not fill the void?

Cassiodorus on 2014-03-04 at 18:12 said:

Hi Cologero,

You have always been gracious in granting me a certain degree of latitude for "chitchat" as you are wont to call it. A few years ago, I became familiar with the writings of the Perennialist school which resonated me with me profoundly. I then slowly migrated back to the religion of my childhood, Roman Catholicism. But as I became more immersed in the teachings of the Catholic faith, the more difficult I have found it to affirm both the universalism of Perennialism and the central doctrines of Christianity. For me, the question of whether or not Christianity reveals something "*more*" than the other great Revelations is extremely important. If it does not, then I'm hard pressed to reconcile the Incarnation and Trinitarian theology with Perennialist metaphysics which regards the Trinity on the level of being- not beyond being (Nirguna Brahman) and Jesus Christ as just one of multiple "avataric descents".

In response, Traditionalists usually say that they are certainly not trying to convert anyone who is at peace with God- exoterism, after all, has its rights. But, there *is* a transcendent unity of religions- esoterism transcends theology from *within*, not from without. No everyone is a jnani, nor should we expect them to be.

Traditional Catholics generally react to this pov by charging Perennialism with being a modern mutant form of gnosticism. Their reason is that the Perennial Philosophy regards ignorance as the great sin- ignorance of the supreme Truth that duality is an illusion and therefore that the heart of spirituality is realization. Traditional Christianity rejects this (says my Catholic interlocutors) on the grounds that only the saving work of the Incarnate Christ reconciles us to God. Moreover, under no circumstance can the Christian accept moksha, *identity* with the Divine. Christian mysticism, union with Christ, transcends other Traditions because the Logos, the Second Person of the Trinity, *became man*. Perennialism is basically a failed attempt to "squeeze"

classical theism into a nondual framework which fundamentally changes the significance of Jesus Christ.

For what it's worth, I hesitated to post this, especially since I've been beating this horse for a while- but I just can't seem to make peace with it. I am not trying to be argumentative and I'm certainly not trying to rile anyone up. Any insight on this matter would be appreciated.

Vincit Omnia Veritas

Frater M on 2014-03-05 at 00:59 said:

Guenon expressed in a brief footnote in his "Perspectives" that it seemed likely that St. Ignatius' "Spiritual Exercises" were an "ascetic" and "active" way, likely inspired (in part) by Islamic Esoterism. Others since Guenon, have also explored this idea (independent of Guenon), and arrived at similar conclusions.

Despite any of this, "The Spiritual Exercises", imo, can stand on their own, and speak for themselves. St. Ignatius describes them as "way", in the sense of pilgrimage, with the pilgrimage being ones' life, and not simply ending after the forty-day retreat, but continuing ever onward, where we so effectively learn the "exercises" that eventually, our entire lives constitute the "retreat" (may we all obtain the grace to reach such a point).

A goal, or perhaps better stated, a grace possibly afforded the spiritual athlete of these exercises, is "revelation"—coming to knowledge of ourselves, the meaning of our individual lives, and what needs to be further accomplished in our lives, to allow God to fully self-disclose Himself through us.

Perhaps my own explanation here of the "Exercises" is far inadequate, and incomplete; however, the process of the exercises, in general, seem to my mind, to satisfy most of what people are after when seeking an "esoterism"—and, they are something quite common, in plain sight—yet often glossed over. They are also a very living, and ever growing tradition, within the bosom of Western Christianity/Roman Catholicism.

Cologero on 2014-03-05 at 07:14 said:

Yes, Cassiodorus, perhaps it may be more helpful for you to interlocute with what has been written here rather than those anonymous third parties. If you become reconciled to God, is that a real change in your being or merely an imputed reconciliation? If the former, then no interlocution is going to help you. Is reconciliation some impersonal mechanical or juridical process brought about by Christ passively, or is something more involved?

Clearly, we have been relying on Tomberg and Solovyov to properly relate the various traditions. Although we have not said it all yet, don't you have anything to say about the actual text written her beyond the chitchat that is now occupying your mind. Remember the First Trial.

The problem with "perennialism" is that it is ahistorical. It teaches the doctrine of cycles, but avoids it in practice by attempting to transcend the world process. But the world process is

not an “illusion” as you apparently believe, but rather a reflection of the divine, even if imperfect. We have emphasized this over and over both here and on the Tarot blog. There is also a reason for the imperfection.

So, no, unlike the Eastern teachings that want to annihilate the self, something certainly possible and it is the limit of their teaching for the reasons given by Tomberg. Nevertheless, the revelation in the Vedanta of the higher self is valid and important. So, yes, realization trumps mere chitchat.

Beyond that, our goal is regeneration, i.e., the return to the state of consciousness prior to the Fall; that is the way of Christ, but you must follow that path. That is not self-annihilation, but self-affirmation. Oddly enough, Evola and Serrano seem to understand that, which is why we have bothered with them.

Avery Morrow on 2014-03-05 at 09:36 said:

Cassiodorus, it is correct to recognize that Guenon has no epistemology. He awakens an intuitive sense that traditional forms serve some higher purpose, but he provides no bounds by which to distinguish these forms perfectly from their mutations, nor does he resolve ancient teachings such as the uniqueness of Christ. Now Tomberg and Solovyov are being employed in this post to provide us with some of those limits. It is worth discussing with your friends whether the points being raised by these writers are discernibly orthodox to them.

Paulo on 2014-03-06 at 07:29 said:

Why do you say that the buddha could not overcome death?

Cassiodorus on 2014-03-07 at 10:41 said:

Cologero and Avery,

Thank you very much for your comments and insights. I have much to contemplate during this Lenten season.

Kind Regards

Cologero on 2014-03-10 at 14:45 said:

First of all, Exit, the idea of “types” in Scripture has been known from the beginning. Tomberg has developed the idea. This begs the question of where the “types” came from in the first place. If the types are also human constructs, then they would not remain constant over the centuries. So actually archetypes and prototypes are revelations from God regarding the inner structure of the cosmos. Human history follows certain patterns based on such a typology.

If you would seriously like to study the Jewish teaching on the end of the world, check out “The Way of God” by Luzzatto, particularly the section “Israel & The Nations”. Luzzatto said that

the gentile nations are on a lower level than Israel because they rejected the Torah. There is no need for any elaborate plot.

Frater M on 2014-03-11 at 01:49 said:

This is really off-topic; however, Algis Uzdaviny's didn't really "write" that Hyksos material mentioned by "Exit" (found in "Philosophy as a Rite of Rebirth, pp 30-33)–he was quoting Jan Assman, and it isn't really much more than a blurb in the book, or all of Uzdaviny's writings. I mention this because "Exit's" comment makes Uzdaviny's appear as a dry academic, "historian of religion", who likely fails to grasp any higher meanings. Such is not the case–in fact, Uzdaviny's revisits aspects of the Hebrew tradition, favorably, in his later book "Ascent to Heaven".

Cologero on 2014-03-17 at 00:31 said:

Without endorsing these particular figures or points of view, the idea of Christianity as esoteric paganism arises in other streams, casting doubt on the notion that Wotanism represents the primal Nordic tradition. First of all, we have pointed out several times that Herman Wirth's researches showed that monotheism was at the source of the Nordic tradition.

Both Karl Wiligut and Guido von List also believed that Wotanism was the exoteric expression of the esoteric "Irmin-Christianity".

burningfireeye on 2021-03-03 at 16:06 said:

Angeology cannot be compared with paganism. Do we sacrifice, do we make offerings to an idol of St. Michael the Archangel? Did Hinduism consist of sacrificing to pagan idols from its very inception or is it a degeneration? If it is not a degeneration, how can it represent the primordial tradition?

Cologero on 2021-03-03 at 22:26 said:

burning fire has apparently affected your eyesight adversely. Where, oh where, did the topic of angelology come up? Or sacrifice? Or Michael? Where exactly is there a comparison?

They say ignorance is bliss, but most of the time it is just the result of laziness.

Please read carefully *Treatise on Separate Substances by Saint Thomas Aquinas*⁴, in which he does indeed discuss angels and paganism.

⁴https://www.gornahoor.net/?page_id=13278

3.4 Esoteric Stoicism

Do not go outside, go back into yourself: the truth dwells in the inner man.

ST. AUGUSTINE

This post is adapted from the chapter on Stoicism in *The Hellenic-Christian Philosophical Tradition* by Constantine Cavarinos. The reader is encouraged to check out that work for references to works by the Stoics, Church Fathers, and in the *Philokalia*.

Three factors go into creative misreading.

1. Place it in a larger context
2. Draw out its logical conclusions
3. Extract a deeper meaning

In this post, we will see how the key concepts of Stoicism were reworked. Stoicism was an exoterism because it held that the representations in the mind were of objects in the material world. However, when the entire psychic contents become the data of analysis, these same concepts lead to an esoterism. We can see that the modern mind is more inclined to the Stoic understanding of the inner life, which reveals a reversion to paganism. The following phenomenological analysis of Stoicism and the Church Fathers will bring to light the workings of the mind.

Stoicism in the ancient world provided an appealing worldview based on living a rational and ethical life. Its weakness lay in its materialism and empiricism. The Stoics held that everything is corporeal so that immaterial or spiritual reality did not exist. The soul is constituted of finer matter while the body of God is the cosmos. Nevertheless, the cosmos is

animated by Logos which had the attributes of thought, consciousness, and providence. In this pantheistic system, everything is a part of God. Hence, God determines all that happens so that there is no distinction between Providence and Destiny. All is fated.

The concept of the Logos, therefore, was known before the Gospel of John, including its identification with God. With their deeper understanding of the Logos, the Church Fathers reworked certain key Stoic concepts into a larger framework. They did this by interiorizing the Stoic's materialism. In particular, the following seven concepts will illustrate how that process worked:

1. The governing principle of the human soul
2. Preconceptions
3. Representations or Phantasies
4. Assent
5. Relation
6. Ataraxy or Tranquility
7. Apatheia or passionlessness

The Human Soul For the Stoics, the idea of lower centers in the soul made no sense. If God is Logos or Reason, and the soul is part of God, there cannot be any irrational part of the soul. Rather they recognized a governing principle. Concepts reside in it and it is the faculty which exercises judgment and applies concepts to particular situations.

This is clearly the intellectual center of the soul, without making the distinction between intuitive and discursive reason. When this principle guides a person's life, he is happy and free from passions. Whereas for

the Stoic this highest state is natural, for the Fathers it is supernatural. The governing principle is the activity of inner attention, the power of discrimination between good and evil, and even sacred contemplation. Obviously, that is the activity of the higher intellectual center or *nous*.

Since the Fathers do not deny the irrational appetitive and emotional parts of the soul, they need to be transcended.

Preconceptions The Stoic concept of preconception is that they are innate principles common to all men. As such, they are not contradictory, but become contradictory when applied to concrete situations in different ways. The purpose of education is to learn how to apply these preconceptions to specific instances in conformity to nature. Epictetus provides some examples: knowing good from evil, beautiful from ugly, knowing what one ought to do and not to do. Other things, such as mathematics, are not innate and need to be acquired.

The Stoics and Fathers agreed that there is innate moral knowledge. However, the Christian understanding of conscience goes beyond that. Not only is it a moral guide, it is also the impartial moral judge. Without that judge, the Stoic follows his preconceptions.

However, for the Fathers, preconceptions also include negative elements: prepossession, prejudice, a predisposition to sin. These need to be opposed and eradicated. These days we hear that so and so has a “good heart”. This is more in tune with the Stoic ideal. However, preconceptions can prevent the right decision. Prejudice or the desire to please will cloud our judgment. Negative preconceptions need to be expunged before they become passions.

Representations A phantasy in Stoicism is an impression made in the mind by an external object through the senses. As in the past, we will use the term “representation” instead of “phantasy” due to the unfortunate connotations of the latter term. The problem for the Stoics was to

distinguish illusory representations from true ones, and they provided some criteria to do that. In that, they agreed with Socrates that the Stoic should not accept a representation as true without subjecting it to critical examination. Epictetus pointed out the need for inner attention to discriminate between acceptable and unacceptable representations. In this regard, the teaching is sound.

The Fathers then brought this idea into a wider context. Our inner attention and discrimination should not be limited just to the impressions of the external world, but should include all the contents of the soul: thoughts, concepts, memories, dispositions, and so on.

The Fathers realized that much of our inner life is demonic. The Stoic must deny that because in pantheism, everything is God, so there cannot be anything demonic. However, once you get past the Hollywood style depiction of demons, then this realization will make sense. Of course, the modern mind regards all inner soul contents as “natural”, not unlike the Stoics, so they are compelled by that logic to accept demonic influences as fully natural, with just the echo of moral preconceptions to restrain them.

Note how this coincides with our earlier discussions. First, representations are accepted uncritically as true or good: this is how it is for the bulk of people today. The philosopher, in the next stage, learns to question or judge the representations. In the third stage, the representations are seen for what they are.

Assent Once representations are recognized as true or false, good or evil, then one must either assent to them or reject them. Otherwise, says Epictetus, “if we fail to do this, the impression will take possession of us and go off with us wherever it will.” There are many examples in the news illustrating how an initial impression, if left on its own, will lead to unnatural or even insane acts. The modern mind has been losing that faculty of discrimination.

The Fathers used this Stoic insight in their understanding of temptation, as shown in this analysis:

- First a *suggestion* comes into our mind via a representation or thought
- Then there is a mingling of the suggestion with our own thoughts
- This is followed either by opposition or assent to the suggestion
- If there is assent, then sin is the result
- Assent then leads to enslavement, so that the same temptation is repeated with the same result
- The refusal to assent results in spiritual combat which will lead to victory or defeat

Relation An important philosophical category of being for the Stoics is relationship: to your body, to God, to those who live with you, and so on. The Fathers also adopted this notion in regard to our relation to God, our fellow men, material things, and secular values.

There is a binding character of psychical relations, which is on a scale. The human soul establishes relations between itself and various things such as money, possessions, glory, and people. Relations involve two things:

1. An awareness of the existence of things or persons.
2. An emotional or conative attitude towards them.

This attitude binds the soul to them in stages:

1. First, there is an interest in a thing, a “feeling towards” it.

2. When the interest gets stronger, an emotional response, called a “passion”, arises.
3. Finally, the relation may become one of bondage or enslavement. E.g.:
 - **Avarice**: bondage to money
 - **Greed**: bondage to material possessions
 - **Ambition**: bondage to human glory
 - **Lust**: bondage to sex

To be free, a person needs to overcome such bondages. Obviously, it is easier to do this at stage (1) rather than (3), but it takes inner discipline to recognize something that subtle.

Ataraxy **Ataraxy** is the state of the soul which is peaceful, undisturbed by external events, thoughts, phantasies, desires, or emotions. For the Stoic, following the governing principle and living according to reason will lead the wise man to this state.

The Fathers recognized a similar state without, however, considering it the highest state. As such, ataraxy is a natural state. This state of inner quiet or tranquility is a preparatory stage for union with God, or *theosis* — or the Supreme Identity as some Traditional writers have phrased it.

The Stoics lived in cities, full of noise, turmoil, and distractions; they tried to reach the state of tranquility in that environment. The Fathers, however, held that outer tranquility was necessary for inner tranquility. Hence, they retired to the desert or the mountains or any quiet, solitary place.

In our time, however, we have to hark back to the Stoics and achieve Ataraxy in the midst of our everyday life. It is not outer things that ultimately perturb us, but rather our own cares, passions, temptations, etc.

Apatheia Alongside ataraxy, **apatheia**, or passionlessness, constitute the highest Stoic ideal. The modern world has lost the understanding of that state, since “apathy” has taken on a negative connotation, not indicative of the highest state. A fortiori, the modern mind is instead *impressed* by passion or emotion. The intensity of feeling is the measure of truth. I don’t need to provide examples, since you can find them everywhere.

The Stoics unfortunately overdid it, regarding all emotions as sinful, irrational, or unnatural. They identified pleasure, grief, fear, and desire as the four chief emotions. This is an unsatisfactory position since it will lead to contradictions.

The Fathers, instead, equated “passions” just to negative emotions. Hence, there are some distinctions to be made about what is properly a negative emotions:

1. **Those emotions which are bad in themselves:** e.g., conceit, gluttony, lust, vanity, pride, greed, malice
2. **Those emotions which are bad only when contrary to nature:** e.g., anger, hatred, sorrow, fear. When these emotions are in conformity to our nature, they are not “negative emotions”. So, for example, misplaced anger is negative, but anger directed against an injustice is not.
3. **Pleasures and desires:** Once again, these depend on the object. For example, a normal desire for food, rest, or sex is not negative. Negative pleasures and desires are of two types:
 - (a) **Excessive:** For example, when the desire for food becomes gluttony
 - (b) **Disordered:** For example, when the desire for food becomes coprophagia

Sorrow for sins, fear of God, fear of hell, are not passions, or negative emotions, in this sense. Rather, they impel us to reject temptations and regain the health of the soul.

Love becomes the highest goal, even higher than *apatheia*. Love, in this sense, is more than worldly friendship or family affection; it is a spiritual love. The overcoming of negative emotions, the state of *apatheia*, is preparation for this higher stage.

Posted on 2015-06-04 by Cologero

* * *

Tom Blanchard on 2015-06-05 at 12:46 said:

I was actually just reading yesterday a similar reflection on Stoicism by the Rev. John Toshimichi Imai, a Japanese Anglican priest who wrote a treatise called "Bushido: In The Past and In the Present" (1906). After emphasising the Bushido is not a religion or a philosophy (his position being that it is more a product of the "spirit of the Yamato race"), and has adapted itself over the centuries to the various religions and philosophies that have predominated in Japan, he compares and contrasts the ethics of Bushido with the ethics of various philosophical and religious systems. On Stoicism, he writes:

"Again, the sternness of the Stoic, and the self control of the Samurai over his emotions have much seeming likeness, but in Bushido at least there was no condemning of the emotional spirit. Duty was indeed the highest object of self-sacrifice, and reason ranked higher than the feelings, but what is called 'bushi no nasake': that is to say, 'the humane feelings of a bushi' were warm and tender. Thus it is that we do not find a Seneca in our Bushido to condemn tears and sympathy. The hardship of self-denial on the part of a bushi was to have a heart and to conquer it when duty so required."

There is a fourth section of the book in which Imai reflects on the present features of Bushido and its bearing toward Christianity, which I have not yet obtained and read (the most available copy of this book is scattered across four different issues of the magazine "Kendo World"). Evola was an admirer of the Japanese race and considered their tradition and heritage to be quintessentially Solar, so Imai's reflections as an Anglican priest seeking to integrate the Japanese race-soul with the Christian tradition may be of interest to some.

3.5 Esoteric Platonism

He was awaiting the city with foundations whose architect and demiurge is the God.

HEBREWS 11:10

God bears in the intelligible world to reason and its objects the same relation which the sun bears in the visible world to sight and its objects.

PLATO, *Republic*

Besides Stoicism, Platonism and Aristotelianism were also reworked in the transition from the Philosophical to the Religious consciousness in the West. Again, this process involves seeing the earlier philosophies in a large context while bringing out its deeper meanings in the light of transcendent revelation. The Philosophical consciousness was focused on Thought, whereas the Religious consciousness was focused on a change in the level of Being. There are two claims that can be made explicit:

1. Plato, Aristotle, and the Stoics together present the highest intellectual teachings in Pagan civilization.
2. The way the Church Fathers reworked those teachings is an advancement.

Claim (1) is really indisputable. The neopagans may reject it typically through a philosophy of “vitalism”, which regards the body and soul life as primary, thereby rejecting a higher intellectual or spiritual life. This position can be rejected philosophically, but poses a danger either by distracting those otherwise interested in Tradition, or by coming to power in an orgy of destruction.

Claim (2) speaks for itself. While absorbing the rationalism of Greek thought, it adds the empirical element, a sort of “metaphysical positivism”. However, since it requires a change of Being, it cannot just be “thought”, it is beyond thought. Spiritual exercises are necessary. This combination of rationality and spirituality is rare, either because of lack of a suitable guide or lack of motivation.

Oddly enough, claim (2) is typically rejected by the “super-correct” who reject this introduction of “pagan elements” into the purity of the Gospels. This is often accompanied by an unconscious crypto-paganism that imagines a Zeus-like god residing in a material heaven not much different from Mount Olympus, all while claiming to be Christian.

The following will all make sense to men of Tradition, since Guenon regards it as an authentic metaphysic. What, then, is required, is an intellectual conversion. That is, to begin to see and understand man, the world, and God in the light of these teachings.

Introduction **Constantine Cavarnos** specifically mentions the following topics from Plato and Aristotle as the most influential on the Fathers. The Fathers did not regard the two philosophers as essentially opposed to each other. We will provide a brief introduction to each of them, usually by combing them into a single section.

World of Ideas Plato distinguished between the sensible realm and intelligible realm. **Julius Evola** described the same teachings in the first chapter of *Revolt Against the Modern World*.

- **Sensible Realm.** Physical order, visible, perceived by the bodily senses, changing, phenomena, appearances, destructible or mortal things,
- **Intelligible Realm.** Metaphysical order, invisible, apprehended by the mind, ideas, unchanging, indestructible or immortal things

Plato	Aristotle
Sensible and Intelligible Realms	Matter and Form
God as Demiurge	Conception of God
Tripartite division of soul	Immaterial Being
Four Chief Virtues	Categories of existence
Unity of the Virtues	Moral excellence or Virtue
Virtues as Beautiful	Four causes

Table 3.1: Concepts from Plato and Aristoteles

While Plato was unsure of the precise nature of the intelligible realm, the Fathers realized that the ideas pre-existed in the Mind of God. This is what **Rene Guenon** claims in the *Multiple States of Being*.

To be clear, this teaching is not a “theory”, one possible worldview among many others. Rather it is knowledge or gnosis itself. No one is clearer about this than **Julius Evola**, not even the Christians. He writes in the very first chapter of *Revolt Against the Modern World*:

Anywhere in the world of Tradition, both East and West and in one form or another, this knowledge has always been present as an unshakable axis around which everything revolved. Let me emphasize the fact that it was knowledge and not “theory”. As difficult as it may be for our contemporaries to understand this, we must start from the idea that the man of Tradition was aware of the existence of a dimension of being much wider than what our contemporaries experience and call “reality”.

Hylomorphism Aristotle expressed a similar teaching as the distinction between matter and form, in which matter stands for the sensible realm and form (or Idea) correspond to the intelligible realm. Aristotle mistakenly rejected the independent existence of the forms or ideas. Of

course, the Fathers rejected Aristotle's belief that matter and form are uncreated.

This doctrine is called Hylomorphism. Guenon pointed out similar teachings in the Samkhya school of Vedanta.

God Plato and Aristotle contributed to the understanding of God, although in different ways. From Plato, came the idea of God as Demiurge, artist, architect, creator.

Platonic ideas:

- God is beyond being
- God created the world as a likeness to an eternal model
- The “inexpressible beauty” of God.
- The physical universe is beautiful
- God is the Idea of the Good
- God bears in the intelligible world to reason and its objects the same relation which the sun bears in the visible world to sight and its object

The main objection is that Plato believed that matter was eternal and the Demiurge merely molded it; of course, matter is also a creation of God. These are some corollaries of Plato's conception:

- If God is beyond being, he cannot be a being Himself. Most people today imagine God as some powerful being out there.
- The world did not arise from material processes by chance. Rather it has developed in conformance with a Divine ideal.

- As the cosmos is good and beautiful, neither Plato nor the Christians are “world denying”. Rather, the world is understood as an element in a hierarchy of being.
- God is not some great being “out there, right now”. Rather, He is like the Sun in our consciousness, bringing the intelligible realm of ideas into our awareness.

While Aristotle misunderstood that God was the Creator and Providential (unlike Plato in both cases), he can still give us a deeper understanding of God:

- God is a substance
- God is immaterial
- God is unmoved
- God is impassive
- God is pure act

Since we are called upon to strive to attain likeness to God, we need to reach the state of passionlessness. Don’t forget that this means freedom from “negative emotions”, not from all emotions.

The Soul Although Plato and Aristotle seem to have different conceptions of the soul, they are harmonizable. The Fathers accepted Plato’s tripartite division of man as body, soul, and spirit as well as his teaching on its powers or parts. However, unlike Plato, they held that man is a body-soul, not just a discarnate soul. They likewise accept the three powers of the soul:

- **The appetitive** (*epithymetikon*). Directed toward sensual pleasure and material gain.
- **The spirited** (*thymos*). Directed toward ruling, conquering, fame.
- **The rational** (*logistikon*). Directed toward the true, the good, and the beautiful.

The Fathers broadened the understanding of these powers. The appetitive function can be sublimated and directed toward what is really necessary to be fully human: to the virtues and to God and His Will.

The spirited function should be directed against inordinate and wrong desires, but also against demons, for we wrestle not just against flesh and blood.

The Fathers include inner attention, meditation, and prayer in the rational function. Thus we see that there is both a lower and a higher aspect to each function.

In association with these functions, there are three possible states:

- **Contrary to Nature.** One of the nonrational powers governs the soul, and the rational part is enslaved.
- **In Accordance to Nature.** The rational part of the soul governs the whole soul.
- **Above nature.** One lets God rule the soul its thoughts, feelings, desires, and so forth.

Plato only recognized the first two, which is the limit of the philosophical consciousness, while the Fathers realized the state above nature. **Mark the Ascetic** describes this state as:

where the mind finds the fruits of the Holy Spirit, which the Apostle Paul called love, joy, peace, and so on.

John Climacos says that:

in this state one has the indwelling God Himself governing him in all his word, deeds, and thoughts. Wherefore through illumination he apprehends the will of the Lord within himself as a certain voice and transcends every human teaching.

Immaterial Being Besides composite substances (i.e., composed of form and matter), Aristotle recognized the existence of simple, immaterial things consisting of form without matter. God, angels (which Aristotle believed to be subordinate gods), and the soul are immaterial.

In particular, man's intellectual center is immaterial. That means it can know essences directly, intuitively, without "becoming" the thing in matter. These we know through thinking, or correct thinking, since most of our thinking is either contrary to nature or contrary to God. Here, Esoteric Stoicism teaches us the importance of discriminating our thoughts and rejecting the useless and harmful ones.

Thus, our experience, say, of demons comes through our thoughts, not from artistic, or not so artistic, pictures. Hence, demonic activity in our consciousness is not so easy to recognize, since it is experienced as one thought among others, not in terms of a sensible image of an ugly demon. Au contraire, the thought may appear quite beautiful and pleasing to your self-esteem.

Another way to understand thoughts is the experience of what Guenon calls "possibilities of being", i.e., they may be experienced as various thoughts or impulses. Of course, the free man transcends this and can decide whether or not to act on such thoughts, while the ordinary man simply accepts most everything that crosses his mind.

Virtues Both Plato and Aristotle wrote on the virtues, and those ideas were further developed by the Fathers. Since these sections are rather long and we have written often on this topic, we will save it for another day.

Categories Aristotle identified 10 categories of being, which were used in different contexts by the Fathers, as gathered in Table 3.2.

Categories of Being	
Substance	Time
Quality	Position
Quantity	State
Relation	Action
Place	Passion

Table 3.2: Categories of being

Fundamental is substance, both material and immaterial. Quality is given primacy over quantity. Things are in relations.

Space is different when speaking of material and immaterial substances. For the former, it refers to physical space and for the latter, mental space. For example, there are three different interior spaces:

- **Contrary to Nature.** The soul forgets or ignores God and His justice, an “unholy, demonic, place” rendered desolate by demonic, impassioned, negative thoughts.
- **In accordance with Nature.** The place of clear self-knowledge and repentance.
- **Above Nature:** the soul rises to prayer and experiences the fruits of the Holy Spirit, e.g., love, joy and peace.

Spatial (above) and temporal (after) metaphors and symbols are used in spiritual writings to describe transcendent states. Not recognizing that these refer to inner or mental space, the common mind tries to imagine

the transcendent in terms of a physical space “out there” or of a here-after as a continuation of physical life in everlasting time. Rather, **Joseph Ratzinger** explains that Eternal Life is:

The kind of life man may graciously come to possess in relationship with God who is life. Eternal life begins in this life through a person’s knowing God and entering into communion with Him.

“State” is also a misunderstood category. Particularly if one is attached to sensible images of spatial and temporal metaphors, it may be confusing to regard Heaven, for example, as a state of being. Once you understand that being human is itself a state of being, then it will make more sense. It does not deny that Heaven is a place, just that it is a material place.

The application of categories of being is a large topic. Begin understanding the world in terms of these categories in order to attain the intellectual conversion.

Causes Cavanaugh does not mention Aristotle’s doctrine of causes, but we’ve added it since it is very important, at least in the West. Again, begin by applying this doctrine to events in your life and in the world. As we’ve pointed out, Science rejected formal and final causes while retaining material and efficient causes. You will often read that science has “shown” that final and formal causes don’t exist, somehow forgetting that was the assumption, not the conclusion. We will say more on this when describing the transition from the Religious to the Scientific consciousness.

Posted on 2015-06-11 by Cologero

* * *

Alistair Fraser on 2015-06-11 at 04:11 said:

A quite fabulous compression of high octane provocation to contemplation on the nature of being

Br. Giles Mary on 2015-07-08 at 21:27 said:

This looks very good. I'm giving a brief talk to religious sisters tomorrow about masculine worship. I'm using some of Ratzinger's writings on symbols and The First Epistle of John where he writes, "I write unto you, young men, because you are strong, and the word of God abideth in you, and you have overcome the wicked one." Amongst other things, I didn't know that Church Fathers explicitly taught the re-direction of the spirited function of the soul against demons, but I do now. Thanks, Cologero.

3.6 Realization in the Pre-Socratics: Rene Guenon and Peter Kingsley, Some Observations

In the final chapter of Rene Guenon's *Metaphysical Principles of Calculus* he concludes his exposition dedicating the chapter to the paradoxes of the Eleatic, Zeno, disciple of Parmenides. Guenon's position is that Zeno's paradoxes are not examples of an emerging scientific "rationalism" as the academic position mostly holds, but a metaphysical and esoteric teaching.

Writing with the credentials of an academic, but voice and authority of the metaphysician, Peter Kingsley throughout his works such as *Reality, In the Dark Places of Wisdom*, and *Ancient Philosophy, Mystery and Magic*, takes a similar approach, insisting that not only have the academics gotten Parmenides, Empedocles, Zeno, and related pre-Socratics wrong from "back to front", not just that what they were not were dry proto-scientists—but as links in the transmission of an esotericism, an esotericism moreover that lays at the very roots of Western civilization, and that their doctrines can never really be subject to any scholarly "debate" —rather, the only way to understand them, is that they "must be lived".

If the goal that Guenon's works point toward might need summarizing, this perhaps could be done with just the word "Realization", or perhaps attainment of the "Supreme Identity" —if we elaborate, as a starting point maybe also taking "man as envisaged in his totality"—in other words, quite simply, knowledge of the Real. Everything else in between—be it castes and civilizations, religions, initiations, social organization, the arts, crafts, and sciences, or teachings about "cyclicity" (microcosmic or macrocosmic), in the traditional worldview, are all but images of the Real, and ultimately just the sign posts pointing back to it. And, "outside" of the traditional world, where these things are unknown, there is not so much of an affirmative opposition to such things, as a radical absence, as Frithjof Schuon remarks,

The spirits of evil, the demons, are inverted shadows—inverted in the direction of nothingness, which itself is in the non-existent—of the Names of God; the "fall of the angels" indicates the cosmic manifestation of the principles of remotion, inversion, privation, and negation, as well as compression and volatilization. Does this mean that the ideas of ugliness or vice are themselves a participation in ugliness or vice, as is the case with positive ideas? Clearly not, for the definition of vice is derived from virtue; goodness is the measure of evil; it is not because of stupidity that we know stupidity but because of intelligence, which makes recognition of this privation possible.

Logic and Transcendence, 19

Quite akin to Guenon, Kingsley and his understanding of Parmenides and Empedocles concern much the same—we are asleep and unconscious, groping through a dream and illusion, a grand cosmic deception, and only by awaking and acquiring consciousness (rather realizing what we already possess) can we experience "Reality". The Real must be experienced, no other way is open —the "Supreme Identity" must be "re-

alized”, or it is but a virtuality. Since there is no way to really know, or cut through the “deception” without “realization”, to “describe” Reality, is really the same thing as transmitting the “Initiatic Secret”—this is the Ineffable Word.

Still, Empedocles offers some framework or reference points: the nature of the four elements (or “roots”), their joining and separation—and the point that their joining and separation weave the fabric of Reality—perpetually... cosmic cycle, after cosmic cycle, after cosmic cycle—which has some pretty important implications concerning our liberation, “final deliverance”... or knowledge of Reality.

As is well known, Rene Guenon also placed some emphasis on cosmic “cyclic” doctrines and symbolism, particularly the Indian, although often exploring relationships with the Persian, Chaldean, Islamic, and others. For Guenon, these cyclic doctrines were valuable in helping to assess the outward conditions of the world where it currently “is”, the impact this has on man and his civilizations, with the ever developing “solidification” of the world being explained as a sort of growing “distance” between the world and the principle of its origin—a “distance” which like the “fall” explained by Schuon earlier, has no “positive existence”, but is privation. In the macrocosmic arena, what is cyclic “devolution” resulting in “solidification”, is in the individual being the degree of their unconsciousness—their inability to know Reality.

Yet, as Guenon and others have said, the “fall” is never total (for again, a total fall would be another negation and nothingness). For the individual, the fall stops, and Reality becomes known, when plurality is resumed within unity, its self-sufficient principle, as Kingley suggests:

When we are absorbed by everything happening all around us and excited with so many changes taking place... there is always movement. But when we start to glimpse the endless repetition behind our restless thirsting and questing for change, this is to catch sight of the motionlessness at the heart of all motion. For

what can be so hard to appreciate is that motionlessness is not some different reality, some other level of existence, separate from the world of motion. On the contrary: the more we try to discover stillness by leaving movement behind, the more movement we end up creating through the very act of running away from motion. And just as Parmenides knew that the easiest way to experience the stillness seemingly denied by this world of the senses is by using our senses to the full, so Empedocles knew how to look for it in the place we would least expect to find it. To observe life with complete awareness is to see that, once movement has repeated itself long enough, the motion turns to motionlessness.

KINGSLEY, *Reality*, 472

What in the individual constitutes the expansion of “total awareness”, via a “stillness” bringing about and the “end of motion”, is in the macrocosm analogous to the end of a cycle, Guenon explains:

If carried to its extreme limit the contraction of time would in the end reduce it to a single instant, and then duration would really have ceased to exist for it is evident that there can no longer be any succession within the instant. . . . As soon as succession has come to an end, or in symbolic terms ‘the wheel has ceased to turn’, all that exists can not but be in perfect simultaneity (“Reign of Quantity and Sign of the Times”, 160).

However, as Empedocles, and related cyclic doctrines inform, as even observation of natural cycles such as the daily, lunar, and annual display, one terminal point in a certain cycle is precisely the initiating point in one to follow, Guenon continues:

The end of a cycle. . . is really only the end of the corporeal world itself in quite a relative sense. . . in reality the corporeal world is

not annihilated but ‘transmuted’ and immediately receives a new existence, because, beyond the ‘stopping-point’ corresponding to the unique instant at which time is no more, ‘the wheel begins to turn again for the accomplishment of another cycle’.

Reign of Quantity, 162

Far reaching is the scope of these workings of reality, Kingsley states, included within and extending to all things, individual, formal, and informal, alike —or, as Guenon might say, in every state of Being (or in the geometrical symbolism of the cross, in every degree of individual manifestation, and every degree of Universal manifestation—that is, every “world”).

As Kingsley soon notes though, with everything therein considered, a ramification that becomes obvious is a certain lack of freedom, because “every soul is dragged out of heaven once more at the beginning of a new cycle, as it most definitely will be, the illusion will start all over again (Reality, 469)”. In fact, to the ire of modern man, as Kingsley explains this tradition —no free will exists at all.

For Guenon, freedom is but a “possibility”. As an “absence of constraint”, freedom can enter no limitation, and consequently can only proceed from non-duality—thus, freedom begins as a metaphysical possibility—for the individual, freedom is but relative, because “the Unity of Being is the principle of freedom in particular beings as well as in Universal Being, a being will be free to the extent it participates in this unity (*Multiple States of Being*, 92)”. This metaphysical unity Guenon mentions individual beings participating in, might then be seen as akin to the “stillness” of Parmenides and Empedocles, Kingsley mentions, with his dismissal of free will in mind:

There is a cosmic law...which states that whenever you come to the point of total pointlessness some other point is lying behind

it...But you also know that the return of the soul to freedom is just as transitory; just as illusory...But inwardly its all over. The drama has no substance. To find that stillness means neither being drawn into the illusions nor trying to escape them. It means that, even when trapped we are free. And even when apparently incarnated we know what it is, at any moment, not to be incarnated. For we are not only where we are. We are exactly where we will always be (473).

The cultivation of the “stillness” producing this state involves, as seen earlier, achieving a “total awareness” that “shrinks” as it were all motion into motionlessness, or all quantity (plurality) into pure quality (unity) within the individual. Empedocles enlists a particular method:

After the certainty that Love is good and Strife is bad comes the conviction that Love is bad, Strife is good. But after this certainty, too, has come and gone we are left with the growing sense that Empedocles is concerned with something far subtler than any fixed identification of either as simply good or bad. It all comes down to the need to discover, in each single instant, what happens to be good or bad for that particular moment. And only one factor can help us now. This is the razor sharp awareness, the totally focused sensitivity to the present moment, known to the Greeks as *metis*. . . . *metis* is as silently meaningful to Parmenides as it is to him (Empedocles). . . . it lies so close to the core of both of their teachings.

Reality, 455

This “*metis*” then, which engenders “*kairos*” —the “moment”, the “eternal present”— the metaphysical freedom that is Guenon’s “Unity of Being”, is as Kingsley translates Empedocle’s poem, “no mere mortal *metis*”; perhaps some would compare this with the contrast between *dianoia* and *doxa* verses *theoria* and *noesis*—but in any event, it is a divine quality, for:

Love is divine. Strife is divine. Each one of the four elements or roots is divine. So whatever you see or hear is divine. And whatever you see or hear with is divine. This means that when you manage to separate your awareness into one pure element—not by thinking about it, simply by doing it—you are pure divinity...not to perceive, but to perceive...perceiving—to watch the perceptive process itself...Nothing is to be left out. Not the slightest preference is to be shown to one sense as opposed to any other. And this choiceless, all embracing awareness can only happen in one moment: right now (348, 511).

The motion made motionless in the eternal now through divine perception, metis, perceiving Itself, shares another kinship in traditional symbolism—the “wu wei” of the Taoist “Transcendent Man” described by Guenon, one who has reached the goal, and attained “metaphysical freedom” in actuality. Thus, perhaps apropos, we conclude these very casual observations with Guenon’s description of that state in his “Great Triad”, as translated by Mr. Kingsley:

Heaven is as it were made manifest to them through him. Because his action, or rather his influence, is ‘central’, it imitates—and from the point of view of the world of humanity it also ‘incarnates’ the ‘Activity of Heaven’. This influence is ‘actionless’, which means that it does not involve any external activity. The ‘One and only Man’ exercises his role as ‘unmoved mover’ from his position at the center. He controls everything without intervening in anything (127).

Posted on 2013-01-30 by Frater M

3.7 The Most Beautiful Work

This is part one of a review of *Plato’s View of Man* by **Constantine Cavarnos**, available from the Institute for Byzantine and Modern Greek

Studies⁵.

It is within our power to transform our lives, to restore the proper order within ourselves, giving primacy to spiritual over material values. No task is more urgent, no work more glorious than the regeneration of individuals and of states. In the *Euthyphro* **Plato** calls it “**the most beautiful work**”, which man can accomplish with divine aid.

C. CAVARNOS

We must take care that a teacher of doctrines, which are food for the soul, does not deceive us, like the merchant and the retail-dealer, who sell food for the body. For the latter praise all their goods, although neither they know what is good and what is bad for the body, nor those who buy from them, unless one happens to be a trainer or physician.

In the same manner, those who take their doctrines about in cities and sell them by retail to the person who desires them, praise everything that they sell, although, my excellent friend, probably some of them are ignorant which of their wares is good and which is bad for the soul; and their customers are similarly ignorant, unless one happens to be a *physician of the soul*.

PLATO, *Protagoras*

There are three philosophical sciences. Although they have their empirical and profane counterpart, these sciences are meant in the esoteric sense of referring to the inner nature of their subject matter.

- **Anthropology**, the science of man

⁵<https://ibmgs.org/ancientphil.html>

- **Cosmology**, the science of the cosmos
- **Theology**, the science of God

In this short book, Mr. Cavarinos focuses on anthropology as taught to us by Plato. The two essays are followed by a series of extracts from Plato's actual works. As such, it provides a good summary of our understanding of man and his destiny. The point is not simply to explain Plato, but rather to encourage us to engage in "the most beautiful work", at least those of us who are capable of it.

Man's True Abode Man's true abode is a world of absolute truth, goodness, and beauty, which is the conclusion of the philosophical life. The devil is in the details; even after becoming dimly aware of that, there is still the work that needs to be done. There are some obstacles that can impede one's path.

Beauty Beauty is understood as order and harmony. Mr. Cavarinos writes:

By contemplating objects that possess measure and proportion and by purifying himself through the practice of self-examination, the lover of wisdom becomes more and more orderly and harmonious, more and more God-like. His whole soul becomes converted from darkness to light, from untruth to truth, from the changing to the unchanging, from becoming to being, from disunity to unity.

Many fall short at this point by confusing the idea of Beauty with the accumulation of beautiful things. The mistake is to forgo the development of one's inner harmony through the attempt to create an orderly and harmonious environment.

Eros is the aspiration for beauty, or love. It is not sublimated sexual desire as in Freud, but rather sexual desire is understood as a lower form of eros; it is the desire for physical immortality through one's descendants. Eros has led heroes to undergo dangers. Love spurs others to create works of the spirit.

The Platonic path of love passes from the concrete to the abstract, from the particular to the universal, from the personal to the impersonal. The true initiate rises from the love of bodies to the love of persons, then to the love of theories, next to that of institutions and communities, and finally to that of absolute transcendent Beauty.

Mr. Cavarinos objects to that on the ground that Christian love is the love of the person, not the abstract. On the other hand, Plato's view is consistent with the increasing levels of abstraction associated with the angelic hierarchy. No man is an island, so it is difficult to conceive of man apart from the institutions and communities that he belongs to. They certainly deserve our love.

Goodness A man's fate after death is determined by his way of life on earth. Lust and a contentious attitude are impediments to the good life:

Whoso indulges in lusts or in contentions and devotes himself overmuch thereto must of necessity be filled with opinions that are wholly mortal and . . . has made great his mortal part. But he who has seriously devoted himself to learning and to true thoughts, and has exercised these qualities above all others, must necessarily and inevitably think thoughts that are immortal and divine. (Timaeus)

Truth

I live in the midst of a lie, and die for a lie, and the earth is a lie, and rests on a lie, on a stupid derision.

DOSTOYEVSKY, *The Demons*

How does one find the truth in a world dominated by the lie? Man suffers from inner deformity or ugliness, from disease of the psyche. He is a deformed being in need of harmony, of beauty; he is a sick being, in need of therapy. This is the result of ignorance, which is the cause of the vices of cowardice, intemperance, and injustice. There are two types of ignorance:

- Conscious ignorance, of which a person is cognizant
- Unconscious ignorance, in which the person claims to know what he does not know

Unconscious ignorance is more insidious, since such a person is not motivated to seek knowledge and believes he is a better person than he really is. The rational man is painfully aware of his faults and shortcomings. He knows how difficult it is to achieve any knowledge. He understands the efforts required to master one's will.

The unconsciously ignorant person, on the other hand, is convinced of his moral superiority. He has a "good heart", a "happy gene", a "positive mind", and so on. He believes in all the right causes with a self-serving passion. Ultimately, he is "beyond dogma and ideas", his religion is love. In practice, that means that he is impervious to rational and intellectual thought. Unconscious ignorance assumes the form of pride, conceit, prejudice, and leads to contentious and false sophistry. Basically, unconscious ignorance is a lie told to oneself.

The "greatest and most efficacious method of purification" is *elenchos*: the process of examining one's beliefs, opinions, and feelings. It purifies "the soul from conceits that stand in the way of knowledge." The proper use of this method results in intellectual integrity and inner health.

It brings about a harmony between what a person thinks he knows and what he really knows, between what he professes to believe and what he really believes, between what he imagines himself to be and what he really is.

Immortality

Two associated aspirations raise the human soul above the rest of created nature: the hunger for immortality and the thirst for truth or moral perfection. Either without the other is meaningless ... Endless life without truth and perfection would be an eternity of torment, and perfection without immortality would be rank injustice and indignity without measure.

VLADIMIR SOLOVYOV

Plato offers several proofs for the immortality of the soul, which we need not go into at this point. Life extension for its own sake is pointless. A soul that has become purified and perfected may eternally behold perfect Truth, Goodness, and Beauty. There the soul will live with the gods. Obviously, no one is interested in that today. However, if you declare that the soul will spend eternity with its dogs, the whole world takes notice.

Plato's explanation is that the soul participates in the idea of Life. Mr. Cavernos clarifies that notion:

That some such view is involved in the Christian conception of immortality is undeniable. But the life in which the soul participates is not for the Christian an abstract idea, but the grace of the Holy Spirit. Only in so far as a man comes to partake of this does he become truly alive and immortal.

I do nothing but go about persuading you, old and young, to care neither for your bodies nor for money more than for the perfection of your souls, or even as much.

Apology

There neither is nor will there ever be anything of greater importance than the cultivation of the soul.

Phaedrus

When the soul and the body are united, nature orders the body to serve and be ruled, and the soul to rule and be master.

Phaedo

Soul, Body, Money

- Care of the soul is fundamental, because a person *is* the soul. Not what a person has, but what he is constitutes his real dignity.
- A person who cherishes the body does not cherish himself, but what belongs to him.
- The person who tends money tends neither himself nor his own things, and is a stage further removed from himself.

A philosopher needs leisure time and funds to pursue wisdom, though he does not need wealth. He keeps his body healthy for the same reason. He does not use his rational part simply for the pursuit of money. He does not pursue the care of the soul solely to cure the body.

Faculties of the Soul

- Rational power
 - Consists of the intellect and eros (love)
 - Directed toward the true, the good, and the beautiful
- Spirited power
 - Consists of conviction (or faith) and thumos
 - Directed toward ruling, conquering, and getting fame
 - Gymnastics strengthens this power and music moderates it and keeps it in harmony with reason.
- Appetitive Power
 - Consists of conjecture (or opinion) and desire
 - Directed toward eating, drinking, sensual pleasures, and material gain
 - There are three types of desire:
 - Necessary desires
 - Unnecessary and spendthrift desires
 - Lawless desires

Five Forms of the State Since there are five forms of individual life, there are five forms of the State corresponding to them. The State arises out of the predominant human characters. These forms are: the aristocratic, the timocratic, the oligarchic, the democratic, and the tyrannic. The first two follow from the rational and spirited powers and the last three from the three types of desires.

This schema can be tried as an analytic tool to understand current events, from the “third dimension”, as it were. The transition from one type of rule to the next documents a process of decline. Of course, any actual society will contain a mixture of the various types and their manifestations may vary quite a bit.

The important lesson here is that it is nearly impossible to communicate across these types, since their aims and their notion of rationality are so different.

Aristocratic The aristocratic man, or the “best”, is virtuous and ruled by reason. He knows the divine ideas, eternal and timeless. Thus he is guided by nature, by the universal.

It is important to note that this definition is not at all what is commonly meant by “aristocrat” today. For Plato, the aristocrat corresponds more to the priestly or spiritual caste, but without the religious overtones.

Rule by the best is unlikely. The other types are more driven to seize power. Moreover, while the aristocrat sees the life of reason as liberation, those who are dominated by the appetites experience it as oppression.

Timocratic The timocrat is the honor-loving man. His guide is not wisdom, but rather law and custom. He is governed by belief and conviction which are time tested. The timocrat corresponds to what was later called the “aristocrat” in the Middle Ages and to this day. He is the one that values his breeding and keeps portraits of his ancestors in the castle. These are the dukes, barons, and so on. In other words, this type corresponds to the warrior caste.

The timocrat is guided by custom and law, unlike the aristocrat; in other words, by the particular, not the universal. In the well-ordered state, he submits to the wisdom of the aristocrats. Otherwise, this creates some tension between reason and custom. Nevertheless, since people are always part of a community, even the aristocrats must be loyal to their

own traditions. It is difficult to see where patriotism fits in, given Mr. Cavarinos' objections.

The timocrat is arrogant and ambitious, but his aristocratic fathers were rational.

Oligarchic The timocrat may be a general or other high office holder. When such men are attacked, outlawed, or otherwise diminished, the oligarchic type arises. Seeing no value in the principle of the love of honor, he instead enthrones the principle of appetite and avarice. This is his psychic center. The rational and spirited part of him is used solely to acquire money.

The philosopher of this type (if that is the correct word to use) is Ayn Rand. While claiming to be a follower of Aristotle, her use of reason is restricted to the satisfaction of necessary desires. A society dominated by this type will not admire reasonable or honorable men, but rather rich men. The oligarch, like a Mr. Scrooge, may often be temperate in the satisfaction of bodily desires. He follows public opinion in most matters.

Democratic The sons of the oligarchic type gradually seek out unnecessary pleasures. They lack the self-discipline of their fathers. All desires are equally alike and he cannot discriminate between better and worse desires. Hence, he discards moral standards.

He calls insolence 'good breeding'. license 'liberty'. prodigality 'magnificence' and shamelessness 'manliness'.

Republic

This type is easily recognized in a democratic society. For example, when extended to public policy, prodigality results in public debt. The last of the list exposes how even some self-described "new right" types are really democrats in disguise.

This type is fickle, bouncing from pleasure-seeking to flirtations with philosophy or even spirituality. But there is little depth to his thinking. He often just says what pops into his head. He is not guided by reason, tradition, or common opinions. Rather, he has an inordinate craving for freedom.

Tyrannic Too much freedom breeds dissension and anarchy. Mob rule results; a leader arises among them, and the appointed rulers are cast out.

The tyrannic type purges out of himself every desire or opinion that is deemed good, discards all self-control and brings in madness to the full. He has no respect for his parents. He is made up of fierce base desires and his life is the furthest from the life of reason. Plato includes murder and incest among the lawless desires, but they are just the peak. There are other such desires that are considered quite normal and respectable in our time.

In a tyranny, assuming the tyrant seizes control, the people are reduced to slavery. The tyrant stirs up wars and impoverishes his subjects by the imposition of heavy taxes. He gets rid of his boldest followers and purges the State of the wise and the brave.

Fifth Virtue Plato sometimes mentions a fifth virtue: holiness or piety (both translate the same Greek word). But this virtue belongs to religion, not philosophy, so philosophy is ultimately insufficient. As we have seen, piety was the most important virtue for the Romans. Therefore, the aristocrat of the soul should strive for holiness, beyond justice, wisdom, courage, and temperance.

Posted on 2014-12-14 by Cologero

* * *

Ezra f on 2014-12-19 at 21:04 said:

According to Guenon, the spiritual caste is supra-rational and a traditional society is based on supra-rational principles. He attributes much of the moderna deviation to rationalism.

Cologero on 2014-12-19 at 23:34 said:

Thanks for reminding us of that, Ezra, but keep in mind that this is a book review. I picked out key points from the book. As Mr. Cavaros points out, there is the virtue of “holiness” which transcends the rational. Mr. Caranovos was the one who reminds us that Platonism (or neoplatonism) is an exoteric teaching. Also keep in mind that the supra-rational is not equivalent to “irrational”; this is important in an era where simply being rational would be an accomplishment. Here, of course, by rational, we mean knowledge of the divine essences, or being. Guenon makes this claim:

It was only among the neoplatonists that Eastern influences were again to make their appearances, and it is there indeed that certain metaphysical ideas, such as that of the Infinite, are to be met with for the first time among the Greeks.

Now it may or may not be true that this was the “first” time. I think not, since the Greeks had learned some things from the Egyptians and Persians. Furthermore, in several other places, Guenon compares certain doctrines of Aristotle favorably with Eastern doctrines. So there is some inconsistency there.

I have also mentioned that Indian writers have often noted points of correspondence with Western philosophers of the rationalist type. Perhaps, then, the Easterners have become just as decadent. That is probably true, since much of contemporary Hindu spirituality is replete with fraud and deception. Hence, we have to start from where we are and from what we know, not from where we would like to end up.

3.8 Plotinus: The Peak of Pagan Wisdom

This originally appeared in *Introduction to Magic, Volume 3*, by the **Gruppo di Ur**. It was published under the name “Plotino” and I haven’t been able to determine the identity.

It is up to the gods to come to me, not for me to go to them.

The whole spirit of the “solar” way is contained in **Plotinus**’ bold response to Amelio, who invited him to approach the gods with the prescribed rites. The surpassing of the religious attitude, the transcendent dignity of man in possession of Wisdom; and his superiority not only in relation to the natural world, but also in relation to the divine, are asserted.

In particular, it is about an inner meaning, which is essential for practice, because if you do not understand it, if you do not achieve it, it is useless to talk of “magic”, it is useless to start with abstruse “ceremonials”, and useless to devote oneself to ascetic disciplines or yogic “exercises”.

It is necessary to create a quality in oneself, through which the super-sensible powers (the gods) are forced to be like females attracted to the male. This quality can be summed up in a word that means nothing and means everything: BEING.

BE, ENDURE, become a CENTER. Through “ascesis”, through “purification”, through what Plotinus himself will now make explicit. You have heard of “solar way”. This is its secret. Separated from those with disordered need, yearning soul, and confused look — more ‘non-being’ than ‘being’ — they are attracted to the invisible worlds.

It is necessary to make yourself one self like the gods: not like the leading citizens *uomini da bene*.

Not to be exonerated from sin, but to be a God — is the goal.

These maxims bluntly separate the way of the initiate from the way of men. The “virtue” of men, in the final analysis, is something indifferent: “the image of an image,” says Plotinus. “Morality” has nothing to do with initiation. Initiation is a radical transformation of one state of existence to another state of existence. A “God” is not a “moral value”: it is another being. A good man does not cease to be “man” by being “good.” At any time and place where the meaning of “initiation” is understood, the idea was always the same. Thus in hermetism:

Our work is the conversion and a change of a being into another being, of one thing into another thing, weakness into strength ... corporeality into spirituality.

Even evil men can take water from rivers. Whoever gives simply ignores that which gives.

How does man stand in relation to the whole? As a part? No. As a whole that belongs to himself.

Minus “one”, are those minus “being”: more, those who are more.

He is himself, every being, belonging to himself; and to belong to oneself, is to center oneself. The One possesses himself, and has all the greatness and beauty. Behold: he does not flow and does not avoid himself indefinitely. The whole thing is now gathered together in its unity.

The first element that constitutes the condition of “being” is unity.

Unify Yourself — Be One.

That bundle of energy, that people of beings, sensations, tendencies that you are, enfold it under a single law, under a single will, under a single thought.

Organize Yourself

Bend your “soul”, use it in every sense, take it to every crossroad as long as it is inert, incapable of proper motion, dead to every irrationality of instinct. Like a perfectly tamed horse, when driven to the right, it goes right, when driven to the left, it goes left, when braked, it stops, when incited, it flings itself — so also your soul is for you: one thing you keep wholly in your fist. Without constraints, you will be One: being one, you *are* — and you belong to yourself. Belonging to yourself, greatness belongs to you.

The ancient classical Aryan wisdom distinguished two symbolic regions: the lower one of the things that “escape”, the higher, of the “things that are.” The things that are powerless to come to the realization and

perfect possession of their nature flow and “escape”. The others are those that have transcended that life that is mixed with death, and that is a flowing and continuous longings. Their “immobility”, and the same ancient astronomical designation of their “place”, are symbols. A spiritual state is designated. Being one, no longer dispersed, follows it.

What is the Good for such a man? He is himself his own good. The life that he possesses is perfect. He possesses the good, insofar as he is not in search of another.

To remove whatever is other in respect to his own being, is to purify oneself.

In simple relationship with you without hindrance in your pure unity, without the thing that it is mixed interiorly with this purity, being you only in pure light ... you became a vision.

Although being here, you are ascended.

You no longer need guidance.

Fix your gaze. You'll see.

With singular brevity, what is expressed here, in a transcendent sense, is to be called “good”: the absence of anything that, penetrating inn itself, might take him outside of himself in desire or impulse. Plotinus is careful to clarify the spiritual significance of such a concept by saying that the superior man can even “look for other things insofar as they are indispensable, not to him, but to those things close to him: to the body to which he is joined, to the life of the body that is not his life. Knowing what the body needs, gives it to him, but these things have no bearing on his life. ”

“Evil” is the sense of need in the spirit: that of every life that, not knowing how to stand up in himself, loses heart here and there, yearning, looking to complete itself with the achievement of one thing or the other. As long as there is this “need”, as long as there is this internal and

radical insufficiency, the Good is not there. It is nothing nameable: it is an experience that only an act of the spirit on the spirit can produce: separating it from the idea of ?? every other, rejoining it with himself. A state of certainty and fullness then arises, when given, one no longer asks for anything, all talk, all speculation, all agitation, is useless, while one does not know what more can produce a change in the deep mind. Plotinus rightly says that the man, who possesses the whole of his life, possesses perpetuity: being only “I”, nothing can be added to him, neither in the past nor in the present nor in the future.

The state of being, is to be present.

Every being is in action and in act.

Pleasure is the act of life.

The souls in this universe can also be happy. If they are not – they accuse themselves, not the universe. They have surrendered in this struggle, where the reward crowns virtue.

Plotinus again clarifies the meaning of “being”: to be is to be present, to be in act. He speaks of “that intellectual nature without sleep”, a strictly traditional expression. We know the term: “Awakened”, the “Always awake” and the symbolism of the “sleep”, which furthermore can be more than symbolism in reference to the continuity of a “being present” and that does not undergo alteration even in the change of state that usually corresponds to sleep.

To be, therefore, is to be awake. The experience of the whole concentrated in an intellectual clarity, in the simplicity of an act — it is the experience of “being”. To abandon oneself, to fail — this is the secret of non-being. The fatigue of the interior unity that loosens and skids, the inner energy that ceases to dominate every part of it as almost, through a disintegration, a multiplicity of tendencies, instincts, and irrational sensations arise – this is the self-deterioration of the spirit that is manifested

in more and more oblique and stunned nature until it reaches the limit form of swoon that is expressed in matter. It is a misunderstanding, says Plotinus, to say that matter is: the being of matter is non-being. Its indefinite divisibility indicates precisely the “fall” of the unity that it represents; its inertia, whence it is heavy, strong and blunt, is the same that is characteristic of those who, while failing, cannot hold and deteriorates. That the “truth” characteristic of physical knowledge is different does not matter. Corporeal being is the non-being of the spiritual.

Like the actual state of culmination, “being” is one with the “good.” So “matter” and “evil”, in turn, identify with each other; and there is no other “evil” except for matter. Here it is naturally necessary to detach oneself, to give up all human preconceptions. The “evil” of men has no place in reality and therefore in a metaphysical vision which is always a vision in accordance with reality.

Metaphysically, ‘good’ and ‘evil’ do not exist, but rather what is real and what is not — and the degree of “reality” (meant in the spiritual sense previously explained by “being”) measures the degree of “virtue”. In the dry and virile view of ancient classical-Aryan man, only the state of “privation” of “being” was “bad”: the fatigue, the neglect, the sleep of the interior strength that sets “matter” at the limit, as has been said. Neither “evil” nor “matter” are therefore principles in themselves: they were derived through ‘degradation’ and ‘dissolution’. Plotinus expresses himself exactly in these terms:

By falling short of the Good, darkness is seen and in the darkness we live. And the evil for the soul is this falling short, the producer of darkness. This is the first evil. Darkness is something that proceeds from it. And the nature of evil is not in matter, but prior to matter in the cessation of the act that gave rise to matter.

Plotinus adds: pleasure is the act of life. It is the same view already established by another great genius of the ancient world, Aristotle, who

had taught that every activity, insofar as it is perfect, is happy. Happiness and pleasure are like that in the form of purity and freedom: those who arise from the act that is fulfilled and that, once fulfilled, realizes the One, Being, the Good – not those passive and promiscuous men grabbed into the middle of the turbid self-satisfaction of cravings, thirsts, instincts. Again we are led to the non-human point of view of “reality”. The one who does not know the irrationality of sentiments. The degree of “being” is the secret and measurement of happiness itself.

Consequently, Plotinus asserts that the even in this universe souls can be happy: highlighting, by this, an important aspect of the pagan conception of existence. If “virtue”, as the dominating spiritual actuality, implies power, one can conceive as little that the “good” is accompanied by “happiness”, as glory is separable from victory. Whoever is defeated by external or internal constraint is not “good”: and for such a being to be happy would be unjust. But he accuses only himself of that, not the world.

Otherwise, we understand, the thing is for whoever reduces “virtue” to a simple “moral” disposition.

He certainly says, then, that “my kingdom is not of this world” and expects God to give happiness in the “afterlife” as a reward to the “just”, who, lacking power, have tolerated and endured injustice with humility and resignation in this life. The warrior and heroic truth of ancient classical-Aryan man was different. If “evil” and all its materialization in violence and limits of inferior forces and corporeal things has roots in a state of degradation of the good—it is inconceivable, it is logically contradictory that it might endure as a principle of unhappiness and servitude in respect to whoever destroyed that root, having become “good.” If “good” *is*, then “evil”—suffering, passion, slavery—cannot be. They, then, will say that “virtue” is still imperfect; “being” is still incomplete; “purity” and “unity” are still “adulterated”.

There are those who are unarmed. But who has weapons, fights—

there is no God who fights for those who are not in arms. The law requires that victory in war is to the brave, not to those who pray.

It is just that the cowardly are dominated by the wicked .

New reaffirmation of the virile, Roman, warrior spirit of the pagan tradition. New contrast with the mystical-religious attitude. New contempt for those who deprecate the “injustice” of earthly things and instead of blaming their cowardice, they either resign themselves to their powerlessness, or they blame the Whole or hope that “Providence” cares about them.

“There is no God who fights for those who are not in arms.” This is the anti-Christian cornerstone of every warrior morality; and it carries back to the concepts explained above about the identification—from the metaphysical point of view—of “reality”, “spirituality”, and “virtue”. The cowardly cannot be good, “good” implies a soul of a hero. And the perfection of the hero is the triumph. Ask God for victory, it would be equivalent to ask Him for “virtue”: since victory is the body in which the very perfection of “virtue” takes place.

The soldiers of Fabius, while leaving, vowed not to conquer or die, but vowed to fight and to return as victors. And the victors returned. The spirit of Rome reflects the spirit of this same wisdom.

For fear, total suppression, the soul has nothing to be afraid of.

Those who fear nothing have not reached the perfection of virtue.
He is mediocrity.

In the higher man *spoudaus* , feelings are not displayed as in the others. Do not reach the interior: they are other things, are suffering and grief, his or others. This would be weakness of the soul.

If suffering passes the measure—that pass it. The light that is in him will last, like the lamp of a lighthouse in the swirling wind and storm.

Master of himself even in this state, will decide what there is to do.

The *spoudaus* would not be such, if a demon was acting within his action. In him, it is the sovereign mind (*nous*) that acts.

Plotinus admits that the superior man can sometimes have involuntary and unreflective fears, but almost as movements that do not belong to him and because his spirit is not present.

Coming back to himself, he will drive them away ... Like a child who remains tamed only by the majesty of those who gaze on him fixedly.

Concerning suffering, it can at most cause the separation of a part of oneself not yet free from passion: but never the overturning of the higher principle. "He will decide what there is to do." When it is the case, he may also withdraw from the game. Do not forget that according to Plotinus the superior man is in himself his own "demon" and he lives here below like an actor who plays a part he freely chose. Against the Gnostics Christians he retorted sharply, "Why despise this world, where you yourselves have come to by your own will? It permits you to go away if good is not found there."

As *nous* in man can be precisely defined as the "being" principle consisting of pure intellectuality, it is the "Olympic mind" with respect to which the "soul" principle (*psyche*) already represents a marginal wrapping up: at most, it is a profundity that is hidden and latent. But then, more than the "I", it is a "demon" who acts in every action. Plotinus says exactly that everything that happens without deliberation, unites a demon to a god. We now see who the opposite condition is revealed.

There, the why of being ... it does not exist as why, but as being.
Better: the two things are one.

May everyone be himself.

May our thoughts and our actions be our own. May the actions of each being belong to him. Whether they be good—whether they be evil.

When the soul has pure and impassible reason for a guide, in full self-mastery, where he wants to direct his energy. Only then can the act be said to be ours, not another's: from interiority of the soul as a purity, as a pure dominating and sovereign principle... not by action misled by ignorance and fragmented by desire ... For, then, passion, and not act, it would be in us.

Feelings are the visions of the soul asleep.

Everything of the soul that is in the body sleeps. To come out of the body, is the true awakening. Changing lives with a body, is to pass from one sleep to another sleep, from one bed to another bed.

To truly awaken, is to leave the world of bodies.

As materiality is the state of swoon of the spirit, so the reality of sleep is every reality that appears to us in the midst of the material senses. The coming out from the body and the abandonment of the world of bodies is, however, not grossly interpreted: it is essentially about an interior transformation, a self-integration in the “intellectual nature without sleep”. And this is the true initiatic and metaphysical realization.

Very effectively, Plotinus assimilates the transformation of the body in passing from one bed to another. When it also had a consistency, the doctrine of reincarnation could not be better stigmatized, as in the part of this pagan initiate. One form is equivalent to another in the “cycle of births” in respect to the center which is equally distant from every point on the circumference. Metaphysical realization is a fracture in the series of conditioned states: one opening above a radically heterogeneous direction. One does not reach it by following the trail of those types who

“flee”, those who pursue a goal that they have outside themselves: in the becoming of the world of bodies.

What must there be in front of you as a spectacle, if one looks at the outer world. But now, you need to look at yourself; to make yourself one with what you have to contemplate; to know that what you have to contemplate is yourself.

And that is your task. As someone who was invaded by the god Phoebus or a Muse, he would see himself shine in divine clarity, if he had the power at the same time to contemplate in himself this divine light.

Posted on 2013-03-19 by Aeneas

* * *

David on 2013-03-17 at 21:12 said:

Interesting. But I always have problem with that kind of reflection as to whether it is Solar, or Promethean in a affirmation so close to existentialism and self-proclamation of God. Of course, the Self is the Whole (Atman is Brahman), and therefore everything is kept in check. But the line is thin. Still, the «Center» and «Unify yourself» themes remind me of Rumi : «You are not a drop in the ocean.

You are the entire ocean in a drop.»

Jason-Adam on 2013-03-17 at 21:40 said:

This text is NOT anti-Christian, despite what moderns may think, I must point out as the goal of perfection – of union with God – is the goal of Catholic mystical theology. St Dionysius and the German mystics of the XIVth century are all in accord with Plotinus – who by the way through St Augustine is an important influence on Catholic philosophy.

Though he never came out and identified as such, Baron Evola was a Neoplatonist, as some have pointed out recently. In fact Traditionalism as a whole has been described as the merger of Neoplatonism with Hinduism, and I am in accord with that interpretation.

David on 2013-03-17 at 21:42 said:

What about the monistic view of Vedanta, or some mystics (sufi or christian), opposed to the dualism of body and soul of Platonic view ?

Logres on 2013-03-18 at 09:13 said:

“An image of an image”: excellent. So much for humanism today. Could someone of a lower caste, by following assiduously the rites, possibly obtain a pre-mortem initiation through obesciance?

scardanelli on 2013-03-18 at 09:22 said:

I don't think that this text is inherently anti-Christian, yet after being exposed to other writers such as Tomberg and Mouravieff and coming back to Evola, it does come off as somewhat proud and vainglorious. At times it seems that Evola defines the solar path as this sense of pride, whereas in Tomberg for example, the solar path has more to do with chastity and love. I have a feeling though that this has more to do with differing perspectives, one of priestly contemplation and the other warrior and active, rather than any dispute over metaphysics. Perhaps this is why the active/warrior path will not take one the full distance to liberation, because this vaingloriousness is essential to the active path, yet is also a major stumbling block, as described in *The Charioteer* in MOT... just conjecture though. Am I right in this?

scardanelli on 2013-03-18 at 09:43 said:

Of course, i'm assuming that this was written by Evola and not one of the other members of the Ur Group.

Cologero on 2013-03-18 at 12:48 said:

I don't know who wrote it, as it is attributed to “Plotino” himself.

Introduzione alla Magia: <http://books.google.com/books?id=JL0nuzXtx2UC&printsec=frontcover&dq=introduzione+alla+magia&hl=en&sa=X&ei=M0NHUd-yDYba8wSYoIGIAQ&ved=0CDMQ6AEwAA#v=onepage&q=Plotino&f=false>

Cologero on 2013-03-18 at 13:00 said:

The tone may appear over the top, but keep in mind that the “gods” referred to are simply the super-human states. We would refer to them, as does Rene Guenon, as angels rather than “gods”. I don't see how that can be accomplished passively (although it may happen as a grace); rather a man must make the necessary efforts. Try to read it in that light.

I don't suspect that Plotinus is referring to the “One” in the same way. And to be consistent with all the other writings that have appeared here, I don't believe he is saying that man qua man is raised up to the “gods”, but rather that the human, all too human, state must give way to the higher state.

On the other hand, and I can't remember the source of this, I believe Dostoevsky said that the man who wants to make himself God succeeds in becoming not even an insect.

Saladin on 2013-03-18 at 20:19 said:

"Though he never came out and identified as such, Baron Evola was a Neoplatonist, ..."

I think you are right as much as we can put a label "...ist" on the Maestro. His praise for Emperor Julian (so called "apostate") who was a thorough Neoplatonist is proof of your conjecture.

scardanelli on 2013-03-20 at 09:56 said:

I see... Thanks for the clarification. I think I am beginning to understand the way in which one approaches these texts. If one wants to see difference and discord, he will remain in the realm of discursive thought and will have difficulty "penetrating" their truths, so to speak. I suppose this is what Tomberg means when he states that the Hermetic path seeks the middle way in neutralizing binaries above.

P.S. Forgive the constant references to Tomberg and Mouravieff... they are my only reference points at this stage though i'm sure they are old hat to the rest here.

Jason-Adam on 2013-03-19 at 08:38 said:

This piece needs further commentary. I am sensing a Nietzschean tone throughout the essay and Evola may be trying to remold Plotinus into a proto-Nietzsche ?

Cologero on 2013-03-19 at 09:17 said:

It may be helpful for someone to verify the Plotinus quotes, since the process from Greek to Italian and then English seems to have produced some awkward wordings. I previously provided the link to the text where the references can be found. I have marked the actual quotes next to a blue vertical bar.

Cassiodorus on 2013-03-19 at 12:29 said:

Do the adherents of Tradition regard the Platonic philosophical mysticism of late antiquity as a Revelation or a merely "human system"? Does the doctrine of the Self suggest that Revelation is not, well, "necessary"? Does the formal "avataric descent" actually make intellection/realization possible? That is, does it "open the door"? Or does Revelation simply point the way?

(Apologies for beating this horse) On Plotinian emanationalism... I'm not sure- historically speaking, traditional Christians have defended the view that *creatio ex nihilo* implies that, between creator and creation, there is an absolute ontological chasm. The classical theist wouldn't, of course, deny Divine immanence, but there is an insistence on the radical divide between the natural and supernatural – to safeguard His transcendence. To suggest anything that resembles the "Supreme Identity" violates *creatio ex nihilo* and automatically leads to howls of gnosticism

and pantheism. Would it be fair to say that, from the perspective of classical theism, it is essential to distinguish between *imago Dei* and the nondual doctrine of the Self?

Jason-Adam on 2013-03-19 at 17:58 said:

As a Catholic who believes in the genuineness of the works of St Dionysius, I will say that despite what the Traditionalists would have us believe it was actually Neoplatonism that was influenced by Christianity – Dionysius predating Plotinus.

Take it from where it comes from, but Dugin in his METAPHYSICS OF THE GOSPEL claims that Orthodox Christianity teaches manifestationism not creationism as the Western church does.

Cologero on 2013-03-19 at 17:59 said:

From the Summa Theologica:

creation, which is the emanation of all being, is from the not-being
which is nothing

For the whole discussion on this topic, refer to: *Question 45. The mode of emanation of things from the first principle*⁶.

As for “resembling” the “supreme identity”, by which I presume you mean God, I consider “image and likeness” to be synonyms, so your accusation of a violation misses the mark (allusion intended).

I hope we will not get bogged down in a theological “debate”, which is on the level of discursive reason. There is plenty of “real” material to ponder, such as the meaning of being “awake” vs sleep, the identity of being and power, what is the “nous” that transcends discursive reasoning, what exactly is that “interior transformation” that was mentioned, and so on. I had to put up with heresy hunters from the neo-pagans, and I won’t tolerate it from the other side. Gornahoor is entirely optional and I have no desire to convince anyone of anything against their will.

Jason-Adam on 2013-03-19 at 20:38 said:

So creation = emanation and all things do contain a trace of the Trinity.

There is then no conflict between Plotinus and St Thomas.

Logres on 2013-03-19 at 23:06 said:

It’s interesting that Clement of Alexandria embraces, even claims, the term Gnostic for advancement in the Christian faith. When he debates points with them, he usually uses their level of reasoning and accepts many, if not most of their dogmas, in some form.

⁶<http://www.newadvent.org/summa/1045.htm>

Logres on 2013-03-19 at 23:08 said:

I think Elder Thaddeus (Your Thoughts Determine Your Life) draws a distinction between image and likeness, but only for those who are not on the true path (which Clement would say culminates in Gnosis). We all have His image, but through sin we deform His likeness. Ideally, you have both.

Cassiodorus on 2013-03-20 at 01:08 said:

Colegero,

I appreciate the link that you provided.

Mihai on 2013-03-20 at 04:40 said:

Trying so hard to equate Christianity and Neo-Platonism is a mistake. So is taking everything uncritically and unconditionally from the ancient greek philosophers.

For me, Plato is an invaluable resource on the path towards Truth. However, I do recognize that, every now and then in his writings, he does show inaccuracies, inconsistencies or exaggeration. It is a question of taking what is good and not being limited by some of the few failings he has. And what is good is precisely what conforms to metaphysical principles, in other words, the exposition of genuine traditional doctrine.

The same goes for Neo-Platonism. Both Plato's writings and those of Plotinus (and the rest of the neo-platonists) represent a synthesis of ancient and traditional metaphysical doctrines, but they are not direct Revelation- such as Christianity is. This means that individual opinion is sometimes present alongside with the great truths they expose, thus presenting certain limitations.

This is why they should be used as templates, as means to an end, but not ends in themselves.

The same goes with the writings of those such as Guenon, Evola and the like.

Jason-Adam on 2013-03-20 at 07:16 said:

I agree, Mihai.

As I was pointing out, Plotinus was influenced by the Christian St Dionysius.

Logres on 2013-03-20 at 07:59 said:

You need to spell this out more: what about natural revelation, the inner image of Man, etc.? If Christianity and the Bible are to be believed, these things have a much stronger place than traditionally accorded within the Faith, although Orthodoxy does better than most. Revelation, I agree, is more than the limiting factor of secular Reason, or a purely esoteric and private truth, however, "Revelation" as usually used within the Faith is exoterically denoted: Plotinus is not

speaking of this, here. Additionally, there is the fact of works like the *Stromata*, in which Clement claims that a natural revelation actually preceded the Scripture, and is endorsed (for example) when St. Paul quotes the poet Aratus. In the *Stromata*, Clement goes so far as to claim that the Greek “revelation” is a corruption of a “barbarian” and “Northern” revelation that comes even more directly from God, and finds its natural heir in the Israelite mythos.

Mihai on 2013-03-21 at 06:41 said:

Of course, the Greek myths and legends were echoes of much more ancient, perhaps even primordial revelations. There are, of course, many Hyperborean allusions in them.

However, the Greek religion(s), as we know them, historically, certainly degenerated into superstitions and polytheism, with sorcery occupying top place, at least in the first centuries AD.

As for Plato and Plotinus: it is said that Plato, his main influence, traveled to Egypt to learn the ancient wisdom, which explains much of the contents of his writings. Plotinus was, of course, also influenced by ancient Eastern wisdom. Both, however, seem to have, afterwards, relied on their own efforts to put all this into a workable template. It is not clear whether or not they received some kind of initiation. In one of his books on initiation, Guenon claimed that Plotinus “seems to have had some kind of hindrance that prevented his initiation from becoming fully active and workable”, but I don’t know where he got that idea from and why.

Anyway, neither of them worked within the confines of a regular traditional revelation, in the light of which to balance their doctrines, which makes them fallible from time to time.

Jason-Adam on 2013-03-21 at 07:16 said:

Plato studied under the Israelites and merged what he learned from them with his own creations.

Cologero on 2013-03-22 at 09:35 said:

The point I was trying to make, Cassiodorus, even if harsh, is that matters are not so simple. As you see, Aquinas did not make a sharp distinction between creation and emanation. Here, we are taking Guenon at his word that theological propositions can be rephrased as metaphysical statements, hence we are taking that approach. If done correctly, there should be no conflict between them. To oppose one to another, would be like comparing a color to an odor; that is why we can’t be bogged down in tedious and unresolvable theological disputes. As Aquinas himself put it, there are certain things he knows through metaphysics that common people must believe by faith. Other things, he leaves to faith. However, as we have often pointed out, Solovoyov claims that even those dogmas can be known. That is something we will get to eventually.

The advantage of metaphysics is that more can be encompassed without unnecessary partisanship (not that it is all unnecessary).

3.9 Yangming's Doctrine of Awakening

It was pointed out in a discussion here that **Valentin Tomberg** wrote the following on “exteriorization”, summarizing the respective attitudes of Buddha and Christ to the vision of a damaged world:

The Buddha saw the true nature of the world and that it was sick. Considering it incurable he instituted an effective path to escape it. Christ saw the same truth, but believed that the world could be cured and instituted the path to heal the fallen world from the inside.

In simpler times, men referred to the Buddha's reluctance to confront the world as “Oriental quietude”. These days, we are privileged to know that many in the Orient did not share that attitude, not at that time nor at other times. One example that has been on my mind recently is the Neo-Confucian philosopher-*cum*-general **Wang Yangming** (1472-1528). The Chinese characters in Wang Yangming's name literally spell out, “King of Elucidating the Solar [Yang].” This name was given to him by his students.

Yangming founded an entire school of Confucian thought, which caused reverberations in China and Japan. One Japanese student, Kumazawa Banzan, said of Yangming, “He initiated a new movement in Confucianism, which lays stress on self-introspection. . . . We owe to him much for this, because the man who gives attention to his own inner self finds there the true man, and the truths of the classics revealed.” The ordinary Confucian draws his morals from his interpretation of society's needs; Yangming, in contrast, rediscovered the knowledge of the inner spirit and transcendence found in the earliest Confucian texts.

Yangming's school is one of practicality and action. In contrast to the tonsured, tenured, and timid Confucian scholars of his era, but in accordance with the Master himself, Yangming accepted government commissions and calmly directed armies into battle. He said, “No one who really

has knowledge fails to practice it. Knowledge without practice should be interpreted as lack of knowledge.” He in fact denounced Buddhism as cowardly:

The Buddhists are afraid of the responsibilities of father and son, and hence avoid such responsibility. They are afraid of the perplexities of prince and minister, and avoid becoming prince or minister. They are afraid of the responsibility of husband and wife, and hence avoid becoming husband and wife. . . . If we scholars have a father or a son, we recompense them with affection; if we have a prince or a minister, we use righteousness in dealing with them; if we have a husband or a wife, we pay attention to differences. Have we then been influenced by the relationships of father, son, prince, minister, husband and wife?

Banzan went even farther, pointing out that reincarnation was an unprovable concept, so therefore all Buddhism’s warnings about the impact of bad karma and future rebirth were mere empty threats. Banzan and Yangming share a belief that good behavior does not come from threats of hell, but from a much simpler source: the Conscience or Intuition within the human mind. To define the nature of this Intuition, Yangming approved of this remarkable statement by one of his students:

There is nothing with which the intuitive faculty does not make one acquainted. It is not necessary to deliberate in the least, nor is it necessary to assist its development in any way, for it is very trustworthy and perfectly clear. When it is stimulated it responds, and when it is influenced it perceives clearly. There is nothing that it does not make clear, nothing that it does not realize, nothing that it does not apprehend. All the sages have traversed this road, all the virtuous men have followed this track. There is nothing else that is like a spirit, for it is the spirit; nothing else emulates Heaven, for it is Heaven; nothing else is more in accordance with the Supreme Ruler, for it is the Supreme Ruler.

To this Yangming only adds: “If you know this, you know that there is no further task before you than that of extending intuitive knowledge to the utmost.” We see here that Conscience or Intuition is that part of mind with an inherent understanding of Principle. “If reflection has reverence to the action of Intuition, there are no thoughts that are not in accordance with natural law.” Cologero points out to me that the Eastern Orthodox similarly saw the “gnomic will”, a type of free will where private desires are entertained, as a potential hindrance on the “natural will”, the free will displayed by Christ who acted perfectly in accordance with God.

Like Buddha, Yangming says that our selfish desires only get in the way of serving higher interests, in this case an interest which is to be found within the mind, but which has nothing to do with the narrowly conceived self. The only knowledge we are lacking in is the Way to acting with perfect intuition, natural law, Heaven, and the Supreme Ruler. It is this Way that must be taught, as Confucius tried to teach, but the *destination* is already known.

The Way according to Yangming is recognizing the origin of phenomena in mind, and tempering the mind to enhance one’s naturally skillful judgment. As in Buddhism, the passions and desires of the mind are viewed as hindrances, “clouds” blocking the “sun”. A perfectly clear mind will be able to make correct decisions without the confusion of private interests. This is the sincere mind, “having no depraved thoughts” (*Analects* 2.2). Unlike Buddhism, though, this does not mean that practitioners should refrain from judgment about worldly things. Practice should accompany contemplation. Our intuition tells us to love the Truth and the Right; it also tells us, with equal validity, to fight for what we love.

Some must be wondering, did **Julius Evola** know about this guy? He did, but not directly. A Japanese Zen writer, calling Yangming by his Japanese name Ō-Yōmei, referenced him, and Evola misquoted the writer in *Doctrine of Awakening*.

When commanding an army in battle, even in his headquarters,

Ō-yō-mei would discuss Zen doctrines. He was informed, on one occasion, that his advanced troops had been defeated; he calmly continued his discourse. Shortly after, he was told that, in the later developments of the battle he had become the victor. The commander remained as calm as before, and did not, even then, change his discourse. This is how one gradually apprehends the existence of a principle that cannot be altered by doubt or fear any more than the light of the sun can be destroyed by fog or clouds. [*Doctrine of Awakening*, 228-9]

I find it interesting that Julius Evola read through a book on Zen and pulled from it one of the few lines that definitely had nothing to do with Zen. Many Japanese of that time combined Zen and Yangming thought, but Yangming himself considered his path of action as a world different from Buddhist contemplation, and he would consider Evola to have confused the two. He wrote, “To sink one’s self into abstraction and keep perfectly motionless, and to prearrange one’s thinking, truly imply using wisdom according to one’s selfish purposes. This is akin to throwing away your intuitive knowledge.” The “natural will” is a will which acts on the world, not merely an understanding of the world’s true nature.

In an essay translated on this website⁷, Okawa Shumei argued that Japan of the Edo period implemented a better, more living Confucianism than China’s stagnant Legalism. If this is at all true, it is because they were able to draw on Yangming’s Confucianism of the spirit. His teaching is far different from the “Confucianism as social system” we learn of in modern schools. Banzan wrote: “If I give attention to my inner self, I can find truth; no matter how clever and exact a man’s teaching may be, if he does not study his heart, his teaching is empty.”

⁷<http://www.gornahoor.net/?tag=okawa-shumei>

Notes/Sources For a footnote to this post about Yukio Mishima's use of Wang Yangming, see my blog⁸.

This post was brought to you by the Internet Archive: *The philosophy of Wang Yang-ming* (1916)⁹ and *Light from the East; studies in Japanese Confucianism*¹⁰ (1914), both able translations.

Posted on 2013-05-16 by Avery Morrow

* * *

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-16 at 13:41 said:

Wow – I need to read these books – I never heard of Wang Yangmin before but am really liking this. I gotta research his influence in Korea soon.

August on 2013-05-16 at 19:46 said:

To 'act without acting' is simply contemplation with an additional layer of activity on top. The activity is effaced in the presence of contemplative knowledge, even if it be inspired by it – this is why it is called 'action without acting'.

Whether such a contemplative does a little or a lot is indifferent. After contemplation, there is only contemplation.

August on 2013-05-16 at 19:50 said:

Fundamentally though, 'act without acting' is a reference to contemplation as pure act.

Caleb Cooper on 2013-05-17 at 18:50 said:

In Buddhism's defense, after Christ it developed the Mahayana 'Greater Vehicle' school in which the highest ideal was not Nirvana, but the Bodhisattva; once a soul had become enlightened and could achieve Nirvana, it was supposed to renounce Nirvana out of compassion for all other beings, and devote itself to continually reincarnating until all sentient beings are liberated from suffering.

⁸<http://avery.morrow.name/blog/2013/05/wang-yangming-on-gornaho-or/>

⁹<http://archive.org/details/thephilosophyofw00henkuoft>

¹⁰<http://archive.org/details/cu31924022939205>

According to Tomberg this development occurred because Christ made possible the redemption of the fallen world, and so the Buddhist tradition sensed the change in the possibilities of the world, and was inspired to institute a path to help realize this possibility.

Avery Morrow on 2013-05-17 at 21:33 said:

This gentleman who lived in China in the 15th century and studied Mahayana then seems to disagree with Tomberg about compassionate, worldly qualities in Mahayana. But I understand Chinese Buddhism was not doing too well at that time, and Mahayana definitely succeeded in other nations based on different local adaptations.

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-18 at 14:56 said:

I think the Buddhism vs Oyomei dispute is another manifestation of contemplation vs action we saw with Guenon and Evola.

My expertise is Korea, so I cannot speak of Chinese history without fear of error, but let me mention some parts of Korean history that may be useful : in 1392 there was a change of dynasty and religion – from the Koryo kingdom of the Buddhist Wang family to the Confucian Chosun kingdom of the Lee family. In the last years of Koryo the established Buddhist hierarchy was very corrupt (research the name Shin Don) and so many people in the elite turned against Buddhism and saw it as a superstition that led people to despise the world and their country – a very Evolian critique.

Lionel Chan on 2018-08-08 at 00:47 said:

Re: “the intuitive faculty”, all very well, even when clearly differentiated from bodily instincts (hence Guenon’s coining or at least usage of “intellectual intuition”).

But only for the elite that are able to process this properly in isolation. Such an idea is utter disaster for a world where the just hierarchies are crumbling or gone, where it will propel and empower fools to make things worse.

China did end up embracing Maoism after all... some monotheistic veiling (esp. Islamic, which embraces the political and military, as does Yangming) for the Mercy of those not equipped by God to be Gornahoor frequenters, might be of great use for my people’s.

3.10 Buridan’s Donkey

Free will is not what you suppose.

Should two courses be judged equal, then the will cannot break the deadlock, all it can do is to suspend judgement until the circumstances change, and the right course of action is clear.

JEAN BURIDAN, c. 1340

Buridan's claim led to the development of a thought experiment that goes by the name "Buridan's Ass"¹¹. However, that word has an ambiguous meaning in American English so I decided to rename the experiment to "Buridan's Donkey". For non-native speakers, if you take your son to the petting zoo, you wouldn't say to him, "Look at that nice ass over there!" You should say instead, "Look at that cute donkey over there!"

The simplest version is to suppose you place two bales of hay equidistant from a hungry donkey. Since he would have no rational basis to choose between the two bales, he would starve to death. Philosophically, this story attempts to convert the metaphysical question of free will into a science experiment. If the experiment were actually carried out, the donkey would not starve. Hence one of the premises must be false, to wit:

- The donkey does not have free will
- The donkey is not rational
- The two options are unequal

The donkey is not rational so he does not have free will. Let's look at al-Ghazali's version which I can relate to:

Suppose two similar dates in front of a man, who has a strong desire for them but who is unable to take them both. Surely he will take one of them, through a quality in him, the nature of which is to differentiate between two similar things.

¹¹https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Buridan%27s_ass

I do have a bag of Turkish dates. Whenever I desire one, I stick my hand in the bag and pull one out at random. What I should do is put two of them each equidistant from me and let you know what happens; maybe I can even record it and put it on Tik Tok. Al-Ghazali says something much more intelligent. He assumes I will take one of them through a “quality” that can choose the correct date. So let’s investigate that quality.

The Intellectual Soul A donkey only has an animal soul, so it is incapable of making a rational judgment. It does not deliberate options and then make a choice, which is a gnomonic will. Rather it acts by instinct, which is its “quality” that “chooses” the correct bale of hay.

A human being has an intellectual soul as well as an animal soul. In a well-ordered person, the animal soul is subservient to the intellectual soul. A being with intellect needs to be free because:

- The intellect chooses the true rather than the false
- The intellect chooses the good rather than the bad

You can see, then, that if the intellect cannot choose between the true and the false, there is no possibility of knowledge. The most important thing to know is what is the good. It would be pointless to know the good, but to be unable to act on it.

Physical Causation The most primitive objection to free will is to assume that the brain works entirely through physical causes and executes “algorithms”. The corollary is that the mind is merely a passive observer of those processes and can do nothing to change them. That is a horrifying thought if you understand it and try to live by it.

While it purports to be “scientific”, there is no science behind it at the moment. There is no testable theory. More critically, there is no scientific

measurement to determine if a subject is conscious or not. Nor is there an independent way to determine if an idea is true or good.

Moreover, who is executing the program?

Free Choice A free choice is one made by the conscious subject or person. The free person knows the good and acts on it. That is our real and true nature. Freedom, therefore, is to act in accordance with our true nature.

Choosing the bad, therefore, cannot be free because the choice is based on ignorance or on weakness that yields to the inclinations of the animal soul.

So you can be a person or a donkey, like Pinocchio.

How to tame your inner donkey: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EDK9K0fknTw>

How to make up your mind: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C0cJ__JBnWg

Posted on 2021-10-10 by Cologero

4.1 The God of the Metaphysicians

Even as regards those truths about God which human reason could have discovered, it was necessary that man should be taught by a divine revelation; because the truth about God such as reason could discover, would only be known by a few, and that after a long time, and with the admixture of many errors.

Summa Theologiae, I.I.I

Any “dualism”, whether of the theological order like that attributed to the Manicheans, or of the philosophical order like that of Descartes, is a radically false conception.

RENE GUENON

It is said that St Jerome was severely chastised for preferring to read the pagan philosophers rather than Sacred Scriptures¹. So it is

¹<http://catholicharboroffaithandmorals.com/St.%20Jerome.html>



with some caution that I turn to the pagans, not to commend them, but rather because such writings have been a great part of my own personal equation. In particular, I am interested in those systems that assume the intelligibility of the world through thought. These have been known as “Absolute Idealism” or “Monism”. We prefer the first term, not always used in the strict sense; moreover, they have more of a “family resemblance” and not a totally common teaching. In short, it represents the Platonic thread in philosophy rather than the Aristotelean. **Joseph Marechal**, in *Studies of the Psychology of the Mystics*, compares it to a strict monotheism as the foundation of a certain type of mysticism.

It is easy to forget that up until a century again, it comprised what was properly called philosophy for educated men. Other systems of thought, e.g., materialism, naturalism, etc., are not really philosophies since they deny the primacy of thought. From Plato and Plotinus, it was revived with the German thinkers. The British then adapted their own version, e.g., with T H Green, Francis Bradley, Bosanquet, etc. A century ago, it was dominated by the Italians Benedetto Croce and Giovanni Gentile. Julius Evola, who learned German in order to study the German idealists, was also an Absolute Idealist. Even Rene Guenon, although he disdained profane philosophy, had points in common with such systems.

The neglect of Absolute Idealism has allowed inferior ideologies to take hold among the educated classes. Often, the only alternative to such ideologies are crudely expressed dogmas of the exoteric religions, which seem incredible to most educated folk. Hence, such writings have a three-fold purpose for us.

- Idealism provides an intellectually sophisticated alternative to naturalism, materialism, and modernism.

- It is a “halfway house” between atheism and theism.
- It provides a safeguard against anthropomorphic and other misconceptions about God. Some idealists identify the Absolute with God, while others do not.

Surprised by Joy C S Lewis was one such person who journeyed from atheism to Absolute Idealism to theism, which he described in *Surprised by Joy*. *The Magdalen Metaphysicals* describes the intellectual climate at Oxford during Lewis’ time there.

The Vindication A recent promoter of Absolute Idealism was **Timothy Sprigge**. He provides an updated defense of it in the *Vindication of Absolute Idealism*. In *James and Bradley and the God of Metaphysics*, Sprigge provides a helpful survey of rationalist and idealist philosophies. In the latter book, he outlines how such a metaphysical system might relate to religion. Unfortunately, I cannot review that chapter here. However, those who have a religious sensibility, but are turned off by the various alternatives available, may gain something from such an abstract presentation.

Self-Realization Following Bradley, Sprigge claims that self-realization is the goal of life. Of course, that makes sense if we interpret that in Guenon’s notion of the actualization of all of man’s possibilities, including the transcendent possibilities. Ultimately, that is, self-realization is the realization of the Self.

Panpsychism Sprigge defends panpsychism, which is the view that the world consists of experiences. For him, there is no dead, or unexperienced, matter, everything is alive. A more recent example, using a different argu-

ment, is *Mind and Cosmos* by **Thomas Nagel**, which is reviewed here². Thus, life, consciousness, and thought do not arise from matter, since the psyche is a fundamental component of the cosmos. Guenon makes a similar claim, since he includes life as one of the irreducible elements of the world.

Infinite Minds In *Infinite Minds: A Philosophical Cosmology*, **John Leslie** derives a system from Plato's idea of the Good. **Hugh Rice**, in *God and Goodness*, develops that idea more fully. He claims that the Scientific Outlook and Objective Values prove the existence of God. Rather than oppose God to Science, Rice claims that the scientific outlook requires three beliefs, which transcend the objects of scientific study:

1. A belief in order
2. A belief in rationality
3. A belief in intelligibility

Then, he demonstrates that there is objective value in the world. From that, he concludes that since it is good for the world to exist, then it necessarily exists.

Leslie builds on Plato, Spinoza, Bradley, and others, to create an idealist system. Interestingly, he acknowledges the problem I mentioned at the top: how can you make such metaphysical ideas comprehensible to the modern mind?

Trying to introduce ideas like these in the twenty first century and in the West, one never knows where to start. The points I want to make could seem entirely natural to a traditionally educated Hindu, or to Hegelians such as Bradley, or to a physicist such as

²<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8373>

David Bohm, who speculated that all the parts of our universe form a collective mind of some sort; yet they can easily be dismissed as preposterous, for all kinds of powerful reasons. . . . One has to paint a huge picture at speed, conscious that every brush-stroke can earn raised eyebrows, incredulous stares, or worse. One has to do this because the elements in the picture make sense only when seen as a whole. From which it follows, unfortunately, that whatever one begins with can look outlandish.

Leslie identifies the things in the world as “the structures of various thoughts in the divine mind”. He goes on to claim that “when God contemplates various physical possibilities in full detail they do not remain merely possible... they are genuinely real, existent, actualized, non-fictitious.”

Readers here will recognize these as Guenon’s “possibilities of manifestation”, which, in Medieval metaphysics, are ideas in the Divine Mind. So what goes around, comes around. Unfortunately, the work is marred by an inadequate understanding of metaphysical Infinity. For this, a reading of Guenon will go a long way to correct.

To get back to the main point, which is that the world exists because it is good for it to exist. This recalls Bonaventure’s journey to God, which surpasses Being to reach the Good. Bonaventure claimed that it is better for something to exist than not to exist. Here Leslie and Rice seem to be in agreement with Bonaventure.

Nevertheless, for many that proposition may not be so obvious. For example, the Buddha claimed that all life is suffering and Schopenhauer asserted that it would be better not to exist. In our own time, abortion and euthanasia are promoted on the grounds that it would be better for some lives not to exist. This topic deserves extended treatment, but in the meantime, meditate on the Wheel of Fortune Arcanum in the Tarot.

The Idealist View of Life That is the title of a book by the Indian philosopher **Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan**. Radhakrishnan reframes Indian thought in the terms of Western systems of Absolute Idealism. He does that more thoroughly in the two volumes of *Indian Philosophy*, quoting Bradley, Gentile, inter alia. In the previous century, European scholars tried to grasp Hindu philosophy in Western terms. Radhakrishnan turns the tables, evaluating Western philosophy in how well it corresponds to Indian thought. His student, **T R V Murti**, did the same for Buddhism in *The Central Philosophy of Buddhism*.

Guenon recommended the study of Eastern thought as the preliminary stage in the recovery of Tradition in the West. Thinkers like Radhakrishnan, Murti, Aurobindo Ghose, and others, may be a good place to start.

Takeaway Obviously, there are many important topics that had to be excluded in this short survey. Some, including Marechal's work on mysticism³ and Nagel's on the philosophy of science⁴, will appear in upcoming posts. However, there is plenty of material to get started on an understanding of the Absolute, the infinite, cosmic Order, Intelligibility, and Rationality, the Objective Value of Existence, and the goal of Self-Realization.

Posted on 2015-11-03 by Cologero

* * *

themaelstromscup on 2015-11-04 at 12:47 said:

I may suggest The Elements of Metaphysics by Paul Deussen, which is available for free on Google Books. Duessen was a follower of Kant and Schopenhauer, as well as an early Sanskrit scholar and friend of Nietzsche. There's much to be learned from Schopenhauer if one disregards

³<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8467>

⁴<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5088>

his pessimism, which wasn't a logical consequence of his system and is easily disentangled therefrom. The aforementioned book is a veritable catechism of Transcendental Idealism informed by Greek, Christian, and Indian Tradition.

Cologero on 2015-11-04 at 17:25 said:

@Maelstrom,

My intent was to focus on recent philosophers writing in English. Nevertheless, I welcome your suggestion.

aegishjalmer on 2015-11-04 at 19:48 said:

This post makes me think of a few other points.

First of all, on the problems of explaining and justifying Idealism, and even philosophy or religion to people today: I think of Hilaire Belloc and his book *Heresy* in which he concludes that modernity is the realm of the half educated, where the masses have been brought up at the expense of the top, which has been brought down. Guenon puts it similarly in the *Reign of Quantity* where he speaks of the dynamic of blocking the supernatural and opening up the subnatural, while Nietzsche speaks of people not being able to think properly, think things through.

When you consider the conditions under which people are born, the propaganda, false education and spurious myths, and centuries of decline in various ways (Evola), in which the struggles of Europe via war (etc) leave nowhere to start, you can see why Guenon recommended the East as a starting point, rather like the Pauline idea of the Gentiles being grafted onto the tree of Israel.

Recently this occurred to me as being an essential part of spiritual growth, and I bought a few kindle books on this exact thing. They look at what a normal human life should be from the point of view of Tradition. I had the distinct intuition that a large part of our problem today is that we have half conscious instincts and spiritual needs that feed on traditional archetypes but are blocked and distorted through ignorance (which amounts to saying the normal human condition of the fall has become modernity's life and is affirmed and justified by it in a negative response to God's grace, although perhaps it has to do with how Tradition in the West has developed historically as well), or need proper forms in order to work at all, rather like Jung and his view of dry river beds needing new streams to flow through them (see his essay *Wotan*). The books were:

1. The four aims of life in the Tradition of Ancient India by Alain Danielou
2. The Four Goals of Life: a survival guide for the Kali Yuga by Cynkay Morningsong

David Ravel on 2015-11-05 at 15:03 said:

Since I am not very well versed in those thinker, I hope this question is not ill-received.

I always thought that Idealism, when speaking of Plato, was actually a bad translation: it came from the translation of ousias into idea, which gave rise to a misconception because in actuality, Plato is a realist (ousia being real), not an idealist (ousia being in the mind (ideation) of the subject) such as Kant.

When we speak of idealism here, do we speak of Kant or of Plato ? If we speak of both, how do they relate since Kant is an inversion of Plato in the subject/object relationship ?

I am confused a bit by all those distinctions. What are we speaking about here when we speak of absolute idealism ? Thank you.

Cologero on 2015-11-05 at 17:54 said:

@David, as I mentioned: "These have been known as "Absolute Idealism" or "Monism". We prefer the first term, *not always used in the strict sense*"

I am not interested in picky philosophical disputes. The point is that reason and thinking have been the foundation of Western philosophy until recently. By the way, I never mentioned Kant, who was not an "Absolute" idealist. For Plato, the Absolute was the Good.

When I get to the review of Marechal's book on the mystical states associated with various philosophies, the purpose may become clearer.

Cassiodorus on 2015-11-05 at 23:56 said:

According to Guenon, following Shankara, the fundamental distinction is between Atma and Maya, or the Absolute and the relative. On this view, the personal God who creates and sustains the universe is on the "maya side" of the Absolute/relative divide. But, as I understand it, the classical theist does not admit of this "maya in Divinis" doctrine, insisting that the fundamental distinction is between the Creator and the created. I think Christianity may be compatible with a qualified nondualism like that of the kind espoused by Ramanuja, but I think the unqualified nondualist traditions are basically patronizing to theists.

obscure on 2015-11-06 at 00:53 said:

Cassiodorus,

One of the fundamental distinctions in Aquinas and the other schoolmen is between the imperfect infinity of matter and the perfect infinity of God. This imperfect infinity of matter ('indefiniteness' if you prefer) consists of its being simply determinable and only possessing determination in complexity, whereas God possesses determination simply (self-determination, aseitas). Matter is like a subject without any subjectivity except insofar as it is determined as an object of God. I doubt I needed to even write this much nor shall I add any further explanation since I assume that any competent reader understands all that follows.

Cassiodorus on 2015-11-06 at 10:30 said:

Obscure, I appreciate your input. I also apologize if my comments betoken an “incompetence”- I only desire to understand. For the record, I came to the Christian position by way of the Perennialist writers. I’ve often wondered why Guenon and Schuon never cited figures such as Ramanuja and Madhva. Are their objections to Advaita without merit?

David Ravel on 2015-11-06 at 11:51 said:

@Cologero

My goal was not to start a philosophical debate, but rather to understand where I should look into. You did not mention Kant, but others did in other occasion, which lead to my confusion. I’m trying to learn.

Cologero on 2015-11-06 at 20:13 said:

I’m not necessarily recommending any of these sites, but they may be of interest for further research.

Vivekananda wrote this short piece on Paul Deussen. Vivekananda was the major influence on Radhakrishnan. Guenon did not approve of V for some reason. Nevertheless, his book on Jnana Yoga brings up many of the same themes that interested Guenon.

The Swedish philosopher Janolof Bengtsson creates an interesting blend of absolute idealism, tradition, and paleoconservative authors like Russel Kirk and Irving Babbitt. An example is *The Case for Idealism*. He writes:

what I mean when I speak about and defend idealism – as I do when I speak in terms of Western philosophy, trying to remedy the lamentable situation – is also an idealism of this original, metaphysical, spiritual and, as it were, uncompromising variety. An idealism that is defined by the affirmation of this absolute truth about God-Being.

In *Idealism as Alternative to Modernity*, he writes:

The optimal resources for the formulation of the idealist contribution to an alternative modernity therefore seem to me to be those of personal idealism or personal **absolute idealism** in its most advanced forms. And as I always point out – both because of the way in which I myself became an idealist and for the sake of corroborating my argument for the universality of these issues – there are from the beginning, despite, or beyond, the obvious difficulties of translation and interpretation, *striking*

similarities with the Western debates between absolute and personal idealists in the Vedanta tradition in the East.

It may not be widely known that Anthroposophy sees its roots in Plato, Aristotle, and Thomas Aquinas. Its goal is to unite the Platonic and Aristotelian streams of thought.

Here is an homage to Timothy Sprigge: Timothy Sprigge: The Last Idealist. Read it with caution since Sprigge held non-traditional ideas. Nevertheless, his main influence – Spinoza, Schopenhauer, and Santayana – were coincidentally important to my own early development.

David Ravel on 2015-11-07 at 08:40 said:

@Cologero

Thank you for those suggestions.

You said earlier that you focused on English philosophers. What would you suggest in French regarding idealism ?

Cologero on 2015-11-07 at 09:36 said:

Oh là là, M. Ravel, you've hit upon a favorite topic of mine!

There is Émile Boutroux, often quoted by Evola. Not to overlook the more famous Henri Bergson, who was a favorite of Valentin Tomberg.

In France, that type of philosophy went by the name of "philosophy of spirit" or "spiritualism" (nothing to do with seances as it might mean in English).

The main figures are Louis Lavelle and Rene Le Senne.

I assume you know of Maurice Blondel? (whose philosophy of action was known to Evola).

Finally, Lucien Laberthonniere. He insisted that ideas "must be lived", not just thought about. In Christian Realism and Greek Idealism (Realisme chretien et idealisme grec), he addresses your initial question. He understands "idealism" as the intellectualistic heritage of Greek thought, including both Plato and Aristotle (although he finds shortcomings in that tradition). You see that is also how I have been using the term.

I don't know why the way of thinking represented by the philosophies of spirit and action has been so neglected.

David Ravel on 2015-11-07 at 13:40 said:

@Cologero

I must say that I know very little of contemporary philosophy. Younger, I had read Nietzsche and Schopenhauer, and was content with that. After reading the 'traditionalists', I only read medieval philosophy and Plato/Aristotle.

I must say that now I've also read Kant, Husserl, Ricoeur and a few others, but I had stopped at Kant regarding any kind of idealism, which I thought was very shortcoming (not including the works of Evola on the matter).

I will read those authors you suggested, especially those french since it is my mother tongue.

Thank you.

Mark Citadel on 2015-11-08 at 13:10 said:

I really connect with what you're saying here about the intelligibility of the world, for it was through such arguments that I actually came to Christianity. How do you think one can reconcile mysticism in Christianity with the very logical approach to the world common to Catholic apologetics in particular? Can we successfully marry the intelligible and the mystical?

Cologero on 2015-11-08 at 16:50 said:

As Guenon put it, "mystical experience" may be super-rational, but certainly not irrational. A follow up to this post will be a review of Joseph Marechal's *Psychology of the Mystics*. He shows how one's worldview relates to the experience of the world. Specifically, he will contrast Absolute Idealism with Theism.

Then, of course, there is Bonaventure's *Journey of the Soul to God*, in six stages. An early stage is the realization of the intelligibility of the world.

Olavsson on 2015-11-15 at 12:45 said:

Re: Mysticism:

From certain reflections by Guenon that I read rather recently, it would seem that his attitude to mysticism was sceptical. He gives the impression of not having regarded mystical experience very highly. (I refer to the first two chapters of 'Perspectives on Initiation'. He admitted that it had its place within Tradition as a whole, and might be a spiritual path suited to the nature and possibilities of a particular type of man, but that ultimately, it is a 'passive' approach to spirituality deprived of the properly initiatic elements that would constitute a certain method for actively overcoming the mortal human condition through the interior realization of higher states. But as far as I can see, this need not necessarily imply that all of the 'mysticist' features must definitely be excluded, only that an exclusively mystical approach is insufficient and has serious limitations in the case of one specifically aiming for gnosis. (Speaking only for myself, I have great respect for some historical mystics.) The same, of course, is true for the strictly rational and intellectual approach, whether we think of theology or philosophy. This point has been stressed more than once in articles on this site. Rather than simply rejecting such approaches, the esoteric path would integrate in order to surpass. Every faculty and function of the being should, then, be ordered into proper alignment so as to fully serve the spiritual work that is our one absolute

purpose in this life, so that all levels of inner activity initially infected by a profane condition are progressively 'sacralized' and mastered in an elevated expression.

I shouldn't forget to thank Cologero for the recommendation of these useful philosophers. They are noted down for future research.

Re: Murti's 'The Central Philosophy of Buddhism': Seeing that the author is a Hindu and not one initiated into actual Buddhist schools (unless I'm very mistaken), would you say that his work offers an understanding of Madhyamika that most contemporary Buddhist-adherents of Madhyamika would see as objective and traditional? All the nuances of the various interpretations and approaches to Mahayana philosophy and metaphysics are still unclear to me. It is a diverse tradition.

A quick thought on 'panpsychism': If not integrated into a vertical metaphysical order, such a concept may easily just get stuck on the level of maya-samsara or the pantheist mentality.

[Cologero quote:] "Nevertheless, for many that proposition may not be so obvious. For example, the Buddha claimed that all life is suffering and Schopenhauer asserted that it would be better not to exist." [...]

Depends upon the context in which life is evaluated. For an existing being, which is a manifested positive, if I may put it that way, the confrontation with nothingness, non-being, the negative hole in being, the unconscious, the dissolution into lower darkness, has always been cause for much instinctive anguish, perhaps the primordial anguish itself. From this point of view, it is clearly better to be, rather than lose oneself in what is less real. However, existence and life itself becomes the object of privation, of negativity, the negation of what is more Real, when compared to the Absolute, the Unconditioned, the Unborn principle. It is when the emanation from that Origin, the positive creative downward flow causing the perpetual cyclical movement of the cosmic 'samsara', is opposed in order to move against the stream as an active return to the Origin, that the natural cycle of conditioned existence becomes the enemy, the problem. That life must necessarily have suffering as an inherent component is inevitable, independently of whether one subscribes to Buddhist views specifically. Every being that is limited by external conditions, that is in need of things, and subject to change, will eventually experience suffering as a consequence of these conditions. That life as such implies suffering seems to be beyond reasonable dispute. The question is rather whether this fact must lead us to conclude that life is bad or even evil (as some gnostics believed), instead of being a positive creative reality that due to its inevitable relativity, limited conditions and multiplicity of possibilities must have as one of its consequences suffering, and yes, even evil. That these conditioned modes of existence equal suffering is a good motivation for heroic spiritual struggle aimed at transcendental freedom, but obviously there is more to the cosmic manifestation than that alone. The very possibility of attaining within life the supreme awakening into illumination and liberation, affirmed by the Buddha, should perhaps make us realize that life, even if ordinarily trapping us in a circle leading away from this supreme state rather than towards it, also is what we choose to make of it. Those

who desperately resign in front of life and take their own lives, for example, perhaps in the hope that they will achieve a nothingness that is preferable to the suffering of existence, would be wiser to welcome their suffering as an invitation to transcend their miserable condition by entering the ascending path in life, which is one of the possible ways to actively give form to life determined by a superior principle. Then the blindfold of illusions will fall away, and we will no longer be subject to slavish reactions following from relying upon ever-changing impressions of relative conditions, but will have elevated the centre of our existence to the highest Truth without which life is indeed meaningless.

Cologero on 2015-11-18 at 18:26 said:

"Mysticism" has a range of meanings, but I would agree with the formulation you made. In the upcoming post on the psychology of mysticism, the texts I am relying on confirm what you said about it. Of course, Guenon was a jnani, so "knowledge", or "realization", is what counts, not some beautiful or unusual experiences.

The thing about Murti is that he was familiar with Guenon. His conclusion that the Madhyamika may be more suitable as the universal vehicle for tradition instead of the Vedanta is certainly worth considering. He wrote:

Mahayana absolutism and the Advaita Vedanta are valuable as providing the basis on which a world-culture can be built. It is only absolutism that can make for the fundamental unity of existence and at the same time allow for differences. Catholicity of outlook and tolerance of differences are their very soul; both insist on the universality of the Real and transcendence of the ego-centric standpoint. The Vedanta, however, is traditional in outlook and is bound to the authority of the Veda, and perhaps it presupposes a specific milieu in which alone it can thrive. The Mahayana is quite liberal, and it has proved its capacity to accommodate itself to various religious and social structure, to revitalise and absorb them.

Your paragraph on suffering proves – perhaps inadvertently – the point. In the realm of Thought, the cosmos seems perfectly ordered and rational. However, for the Will, it is much more problematic as it encounters obstacles and faces up to its own weaknesses. The Will is individulized.

Max on 2016-06-29 at 12:29 said:

I took hold of this line, that in order to see the world as not just random happenings "one has to paint a huge picture at speed". This comes down to conceptions. If someone is not able to

see that for themselves, it is very difficult to paint that picture for them. One can help by pointing in the right direction, but having someone explain it by a sort of step by step process does not really do it in the end, since it has to be seen as a whole. To a large extent this comes down to one's capacity to dwell on large or multiple things simultaneously. The better one is able to do this the more sense things will make. I am not sure to what degree this is by nature, but it should at least be possible to improve upon it by training. For example I read about someone who was intrigued by other people saying they could dream in colour although he could not. By determination and effort he then managed to reach the same degree of "visualization-power". So an improvement in conceptual areas like this is definitely possible, but it does not come by itself, meaning that someone who is perfectly happy with regarding the world as some random hell will not get out of that view unless they actually wish to do so. Most people make up their mind about something and then by solidification becomes impossible to reach no matter how many indications to the contrary. In the actual world of conflicting wills this then translates into a kind of hell since everyone is determined to concede nothing to anyone else, and holds firm that they alone are correct.

However if there is no purpose, why is it so important to hold on to one's own opinions in the first place? Could they not just vote on which opinion is correct and then stick to it? It seems as if they have already tried that approach but it does not work out very well since they take some kind of pride in always having different opinions, which means that the natural distribution, in a mechanical fashion, always tends towards the greatest diversity, while at the same time resulting in the largest possible number of people feeling oppressed by the other half. I always wondered why in almost every "free election", the margin for victory is just a few points, rather than say 90-10. This just shows that what is debated has nothing to do with reality, since if the right answer was immediately obvious to everyone, we would not need to vote in the first place. What this means is that when people think we need to vote on something, that means that they do not understand the issue, and if they do not understand it, they should have no say in it, demonstrating how the very idea of voting is a joke from the beginning. In a responsible society the options should rather be something like this: either I understand something in which case I would not agree to merely "vote on it", or I do not understand it in which case I would not agree to vote on it for fear of messing up.

4.2 Tradition and German Philosophy

The attitudes of **Julius Evola** and **Charles Maurras** toward the influence of German thought were fundamentally different. Maurras opposed it on several points; he regarded the Germans as barbarians and rejected,

in his view, German nationalism, racism, its Protestant outlook. Specifically, he rejected Fichte's philosophy as the basis of German thought. Rather than an alliance with the Germans, Maurras was hoping for an alliance of the Romance language speaking nations of Europe. The documentation for this will have to wait for another time, since it involves pulling together and translating statements from multiple works.

On the other hand, Evola was a Germanophile; he admired the German spirit and regarded the civilization of the Middle Ages as a joint creation of Europe's German and Roman elements. In his youth, the heirs of German philosophy were found in Italy in Giovanni Gentile and Benedetto Croce. Evola embarked on a program of self-study of German philosophy well before his turn to Tradition. This influence colored (or tainted, depending on your point of view) Evola's exposition of Tradition in some significant ways. Oftentimes, it seemed strained, as he tried to combine the two streams of thought.

I should add a disclaimer here. I myself have a great respect and admiration for the German people and their accomplishments in the arts, music, science, and philosophy. Since the thinkers about to be discussed were trying to come to terms with the fundamental and hidden structures of the world, their ideas deserve to be carefully considered.

German philosophy is a series of footnotes to **Immanuel Kant**, who tried to reconcile empiricism with traditional metaphysics. In the *Critique of Pure Reason*, Kant demonstrated that, starting solely from empirical data, the pure intellect was incompetent to know reality in itself. This is the opposite of metaphysics whose fundamental claim is that the Intellect knows reality through a direct intuition of the ideas, or forms. In one way, this first critique can be read as a *reduction ad absurdum* proof that empiricism, and, *a fortiori*, the scientific method, is false as paths to knowledge. Instead, Kant went in another direction.

He wrote the *Critique of Practical Reason* in response. Since we have direct experience of ourselves as moral beings, i.e., beings acting in the

world, this can be the only source of truth. To make sense of the moral life, Kant postulated the existence of God, the freedom of the will, and immortality as fundamental truths. However, he did not intuit these truths as a metaphysician, but saw them as logically necessary axioms.

From the Traditional point of view, the Intellect is prior to the Will; Kant reversed this, denying the Intellect its priority, and making the Will fundamental. The corollary was that action was the means to knowledge, a point not lost on Evola. Post-Kantian German philosophy developed this philosophy of the Will.

Arthur Schopenhauer's system was the most extreme. Since Mind is not the fundamental reality, it was the Will. But, unlike Kant, for Schopenhauer the Will is itself unknowable; since it is not directed by the Logos, it is blind and irrational. We do not know that Will directly, but only through its representations or appearances, what we call the "world". The Will becomes dual, splitting into the knowing subject and the known object. But this is all illusion; when the duality is abolished, the individual will dissipates, and there is only the Will.

Johann Fichte did not go so far. In his understanding, the "I" is itself the noumenal reality, not the abstract Will, but one's own will. As Kant showed, our conception of the world cannot derive from the world, which is noumenal and unknowable. Fichte, accepting Kant's postulate of the freedom of the will, concludes from this that our conception of the world must be a free creation of the mind. Since the I is primary (I experience it directly, although as subject and never as object), it is the phenomenal world that is derivative. A morally acting I creates that world as its field of action; without something to oppose it, the I cannot be "moral" in any real sense. This all follows logically from the initial assumptions.

The echoes of this manner of thinking resound in Evola's philosophical works, as is obvious from *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*⁵, and what he writes about the "I" or the Absolute Self. It is the

⁵<http://www.gornahoor.net/?tag=the-individual-and-the-becomin>

source of most, if not all, of his divergences from **Rene Guenon**. Clearly, Evola's claim that action is a way of self-realization is based on this type of philosophy.

Nevertheless, it is not without danger. It may be hard to accept that the physical world is the creation of my "I", but if we restrict ourselves to the social world, it gains much more credibility. Specifically, it reveals itself in the modern idea that our social world is a construct. Two hundred years later, this idea has become commonplace, even among those who have no idea who Fichte is, and, in any case, could not even understand him. To the modern mind, then, there is no objective social reality, as it is simply a free creation of the mind. Hence, by changing our conception of it, we can mould our society any way we please. Still following Fichte, this is not simply an intellectual exercise, rather it is a moral quest. Therefore, those who reject the dominant conception are experienced as ignorant, as immoral, as enemies, as mortal enemies.

Furthermore, the postmodern mind fully embraces Fichte, seeing the physical world itself as a free creation of the human will. This leads logically to causes such as man-made climate change. Even more, what may seem to be undeniable physical differences, such as sexual and racial diversity, are themselves regarded as products of the human will. For those who have followed thus far, this is all too obvious to require further elucidation.

There is a serious consequence: this philosophy cannot be countered on its own terms. It is pointless to mention biological realities to those who do not even regard them as independent of human conception. You cannot try to create a counter-conception, which logically makes no sense.

Yet this is the direction of modernity and postmodernity. It follows its own logic and to deny that logic is seen as a moral failing. There can be no discussion with such a point of view; that is why Evola appreci-

ated Donoso Cortes so much. Guenon insisted that only an intellectual conversion can overcome that perspective.

I know this will not please many people, since it seems to be too passive. They believe in debate and confrontation. But those who understand Tradition will agree that one's own intellectual conversion must come first. Then, instead of debate, an alternate worldview must be presented and events understood in the terms of a new historiography.⁶

Posted on 2012-11-06 by Cologero

* * *

Kaulaphon on 2012-11-07 at 05:52 said:

"All I ever talked about was masturbation." – Derrida.

The interesting thing though, is that when postmodernism turns everything on the battlefield into volitional happenstance to be assembled anew, the assembly in most cases ends up with a set of prefabricated moralistic notions chosen prior to entering the philosophical field.

Even when this kind of intellectual assault is turned upon itself, so to speak, the end product of philosophical deconstructionism is shown to be equal to the deconstructionist's personal pet beliefs.

Postmodern analysis consists of playing language games in order to give oneself the power to justify one's own beliefs (this is the essence of ALL philosophy, if one would believe Mad Freddy). In many respects, it is just a complicated and labyrinthine way of communicating very simple notions. This is why postmodern analysis never produces any novel results. This is why postmodern analysis never ends up defending the difference between the sexes, or defending colonialism, or finding that social hierarchy is just.

Choosing from a set of arbitrary constructs, the constructs willed into manifestation are always the same ones. Quaint, aint it?

Saladin on 2012-11-07 at 19:24 said:

I am not an expert on either Kant or Fichte but I have read Schopenhauer and I think that your description of his philosophy is not entirely accurate. True, Schopenhauer's philosophy was indeed most extreme in its pessimism. However, he in fact postulates that The Will is knowable

⁶A different way to read Fichte, as well as the influence of Nietzsche, will have to await another day.

and that “Kant had ignored inner experience, as intuited through the will, which was the most important form of experience. Schopenhauer saw the human will as our one window to the world behind the representation; the Kantian thing-in-itself. He believed, therefore, that we could gain knowledge about the thing-in-itself, something Kant said was impossible, since the rest of the relationship between representation and thing-in-itself could be understood by analogy to the relationship between human will and human body. According to Schopenhauer, the entire world is the representation of a single Will, of which our individual wills are phenomena. In this way, Schopenhauer’s metaphysics go beyond the limits that Kant had set, but do not go so far as the rationalist system-builders that preceded Kant. Other important differences are Schopenhauer’s rejection of eleven of Kant’s twelve categories, arguing that only causality was important. Matter and causality were both seen as a union of time and space and thus being equal to each other.”

Jason-Adam on 2012-11-08 at 02:10 said:

The Abbe Barruel, exposé of the true powers who were behind the French revolution, wrote that Immanuel Kant was a member of the Illuminati in volume 4 of *Memoirs sur l'histoire du Jacobinisme*.....it is a pity he died before he was able to complete his refutation of Kantianism.

Another fact I am surprised more people on the right are not aware of is how in the “Protocols of Learned Elders of Zion” Nietzsche is classed along with Marx and Darwin as agents of destruction. Again, we know the Protocols are not as simple as they appear but I do think they are worthy of being studied, as Evola thought so, and it is puzzling to me that no one seems to have picked up on the anti-traditional role ascribed to Nietzsche in said document.

Going a bit further, in the Protocols, the “Jews” (not to be taken as meaning Jewish people but something else entirely) claim that their only worthwhile enemy is the Society of Jesus. Could it be that the Jesuits are, or are the only thing close to being, the Western spiritual elite discussed by Guenon? I wish someone would investigate whether there is any initiatory character in the exercises of St Ignatius as well as the other works of Jesuit mysticism.

Cologero on 2012-11-11 at 10:44 said:

Nietzsche is a complex figure. Yes, he is destructive insofar as he opposed the established order, often in false or unwise ways. On the other hand, he can be read another way, as we showed with Coomaraswamy. There is a small group, seeing no alternative, that turns to Nietzsche as a source of a new spiritual vision. Whether that leads to anything or not remains to be seen. I think they are overly polemical and reject too much of Western history to be completely effective.

The Ignatian exercises are similar to the Hermetic meditation described by Tomberg. Their organizational structure and goal to serve as a transnational spiritual elite point to something initiatory. The cause of their current state of dissipation is unknown to me.

Jason-Adam on 2012-11-11 at 22:30 said:

Someone told me once that he believed the Jesuits had adopted an outward “leftist” political stance as a means of bringing about the end of the present age sooner by increasing the speed of destruction & degeneracy, a “ride the tiger” type scenario. Whether this is true or not I can not say. There is also the possibility that the Jesuits have been infiltrated and “switched” from a force for good into a force for evil.

Do you know why more traditionalist writers have not discussed Ignatian spirituality ?

4.3 The Persona and Ego

In the beginning the world was nothing but the Atman, in the form of a man. It looked around and saw nothing different to itself. Then it cried out once, ‘It is I.’ That is how the word ‘I’ came to be. That is why even at the present day, if any one is called, he answers, ‘It is I,’ and then recalls his other name, the one he bears.

Brihadâranyata-Upanishad

In *The I Problem and Genius*⁷, **Otto Weininger** writes about the realization of the sense of the “I”, that is, the experience of being an independent centre of awareness. Here are some descriptions he provides:

There has been no famous man who, at least some time in the course of his life, and generally earlier in proportion to his greatness, has not had a moment in which he was absolutely convinced of the possession of an ego in the highest sense. Let us compare the following utterances of three very great geniuses. **Jean Paul** relates in his autobiographical sketch, *Truths from my own Life*:

I can never forget a circumstance which, so far, has been related by no one – the birth of my own self-consciousness, the time

⁷<https://www.gornahoor.net/library/IProblem.htm>

and place of which I can tell. One morning I was standing, as a very young child, at the front door, and looking towards the wood-shed I suddenly saw, all at once my inner likeness. 'I' am 'I' flashed like lightning from the skies across me, and since then has remained. I saw myself then for the first time and for ever. This cannot be explained as a confusion of memory, for no alien narrative could have blended itself with this sacred event, preserved permanently in my memory by its vividness and novelty.

Novalis, in his *Miscellaneous Fragments*, refers to an identical experience:

This factor every one must experience for himself. It is a factor of the higher order, and reveals itself only to higher men; but men should strive to induce it in themselves. Philosophy is the exercise of this factor, it is a true self-revelation, the stimulation of the real ego by the ideal ego. It is the foundation of all other revelations; the resolution to philosophise is a challenge to the actual ego, to become conscious of itself, to grow and to become a soul.

Schelling discusses the same phenomenon in his *Philosophical Letters upon Dogmatism and Criticism*, a little known early work, in which occurs the following beautiful words:

In all of us there dwells a secret marvelous power of freeing ourselves from the changes of time, of withdrawing to our secret selves away from external things, and of so discovering to ourselves the eternal in us in the form of unchangeability. This presentation of ourselves to ourselves is the most truly personal experience upon which depends everything that we know of the supra-sensual world. This presentation shows us for the first time what real existence is, whilst all else only appears to be. It differs from every presentation of the sense in its perfect freedom, whilst all other presentations are bound, being overweighted by the burden of the object. Still there exists for those who have not this

perfect freedom of the inner sense some approach to it, experiences approaching it from which they may gain some faint idea of it. . . . This intellectual presentation occurs when we cease to be our own object, when, withdrawing into ourselves, the perceiving self merges in the self-perceived. At that moment we annihilate time and duration of time; we are no longer in time, but time, or rather eternity itself, is in us. The external world is no longer an object for us, but is lost in us.

Finally,

Every great man knows this phase of the ego. He may become conscious of it first through the love of a woman, for the great man loves more intensely than the ordinary man; or it may be from the contrast given by a sense of guilt or the knowledge of having failed; these, too, the great man feels more intensely than smaller-minded people. It may lead him to a sense of unity with the all, to the seeing of all things in God, or, and this is more likely, it may reveal to him the frightful dualism of nature and spirit in the universe, and produce in him the need, the craving, for a solution of it, for the secret inner wonder. But always it leads the great man to the beginning of a presentation of the world for himself and by himself, without the help of the thought of others.

Miguel Serrano has his own take on this in *Nos: Book of the Resurrection*.

Where is this persona when the child still has no sense of the individual “ego”? In my case, I remember, when I was a year old or perhaps less, I was leaning out of a tower holding my grandfather’s ring tightly in my hand. The women of the house ran to take hold of me, because they were afraid that I would let it drop. But, I remember, that child felt itself to be a persona, it knew the importance of the ring and knew that it would never let it drop. It felt deeply offended by this lack of trust. That child was a very

old and wise man. And when the “ego” became defined, it was a philosopher who asked himself the question. That is the difference, I believe ... and this is the ring. I have recovered it.

Posted on 2018-05-31 by Cologero

* * *

Lyon on 2018-06-01 at 20:58 said:

“But, I remember, that child felt itself to be a persona, it knew the importance of the ring and knew that it would never let it drop. It felt deeply offended by this lack of trust. That child was a very old and wise man.” Miguel Serrano

I recall having a somewhat similar realization around 4 years old, where I was clearly older, maturity-wise, than my age would betray.

4.4 Schopenhauer on the Will

Schopenhauer recognized that space, time, and causality are required for any experience and understanding of the natural world, or the world of phenomena. Knowledge, then, consists in understanding the sufficient reason for things, that is, the causal relationships between them. He also recognized, following Kant, that the phenomenal world is not self-explanatory or self-sufficient: there must be something beyond the natural, phenomenal world. Thus, he claimed, there is the noumenal, which he named the “Will”.

However, as a rationalist and philosopher, this Will is beyond knowledge, in the sense defined above. As unknowable, it can only be described as blind, purposeless, and unpredictable. Otherwise, we would know its sufficient reason, and it would be just another thing among other things in the natural world, and no longer the one ultimate reality and cause.

From a psychological point of view, the Will manifests as our drives, instincts, desires, and so on. Since it is purposeless, so, too, are our drives,

instincts, and desires. This is the cause of pain and suffering, so his solution lies in the rejection of the Will. The negative consequence is that it leads to a life of quietism and resignation.

From a metaphysical point of view, we would say he recognizes the faculty of reason, but rejects the higher form of knowledge called “intellect”, which knows transphenomenal reality directly and intuitively.

Posted on 2009-08-11 by Cologero

4.5 Nietzsche on the Will

Nietzsche, who early on regarded Schopenhauer as one of his educators, came to reject his doctrine. The first step was to reject Schopenhauer’s implicit supernaturalism, so for Nietzsche, the “Will” is part of the natural world and therefore has to be knowable, *viz.*, a will is known by its purpose and Schopenhauer’s Will is purposeless and therefore unintelligible. As a psychologist, Nietzsche looked within and recognized the Will as the “Will to Power”, as the propensity to growth, creativity, expansion, strength, and so on as described in his analysis.

Since the Will to Power is the ultimate reality, it cannot be dependent on anything else. In particular, it cannot be dependent on Reason; quite to the contrary, Reason is a manifestation of the Will to Power and is of value only insofar as it enhances the Will. This means — and I am speaking of the intellectual realm — that there is no ultimate criterion of Truth to which the Will to Power must submit. Instead, there are competing perspectives, each vying for influence but none of them ultimately convincing.

There is a further step. The Will to Power is originally a positive concept, that is, it is descriptive of the actual state of affairs in the world. However, it becomes a normative, or moral, concept: what is stronger,

that is, what has more power, becomes the Good. Nietzsche explains in *The Antichrist*:

What is good? — All that heightens the feeling of power, the will to power, power itself in man. What is happiness? — The feeling that power increases.

Note, however, that for Nietzsche the opposite of the Good is not Evil, but rather what is “bad”, that is, the opposite of the “feeling of power”. In particular, we can identify the Good with what is noble or strong or higher, generally what is more difficult and rare. The “bad”, then, is whatever glorifies weakness.

In the battle of ideas, although there is neither ultimate truth nor a God to guarantee it, we can still measure strength in the force of an idea. We reject ideas that rely on blind belief, ignorance, or stupidity. Instead, we may choose to embrace ideas that are rational, factual, intricate, and uplifting. That is why Nietzsche seldom argues as a philosopher might, but rather relies on oracular pronouncements and insightful observations on individual and society.

Psychologically, we may question the reliance on the mere “feeling” of power. It is not uncommon to observe “Nietzscheans” puff themselves up to achieve that feeling, yet without being particularly powerful themselves. It seems there should be an objective standard to measure power, but then the Will to Power cannot be dependent on such a standard (or else the standard itself would be the ultimate reality.) There is also the problem that oftentimes Nietzscheans argue as if they were discerning ultimate truth and opposing “Evil” rather than the bad.

Metaphysically, we have to reject Nietzsche’s naturalism and see the Will to Power as arising from something transcendent.

Posted on 2009-08-11 by Cologero

4.6 Evola on Will

In *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*, Evola devotes himself to the question of the Will. While acknowledging the influence of Nietzsche on his thought, Evola nevertheless rejects Nietzsche's naturalism and reintroduces the supernatural element. He does this by bringing back Schopenhauer's second foundation of the world, the "Idea", which Evola calls "essence" in line with Traditional thought.

Evola rejects, however, Schopenhauer's view that consciousness is the passive observer of phenomena, which is a creation of the Will. In place of this dualistic view, Evola identifies the center of consciousness, the "I", with the Will. Thus the individual is both the creator and the observer of the World. For the undeveloped man, this will is "spontaneous", that is, it is unconscious, undirected, and predestined, rather like Schopenhauer's Will. (See the chapter "Privation"⁸.)

On the other hand, the developed man has True Will and is the unconditioned cause of his world. As Evola puts it:

This principle is: THE POWER OF CONTROL. The "I", in fact, is not a thing, a "given", a "fact", but, essentially, a deep centre of will and power. As "I", Fichte says, it is, only insofar as it posits itself — and only a pure self-positing is, to tell the truth, its "being".

Note, in particular, that the "I" is not a fact, i.e., an object in the world, but is transcendent to the world.

As for the "essence" or "concept", Evola points out that concepts are sufficient for rational explanations; that is, the essence tells us "what" something is. However, the brute fact of existence — "that" something is — is not, and remains beyond rational explanation. Yet the fact of existence does become comprehensible when we realize that it is the creation of

⁸<https://gornahoor.net/Individual/IABW.htm#Privation>

our Will. Hence, the measure of one's will power is the ability to actualize what was only there in potential.

So, Evola's supernaturalism is world-affirming, not world-denying. He does not advocate a passive escape to the pure world of ideas, but rather the active bringing the ideas into reality. Thusly does Evola succeed in explaining Nietzsche's Will to Power, while retaining the transcendent supernaturalism of Traditional metaphysics.

Posted on 2009-08-13 by Cologero

4.7 When the Angels Disappear

Excellent personal qualities should beg to be excused or conceal themselves, for intellectual superiority offends by its mere existence without any desire to do so.

ARTHUR SCHOPENHAUER

It is not things that disturb men, but opinions about them.

EPICTETUS

True wealth is only the inner wealth of the soul. Everything else brings more trouble than advantage.

LUCIAN

Aristotle in the *Nicomachean Ethics* divided the good things of human life into three classes:

1. Those outside
2. Those of the soul

3. Those of the body

Arthur Schopenhauer described them in more detail.

1. **What a man is** and therefore personality in the widest sense. Accordingly, under this are included health, strength, beauty, temperament, moral character, intelligence and its cultivation.
2. **What a man has** and therefore property and possessions in every sense.
3. **What a man represents.** We know that by this expression is understood what he is in the eyes of others and thus how he is represented by them. Accordingly, it consists in their opinion of him and is divisible into honour, rank, and reputation.

What a Man Is What a man is ultimately depends on his own consciousness. Therefore, attempts to alter the material conditions of life, e.g., through legal means, so-called “safe spaces”, etc., will have limited effect. Schopenhauer explains why:

Everyone is confined to his consciousness as he is within his own skin and only in this does he really live; thus he cannot be helped very much from without.

People living in the same environment and political system may still have radically different understandings. Despite being in the identical material situation, people live in worlds of their own. Schopenhauer explains why:

A man is directly concerned only with his own conceptions, feelings, and voluntary movements; things outside influence him only insofar as they give rise to these. The world in which each lives depends first on his interpretation thereof and therefore proves to be different to different men. Accordingly, it will result in

- being poor, shall, and superficial,
- or rich, interesting and full of meaning.

For example, while many envy another man the interesting events that have happened to him in his life, they should rather envy this gift of interpretation which endowed those events with the significance they have when he describes them.

What a man *is* contributes to his happiness more than what he *has* or what he *represents*. Hence, we will focus on that essay, which can be found in Volume I of *Parerga and Paralipomena*.

Aside from cases of serious misfortune, how we interpret and feel about the events of our life is more important to our inner well being and happiness than the events themselves. That is why misfortunates that originate from outside us are more easily bearable than those we have created ourselves. That is why people berate themselves for their errors. Schopenhauer tells us why: we feel that our luck can change, but it is much more difficult to change one's nature.

Therefore, subjective blessings should be pursued more readily than objective ones. Schopenhauer has his own list:

- Noble character
- Gifted mind
- Happy temperament
- Cheerful spirits
- Well-conditioned and sound body

Cheerfulness Although Schopenhauer has a reputation for being the “philosopher of pessimism”, in his personal life he valued being merry and cheerful. Obviously, they are their own reward. Curiously, people tend to be suspicious of cheerfulness and look for a reason for it. Health is an important factor. He recommends the avoidance of:

- excesses and irregularities
- violent and disagreeable emotions
- prolonged mental strain

Of course, movement and regular exercise contribute to health.

Pain and Boredom Pain and boredom are the enemies of happiness:

- Lack and privation produce pain
- Security and affluence give rise to boredom

Inner vacuity and emptiness, which Schopenhauer claims to be able to see in the faces of the masses, crave events in the external world to fill up their minds. He describes the process:

This vacuity is the real source of boredom and always craves for external excitement in order to set the mind and spirits in motion through something The emptiness of their inner life, the dullness of their consciousness, the poorness of their minds drive them to the company of others which consists of men like themselves. They then pursue pastime and entertainment in common which they seek first in sensual pleasures, in amusements of every kind, and finally in excess and dissipation.

Solitude The greater our inner wealth, the less room there is for boredom. While inner vacuity results in “the craze for society, diversion, amusement, and luxury of every kind”, inner wealth is different.

The clever and intelligent man will first of all look for painlessness, freedom from molestation, quietness, and leisure and consequently for a tranquil and modest life which is as undisturbed as possible. Accordingly, after some acquaintance with human beings so called, he will choose seclusion and, if of greater intellect, even solitude. For the more a man has within himself, the less does he need from without and also the less other people can be to him. Therefore eminence of intellect leads to unsociability.

The Three Physiological Fundamental Forces By these, Schopenhauer means eros, thumos, and nous. In the primal state, their originary use was in the struggle against lack and privation. When that problem is solved for the most part, the forces are underutilized and require stimulation. Depending on his dominant centre, a man will pursue different pleasures.

- **Eros.** The pleasures of the power of reproduction: eating, drinking, digesting, resting, and sleeping.
- **Thumos.** The pleasures of irascibility: walking, jumping, wrestling, dancing, fencing, riding, hunting, athletic games, and even war.
- **Nous.** The pleasures of sensibility: observing, thinking, feeling, writing, poetry, improving the mind, playing music, learning, reading, meditating, inventing, philosophizing, etc.

Sensibility, i.e., the ability to respond to intellectual and aesthetic sensations, ranks the human being higher than the animals, which are restricted to the two inferior forces. Schopenhauer describes the two types like this:

The life of the masses is passed in dullness since all their thoughts and desires are directed entirely to the petty interests of personal welfare and thus to wretchedness and misery in all its forms.

On the other hand:

The existence of the man who is endowed with outstanding intellectual powers is rich in ideas and full of life and meaning. Worthy and interesting objects occupy him as soon as he is permitted to devote himself to them, and he bears within himself a source of the noblest pleasures. Stimulation from without comes to him from the works of nature and the contemplation of human affairs and then from the many and varied achievements of the most highly gifted of all ages and lands; only such a man is really capable of thoroughly enjoying those things for he alone can fully understand and feel them. Accordingly, for him those highly gifted men have actually lived; to him they have really appealed; whereas the rest as casual hearers only half-understand something or other.

The Two Lives Such a man lives two lives: a personal life and an intellectual life. The latter is his real life and the former is merely a means. The intellectual life obtains cohesion, wholeness, and perfection, “becoming ever more complete like a slowly maturing work of art.”

The centre of gravity of such a man is entirely within himself. Schopenhauer makes this rather strange point:

Our moral virtues benefit mainly other people; intellectual virtues, on the other hand, benefit primarily ourselves. Therefore, the former makes us universally popular, the latter unpopular.

Pain and Melancholy Up to this point, we have been emphasizing the positive aspect of the intellectual life. However, it can be a mixed blessing. That is because, in his words:

Great intellectual gifts may produce a very much enhanced sensitiveness to pain in every form. Further, the passionate temperament that conditions such gifts, and at the same time the greater vividness and completeness of all images and conceptions inseparable therefrom, produce an incomparably greater intensity of the emotions that are thereby stirred.

Since there are more painful emotions than pleasant ones, the former can be aroused more readily. For example, I know a great souled being who sometimes sees too deeply and too far ahead, beyond what she can handle, resulting in sadness.

Others have perhaps noted this ambiguity. For example, **Aristotle** can assert, on the one hand:

The philosophical life is the happiest.

Yet, he also wrote:

All those who distinguished themselves whether in philosophy, politics, poetry, or the arts, appear to be melancholy.

Sophocles has also contradicted himself in the same way:

- To be intelligent is the main part of happiness. (*Antigone*)
- The most agreeable life consists in a lack of intelligence (*Ajax*)

Even the Bible leaves us in ambiguity:

- The life of a fool is worse than death! (Sirach 12:12)
- In much wisdom is much grief, and he that increaseth knowledge increaseth sorrow. (Ecclesiastes 1:18)

Love and Will Although Schopenhauer's essay focuses on the physical and intellectual aspects of happiness, a brief mention can be made about the moral and aesthetic life, as they relate to happiness. Thinking is self-limiting, and true Wisdom lies in a realm beyond thought. If Wisdom is the feminine element, then Love is the masculine element that resolves contradictions. The intellectual is content, like Epicurus in his garden, to remain alone in his solitary contemplations. Love, on the other hand, draws him back out of himself to another, albeit on a higher level than the sociability of the dullards described by Schopenhauer.

On the level of cataphatic theology, or thinking, one can meditate on the Unmoved Mover. However, in Love, one learns to *be* the Unmoved Mover. In the second appendix to the *Yoga of Power*, **Julius Evola**, quotes **Dante**:

I am as the centre of a circle, to which the parts of the circumference stand in equal relation.

In other words, Love is characterized by **centrality**, **transcendence**, **stability**, and **immutability**. Love, whether in the form of an actual woman or, if you prefer, as a metaphor for the feminine part of a man, brings a huge risk to the philosopher. The wholeness which he thought he had achieved turns out to be missing an essential element, viz., transcendence.

If he can raise himself to the point of centrality, stability, and immutability, he reaches a level of being that transcends mere thinking and finds his True Will, i.e., not motivated by worldly concerns, nor even in the service of thought.

Posted on 2018-05-24 by Cologero

4.8 The Beautiful Losers of History

Then know that Allah has described Himself as the Outwardly Manifest and the Inwardly Hidden; He brought the universe into

existence as a Visible world and an Unseen world so that we might know the Hidden by the Unseen and the Manifest by the Visible.

IBN ARABI, *The Wisdom of the Prophets*

Schopenhauer Much is missed if you don't read the deepest thinkers directly. You miss the motivation, the problems that need to be solved, and so on. One image from Schopenhauer's masterwork remains with me. He relates the story of a man in Morocco whose lower jaw was pulled from his face. I don't know how long news like that took to reach Germany, but how, just how, does that event fit into a philosophical system? That is what he tried to answer.

The World as Representation If a tree falls in the forest, and no one is nearby to hear it, does it make a sound? You may have already answered that, although it produces sound waves, there is no sound.

If a tree falls in the forest, and no one is nearby to see it, does it make a sight? The answer "no" will elicit doubt from most people.

Yet if the former is true, then so must be the latter. Following Spinoza, if Extension has no qualities, then qualities must be a product of Thought. This does not imply that the world is imaginary or arbitrary. Analogous to Jung's Collective Unconscious, there is a Collective Conscious that experiences the world.

This is the outwardly manifest world.

Kant called that the phenomenal world. He speculated that there is an unseen world — the noumenal world — that corresponds one-to-one with the phenomenal world. That makes no sense. If objects are creations of the Mind — and Extension has no qualities — postulating invisible objects corresponding to manifest objects make no sense. The world represented in the Mind simply is that world.

This, Schopenhauer asserts, must be grasped intuitively as a Principle. He writes:

“The world is my representation” is, like Euclid’s axioms, a proposition which everyone must recognize as true as soon as he understands it, although it is not a proposition that everyone understands as soon as he hears it.

Space, Time, Causality, Will Space and time are, from the metaphysical perspective, preconditions for the human state.

Space, time, and causality are likewise mental phenomena. That is, there is no space independent of mind that gets filled up with stuff, nor time without any objects. Things relate to each other in terms of space, time, or cause. It is unnecessary to resort to “matter” as the causal element for the objects of our experience.

For Descartes, the primary object of our experience is “I am”. Schopenhauer takes it one step further, identifying our Will as our primal experience. This is consistent with Spinoza’s notion of “conatus”, i.e., the striving of things to preserve themselves in being. This is experienced in human beings as the conscious experience of desire, human freedom, and good and evil. Thus the human being strives for an increase in power, which is the same as virtue. To the extent that he recognizes the source of his motives, he gains power over himself.

Thought occurs successively in time, so it is how the subject comes to know itself. The will is identical in time and manifests itself over the course of life. He asserts:

The course of life retains the same fundamental tone; in fact, its manifold events and scenes are at bottom like variations on one and the same theme.

Thus life is like a symphony or an opera, in which themes reappear in slightly different forms. For self-understanding, it is necessary to pay attention to those themes. And like a good opera, the main theme ultimately is resolved. You can consciously act out your role or you can just let it happen to you.

Our will and our acts are not two different things, as some assume that the will is the “cause” of the movements of the body. The Will is to the Act, as the inside is to the outside. The gnostic will, the feeling of deliberation of alternatives, often accompanied by anxiety or inertia, is not at all our True Will. Our true will is the spontaneous expression of who we are. When the proper circumstances appear that are in conformance with one’s destiny, then the True Will seizes the opportunity. The gnostic will delays and the opportunity is lost.

Schopenhauer’s God So if things, space, time, cause, and even one’s own self are aspects of the Manifest World, Schopenhauer turns to what is Hidden, or the Noumenal, as he calls it. Matter is part of the phenomenal world. But matter is in motion everywhere we look, from the stars and planets down to animals, plants, and so on; hence, it can’t be ultimate. Rather it is energy that is ultimate in the phenomenal world. Matter, therefore, is just condensed energy, that is, energy confined to a particular space.

Now the only thing that we are aware of, from the inside, is our own will. It is clear that we don’t know what it is like to be a “bat”, for example, or a stone, etc. Hence, the conclusion is that ultimate reality must be related to the Will. So energy as phenomena is condensed Will, as noumenon; this Will is not the same as the human will. Rather, it is a blind urge, purposeless, a striving devoid of knowledge.

As it is Hidden and Noumenal, we can have no direct experience of the Will. Rather, our experience of it consists of the random motions and events of the phenomenal world. It is easy to see our world as random, cruel, and without any particular goal.

Just like Spinoza’s God, Schopenhauer’s Will is a challenge to Traditional teaching since they mimic it in many respects. The difference is that the philosophers believe that they can comprehend the essence of the Absolute, or the Unseen world, through reason alone.

World Denial as Way of Life In the face of the hopelessness of the blind will, Schopenhauer retreats into a profound pessimism. His only moral principle is to cause no harm, to bring no more suffering into the world. The obviously corollary to that is his antinatalism. Life brings suffering. Although he admired Buddhism for its pessimistic outlook on life, he failed to accept its teaching on the end of suffering. Besides Buddhism, he also found solace in the mysticism of Brahmanism and also of neoplatonic currents in Christianity.

His escape valve was his love of the arts and High Culture, particularly music. That is a countercurrent, a swimming against the tide, of the force of the Will.

Power as Virtue In our time, particularly in the Western countries, a philosophy akin to Schopenhauer's, is dominant, usually unconsciously. Thus birth rates have plummeted. However, there is no longer High Culture as solace, since the blind will is even destroying that.

There are many naïve souls who believe that logic, evidence, facts, persuasion, objectivity, and the like, will convince the Will to behave. Only power can oppose power. Until the revolvers against the modern world recognize it, they will be counted amongst the beautiful losers of history.

Posted on 2021-04-18 by Cologero

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Greg on 2021-04-21 at 12:11 said:

Only power can oppose power. A sobering truth. It appears that all power resides with the elites who have shaped the modern world and will continue dragging it down. So we are destined to be beautiful losers? What of it? What good is it too be on the right side of history if that places you on the wrongside of eternity?Apocalyptic literature suggests that history ends with the triumph of darkness and evil. It may be that to choose God, one must surrender the world. Or perhaps you mean supernatural power, sacred magic as Tomberg calls it. Perhaps a battle between sacred power and the powers of the world?

Cologero on 2021-04-29 at 07:44 said:

Who knows, Greg. Morality seems to be a luxury, suitable only for life in a civilization. Otherwise, raw power seems to hold sway.

Angolmois on 2021-05-02 at 14:10 said:

Greg, there was a line in Robert Bolton's *The Order of the Ages* that caught my eye and which went something like this: "it is no great feat to be spiritual in a spiritual civilization where everything anti-spiritual is suppressed; the true way is found only when almost everything is opposed to it." Spiritual people must be living the best times since at least one's convictions are being challenged from every possible direction.

Jorgen B on 2021-05-23 at 23:31 said:

Schopenhauer would have been a monk in the middle ages.

Reza on 2021-06-21 at 22:51 said:

@Jorgen

Not so my friend! Don't confuse his philosophy with his personality and inclinations. From his biographies one comes to know the man to be a *bon vivant*.

4.9 Intuition, Infinity, Science

Robin Collingwood is probably the last of the idealist philosophers⁹ and he was greatly influenced by the Italian philosopher, Giovanni Gentile. Unfortunately, in our time, Gentile is quite forgotten, even by those on the "right" who should be recovering his thought. Perhaps these quotes will motivate some to return to the richness of Western thought, rather than worrying about what some Cro-Magnon man was thinking 20,000 years ago. Note, too, the emphasis on will and self-creation. Following the long quote, I offer a brief commentary.

Man's life is a becoming: and not only becoming, but self-creation. He does not grow under the direction and control of

⁹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=54>

irresistible forces. The force that shapes him is his own will. All his life is an effort to attain to real human nature. But human nature, since man is at bottom spirit, is only exemplified in the absolute spirit of God. Hence man must shape himself in God's image, or he ceases to be even human and becomes diabolical. This self-creation must also be self-knowledge; not the self-knowledge of introspection, the examination of the self that is, but the knowledge of God, the self that is to be. Knowledge of God is the beginning, the center, and end, of human life.

How is the mind to be at once in change and out of change? Only if the mind originates change in itself. For then, as the source and ground of change, it will not be subject to change; while on the other hand, as undergoing change through its own free act, it will exhibit change. This double aspect of the mind as active and passive is the very heart of philosophy the distinction between fact and act. The act is out of time in the sense that it creates time, just as it is supernatural in the sense that it creates nature; the fact is temporal, natural, subject to all those laws which constitute its finiteness. But between the act and the fact there is no division: the distinction is only an ideal distinction. In creating the fact, the act realized itself, and does not live apart in a heaven of its own for which it issues mandates for the creation of facts; it lives in the facts which it creates.

The life of absolute knowledge is thus the conscious self-creation of the mind, no mere discovery of what it is, but the making of itself what it is.

The infinite is not another thing which is best grasped by sweeping the finite out of the way; the infinite is nothing but the unity, or as we sometimes say, the "meaning," of finite things in their diversity and their mutual connections. To look for the infinite by throwing away the finite would be very much like making the players stop playing in order to hear the symphony. What they are collectively playing *is* the symphony; and if you cannot hear it

for the noise they are making, you cannot hear it at all. The notes are, so to speak, the body of which the symphony is the soul; and in that sense we might say that the finite is the body of which the infinite is the soul; though, if we say that, we must beware of the materialism which would delude us into talking of disembodied spirits, and remember that it is of the essence of spirit to embody itself.

ROBIN COLLINGWOOD

There has been much discussion, and probably more than a little bit of confusion, about the related issues of

1. Where does science leave off and metaphysics begin?
2. How does the rational knowing of the sciences differ from the intuitional knowing of metaphysics?

I have a short article by the philosopher Robin Collingwood that, I believe, clarifies these issues, even though he frames the discussion as religion (metaphysics) vs. science, and faith (intuition) vs. reason. So, keeping that translation in mind, I can offer a few of his thoughts.

Fundamentally, he points out that faith (intuition or intellect) is the knowledge of the infinite and reason the knowledge of the finite.

What is known by intuition is universal, necessary, and rational, but not demonstrable by logic. It cannot be denied without creating a contradiction. Therefore, it is not knowledge of any particular fact (e.g., my “intuition” tells me who is on the telephone). Science deals with the details of the world and a scientific theory is always falsifiable (deniable) in principle. Therefore, it can only be considered *opinion* and lacks the absolute certainty of metaphysical intuition.

The proper sphere of faith (or intellect) is everything in the collective sense — everything as a whole. The proper sphere of reason is everything

in the distributive sense, each separate thing, no matter what. Superstition means to select certain finite things from among the rest and withdraw them from the sphere of reason (that is, it makes the claim that the part is the whole).

Collingwood also deals with the question of why we talk about what allegedly cannot be talked about. If you believe i.e., have faith in, know by intuition in the rationality of the world and the trustworthiness of human thinking, you will embody your belief in detailed scientific inquiries. That shows the foundation of science in an intuition about the whole. Conversely, the spirit of faith intuition is shown to be a real spirit by embodying itself in reason, that is, by developing its own assertions, which as undeveloped would be mere abstractions, into a rational system of thought and conduct.

Posted on 2010-04-05 by Cologero

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littleM on 2018-04-05 at 10:50 said:

I am so glad to be very untalented in fields of empirical science, especially Mathematics. Ontological truths are better supported by simple minds, not speculative conjectures. I am unsure what is the word for it in English, but in German it is Hochmut, in Greek megalopsychia, or Latin superbia – to dare to ponder and give speculative answers about Prim Truths.

4.10 Soloviov's Philosophical Principles of Integral Knowledge

4.10.1 Law of Development

One of the earliest works of **Vladimir Solovyov**, published when he was 24, was *The Philosophical Principles of Integral Knowledge*. There, he tackles the meaning of historical development, integral knowledge,

the Absolute, and the Idea. Solovyov's doctoral thesis was a survey of **Positivism** and similar movements in which he was highly critical of **Auguste Comte**. Nevertheless, the chapter on historical development seems to owe something to Comte, perhaps in an attempt to bring Positivism into a higher understanding. In the latter part of his life, Solovyov ameliorated his opinion of Comte.

He begins by asking the question of the purpose of human existence, which is really a question about the final cause of existence, something ruled out of bounds by the modernist project. Everyone, I suppose, has asked himself that question. However, Solovyov wants to go beyond the personal to the general and asks about the goal of human existence in general. Since man is always in community, Solovyov claims that "the dignity of the personal and immediate goals of a human life can define itself only by its relationship to that common and final goal for which it serves as the means."

The question of a goal naturally leads to the question of development, the process of achieving that goal. If the "changing phenomena [of world events] linked with each other merely in an external manner," then clearly a common goal is a meaningless concept. Of course, that is what the Baconian project entails. Hence, progressives are always in a state of perpetual development without any articulated goal.

First and foremost, "development presupposes a specific subject"; it is the subject that develops. First, he distinguishes between an aggregate (or heap) and an organism (or system). An aggregate cannot be said to develop. Only an organism, "a single being that contains in itself a multitude of elements that are internally connected to each other" can develop. However, the organism exists not in isolation and the "material of development and the impelling source of its realization come from the outside". This "impelling source can act only in conjunction with the peculiar nature of the organism. In traditional terms, the external elements constitute the material and efficient causes of development whereas the

formal and final causes are contained in the subject of development.

Change by itself, without a known point of origin that continues indefinitely, not having any specific purpose, cannot be considered to be development. Here, Solovyov defines development.

Development is that series of immanent changes in an organic being that proceeds from a known origin and directs itself toward a known, definite goal.

Endless development, then, is a logical absurdity. In nuce, the Law of Development contains three stages:

1. A known primary condition, from which it is initiated
2. Another known condition, which is its goal
3. A series of intermediate conditions, as a transition or means

We note some consequences of this. First, there is a unity in the subject, which is its Form or defining characteristic. Then, the defining characteristic is transferred to the separate components.

Historical Development Solovyov next seeks to apply the Law of Development to humankind as a real, collective organism, a task he claims had never been satisfactorily carried out. Let's be clear that this is not an obvious project. For example, libertarian philosophers, such as **Friedrich Hayek**, are consistent nominalists and hence deny the real existence of humankind or any collective. He regards the individual as a real existent, but the group as such is a convenient fiction and no more than a mere name for an aggregate of individuals.

Solovyov anticipates this objection and notes that every being and every organism possesses a necessarily collective character. He points out, for example, that the cells in your body are themselves individual entities

and they exist oblivious to being a part of the human organism. Hence, the individual man can be a real, individual being while still participating in a higher system. At this point, readers may want to reconsider **Boris Mouravieff**'s description of a series of higher order worlds or systems, considered as an aspect of orthodox theology.

An organism has a static part, its components, and a dynamic part, its subsystems. The component parts of the organism of humankind are not individuals, however, but rather tribes and peoples. Solovyov will proceed to develop the common formative systems of humankind.

Like Comte, Solovyov identifies three basic forms of being: *feeling*, *thinking*, and *active will*. Personal and subjective expressions of these forms of being cannot serve as formative principles. Only objective expressions can be part of the process of development.

- **Objective Beauty.** That feeling that strives to strengthen its existing condition by an objective expression of it.
- **Objective Truth.** That kind of thinking that strives for a specific objective content.
- **Objective Good.** That will that has in mind definite general goals.

4.10.2 Development of the Will

The Will manifests as Objective Good in three levels: prosperity, justice, and eternal bliss.

The nature of a person manifests in three forms of being: *feeling*, *thinking*, and *willing*. **Vladimir Solovyov** is interested only in their objectifications, unlike the modern mentality which considers these forms of being as merely subjective. The first form Solovyov looks at is willing. The modern mind considers the will only insofar as it reflects personal desires or, in the abstract, as simply the *will to power* for its own sake. But

to regard the will as a positive principle for life, requires that it seeks its objectification, or manifestation, in definite goals, a fortiori, as an objective good.

The objectification of Will takes place in three levels, corresponding to the three castes¹⁰. In order to achieve any goal, it is first necessary to provide for the existence of persons, which depends on their relationship the external world and the activities required to extract the means for existence. This is the beginning of economic society, whose task is the organization of labour. This task belongs to the Vaishyas who are oriented to the external world. This is the material basis of society. Its primary elementary form is the family, which is based on the division of labour. We saw that the Ancient City was based on extended family relationships, up to the clan.

The next level is concerned with the relationship of people to each other and their interactions as members of a single collective whole. This is political society, or the state, whose task is the organization of workers, and this task is the responsibility of the Kshatriyas. Since there are many states, there is also the problem of international relations between states. These relations are not always pacific, so the Kshatriya caste must also include warriors. However, this does not preclude the possibility of the realization of a universal state, as in the case of the Roman Empire.

The third level is determined by the religious character of a person, or his relationship to the transcendent. Clearly, the ultimate responsibility belongs to the Brahman caste. Solovyov writes:

A person desires not only *material* existence, which is provided by economic society, and not only *lawful* existence, which is given to him by political society, but he desires as well an *absolute* existence, one that is complete and eternal. Only the last of these is a genuine, supreme state of well-being, the summum bonum, with respect

¹⁰<https://gornahoor.net/?p=1647>

to which material goods attained through labour, and economic and formal goods attained through political activity, serve only as the means. Since the attainment of absolute existence, or eternal and blissful life, is the highest goal for everyone alike, this goal necessarily becomes the principle of social union, which may be called spiritual or sacred society.

These considerations may be summarized in chart 4.10.2:

Level	Society	Correspondence	Role in development
I	Economic society	Matter	External basis
II	Political society	Form	Means
III	Spiritual society	Spirit	Goal

Table 4.1: Role of development

- A person must live
Material prosperity, the fruits of his labour, do not provide a person with well-being for his essential, or True, Will. Economic activity alone is not moral.
- A person must live with others
To be moral, the Will must take the form of justice, which is determined by the political society, or the State. Even still, just interpersonal relationships do not produce bliss.
- A person must relate to the transcendent
Bliss comes from principles that are outside and beyond the natural and the human worlds.

Solovyov concludes his discussion:

Only that society that is based directly on relations with these transcendental principles can have as its direct objective the well-being of a person in his totality and absoluteness. *This is what spiritual society or the church must be.*

Here we have a program, as yet still partial since it only concerns the Will, for any attempt at the reformation of the modern world.

- It must provide for the material well-being of the people, whose fundamental unit is the family, not the individual.
- It must provide a stable and just political system that also protects against external threats.
- It must be unified by a common spiritual tradition, since the relationship to the Absolute provides the ultimate meaning to man.

4.10.3 The Development of Mind

A person may deal with the data of conscious activity on three levels: Science, Philosophy, and Theology.

Science **Science** seeks to organize and determine the underlying laws behind the mass of factual information gleaned from the observation and experience of the external world and human life. The basic element of science is the **fact**.

Our empirical knowledge of the the physical world can never be complete. On the one hand, our senses are subject to illusions and on the other, there can never be complete certainty regarding scientific theories. They cannot be fully verified, yet are always open to being falsified¹¹. Our theories of the contingent events of the physical world are necessarily

¹¹<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Falsifiability>

matters of opinion and hence no more than likely stories. A scientific theory is the most likely story.

However, of the three levels of knowledge, science is the easiest to master, hence, it has produced the most impressive results over the past several centuries. Science is universal in the sense that it is accessible to anyone with the proper preparation and ability to understand its mathematical models. There is no requirement for a personal transformation. That is why past assertions of an “Aryan science” or a “Jewish science” were misguided. Science is no respecter of persons.

This is also why science is accumulative. Each scientist can build on the work of previous scientists; there is no need to repeat all the earlier experiments once certain facts have been established. Science owes its success because it makes simplifying assumptions about the world. For example, Francis Bacon¹² made the methodological assumption of science to bracket out the question of formal and final causes. Hence, the scientist can focus on physical things and the relationships among them. Their function or purpose are of no concern.

Scientists often make other methodological assumptions such as the anti-philosophies of materialism, atheism, or determinism. As such, there is no objection. However, scientists, in their one-sightedness, sometimes err in claiming that these assumptions are objectively true descriptions of the world.

Philosophy **Philosophy** is the formal perfection of knowledge and its logical coherence. Its basic unit is the idea. Philosophy can only point out the necessary conditions for the genuine attainment of knowledge, but it does not provide its content. The content must come from the level below or above.

Science seeks to determine the relationships among things. The goal

¹²<https://gornahoor.net/?p=3468>

of philosophy is to know the Sufficient Reason¹³, that is, the reason or cause for something to exist. Philosophy develops much more slowly than Science, because each generation of philosophers must recapitulate the thoughts of previous philosophers, a tedious and demanding process.

The potential errors of science are the possibility of delusion in the observations and the possibility of a theory being falsified. The potential error of philosophy comes from starting with false first principles. In that case, all deductions from such a principle will be logically false. Another potential error comes from the temptation of the sophists, the demon of dialectics; the sophist will use the tools of logic and the vocabulary of philosophy to make a case for a predetermined position, thus having only a subjective significance. A true philosopher must be disinterested in his search for first principles and sufficient reasons.

Theology **Theology** is concerned with the universal or absolute content of knowledge. Science is concerned with particular beings, philosophy with the form of knowledge, and theology with absolute being.

Unlike Science, the truths of Theology are independent of external reality. Unlike Philosophy, the truths of Theology are above Reason. Its subject matter is the absolute first principle of all of existence. Solovyov concludes:

Only this principle imparts genuine meaning and significance both to

- The concepts of Philosophy
- The facts of Science

Without this:

- The concepts of Philosophy becomes meaningless form

¹³http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Principle_of_sufficient_reason

- The facts of Science become undifferentiated matter

Thus we see that genuine knowledge is *knowledge of the Whole*, or the One in Neoplatonic terms, or the Absolute, the Infinite, or the Tao. This form of knowledge is Gnosis and is superior to Reason.

4.10.4 Development of Feeling

By “feeling”, **Vladimir Solovyov** is not referring to subjective and personal impressions, but rather to the higher feeling centre, insofar as it is objective and leads to creation. Again, these feelings are manifested in the material, formal, and absolute levels.

Technical Arts In material creation, the idea of beauty serves merely as an ornament in the context of utilitarian goals. Solovyov actually calls this “technical applied art”, and its highest representative is architecture. This hardly seems true in the modern world, where ugly architecture¹⁴ is the norm. Oddly enough, more effort is now put into making electronic gadgets aesthetic as well as functional. At this level, the expression of beauty is limited by the necessity to be functional and useful. Artisans and craftsmen are the representatives of this level.

Fine Art Fine art is a kind of creation whose defining significance comes from the aesthetic form and is expressed in purely ideal images. Fine arts come in four forms, which are organized in an ascent from matter to spirit. The fine arts are distinguished from the technical arts by not having a utilitarian necessity.

Sculpture Sculpture is the most material art, the one closest.

¹⁴<http://www.forbes.com/2002/05/03/0503home.html>

Painting Painting is more ideal than sculpture since there is no imitation of the corporeal in it. Unlike sculpture, which is three dimensional, the images in a painting are depicted on a flat surface.

Music Music possesses more of a spiritual quality, as it is no longer embodied in or on the material itself. Rather, it is embodied in the movement and life of its substance—sound.

Poetry Poetry finds its expression in the spiritual element of the human word. This is why so much of the greatest spiritual literature is in the poetic form. Poetry, along with command, was the primary way of thinking in the primordial state¹⁵.

Mysticism Fine art still does not reach the ideal of Beauty in its totality, since the contents of a work of art are accidental. The content of **Absolute Beauty** must be definite, necessary, and eternal. This type of beauty is not manifested directly in the world, although objects and phenomena are reflections of it. Genuine and complete Beauty, therefore, is located in the superhuman and supernatural world.

Solovyov calls the creative relationship of feeling to the transcendental world **Mysticism**. Specifically, he means the direct spontaneous relationship of the Spirit to the transcendental world, and not the negative connotations this word carries. Solovyov lists three criteria for juxtaposing mysticism with technical arts:

1. Both have feeling as their basis, rather than perception and active will
2. Both rely on imagination or fantasy, rather than reflection and external activity

¹⁵<https://gornahoor.net/index.php?s=jaynes&submit=Search>

3. Both presuppose a an ecstatic inspiration, rather than a calm consciousness

Mysticism, for Solovyov, who himself had direct mystical experiences, is far from the popular association with the vague, unclear, and incomprehensible. He explains:

The sphere of Mysticism possesses an absolute clarity by itself, and it alone can clarify everything else, precisely as a result of this its light is unbearable for weak and unprotected eyes, and it plunges them into absolute darkness.

The Degeneration of Beauty Concerning the degeneration of art, Solovyov writes:

Contemporary Western art cannot capture the ideal content of life for the simple reason that it itself has lost it. In the sphere of creative work we see in the West the same alteration in the three supremacies. In the Middle Ages unfettered art does not exist; everything is subordinated to mysticism.

Since the Renaissance, as a result of the general weakening of religious principles, the fine art of form emerged, and art was restricted to the accidental and arbitrary. In the modern world, the technical arts prevail, which are utilitarian and practical. Art has become a trade and a business. What does it cost is the primary interest of the art collector.

Art for art's sake, for the sake of beauty, no longer exists. In the attempt to transcend form, art has instead become formless. Paintings are random, music discordant, poetry meaningless. Sculpture, as the art of three dimensions is replaced with arbitrary collections of debris and detritus. In a forced effort to appear engaged and relevant, the contemporary artist can only shock the common man rather than raise his consciousness to the Ideal of Beauty. Those who are beyond being shocked are

most in need of a raised consciousness, which is an invisible target for them.

4.10.5 Three Stages of Development

In old Europe human life received its ideal content from the Catholic faith, on the one hand, and from knightly feudalism on the other

VLADIMIR SOLOVYOV

Vladimir Solovyov claims that there is a three stage process of development.

1. In the first stage, the levels exist in an undifferentiated form. The levels exist virtually, not actually.
2. In the second stage, the lower levels manifest independently of the higher one and seek to exist independently. Furthermore, to assert its independence, each area rejects the corresponding areas on its own level.
3. In the third stage, the highest level separates itself, gaining its freedom and thus bringing about the possibility of a new unity. Since none of the lower levels can actually achieve exclusive domination, they are forced to seek a higher center outside themselves. This must involve the free, conscious subordination of the lower levels to the higher as their true centre.

These stages will be discussed in terms of the Cosmic Cycle as well as specific historical manifestations. For reference, chart 4.10.5 is included.

Spheres of	Creation	Knowledge	Praxis
<i>Subjective Basis</i>	Feeling	Thinking	Willing
<i>Objective Principle</i>	Beauty	Truth	Good
<i>Absolute Level</i>	Mysticism	Theology	Spiritual Society
<i>Formal Level</i>	Fine art	Philosophy	Political Society
<i>Material Level</i>	Technical Art	Science	Economic Society
<i>Integration</i>	Theurgy	Theosophy	Theocracy

Table 4.2: Spheres of existence

Cosmic Cycle From the Traditional perspective, this development is understood this way.

1. In the Primordial Golden Age, there is a true unity and everything is ordered to the level of the Absolute. There is no caste distinction since everyone has this understanding.
2. The next stage encompasses the degeneration of castes in a process of decline. The centre moves from the Absolute, to the formal, to the material following the successive revolts of the lower castes. Eventually, the material world is the main focus. However, this degeneration cannot continue unabated.
3. In the ascending phase of the Kali Yuga, there is the possibility for some men to come to a higher awareness and adopt the higher viewpoint, not as a matter of birth, but rather as a conscious and free choice. This will lead up to a new Golden Age.

Historical Manifestation Solovyov does not explicitly mention the law of cosmic cycles, though he had to have known of them. However,

he helpfully gives several examples of the Law of Development.

Ancient City In the Ancient City, the spheres and levels were not differentiated. The family and clan were the first forms of economic life, but they also possessed a political and religious significance¹⁶. Solovyov notes that the levels were not distinguished and hence they formed interconnected wholes. He identifies them as:

- **Theosophy**: comprising theology, philosophy, and science.
- **Theocracy**: comprising church, government, and economic society.
- **Theurgy**: comprising mysticism, fine art, and technical art in a single mystical creative process.

Together, these three form a single religious whole.

Christendom It is difficult for many to view the period of Christendom with the necessary detachment to understand it. In late paganism, the rites and rituals of the Ancient City had become empty forms, poorly understood, if at all. It was in this milieu that a change was required. Keep in mind Guenon's claim that the initial impulse of Christianity was esoteric, but that at a certain point it was necessary for it to become exoteric. Solovyov points out the reason for this:

It must be acknowledged that in the universal consciousness of humankind the original interconnectedness was shaken decisively and to its very foundations only with the advent of Christianity,

¹⁶Since we have already written extensively on this in *The Mind of the Ancient City*, *The Religion of the Ancient City*, and *The Degeneration of the Ancient City*, we will pass over this cursorily. See its respective Sections in the *Ancient City* volume.

when for the first time the sacred was separated from the profane. In this respect, as a force that dealt the final blow to this external, involuntary unity, Christianity represented the beginning of genuine freedom.

Solovyov then traces the detachment and isolation of the spheres and levels that followed in Christendom. The process begins with the separation of the two lower profane, natural levels from the sacred, divine highest level. Specifically, the government and economic activities separate from the Church. The full explication of this process will have to await a separate posting, but we will report Solovyov's conclusion.

Christians stripped [the government] of any positive spiritual content. For them the emperor —the last god of the pagan world— could be only the chief administrator of the police. This relationship negated the very principle of ancient society, which entailed specifically the deification of the republic and the emperor as its representative, the merging of spiritual and secular principles. Hence the emperors, in persecuting the Christians, were acting not as bearers of government powers in the narrow sense of the term, but as bearers of the entire ancient consciousness.

There are many today who resent this either because they still retain elements of the ancient consciousness or, as is more likely, they resent the imposition of freedom required by the new order of things. The separation of the sacred from the profane introduces an element of choice, which interferes in the felt immediacy of a natural consciousness.

Next: The decline of Christendom and the lineaments of the next stage.

Reformation and Revolution

The Third Stage

Posted on 2011-12-01 by Cologero

* * *

Logres on 2011-12-06 at 23:20 said:

This is perfectly put together – how is it done? But it doesn't matter. A thought or a question – in a graded hierarchy (replete with caste and with shades of gradation through the human pyramid), wouldn't it actually be EASIER to relate to others, both immediately above you, and slightly beneath you? Since the difference (although perhaps great in terms of caste) would be not so great in terms of human gradation or circumstance? Barzun thought that democracy had caused a huge suspicion of intellect & endless jockeying for position, since no one “knew where they stood”.

Avery on 2011-12-07 at 00:03 said:

Hello, I'm sorry for posting my comment on your last article without reading the article itself. (It was a very weird thing to do, and I think I was in a mental pit devoid of all self-awareness.) I have now read both articles and I think the subject is fascinating.

I agree with Logres that this hierarchy is better than the status quo, but I think democracy is only part of the issue. Human beings respond to the metaphors our teachers fit us into. Economics analogizes human behavior to the physics of a machine. If our society is analogized to a machine by its smartest leaders, then we will act like we are trapped in a machine, and indeed many intellectuals seem to be ruled by this delusion. But if we are meant to be playing a role in a great Will, then we will engage ourselves to express that Will. In your model, flaws in our society come not from the rulers playing with the controls of the machine, but with everyone's personal lack of understanding of what the Will of their nation is and how they are meant to execute it.

Boreas on 2011-12-15 at 07:11 said:

Good and relevant text.

“Art for art's sake, for the sake of beauty, no longer exists.”

If this (for the sake of beauty) is behind “art for art's sake”, then I'm absolutely for it, but as I have understood, the (post-)moderners have twisted this concept to its opposite, when it has become to mean that art has become “a luxury item for idle parasites” together with being transformed into a meaning in itself in the form of ugly, pointless and abstract public scenery sculptures made of...junk and rubbish.

Matt on 2011-12-15 at 17:33 said:

The experience music project building looks like a collapsed lung combined with a mangled artery.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-15 at 18:14 said:

Does beauty alone need art or, indeed, does beauty exist outside its connection with the other attributes of God? you could call God beautiful, but could you call beauty God? You could argue that a portrait of a very beautiful woman, or a sunset, for example, were works of art that have the sole purpose of capturing beauty, but they are bound to fall short of the perfect originals and are, therefore, essentially acts of praise/worship. Beauty doesn't exist in a vacuum, for wherever you find beauty you will also find truth, power, wisdom, etc...

Cologero on 2011-12-15 at 20:09 said:

I really don't understand this comment, Charlotte, whether you're disputing or expanding on a point. There is no intent to "argue" anything, rather simply to describe. Beauty as one of the three highest ideas manifests on three planes corresponding to the tripartite constitution of man: spirit, soul, body. So it is not the case that "beauty needs art", but rather that it manifests as art on the formal level. Solovyov makes the point I believe you are trying to make, that art at the formal level, because it always has a specific and somewhat arbitrary subject matter, is not the fullest manifestation of beauty. That is reserved to mysticism.

We have been illustrating the relationship of the Absolute with the Infinite, which manifests in all the permutations of the world process. So, of course, Beauty does not exist in a vacuum, but it is helpful to analyze how the ideas do manifest in isolation. For all practical purposes that is how we typically experience the ideas ... in isolation. The scientist denies the mystical, the mystic knows nothing about economics, and so on. Wisdom is knowledge of the whole and we are here trying to gain such knowledge.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-16 at 04:09 said:

I wasn't doing either, just commenting, apologies if nothing interesting was added (or taken away!)

4.II The Temptation of the Absolute

I loved her, and sought her out from my youth, I desired to make her my spouse, and I was a lover of her beauty.

WISDOM 8:2

A process of mind is thinking only so far as it realizes the end of thinking, which is always to understand, that is, to see things within a system which renders them necessary.

BRAND BLANSHARD, *The Nature of Thought*

The evolution of knowledge is, as Plato long ago portrayed it, the emancipation of individual minds from their accidental limitations, and their education into the knowledge of the one real and intelligible world.

BERNARD BOSANQUET, *Logic*

Truth is free development of one's inner powers. The light is in us.

BENEDETTO CROCE, *Logic*

In *La Vita Nuova*, **Dante** tells the story about encountering Beatrice in a public. Not wishing to stare at her beauty in public, he directed his gaze to another woman who was in the same line of sight. That way onlookers would assume he was staring at the other woman even though he could see Beatrice out of the corner of his eye. The woman and the onlookers assumed Dante was interested in the other woman. Not ready to reveal his secret desire, Dante allowed that misconception to persist for several years.

In *Il Convivio* (*The Banquet*), Dante explained that this woman was Philosophy, which was the first dish at the banquet. Ultimately, however, it was Beatrice who led him to Heaven, and not Philosophy.

The Quest for the Absolute I, too, understand the attraction of that woman. I have always been interested in Philosophy, not Naturalism

which is her ugly step-sister, but the true Philosophy for which I'll use the umbrella term "Absolute Idealism". I've been more interested in Plotinus, Spinoza, Schopenhauer, Bradley, Gentile, Collingwood, Blanshard, and more recently, Timothy Sprigge, although there are certainly other options.

In my own case, I would include Indian philosophers like Aurobindo and Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan; the latter note the many points of contact between Eastern philosophy and Western Absolute Idealism.

Fundamentally for Absolute Idealism, thought is primary. The world is intelligible, and there is a drive to know, i.e., to become intelligent. Ultimately, the thinker attains to knowledge of the Absolute in which all antinomies are dissolved. The world, then, in all its manifestations is an appearance of the Absolute.

Emergent Evolution and Holism Two books appeared early last century: *Holism and Evolution* by Jan Smuts and *Emergent Evolution* by Lloyd Morgan. Although I doubt they are read much anymore, the two concepts they described are part of today's intellectual atmosphere. Put together, the claim is that evolution proceeds by simpler things organizing into larger wholes (holism), in which new properties emerge, which are inexplicable simply in terms of the constituent elements.

In one sense, these ideas are an advance because emergence is opposed to reductionism and holism to atomism. The atomic viewpoint cannot distinguish between a bunch of matches randomly thrown on a table and a matchbook sculpture¹⁷. The sculpture is explained as the result of natural processes and any design is a human superimposition.

However, the realist viewpoint of those two books is the opposite of idealism. They agree that the world consists of ever larger wholes, and that larger whole cannot be reduced to smaller ones. The evolutionary

¹⁷<https://www.bing.com/images/search?q=matchstick+sculpture&FORM=HDRSC2>

view presumes that there is an inner force of some sort that drives the lower elements to self-organize into the higher. Nevertheless, it cannot be intelligent — since it hadn't yet evolved — so the theory is unsatisfactory.

The alternative is that evolution occurs in thought. The intellectual drive is to see things in a larger whole. If the idea is logically coherent, the data of experience are understood at a more satisfactory level. For example, in human affairs, the actions of individuals are more adequately explained in terms of higher relations such as ethnicities, races, political and religious affiliations. To go a step further, time needs to be taken into consideration. Generational changes need to be understood.

On a personal level, the same applies. We note that we are inconsistent in our consciousness. Hence, we should try to develop a unified Self. The more that thinking can encompass, the closer we get to the knowledge of the Absolute.

Pansychism This is the idea that interiority is ubiquitous in the world. **Rene Guenon** wrote in the *Reign of Quantity*:

there can in fact be no 'inanimate' objects in existence, and also that 'life' is one of the conditions to which all corporeal existence without exception is subject; and that is why nobody has ever arrived at a satisfactory definition of the difference between the 'living' and the 'non-living', for that question, like so many others in modern philosophy and science, is only insoluble because there is no good reason for posing it, since the 'nonliving' has no place in the domain to which the question is related, and the only differences involved are really no more than mere differences of degree.

Obviously, from this perspective, there is no mystery about the origin of life. What science cannot explain is the inner experiences that accompanies life. For science, which deals with quantities, thunder is a sound

wave of certain frequencies and energies and lightning is a measurable electromagnetic event. The awareness of thunder and lightning is at best a useless epiphenomenon. Robots will be able to deal with thunder and lightning but will have no inner awareness of it.

A less jaded age would have experienced thunder and lightning as signs of higher intelligences. They believed that natural things like wind, fire, and even bodies of water are the physical manifestations of those higher intelligences.

The Absolute and God Croce made the point that Religion and Philosophy were concerned with the same goal: the Absolute. Hence, they are incompatible and once a man has achieved philosophical knowledge, he no longer has any further need of Religion.

Guenon can be misinterpreted that way also, given his claim that all validly Traditional religions, with their symbolism, creeds, and rites, share a common metaphysic. Nevertheless, religion itself cannot be abandoned, since it serves both as a support to metaphysics and a pathway to self-realization.

Many of the Idealists would agree with Croce. Once thought has attained the Absolute, it sees religion as simply an appearance of the Absolute. However, if you accept a version of panpsychism, then the Absolute is not simply an object of thought. It, too, must be conscious and have a Mind, i.e., it is also a subject.

Thinking, then, does not suffice. There must also be a path of realization. Specifically, beyond thinking, a change of being is also required. That leads us beyond philosophy proper.

The Russian theologian **Sergei Bulgakov** made the transition from Marxism through Idealism to Religion, so he understands what is at stake. In *Sophia: The Wisdom of God*, he explains:

Absolute being, self-existent and self-sufficing, while maintaining all its absolute character, yet establishes as it were alongside or

outside of itself a state or relative being, to which it stands as God. The Absolute is God, but God is not the Absolute insofar as the world relates to him.

* * *

james on 2018-02-16 at 04:51 said:

Thanks for another great post.

sindre on 2018-02-18 at 11:56 said:

Christians can learn a lot from other religions; but those of no particular religion cannot learn anything substantive about Christianity – or indeed anything else.

Instead, these 'spiritual seekers' or adherents of the 'perennial philosophy' merely become trapped in a self-congratulatory/ self-indulgent version of the mainstream modern lifestyle – with its trapping of the sexual revolution, political Leftism, and technological self-manipulation of emotions (via drink, drugs, 'body-art', social activism etc.).

The perennial philosophy is therefore an amusement, not a conviction; an open-ended life-option that seeks no end and attains no progression; an interest, not a faith; and complacency, not courage. It is simply an addictive kind of feebleness – a craving for a pain-free and engaging mortal life – with genuine escape/ enlightenment always just around the next corner... True seeking is based on the conviction that there is a right answer that leads to more right answers – it is serial finding, not serial seeking.

All answers – all true knowledge – are partial and biased (i.e. perspectival). Progress comes from the process of integrating and correcting these answers – and it never ends; because reality is creative, so there is always more to know.

Spiritual seekers expend their mortal lives in looking-for a form – asserting that all forms and motivations are one. This is lethal to real spirituality; since it discards the ens and essences of metaphysics and motivation – and instead focuses on the means and peripheries of emotions, lifestyle, and detached/ fragmentary utterances and writings.

(A monk who seeks detachment-from the world is equated with a shaman who seeks absorption-into the abstract divine and a priest who seeks a personal communion-with a personal god... on the basis that they all wear robes and spend time sitting with their eyes closed...)

That the perennial philosophy is nonsense is a matter of simple common sense and logic; which is why the idea is only ever held by intellectuals who have the cognitive capacity to confuse themselves with complexity.

The perennial philosophy is at least tolerated, and probably encouraged, by the demonic beings who pursue strategic evil in this world, because it permanently neutralises the basic

human quest for god, for true religion. Once enmeshed in endless syncretism and research – the spiritual seeker is trapped in a kaleidoscope of images and assertions, and cannot find a way out.

Of course, even sincere and genuinely motivated individuals will likely go through some kind of phase of comparison and learning about religions – but to defend this as a valid permanent option, to crystallise it as ‘the truth’ about the human condition, is fatal to faith, hope and charity – leading instead to this-worldly materialism, purposive hedonism and despair.

Evola's Magical Idealism

5.1 The Three Trials

To accept suffering in itself and for itself, to consent to it, to seek it, to love it, to make its identifying mark and the very object of disinterested and generous love, to put perfect action in sorrowful passion, to be active up to the point of death, to make of every act a death and of death itself the act par excellence, here is the triumph of the will that disconcerts again nature and that in fact engenders in man a new — and more than human — life.

MAURICE BLONDEL¹, *Action*

As a young man, Julius Evola embarked on an intense course of auto-didactic studies of German Idealism, French Personalism, and Oriental Metaphysics, particularly Taoism and Tantrism. Around the same time he discovered Rene Guenon and read what was available from him up until that point. The result was his philosophy of **Magical Idealism**, which

¹<http://www.iep.utm.edu/blondel/#H3>

is succinctly summarized in the *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*. The argument starts from the self-awareness as an acting person and is developed logically and thoroughly until its conclusion. However, one cannot be convinced by the argument on a strictly intellectual level, on which it is neither true nor false. Only by going through a process of self-transformation can one determine the validity or falseness of magical idealism. In his book, *Saggi sull'Idealismo Magico* ("Essays on Magical Idealism") EMI, published in 1925, Evola explains:

The truth or falsity of idealism—and that means if man can or can't give certainty and sense to his life and his experience—cannot be demonstrated theoretically: it can be decided not through an intellectual act, but through a concrete realization.

In EMI, Evola not only provides a logical development of magical idealism, but he also proposes a methodology whereby the reader can achieve such a concrete realization. There are two phases, the first being the state of purification or catharsis. The first stage requires some preparation which involves **three trials: fire, suffering and love**. The goal of this preparation is:

1. To confirm the absolute autonomy of the center of the I
2. To generate the principle of an entirely active acting

Trial by Fire The trial by fire begins with the experience of negation. The I habitually pulls its support from peripheral elements such as science, culture, attachments, faith, and so on. In this trial, he must destroy every such mental and emotional support. He must "deny every faith, violate every moral and social law, scorn every sentiment of humanity, every love and generosity, every passion, affirm an implacable and all-pervasive skepticism, reaching finally a conscious and critical madness."

The horror and disvalue that is instinctively felt by such precepts, proceeds only from an internal unconscious fear, that one is not sufficient in himself. Evola gets support for this view from the Tantric teaching of *bhutashuddhi*² or “purification from the elements” and in alchemy to the “liberation of the metals”.

Trial by Suffering The trial by suffering is the condition of remaining close to the denial of one’s own life, but insofar as the denial is not authored by the I, which is freed from the dependence of the object to deny. In the trial by fire, the individual made himself independent from those determinations in a relative way: he needs them to deny them, hence is dependent on them. In this trial, he is freed only by detaching from himself, eliminating the negative power: not willing it, not attributing it to himself, but rather simply undergoing it, accepting it as something foreign and transcending his own will.

From this perspective, we see the value in Stoicism and Christian resignation; this is how we understand why various saints invoke suffering as a divine grace.

Trial by Love This trial is no longer about the abstract denial of the self, but in that deeper denial of the self, that is the existence in oneself of a thing as object of unconditioned love. At this point it is not about destruction, but of constructing oneself at every moment, through a renewed act of love and renunciation, on a plane higher than oneself where there is the impossibility of the Watcher³ or, better, the Lord, outside any storm or tumult whatsoever, whether interior or exterior. It is not a question of the denial of passion, but rather an indifference that has no need

²<http://www.itimes.com/public/people/iti133802/blog/Dhyan-Yoga-by-Chakra-Meditation>

³http://www.kktanhp.com/vipassana_hm.htm

to exclude anything. This is the greatest non-resistance alluded to by Lao Tzu.

In the other trials, the I was autonomous as pure essence; in this trial, as pure act. There is an action that has its origins in the desire for something, not in itself, but only as it relates to the I. This reveals an insufficient centre. But to want something for itself, is to remove the I as object of volition, and thus to really have it.

Equally, violent and passionate action against things reveals they have a reality for the I, which is the opposite of absolute self-determination. Violating things is tantamount to violating only oneself. The fundamental principle of magic is:

To really want a thing, it is necessary to want it not for the I but for itself, that is, to love it.

Violence is the way of weakness and impotence; love and gentleness, the way of strength and mastery. This is the profound Taoist doctrine: not to desire to have in order to have, to give in order to possess, to cede in order to dominate, to sacrifice oneself in order to realize oneself. This is *wei-wu-wei*, or “acting without acting”.

From this we see the profound meaning and value of the greatest teachings on humility, submission, self-denial, detachment, surrendering one's own will to God. The elimination of every pride, a life permeated with humility and self-denial, the constant death of one's own will are tasks to which the individual is inadequate unless he manifests a power infinitely superior to that demand for any madness of negation and destruction. This is a hard trial that only constitutes the preliminary condition for the life of the ruler.

Commentary The preceding text on the three trials are taken from EMI; I don't always use quotes because the material may have been abridged or rearranged.

This text should convince everyone by now that we are not engaged in an abstract intellectual discussion, but rather in a personal, existential process of self-transformation. This should also show the Traditional sources of Evola's system: Tantra, Hermetism, Gnosticism, Catholicism, Stoicism, Taoism. These two points should no longer be an issue.

It is important to remember that these three trials constitute just the preliminary part of the first phase of purification; more will be forthcoming in future posts.

The Trial by Fire may sound harsh until one realizes that nothing real is being denied. Instead, the I is freeing itself from artificial thought constructions that he had previously considered to be real. This is consistent with Traditional practices. In Tomberg's system, it is part of the purification of consciousness described in Arcanum II.

The Trial by Suffering is the acceptance of whatever appears to be. The individual's attitude towards suffering must be no different from his attitude toward a rainy day; it is something exterior and of no concern. Besides the writings of the saints and Stoics that Evola mentions, there is also Nietzsche's concept of *amor fati*.

With the Trial by Love, Evola makes clear that he is not speaking of egoic desires. Desirelessness is the end result of this Trial. This involves a state of inner detachment; things are willed not to fulfill my needs (which would be a limitation) but rather for their own sake. Drawing on the Tao Te Ching, Evola compares this actionless action to Taoist ideas. He also likens it to Arcanum XI of the Tarot, "Strength", showing his familiarity with Hermetism. It is also constructive to compare Evola's depiction of the Ruler who rules without violence with what Tomberg writes about the Emperor in Meditations on the Tarot.

This trial is creative; while the Trial by Fire was eliminative. This Trial is active, willing things from Love. Evola points out that love, respect, devotion and so on are not ends in themselves but rather the means to a higher power.

Morality is a means, never an end: it is not of value in itself, but in as much as through it, the will can empower its own affirmation.

Posted on 2011-03-12 by Cologero

* * *

Albion on 2011-03-12 at 21:55 said:

Very clarifying, vis Evola. "To become God" is to imply that one is NOT God now, therefore, only to be taken literally (in becoming) as it is stated and meant. Thank you. The metaphor of the "rainy day" is a very good one.

Cologero on 2011-03-13 at 11:58 said:

Evola begins this chapter with this enigmatic quote from John 10:34

"Is it not written in your law: I said you are gods?"

So he is attempting to bring out the possible meaning for that.

Evola also claims that is is just incorporating elements from Yoga (Tantra/Patanjali), the various Western esoteric traditions (including Christian), and Theosophy (Blavatsky, Steiner). He claims to be purifying them (e.g., ignoring any claims of special paranormal powers as in Steiner), reducing them to their inner meaning, that is, to what can actually be experienced in consciousness. So it is by this standard that he is to be judged: has he, in fact, synthesized a method for spiritual development stripped of the particularities of their historical and cultural accretions? Or has he somehow distorted them?

In one of the early reviews of the book, a Theosophist (Jasink) points out that from Oriental conceptions, it makes sense, in understanding the I as Atman and Brahman. That is how Evola needs to be read, at least for anyone familiar with the terminology and teachings of the Vedanta. However, he goes on to say that it becomes "muddled or objectionable" was translated into Western languages. That is why Atman and Brahman are always left untranslated, a practice which really obscures their meaning. Jasink explains that in the West, I has the meaning of the empirical ego, and this I is certainly not the creator of everything, as there are multiple subjectivities in this sense.

It should be clear that Evola is not referring to this empirical Ego, nor is the Will the mere satisfaction of the desire of that Ego to dominate. Absolutely to the contrary, such an egoic life demonstrates a weakness, not power.

Albion on 2011-03-25 at 07:59 said:

Does Evola attempt to "order" these trials, or are they occurring "as they occur"?

Albion on 2011-03-25 at 08:09 said:

Cologero, do you think you could comment (at some point in time) on Christian Platonism and Plato in general? If where you are headed is true north (and I think it is) then situating it in relation to Plato would be helpful to the rest of us (I think), as it is a familiar landmark. Then again, I am having to rethink everything I thought I knew about Plato.

Cologero on 2011-03-25 at 12:29 said:

I assume by "as they occur" you mean "as the opportunity arises." But there are always opportunities.

Sample opportunities:

1) Do you question the sources of your thoughts and opinions. Do your ideas prevent you from hearing anything "new".

2) How do you react to negative people or events in life? Do you automatically react, or is there a "space" between the stimulus and response where free will can act.

3) How do weakness and concupiscence affect your life? Are you frustrated when the satisfaction of desires is delayed? Do fears inhibit your acts?

There are plenty of opportunities in the course of the day. These are areas that I think are best explored in the private area of the forums.

Cologero on 2011-03-25 at 12:39 said:

The place to debate specific points about Plato or some other specific writer is in the forums.

However, I am planning to bring in more about the cubist painter Albert Gleizes, who was quite familiar with Guenon and employed Traditional themes in his work. Interestingly, he considered Plotinus, Augustine and Boethius (all Platonists) as the intellectual fathers of the Medieval era.

Evola considered Plotinus (along with Patanjali) as secure guides to the inner exploration of the Spirit, what he termed "metaphysical positivism". These are connections that need to be explored.

Albion on 2011-03-27 at 01:28 said:

Thank you, that is exactly what I was asking. I will see you in the Forum.

Paulo on 2014-08-23 at 22:31 said:

"Violence is the way of weakness and impotence; love and gentleness, the way of strength and mastery. This is the profound Taoist doctrine: not to desire to have in order to have, to give in order to possess, to cede in order to dominate, to sacrifice oneself in order to realize oneself. This is wei-wu-wei, or "acting without acting".

"Morality is a means, never an end: it is not of value in itself, but in as much as through it, the will can empower its own affirmation."

The fear of pain, has to be understood, if the will is strong, love gonna appear as a answer to pain and fear!

aegishjalmer on 2014-10-09 at 13:07 said:

The lust of the eyes, the lust of the flesh, and the pride of life

Frater M on 2017-03-13 at 22:27 said:

If things are not willed for my own "needs", once resolved via detachment, but still willed "for their own sake", one might then ask, why will them at all then?

What is this other "own sake" that obligates further willing whatsoever? Is it not still, all things considered, another limitation, another willing?

Only Bodhisattvic logic works here.

Noct on 2022-04-17 at 01:30 said:

I do not think that wanting things for themselves implies a heteronomy or something that "obligate", rather the opposite: it is not an imposition, but a free act of the will. Remaining in the fullness of the Self, one experiences a kind of "superabundance of being" and desires in a positive sense, not as something that is suffered, but as a creative activity, the highest good of all beings.

Is this not the teaching of the Lord when he says that we are to love our neighbor as ourselves?

Cologero on 2022-04-17 at 09:01 said:

Noct, I do not think that we are reading the same text, since you draw the opposite conclusion. "It is about constructing oneself at every moment, through a renewed act of love and renunciation, on a plane higher than oneself." That sounds creative to me.

You can love your neighbor as yourself, but do you do so to show what a great guy you are (i.e., to enhance the "I"), or because you actually love the neighbor.

5.2 Contemporary Requirements for Magical Idealism

Evola invests the dark matter of esoterism with a dialectic and discursive reflexion.

From Franco Volpi's introduction to *Magical Idealism*

TRANSLATION of Chapter 6 of *Essays on Magical Idealism* (*Saggi sull'idealismo magico*) by **Julius Evola**.

In this early book, the young Evola sketched out his philosophical position which he named "Magical Idealism" (presumably inspired by **Novalis**). Although this predates his interest in Tradition aroused in him by Rene Guenon, he never repudiated his philosophy, but rather tried to integrate it with his understanding of Tradition.

It is easy to forget in our time how influential philosophical idealism was in the 1920s. It was still dominant in Germany after more than a century of development. England had Green, Bradley, Bosanquet, and Collingwood. France, too, had its own stream which reached its peak in the spiritualism of Lavelle and Lesenne (both indirectly influenced by Octave Hamelin.) And of course, Italian philosophy was dominated by the idealists Benedetto Croce and Giovanni Gentile. Evola sought to insinuate himself in that current of thought. Actually, as this introduction shows, he regarded his own system as the culmination and fulfillment of what went before.

Evola includes brief summaries of five thinkers who most influenced magical idealism. These are **Carlo Michelstaedter**, **Otto Braun**, **Giovanni Gentile**, **Octave Hamelin**, and **Herman Keyserling**. Of these, I will be offering translations of the first, third, and the fifth, since I am familiar with them and have read their works. I know nothing of Braun and Hamelin, both

very obscure today, so I doubt I will bother to translate those sections.

A requirement raised many times in these pages is to show how the conception of magical idealism carries on by way of logical continuity and integrates the most advanced positions that modern Western speculative thinking has achieved. We now want to give a specific, direct satisfaction to one such requirement by considering a group of thinkers among the most significant in contemporary culture, emphasizing the deep theme that informs their conceptions and finally showing how, when such a theme is given free reign in the interior of their own systems — and without violating any of their existing parts, but rather bringing them to a great organic perfection — we reach those assertions that were sketched out in the preceding chapters.

However, it is first necessary to understand well the meaning of this *historical conclusion* of magical idealism. It is that if we conceive history as existing in itself, as therefore imposing the bad misfortune of a group of *given* elements from which, in one way or another, the current moment would come to be conditioned, a demonstration of the historical necessity of magical idealism in truth could have value only as a true rebuttal of magical idealism itself, since the fundamental principle of this doctrine is absolute, unconditioned self-determination. What cannot therefore happen if something stands against the I, which is simply given to it, something that is there without the participation of its will. Things proceed however quite differently when one holds firm to the principle of the ideality of time and, with it, of history. If time is not a thing in itself, but rather—as Kant taught—a category, if it is simply a mode by which the I orders the matter of representation which therefore, in itself, is neither temporal nor intemporal, it does not exist as a before nor as an after—then the spectre of an inevitable determination from part of the past vanishes into nothing. Since in such a case it instead remains true that, insofar as the past exists only inside the act—which in itself,

in this regard, is to be understood as metatemporal—by which I make my various affirmations appear temporally, the past does not condition or determine the present, but the present conditions or determines the past.

The past remains simply a mark with which I identify a part of my current experience, since a past *in itself*, i.e., a past that falls outside my real experience, which is not an object, isgnoseologically an absurdity and non-being. From that, it follows that history is nothing other than a mode according to which the I projects onto the canvas of time, I would say almost as in a mythical figuration, that it is to will interiorly and intemporally. As creator of history in the current historical moment, the individual experiences in this way only the limit-point of his own affirmation. The theory of the ideality of time therefore makes history a plastic faculty and in itself is indifferent to freedom—no longer a tyrannical fact that does violence to the individual, but rather a docile creation that the individual dominates, reflects and confirms unfailingly *a posteriori* what it *a priori* and metahistorically affirms. Thus, properly, it should be said that history is nothing other than the very power of freedom in reflecting and demonstrating *a posteriori*, alongside the category of time, its determination having happened *a priori* in an intemporal and metahistorical point. The “historical conclusion” is always something that comes after, an *epiginomenon*, and its necessity is only the phenomenon of freedom that determines it unconditionally.

That granted, we can show the historical necessity of magical idealism without that assumption implying a contradiction. It rises like the synthesis of a dialecticism, in which the thesis is the rationalism of romantic philosophy which, exhausting itself in a conceptual world abstracted from reality and from individuality, generated the antithesis of materialism and positivism. 1 For the consummation of the thesis in the antithesis, the empty ideality had to be refilled with a concrete content whence, in the terms of the Hegelian Left (Stirner, Nietzsche), the mentioned

emergence in the affirmation of the real individual in the value of the unconditioned. This principle of synthesis was developed, then it led to the concept of an individual affirmation such that in the same plane of the real world presented antithetically by positive science and established that sufficiency in that mediation, of which in the abstract world of the rational only the image without life was known. As the rationalistic thesis culminated in an idealization of the real, so a realization of the ideal was postulated of the synthesis of magical idealism (which is then the true derealization of the real), that is, a power of the individual so real, that he was the being and determination of nature studied from the antithetical moment of science. 1 The surpassing of the Hegelian Logos, so that this acquires its concreteness, is not that of nature, internal to the pure logical sphere of the Encyclopedia of Philosophic Sciences, but rather that of the entire Hegelianism, through the Hegelian left, in the sciences of nature, with the organs proper to which and falling outside the pure conceptual apriorism and took specific knowledge of concrete reality.

Posted on 2014-05-23 by Cologero

5.3 Conviction and Rhetoric

That henceforth we be no more children tossed to and fro, and carried about with every wind of doctrine by the wickedness of men, by cunning craftiness, by which they lie in wait to deceive.

EPHESIANS 4:14

Rather than cluttering up the section on **Carlo Michelstaedter**⁴ from *Essays on Magical Idealism* with a commentary, let this serve as an introduction. Yet nothing, or almost nothing, is posted on Gornahoor

⁴SeeSection\ref{sec:Michelstaedter}inthisbook.

without a reason, without being part of a larger undertaking, without being related to what has been written before.

In his philosophical writings, we see that **Julius Evola** had developed a complex world view before he was 30. Since the majority of readers here are men under 30, take this as a challenge to do the same. Create a redoubt in the mind. It will protect you from the winds of doctrine. Even if, for a time, it must be placed aside, it will return to you when you need it.

The bulk of men, even those who consider themselves educated and intellectual, are content to wander through the orchard of ideas, picking off the lowest and prettiest fruits, accumulating them in a basket. The wiser, however, will go for the higher and harder-to-get fruit, while the wisest of all, will go to the trunk and look for the source in the roots.

Thus, Julius Evola announces his plan and his indebtedness to certain predecessors. He sees himself as their fulfillment, drawing out unexpected conclusions, and amplifying certain points. Sometimes, a misreading is necessary to move the argument forward. The first figure Evola points to is **Carlo Michelstaedter**, specifically to his book *Persuasion and Rhetoric*. By now, his story should be known. He finished his dissertation and then immediately shot himself dead at the age of 23. Presumably, there was a psychological problem and his philosophy does not entail such a radical end to life.

In a few dialogs, Plato distinguished “rhetoric and persuasion” from “wisdom and reason”. The city, as it is, is governed by rhetoric and persuasion. In other words, rhetorical techniques, primarily emotionally based, are used to persuade men to a belief on a course of action. Plato claimed instead that the Republic should be guided by wisdom and reason. Now this should be common knowledge among all educated men today, but it certainly is not. Even worse, in our time, there are no wise men, and reason cannot persuade anyone, since few are capable of reason.

So even the most intelligent use their gifts as rhetoric. They are con-

tent to display the fruit they gathered, perhaps creating a sweet tasting concoction out of it. Even in our world of Tradition, rhetoric dominates. That is why we see long quotes from Evola or Nietzsche posted everywhere. Or youtube videos consisting of nothing but quotes, gathered in a heap, with some sort of martial sounding music in the background. In other words, a rhetorical appeal to emotion.

Instead, we must dig into the roots of thought, to read carefully and completely. A good writer will leave nothing in by accident, as he expects to be understood. Men should avail themselves of the opportunities offered them, since they are not offered very often. But the state of nature is sleep, and sleeping men can gather and eat fruit.

Absolute Self Michelstaedter, in his misreading, contrasts rhetoric and persuasion. Rhetoric is inauthentic, it means to be immersed in the world of things, in becoming, in giving up oneself to others. Persuasion, on the other hand, is to be in full possession of oneself, to not depend on others, to not be driven by deficiency or lack.

But rhetoric is also speech. So if persuasion is its opposite, then it is mute and dumb. It can only be and cannot express itself. It is absolute and one with all things. This will come out in Evola's commentary. In Italian, it seems to me, persuasion is a stronger word than in English. It can also mean conviction. So I would call the persuaded man, the "convinced man", but to do so would introduce an inconsistency.

Of course, the Absolute I or Self is Evola's cardinal point, so Michelstaedter serves as a support for that idea. Also for Jung, whom Evola ignores, the Self must be created since it is not part of nature. Jung also recognizes that Christ serves as the idea of the Self, although that is largely forgotten. The Logos comes in our second birth, not given to all, since it is not part of our natural birth, which is given to all.

Potentiality Another common rhetorical device is the claim that we all have “infinite potential” or something similar. This makes people exult in their own unfulfilled promise; to deny that idea is considered heresy. Yet what distinguishes men is not their potentiality but their actuality. The measure of power is what they can bring into manifestation. Of course, we must emphasize that the proper measure is the difficulty of the thing, since most things are rather easy to manifest.

In Michelstaedter’s philosophy, mere potentiality is simply non-being, a lack, a deficiency. As such it belongs to rhetoric. Sure, we can talk about it, since that makes us feel so good, but it is still far from persuasion.

The Bodhisattva and the Jivan Mukti This is still the difference between a Guenon and an Evola. The former aims to be a Jivan Mukti, to transcend the world, into the Absolute. Apparently, a jivan mukti is indistinguishable from a dead man⁵.

The latter aims for the Absolute Self, to be self-sufficient. Like a bodhisattva, the enlightened one does not disappear, but returns to show others the way.

Posted on 2014-05-30 by Cologero

* * *

Synodius on 2014-06-05 at 15:58 said:

I don’t quite understand that distinction between Guenon and Evola.

In his essay *Ascending and Descending* Realization Guenon writes:

“... the difference in question is finally that which exists between the Pratyeka-Buddha and the Bodhisattva. In this regard, it is particularly important to note that the way which has the first of these two states as its end is designated as a ‘small way’ or, if one wishes, a ‘lesser way’(hinayana), thus implying that it is not exempt from a certain restrictive character, whereas

⁵<http://www.telegraph.co.uk/news/worldnews/asia/india/10860998/Indian-court-asked-to-rule-on-whether-Hindu-guru-dead-or-meditating.html>

the one leading to the second state is considered to be truly the 'greater way', and therefore the one that is complete and perfect in all respects. This allows us to answer the objection which could arise from the fact that in a general way the state of Buddha is regarded as superior to that of Bodhisattva. In the case of the Pratyeka-Buddha, that superiority can only be apparent, and it is due above all to the character of 'impassiveness' which, apparently, the Bodhisattva does not have; we say 'apparently' because it is necessary to differentiate between the 'reality' of the being and the role it has to play with respect to the manifested world, or in other words, between what it is in itself and what it appears to be for ordinary beings."

Is there any essential difference between Guenon and Evola on this question?

Cologero on 2014-06-06 at 07:03 said:

Although Evola has indicated where he thinks Guenon had gone wrong, I am relying more on impressions.

Guenon distinguishes between what he labels "salvation" and "liberation". The former is the fulfillment of the human condition while the latter is the fulfillment of all possible conditions.

These states are perhaps clearer in some other authors in our pantheon. E.g., Tomberg represents these two states in the *Emperor*⁶ and the Pope. The Emperor is the ideal human being and has authority (we cannot here refer to other traditions such as the Sufi man of light, etc).

In our *Monday study group*⁷, we again see Mouravieff make the distinction between two higher states of consciousness: (1) Consciousness of the Real I and (2) Absolute consciousness.

I don't see Evola making that distinction and it seems to me that he even confuses them. Yet, he is excellent in describing the consciousness of the Real I. That is why we have made use of his writings so often, since that is probably the most that can be described over the Internet.

But this leads to two limitations, although Evola does not see them as such. On the contrary, he has criticized Guenon for not recognizing them.

The first is his insistence on "action" as a path on a par with "contemplation". That is true as far as reaching the first higher state, but not for the second.

The second is his insistence that ultimate authority resides in the Emperor, not in a separate spiritual or religious authority. Again, that is true on the human plane, but not for the divine plane. We have been dealing with the Emperor on the *Medtarot Discussion List*⁸ and will be discussing the role of the spiritual authority over the next several weeks.

The second stage of higher consciousness requires a spiritual/religious orientation, which Evola eschews, and even rejects.

⁶<http://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/alchemical-transformation>

⁷<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=7205>

⁸<http://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/medtarot-discussion-list>

Synodius on 2014-06-06 at 10:47 said:

Thank you for your clarification, I'll do some cross-reading with this in mind.

5.4 Carlo Michelstaedter

The is the part, in which **Julius Evola** details his debt to **Carlo Michelstaedter**. “Conviction”, for Michelstaedter, is being and “rhetoric” is non-being, or becoming. Hence, he is attempting to describe the man who is convinced, i.e., the man who has being, who “is”.

Opposed to him, is the man who is always lacking something. He looks to other people, conditions, or things, to fulfill himself. He imagines the future will somehow satisfy him, so he never lives in the present. You have known such types: they are always agitated, forever seeking novelty or excitement. They hide their sense of lack with rhetoric, creating entire worlds out of talk *gerede* which they then inhabit. There is always an injustice, something to change, a new program to adopt, the politics of resentment, a glorious future that kills every current moment. This masks them from facing being in its totality. They don’t even think with their heads, but with their tongues, as Carl Jung says.

Interestingly enough, the convinced man gives himself a mission of cosmic proportions, viz., to redeem the world.

There is a man in whom the demand of the real individual toward absolute value, toward *conviction*, has been confirmed in the modern epoch, like a lightning flash and in a reality intense with life; this man, who in the clearest way, by shattering all compromises by which the I, inadequate in itself, masks its *abios bios* “not living life”, Ariphon the Sicyonian, has been able to take life to its goal, compelling it to that which man has *terror* of, more than any other thing in the world: to place oneself in the presence of oneself, to recognize oneself, to measure oneself at last with

that scale which, alone, is the scale of *value*, of *being*—that man is **Carlo Michelstaedter**.

Previously, we alluded to some positions that however are forcefully asserted in Michelstaedter, and almost a tragedy, so as to see that his work to a great extent transcends the framework of an abstract discursive exposition. The fundamental point on which such a work is centered is the need for “conviction”, i.e., of the I’s absolute sufficiency in itself, understood as the *real* principle of the individual. Now the concept of conviction is essentially characterized by Michelstaedter as the *opposite of relationships*: that is, the I is not in itself, but in “another”, it puts aside the principle of its own being, where its life is conditioned by things and relations, and there is not conviction, but rather lack, the death of value. Value is only what exists for itself, it does not ask from anyone the principle of its own life and its own power—autarchy. So not only the whole of life consisting of needs, feelings, social conventions, intellectual embellishments, etc., but even the corporeal organism itself and the system of nature (that is, understood as generated, in its infinitely recurrent spatial-temporal development, from the interminable gravitation with which lack pursues being that, however, insofar as it seeks it outside itself, will never succeed in possessing it), is brought back into the sphere of non-value.

The I that is convinced that it is as *continuous* as it keeps itself outside the fullness of actual possession and pushes its conviction onto a later moment, by which it is made dependent; the I flees from itself in every moment, it does not have itself but seeks itself and *desires* itself, and yet it will never be able to have that in any future, since the future is the very symbol of its privation, the shadow that follows the man who flees from the body of his reality that is maintained at every unchanged point. This is the meaning of everyday life for Michelstaedter except, in one thing, non-value, that which must not be. As opposed to such a situation, this is the voice of conviction: to endure, to resist lack with all one’s life at

every point, not to give up on life—which is lacking in itself, by looking outside or in the future—not to demand, but to hold *being* in one's own fist: *not to become, but to endure*.

While lack, “always anxious about the future, hastens time, and replaces one empty present with the next, the stability of the individual occupies infinite time in the present and stops time. Its firmness is a vertiginous path for all others who are in the current. Its every moment is a century in the life of others—as long as he sets himself on fire and succeeds in enduring into the utmost present”.

To identify such a point, it is rather important to understand the nature of the connection that is contained in the premises: since the world is understood to be produced from the direction of lack, whose concrete incarnation it almost is, (and in that, the idealistic demand remains satisfied, in fact, it is reinforced in significance, because the genesis of the real, as in Buddhism, is connected to a moment of value, to a direction of will) it is an illusion to think that the point of conviction can be realized through an abstract inner and subjective endurance in a value that, as in the Stoic, would have as opposed to being (nature) such that it is, while not having value.

Those who ask for conviction must instead rise to a world responsibility, the work of conviction is essentially cosmic. I must not flee my lack — or the world — but take it on myself, adapt myself to its load and redeem it. Michelstaedter in fact says: “You cannot be called convinced as long as something still is, which is not conviction” and points to conviction as the “extreme consciousness of someone who is one with things, has in himself all things: *en sunexes* tr. continuous”. The concrete point of conviction would therefore have the sense of a cosmic consummation.

In order to illuminate Michelstaedter's central problem, it may be useful to connect the concept of insufficiency or lack to the Aristotelian

concept of the imperfect act. The imperfect or impure act is that of powers that do not achieve actuality from themselves, but require the involvement of the other. An example is the act of sensible perception; in it the power of perceiving is not sufficient in itself, it does not produce perception from itself, but needs correlation to the object. Now the fundamental point, which is linked to Michelstaedter's position, is this: the imperfect act resolves the privation of the I only apparently, since it in reality reconfirms it.

For example, the I is thirsty: as long as it drinks, it will continue to be thirsty, since by drinking he will prove the point of anyone who is not sufficient to his own life, but who needs the "other" in order to live, who *is* not but *becomes*: water and the rest are only the symbols of his deficiency (it is necessary to pay attention to this: *one does not desire because there is a privation of being, but there is a privation of being because one desires* and, in the second place: *there is only a desire*, e.g. thirst, *because there are certain things*, e.g. water, *but the things desired, just like the privation of the being that drives toward it, are created at birth by the desire for a relative, which therefore is the prius that creates the correlation as its two terms*, viz., privation and the related object, thirst and water), and since one feeds on it and *demand*s life from it, the I feeds itself only from its own privation and remains in it, fleeing from that pure or perfect act, from that eternal water, of which Christ speaks (John 4:14-15), so that every thirst, just as every other privation, will be forever defeated. This craving, this obscure drive that brings the I toward the outer world — toward the other — is that which generates the system of finite and contingent reality. Conviction, which burns at the point of absolute endurance, therefore, such a drive of the pure being-in-itself also has the sense of a consummation of the world.

Now it must be understood in the sense of such a consummation. Here various consequences arise that Michelstaedter did not completely treat. First of all, to say that I must not flee my lack means, among other

things, to say that I must recognize myself as the creative function of the world: the justification of idealism follows from it (i.e., the system that says the world is posited by the I) according to a moral imperative. But the world, according to the premise, is recognized as the denial of value. From the general imperative of redeeming the world, of accepting the person of lack, then proceeds, always as the moral postulate, that is, not as theoretical construct, but rather as the object of a morally imperative affirmation — of a practice. A second point is that the same denial of value *must* be recognized in a certain way as a value. This point is important. If in fact I mean the desire that has generated the world as a brute given, as an irrational absolute, it is evident that conviction, conceived as its denial, *depends* on it, therefore it is not in itself unconditionally sufficient but rather owes its life to another, that lets affirm itself in denying itself. In such a case, i.e., in the case that the same craving must not be taken back to an order included in the affirmation of value but remains absolutely a given, conviction would therefore not be at all conviction — the initial mystery would inexorably damn its perfection into an illusion.

Therefore, as a moral postulate it is necessary to admit that the same antithesis participates in a certain way in value. But in what way? Such a question brings to life the concept of conviction into a dynamic principle. It is clear in fact that if conviction sharpens itself to a pure, unrelated sufficiency — i.e., to a state — rather than to sufficiency as denial of an insufficiency — i.e. to an *act*, to a *relation* — the antithesis certainly has a value and is explained: in a first moment, the I *must* posit privation, a non-value, even if under the condition that it is posited solely because it must be denied, since this act of negation, and this alone, makes the value of conviction come to light.

Besides, what does it mean to deny the antithesis — which here is the same as saying nature? If you recall that for Michelstaedter nature is a nonvalue as a symbol, the incarnation of the flight of the I from actual possession of itself, since it is correlative to an imperfect or impure act. It

is not therefore a question of annulling this or that determination, since by doing that, one would only hit the effect, not the transcendental root of the non-value; not even annulling in general every action, since the antithesis is not action qua action in general, but rather action insofar as it flees from itself, insofar as “becoming”, and it is not that every action is necessarily such. Rather, what is necessary to resolve is the passive, heteronomous, extraverted mode of action. Now the negation of such a mode is constituted by sufficient action, or actions on the basis of power, which was previously explained. To live every act on the basis of perfect possession is therefore to transfigure the whole of universal determination to the point of expressing only the same body of infinite *potestas*, of the absolute Individual made of power, such is therefore the meaning of cosmic consummation. As the concreteness of “rhetoric” is the development of the world of dependency and necessity, so the concreteness of persuasion is the development of the world of autarchy as the cosmic dominator, and the point of the austere denial is only the neutral point (*laya*, “dissolution, extinction”) between the two phases.

The development of Michelstaedter’s views in magical idealism thus results pursuant to logical continuity. On the other hand, Michelstaedter remained in a certain way closed to indeterminate negation and this, in great part, in order not to be fixed sufficiently on that, which, finite and infinite, is not an object or a particular action, but rather a particular way of living whatever object or action. The true Master does not, in general, need to deny (in the sense of annulling) and, with the pretense of rendering it absolute, to exalt life into an immobile undifferentiated unity or sudden inspiration: the creative act, the act of power — that is not an act of desire or violence, but an act of a gift — rather than destroying perfect possession, it witnesses to it and reconfirms it. It is that Michelstaedter, captivated in the immediacy of the terrible intensity in which he experienced the exigency of absolute value, unable to give this a concrete form and therefore to deploy it in the doctrine of power: we can perhaps

attribute the tragic end of his mortal existence to that.

Posted on 2014-06-13 by Cologero

* * *

Logres on 2015-04-18 at 21:21 said:

"Rather, what is necessary to resolve is the passive, heteronomous, extraverted mode of action."

This sounds a lot like "making every task play" or making "all yokes easy".

"The true Master does not, in general, need to deny (in the sense of annulling) and, with the pretense of rendering it absolute, to exalt life into an immobile undifferentiated unity or sudden inspiration: the creative act, the act of power –that is not an act of desire or violence, but an act of a gift—rather than destroying perfect possession, it witnesses to it and reconfirms it."

The first sentence here, "to exalt life" perfectly describes the Romantic movement in poetry (not to deny them their insights), at least historically, as well as my own early tendency in life. This is perhaps the finest sentence I've read so far in Evola.

Logres on 2015-04-18 at 21:26 said:

So much of modern life seems to revolve around a confused and inchoate grasp of "the cloud and the tree are One, to the eye of the child". They are, but not as dissolved in a mush to be possessed and gobbled as part of the mass, but as the energies of the same All Creative God, which (I learn, thanks to Exile and Cologero) even have different qualities (creating, sustaining, glorifying). One, but never the same. Never the same, truly Infinite, always One. Logos.

5.5 Giovanni Gentile

This is **Julius Evola**'s commentary on **Giovanni Gentile** in *Saggi sull'Idealismo Magico (Essays in Magical Idealism)*. It has been difficult to translate, not just because of the difficulty of the subject matter, but more because there is no corresponding philosophical tradition in English from which to draw the requisite vocabulary and concepts.

As per his proclaimed method, Evola will point out an unexamined, and unresolved, problem in Gentile's system of **Actualism** that can only then be resolved in his own system of **Magical Idealism**. According to him, as long as Gentile remains on the philosophical, rational, abstract level, Actualism will never reach its goal. What is therefore required, as its completion, is a method of self-realization that transcends that level. This is, as Evola points out, the "entire difference" between the two systems.

Our goal, in going through all this trouble, is the meagre hope that some young philosophy student will become interested in this and be willing to dedicate his career to moving such a line of thinking forward. If you are that one, please contact me in any way for some suggestions.

Now I understand there is a bit of excitement in some small circles among those who seem to have discovered "neo-reaction" a couple of years ago. Their writings have been described in various superlatives. But, in reading what follows, can any of them be said to have the ability to "play the game" at such a high level? The question is obviously rhetorical. They often make use of Evola's political analysis, as though it arose fully formed from under a cabbage leaf. Rather, it is secondary and is the fruit of much deeper thinking.

That is the challenge, then, to neo-reaction, identical to Evola's challenge to Gentile. As long as it remains on the plane of the rational, it will do no more than engender a torrent of abstractions. It will splinter into various sub-genres and devolve into a battle of personalities. What is required is a method of self-realization, a spiritual perspective, a religion. In other words, more than a Philosopher, we are awaiting a Prophet.

Contemporary idealism can be defined like this: a deep need for absolute self-realization, which, however, the I does not acquire immediately in its

interiority, but rather that it simply knows, assimilating it from outside itself in the phenomena that it causes in the rational order in the abstract. In Giovanni Gentile, this situation appears in a particularly clear way: for him, the effort of embracing and dominating the whole of the world in an immanent principle reaches its perfection; but, on the other hand, this principle remains a simple ideal entity, it is the previously criticized “transcendental I” and expresses only a dull reflex of that deep individual power that was experienced, for example, in Michelstaedter. If Gentile could really call the I the “pure act” of his rationalism, then he would appear not as the university professor, whose “actualism” has the reform of the educational system as its goal, but rather as that cosmic centrality that esoterism shows, for example, in the types of the rishi, the yogi, Christ, and the Buddha. This is the entire difference between “actual idealism” and magical idealism. Now since the pure rational-in-itself can never have its own justification, it can be shown how Gentile’s system is based on an irrational fact, which, however, as such, contradicts his principle: from that a crisis arises, for which no solution can be given, if one does not pass from the first idealism to the second.

Gentile’s fundamental principle is derived from Hegel and is expressed in the claim that pure immediacy, pure being is gnoseologically absurd, that the condition of every being is an act that posits it for the I. The priority of the category of the act over any content whatsoever of experience follows from that. Such an act is naturally that of the gnoseological subject, of the impersonal thinking I. Now thinking implies something thought. Regarding the concept of the thought, Gentile falls into a compromise: he distinguishes a “logic of thought” with its own laws (relative to “nature”) from the “dialectic of thinking”, i.e., from the concrete and actual process of thinking and knowing. If nothing is, unless mediated, the “thought” is nothing outside a logic of the thought that mediates it, which in its turn is inconceivable outside the concrete process of thinking, that is, from the actuality of thinking itself. So there is no way to

truly distinguish a logic of the thought (or “abstract logic”), supported by its own laws, from the process of thinking (or “concrete logic”): these laws can appear only as some particular formations of the concreteness of this.

It is hardly worth pointing out that abstract logic is only the comprehension or abstract thinking of concrete logic, since here it would represent the difficulty in the question of knowing how such abstract thinking is possible since it, not thought, evaporates in the nothing; thought stops being abstract, and becomes a type of category of concrete logic itself. The concept of “thought” and of “fact” thus ends up affected by the same contradiction of the Kantian noumenon and is resolved in the concept of determination in general of thinking.

Thus we end up in this situation: on the one hand, thinking or “pure act” remains the only category, capable of reclaiming every phenomena into itself; on the other hand, it is necessary to try to deduce from it a principle of determination, so that it effectively takes into account the multiplicity and diversity of the phenomena themselves, that it goes on to absorb. Gentile then considers the “dialectic of concrete logic” for such a goal. To think, he says, inasmuch as it is self-positing, is to discern itself, i.e., to abolish the abstract, precise identity of the I in an object or non-I, (i.e., to determine itself) and, in then recognizing itself in this determination or object, mediates itself, to be like the I, like self-knowledge. But the recognition restoring immediate, precise identity, results in its process hurling toward the infinite.

The internal self-separation relative to autosynthesis, to the self-positing of the I as such, would therefore explain the genesis of determination: but the bad thing is that it does not explain itself. Gentile does not in fact give any foundation to that, because the I, in general, separates from itself “another”, and then also because it is not exactly reflected in this “other”, as, for example, in the divine trinity of Athanasius. In other words, there is in Gentile a simple, exposition of becoming, not a transcendental de-

duction, its meaning does not become obvious in any way; it remains a being of fact, not a being of law and the necessity that is connected to it apodictically can then only derive from an empirical suggestion. That is, it shows that from the Logic there is a problem of value, which, however, is absolutely neglected by Gentile.

Since the concept of the Aristotelian God that is used in the eternal identity of his act and that of the unmanifested Shakti of Tantra do not offer any inconceivability a priori, the question must be asked why the spirit must become (or is becoming). If one responds that a spirit that would not be objectified and therefore is not becoming, would not be self-consciousness, spirit, but rather nature, one retorts that since when was such a reaction something more than question begging; in reality nature would instead be spirit that, as such, being eternally constrained to self-objectification and becoming, would not be dissimilar in any way from the plant that, as such, can only vegetate.

Now every "nature" presupposes, in its essential definiteness, a law, so that it is that determined nature and not another, but every law is a legislator that, as such, cannot itself be subject to a law. For Gentile, stuck on the plane of abstract speculation, the character of the legislator cannot have any meaning: believing that the problems are resolved through simply transporting them from the "metaphysics of being" to that of "knowing", believing that a certain determination of experience should turn out more comprehensible when the place of substance is called "thought", he then restores becoming as the unavoidable nature of thinking, not realizing that a thousand questionable points then arise in order to substitute for them a thousand more. Does he notice that the objection presupposes the abstract point of view which, making the act an object, precludes the way of understanding it? Then one will reply that such an instance, rather dear to Gentile, has no value, because he gratuitously claims what he assumes as explanatory principle what is made by his opponents the matter of the problem. In the second place, that

in the inebriated coalescence of the I to its act the problems are not only not resolved, does not even reach up to them, and that by basking in the obscurity he deceived himself that he has dispelled it.

Since “actual consciousness” is understood as the form that collects every phenomenon, the adherence to it absolutely means, as we say, to adhere to the same world, letting oneself live from it and therefore to end up in a type of passive mysticism that then, in the concrete, is identified with an absolute, perplexed phenomenalism. On the other hand, according to his own principles, Gentile could well assume the noted objectification exactly because “abstract” (and an objection, insofar as it is not identified with his doctrine, for the actualist will always, *a priori*, be “abstract”) for, on the other hand, taken as the antithesis, it creates itself “concretely” in a new synthesis. But this is precisely the critical point: when the actualist really does that, he would be constrained to transcend the plane of the rational and to affirm the principle of the arbitrary.

In this section, **Julius Evola** deals with the nature of thought itself. Thought cannot be the object of thinking, since it would then be just another thought. Rather, there must be something that transcends thinking, the “non-rational”. Nevertheless, the non-rational is not the same as the irrational. Certain philosophers, Schopenhauer in particular, who consider the Will as irrational fall short. They experience themselves as the playthings of irrational forces. Instead, the Philosopher who has is in full self-possession experiences himself as the author, or at least master, of these forces.

That can be clarified as follows. For whoever possesses himself in the naked creative center of the I, it appears as the action of unconditioned freedom. Instead, it is experienced as logical necessity by whoever keeps himself on the peripheral plane of the discursive, as the inescapable im-

perative of a *Sollen*⁹, as the *vis a tergo*¹⁰ of duty and law. The arbitrary affirmation, insofar as experienced so to say from the outside, passively, appears as truth or logical cogency, as apodictic. Gentile understood the formula $I = \text{Not-}I$ in conformance to that, in which synthesis the process of concrete logic, as the “ultimate and unconditioned condition of every thinking” without realizing that a condition can never be unconditioned or else the I is really *its own norm*, and then every law can only be contingent and an “unconditionally imperative characteristic of the law of concrete logic” becomes an empty sound. Or else there is a limit, or law indifferent to the power of the I , only in virtue of which this is such (as the *Anstoss*¹¹ of Fichte’s philosophy) and clearly postulated by the *impotence* of being or thinking otherwise, if only not properly affirmable in the gnoseological sense; and then one may as well confess himself as a creature and pass on to religion – because one idol is not better than another.

It is not worth objecting, with Rickert, that the denial of the imperative of the law could be a particular case of this in the sense that, to the extent that it is willed, it is recognized worthy of the choice in respect to the opposed alternative of adhesion to the law, since that presupposes agreement with that which is in question, i.e., that it cannot be given a real negation, that it is not possible to be reaffirmed beyond the given facticity of the law *in general* of *Sollen*—that the mode of living the act according to *Sollen* represented an extreme instance. This difficulty reappears from another side and is close to the problem, as the same philosophy of the act it is general possible. Since, of the two choices:

- Either the I is entirely compenetrated with its activity, and then cannot embrace it with a synthetic gaze and discover its general law,

⁹German word for *should*, *having to*.

¹⁰A force from behind.

¹¹opposition

but rather, lost in it, it can only learn from it in the unpredictable, uncoercible contingency of the moment.

- Or else the I, almost lifting itself from itself, can know that law, but then otherwise its contingency is conceded, since with that, this becomes a distinct “thought”, and remains almost interiorly surpassed in the principle that makes such a distinction possible—this surpassing, keeping in mind that, by hypothesis, has nothing to do with the internal surpassing of that law and contemplated by it.

Gentile has seen the difficulty and, having rejected the second option, tries to make himself sufficient to the first, saying that if he recognizes he has given with his doctrine not thinking in itself, but a *concept* of thinking, that is, not thinking but *a* thought. He concedes otherwise the relativity and the abstract nature of such a “concept of the self-concept” (that is, of his entire philosophy) and he is ready to abandon it to the indomitable becoming of dialecticism, his own *Logica* being understood as a simple milestone, and as abstract as all the others. But the parry is mistaken: relativity, the remission to the becoming of the spirit is also the principal content of the Gentilian concept of the self-concept, to that “thought” in which Gentile—here and now—conceives and kills “thinking”, so that this relativity is the hypocrisy of exclusivity and dogmatism, this pretense comes from itself, this sacrifice does not accomplish anything but a staying firm, in the closed circle of the contingency of the moment, having outside of itself its own reason.

If the solution must be *real*, if the vicious circle must be ruptured, then it is necessary that the passage is not that from one concept to another, from one “thought” to another, but *rather that of the entire dimension of the logico-discursive consciousness into that higher or deeper plane of absolute freedom*. Then it is necessary to surpass the creatural concept of the identity of freedom and the law, the *vis a tergo* of the *Sollen*, and be recognized in that unconditioned principle in respect to which the same

act is a fact and that in truth stands at the beginning of Gentilian philosophy approximately in the same relationship that the Gnostics understood between the spiritual principle and the demiurgic principle.

This is an utterly significant situation: the instance of its own surpassing rises from the same rationale: the same discursive consciousness imposes on the I to go beyond it, if it wants to penetrate, to its foundation, that thinking that resolves the world in an immanent principle. As Abbagnano sharply notes, true thinking, thought *thinking*, it can never become an object of itself, it can never be *thought*, what other meaning, if not that it falls outside the plane of the rational? Thus the effort of contracting all reality in thinking and all life is overturned in emptiness: the very act of celebrating the greatest power of thinking implies that it is transcended in a the non-rational.

Nonetheless here a new question arises: what is the meaning of this non-rational? Or: in what relationship is the I with this non-rational? Such a point is important because it defines the position of magical idealism in respect to irrationalism. When the non-rational (to which therefore the foundation of rational law, or logical *Sollen*, must be pushed back: every rationality should be the effect of a deep non-rational, but arbitrary, affirmation) for the I is like a blind and uncoercible power, that cannot in any way direct and dominate and which is felt as an accident dispersed in an indefinite, unpredictable becoming, it is truly to be thought that the surpassing beyond the rational has not yet entirely accomplished, that the I still looks at the *alagon* from the outside, that it has not penetrated itself and *possesses* at the center of the originary and unconditioned principle of creation.

The irrationalism that proceeds from such a situation is that of Schopenhauer, Bergson, Le Roy, Abbagnano, etc., and is confused with a type of vivified empiricism: it indicates the moment of transit, in which the I is already detached from the hallucination of pure logic and is oriented to the deep power from where logic rises, but on the other hand is not

yet sunk into this power, so that it lives it only passively. For those who have instead absolutely possessed themselves, the *alagon* indicates only the unconditionality of his will, autarchy. Therefore, beyond the abstract intellectual, there is still an abyss between the man who lives his own life as lord and master, and the man who feels himself only as a demonic force of a nature that is passive to himself and that has its *raison d'être* outside himself (certainly, not in the rationalist sense of the phrase, but in the Greek sense, used by Michelstaedter), briefly: spontaneity.

This is the third and final installment of **Julius Evola's** commentary on **Giovanni Gentile** from *Essays on Magical Idealism*.

Although it is highly technical, we can cut to the main point. First, there is the distinction between *spontaneity* and *freedom*. In a free act, "I" make the choice. A spontaneous act seems to happen automatically, seemingly without the awareness or involvement of the I.

The application of this comes in the idea that the *world is my representation*. That is, I create in consciousness the sensation of the world: its colors, shapes, sounds, etc. The naive realist view, on the other hand, believes that there is a real world, out there, right now, that somehow impinges on my consciousness and that is the source of my representation of the world. No one can say exactly how that happens; besides, Kant seems to have demolished that as a possible explanation.

In opposition to that, previous idealists have instead proposed other sources for such representations, as Evola points out. Evola rejects them all. Instead, he claims that the spontaneous nature of the representation of the world is due only to a privation, i.e., it is due to my impotency.

This is important because almost all non-philosophers are naive realists; that is, they believe they are passive receptors of a true

representation of the world in their mind. When restricted to the physical world alone, this is not so serious as people can get along in the world with this naive belief.

However, the mischief arises in regard to the human world. Naive realists falsely believe they have been given a true representation of the human, or moralized, world, that is, the world of action, motivation, desire, and so on. They are unaware of the extent to which they are projecting their own ideas, prejudices, errors, ignorance, etc., onto their representation of the world. That is, their representation is spontaneous, created without conscious awareness.

Here, the magical idealist has a way out. He takes possession of his own world representation in the awareness that he has freely chosen it.

It is clear that when the surpassing of the rational occurs in connection with that impulse to persuasion that was manifested in rationalism as the will to dominate every reality in thinking, only at the point of life experienced as autarchy is the principle restored, that can give to logic its justification. Therefore the further dimension in magical idealism must be understood, in which the positions of Gentilian philosophy are integrated.

That said, let's definitively establish what is, in the last instance, the inherent value to modern idealism starting from Kant up to Royce, Weber, and Gentile. The fundamental principle is that *spontaneity* is one thing, and *freedom* another. The former is the activity whose principle one has simply in oneself (which is spontaneity, according to Aristotle's definition); the latter is the activity whose principle the I has in itself, but stands to this *in relationship of possession*. In spontaneity the possible is identical to the real in the sense that the act has the form of an absolute being-tied-to-itself, of a nonconvertible compulsion, of a mindless occurrence: briefly, in it the principle is *passive* in respect to oneself. Instead, in

freedom, the possible is *not* identical to the real, a moment of autarchy, of real possibility (not of *dynamis*, but rather of *potestas*) controls the act as the ultimate reason for its being or non-being, of its being this or that. Hence, it is that the real is contingent to the possible—and not through privation, but rather through perfection and through the possession of the principle of actuality. In conjunction: one thing is not having conditions from another (i.e., coerced non-being, *negative* freedom exactly characteristic of spontaneity, of the false Spinozan *causa sui*), another is the not having conditions absolutely, being *positively* free, which also implies the absence of internal determinations and arbitrariness (the non-inconvertibility) of the act. *Now to the extent that a being is an I, to that extent and for that reason, it is freedom and not spontaneity.*

Once that is understood, when the idealist, against any contingency of experience—for example, against an expanse—says that it was he who posited it, it is evident that he is referring not to freedom, but rather to spontaneity. He in fact refers to the simple representing, to that elementary assent so that, in general, this is to be aware of things, assent that, if it is the *necessary* condition for every reality, qua reality, then *for* the I, it is quite far from also being the *sufficient* condition. In fact, in representing there is not a subordination of reality to possibility; the I is passive to his own act, he does not so much affirm things, but rather these are affirmed in him. As passion or emotion, the representation is something of *his*, that is intimate to him and which he draws out of his own interiority (at this point the legitimacy of the application of idealism arrives, moreover satisfied by Leibniz), but it is not *him*, since the I cannot say he gives it freely to himself, since he is not at its determination in regard to *unconditioned* causality and possession.

Consequently, *to the extent that the idealistic reduction of nature appears as a position of the I, it reduces the I itself to nature, i.e., insofar as that I, which is freedom, knows nothing or, better, acts as if he knew nothing, and, with obvious paralogism, it equates the concept of the I with that of the*

principle of spontaneity—which is then in truth that of nature. So that the meaning of the idealistic claim that “The I posits the non-I” is, in reality, “Nature posits itself” or more simply: “A world is”.

The crux of such a doctrine is therefore Spinozism. But Spinozism, dedogmatized, leads to phenomenalism. And this demonstrates the very history of idealism. In Kant if in the transposition of the individual I to the impersonal “I think” and to “consciousness in general”, there is the first step toward the dissolution of freedom, there nevertheless still remains a residue of interiority in virtue of the opposition of the limit of the thing-in-itself to the activity of the synthetic *a priori*. The progress of the theory of immanence about this dualism is moreover that of the *détente* of individual affirmation. The I of Fichte assimilates the non-I (the Kantian thing-in-itself) only by becoming the abstract egoity dispersing itself in the world of the preconscious. The Hegelian Idea does not reaffirm the logical principle on that totality of concrete determinations that Schelling’s monochrome “philosophy of identity” let fall outside of itself provided that it admits the “other” in itself, makes itself dialectic, calls rational and free those contingent determinations of things which, being simply *given*, standing to the I in a relationship of *force*, that justly can only be called irrational (in the Greek meaning of the word).

Finally, among the ruins of the “philosophy of nature” and the heterological of the *Ohnmach der Natur* [impotence of nature] on the one hand, on the other by falling short of the ideal of *a priori* knowledge in the order of positive science (to the reduction of geometry and mechanics by deductive science prior to experimental sciences – so that the presupposition collapses from Kant’s criticism) there is the final collapse of the individual in the irrational becoming of phenomena, with which he makes self-knowledge itself coincide, without residue and further mediation. The I does not make itself the form that dominates (gnoseologically) the contingency of the phenomena — Schlegel’s “Chaos outside of the system” — that as the current awareness of Gentile’s philosophy,

i.e., that as the absolute adhesion of the act in spontaneity according to which things become and assert themselves in the I — however, just as it was said, for a type of passive mysticism that in practice is identified with an absolute, perplexed phenomenalism.

We pointed out in the second essay that beyond the identification of reality and will (= possibility) the question remains, whether the will is the criterion of reality or whether reality is the criterion of the will. That is, if what happens is called real because it is willed (however real only in the measure in which it can be called willed, moreover that correlative of a *privation* of the will remaining not real), or else if it is called willed because it is real, i.e., for the simple irrational fact of its being there (*Da-sein*), of its brute *to oti*: it was shown that only the second alternative meets actualism insofar as it is not elevated to a *doctrine of power or magical idealism*. The being that it rightly posits does not posit it that way because it finds it *de facto*: “Mustness” is the truth and the foundation of its “shouldness”. Analogously, since a great number of the events of experience in general cannot be connected back to a beginning of informed deliberation, of intentional predetermination on behalf of the real I (and this I can prove at every instance to the idealist, since he does not want to deceive himself purposely), from that subjective activity from which things are posited, it is necessary to abstract the natures of finality and conscious predetermination – at long as one does not prefer to pass (as was the logical consequences of the premises of transcendental philosophy that Hartmann precisely dealt with) to a philosophy of the unconscious.

Finally, since one cannot even give *a posteriori* a logical-axiological construction of such a vast complex of phenomena (Prof Krug’s pen is still waiting to be deduced), the logicity proper to this cosmogonic function of the I must be reduced to a *minimum*, to an abstract generality, to an empty universal that is equally adequate to the specificity of infinite distinctions – to which the character of logic characteristic of the pure Gentilian act responds exactly, which being able to be called everything

indifferently, is as if it is called nothing; it is a sack that can equally well contain everything. Empty indetermination from the logical point of view—however, *materialiter*, irrationality — intentionality, afinalism, passivity, pure spontaneity exhausting itself all in the variety of “here and now” — such are therefore the marks that define the function, in which the doctrine of immanence believed it recognized its supreme celebration, since it has the courage of thinking it down to the foundations.

In Spinoza that blind spontaneity of that which can be only what it is, of that which is passive in respect to its own nature – so that the I is reduced to a vain and incomprehensible shadow — was God; in Gentile this God is known in its truthfulness and is made explicitly nature, the uncoercible folly of phenomena so that the relevant doctrine is identified, beyond all the logical paraphernalia, with Bergson’s. In the one as in the other, the individual does not *consist* but *surrenders*, does not dominate things but loses himself there and is dissolved in an intoxicated coalescence that recedes into a demonical principle. Such is the way of corruption, the self-lampooning of the immanentistic application.

In conclusion. I said that mere representative activity is the necessary, but not sufficient, condition of the reality of things, *since these are related to an I*. I can say I posited things, but insofar as I am spontaneity, not insofar as I am an I, and that is freedom. Now to say that I, as I or sufficient principle, cannot recognize myself as the *unconditioned* cause of the representations (i.e., of nature), it does not at all mean that these representation are caused by “another” (by real things or existing in themselves) but, simply that I am insufficient for a part of my activity, which is still spontaneity — *that such a part is still not moralized, that the I, as freedom, suffers a privation in it*. So that it is realism, as we said, that must be pushed back for a goal of not receiving. When then will one be able to truly affirm the principle of idealism, that the I posits things? When the individual has transformed the dark passion of the world into a body of freedom, i.e., when he has made the form pass by which he

lives the activity represented by spontaneity, by connection of reality and possibility, to unconditioned, arbitrary causality — to potency. In the face of this task, the idealist flees instead: to the real or magical act, to the act that, by possessing them, abolishes things. He substitutes the discursive act that recognizes them and is supported on them. *He calls being his non-being*, he calls real that which, being real that, as the privation of his power, should instead correctly be called unreal, and so confirms this privation, adulates it, and incestuously feeds on it. Insufficient at the point of the I, he abdicates and dissolves himself in things; and rationality, historicity, concrete liberty, the transcendental I, etc., are only so many names of this flight, are only the symbols of his impotency, that the values given by force to that which, in relation to the point of the I and morality (in Weininger's and Michelstaedter's sense of the word) is non-value = death and obscurity: nature.

Posted on 2014-07-06 by Aeneas

5.6 Hermann Keyserling

This is the part on **Julius Evola's** interpretation of **Hermann Keyserling**, originally published in *Saggi sull'Idealismo Magico*. The School of Wisdom¹² referred to was established by Keyserling in 1920 and is apparently still active today.

Keyserling bases his philosophy on “understanding”, which is “metarational”. Specifically, it is not something that can be given to someone nor compelled by a logical process. It should be familiar to all readers. For example, you may have had an “aha” experience, where you suddenly “get it”. Or it could be as simple as “getting a joke” ... you all know someone who failed to comprehend the punchline! If you consider such moments, you will see

¹²<https://www.schoolofwisdom.com/>

how not understanding changed to understanding. This is a free spontaneous act, since nothing caused it, not even neurochemical reactions.

The second point is that meaning is always in reference to a Self, not in the object. The exterior world takes on quite a different feeling once it is realized the extent that the Self understands it and invests it with meaning. Matter, then, is the privation of meaning, since it belongs to necessity and understanding is free.

In the second part, we will see that through understanding and meaning, the world of representations is created. This is not to say that the material world is such, insofar as it is privation, but, rather, there is a large part of social life that is not matter, but rather the creation of the mind. This is the will to power, and it depends on reaching increasingly deeper levels of understanding.

This is not much different from what Boris Mouravieff says: “Esoteric Tradition teaches that any civilization is none other than a projection of the consciousness of the I’s of elite man onto the exterior world.” Now if the elite is made up of Sages, as Keyserling describes, the projection will not be that of the chaotic I’s of the personality, but rather of the Real I.

Hermann Keyserling created tendencies that gave rise to the so-called “School of Wisdom” in Germany and are interesting for this reason: they aim to transfigure the intellectual synthesis itself in the metarational principle of freedom and therefore to shift the center of the I from the *vis a tergo* of the rational imperative and every necessity in general, without suppressing the plane of concrete experience.

The key to Keyserling’s views is the phenomenon of understanding. He contemplates the point in which the I says to himself: “I understood.” It is essentially a point of spontaneity, freedom, and interiority: there is no way of compelling one to understanding. It on the other hand has a mystico-illuminative character: it seeks to *live* the moment of “meaning”, not of this or that meaning, but rather of meaning in general, of the pure

element of the understanding conditioning every understanding, then one will feel that something ineffable shines in it, something that, even if contending with it and being supported on it, absolutely transcends the whole of the means and forms from which it was propitiated. This mystical moment of pure understanding is the moment of the spirit. Certainly, a meaning exists only in connection to a certain form or nature that expresses it — but the inverse is also true, and that is that being understood, interiorized, is always the condition so that anything has existence for the I and that therefore the synthetic function of understanding is, directly, the absolute *prius*, the base, or *apriori* of each one of our experiences, if only in accordance with somewhat diverse levels.

Since it is absurd to speak of a meaning existing in things independently of the I (nothing has meaning through itself but everything can acquire it) and since understanding is always and essentially interwoven with spontaneity and interiority, it appears clear that by that, Keyserling defines a function, capable of reaffirming, on the entire ambit of human experience, the principle of the free and creator I. Since — and this is Keyserling's improvement, previously sketched out by Novalis, on Kant's synthetic a priori which, as everyone knows, is preconscious, impersonal, and abstractly intellectual — there understanding is the same as an unconditioned and immanent power of the real I, it is not a concept, but an effective element of interiority. It follows that the entire world assumes the character of an expressive means, of a symbolic material that the I must invest, animate, and almost recreate with the act of his understanding.

The distinction between nature and spirit is thus reduced to that between a half expressive abstraction and half expressive entirely resolved in the actuality of meaning. Matter or necessity would only be the *privation* of meaning, the mindless opaque "letter" to oneself. Nevertheless, even reduced to this form, such a distinction must be explained. It is that meaning, in its essence of deep subjectivity and in law, is absolute

freedom: but, in expressing itself, it cannot be crystalized into a given nonconvertible body, it cannot make that unconditioned principle fall into necessity (that is, in a mechanical discourse) in which it comes to fruition — as in a type of enlightenment — in the pure moment of self-determination, of the creative conception balanced between the “not yet” of the possible and the form in which the possible asserts itself. The half expressive abstraction, or nature and necessity, is constituted by nothing other than the preceding processes of self-expression already exhausted and sustained through mechanical repetition; from which however, the spirit rises in self-conception on the basis of a deeper meaning, which it then expresses and incarnates utilizing precisely that matter in which it is coagulated and which rendered its preceding freedom mechanical — and the process is continued toward an always deeper meaning or interiority, correlative to an always richer, organic, and articulate body of expression. From this rises the concept that the various natural or historical laws are simple laws of grammar and syntax, which those who live in the deep level of meaning do not need to deny, but only to dominate interiorly, just as the artist dominates the material in which he incorporates his creation.

That brings up the problem of the human “type”. It, according to Keyserling, is not to be pushed back onto art, religion, or philosophy. Artists are, typically, mediums: that greatness that speaks in, or by means of, them almost never coincides with their personal knowledge. As for religion, it must be excluded because, as such, it introduces a principle of authority and dogmatism on the one hand, of dependence and passivity on the other, that is incompatible with the character of autonomous, individual assertion, that was connected to “meaning”. Still less can it be pushed back to the thinker, who is held fixed in a world of abstract concepts, alien to reality and separated from the depths of the creator I. It is better instead to connect it to the ancient concept of *Wisdom*, when it is understood as a synthesis of life and science in the individual unity of the creator. What is essential, is that the I does not become a slave of

abstract knowledge, but produces it interiorly in living reality; that he survives in an ideality no more than an abyss separated from concrete reality, but rather he places himself outside the world and *expresses* himself in it, incarnates fully in it to the extent he conceives the deep level of meaning. Hence, the type of the Sage becomes moreover that of the Lord: and that clearly not in regard to naked power, but rather in regard to the principle that is interiorly superior to the totality of life, that commands it and molds from above the power of freedom. And how much deeper is the plane in which understanding is realized, so much more perfectly and fully the I dominates and commands the whole of the various forces (natural, social, etc.) that it reclaims in that way as the matter of his “language”.

From this development it becomes clear that Keyserling speaks of “meaning” and “understanding” in a rather metaphoric way, in order to give a suggestion of a certain function, which he then, to tell the truth, reaffirms in the totality of all concrete powers of internal and external experience.

This is the second and final installment of **Julius Evola**’s commentary on **Hermann Keyserling** from *Saggi sull’Idealismo Magico*. Evola refers to Keyserling’s “brilliant interpretation of the function of meaning, according to which understanding is removed from the rational and peripheral plane and compenetrated with the principle of deep self-realization and power.”

Some of the main points to note:

- There are deeper levels of consciousness from which the Self has more power over the physical world.
- The physical world is not self-sufficient, but is related to a spiritual power for its ultimate explanation
- The accumulation of facts and knowledge is not the important thing. Rather, it is the deepening of one’s level of consciousness

- Meaning is really the self-possession of the person
- The physical world is not destiny, it does not consist of brute facts
- Reality is in fact malleable, perfectly reflecting what the Self conceives as its meaning
- The individual must accept full responsibility for his world
- In that way, he overcomes fate and becomes free

Clearly, the problem of knowledge in the doctrine of “meaning” is strictly connected to the problem of power, which Keyserling resolves by means of the theory of the levels of consciousness. As we previously noted as characteristic of idealism, the premise is that every objective thing depends on a subjective thing, that things are what we are or, better, what we posit to ourselves. To will to dominate the external world, i.e., acting in the level of the mass and physical determinisms, is an impossible and contradictory assumption: but things are quite different when the I brings its own action into the deep level of transcendent causes, into the sphere of “meaning” that is that incorporeity that conditions the corporeal and that is conditioned by nothing. Human liberty in its highest aspect consists in the idea that where the focus of our consciousness falls depends on us. We can posit this focus in the world of the phenomenon where there is no place for a real initiative, or else at the point of the original creative function, whose principle is freedom and *possibility*. In other words: every phenomenon never constitutes a last instance, but presupposes a spiritual power to which its explanation and consistency refers back: when we posit ourselves with this power in relation to the other, when we do not *understand* it, it appears to us as unbending fate; when instead it is reaffirmed to us in that divine spark that remains in the individual and that is the deep source of his life, that world that first held us in iron slavery becomes our instrument for a silent transformation.

Then it will be able to determine unconditionally the form in which reality will have to appear to us, to actually live the given not as a last instance, but as one that is malleable and reflects passively what the I conceives in the region of meaning. "The representation creates reality, and not vice versa"; "the faculty of representation is unconditioned"; the I can, by means of a movement of the level of consciousness, possessing itself in this faculty"—such are the principles of Keyserling's doctrine of power similar to those characteristic of esoterism and certain western schools of magic.

The fundamental point is added to that, even if not so distinctly affirmed like Michelstaedter: namely, the individual must rise to the awareness of absolute responsibility, he must make himself adequate to his own life and not only in the order of the subjective properly called, but also in the order of the cosmic and the universal. The I must make himself the last cause and must be able to take the weight of world responsibility on himself, without trying to push it back onto another; since only on condition of assuming it, can the person hope to go beyond destiny to freedom.

The principle merit of the "School of Wisdom" is that it affirmed that what is important is not to procure new knowledge or experiences, but rather to change the *level* of one's own personality, to bring the center of the I onto another plane or dimension in which the relationship to one's activity is that of possession and unconditioned determination. In that he agrees fully with magical idealism, and still more so when he suggests such a plane as that of the Lord. The concept of "meaning" instead demands a greater individuation. In fact the question must be asked: what is the *meaning* of this "meaning"? Since it certainly has something to do with its general mystical and self-creative aspect: but when the dialectic of expression mentioned above is grafted onto it, things become complicated. "Meaning" understood as a fate of self-expression, objectifying itself, reasserting itself in new expressions, etc., is what can be less com-

prehensible and in no way surrenders to the brute given of dialectic laws to which rationalism is subjected to.

Even here, freedom must certainly be asserted beyond the entire process. On the other hand, in order to organically connect the same process—understood as the ever deeper self-penetration of meaning—to the principle of the Lord, it is necessary to understand this dynamically, i.e., to place it properly in the *interval* in which the I transcends his freedom which became an objectivity, in order to reassert a principle eternally irreducible to *being*. Then “understanding”, “meaning” should have self-possession for its deepest meaning, the self-realizing of the I in pure actual essence in an ever more perfect way. *Autarchy* should thus be the key to the process, the quality in which original freedom willed itself—consequently, Keyserling clouds over when he points to the principle that is necessary to make oneself the last reason, that it is necessary to rise to the meaning of world responsibility, to take destiny onto oneself, to make oneself adequate to it and to resolve it in the principle of the Lord. Besides, once that determinism is established, the rigidity is what constitutes the anti-thetical moment since as matter for the expression, the reassertion of the principle of meaning—which is freedom—follows from it or it can have only a negative character—of *derealization*, of agitation, of dissolution of every necessity in the contingent and in the easily moveable—so that the idea of a substrate of material necessity, of laws, whether restricted only to the only “grammar” or “language” (the same languages moreover change, transforming themselves according to various needs), cannot in the final instance be maintained, and the idea of a world system entirely compenetrated by the function of the “meaning” is enriched with the idea of the “body of freedom” that is also the “body of negation”. With Heraclitus, Novalis, Bhagavan Das, and the conception here sustained, it is necessary to understand the world process as a *burning* and its immanent goal as the accomplishment of the I as *entity of pure negativity*—e.g., of pure contingency and absolute possession.

If we wanted, we could still make a few and more serious objections to Keyserling, to the asystematic and “symphonic” character of his expositions: in the actual form specified, in regards to history, by which he does not mean completely *ideality*, and that therefore he often treats from an empirical point of view, really transcendent to the plane of “meaning”. So that while on one hand he affirms that the historic fact does not create “meaning” but that “meaning” creates the historic fact, on the other, like Benedetto Croce, he in fact nevertheless recognizes given historical determinisms that impinge, epoch by epoch, the uneliminable conditions so that meaning can incarnate itself and make itself concrete. We may think of Keyserling’s principle that meaning exists only insofar as it is expressed, and one will notice here how dangerous the position is and how instead—since he holds firm to the principle, that nothing is that is understood in a certain measure and that understanding has freedom for an inseparable attribute—the right way would be to deny the *real* anteriority of any historical condition whatsoever, and therefore of the entire past or antecedent history to make absolutely unformed matter, whose identification is not *given* or *found*, but is pinned only to the metahistoric unconditioned self-determination of meaning—i.e., to make something conditioned from it and no longer something conditioning.

But this is not the place to repeat myself. It was important only to point out Keyserling’s brilliant interpretation of the function of “meaning”, according to which understanding is removed from the rational and peripheral plane and compenetrated with the principle of deep self-realization and power.

Posted on 2014-07-29 by Cologero

5.7 The Pearl Tiara

A pearl tiara has a design and a structure. The pearls are arranged in a certain way, usually by size. It is built around precious metals and may include other gems. Although the quality of each individual pearl is important, the piece of jewelry achieves its beauty in its totality, not from any pearl in particular. This is opposed to a bowl of pearls, in which each pearl has no relation to its neighbor, that is, it is a heap. In a world that considers a bowl of pearls to be a work of art, there are obviously many who cannot discern the difference.

Blogs, too, can be read in two different ways. Careless readers will regard the blog posts like pearls in a bowl, with nothing but casual relationships among the various posts. They cannot see that Gornahoor is architectonic, posts are related to each other, themes appear and reappear with variations, and that nothing is posted without a reason nor without a place in the totality. Although this design is not visible to the senses as a pearl tiara is, it should be visible to the intellect.

Besides the text itself, there is an art. The coat of arms, the motto, the colours, etc., are all planned for a certain effect. The vocabulary is deliberately chosen so that only those of a certain intelligence and education can understand it, yet any difficulty is not from intentional obfuscation.

Tone Deaf to Life For example, one of our first posts, *Tone Deaf to Life*¹³, published in 2007, illustrates this. On the one hand, it starts with the notion of the consciousness of the True Self (or Real I). It ends with the challenge to see one's life in its totality, i.e., like a tiara, rather than a collection of random events like a bowl.

Seven years later, we come back to this, but a little deeper. Instead of isolated quotes, we provide entire, previously untranslated, texts from Julius Evola on the same theme of the consciousness of the true self. Fur-

¹³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=12>

thermore, beyond each individual post, there is an implicit, if not explicit, relationship among the posts. In other words, Gornahoor as a blog tries to be, in microcosm, an exemplar of the macrocosm it describes.

And not just rhetorically, since that is the recent theme. We are now also providing the opportunity and the venue¹⁴ for some among you to actually develop the consciousness of the true self as a reality, as being, and not just as text, rhetoric, or thought.

The Attraction of Rhetoric So when I read of a suggestion to do a comparative study of Evola, Michelstaedter, and Heidegger, I should feel frustrated, except that I understand the human, all too human, condition too well. It suggests rhetoric in a post that is anti-rhetoric. Such a study is suitable for a professor who needs to publish in between his various conferences and seductions of his graduate assistants.

To look at things in their totality: it starts with Evola's intention to discuss five earlier thinkers. In no way, did he write a comparative study of those five men. Rather, he had a different purpose. He saw his philosophy as the fulfillment of what those men may have started, but never completed. Specifically, he wrote:

Magical idealism carries forward by way of logical continuity and integrates the most advanced positions that modern Western speculation has achieved

How could anyone have missed that? It is the opposite of rhetoric, Heidegger's *gerede* or idle chitchat. Instead, in an act of possession, Evola incorporates the best of those writers into his own scheme, as he claims. He brings out the logical consequences of the earlier writers, consequences that they themselves may have overlooked. He integrates their positions into a larger whole.

¹⁴<https://gornahoor.net/?p=7205>

Is that vanity, or self-aggrandizement, or confidence? Or perhaps the words of one who knows?

Can anyone take the next logical step? Why would we would we bother to translate and publish such an obscure text? Evola's text is the object and Gornahoor is the frame. Next is to see Gornahoor as the object and then determine the frame.

Perhaps you have guessed by now. Evola announced a project and a method. Since we take such writings seriously and not as mere rhetoric used to provide intellectual entertainment, we take possession of that project and method. Hence, Gornahoor is best understood as the historical fulfillment of the most advanced positions that Western tradition has achieved.

This has been done by bringing out the logical consequences of previous writers and by integrating their positions into a larger whole. The list of writers referenced is large, but not that large. Does this help anyone seek the tiara rather than the bowl?

So, let us go back to the original proposal. An intelligent man will write about Evola, Michelstaedter, and Heidegger, not to exalt them, compare them, or contrast them, but to overcome them, fulfill them, and integrate them into a larger whole.

Posted on 2014-06-06 by Cologero

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Michael on 2023-06-06 at 09:48 said:

It is important for reader's to understand the goal of this post. To truly understand and incorporate these thinkers is to sit with them and not try to resolve them with each other, but to resolve them within oneself. Producing something from that point brings the current to the surface.

Modern Philosophy

6.1 The Moral Universe

First and foremost, I will tell you who should work in this work, and when, and by what means: and what discretion you shall have in it. If you ask me who shall work thus, I answer you—all who have forsaken the world in a **true will**.

The Cloud of Unknowing

If you start at the Greek and Roman antiquities section of the Louvre, then the transition to the Medieval art exhibit is striking. So much so, that it does not seem possible that they could have been created by the same peoples. In the same way, the transition from the Naturalistic poetry of Lucretius to the Moral Universe of Dante also cries out for an explanation. Keep in mind that Virgil, who aided Dante on his journey, had studied, like Lucretius, with the Epicureans.

Naturalism For naturalism, the purposeless movement of atoms leaves no space for moral acts. It recognizes a single force, the *élan vital* or vital

impulse. The moral universe requires a countervailing force, the frein vital, which is the vital control that acts as a check on the impulse. That naturalistic goal is the satisfaction of the appetites, and any check on the appetite comes from an external source, not from an inner check.

Rationalism **George Santayana** in *Three Philosophical Poets* asserts that Socrates provides the link between Lucretius and Dante. In the *Phaedo*, while sitting in prison, Socrates recounts how in his youth he had sought the ultimate cause of the Universe. The Epicureans claimed it was atoms. Other thinkers had proposed alternatives such as Water, Fire, Air. Socrates rejected them all, favoring instead Reason or Mind as the source of order. In that case, things are to be understood by their use or purpose, and not by the initial element that set them in motion.

This is the beginning of Absolute Idealism, since Being is known by Thought and not by the physics behind it. In this case, Being is the object of contemplation. This is cataphatic philosophy which seeks to make positive statements about the Absolute. The three main strands among the Greeks offer different qualities as the object of contemplation:

- **Aristotle:** The Unmoved Mover
- **Plato:** The Good
- **The Stoics:** The Logos

Still, in these formulations, the Absolute is passive in relationship to Man, who is a Subject, an I. With its historical revelation, Christianity went beyond that. It was revealed that the Absolute itself was also a Subject. Obviously, the Absolute as Subject is the God, now an active force. The three qualities now take on a deeper dimension.

- **The Unmoved Mover.** The unmoved mover that sets the universe in motion becomes, as Subject, the **Creator** of the universe.

- **The Good.** The Absolute as subject seeks, or wills, the Good. That is, the Absolute is **Love**.
- **The Logos.** The order of the Universe is not merely the object of contemplation, but as subject it is the **Christ**. Any disorder in the world must be rectified by a Savior incarnating into the World Process.

The World as Magic Santayana raises the question of how does Love act on the physical world. Science is insufficient to explain the World. A moral interpretation of Nature is necessary. Santayana describes the action of the moral universe on the physical as magical. He writes:

[The Absolute] works only in its capacity of ideal; therefore, even if it exists, it works only by magic. The matter beneath feels the spell of its presence, and catches something of its image, as the waves of the sea might receive and reflect tremblingly the light shed by the moon. The world accordingly is moved and vivified in very fibre by magic, by the magic of the goal to which it aspires.

Santayana explains that on Earth, the Magic is called Love. Actual things are symbols for what they ultimately should be. That is, existing phenomenal things are a theophany of something higher, and it requires the powers of a spiritual vision to discern that. Santayana describes it:

We should attribute the power which things exerted over us, not to the rarer or denser substance, but to the eternal ideas that they existed by expressing, and existed to express. Things merely localized—like the saint's relics—the influences which flowed to us from above. In the world of values they were mere symbols, accidental channels for divine energy; and since divine energy, by its magic assimilation of nature, had created these things, in order to express itself, they were symbols altogether not merely in their use, but in their origin and nature.

So for Dante, the world is love, magic, and symbolism. The pessimist Santayana has this vain hope:

A thousand years after Dante, we may hope that his conscientious vision of the universe, where all is *love, magic, and symbolism*, may charm mankind exclusively as poetry.

Of course, that is not sufficiently pessimistic, since in our time Dante is not even appreciated as poetry. The lure of naturalism, the worldview of Satan, persists in obscuring love, magic, and symbolism from the World. For the naturalist, the solution to the mystery of life is to maintain adequate levels of serotonin, dopamine, and oxytocin, pharmacologically if necessary.

How radically different is the world filled with love, magic, and symbols of spiritual reality from the blind movement of atoms. No, Dante is not merely a poet, he is a guide showing us the way from Hell to Paradise.

Demanding a Choice Curiously, Santayana has the incisive intelligence to discern what is really at stake between the naturalistic and moral views of the world, even if he has personally chosen the path of naturalism. Paradoxically, for the naturalist, there is no choice; the mind is an illusion and everything is determined by the motion of atoms. For the moralist, on the other hand, a choice is demanded. Making the choice is ipso facto the proof of Dante's poetic vision of the world. Here are some selected passages from the text. Decide where you stand.

Nature was a compound of ideal purposes and inert matter. Life was a conflict between sin and grace. The environment was a battleground between a host of angels and a legion of demons. The better and the worse had actually becomes the sole principles of understanding.

The highest good became God, the creator of the world. The various stages or elements of perfection became persons in the

Godhead, or angelic intelligences, or aerial demons, or lower types of the animal soul. Evil was identified with matter. The various stages of imperfection were ascribed to the grossness of various bodies, which weighted and smothered the spark of divinity that animated them. This spark, however, might be released; then it would fly up again to its parent fire and a soul would be saved.

Moral values came to be regarded as forces working in nature. But if they worked in nature, which was a compound of evil matter and perfect form, they must exist outside. ... The forces that worked in nature were accordingly supernatural virtues, dominations, and powers; each natural thing had its supernatural incubus, a guardian angel, or a devil that possessed it. The supernatural—that is, something moral or ideal regarded as a power and an existence—was all about us. Everything in the world was an effect of something beyond the world; everything in life was a step to something beyond life.

Posted on 2018-03-18 by Cologero

6.2 The Third Ring of Saturn

George Santayana is the third of the Saturnine philosophers, following Spinoza and Schopenhauer. Although all three have a similar understanding of the Manifest world, they differ on how to express the Unseen. By dint of human effort, they rise to the top of the Visible world and point their mental telescopes at the sky. There they find the secret sun, which shines so bright, that its light hides all the lesser lights of the Visible World.

Spinoza calls it God. This God has attributes including Thought and Extension, although He cannot be found there. These attributes are his versions of the Names, or even Energies, of God. The multitudinous events we observe in the Manifest world are merely modifications of God,

the one and only Substance. Our fulfillment, even salvation, is to learn to love that God.

Schopenhauer maintains that the Manifest world of phenomena is a representation in the human mind, although he doesn't explain why the human state is so privileged to give birth to that world. Ultimate reality cannot be found among those phenomena, but he notices that the will is outside phenomena, that is, it is noumenal. Hence, the Ultimate is pure Will, with no intelligence or purpose. Hence, it cannot be understood. Salvation can only mean to stop producing pain in sentient beings, but, best of all, would be to end existence itself.

The Reluctant Catholic Although George Santayana was Spanish — and retained his citizenship throughout his life — he was raised in Boston where he got a classical education at the Boston Latin School. He was never comfortable there, so, after receiving an inheritance, he ended up living in Rome during the Fascist era. I know the feeling. After being raised in a section of Somerville that was 75% Catholic, there was a culture shock when my family relocated to a suburb that was dominated by Protestant descendants of the Puritans.

Santayana was culturally and aesthetically Catholic although he could not bring himself to faith. Thus he saw, in Spinoza, the intellectual alternative. Santayana follows Spinoza in many ways, except he concludes that the Attribute of Extension, i.e., “matter”, is the ultimate reality. Therefore, Thought must be derivative of matter. However, matter has no I, it cannot be a god.

We see a decline in the three rings of Saturn:

1. **Spinoza:** God is the ultimate reality, revealed through Thought and Extension
2. **Schopenhauer:** Arbitrary Will is the ultimate reality, revealed through our noumenal grasp of the human will

3. **Santayana:** Matter is the ultimate reality, known intuitively by an “animal faith”.

The Life of Reason

Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it.

Reason in Common Sense

Santayana’s first masterpiece was his *Life of Reason*, which addressed the role of reason in Common Sense, Society, Religion, Art, and Science. It is impossible here to summarize such a wide-ranging work. It suffices to point out how expansive the Life of Reason is. Unlike some narrow conceptions that would exclude Religion, or even Art, from the Life of Reason, Santayana addresses all the important manifestations of human life. Moreover, the Life of Reason covers history and political science and cannot be restricted just to science and technology.

Hence a commitment to the Life of Reason benefits from the three rings of Saturn. Ultimately, Reason leads to Love. For Spinoza, the intellectual love of God is one’s highest achievement. Santayana likewise points to the necessity of Love, although not in such lofty terms.

Animal Faith

That there is a world, that there is a future, that things sought can be found, and things seen can be eaten.

Skepticism and Animal Faith

We are born in the midst of a world; there is no objective and detached standpoint from which we can view the world. Animal Life precedes the Life of Reason. The above quotation applies both to animals and

humans. Moreover, there are unexamined assumptions that Santayana makes explicit. For example, a belief in the existence of the material world and the reliability of the senses.

All that makes sense in itself. He is making explicit one of the inner wits of the Medievals, the one that C S Lewis translates as “estimation”. Yet as much as Santayana insists that he is a materialist, he can be read, or perhaps creatively misread, as an idealist as I am wont to do. Why stop at our assumptions about the material world, since we can continue to play his game.

The philosopher has faith in the rationality and intelligibility of the world and the trustworthiness of human thinking, otherwise he would not bother with detailed intellectual studies.

Can we leave out the religious mind? If there is reason in religion, then religious faith is just as certain and “a priori”, that is, prior to any possible proof. Do we doubt the perversity of the human condition, the sense of a fall from a higher state, the desire for salvation and ultimate liberation?

Realms of Being After elucidating the Life of Reason and our animal faith, Santayana then turns to existence, which comprises four realms of Being (the Realm of Truth adds nothing to this discussion). He believed he was creating a new system of philosophy, but all he did was rearrange traditional metaphysics.

Essence is the first realm. What we know are essences. This is what he owes to Plato; Schopenhauer likewise considers essences to be fundamental. Arguists will emphasize the differences. Yet if we have a faith in the objective reality of the world, then such differences must needs be verbal, not real.

Matter is fundamental or primordial. It is Being itself. However, its various arrangements do not speak for themselves, but only through essences.

Spirit is the third realm. Santayana seems to mean consciousness. So we see the unavoidable issue. Matter and Spirit are variations on a theme, whether the attributes of Extensions and Thought in Spinoza, or the two Cartesian substances. Santayana presumes that matter creates spirit, or consciousness. Hence, a human person arises, lives a life for no particular reason, and then passes away into oblivion. Santayana denies that Spirit has agency; hence it can only be the passive observer of the material flux.

The esoterist can gain insights from the rings of Saturn. The Realm of Essence corresponds to the Divine Intellect (or Buddhi), the Realm of Matter to the Gross Body, and Spirit, or the real I, to the human state.

Posted on 2021-04-30 by Cologero

6.3 Philosophy Around the World

Hermann Keyserling Once a prominent philosopher, **Hermann Keyserling** is largely forgotten today. His philosophy was oriented toward freedom, action, elitism, reaction, and anti-rationalism. Apparently Evola met him in person at some point, but took a dislike to him. I wouldn't be surprised since Keyserling was a bit pompous. After all, he had achieved some worldly success; in those days, philosophers like Keyserling and Henri Bergson could actually get large audiences for their lectures ... not necessarily that the people were smarter, but probably because the philosophers were better. Nevertheless, I've recently learned that these frequent debates in our time about religion and God provide a prosperous income for the debaters.

Although I have never read any of his philosophical works, many years ago I found his two volume work *The Travel Diary of a Philosopher* at a used bookstore. He had made a journey from Europe through the Near East, then India, China, Japan, across the Pacific on a steamer, then across the USA, finally returning to Europe. I recall feeling some envy

that he could do such a thing. Keyserling was born to the landed gentry, so he had an independent source of income to support such a journey. He was drawn to philosophy after reading *The Foundations of the 19th Century*, by Houston Chamberlain. That would set him on the path of German Idealism, with the grand style of covering vast swaths of history and geography in his writings.

It is not easy to summarize the travel diary, since it is a collection of disjointed impressions without any sustained argument. Keyserling was actually quite sensitive to the best features of the cultures he encountered. In particular, he was interested in the philosophical and religious traditions of the countries he visited. However, his interest was not in the practices, dogmas, and metaphysics of those traditions, but rather in their effect on their adherents. We may say, in other words, that his interest was in the races of the soul of the various peoples.

The American Ideal Keyserling had mixed feelings after his 3000 mile journey across America. His comments are probably why American exceptionalists despise European intellectuals. For example, he writes:

Not freedom so much as arbitrariness predominates in America—the arbitrariness, not of one, as in Asiatic despotism, but of every individual, which is not better.

The will of the people expresses itself on the whole as the rule of incompetence.

The emancipation of the spirit has led first of all to the rejection of all inherited wisdom—to immorality, positivism, nihilism—philosophies which are infinitely more foolish than those handed down from times of greater limitation.

Erecting Barriers He points out that Americans desire freedom without understanding what freedom really is. Keyserling points out that Traditional order reflected a divine reality. The differences between men

are real and cannot be legislated away. Overturning all traditional order can only lead to self-destruction. Perhaps this, and subsequent passages, gave Evola the idea for his metaphysical positivism.

The desire for freedom is awakened generally before recognition is ripe, before it is aware of what it means, how it is expressed, and this necessarily brings with it temporary coarsening and superficiality. The New World illustrates this state of things with terrifying clarity. The Americans have understood less than anyone else that, *if the barriers which were imposed from without are to be removed, this is not for the purpose of dispensing with barriers altogether, but that they must give way to others which have been chosen freely*. They do not want it as yet to be true that the traditional orders among men, however conventional in detail, express realities; that differences in the age of the soul, in character, in talent, and even in inherited position, are something just as real as the differences between chemical elements, and that no God, as long as he remains in the sphere of nature, can act contrary to its laws; they want to be free without taking empirical reality into account.

The consequence is that life, instead of becoming more self-determined in a wider frame, loses its autonomous nature progressively. In the most modern democracy actions are determined mechanically to a degree which never existed under ancient tyranny: there, at any rate, something living took the decision, good or evil; here accident decides, the force of circumstances, the conjunction of events; here life is absolutely dependent on inorganic forces, as the ignorant chemist is dependent on the sweet will of his ingredients; if an explosive is compounded by his blind hands, he is blown up. But this experience had to be gone through.

The Future of the World Yet, he feels that the world may become more like America, if only as the battleground for the triumph of the

spirit:

The spiritual part of man is strengthened in battle, and unfolds itself all the more completely and freely, the more resistance is overcome. Thus our present materialism is verily the guarantee for our future spirituality. The suitable body for this has already been prepared in America of today. Humanity of tomorrow will undoubtedly live in an external condition which will resemble most closely that of the United States. It will not recognize any rigid forms, and will allow absolute self-determination to everyone. It will, in rising above all nature, and in taking account only of what springs from the spirit, even realize the ideal of equality.

The Obscure Urges

Some day or other, democracy will have been overcome. Then, however, it will be revealed, to the surprise of many, that humanity was conscious once more, in following its obscure urges, of being on the right track. That lack of outer barriers which conditions tyranny and barbarism in America today will grant to a humanity of the highest inward culture the corresponding frame of life. Humanity will have acquired so much knowledge by then that its attitude to the soul will not differ from our attitude to nature. It will countenance psychic facts in exactly the same way as material ones; it will grant the man who inwardly is on a higher level the higher external position as a matter of course, without strife, well aware of the fact that it is just as senseless to decide a man's value by majority vote as to decide the question of the existence of Selenium.

This passage seems odd to me, since humanity has already acquired as much knowledge as is necessary. I am not so sanguine that the inner nature of men will be so visible, simply on the principle that the lower cannot understand the higher. Keyserling also claims that, at some point,

the spirit will have become so powerful, that it can dispense with tradition. Perhaps, too, Evola accepts that, since the I, surpassing all his privations, freely chooses his representation of the world.

The Pragmatic Test Although Keyserling appreciates the wisdom of the East, believing it to be superior to the West, he sees them, the Indians in particular, as unsuitable for practical life. Europeans are more practical minded; rather than seeking to transcend the world of appearances, they instead strive to manifest their ideals in the physical world. That is the idealism of the West. He points out that the divergent religions in the West can nevertheless bring about material progress. In other words, the beliefs and dogmas seem to be secondary. He proposes the “pragmatic test”, as the touchstone for the validity of an idea.

The spirit of Christianity is a spirit of practical work, for which reason it does not matter too much to what dogmatic concept it appears to be related at a given time.

The teachings of the Bhagavad Gita and Mahayana Buddhism are more profound than Christianity.

As a religion of practical action, it surpasses all others. Among Christian peoples alone the ideas of love, compassion, humanity have become objective forces, and this means that even the most imperfectly recognized metaphysical reality has been realized in appearance better through Christianity than through any other faith.

In the sphere of actual life *the best version of an idea is the one which stands the pragmatic test best*—no matter to what extent it satisfies the mind. This is the meaning of that superiority of Christianity which history has proved, however much the one-sided intelligentsia may doubt it.

The practical superiority of Christianity is the expression of an absolute metaphysical advantage: it embodies, as no other reli-

gion does, the spirit of freedom. Man, conditioned by nature can show himself free only in two ways:

- By saying yes inwardly to all events
- By taking the initiative in directing them.

Accordingly, two commandments sum up Christian ethics: that everyone should take his cross upon himself, and that everyone should fearlessly fight for the victory of good in a spirit of ready sacrifice. These two commandments really induce a life of freedom in everyone.

If the Indians, the profoundest of all thinkers, fail in practical life, this is due to the fact that they do not know how to impress their free being upon appearance.

- Instead of taking up their cross, they think of its insubstantiality.
- Instead of letting the recognition of their essential unity with Brahma, who wishes to manifest himself more and more fully in this world, develop into action by displaying initiative everywhere in accordance with the Divine will, they merely watch how God helps Himself.

The Sage and the Bodhisattva Keyserling concludes his diary with a meditation on the Sage and the Bodhisattva, concluding that the latter “embodies the aim of human aspiration.”

The sage who, indifferent to the world, only strives after the realization of God. He is not beyond name and form as yet since it is *he* who wants to see God.

The Bodhisattva has discarded this last bond. The Bodhisattva says yes to the most evil world, for he knows himself to be one with it. Rid of himself he feels his foundation in God, while his surface is intertwined with everything which exists.

Posted on 2014-07-17 by Cologero

The Foundation of the Modern World

7.1 The Metaphysics of Deliquescence

del-i-ques-cence *n* The process of dissolving or of becoming liquid through the absorption of moisture from the atmosphere.

Form and Formlessness The new and interesting artist — **Jillian Taylor**¹, in her series on *deliquescence* writes:

A container is often presented as an appealing package concealing something great inside, while it may simply be a small structure enclosing an allotted and restricted space. These simple box-like structures of confinement are the product of a given set of instructions,

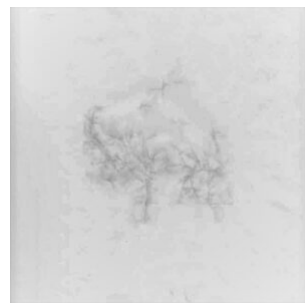


Figure 7.1:
Deliquescence

¹<https://www.facebook.com/search/top?q=jilli-art>

compiled of rigid diagrammatic lines and shapes. As each instruction is followed, a permanent fold is pressed simultaneously, and the result is an enclosed structure of folds. Echoes of one's thoughts repeatedly bounce inside their confines. In an abandonment of the given instructions, the containers are unfolded and discarded. Through the folds, a constant reminder of the followed directions, will never disappear.

A myth in the Sorelian sense is not mere intellectual assent to a worldview. It is a power-idea and, as such, is an effective motivation to action. The myth is also presented as an appealing package, which then shapes its "contents" — those who believe.

Memories begin to unintentionally fade as a result of acceptance and the new state of refinement. As the represented memories fade, the existing creases and folds begin to flatten and dissolve into their surrounding spaces. Specific moments linger, creating the potential for faded moments to resurface before fully dissipating.

So everything and everyone is placed into a container of a political correctness, then deliquesces into formlessness, taking on the shape of the container and losing any vestigial memory of prior differentiations.

Yet absolute formlessness, the equivalent of non-existence, is metaphysically impossible, so there is always "the potential for faded moments to resurface".

Posted on 2006-06-29 by Cologero

7.2 Two Incompatible and Irreconcilable Worldviews

There are two incompatible and irreconcilable worldviews.

Anti-tradition One, is the idea that humans evolved from animals and then, even within human society, there is a continual process of evolution and progress to higher stages of intellectuality and morality.

Tradition The second is that humans began in a perfected state, or “Golden Age”, but through choices there has been a continual state of decline from that state of perfection, and only a cataclysmic event can restore a new state of perfection.

Synthesis There is certainly no scientific basis for evolution or progress. If, in fact, we do seem to observe change, progress, or evolution, then its etiology lies elsewhere. For every idea or movement, there is an impetus that sets it in motion, that brings about its realization. However, over time, that initial impetus gets distorted and every movement or organisation will tend to decline even to the point of turning into its very opposite. That is due to the common unconscious state of humanity. Nevertheless, it is possible at certain key moments in the process — and time is qualitative, not quantitative == that another conscious impetus can be applied to bring the process back into alignment. This can only come about through the activities of a conscious elite.

Posted on 2010-09-12 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2010-09-13 at 11:53 said:

Guenon, if I understand him, thought that the movement within each cycle was the product of a confluence of opposite currents, ascending and descending, as it were. But I don't think the positive movements were able to completely reverse or halt the overall cyclical movement.

At the end of the cycle [Judgment Day] the positive remainder [the Qabalistic klippoth] would be passed on to the new cycle; this was the function of the elite, for Evola. But I don't believe even he thought there could be an ultimate, or permanent, “reversal” of the cycle. At best, the elite might survive the cataclysm and pass into the new cycle [the Earthly Paradise].

Cologero on 2010-09-13 at 19:36 said:

"That is due to the common unconscious state of humanity"

You could start by Evola's description in *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*. There are several references on Gornahoor.

Or Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin on the Man of Torrent (In the stream): Men without will-power and little individuality, who follow the way of life in a given epoch without bothering about anything except their elementary needs.

Gurdjieff on the man as asleep.

Guenon on men dominated by a modern ideology who are unable to recognize higher dimensions.

You take on the moniker of a Hermetist: How do you view the Great Work?

Cologero on 2010-09-13 at 19:57 said:

There are movements that have their own course within a part of the entire cycle. Guenon's model gets complex as he described in the Symbolism of the Cross, but there the point is not the regeneration of the Earth, but an entirely new world. I'm not sure what you mean by currents. Guenon has written about the gunas, but there are three, not two.

Nevertheless, there are still possibilities within a cycle².

James O'Meara on 2010-09-14 at 18:34 said:

"I'm not sure what you mean by currents. Guenon has written about the gunas, but there are three, not two."

I can't find the quote right now, but I think he was in fact talking about the gunas as features of cosmology. However, even with three or more gunas, they would act together in various combinations or 'strengths' [today, for example, raja would hardly dominate] to produce an overall direction or vector. If the cyclical descent could be compared to a curling stone, the various forces, gunas, magical chains such as the UR group proposed, counter-traditional forces, etc, would be the sweepers in front, speeding up or retarding, perhaps even slightly reversing the movement of the stone, but never bringing it to a halt or sending it back up.

²I addressed Guenon's viewpoint here: <http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=35>.

7.3 The Truth is far from Suspected

Be assured, savants of the world, it is not in disdaining the sacred books of nations that you show your knowledge, it is in explaining them. One cannot write a history without monuments and that of the world is no exception. These books are the veritable archives wherein its deeds are contained. It is necessary in exploring the venerable pages to make comparison between them and to understand how to find the truth, which often languishes there covered by the rust of ages.

FABRE D'OLIVET

In our task to identify the sources of the “formidable mental deviation that characterizes the modern west” [**Rene Guenon**], I took one for the team and endured a “debate” on youtube between the two Christophers — Hitchens and Hedges. It was advertised as the contest between two worldviews: the scientific one represented by Mr. Hitchens and the religious by Mr. Hedges, although, in point of fact, they more or less agreed on everything. What is more remarkable, however, is their unexpected, and probably unwelcome, agreement in many respects with *séance* meeting spiritualists as described in Renen Guenon’s *The Spiritist Fallacy*.

There is no value in getting involved in such debates if only for the most basic reason that it assumes a common intellectual plane for such a debate to occur. Nothing could be further from the truth since what would be necessary is the questioning of fundamental assumptions. The religious point of view in that debate involved too many disparate and incompatible notions; to do it properly would require the translation of the religious dogmas to their metaphysical equivalents. Only then could there be a fruitful discussion apart from the obvious difficulty that few would be capable of engaging in such a discussion for a variety of reasons.

The modern worldview represented by the Chrises must start from the assumption that the past is no more than a period of darkness, igno-

rance and depravity that can only be redeemed by modern ideas. Regarding the study of the past, Guenon writes:

History, as officially taught, limits itself to exterior events, which are only the effects of something deeper; and it sets these events forth in a tendentious manner under the influence of all the modern prejudices. And further, there is a veritable monopoly on historical studies in the interest of parties, both political and religious.

The Hermetic method of doing history as described by Fabre d'Olivet, whose influence on Guenon is undeniable, is quite different. To grasp the world of the ancients expressed through their sacred scriptures requires a deep understanding of their essences which is revealed in their homogeneity rather than simply in the outward events described. To disdain those writings and neglect their truths is to limit oneself to the parochialism of the present. Even more than Guenon, who mined such texts for their symbolic and metaphysical value, **Julius Evola** made use of myths, legends, and sacred texts to discern the worldview of the ancients. Regarding the deprecation of that worldview or the deliberate ignorance of it, Guenon writes:

This falsification of history seems to have been accomplished according to a set plan; but if this is so, and its essential aim has been to have public opinion consider this deviation as 'progress'. everything seems to indicate that it must be the work of a directing will. . . . in any case, it can only be a collective will, for there is manifestly something that goes beyond the sphere of activity of individuals considered in isolation.

First of all, let's be clear about the more or less common opinions held by the modern mind. It is characterized by appeals to humanitarianism, moralism, or sentimentalism, rather than anything properly intellectual. They envision a world of pacifism, universal brotherhood, various

“rights”, liberation, and so on, all to be brought about in a more or less distant future. All of this is couched in the guise of “progress” and “evolution” and allegedly backed up by science. Guenon describes its effects:

One can hardly imagine the seduction that grand words offering a false semblance of intellectuality exercise ... This is a kind of verbalism which provides the illusion of thought for those incapable of really thinking; it is also an obscurity which passes for profundity in the eyes of the common man.

There is little chance for intellectualism to gain any headway in this discussion. To those accustomed to live only by their passions and their arbitrary “likes”, a commitment to the intellect seems oppressive to them, rather than the true liberation that it is. The appeal to Tradition is associated with the defects of the known past. On an emotional level, that can only fall short of the imagined glories of the unknown future.

What is really curious about all that is how that modern worldview arises as the conclusion of disparate premises. For example, spiritualists and the “new atheists” come to the same conclusion, although the latter abjure the former. New Agers, liberal Christians like Hedges, socialists, and so on all agree on that worldview. In other words, it matters little the exterior religious or philosophical allegiance, so long as the result is the same. This leads Guenon to this suspicion:

If one does not believe in chance, one is forced to admit the existence of some kind of equivalent of an established plan, but one which evidently does not need to be formulated in any document. Isn't the fear of certain discoveries of this kind one reason for the superstition of the 'written document' as the exclusive basis of the historical method? Starting from there, all that is essential necessarily escapes investigation.

Once again, we see that understanding history requires determining the essence behind the appearances. Since that cannot be determined from

written documents, it is rejected by “official” historiography which is based on texts. Hence, any mention of a “plan” is ridiculed as a conspiracy theory. This is exacerbated by the fact that most people are merely the unconscious instruments for the plan’s effectuation, so they can plausibly deny it. Of course, Guenon is not some simple-minded conspiracy theorist. He elaborates:

It is impossible to believe in the spontaneous production of movements of any importance. In reality, things are more complex than we indicated; instead of a single will, we should envisage several intentions as well as several results; there could be a whole special dynamic in this, whose laws would be interesting to ascertain ... the truth is far from being generally known or even suspected.

Posted on 2013-01-02 by Cologero

* * *

Jason-Adam on 2013-01-02 at 23:40 said:

I'm currently reading Fabre d'Olivet's book right and clearly see the huge influence it had on Guenon & Evola – though obviously more on Guenon.....

In studying the history of ideas one needs to understand that the person said idea usually had an end in mind beyond innocuous speculation....by discovering the hidden ends and means we unravel history.

7.4 The Future They Hope for

What inspired Teilhard de Chardin, and inspires his followers, is a certain unitary view of reality, a joining of God and the world, of the spiritual and the secular, into a single harmonious and all-encompassing process which can not only be grasped by the modern intellectual, but can be felt by the sensitive soul that is in close contact with the spirit of modern life; indeed, the next step of

the process can be anticipated by the modern man, and that is why Teilhard de Chardin is so readily accepted as a prophet even by people who do not believe in God: he announces, in a very mystical way, the future which every thinking man today hopes for.

FR. SERAPHIM ROSE

Since we never got to the actual debate between the Chrises yesterday³, we can try to mention the main points. Neither of the men are very deep or careful thinkers. As Fr. Rose points out, they share a common vision of the future, something they “feel” more than “think”, despite their radically different starting points. They are the heirs of currents of thought that began centuries ago, which they now accept uncritically.

The best thinkers, those who laid the foundation for the modern world, dig down to the roots of thinking. By rejecting Euclid’s famous fifth postulate, geometers were able to create alternative geometries. In an analogous way, certain thinkers rejected one or another of the fundamental concepts of Traditional metaphysics, and drew out all the consequences thereof. We have provided the examples of Francis Bacon who rejected formal causes, Spinoza rejected final causes, and Nietzsche proclaimed the death of God. They are not necessarily the conscious agents of change; more likely, they simply can’t understand, or intuit, the point of traditional teachings.

Over time, the professors pick up these ideas, their students accept them uncritically, until eventually certain ideas enter the public realm; the conclusions are adopted although no one any longer understands how they came about. The common element is the revolutionary idea and opposition to the status quo. Several years ago, a secular friend married a spiritualist. She told me she was an “iconoclast”. I recall that I thought

³See Section 7.3 in this book.

it was quite a strange thing to say. I pointed out that her husband was a real iconoclast, but he didn't have to boast about it. That ended that friendship.

I wonder how she feels now that the revolution is firmly in control, so it makes no sense to smash the idols. Of course, like the ancient Hebrews and Greeks, mere victory is insufficient; every man, woman, child, livestock, and edifice must be destroyed. That is why the modern mind is so rabid and intolerant of any opposition to their imaginary future.

When someone argues very emotionally and illogically, you can be assured their point of view has little validity. That is Christopher Hitchens. Unlike Nietzsche's atheism, with its attendant transvaluation of all values, Hitchens' new atheism is rather tame, and actually unnecessary to his point of view. As we pointed out, his anti-clericalism and progressivist view is common to spiritualists, new agers, and others who may not share his atheism.

He does not think deeply, but instead begins in the middle with unexamined assumptions. A frequent theme is that religions are man-made creations. From a certain perspective, that is true especially if history is considered as no more than the examination of written texts as Guenon points out. What Hitchens doesn't mention is that scientific theories are likewise man-made creations, subject to change and refutation. Unlike religious texts, a scientific text can claim no higher authority, so it serves as a shaky basis for a worldview. Of course, that worldview claims that knowledge is progressive; so if it is admitted that what science teaches now is incomplete or even false, why should we accept anything now?

Hitchens' main point is that he adheres to a higher morality. He thinks that because he is under the illusion of ordinary life and simply cannot conceive a contrary point of view. The deeper question is why be moral at all? Morality makes no sense in his atheistic worldview. One can only be moral out of habit, inculcation, or from blindly accepting the imperatives of one's genetic programming. He fails to grasp that his

moral and political views have no necessary connection to his atheism and belief in science.

He rants quite a bit, all in support of a progressivist worldview and in opposition to all religions which he lumps together. Of course, he does not allow the opposite, refusing to be linked to the nefarious actions of other atheists. He was obsessed with the treatment of menstruating women in Jewish law, but his point is unclear. While we don't think it right to banish such women from the public square, it is certainly not something to embrace. But that brings up a point. If you accept the premises of evolutionary biology, then feelings of revulsion must have a survival value. Nevertheless, he seems to praise practices that evoke such feelings in normal men.

There is a final point. Science is based on careful study of the past, from which hypotheses are derived. For example, Tycho Brahe spent decades tracking the motions of the planets; that allowed Kepler to formulate his laws of planetary motion. Similarly, the understanding of human nature, as a science, must begin with the study of history, from which an anthropologist can propose general laws. Since the future is everything to Hitchens, he departs from true science by ignoring the past. He proposes, in his utopian vision, revolutionary changes in social arrangements, changes which may never have been tried in the past. A real scientist, it seems to me, would be much more cautious about advocating such changes without first understanding all the ramifications.

Hedges was a non-entity as the foil. The only remnants of his Calvinist background that he retains is a dour personality and a belief in total depravity. Apart from that, the two Chrises agree on the revolutionary future. Hedges sincerely believes that the religious right is the greatest danger in the USA. In actuality, the religious right has been politically ineffective as they lack the intellectual chops to oppose the revolution effectively. For Hedges, they are nevertheless the tattered remnants of throne and altar, or the windmills of imaginary fascism that he thinks he

is jousting.

Posted on 2013-01-03 by Cologero

* * *

Mihai on 2013-01-04 at 10:09 said:

It seems to me very relevant that the only people from the religious "side" who are called to such debates are protestants and neo-protestants or at least progressive types in general—such as Vatican II Catholics.

Since you mentioned Fr. Seraphim, he is very accurate in pointing out that Christians with an evolutionist/progressist worldview are extremely immature in thinking that simply adding God to the whole evolutionist paradigm "solves" the problem. I've read even the statements of an orthodox monk who thinks there is no problem with darwinian evolutionism as long as one puts God as the cause of the process.

Certainly, Christians who think like this, especially the ones who spend extended time with Scripture, like the monk above, suffer from a certain "hardening" of the intellect when making such statements. And I am not saying this as an insult or an exaggeration. Clearly they did not spend a single moment to trully ponder the implications of such a worldview. For example: can anyone explain to me, in the light of evolutionism, the first 11 chapters of Genesis ? Or what is the purpose of the birth of Christ, who came to halt history's decline, if we are to accept no such decline, but on the contrary, an unconscious and impersonal evolution ?

And what about the description of the end times, which are represented as a period of utmost degeneration ?

Matt on 2013-01-04 at 12:03 said:

Mihai,

That monk may have been speaking about evolution (genetic change) without the neo-darwinian framework attached to it that disregards formal and final causes. However, if he is speaking about it with the framework in mind, then yes, the problems are merely pushed to the side.

Michael on 2013-01-04 at 14:56 said:

Mihai,

Of course you know the problem is that virtually all scientists teach the evolution of man. Do you believe that the theory of evolution will one day fall into disfavor as we learn more about our past?

Mihai on 2013-01-04 at 16:27 said:

@Matt: Genetic change is one thing and evolutionism is another. Of course, these two things are confused with one-another, or people falsely assume that genetic changes “prove” evolution, which is why we have this problem in the first place.

@Michael: The problem is not about the study of the past. It is about the worldview. Evolutionism was the dominating paradigm of the western world way before Darwin formulated his theory. This is not a scientific fact, it is a philosophical formulation. The large public (and indeed many scientists) cannot tell the difference between these two domains and this is why evolutionism is at the very hub of the modern mentality.

Cassiodorus on 2013-01-04 at 16:33 said:

I've been reading some interesting material featuring the on going debate between the Intelligent Design community and Thomist defenders of theistic evolution. I finally understand the difference: the ID people have largely accepted the premises of the materialist's mechanical philosophy whereas the Thomists staunchly remain true to immanent teleology and Aristotelian formal and final causes.

I keep wondering if there is something about Scholastic moderate realism that made the surrender to nominalism something of a forgone conclusion.

Cologero on 2013-01-04 at 23:56 said:

“I keep wondering if there is something about Scholastic moderate realism that made the surrender to nominalism something of a forgone conclusion.”

Perhaps in the sense that non-Euclidean geometry is the conclusion to Euclidean geometry. There is no logical connection. Nominalism is the forgetting of the ideas. For the Scholastics (and beyond) to know is to know the essence or idea of the thing. When that no longer makes sense to anyone, nominalism is the result.

Noct on 2023-01-03 at 10:30 said:

Evolution cannot be real because the greater is not derived from the lesser, it is the same narrative of the tower of Babel and progressivism in general. Pretending to reconcile religion and modern science is an absurdity that only leads to the corruption of traditional understanding by giving ground to materialism.

The ape is not potentially a man, and to involve God as an explanation of the process is to ignore causality for a simple evolutionary bias. God does not magically add new genes, mutations cannot mean a qualitative progression, every actualization depends on an already existing potentiality. The lesser does not contain the greater, but the greater always contains the lesser. Species do not evolve, but degenerate.

7.5 Francis Bacon and the Creation of Modernity

It is our contention that great events in world history are deliberately planned; nothing happens at random, and things happen for a reason. To understand such reasons is the very definition of intelligence. The beginnings of the modern mind were found in the anti-metaphysics of nominalism. But it was **Francis Bacon** who sketched out the intellectual lineaments of modernity and, in the process, redefined what it means to be an “intelligent” man. His definition still holds today among the university educated and is even absorbed unconsciously among the masses.

Bacon lays out his plan in the Great Instauration, an ironic reference to Ephesians 1:10, “to instaurate everything in Christ”. We must not be deceived by Bacon’s pious language and Biblical references which are included to mask his true intentions, as the consequences of his method had to have been known to him. To deny that is to deny Bacon’s intelligence; Bacon was anything but unintelligent. The consequences of his plan will be the denial the supernatural from any understanding of the world. Bacon reveals his purpose in the Preface:

That the state of knowledge is not prosperous nor greatly advancing, and that a way must be opened for the human understanding entirely different from any hitherto known, and other helps provided, in order that the mind may exercise over the nature of things the authority which properly belongs to it.

1. **Problem:** The state of knowledge is not advancing.
2. **Solution:** A way of knowing entirely different from anything in the past.
3. **Benefit:** The mind exercises its authority over the nature of things.

The attack on Tradition is made head-on. The Traditional view is totally opposed.

1. There can be no advancement of Traditional knowledge.
2. There is nothing new under the sun.
3. The nature, or essence, of things has its authority in the mind of God.

Bacon masks his intentions by claiming to be returning to the Primordial State, when Adam was given dominion over the world. But Adam's naming of the animals was an act of recognition, a remembering of their nature or form. Bacon, despite his protests, takes on the Satanic project of replacing God, so that the new man is now the arbiter of forms. This is not a moral judgment, but rather a description. To know what a thing is, is to know its sufficient reason. The Western Tradition lists four causes to explain a thing or event, as shown in Table 7.5.

Cause	Description	Question
Material	What something is made of	
Formal	What it is	What
Efficient	How it came to be	How
Final	What is its purpose	Why

Table 7.1: The traditional doctrine of four causes

Bacon takes his stand against this schema by first rejecting the final causes. He explains why:

I am laboring to lay the foundation, not of any sect or doctrine,
but of human utility and power.

Hence we see that everything must be in service to human utility and power. If anything has its own reason for being, that is, its formal cause, then its usefulness for human ends is no longer the prime consideration. He then rejects the notion of formal cause:

Matter rather than forms should be the object of our attention, its configuration and changes of configuration, and simple action, and laws of action or motion, for forms are figments of the human mind, unless you call those laws of action forms.

Can it be said more clearly? Only matter, its configurations, changes, and actions are to taken into account. There is no hylomorphism and hence the natural world is not the reflection of the supernatural. There is a subtle change in the notion of the efficient cause. It no longer refers to the essential and internal relationship between forms, but rather to the accidental and external relationship between material configurations. Now Bacon calls the alleged intuition of forms a “figment of the imagination”. This is why we insist that debate is pointless. If a man can see the forms, or ideas, it is no figment; otherwise, it may as well be. Philosophical discussion can make the concept plausible, but only gnosis can prove it. Let us make a point in passing. The laws of action or science are not the forms. Scientists often claim they are reading the mind of God; however, this is not true, since the forms are in the mind of God.

We can briefly mention the consequences of the line of reasoning instaurated by Bacon. First and foremost, the function of Reason has been radically altered. In the Traditional view, it is the defining quality of the intellectual soul and its goals is complete understanding of the Logos. For Bacon and his successors, Reason has simply an instrumental value, as a tool used to accomplish human ends. This reaches its ultimate conclusion in Nietzsche when the will to power is pursued for its own sake, not simply for human betterment.

Not only are things considered configurations of matter, but so also is human society. Without a common understanding of final causes, there

can be no rational discussion of how to achieve the common good, since the idea of the good is no longer common. Thus, every socio-politico-economic decision becomes a battle for power, with so-called rational discussion being just a means to an end.

Without any understanding of formal cause, the power to define “what is” is left to man, so it too becomes a contentious battleground. The end result is the hermeneutics of suspicion, so that any attempt to explain events is regarded as a deliberate deception with hidden motives. Thus, what started out as the desire to redefine Reason, ends up in total irrationality. **QED**

Posted on 2011-11-26 by Cologero

* * *

Boreas on 2011-11-27 at 12:15 said:

A good and thought-provoking post! It brought to my mind a few things, especially the notion about “a satanic project”. Bacon truly represents – together with Machiavelli and the like – the humanistic ideals of many satanists out of whom many aspire to be “world-embracing geniuses”. When understood in this sense it really does look like that Anton Lavey was right in saying that very many (modern) men are “satanists” without knowing it themselves, that is, they reject the idea of the supernatural and God & wish to increase man’s power and knowledge for its own sake and over the natural world. The “funny” thing is that there are a lot of those who see themselves as pious christian believers and see this “satanic project” as man’s – “the crown of Nature” – manifest destiny appointed to him by God.

This also brought to my mind the fact that historical christianity is the father of God-denying atheism and the progressive messianic belief of transforming (“saving”) the world, which is a historicist and horizontal perversion of the idea of spiritual evolution, salvation and liberation. From sphere to cube?

I just read Bacon’s biography and there was a mention of him belonging to the Freemasons, and there were also suspicions of him belonging to the Rosi-crucians. While the first one seems to be an established fact and no cause for wonder, the second one sounds a little strange, at least if were talking about the true Rosi-crucians.

Cologero on 2011-11-27 at 22:14 said:

Good insight, Boreas, and the Lavey quote was on the mark. The easy way out is to assume that Satan is pure and easily recognized evil, but that is far from the case. Voegelin described what you call the historicist and horizontal perversion as “immanentizing the eschaton”. Interesting claim about historical Christianity fathering its own demise. I’ll try to relate that to Solovyov’s discussion of development.

Boreas on 2011-11-28 at 04:57 said:

You may also want to take into consideration Gurdjieff’s ‘law of octaves’ and Evola’s notions about the reason why Christianity has been relatively easy to attack and out-throw, while the more metaphysical (instead of theological / scholastic) systems of Hinduism, Buddhism etc. – despite their internal schisms and modern corrosions – have remained more intact and above modernist & rationalist criticism. The degenerated Atlantis always resides in the far west.

Logres on 2011-11-28 at 08:58 said:

Didn’t Bacon even write something entitled “New Atlantis”?

Count Cagliostro on 2011-11-28 at 17:10 said:

Excellent post and very insightful comments!

Would you care to elaborate on the statement that “historical christianity is the father of God-denying atheism...horizontal perversion”???

To my limited knowledge, Krishna, Bodhisattva and Christ embody the Savior archetype, which is obviously indispensable to the founding of every religion.

Boreas on 2011-11-29 at 03:30 said:

“Would you care to elaborate on the statement that ‘historical christianity is the father of God-denying atheism...horizontal perversion’???”

As I understand it, Christianity in its historical manifestation was the first religion and tradition that emphasized the historical – that is, temporal – role of Christ as a messiah. Christianity “temporalized God”, so to speak: God became man so that man might become God, the Word became flesh etc.

Christianity was also the first religion to exoterise (emphasis here) the monotheistic conception of the world, which could not lead to anywhere else in the popular mind and among the masses of humanity than to the irreconcilable dualism, antropomorphism, and via these eventually to the deistic, a-theistic, and naturalistic aberrations, the first one denying God’s absoluteness and omnipresence, the second one God / divinity, and eventually naturalism denying transcendence and the conception of sacred itself, via “solidification” leading to rationalism, rationalistic science and to the enlightenment – and so on. Yet, *mutadis mutandis*, the last ones still bear in themselves the conception that the world is to be transformed by man and man can

do this, yet in these world-outlooks by rationalistic, mechanistic and scientific means. In this way the Christian conception of spiritual salvation and apotheosis was transformed by the 'terror of history' (Eliade) into the liberal myth of progress. Man must conquer the world, because Man is God!

This is a short summary and by necessity a simplification, but I hope this satisfies you, Count Cagliostro.

As a further reading I could recommend you Marty Glass' excellent and poetic analysis 'YUGA – An Anatomy of Our Fate'.

<http://www.sophiaperennis.com/books/eschatology/yuga/>

logres on 2011-11-29 at 22:51 said:

Not all Christian theologians have let it go unnoticed – the Lutheran theologian Walter Kunneth wrote *Theology of the Resurrection* specifically to emphasize the ahistorical "mysterious" pleroma of Christ, as over against both Bultmann (existentialists) and the fundamentalist/neo-orthodox movements.

Boreas on 2011-12-01 at 10:36 said:

Yes, there has of course been and are men and women who understand the a-historical nature of the Christ and the corresponding teachings. Neither do my previous posts try to deny the eschatological and historical importance of Jesus, it has only been largely misunderstood and distorted very badly.

One thought came to my mind about this "satanic" nature of Bacon & co. Could it be conceivable that the appearance of the "accuser" and "opposer" of this kind was in a way unavoidable, because (exoteric) Christianity has conceived Satan also quite unilaterally as "the devil", which is one part of the dualistic problem.

There is also the nagging, unsolved problem of theodicy which theological thought is very badly equipped to solve with its own means, since it is also still in the grips of unrecognised dualism. This may be one of those reasons why the more metaphysical systems have remained more intact; they acknowledge the importance of cosmic evil in the world process and in the great economy of the universe. (From this should not be drawn the conclusions that 'evil is good because it is necessary'. This leads to a very downward path.)

Boreas on 2011-12-01 at 10:43 said:

Typos abound, sorry for that.

I forgot to mention in the previous post that maybe the world is slowly but steadily moving to a more balanced view in this matter, once the age of Saturn starts to loom in the horizon and the Sun moves closer to Capricorn. Most fortunately this is not even a blink of an eye in the

cosmic time scale, although in the viewpoint of a temporal consciousness it seems sooooo far ahead (Saturn again!).

Eric on 2011-12-04 at 17:52 said:

I like the post, it was informative, and I'm sympathetic towards your views, but your conclusion is weak.

If human society is merely a configuration of matter, that in no way precludes various moral theories such as virtue theory (the good is defined as those actions which concord to cultural virtues – which are defined according to that culture), or Kants moral theory, which merely looks for universal action in the light of reason to judge moral acts, even Hume's emotionally inspired moral theory is not dependent upon a notion of God.

Your final comments, "The end result is the hermeneutics of suspicion, so that any attempt to explain events is regarded as a deliberate deception with hidden motives. Thus, what started out as the desire to redefine Reason, ends up in total irrationality", are particularly weak, there is no necessary connection between a Godless worldview without forms and the 'hermeneutics of suspicion'. I'd like you to elaborate on why you think it *"must"* be the case. As previous said, cultural norms can be the final appeal by which virtues are decided, why do you think that option, as well as the aforementioned Kantian and Humean options are irrelevant?

Cologero on 2011-12-04 at 20:46 said:

Eric, there is no claim about precluding "various moral theories". So who cares about accumulating theories? The point Gornahoor has been trying to make in many different ways is that if there is no objective morality, that is, a legitimate way to determine justice, then power is the only way to resolve disputes of justice. That is far from a "weak" conclusion, it is absolutely logical. If there are multiple moral theories, then how does a polity decide which one to adopt? Obviously, there is no rational way to choose one. Hence, it is personal preference or whim.

If there are multiple moral theories, then each one will have different results in practice. These will result in one group or another benefiting. Hence, the hermeneutics of suspicion because of the necessary distrust that engenders. If there is no "necessary" connection, it is only because one of the parties is too ignorant or gullible. So, it must be the case; it certainly is the case. How can it be made more clearly?

I don't believe the post claimed that morality was dependent upon the notion of a God, but rather on the notion of formal and final causes. Kant and Hume can come up with all the incompatible moral theories they like, but how do you convince someone to be moral at all? A moral theory is dependent on the notion of good ... what is good, what is justice? I know what a good score in golf is, so I can act accordingly. Golf has rules and a purpose. But how do I know what a good life is? or a good polity? That requires I know the purpose of my life, of human life, of social life.

Relying on cultural norms is circular reason. In a multi-culture, which is the situation nearly everywhere today, it is a recipe for civil strife.

Leonardo Cavalcanti on 2020-09-08 at 08:49 said:

Of course it is logical, Cologero, and there is an entire book to demonstrate this point, by Alasdair MacIntyre called *After Virtue*, after the notion of finality was abandoned, the understanding of ethics went downhill. This is obvious, but people become emotional about this, they don't want to find out that the modern institutions cannot be trusted, well, many people are afraid of the truth, that's why they deny it.

7.6 Cultural Marxism

As for the modernists, it is necessary to invert the positions and even tell them, “they are the latecomers”; that up until their futurism it is a traditionalism or it is condemned to a short expiration date to become such: that which they consider as the future being only of rather elementary and infantile forms of traditions or liberation, in respect to a truly constructed new epoch, whose creator will be neither the petty bourgeois reactionary nor the promoter of cultural Marxism and the new art, but rather the man of the living Tradition.

JULIUS EVOLA, *Sui limiti del bolscevismo culturale*, La Vita Italiana, February 1938

Long before anyone had heard of the Frankfurt School, **Julius Evola** wrote about **cultural Marxism**⁴. In this essay, which I am summarizing, Evola distances himself with his youthful, pre-Guenon, flirtations with Dadaism, futurism, and the anarchism of Max Stirner. This is his definition:

⁴*Bolscevismo culturale*

The expression cultural Marxism designates a whole of manifestations in the fields of literature, art, thought, science and, in general, culture which, even when they lack any relation whatsoever with Marxist and communist political propaganda and even when their creators or promoters don't think they are exercising any political influence, equally measured by their direct or indirect effects, preparatory forms and ferments of ethical and spiritual decomposition are revealed, and their ultimate consequence can only be Marxism.

Spiritual Decomposition The expression "cultural Marxism" is very apt since it tacitly implies the conviction that political Marxism would not be possible without a preliminary disruptive action in the heart of culture where, with a sure glance, the germ of Marxist evil is identified even where it still acts only in abstract domains, exterior to the specifically social, political and governmental spheres. But these same germs, that is, cultural Marxism in its contemporary forms of manifestation, are considered more as visible symptoms than as the ultimate cause of the evil.

The undoing of an organism with the liberating of the forces that it had held in a unity and with the appearance of new forms of life tied to its putrefaction is not the cause of its death, but its effect, standing at the center a fact that is spiritual at its base. Equally things stand about what we can call the culture of decomposition and this analogy is not only artificial but offers an important base for the considerations that we intend to develop here: one of the most characteristic aspects of the decomposition is the passage to the free, elementary and impersonal state of force and processes, which, before the crisis of death, had obeyed a higher law and figured in the synthesis proper to knowledge and will of a "person".

Social Aspect There is, first of all, a social aspect consisting in tendentially emphasizing all the cases in which ideals are presented as illusory, values as pure convention, institutions as unjust and defective. Corresponding to that, this culture emphasizes the higher right of life, instinct, the irrational, the purely “human” and, in a certain special domain, creates the new superstition of the subconscious, the unconscious, the libido and primigenial eros as the true root of existence and the human person. It is absolutely superfluous to name names. The theatre, the novel, the new psychology, even certain forms of biography and interpretations of history, in any case, cinematography and even the economy are today the organs of action and the dissolving influence in this sense.

Moral Aspect This social aspect is naturally inseparable from the moral aspect of cultural Marxism. The constitution of love and sexuality in forms of true obsession is a fundamental point and not just the direct effects should be considered, which are, for example, practical immorality, the sensualization of life, the breakup of the family, the debasement of the institution of marriage to a social convention and utilitarian contract, revocable by a stronger claim of instinct or temperament, and so on. But we must also consider the indirect effect of the reaction, constituted by moralism, whose attention, if only from the opposite side, is equally obsessed with eros and no longer manages to recognize any truly higher point of view.

Main Forms

Important forms of cultural Marxism are the collectivization of life and sensibility, mechanization and finally the unleashing of elementary forces. There in certain of its aspect, these tendencies lead to an anarchist liberation of the Self and subjectivity, in other of its forms we see a veritable destruction of the human element, of the feeling of all that is individual and tied to its own proper

quality. In a certain measure, it is about the repercussions of an environment in which technique has determined, close to a fatal premise of standardization and leveling, the principle forms of life, sensibility, and taste.

Decadent Art Alongside technique, Evola mentions modern art. Evola points to modern music which

puts the pure symphonic element over the melodic in a way that leads either to the unleashing of pure rhythm (Stravinsky) or the breakup of so-called atonal music (Schoenberg)

As for pop music, he singles out African influenced music, or more generally, the savage element, which involves not just the snobbish connoisseurs, but

rather the great masses of the entire world, which in the syncopated forms of rhythm, in the motifs of jazz where precisely the essential is formed by the primitive, by pure sound texture in forms of an automatic and obsessive repetition, we find rather more than in any of their traditional music.

How that would apply in particular to pop music is left to the reader, much of which is pure rhythm and no melody, even among those who claim Evola as an inspiration. In pictorial art, he points to the “liberation of”

- pure color (post-impressionism)
- pure form (cubism)
- pure dynamism of pure sensation (futurism)
- pure incoherency (Dadaism)

As for architecture,

the elementary and rational are associated in a single front that chooses for its ideal the functional style of the machine and tries to liberate constructive forms from every residue of decoration, of traditional estheticism, and of the artistic will.

The Traditional Conception In order to understand the deleterious effects of cultural Marxism, Evola first makes clear the basis of Tradition.

According to the traditional conception, every organization is based on a dualism, on a polarity:

- on one side there are the forces of the **cosmos**, that is of order, form, conscious personality;
- on the other side, there are the forces of **chaos**, unleashed nature, instinct, the subpersonal.

The symbolism of the ancients attributed to the former a divine, luminous, heavenly character and to the latter, instead, a dark and demonic character. The organization needs both these forces, however in a combination according to which the forces of chaos are constrained, ordered, formed and liberated from their primordial nature by the forces of the cosmos.

Such a transformation has various levels, and such levels correspond to as many planes and, in certain civilizations, to as many castes of the hierarchical ordering. At the highest point, this transformation has the human personality appear directly as the virile, regal, and dominating carrier of pure spiritual authority. At the next plane, there is already a residue of elementariness, but it receives the form proper to the warrior, the aristocrat, the military chief: it is the warrior-aristocratic caste. Still lower, there is the bourgeoisie and finally the working mass, which, in this traditional order, also has its ritual mode of living that, for example,

is clearly visible in the ethical and even religious character of the ancient guilds.

The Essence of Marxism

The essence and meaning of Marxism and communism is lost on those who do not know how to see in it not an isolated phenomenon and a type of unexpected perversion, but rather the last episode of a series of destructions and subversions that, for the successive levels, have overwhelmed the higher formations of the general hierarchical ordering and, reaching the plane of the masses, have led them to a definitive liberation from every superior principle and there to a unleashing that had to make its immediate expression of a bursting out of the substrate of chaos, of elementariness, and of an obscure materiality that previously had been constrained and formed by higher forces. And so that a purposeful light rises on the fact that in Marxism the ultimate products of the western ideological disintegration meet with the primitivistic, confused substance of a people who, like slaves, have never had the benefit of a true formation and traditional articulation.

Posted on 2011-08-18 by Cologero

* * *

logres on 2011-08-21 at 20:23 said:
I wonder if Gramsci had read Evola?

I on 2011-08-22 at 14:19 said:

When a tree grows old, it begins to rot from the inside. Many trees seem to stand to old age even when they are already dead within. When a tree finally falls and starts to decay in the soil, moths and other forms of dissolutive agents appear to finish the tree. The most dangerous form of a tree is the one that stands even while it is wholly rotten inside, and a friend of the whole will support and even help to hack it down before it falls destructively and uncontrollably.

A new tree rises only after the process of dissolution is finished, when moths and fungus' disappear. Some forms of fungus live in harmony with a tree. A reasonable amount of destructive & dissolutive agents is an essential part and a requirement for the health of the whole biosphere.

Logres on 2011-08-22 at 21:17 said:

Doesn't most cultural Marxism masquerade as a "new whole"?

Discrimination of unhealthy ideas

8.1 Spinoza and Einstein

The mind is its own place, and in itself can make a heaven of hell,
a hell of heaven.

SATAN

I believe in Spinoza's god, who reveals Himself in the lawful harmony of the world, not in a god who concerns himself with the fate and the doings of mankind.

ALBERT EINSTEIN

All things excellent are as difficult as they are rare.

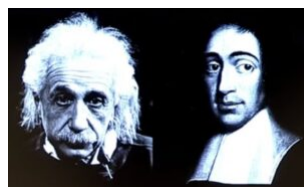
BENEDICT SPINOZA

There is a meme going around social media based on the alleged philosophical views of Spinoza. Moreover, the claim is reinforced by reference

to Einstein's approval of Spinoza. The text is ridiculous, but that hasn't stop anyone from repeating it verbatim.

Of course, they have as much chance of understanding Spinoza's *Ethics* as they do of understanding Einstein's General Theory of Relativity. On the other hand, they do understand this lousy version of hippy philosophy.

My issue is with the meme creator. What kind of person — call him X— has such little intellectual integrity? Clearly, he has not read or understood Spinoza, yet he feels confident to fabricate quotes. Why not own up to it as his own philosophical view, rather than that of Einstein and Spinoza.



Here are some obvious bloopers:

Unlike X, Spinoza did not believe in free will. Quite the contrary, he claimed that man is driven by forces of which he is unaware and therefore keep him in bondage.

X seems to get it: "I [i.e., God] filled you with passions, limitations, pleasures, feelings, needs, inconsistencies... free will." But he draws the wrong conclusion. As long as you are motivated by those things, you are the opposite of free.

The goal of *Ethics*, therefore, is self-knowledge, which does not come easily. If God does not judge you, then you need to judge yourself:

have you ever really observed yourself consciously and uncritically and looked at yourself from this absolutely neutral angle where no self-justifying or excuses count? Or are you all the time taking yourself as yourself and thinking it is the only way to take life?

MAURICE NICOLL

X believes in sexual excess, nowhere to be found in Spinoza. Why not,

then, food excess. Why not praise gluttony or bulimia. After all, the God of X implanted the enjoyment of food as well as that of sex.

Moreover, unlike X, God does not interact with humanity, nor does he love anyone. The task is the opposite: the highest end of the person is the “intellectual love of God.”

X says: “I am beating within you.” Au contraire, mes amis, Spinoza believes in the Unity of Being. “You” are merely a part of God, a part of the world process.

X inadvertently reveals the true source of his philosophy:

You are absolutely free to create in your life heaven or hell.

That is precisely Satan’s philosophy as revealed by **John Milton** in *Paradise Lost*.

Fake Philosophy Did you know that when Einstein gave lectures at the numerous US universities he was invited to, the recurring question that students asked him was: Do you believe in God?

And he always answered: I believe in the God of Spinoza.

The ones who hadn’t read Spinoza didn’t understand...

I hope this gem of history, serves you as much as it does me:

Baruch de Spinoza was a Dutch philosopher considered one of the three great rationalists of 17th-century philosophy, along with René Descartes in France, and Gottfried Leibniz in Germany.

Here’s some of his wisdom:

God would have said: Stop praying and punching yourself in the chest!

What I want you to do is go out into the world and enjoy your life. I want you to enjoy, sing, have fun and enjoy everything I’ve made for you. Stop going to those dark, cold temples that you built yourself and say they are my house! My house is in the mountains, in the woods, rivers, lakes, beaches. That’s where I live and there I express my love for you.

Stop blaming me for your miserable life; I never told you there was anything wrong with you or that you were a sinner, or that your sexuality was a bad thing! Sex is a gift I have given you and with which you can express your love, your ecstasy, your joy. So don't blame me for everything they made you believe.

Stop reading alleged sacred scriptures that have nothing to do with me. If you can't read me in a sunrise, in a landscape, in the look of your friends, in your son's eyes... you will find me in no book! Trust me and stop asking me. Would you tell me how to do my job?

Stop being so scared of me. I do not judge you or criticize you, nor get angry, or seek to punish you. I am pure love. Stop asking for forgiveness, there's nothing to forgive. If I made you... I filled you with passions, limitations, pleasures, feelings, needs, inconsistencies... free will. How can I blame you if you respond to something I put in you? How can I punish you for being the way you are, if I'm the one who made you? Do you think I could create a place to burn all my children who behave badly for the rest of eternity? What kind of God would do that?

Forget any kind of commandments, any kind of laws; those are wiles to manipulate you, to control you, that only create guilt in you. Respect your peers and don't do what you don't want for yourself. All I ask is that you pay attention in your life, that your consciousness is your guide.

My beloved, this life is not a test, not a step, not a rehearsal, nor a prelude to paradise. This life is the only thing that exists here and now, and it is all you need. I have set you absolutely free, no prizes or punishments, no sins or virtues... no one carries a marker, no one keeps a record.

You are absolutely free to create in your life heaven or hell.

I could tell you if there's anything after this life, but I won't... but I can give you a tip. Live as if there is nothing after... as if this is your only chance to enjoy, to love, to exist. So, if there's nothing, then you will have enjoyed the opportunity I gave you. And if there is, rest assured that I won't ask if you behaved right or wrong, I'll ask. Did you like it? Did you

have fun? What did you enjoy the most? What did you learn?...

Stop believing in me; believing is assuming, guessing, imagining. I don't want you to believe in me... I want you to feel me in you when you kiss your beloved, when you tuck in your little girl, when you caress your dog, when you bathe in the sea.

Stop praising me, what kind of egomaniac God do you think I am? I'm bored being praised, I'm tired of being thanked. Feeling grateful? Prove it by taking care of yourself, your health, your relationships, the world. Express your joy!... that's the way to praise me.

Stop complicating things and repeating as a parakeet what you've been taught about me. The only thing for sure is that you are here, that you are alive, and that this world is full of wonders. What do you need more miracles for? Why so many explanations?

Look for me outside... you won't find me. Find me inside... there I am beating within you.

Spinoza.

Posted on 2021-06-25 by Cologero

* * *

Michael M on 2021-06-26 at 09:46 said:

"Spinoza believes in the Unity of Being. "You" are merely a part of God, a part of the world process."

I have been examining this in my own experience, I found Guenon's Symbolism of the Cross helpful and timely.

"In each being envisaged in particular, this spark of the intelligible Light constitutes, if one may so put it, a fragmentary unity (an expression inaccurate if taken literally, for unity is really indivisible and without parts)."

My understanding of what Guenon goes on to say is that the Man, in his proper term, will then reflect the properties of Being given that he is of Being, though from the view of manifestation it can appear that Being is "within" him so to speak. (Micro/Macrocosm being displayed)

This meme creator says consciousness needs to be a guide and as much as I want to give X the benefit of the doubt, he seems to bank on the error, well put by Barfield, that everyone has

and has had the same consciousness throughout history and is somehow on equal footing to talk about God, let only some life “philosophy”. How is it that the modern mind, understanding how infinitely small it is even in just a material sense, can find itself capable of trying to juxtapose what God would “say” in the form of a dead man’s name?

30 blows on the head would be too compassionate for this one.

Sylvan Savant on 2021-07-14 at 00:22 said:

I quite wanted to retch while reading that alleged “Spinoza” shitpost. If the quote cited here is the best he can come up with, it’s no wonder the devil has been overtaken by Mammon and Elon Musk.

I mean it’s such a low hanging fruit that it can only appeal to the Gen-X American consumer mentality, which the adversary realized had run its course. The great temptation of the future will not come from this hedonistic sappy nonsense, but from the human desire to see truth and justice raised to the absolute in the social environment. The subtle whispers will that one be making into the ears of future Savonarolas and Hitlers, the seekers of ruin in the name of justice.

Dimitri on 2023-03-26 at 19:10 said:

Would you recommend reading Spinoza or could he be skipped?

Cologero on 2023-03-28 at 19:05 said:

Skip him, unless you have a lot of free time.

8.2 Hermit Crabs and Nietzsche

Perspectivism and the Human Race *Part I of a series.*

Hermit crabs don’t have a shell of their own. Since that makes them vulnerable to predators, they have to scramble to find empty shells left behind by gastropods. As they grow and no longer fit completely within their current shell, they once again are forced to go out and find a better fitting shell.

Ideation We find this also in the human being. Naked and vulnerable, with no real identity of his own, he goes out in search of a shell, which in this case, takes the form of an ideation: a conceptual scheme,

system of thought, religion, philosophy, political theory, and so on. As his new “home”, it offers protection, shapes his identity and he defends it with vehemence.

Such ideations are thus viewed from the perspective of each crab. As such, it seems perfectly reasonable and true to the crab. **Perspectivism**, as developed by Kant, is the philosophy that no such perspective is definitively true. Nietzsche developed this further and claimed each perspective is the manifestation of the “**Will to Power**”.

So, rather than evaluating perspectives from their truth value, they should instead be evaluated by how much Power they manifest. Thus, a lower type of man, will adopt any old shell that he comes upon. Not thinking too much about it, he accepts his perspective as a given, usually on some sort of authority.

A more “thoughtful” person, hence with more power, is more selective. Having heard of higher ideals, this person looks for an ideational home that resembles those ideals. For this person, appearance trumps reality. Not fully understanding those ideals, he takes on the pose of what a spiritual person should look like, or a Christian, or a liberal, or a “cool dude”, and so on.

Still higher types of men are the creators of ideational frameworks, and operate on a more serious level. These frameworks aspire to be rational, coherent, and evidential. Since few people are able to follow a logical argument, achieve consistency in thought, or make the effort to learn the facts, this approach appeals only to a few.

Predators A predator, thus, is anyone who is a threat to destroying one’s ideational home. The third type will use the tools of debate to ward off a threat. So we see millions and millions of words defending one position and attacking others. The more skilled are able to take these arguments many levels deep, but ultimately, they end up in a stalemate. Some ideological systems, such as Marxism or Freudianism, are able to

account for contradictory events, so no factual evidence is able to refute them, hence their appeal.

The middle type is forced into a more emotional response. They will use ideals of “love” or “compassion” to counteract threats to their self-image. Usually, they promote a non-judgmentalism, which prevents threats from coming up in the first place. This group feels safe and secure among each other, and conflicts are reduced to the personal level, not ideational. Since coherence is not valued, different and even incompatible ideational schemes can be tolerated not only within the group, but even within a single individual. This gives the ability to ward off intellectual threats, but simply shifting one’s own intellectual framework.

Resentment Threats to one’s ideational “home” or worldview give rise to resentment. If an ideational threat cannot be counteracted with a logical argument, or diffused with a claim to a higher spirituality, then resentment arises. This may take the forms of contempt, hostility, or even physical conflict. In some cases, one is forced to give up one home for another; this is called a “**conversion**”. Converts are valued in ideational battles.

This happens despite the fact that they are all hermit crabs. There is a **forgetfulness of Being** or primary reality, which is replaced with the self-identification as a particular “shell”; thus one lives in an artificial or **second reality** created by thought.

Man of Tradition The Traditional man lives free of illusion (not to be confused with cynicism or misanthropy). Although, as a being manifesting in the physical world, he necessarily has a perspective, he understands them for what they are. He remembers himself and knows who he is, transcendent to any ideational scheme. Instead of resentment, he has a sense of *noblesse oblige*¹ towards others. Understanding the difficul-

¹<http://dictionary.reference.com/browse/noblesse-oblige>

ties and efforts required to “know oneself”, he has compassion for those unable or struggling to achieve that state. However, he also understands he cannot make the efforts for them.

Part II on the Will to Power is forthcoming.

Posted on 2010-07-18 by Cologero

8.3 Everything else is a Pastime

One can call the whole of experience false, illusory, nonexistent — but whoever experiences and asserts this falsity, illusion, nonexistence cannot himself be false, illusory, nonexistent. Beyond the obliqueness and fluctuation of “things that are and are not”, there is then one single certainty: the “I”. Only here the individual, with possession, has an absolute and self-evident reality.

JULIUS EVOLA, *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*²

New Age spirituality claims that if we rise — or better said, evolve — to our “higher selves”, our lives will be full of Light and Love, we will all be “One”, there will be no judgment of morals or lifestyle, and we will manifest abundance, perfect health, wonderful “relationships”, and so on. New Agers furthermore claim that the world is in our consciousness and if we would only change our consciousnesses, the world would instantly improve. With such a wonderful sounding and easily accessible agenda, it is curious that the results are so meager.

The New Age is actually based on distortions and misunderstandings of Tradition. The common view raises some unanswered questions.

- What is consciousness?

²<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=187>

- If all is consciousness, then who brings about the change?
- How does he bring about the change?

Consciousness

Existence is only real when it is conscious to somebody.

CARL JUNG, *Answer to Job*

Consciousness refers to what we are aware of, either virtually or actually, that is whatever is experienceable. In other words, consciousness is the phenomenal world. What we call the objective or external world is what we experience through the senses: sight, hearing, touch, smell, taste. This is the realm of “becoming”. Clearly, then, a change in consciousness is tantamount to a change in our world, that much is true. However, unlike New Age teachings, there is not a “cause and effect” relationship, and it is certainly not so simple as it sounds.

Besides the external world, there is an inner world of experiences, such as emotions, thoughts, imagination. What New Agers really mean is that a change in imagination will result in a corresponding change in the external world. This is not a cause and effect relationship, but considers that the “universe” or the “subconscious” will somehow bring about the change. Clearly, this is impossible, or else everyone would win the lottery every week, or every teenage boy would be having a relationship with Jessica Alba.

Atman

The “I”, in fact, is not a thing, a “given”, a “fact”, but, essentially, a deep centre of will and power.

JULIUS EVOLA, *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*

The next question is “who desires, initiates and brings about the change.” If the world is phenomenon, then the “who” must be outside phenomenon, that is, noumenal, not a “thing”. The “who” is the constant in every act of consciousness, which is in perpetual flux. As such, it is not part of the world, but rather the silent observer of all that is. This is unobservable to scientists, who must necessarily deal with phenomenon. For the philosopher, it can only be an issue for debate, ultimately unresolvable. But for the metaphysician — and this is what distinguishes him from the philosopher — it as a definite and knowable state. In Tradition, this state has been called, *inter alia*, the Unmoved Mover, the Observer, True Will, or Atman.

Will

The explanation that *magical idealism* demands is completely different: it is *an explanation by means of action, a resolute explanation*. It is to ex-plicate, or to actuate, to make perfect: to make what is in potential pass into act, what is imperfection into perfection, what is insufficiency into sufficiency, according to a synthetic, creative, primordial process. This is the only true explanation. *Everything else is a pastime.*

JULIUS EVOLA, *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*

The next question is how change comes about in the world of becoming. This is the answer to the question of the sufficient reason for existence, or how does essence (the idea) become existence (the thing or situation). Now the idea may be experienced in the imagination, but at a deeper level, the idea is known directly by a process of intellectual intuition, beyond any sensual imaginings. But it is the Will that actualizes the idea in Existence. For the Sage, this Willing is conscious, free, and deliberate.

Otherwise, it is unconscious, determined, and spontaneous. As unconscious, the source of the Will is projected onto some other entity, such as the “universe”.

Posted on 2010-08-05 by Cologero

* * *

Matt on 2010-08-05 at 23:51 said:

Funny, I was just reading critiques about the relativistic chaos that post-modernism and structuralism/deconstruction falls into and I was thinking to myself I wonder if the contributors at Gornahoor will do a critical post of those views and sure enough you have a post critiquing something that is in many ways similar to those movements. A good post as usual mixed in with some of your good sense of humor! Maybe you'll do a post critiquing those movements in the near future, though I guess you touched on them a bit with your Descartes' nightmare essay.

Matt on 2010-08-06 at 01:06 said:

Also, I suppose it would be fair to say that the new-agers also make the mistake of confusing the Self/Absolute Principle with the cosmic process, rather than acknowledging what tradition affirms, which is that the cosmic process – the world process is I guess a more accurate statement since it is not yet a harmonious ordered unity (cosmos) but a disharmonious unity – is part of the “I”, but not the sum total and whole of the I. I think Evola made a good metaphor for the world process and all its multiple states as the I's body of experience.

Liz on 2010-08-06 at 11:23 said:

I'm finding that the more I read the less I know – very frustrating, I might add. I also think it's good to open your mind to new thoughts and new theories – want to recommend “Sun of gOd” by Gregory Sams. Look at it this way – the secret of “The Secret” was in recognizing that we live in a responsive Universe. “Sun of God” helps us understand why this is the case, which is unaddressed in “The Secret” itself.

Will on 2010-08-06 at 11:49 said:

In my opinion, most of the ‘post-modernist philosophers’ are not worth writing about. Most of them have the annoying habit of taking an idea that could be expressed in a single paragraph and writing a 200 page book about it.

Jean Baudrillard made an interesting critique of Marxism back in the seventies, revealing it as the flip-side of capitalism, but Evola said as much back in the 30s, and said it better. Paul

Virilio's works are an interesting critique of technology, but if you've read one, you've read them all, and furthermore, the language is very obtuse. Michel Foucault's works are somewhat worthwhile if you have an interest in history, but his ideas and concepts have mostly been used by the left, as he himself was a far-leftist. Not that that invalidates his ideas in and of itself, but it's a bias that comes through. Pretty much all of these guys are coming from a post-Marxist, post-Freudian, Frankfurt School perspective.

Jacques Derrida is, in my humble opinion, utterly worthless. If you want to understand 'deconstruction,' study Nagarjuna.

The only one of the postmodernists I can recommend – and with MANY reservations – is Gilles Deleuze. His book on Nietzsche is excellent, and the introductory essay to *A Thousand Plateaus* – "Rhizome" – is a worthwhile piece in the way that it outlines two different modes of conceptual thinking. But here again, there is a huge left-wing bias in most of his work, and furthermore, he likes to invent his own language (like Heidegger) and this makes studying him a very labor-intensive process.

Matt on 2010-08-06 at 15:10 said:

Will,

Yes, I'm aware of those names and what they believe, and I agree, none of them are worthwhile (besides Nagarjuna of course). It's not just the left-wing bias, but since they believe pretty much everything is a social and linguistic construct, their writings lead to that relativistic chaos I referred to in my earlier post. None of them can really give their own answers to a fundamental question of what is "being" because they define themselves and the rest of humanity by what they are not.

Tosti on 2010-08-06 at 17:50 said:

About Nagarjuna-agreed. I'm curious as to your take on the Traditional writers, specifically Schuon?

Will on 2010-08-06 at 19:08 said:

Matt, I think you hit the nail on the head in raising the "fundamental question of Being." The postmodernists all take their cue from Nietzsche. Interestingly, so did Evola, though they went in opposite directions. Whereas Evola saw that Nietzsche's philosophy represented a confused attempt at transcendence, and then sought to remedy the defects in his own work, the postmodernists go with Nietzsche's rejection of Being in favor of becoming, which from a Traditional standpoint is an error.

Beneath Nietzsche's criticism, however, was a deep spirituality which, in my opinion, failed to find a satisfactory form of expression. I don't think the same can be said for most of the

postmodernists, who seem bogged down by nihilism and relativism in a way that Nietzsche was not.

Will on 2010-08-06 at 19:12 said:

Tosti, I must confess almost total ignorance in regards to Schuon's work. My favorite writers among the first generation of Traditionalists are Ananda Coomaraswamy and Julius Evola.

Tosti on 2010-08-07 at 08:42 said:

Will,

Evola, of course. And Coomaraswamy has been most enlightening. His *Symplegades* (I have *Guardians of the Sun-door*), lays it out quite nicely. What a wonderful guidepost! Schuon has influenced me quite a bit, casting light on my understanding from perspectives I hadn't dreamed. He was possessed of both a marvelous intellect and a passionate soul. Highly recommended. My only regrets are that I can find only a few individuals in my area who are familiar with these writers.

8.4 Twilight of the Gods

Zeus and Christ, all of the inmates of the institution and all the gods in the rest home merged into one wildly incoherent super-god, but one so ancient, so grandly senile, so sweetly insane that even the grasses trembled at the very thought of his approach ... the senile god shouted his incoherent truth to multitudes, who in turn killed their neighbors and rode in bitter triumph through endless savage wars.

JANE ROBERTS, *The Education of Oversoul Seven*

In his massive volume, *The System of Antichrist*, **Charles Upton** expends considerable effort and talent in analyzing several New Age movements in terms of Traditional principles. Unlike **Seraphim Rose's** *Orthodoxy and the Religion of the Future*, a similar work which gives no quarter to such movements, Upton is more sympathetic, pointing out where the movements are somewhat traditional and where they are not. Perhaps

that is due to flashbacks as a youthful hipster when he took such ideas more seriously.

Although it is a good idea for those of a Traditional bent to comment on popular culture (if they can bear it), the purpose of the book is not clear. Traditionalists do not take such movements seriously in any case. New Agers will hardly be convinced; Upton relates that a New Age group called his views “patriarchal” to his face. Yet, **Rene Guenon** himself wrote long tracts against Theosophy, spiritualism as a religion, and even Mormonism, so perhaps it is worth the trouble. The more interesting parts of the book are the interludes in which he ably expresses his own views of Tradition.

Unfortunately, the real question of why New Age ideas have taken hold is not answered. In Guenon’s views, the New Age can be nothing but a form of degeneration. However, it can only take hold because of the spiritual vacuum in the West. In preparation for this review, I researched some of the movements on Amazon and meetup. I was surprised to see that the Course in Miracles is in the Top 10 list of Christian self-help books and that there are several meetups just in my area. The Seth books, as well as the Course, have hundreds of reviews on Amazon, including many positive stories of self-transformation.

Reality Creation While Guenon was looking to recover the primordial Ur-Tradition, New Age writers like **Jane Roberts** took Nietzsche’s idea of the Twilight of the Gods as the point of departure. As her parable in the epigraph shows, the old gods have become senile. It’s not that they are merely ineffective, but, on the contrary, when they take action, people die.

Roberts was a sci fi writer, but only became successful with the Seth books. You can think of him as Jane’s performance art or as the discarnate voice of a higher being who is obsessively interested in events on earth. I used to own a few books but gave them away years ago. I checked

again and noticed that there now seem to be a few dozen books available. Apparently Seth won't shut up.

Upton carefully goes through the material, and whenever he finds something interesting, he points out that the Sufis discovered it first. Seth teaches about the multidimensional god at the top of the hierarchy of beings. God is an idea, bearing in mind that ideas are the most real. Did not Guenon affirm that possibilities are as real as things? Hence, angelic intelligences are really ideas, although perhaps non-formal manifestation would mean the same thing.

Seth also seems to know about the degrees of existence. A being exists in multiple states which can be described as simultaneous. Seth describes this as "reincarnation" but Upton makes a better case for "transmigration" instead. That is a large topic for another occasion. Nevertheless, Guenon also teaches that a being exists in multiple states that are both simultaneous and sequential.

Seth also focuses on creativity over being. Upton objects to Seth's claim that a being strives to become more itself. It seems, however, that this is what Guenon may mean by a being actualizing all its possibilities. It is also a theme common to **Nicholas Berdyaev** and even **Julius Evola**.

What Seth is most known for is the idea that we create our own reality. Now as an absolute statement, that is impossible to accept. But in a relative sense, it is important. It is hardly a new idea, since **Plato** discussed it in the *Republic*. There we read that Er had to choose the conditions of his birth. It comes down to a question of being the active agent in our lives or of being passive in the face of circumstances.

Seth claimed, "It is quite possible to take your normally conscious 'I' into the dream state, to your advantage. When you do this you will see that the dreaming 'I' and the waking 'I' are one, but operating in entirely different environments." This is called lucid dreaming. I'll leave you with a personal story.

Last week, as I was reading this chapter, I was coming down with

a severe bronchitis attack. While asleep, I became aware of my labored breathing and wheezing. Alongside that awareness, I “heard”, or silently “said”, over and over: “You create your own reality.” When I woke up, I found that the bronchitis had cleared up.

Power and Shamanism Carlos Castaneda’s books were my favorites at one time. Carlos had to wander in the desert to find the rather dangerous shaman, **Don Juan**. Nowadays, it seems that shamans abound. I had dinner with a nice lady a few months back. She told me she had her own shaman teacher. Although she was quite interested in Gornahoor as I described it, she seemed disappointed that it doesn’t generate any cash. My sister thinks I’m a shaman, so maybe I’ll print up some business cards and sell my services. I just need to work on that shape shifting thing.

Upton takes Castaneda’s experiences as real and admires his literary skills at describing certain states of non-ordinary reality. Don Juan is a **Man of Knowledge**, and a master of Power. The key to Power is Will.

The goal of the Man of Knowledge is to avoid death by remaining conscious. This is not as far-fetched as Upton believes. There is value to being conscious at the moment of death. As an exercise, stay conscious as your breathe. Pay attention, in particular, to the exhalation. Consider that it may be the last breath you take. Can your mind withstand that shock of physical death?

Don Juan and Castaneda inhabit a world of psychic events. They are not false although we evade becoming conscious of such things. For example, the experience of familiar spirits was common to our ancestors as we’ve pointed out several times. Psychic attacks are likewise real; Guenon himself claimed to have been the target of such attacks.

Upton also objects to the idea of a “mold” for man. But that is just the Thomist form. Is that mold God? Perhaps it is just an understandable mistake, given that St Theresa d’Avila claimed that if you could see a soul in all its purity, you might mistake it for God.

Like Seth, Don Juan teaches that we create our own reality to some extent. That is the “*tonal*”, i.e., everything knowable and intelligible. The *nagual* is beyond definition; it is power. As a practice, the shaman can see the arbitrary nature of the tonal, how it is a mental construction, and thereby reach the nagual. Readers will recognize this as the Hermetic test to question all one’s assumptions. In my experience, the beginning stages of a spiritual path may feel like incipient insanity as our naïve world conception dissolves, only to be recreated at a higher level.

Upton is somewhat uncomfortable with Don Juan’s teaching of raw power. He correctly relates it to **Shakti**. That is also one of Evola’s accomplishments, to incorporate Power into spiritual life. In a Hermetic work like *Gnosis*, by **Boris Mouravieff**, knowledge or gnosis is just the first stage of transcendence. Ultimately, it will lead to the True Will.

Miracles **Richard Smoley** pointed to three books that appeared last century about what he calls “esoteric Christianity”: *Meditations on the Tarot*, *Gnosis*, and a *Course in Miracles*. Now we have mentioned the first two many times. They each insist on ties to legitimate exoteric traditions; that is what we would expect from a real esoteric teaching. The Course, although it claims to be dictated by Christ, is more ambiguous. Hence, if it has any value, then it must be read as a sort of “third testament”, perhaps along the lines of **Joachim de Fiore**’s third Age of the Holy Spirit. But that is not how most of its adherents read it.

The course consists of two main parts: a workbook with 365 daily exercises in applying its principles in daily life. The text contains the core metaphysical teaching. I need to admit here that I followed the course decades ago when it first came out. I followed the exercises carefully for a year, carrying around a little card with each daily lesson as a reminder. I am sure it has affected me to this day, not always in conscious ways. Specifically, it was compatible with my own understanding of a sort of Vedantized Christianity. Now Guenon believed he was psychically dam-

aged from his early involvement with certain occult movements in Paris. I don't think I will accept that, since there is no guilt, only forgiveness. Upton admits

There is a great deal of profound truth in *A Course in Miracles*: the uncompromising sense of God as Absolute Truth and Love, deep insight into the convoluted games the ego plays to escape this Truth and Love, and understanding that the subject/object mode of consciousness cannot directly witness Absolute Truth; the doctrine of one and only choice which is completely free, that between Truth and illusion; the primacy granted to forgiveness in the process of metanoia, that total change of mind by which Truth is chosen and illusion dismissed; the doctrine that humanity never really fell into sin, never entered into the illusion of separation from God.

After that glowing introduction, one wonders why the next 30 pages are devoted to debunking it. Like Seth, the Course gives the Self power over reality. One exercise starts with this:

I am responsible for what I see. I choose the feelings I experience
... everything that seems to happen to me I ask for, and receive
as I have asked.

Of course, if the ego says this, it is false. The goal, then, must be to rise up and experience life from the Holy Spirit. Ultimately, just as he did with the other movements discussed, Upton points out its many inconsistencies, its misunderstanding of true metaphysical doctrine, and its active opposition to the true Tradition.

Nevertheless, in a way it has served as a model for the Gnosis Study Group. We have daily exercises, it is based on sound metaphysical principles, and it is tied to a valid exoteric tradition. I'm afraid it does not generate wide interest, but what interest it does generate is intense.

Conclusion These teachings fill a vacuum that the western Tradition has lost. There is the active call to create one's own life. The shaman points out the loss of theurgy. And the course fills the need for transcendence and a concrete spiritual path. So on the one hand, the movements reviewed by Upton sometimes bring out forgotten aspects of Tradition. On the other hand, they all oppose valid Traditions in their fullness. They promise secret knowledge and cheap grace. As far as I can tell, they end up in Dante's seventh circle of hell.

Upton is intelligent enough to understand traditional doctrine and create his own religion that is not found in any typical church or mosque. It is clear that these New Age teachings awakened in him the desire for something more. That they fall short of full metaphysics is quite understandable. After all, what religious documents have clear metaphysical teachings? None. It is up to those capable of it to tease such teachings out of the symbolism.

Posted on 2015-02-19 by Cologero

* * *

rhondda9 on 2015-02-22 at 13:36 said:

I read Upton's book a couple of years ago. To me it read like a confused confession. In parts he is talking about Christianity and in other parts about Islam and it was as if he wasn't sure to which one he was committed. Then he would bring in his wife who is a Christian and it just got more and more confusing. Dante was in there too.

When I looked up Seraphim Rose, there was a book called Nihilism. There was a quote that hooked me. I cannot remember it exactly but something about the greatest denial expressing the greatest need. I have ordered the book.

Cologero on 2015-02-25 at 23:34 said:

I agree, Rhonda, but I didn't want to make it about Upton. Rose's Nihilism is worthwhile.

Cologero on 2015-02-26 at 00:03 said:

There is a Christian gnosis, theosis is ancient Christian teaching, what exactly is the "unitive way", what is the proper interpretation of panentheism (actually the position of the

Eastern churches), why did the Fathers have a high regard for hermetism (I don't accept the modern methods of dating texts), why did the ancient church distinguish between catechumens/faithful/perfect, what are the roles of the angels, and so on and on. Now JP II had high regard for Vladimir Solovyov ... what about Solovyov's relationship to gnostics, hermetism, the divine Sophia? There is an orthodox way to understand all these things, apparently and unfortunately they have been ignored or forgotten. Gornahoor as a whole is a commentary, although we prefer readers go back to the original sources.

8.5 Mental Death

Gornahoor places the fateful junction of Western intellectual history at Francis Bacon³. It was Bacon's head-on assault against metaphysical knowledge ("useless knowledge" that is not power) which signaled Western intention to abandon the medieval project wholesale. Although at various times and places, other movements had been made, Bacon's *New Atlantis* was more completely "modern"⁴ and also more suited to corrupt its age. Bacon (for instance) uses "Magic" to refer to applied science & technology, while "Knowledge" becomes essentially what we mean today as "Science". Blake's "dark, Satanic mills" were seen, prophesied, & invoked by Bacon, and in their present form. Other "seers" had conjured up similar forms, but Bacon was seminally specific. Bacon's project (for instance) is innately inherent in William of Ockham's denial of universals. Richard Weaver writes⁵:



³See Section 7.5 in this book.

⁴<http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/francis-bacon/>

⁵<http://www.nyx.net/~kbanker/chautauqua/consequences.html>

Surely we are justified in saying of our time: If you seek the monument to our folly, look about you. In our own day we have seen cities obliterated and ancient faiths stricken. We may well ask, in the words of Matthew, whether we are not faced with "great tribulation, such as was not since the beginning of the world." We have for many years moved with a brash confidence that man had achieved a position of independence which rendered the ancient restraints needless. Now, in the first half of the twentieth century, at the height of modern progress, we behold unprecedented outbreaks of hatred and violence; we have seen whole nations desolated by war and turned into penal camps by their conquerors; we find half of mankind looking upon the other half as criminal. Everywhere occur symptoms of mass psychosis. Most portentous of all, there appear diverging bases of value, so that our single planetary globe is mocked by worlds of different understanding. These signs of disintegration arouse fear, and fear leads to desperate unilateral efforts toward survival, which only forward the process.

Like Macbeth, Western man made an evil decision, which has become the efficient and final cause of other evil decisions. Have we forgotten our encounter with the witches on the heath? It occurred in the late fourteenth century, and what the witches said to the protagonist of this drama was that man could realize himself more fully if he would only abandon his belief in the existence of transcendentals. The powers of darkness were working subtly, as always, and they couched this proposition in the seemingly innocent form of an attack upon universals. The defeat of logical realism in the great medieval debate was the crucial event in the history of Western culture; from this flowed those acts which issue now in modern decadence.

One may be accused here of oversimplifying the historical process, but I take the view that the conscious policies of men and governments are not mere rationalizations of what has been brought about by unaccountable forces. They are rather deduc-

tions from our most basic ideas of human destiny, and they have a great, though not unobstructed, power to determine our course.

For this reason I turn to William of Occam as the best representative of a change which came over man's conception of reality at this historic juncture. It was William of Occam who propounded the fateful doctrine of nominalism, which denies that universals have a real existence. His triumph tended to leave universal terms mere names serving our convenience. The issue ultimately involved is whether there is a source of truth higher than, and independent of, man; and the answer to the question is decisive for one's view of the nature and destiny of humankind. The practical result of nominalist philosophy is to banish the reality which is perceived by the intellect and to posit as reality that which is perceived by the senses. With this change in the affirmation of what is real, the whole orientation of culture takes a turn, and we are on the road to modern empiricism.

Conservatives quote Weaver all the time, but nobody takes this seminal passage seriously (or indeed, seems to have read him attentively at all). George Heart in *Dogmatic Faith & Gnostic Vivifying Knowledge* actually suggests that Aquinas represents a "first compromise" by way of Aristotle's influence. Although Hylomorphism is a far cry from modern empiricism, it was a first step:

Although Albertus Magnus himself started to work at amending Aristotle's most conspicuous aberrations, he could never bring his work to completion, and he left the rest of that impossible task to his disciple Thomas Aquinas. We say "impossible" because we fully know now that Plato and his unfaithful disciple who betrayed his teachings after having spent 20 years in the Academy could never be reconciled. Origen was right when he said that Aristotle was simply a traitor.

Heart thinks that Aquinas betrayed Aristotle to attempt to synthesize Plato & his wayward student, but others were not so discriminating;

Catholics should not forget that in 1210, the Church found it necessary to issue a condemnation of indiscriminate use of Aristotle, Averroes, and Avicenna. The threat from combining things that ought not to be combined was “sterile heterogeneity”, such as can be found in St. Anselm (1033-1109).

As GK Chesterton noted⁶, the big task (exoterically) of our present generation is to conduct committees of correspondence in order to lay the groundwork for understanding what was lost, and why. A scope for action is very limited, but this is to simply put us in the same position as those who created the avenues of decay all those centuries ago – we will be forced to rethink: a man in prison has time for reflection, at last.

Posted on 2011-12-03 by Logres

* * *

Michael on 2011-12-03 at 14:59 said:

Outstanding post. What authors do you recommend to start us on the task?

Logres on 2011-12-04 at 00:41 said:

Well, one has to remember that the “Greater Struggle”

<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3005>

takes precedence, even for the fighter or the peasant, whomever they are. Because of this, Tomberg’s book has to be a good place to begin the arts of transformation of the self; Tomberg represents a continuation of the Inkling’s insight that the moral universe is opened by the imagination – that is, it is a key, because it lets us out of the modern prison. But it isn’t an end in and of itself, contra the poets. I would suggest that a Westerner include a certain familiarity with the enemy – even Orthodox monks in America study Nietzsche, if for nothing else than to help “see through” flimsy arguments supposedly made on that very basis. It would be interesting to know (for instance) where Bacon got his ideas (that was discussed a little on that post). Beyond that, I would say ANY book that helps recover the link between Christendom and the Greco-Roman/Nordic heritage is a priceless asset, and in this sense, it hardly matters where one starts. For those who are contemplative, Augustine’s Confessions or Boethius’ Consolation (my

⁶<http://distributistreview.com/mag/2011/12/two-difficulties/>

favorite). The dialogues of Plato are read by very few people, and Platonism is a strong antidote to nominalism/empiricism in all its forms. It teaches good mental hygiene. Any historical work that recasts the data into an unfamiliar but plausible shape (eg., Polyani's *Great Transformation* which debunks the golden mythos of modern capitalism to a great degree) can be useful for purging mental parasites that swarm around us on the TV, in the papers, etc. Anything to set the mind to actually ask itself questions and answer is useful. The turning point for me was realizing how bad the Reformation was, in so many ways:

<http://jcrao.freeshell.org/LouisVeillotReevaluation.html>

Tarapelli is another good Catholic political writer, as is Cortes.

Sir John Polkinghorne has done some thoughtful writing on the implications of quantum physics for religion, and vice versa, although he is not a "traditionalist" – he is, however, an independent thinker and someone who actually "counted" in the history of physics. It depends upon your field of interest, your temperament, and whether you want to be a scholar, a man of letters, or a fighter. Dante's political treatise on *De Monarchia* is reliably good, I've been told. And there is a whole slew of new scholarly works, compilations, editions, etc. out there, such as Glenn Magee's new study on Hegel & Hermeticism, which places an old Leftist favorite in a brand new light. We have to transmute, or undo, what has been done. Perhaps someone should study Bacon and trace how and where he got his concepts and twisted them, in what ways and by what means they shadow and parody truth. They wouldn't be so powerful unless they contained some measure of the truth, even to be powerful in the debased way they are. Remember what Cologero has quoted before – "the errors of the great are more interesting than the rightness of the small". Alchemy is important because I think that is what modern science parodies, or apes. Someone could do worse than begin to follow in Franz Bardon's footsteps, and read what he wrote about the Kabbalah, etc. But beyond that, any book which "calls" to you in your personal quest for truth, your hunger to escape the prison, is going to help you, by inexorable laws, even if negatively. Following footnotes can sometimes lead you in that quest. If you are specifically interested in Science & Religion's interaction, I can be more specific. Or if you tell me anything more of where you're coming, I can also be a little more specific. Personally, I need to read Evola on the Grail and his work on magic. I also need to finish Tomberg's *Meditations*, which are fabulous. What are your favorite books, and what is your "read before I die" list?

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-04 at 12:36 said:

I also love *MoTT*, it's far and away my most well-used book. I also love Sufi poetry – Bird Parliament, Rumi and the *Rubaiyat* of Omar Khayyam – and of course *The Prophet* by Khalil Gibran is a magical masterwork that even a child could read. *The Master and Margarita* is probably my favourite novel and Carlos Castaneda inspired me to become conscious in dreams. Whether fact or fiction, his journeys with Don Juan certainly fire the imagination. *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is my favourite Shakespeare play (or Bacon play as some of you probably think!) and Yeats

is one of my favourite poets. Von Balthasar's Prayer is one of the best tools for helping one to learn contemplative prayer that I know of and certain parts of Augustine's confessions have touched me very deeply and 2 Corinthians 6 is my favourite part of the Bible. From the Greeks I love the dramas and Orphic Hymns. More recently The Discovery of Heaven by Harry Mulisch is amazing (as is the film of the same name), but the best thing I ever EVER read in my life was a love poem written by God for the lost Divine feminine which generated the universe so he could try to find her :-)

logres on 2011-12-04 at 17:08 said:

Charlotte, what do you mean, conscious in dreams? Waking up inside of them?

logres on 2011-12-04 at 17:11 said:

I should also say that Chesterton and Belloc thought (think) that those who can, should go back to the land, in one way or the other. This gives an existential, practical base to the struggle which permits more independence of thought, than (say) someone whose opinions (if known) could affect their employment. Evola is still the best Western introduction for many people, I would think? Gornahoor has a lot of his essays here – the one on Falangism is good, as well as Reincarnation.

nous on 2011-12-04 at 17:12 said:

Placing the cosmos in philosophical terms represents the first fall or any dialectics that could elicit an opposite reaction, outside even of historiography. Somewhere at the point of paradisaical origins authority was over-ruled. But let me echo Micheals question: "Moar sauce."

Indeed, I commend you Logres on those examples given but what of the action orientated spirit? What recommendations can be given to those who wish to follow a direct path of the fighter (striking both inner and greater battles). I would like you or any member of the Gornahoor staff to address this important question.

I have read Franz Bardons books(achieving the goals therein if even possible beyond the 4th level is another question). Evola's operative methods in "Introduction to Magic" and "Yoga of Power" are intriguing but not final. Catholicisms mortification of the flesh is another tempting facet, as is that of the Buddhist/Zen response to "no mind" and to the perfection of ones actions. What is needed is real life engagement which is what I believe O.D founder St Jose-maria Escriva had in mind to the inter-war period of decadence he found himself in.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-04 at 19:27 said:

Yes, Don Juan's teaching to Carlos about dreaming, is in fact a useful method for learning how to 'wake up' – to become conscious with will and mind – in a dream. The Indian tells his pupil he must strive to see his own hands in a dream, which takes the pupil a long time. It took

me ten years, although I had out of body experiences often, in both the lower and higher astral, but not of my own volition until this one time. Basically one conditions one's self to associate seeing the hands with being conscious, it's a form of inner programming. Actually one could choose anything, it's the technique that's important in this case rather than the particular, as I understand it. One might equally decide to see one's feet I suppose. When this happened to me (ie, I saw my hands), firstly I note they looked very strange to me, being whiteish grey and translucent in that state it led to the vision of Genesis I mentioned above:

<http://alchemical-weddings.com/alchemical-weddings/tunnel-vision>

<http://alchemical-weddings.com/alchemical-weddings/rainbow>
more generally, the shamanic training helps to hone the faculties necessary for fruitful spiritual work, such as concentration, self discipline, dedicated endeavour, right motivation, discernment etc.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-04 at 19:31 said:

I agree with Chesterton and Belloc by the way, that's why I'm off to Guatemala in February to build a house, farm the land, keep bees etc....

<http://www.greennewworld.org/>

it's the only way forward unless we want Earth to become an inorganic sort of hell with half human half robots, weird animal hybrids, totally polluted environments etc. It'll happen sooner than people think if there isn't a significant mass turnaround in terms of commitment to saving the world

logres on 2011-12-05 at 19:06 said:

I think I may defer to Cologero on your question, Nous (and Michael, if there was more). My path is intellectual fighting, when it comes to initiative. It is difficult for me to recommend "when" or "how" unless it is already clear. You are essentially (I think) wanting an order, something that will require special gifts to institute. If I was going to recommend something, Coudreanu's Legion of the Archangel Michael might be a good place to start. It would be interesting to examine this movement in a dispassionate sense, and to parallel this study with more research along Evola's lines. I am not qualified to state anything further.

logres on 2011-12-05 at 23:04 said:

I hate adding to my essay, but I should devote something to this man:

<http://truerestoration.blogspot.com/2008/10/book-review-liberal-illusion-by-louis.html>

I don't think any effective rebuilding can occur until the insights of Christian theology are yoked with metaphysical insight (which necessarily draws on pagan elements). Essentially, as

Charlotte has pointed out, this is a matter of connecting dots in every sense of the word, which is Cologero's ambitious and noble project. If Catholic dogma could be transmuted/translated into metaphysics, and vice versa, by an elite, then the path of the fighter is made much easier, and less subject to disastrous mistakes as they struggle to bore back into their heritage from the outside. So long as one individual "hears the music" and does not bow the knee to Baal or any lesser gods, the world exists for him/her. That being would be sovereign. Like a soul who battles to save the body, or a spirit, the soul, so would that one person fight to inherit the world called earth for the Pantocrator. They would be the viceroy.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-06 at 06:09 said:

Yes, we have to know where we came from to really know where we're going – the past proceeds from the future as much as the future proceeds from the past. When I was first converted to Christianity I discovered a sublime unity – and no conflict – with classical religion, but also Buddhist and Sufi principles in a truly universal sense. Problems might come via the reincarnation doctrine, which might cause one to redevelop a soul attachment to the 'old ways' then trauma when this is necessarily severed. However consciousness of the hows and why helps make this easier to bear and it is not so difficult to put those kinds of memories back into the realm of imagination.

Gabe Ruth on 2011-12-06 at 10:10 said:

Thanks for this, it really got my blood racing. For those more action oriented, John Robb (writes Global Guerrillas) is very interesting and somewhat practical. Though I've never seen him comment on metaphysics himself (has linked to others of this bent on occasion), his thoughts on how far wrong we have gone and where we need to go jive with the ideas around here with regards to worldly steps. The whole resilient community is worth a look, though they are generally not cognizant of metaphysics.

logres on 2011-12-06 at 22:37 said:

That's a good point about "time flowing backwards".

logres on 2011-12-06 at 22:38 said:

I've heard of John Robb, & will look him up, thank you.

Perennial on 2011-12-08 at 03:51 said:

I recommend anything on the Action Francaise, which works were so action-packed I became a traditionalist just from reading a history of it! The Camelots du Roi, their seminars, their newspaper and of course the pivotal Charles Maurras were all inspirational. The Legion is excellent also, and of course anything related to the Carlists of Spain is great, although I know of

only 2 works in English. These were all action-based movements (Action Francaise says it all) and therefore an excellent study for those who wish to benefit from them as well as to attempt to rectify their shortcomings.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-08 at 14:58 said:

'If Catholic dogma could be transmuted/translated into metaphysics'

Does Rudolf Steiner go some way towards achieving this? Granted he is elliptical and strange, but he was pretty ahead of his time all the same....

Apart from that, I think this is a matter that is wholly dependent upon subjective experience, because without that one would not necessarily recognise the analogies in philosophical/theological works. Even then it depends on 'right place and right time'. I might read something one day that means nothing, but ten years later speaks volumes (or indeed vice versa).

In terms of a catholic theologian who regularly speaks volumes, von Balthasar I find outstanding. Recently this aphorism from his 'A grain of wheat' helped me to understand a very particular spiritual 'problem' or 'question' I had pertaining to one experience in particular that was both very upsetting and something for which i felt unaccountably (but profoundly) grateful. At the time I viewed it as being a certain spiritual death, so the gratitude was difficult for me to comprehend, although I did at the same time 'see' something akin to fireworks going off deep in outer space so assumed it was an occasion for some form of celebration. The extract is on my blog (it is short):

<http://alchemical-weddings.com/alchemical-weddings/integration>

logres on 2011-12-08 at 23:52 said:

Charlotte, here is a quote from what you posted:

"But if no understanding is developed, if this particular faculty is stamped out, if those who speak about faculties of this kind are put away as if they were insane, disaster is inevitable and humanity will sink in the morass of materialism. Everything will depend upon whether understanding is awakened for Spiritual Science, or whether Ahriman will succeed in suppressing its intentions..."

I've linked to Bondarev's interpretation of Steiner, which removes some of the necessary detritus and evolutionary Zeitgeist which adheres to Steiner's work (which Cologero has quite properly drawn attention to). This is almost a quote of St. Anthony – "in that time, when men go mad, they will find him who is not mad, and call him mad". Isn't this where we have arrived at? Even Phillip Rieff (a total "secularist" & Jew) could see this quite clearly. Goethe also prophesied it – "we will all take care of each other in hospitals". The stench of the mental sick bed is all around us. But I think Steiner is a piece of the puzzle, provided someone can interpret him in a less "spiritualist" viewpoint, although the "spiritualist" viewpoint had more traditional elements, then. So I think this is right, your insight here.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-09 at 05:37 said:

In answer to this question:

"in that time, when men go mad, they will find him who is not mad, and call him mad". Isn't this where we have arrived at?"

No, I think we have just been there and that now the network of the 'non mad' – ie, the pioneers – have collectively 'fought off' the assault, so to speak, and have consolidated their forces. Just. It's very early days but we're on the way back up now because a critical mass of 'seers and believers' has been reached. Only just! it's inconceivable that once the universal tipping point has been reached we'll collectively fall back into the abyss – we went through the abyss to ensure we won't go there again en masse.

Metaphorically speaking, enormous numbers of people are loaded onto the 'Mother Ship' ready for take off, mostly without realising it!

I do think, however, that perhaps more than ever these are days for prayer and focus on the joyful and luminous mysteries.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-09 at 05:41 said:

By the way I am not a diehard fan of Steiner – I agree with many of the well known reservations – it's just that I can see that he could see and am only recently starting to understand how he presented his information. He relentlessly spoke to the developing spiritualised being in us all and was fearless in risking being wrong in order to be right! Crazy wisdom....

Boreas on 2011-12-09 at 08:35 said:

Charlotte, I think you are right about the fact that "a critical mass of seers and believers" has been reached and we're heading towards a new upward pointing cycle in the longer run, but despite – and because of! – this, the current world-age is in its death throes and the world is on the verge of a third planetary cataclysm in the short run. No utterance for world peace etc. can change this fact, no matter how good-willed a man or a woman might be. (I think you know this also and this was not exactly what you were referring to, but as an semi-official voice of cosmic pessimism I had to say this!)

Here's the true "beef" of the matter: this is not a call for panic, anguish and despair, but for hope and joy. Things couldn't be otherwise than they are. The divine spirit of man is awakening again from its slumber and THIS is the very thing that is the primal cause of all that's happening – even in its negative manifestations.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-09 at 09:12 said:

Boreas yes, I think we are in agreement and I am in the mode now of being positive. I stared into the abyss from 2009 – 10 and at the time I wondered how people would cope with

what was to come, if it proved so devastating to me personally, for all my faith and hope in 'other things'. Clearly we are in a time of major, enormous change – an 'anything goes' type of situation in which all the birds are coming home to roost. The relief comes from the fact that karma is finally being faced, because as you point out, we can't move on with the new until we've moved on from the old. However I don't see that there is a need to throw the baby out with the bathwater, and we should always bear in mind that the heavenly quality of mercy 'wins' in the end. This is why prayer is still so important. I firmly believe that we should all be praying for mercy and redemption – for both self and others – on a daily basis now, as to do less would be to deny the possibility of damage limitation. Anything is possible.

There is something on my blog here about Prayer/Benediction:

<http://alchemical-weddings.com/alchemical-weddings/act-of-benediction>

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-12-09 at 09:31 said:

http://beforeitsnews.com/story/1483/117/Pope_Highlights_Marys_Role_As_Woman_Of_The_Apocalypse.html

Boreas on 2011-12-10 at 10:45 said:

You are of course right Charlotte. I never meant to mean that prayer is futile or hoping for a peaceful solution to world problems is in vain / naïve. On the contrary, I think these are the very duties of spiritual or religious people in these times.

Golgonooza on 2011-12-12 at 12:04 said:

Thanks for the post, especially the link to the Richard Weaver writing, which was fascinating. Thanks also Charlotte, for the Von Balthasar aphorism; as usual you have brought something to my awareness which chimes with what I'm currently pondering!

8.6 Perspectivism

It seems to me important that one should get rid of the All, the unity, some force, something unconditioned; otherwise one will never cease regarding it as the highest court of appeal and baptizing it 'God'. One must shatter the all; unlearn respect for the all.

Some definitions:

Naïve Realism The view that reality is “out there, right now” and that knowing is like “seeing” (see Bernard Lonergan, *Insight*). This is probably the view of the average unreflecting person. However, it is difficult to defend philosophically.

Correspondence Theory of Truth The idea that truth consists of statements that “correspond” to reality “out there”. Naïve realists usually believe this, though some philosophers accept it, too (e.g., the logical positivists). In this case knowledge is equivalent to a collection of true statements. The philosopher Alvin Plantinga describes the omniscience of God to be: “He believes all true statements and doesn’t believe any false statements.” This assumes that all Truth can be expressed verbally.

Perspectivism Nietzsche’s position regarding truth, which asserts that there is no such thing as an absolute truth, but merely different perspectives that one can adopt. We could think of truth as a sculpture, where there is no single “right” perspective to look at it. To properly appreciate the sculpture, we must walk around it, looking at it from as many different perspectives as possible. Similarly, Nietzsche insists that we should not get caught up in dogmatism, but rather look at the truth from as many perspectives as possible.

Of course, Tradition denies the validity of Naïve Realism, the Correspondence Theory and Perspectivism, for a few reasons.

1. Against naïve realism – the objection is that appearances are deceptive (Maya) and reality is best understood as the source of the appearances. This source is beyond all appearances.
2. Against the correspondence theory – this theory assumes that all truth can be known/expressed by the rational mind. However, Tradition has always insisted that there is a knowing (gnosis, jnana)

higher and more certain than the rational mind. This is clear from the Eastern Traditions. However, it used to be true even in the West. The Medieval Scholastics distinguished between the intellect and the rational mind (although they are mere synonyms today). Or they insisted that faith (which again meant something different from what it means today) is a higher truth than the rational mind. The intellect is associated with the heart — on certain French cathedrals, there are statues of headless saints holding their heads in front of their hearts (the legend of St Denis) — this symbolizes the subservience of the rational mind (head) to the intellect (heart).

3. Against perspectivism – that’s precisely the point: ultimate truth cannot be known from the phenomenal world, no matter how extensive the experience (i.e., number of perspectives). One is left only with appearances, or mere opinion. Truth can only be known by transcending the phenomenal world. This is brought out most clearly by Nagarjuna in Madhmyka Buddhism (see Murti: *The Central Philosophy of Buddhism*).

The Traditional teaching is that the phenomenal world of appearances is always changing, and so cannot be the ultimately Real. From observing the arising in consciousness of the phenomenal world, one discerns the one constant is consciousness itself. In that sense it is unchanging, since it is present in every act of consciousness, yet is not itself a part of the phenomenal world. It is also without quality – i.e., it has no color, weight, taste, etc, but is rather the source of all qualities. In that sense it is the most real – and this is the common understanding of the real as the (hidden) underlying source of what only appears to be going on.

Originally, class notes for a seminar delivered in 2004.

Posted on 2011-02-23 by Cologero

8.7 On discovering you're not an Android

The Turing test was developed to expose androids masquerading as humans. But what if humans themselves are actually androids?

Over at Gene Expressions⁷, we learn this alarming fact:

The idea that the self, or the conscious mind, emerges from the workings of the physical structures of the brain — with no need to invoke any supernatural spirit, essence or soul — is so fundamental to modern neuroscience that it almost goes unmentioned. It is the tacitly assumed starting point for discussions between neuroscientists, justified by the fact that all the data in neuroscience are consistent with it being true. Yet it is not an idea that the vast majority of the population is at all comfortable with or remotely convinced by. Its implications are profound and deeply unsettling, prompting us to question every aspect of our most deeply held beliefs and intuitions.

Although I have great respect for the intelligence and learning of scientists, they persist in being philosophically naive. Materialism leads to empiricism which leads to Kantian scepticism which leads to idealism, the very opposite of the starting point. A methodological assumption that is appropriate for neuroscientists is not tantamount to a proof of its universal validity.

Astronomy, for example, assumed that the motion of the planets could be explained by matter and the force of gravity. That assumption worked very well and astronomers built up a large inventory of observations of planetary motion. Unexpected anomalies in those observations led to the discovery of more planets beyond Saturn, which would have been inexplicable had astronomers assumed there were only six planets.

⁷<https://www.gnpx.com/WordPress/2011/07/04/on-discovering-youre-an-android/>

Neuroscientists are at the incipient stage of building a library of observations. There is a lot to do if they hope to explain all subjective inner states of consciousness by means of material electrochemical processes. But that is the first problem they face: they do not accept the reality of inner states of consciousness, but rely on what the experimental subject reports.

all those kinds of experiments have, of course, been done on human beings, tens of thousands of times. Functional magnetic resonance imaging methods let us correlate the activity of particular brain circuits with particular behaviours, perceptions or reports of inward states.

Since inner states cannot be directly observed by any apparatus, the scientist relies on the “report” of the experimental subject. Let’s say, for example, that when his neurons are stimulated a certain way, the subject reports, “I felt a pleasant sensation accompanied by a vision of yellowish colours.” Does the scientist then take out his oscilloscope to analyze the report in a scientific manner? Of course not. He relies on his own subjective experience of pleasantness and yellow to imagine what the subject reported. On the assumptions of the neuroscientist, we must conclude that when the subject’s neurons are stimulated in a certain way, the subject will then emit sound waves of a certain frequencies and duration, which will then stimulate the corresponding neurons in the brain of the neuroscientist. Maybe for Occam this seems like the simplest explanation, but for the rest of us, something rather essential seems to be left out.

A second difficulty is that, for the neuroscientist, inner states don’t really exist. This is truly awkward, since his goal is to explain the experience of inner states by bio-electro-chemical processes. But we are invited to participate in this thought experiment:

Imagine you came across a robot that performed all the functions a human can perform – that reported a subjective experience apparently as rich as yours. If you were able to observe that the activity of certain circuits was associated with the robot’s report of subjective experience, if you could drive that experience by activating particular circuits, if you could alter it by modifying the structure or function of different circuits, would there be any doubt that the experience arose from the activity of the circuits?

This presumably demonstrates that inner experiences are not necessary to produce a “report” of them. However, the human subject believes he is reporting an actual experience. The usual solution is to call it an *epiphenomenon*, that is, a meaningless side effect of the bio-electro-chemical process, much like our experience of the rising and setting of the sun. The epiphenomenon cannot exist, otherwise it would have effects. But the scientist rules that out from the start.

A third problem is the notion of truth. Material processes are neither true nor false. Those are logical, not physical, categories of thought and apply only to propositions. So our neuroscientist observes the effects of his experiments and concludes with the theory: “All inner states of the mind are the result of material processes in the brain.” He wants to convince us all that this is true.

Presumably, since a thought is an inner state, the report of a thought is the result of a material process. Let’s call the neuroscientist’s theory proposition A. So when I have a thought of A, that is the result of a material process. Yet so is the thought of not-A. So how do I determine which is true? That requires another thought: “A is true”, which is the result of a different process, as is its opposite, “not-A is true”. Hence, the scientist can stimulate my neurons and make me believe either proposition. There is no necessity to convince me by arguments. Obviously, an argument is a report that stimulates the neurons of the hearer to believe the argument, at least in those brains trained to “understand” the argument,

whatever that may mean. But very few have the intelligence and resources to become neuroscientists. Hence, we can shortcut the process and just provide them with a neuron stimulation kit. We could then provide neuron simulation kits to make users experience or believe all sorts of things. We can make everyone equally intelligent, since they would then know all true things (given the right kits), or courageous or just and so on.

I will leave the neuroscientist with another thought experiment. He will hook the human experimental subject up to his apparatus. Before each experiment, he will tell the subject what the subject will report. The scientist will then stimulate the subject's brain and wait for his report. Eventually, the subject will be convinced that the scientist's theory is correct since he is able to anticipate the subject's reports in advance. He will, won't he?

Posted on 2011-12-28 by Cologero

* * *

Golgonooza on 2011-12-28 at 05:22 said:

Again, excellent post Cologero. Another critique of the reductive materialist or functionalist theory of mind comes from Searle's Chinese Room argument. Imagine someone who knows only English sitting in a room alone with a rule book in English for manipulating strings of Chinese characters. Someone who passes a question into the room from outside in Chinese will get an appropriate answer back in Chinese and it will look to them as if the person in the room understands it. But inside the room, the person is just using a rule book to construct the characters and understands no Chinese. It is often used as an argument against the possibility of AI. But also it implies that meaning is not equivalent to the sum total of physical processes that convey it.

Cologero on 2011-12-29 at 09:35 said:

It makes you wonder, Golgonooza, about the inner states of awareness of some people. Perhaps their consciousnesses are rather bland so their theories seem plausible. Tomberg gives the example of the materialist reading a book. He believes the letters wrote themselves, then combined themselves into syllables as the result of chemical reactions of the ink. The letters and words are then nothing but epiphenomena of the ink.

Yet this way of thinking is considered cutting edge and its adherents call themselves “bright”.

Ultimately it is the result of an incorrect understanding of the Traditional notions of syntax and semantics. The materialist only accepts syntax and denies semantics. Unfortunately, that denial is not possible in practice, so semantics always creeps in ... words actually “mean” something.

This is a throwback to Hilbert’s challenge to produce an automaton that proves mathematical theorems. In effect, mathematics must be reduced to syntax alone, without semantic meaning. Godel showed that no such automaton is possible, but news travels slowly. Beyond that, of course, materialism is a continuation of Bacon’s project of eliminating formal and final causes. In this view, phenomena are what they are and have no meaning or objectivity beyond that. It is successful as a methodological assumption but not as a guide to life.

Attila on 2011-12-29 at 10:53 said:

Any system or mechanism will always be less complex than its creator.

Perhaps there is a connection between homosexuality and a this-is-all-there-is view of life – which could shed some light on Bacon’s alleged condition and his “philosophy” – abusing the term here.

Cologero on 2012-02-20 at 20:42 said:

Beyond the philosophical issue, I proposed what I believe to be a scientific test. I don’t know of any such test proposed by a neuroscientist; if there is one, I would like to know.

Sparrow on 2015-10-23 at 08:58 said:

When one considers the opposite of the materialist proposition: that psyche exists before matter and puts it into motion, not the other way around, everything falls into place. The materialist should seriously consider this, as it better explains their worldview better than their current proposition that single celled organisms inevitably evolved to have brain cells and produce consciousness. Of course, their beliefs would still be flawed, but at least a little less so.

White Rabbit on 2015-10-23 at 14:41 said:

I’ve never been a materialist but the idea that psyche is primary has always seemed counter-intuitive to me. Whether you take psychoactives or bump your head, your psyche follows matter. That needs to be accounted for.

obscure on 2015-10-24 at 01:24 said:

White Rabbit,

What most people mean by consciousness is usually too broad. Obviously one is conscious of one's body and is thus a subject receiving various internal and external bodily modifications. It would therefore be best to consider this broad definition of consciousness and then strip away everything. The only thing left is the purest intentionality; the external efficiency of which we may call will. But, what is of primary interest is simply the pure, intellectual intention which must even exclude the simplest external efficiency. Remind yourself of Plotinus' spiritual exercises involving the imaginary sphere. These types of exercises are so clear, simple and necessary for removing all of the unnecessary associations usually attached to the pure intellect. In the purest intention the concept intended and the agent intending are identical; the concept intended may be called 'Absolute Unity' or 'Universal Possibility'. The supposed problems presented by bodily modifications ought to disappear here and also the superficiality of most psychedelic drug use ought to be very apparent.

Nonetheless, it will also be clear that everything which is experienced is also a modification of Universal Possibility and therefore it is possible to subsume even the grossest phenomena we encounter through a correct understanding. But, he who attains the highest states experiences everything in the highest possible way and thus there is no need to depart from mundane phenomena in one's external activity. Indeed, everything experienced externally (including the internal sensation of the body and its affections) insofar as it is not also understood to signify something beyond itself (and is thus only taken as an external ejaculation of physical force; subjected to decay and disappearance) is absolutely mundane. So, the spiritual man does not see the mundane things because he only sees signs and so his criterion does not direct him to strange phenomena, but only to his tasks.

White Rabbit on 2015-10-24 at 14:25 said:

I concur Obscure, but when we strip away everything we strip away the particular "inner states" Cologero referred to. This is what I meant by psyche.

obscure on 2015-10-25 at 02:32 said:

The purpose of stripping away everything is to see the real ground for all of those later consequences so that one does not have crude pictorial thoughts about matter. The materialist thinks that he has the same plan in his research, but he is moving towards the periphery rather than the center of things.

To re-state this topic in another way: One must strip away the inner states in order to grasp the spiritual ground in the same way that the materialist believes that one must strip away those states in order to see small bodies impinging upon one another (or more probably the physical models of such things). The point is that he does not reach the term, but he proceeds indefinitely to collect data and conventionally organize it. His activity is justified by technological progress. Our activity, on the other hand, is only justified by spiritual experience which is necessarily less

egalitarian, less blatant, more difficult, more obscure, etc. than what is readily perceived in the techno-culture. So, only certain presentations of metaphysical arguments or valid criticisms of the immaturity of materialism can suffice from an exoteric standpoint. Under this latter aspect we see the character of Cologero's post here which has nothing to do with the spiritual 'stripping away' of inner states. Sometimes one may indicate the right direction not so much by a definite affirmation but by a negation of the contrary.

Alistair Fraser on 2015-10-25 at 21:37 said:

The chinese room argument is rationally revealing of the contradictions

Also The proposed scientific test would never be entertained = Why would the WHO expose its own limitations of understanding which is one of the most lucrative evolving "industry" in modern times.

On neuron stimulations accuracy of anything, a simple mechanical car has electrical, exhaust, fuel circuits , not to mention the hardware and software , of which a fault can develop in any that effects the whole , what makes them think humans are less complex than a simple car ?

Heres something else to think about = Today i watched an excerpt of an experiment in japan whereby a human wore one of those virtual viewers in which they could see through it to the outside world plus one more ingredient was that the computer it was attached too could input virtual influence.

So the computer simulated to the person wearing the viewer that a small green ball was sitting in the air in front of the viewer , the person then lifted their hand up to feel the ball and they confirmed they squeezed and felt it .

After, it was disclosed that the computer had actually re-represented their hand as it moved up to look like it was squeezing the green ball, but what had happened in reality was that the person had simply squeezed / rubbed their fingers together being fooled into believing it was a virtual green ball .

Now what this proved was that , as some recent studies had shown, people give priority of belief to what they see , over that of which they feel .

And i think this is a result of the electronic technological mediated world , where people have been mass-conditioned by the power of television and film to form their opinions so that their instinctive feeling power has been quietly and efficiently subordinated below their seeing faculty , just from sheer laziness , if its shown enough then it must be true , or if its shown on an official platform then it must be true

This then breeds a level of trance-induced imported certainty of opinion that cannot justify itself, and if questioned, reacts with disturbed anger at the questioner as if they be mad

Cologero on 2015-10-26 at 20:35 said:

@White Rabbit, who wrote: “Whether you take psychoactives or bump your head, your psyche follows matter.”

That’s great news WR. Perhaps you can take a drug to bring you peace, joy, happiness, and enlightenment.

White Rabbit on 2015-10-26 at 21:20 said:

That would be possible if supra-human states followed matter like any ordinary states of consciousness, Cologero. Or instead, what Guénon says about symbols, rites, ect. could apply:

“But some will ask, how is it possible that merely contingent means can produce an effect which immeasurably surpasses them and which is of a totally different order from that to which the instruments themselves belong? We should first point out that these means are, in reality, only fortuitous. The results they help to attain are by no means consequential; they place the being in the position requisite for attainment and that is all..

As for us, we do not confuse a simple means with a cause in the true sense of the word and we do not regard metaphysical realization as an effect, since it is not the production of something which does not yet exist, but the knowing of that which is, in an abiding and immutable manner, beyond all temporal succession, for all states of the being, considered under their primary aspect, abide in perfect simultaneousness in the eternal now.”

8.8 Evola and Nietzsche – 40 years later

Transcending oneself: this is the great imperative of the human condition; and there is another that anticipates it and at the same time prolongs it: dominating oneself. The noble man is the one who dominates himself; the holy man is the one who transcends himself.

FRITHJOF SCHUON

In writing about the significance of **Friedrich Nietzsche** today, it is clear that **Julius Evola** is more concerned about the significance of Nietzsche for Evola. This is actually an important question, since it is through Evola that Nietzsche has entered into Traditional thought, at

least in some circles. Usually this has had a deforming effect because Nietzsche's ideas trump Tradition; Nietzsche needs to be adapted to Tradition, not the reverse. This is what Evola tries to do. For Evola, the "figure of Nietzsche" is more important as a "symbol" rather than for any specific doctrine.

First of all, any of Nietzsche's metaphysical claims need to be rejected, and Evola never adopts them. Specifically, eternal return is a doctrine that is incompatible with the Infinite; Guenon explicitly rejected it. Obviously, Nietzsche's naturalism is not part of any Tradition, and Evola often rejected that, especially in any biological or naturalistic interpretations of the "superman".

Of course, Nietzsche's atheism is not helpful, which is related to the Will to Power. Together, they amount to the rejection of Intelligence and a Cosmic Order as the ultimate reality of the world. The world, then, is absurd, the result of the will to power. In the Traditional view, the world, too, is absurd, since it is the result of an illusion or a fall. The task, therefore, is self-transcendence, to overcome the world. Yet, Nietzsche's naturalism does not recognize any such transcendence; hence, the world can only be overcome by more power. Unfortunately, that is a Sisyphean task and can only lead to insanity. So if Nietzsche is not a metaphysician, that just leaves Nietzsche as Psychologist, Poet and Moralist.

There is no doubt of Nietzsche's power as a psychologist, in his ability to unearth the hidden motivations of the human mind and to expose hypocrisies; whence his insightful critiques of the bourgeois society of his era. However, Nietzsche's message gets distorted in the minds of the less skilled thinkers, who reason along these lines: "The bourgeois Christian morality is the mentality of the herd; I am a pagan; hence I don't practice the herd morality." This is to confuse outward labels with interiority, and to accept the false idea that joining a different tribe will *ipso facto* make one a different man. Not at all, the task of self-transcendence and self-domination still remains.

Even if for no other reason, Nietzsche's skill as a poet will keep his memory alive. He writes in a powerful, aphoristic style that tries to reach the deeper and nobler parts of our emotional life. Evola often imitates that, which accounts for his enduring appeal. Such evocations to our noble and warrior instincts are quite effective with those who would likely belong to the Kshatriya caste, although less effective on Brahmins.

That leaves Nietzsche as moralist, and this is precisely the area that Evola focuses on. Here, I'm afraid, Evola engages in a lot of wishful thinking. He even claims to understand Nietzsche better than Nietzsche understood himself. In *Revolt against the modern World*, Evola writes in a footnote:

The only modern thinker who comes close to this view, yet without being aware of it, was Nietzsche; he developed a view of absolute morality with a naturalistic basis.

What this really means is that Evola has developed a view of absolute morality, but feels it would "sell" better if people believed it really came from Nietzsche. Evola's view is actually very sound, despite his taking pains to hide its true source. It is true that modern thinkers do not come close to Evola's view, although ancient and medieval thinkers do. In his essay, Evola admits that "certain connections could even be established with ancient Stoic ethics, which likewise advocated an interior sovereignty." Once that connection is admitted, it is easy to connect it to the ancient Greek world and then to the Thomist ethics that he grew up with.

First of all, let us look at the rudiments of Evola's morality and then see how he then "improves" on some of Nietzsche's more famous images, and I'll concede it is an improvement. Evola summarizes his position best in the passage from *Revolt*:

Undoubtedly, there may have been a margin of indetermination even in the case of traditional man, but this margin in him only

served to emphasize the positive aspect of these two sayings: “Know yourself” and “Be yourself”, which implied an action of inner transformation and organization leading to the elimination of this margin of indetermination and to the integration of the self. To discover the dominating trait of one’s form and caste and to will it, by transforming it into an ethical imperative and, moreover, to actualize it ritually through faithfulness in order to destroy everything that ties one to the earth (instincts, hedonistic motivations, material considerations, and so on).

For Evola, there is a margin, or gap, between knowing and willing, that man, particularly modern man but even traditional man, has not fully willed to be who he is, or in other terms, has not actualized all his possibilities. Here Evola follows Tradition in that a man is born with a certain essence, including his caste, his sex, his family, his nationality, his race, and so on. His task, then, is to know his essence, *who he is*, and to conform his will to his being. This is opposite to modernity, which has embraced existentialism. For the modern mind, existence is prior to essences, which are then simply arbitrary, accidental, socially constructed, and often unjust qualities a person is stuck with. Modernity, thus, is implicitly atheistic because it denies a just social order.

However, Stoicism is indeed close to Evola’s view, using **Marcus Aurelius** as its exemplar. For him, the cosmos is ordered by Intelligence, or the Logos, which he calls reason, and it is inherently just. Furthermore, everything has a “nature”, and the moral course is to conform oneself to it. In particular, a man has a nature, which may differ from an emperor (Aurelius) to a slave (Epictetus). Each has to actualize his life in a different way. For the stoic, nature is what something should be, i.e., its essence, and the margin between what actually is, and what its nature is, must be closed through an act of the will. This agrees with Evola, but does it conform to Nietzsche?

Kant denied that essences, as noumena, could be known, and only

appearances, or phenomena, are known. It seems that Nietzsche goes a step further, denying essences outright, and only appearances matter. Hence, the one thing necessary is to give “style” to one’s character⁸. When Traditional man looks within, he sees who he is and recognizes his destiny to live out that life. In doing so, he first finds himself trapped in those base and vulgar impulses that tie him to the earth. So, he responds to Zarathustra, “I set myself free so I can become who I am.” Evola takes pains to show that this is not anarchy, nor the rejection of authority, as so many Nietzscheans may think “because they do not have in themselves a higher principle that commands”. This is a significant clarification of the will to power, since Evola makes clear its actual role. The will to power, the superman, or being beyond good and evil, are meaningless concepts unless they derive from “a higher sanction”.

There is the question of the margin or gap which, as we pointed out previously⁹, are an affront to a certain desire to live fully in nature. Here we mean “nature” in its contemporary meaning as whatever actually exists apart from the artifacts of man. Evola objects to the phrase, “blond beast of prey”, which seems to imply an immediate mode of existence without any such margin. It brings to mind **William Blake’s**, “One law for the lion and ox is oppression,” the precise opposite of a universal morality, or any morality at all, for that matter. There is no vice in the lion for killing the ox, not any virtue in the ox for being the sacrificial victim.

Evola also claims that Nietzsche’s call for “fidelity to the earth” is not the justification for being tied to the earth and indulging the baser motivations (instincts, hedonism, consumerism). Obviously, the meaning of Nietzsche today for many is precisely to justify those motivations; we will take Evola’s side on this question.

Finally, Evola addresses Nietzsche’s iconoclasm because it makes him

⁸https://www.gornahoor.net/?page_id=5545#Needful

⁹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5471>

appear to justify destruction and revolution for their own sake. Evola rejects the “revolution of nothing” and claims that Nietzsche is merely using rhetorical techniques to appear shocking or sensational. His real target, in Evola’s view, is really “petty morality” and “herd morality”, in order to make room for the higher morality of the superman. It should not be necessary to point out, however, that many Nietzscheans today simply stop at the point of idol smashing and immoralism, i.e., those who cannot recognize any higher principle within themselves. I suppose this is the “danger” that Evola refers to.

Posted on 2012-12-31 by Cologero

* * *

Sigurd on 2017-03-04 at 05:18 said:

What is the correlation between essence and the Kantian “noumena” here? Kant denies essence is immanent, in this sense? Is the Stoa essence the same as the Aristotelian essence?

Matt on 2017-03-11 at 16:38 said:

Sigurd,

In Kant’s system, the noumena means essence – the “thing-in-itself”. Kant denied that we can know a thing’s essence/intrinsic nature, or substantial form (to use aristotelian and scholastic terminology). For Kant, all we can know of a thing is it’s appearance (phenomenon) to us. Here, Kant breaks with the classical-scholastic tradition because that tradition asserts that we can indeed know essences, and so therefore the world is intelligible; but the implication of Kant’s position is that the world is not intelligible to us because we can never know essence (the noumena), and essence is what provides intelligibility. The world remains opaque to our understanding.

As to your second question, while I have not dived into stoic philosophy to the extent I have with Aristotelian and Platonic philosophy, from what I gather in my readings, essence in Stoic philosophy is more or less used in the same sense as seen in Aristotelian thinking.

Sigurd on 2017-03-15 at 05:05 said:

Very interesting. I did not know Kant’s noumena was the Aristotelian essence! And here I thought Kantian thought was more-or-less reconcilable with Traditionalist metaphysics vis-a-vis Evola’s influence by the post-Kantians (Schelling, Fichte), though I realize their *raison d’être*

was to eliminate the noumena by bringing objectivity and, in Schelling's case, naturalism to the Kantian thought.

Matt on 2017-03-15 at 17:53 said:

Sigurd,

I haven't read much of Fichte and Schelling, so I am not familiar with the details of their respective systems; just the general outlines. I think Cologero is quite familiar with them, though.

With respect to the idea of reconciling Kant with Tradition, while I don't think Kant's system of thought in total* (*emphasis on that) can be reconciled with Tradition, I think there is a possibility that certain elements of his thought that can be legitimately synthesized with Traditional thinking. There is a strand of Thomism known as transcendental thomism whose aim is to synthesize Thomism with certain elements of Kant's epistemology. Awhile back, Cologero posted his review of one of the main texts of its founder, Joseph Marechal. It's debatable whether or not the adherents of this strand actually accomplished this aim. Many think they failed and only created a Christianized form of Kantian philosophy. Personally, while I lean towards that assessment, I'm not closed off to the possibility that this synthesis can be done.

Sigurd on 2017-03-16 at 09:36 said:

I see. I understand Guenon criticized the West's tendency to be "systematic," and I take this to mean turning our "quantifying" gaze toward philosophy, creating some monstrous chimera full of quasi-organic axiomatic premises, some false vector that removes any quality from our experience (and I think we can refer here to something like economics), however, I am more disposed toward Western thinking than Eastern; and despite the relative non-importance of linguistic theatricism, I do think Western philosophy is meaningful if taken in its, perhaps, Platonic sense: a life, as opposed to a classification of discussion.

Well, that was quite a drawn out preface just to ask you: what philosophical system do you think best fits the Traditional mindset? First coming to the Traditionalist was interesting for me as I hadn't read anything like it before, but I also came to read the Neoplatonists and Aristotle *through* them, so perhaps it would have been more familiar than it was, as Guenon and the others *were* writing to a Western audience. Do you think something like Thomism is totally reconcilable with Tradition? And does this make Tradition philosophically and morally realist?

Thanks for continuing this discussion by the way. I'm so glad I found this website, often it feels all my Traditional interlocutors are effectively retired! It's good to see the Tradition is still alive.

8.9 Pinker the Thinker

So, how many people know how to observe? And of these few, how many to observe themselves? ‘Everyone is farthest from himself’ — every person who is expert at scrutinizing the inner life of others knows this to his own chagrin; and the saying, ‘Know thyself’, addressed to human beings by a god, is near to malicious.

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE, *The Gay Science* §335

The NY times published an article about a year ago on *Why the Fight Over Abortion Is Unrelenting*¹⁰. The answer is postulated in the first paragraph:

Why is the debate so bitter, so emotional? Part of the answer is very simple: the two sides share almost no common premises and very little common language.

Our intent, therefore, is not to debate the morality or legality of abortion, but to explore the lack of common premises and language. Nevertheless, prior to 1973, there was a long stretch of time in which there were common premises around the morality and legality of abortion. In any case, whatever changes in attitude have occurred in recent decades, the positive law cannot exceed the general moral level of the population.¹¹

Since Steven Pinker is a well-respected public intellectual today, we want to focus on his contributions to the discussion.

Health

¹⁰<https://www.nytimes.com/2019/05/29/opinion/abortion-restriction-s-politics.html>

¹¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=8578>

Health is the state of an organism in which disease and infirmity are absent. In particular, fertility is considered to be the healthy state and infertility is the inability of a person, animal or plant to reproduce by natural means. It is not the natural state of a healthy adult, except notably among certain eusocial species (mostly haplodiploid insects). (*Wikipedia*)

So apart from some insects, infertility is not the natural state of a healthy adult. Hence, artificial means to prevent the healthy state of fertility needs to be justified, not the other way around. Of course, the Times article will justify them because there may be other health concerns beyond fertility in play. Moreover, throughout history the prevention and termination of births was quite unreliable. Now that medicine has transformed that process, attitudes have changed: demonstrating once again that the material conditions of life alter consciousness.

Life The pro-life cause has not helped with the common language, due to its insistence of referring to the unborn as a baby or child. Nevertheless, for those who effing love science, the unborn is scientifically a human life. It starts as an embryo, then becomes a fetus. So a human life, in the biological sense, passes through multiple stages: embryo, fetus, infancy, childhood, adolescence, etc. That is the starting point for a common language.

The other mistake is to equate abortion with murder. Legally, there are different crimes associated with the loss of a human life by another human, depending on circumstances. Hence, abortion should have its own legal category, unless you are ready and willing to execute mothers, doctors, nurses, etc. In an earlier article, Pinker makes this point:

Mothers who kill their newborn infants should not be judged as harshly as people who take human life in its later stages because newborn infants are not persons in the full sense of the word, and

therefore do not enjoy a right to life. Who says that life begins at birth?

Pinker is using rather loose language here by confounding the notions of personhood and life. Life is a scientific category and begins long before birth. Personhood is a metaphysical category, which leads to the next topic.

The Right to Life Once again from Pinker:

To a biologist, birth is as arbitrary a milestone as any other. No, the right to life must come, the moral philosophers say, from morally significant traits that we humans happen to possess. One such trait is having a unique sequence of experiences that defines us as individuals and connects us to other people. Other traits include an ability to reflect upon ourselves as a continuous locus of consciousness, to form and savor plans for the future, to dread death and to express the choice not to die. And there's the rub: our immature neonates don't possess these traits any more than mice do.

Well that is too bad for the biologists who cannot tell with certainty what life is, thereby destroying its claim to be a serious science. What Pinker is actually asserting is the "right to life" — which depends on being a person — and not really when biological life begins. However, his definition of "person" is arbitrary, and not at all scientific for someone who claims to be a scientist.

By the way, mice do dread death which should be common knowledge.

The Will to Life The *Declaration of Independence* correctly asserts that the right to life comes from God, not from the state or the arbitrary

opinions of so-called “moral philosophers”, politicians, talking heads, etc. Every living being derives that right from its own Will to Life.

Life is being discovered in the most unlikely and seemingly inhospitable environments. In every little crack in asphalt or concrete, you will probably find some plant trying to poke through it. Even around Chernobyl, which is unsuitable for human habitation, an entire ecosystem of flora and fauna has been thriving there.

A life is never a “clump of cells” because it has a central organizing principle. That makes it a life rather than an arbitrary clump. A human artifact, on the other hand, lacks its own organizing principle; it may seem to function as a unit, but that is because its apparent unity is actually inserted by the designer.

The conclusion is that a life has value in itself, not because it may or may not have a value to others.

Genetic Health Pinker provides the evolutionary explanation for opposition to abortion:

[It] is straightforward. Humans are unusual among mammals in that men invest in their children, feeding, protecting and teaching them. As a result, a father who invests in his children will have more successful children, which favors any genes that tilt a man toward investing in his children. But of course that only works if they are his children. Evolutionarily speaking, cuckoldry is the worst thing that can happen to a man, because his investment would be wasted in protecting another man’s genes.

So Pinker confirms that opposition to abortion is a sign of a healthy genetic makeup. That is, the selfish gene expresses its impulse to pass on and preserve itself. The obvious corollary is that abortion is, from the biological point of view, akin to a deleterious genetic mutation. The genetic urge to perpetuate oneself is so strong that it controls our mental processes. Pinker asserts, without providing any evidence:

the actual thoughts and emotions running through people's brains are not about babies, cuckoldry, genes, investment or any of the concepts that enter into the ultimate, long-term, evolutionary explanation of people's motives.

I don't see how our genes become aware of complex social and political issues, even to the point of controlling thoughts. Certainly Pinker does not demonstrate a causal chain. If anyone other than Pinker had said that, he would be considered a crank. Note how the Times sneakily alters Pinker's point:

The *men* who are pressing to make abortion illegal are unaware of the evolutionary forces motivating them

Pinker said that "*people*" are unaware, unless the Times is using "men" in the generic sense to apply to human beings generally, without regard to sex. But I don't think so.

By this logic, unfortunately, the promotion of abortion must be the sign of a deleterious genetic mutation, since the genes of those people fail to get passed on. Moreover, the desires of "people" to pass on their genes, and *to not pay for the upbringing of other men's children*, must be indicators of biological health. If an evolutionary psychologist can show otherwise, perhaps he should give it a try.

Of course, there may be moral reasons that transcend biology, but then we are leaving the realm of science.

Group Consequences

A country whose population is stagnating, diminishing, or aging, creates a vacuum for younger, more active, poorer peoples. A country that no longer has children is a country that has lost confidence in itself, its culture, its history and its values.

FR. GREGORY CELIER

Decisions that seem best for an individual often have adverse effects on society as a whole. Artificial contraception is an example. It seems so reasonable to gain the pleasures of sexual intercourse without the possibility of an unwanted pregnancy; the alternative seems absurd to most people today. *Humanae Vitae* warned of the long-term consequences, including the decline of moral standards. Another consequence is the reversal of the general understanding of the purpose of sex.

Moreover, when individual decisions are repeated, the social consequence is the decline in the general population. Most European countries have a sub-replacement level birth rate, as individuals deliberately choose not to reproduce. The social upheaval that will result from this will be ongoing. Nevertheless, the individual does not, and cannot, take the societal consequences into consideration.

Anti-Life

To the woman he said: in sorrow shalt thou bring forth children

GENESIS 3:16

When the purpose of sexual activity is pleasure alone rather than reproduction, then pregnancy is no longer understood as an indicator of health, but as a curse to be avoided. The following is a tweet that had more than 50 thousand “likes”, the last time I checked.

WHY IS GIVING BIRTH SO NORMALIZED??? LIKE YOU LITERALLY CARRY A MONSTER INSIDE YOU THAT MAKES U HORMONAL FOR 9 MONTHS THEN SPLIT YOUR BODY IN HALF GIVING BIRTH?? AND LIKE PEOPLE JUST EXPECT THAT OF WOMEN????????!!!!!!

This young woman understands Eve's curse, probably better than most. Woman's sex drive is so strong in order to overcome that reluctance to pregnancy. In most if not all materially advanced countries, the birth rate is becoming precipitously low.

The Best Life Several months ago, USA Congresswoman Katie Hill resigned after a photograph appeared of her grooming a staffer while naked. She admitted to being bisexual and engaging in three-way relationships. Surprisingly, her own party coerced her to resign.

That evening, I watched a liberal commentator on TV who condemned the resignation. She defended Mrs. Hill with the interesting claim, "all she was trying to do was to live her **best life**."

I was taken aback because I had never considered a life of sexual excess and drug use as anyone's "Best Life". Traditionally, the best life has been considered a life of virtue. Now there may be disputes about the precise virtues, but they have been close enough. Katie Hill's lifestyle would never qualify.

Death and Violence One often hears, "Violence is never the solution." Obviously, that is quite untrue. Violence ends wars, stops criminals, overturns government, provides food. A youthful unwanted pregnancy more likely than not might prevent the woman from her "best life", however understood. Perhaps she would drop out of law school, or give up dreams of Hollywood stardom. Or she could terminate the pregnancy and get her life back on track.

When it is a matter of convenience or adherence to abstract principles, convenience will usually win out.

Summary The lack of common premises and languages have been delineated. One side is arbitrary in its understanding of life, genetics, physi-

cal health, pleasure, convenience. The other side is objective in its understanding of life, health, the purpose of life.

Posted on 2020-06-03 by Cologero

* * *

Tannheuser on 2020-06-05 at 12:15 said:

I've always felt that "Abortion is murder" was a cheap and inaccurate talking point. Again there seems to be no distinction between "human" (biological entity) and a "person" (a metaphysical category as you point out), which causes a lot of confusion on both sides. Canto XXV from Dante's *Purgatorio* is relevant here. The below makes a lot more sense intuitively than the ideas in vogue today:

Having become a soul (much like a plant,
though with this difference—a plant's complete,
whereas a fetus still is journeying),
the active virtue labors, so the fetus
may move and feel, like a sea-sponge; and then
it starts to organize the powers it's seeded.
Open your heart to truth we now have reached
and know that, once the brain's articulation
within the fetus has attained perfection,
then the First Mover turns toward it with joy
on seeing so much art in nature and
breathes into it new spirit—vigorous—
which draws all that is active in the fetus
into its substance and becomes one soul
that lives and feels and has self-consciousness.

8.10 Prelest and Other Dreams

By now, everyone should have figured out the meaning of my dream, which is:

Sleeping people are full of spiritual delusions. Awake men are more cautious.

This spiritual delusion is called *prelest*. This cannot be considered a rare condition, but rather it is the universal state of people. It begins with a false thought. Since the nature of error is not to recognize itself as error, a whole worldview is weaved from that thought and all its consequences. Then, one's very identity becomes associated with that worldview, to the extent that any challenge to the worldview is taken as a personal threat. That is why people become so enraged and irrational when discussing or debating worldviews. The alternatives, as in every menace to one's life, are fight or flight.

Yet, it is not death that follows from the destruction of a false worldview, but rather an awakening from a form of sleep. In our recent posts, *prelest* can be related to rhetoric. Since the worldview born in *prelest* is necessarily false, it cannot lead to being, but only to a torrent of words. The opposite is self-possession, or said differently, an increase in the level of being.

Self-possession describes facts and phenomena, hence it does not promote one particular worldview over others. Thus, it is more like an invitation to look, not a desire to debate. However, those stuck in rhetoric can only understand it as a worldview to be defeated.

Chopra's Challenge Although I am hardly a fan of Dr. **Deepak Chopra**, and am only vaguely familiar with his thought, I give him credit for offering a million dollar challenge¹² to atheists, materialists, and skeptics to explain consciousness in terms of science. Specifically, they need to produce a falsifiable, scientifically demonstrable theory of consciousness.

I've since found out that he has often debated the usual cast of characters and in a way, I prefer his approach to those of the protestants who engage in such public debates. I also found out that there are high speaking fees for debaters, up to \$80K for an appearance.

¹²<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Up6GqgBK5Qo>

Dr. Chopra is a philosophical idealist, that is, he accepts the primacy of consciousness or, as **Valentin Tomberg** put it, the subtle rules the dense. Idealism used to be philosophy proper, and was the philosophy of intelligent and educated men throughout time.

As our recent discussions of magical idealism have shown, the World can be explained by idealism, but consciousness cannot be explained by materialism.

Spark of God Despite his origins in Hinduism, Dr. Chopra seems to hold new age ideas. This is one of the most common new age beliefs, not just his: He said that he used to be an atheist until he realized that he *was* God. Similarly, men have told me that right to my face. If that is the *prima facie* argument against atheism, atheism is preferable. I do know such a claim is popular with the audiences.

Those who are more modest will say we all have a spark of God. But even that new age idea is derived from gnostic heresies. There is no point to such a vague formula, since whatever it is intended to convey is adequately dealt with through other concepts. Specifically, what of God we have in us is **consciousness** and **free will**. Hence to be more Godlike is to be more conscious and to be more free.

To summarize it, however, someone with the “spark” of God is recognizable from what he wills, since divine wills cannot be in conflict.

Children of God Another new age idea is that we are all children of God, as a birthright. I don’t know the derivation of that idea, but it is not from the Western religious tradition, and its propagation has led to all sorts of mischief. To be a child of God is a supernatural gift and requires the second birth.

Addiction to Spiritual Experience The purpose of meditation is often lost on meditators. Often its defenders will point to it health bene-

fits, such as lowered blood pressure, etc. Those benefits may or may not occur, but the purpose is not material betterment.

Hindus, due to their mechanical conception of karma, consider time spent in meditation as a sort of ransom to burn off accumulated karma. That cannot be true. Rather, the purpose of meditation is to learn how to detach from the contents of consciousness. So during the time allotted for meditation, there may actually be just a few moments of actual meditation going on. Those moments should increase in duration and intensity with practice.

There is also the possibility of addiction to meditation. Many years ago, it was my practice to meditate 30 minutes each morning. At some point, I began to experience periods of intense physical pleasure during these meditations, which are difficult to describe. Of course, this was highly motivating and I looked forward to my daily meditation practice. Over the course of several months, these experiences became rarer and rarer, and eventually stopped altogether.

Looking back, I should have written a book about it and gone on the Oprah Winfrey show. That is because people are impressed with wonderful experiences and want to know how to get them. That is a fundamental aim of new age religions. However, in my case, I knew that the goal is transcending all such experiences, so I persisted despite the resulting dryness. I don't know today if it was a little blessing for me or rather a test of resolve.

Posted on 2014-06-20 by Cologero

* * *

mohenko on 2014-06-20 at 05:01 said:

Your posts become ever more apt for my own situation, I follow the crumbs eagerly. Thank you for setting the trail.

Bill on 2014-06-20 at 10:35 said:

Your postings are very helpful to me and I find myself constantly referring back to previous posts for assistance, clarification, and inspiration. I believe you had once mentioned that you were going to limit yourself to 1000 postings. If that is correct, has any thought been given to the possibility of publishing a complete set of postings in book form once this blog project is completed?

Synodius on 2014-06-22 at 17:02 said:

A version for kindle with a good index would be very helpful...

Tosti on 2014-06-22 at 18:33 said:

Prelest is extremely common, as you suggest. Typically the sort of 'powers': siddhis, charisma, which can be seen in various spiritual practices fall into two main categories—those which develop naturally through certain exercises (these may be likened to a psychic muscle if you will), and those which are granted by proper orientation through the Grace of God. The former, which are natural enough to the authentic man, are in principle no different than any other material quality such as a rational mind, a physical prowess, or discernment through wit, and can be as dangerous as those accomplishments due to the error of pride. The latter, bounded by a proper structure and guided by reliable guides (elders), is a route much less dangerous, much less susceptible to the prelest which seems to be a very part of the modern air we breathe.

8.II Anti-philosophy and Panpsychism

A philosophy is not a court of law. It is not a matter of being right or wrong. It is a sign of great vulgarity to want to be right and yet more to want to be right against someone else. And it is a sign of the same vulgarity to attend a philosophical debate with the thought only of seeing one of the two adversaries be right or wrong. Speak to me only of a philosophy that is more resolute, or more profound, or more attentive, or more pious. Or more unbound. Speak to me of an austere philosophy. Or of a happy philosophy. Speak to me above all of a certain *fidelity* to reality.

CHARLES PÉGUY, *Note on Bergson and the Bergsonian Philosophy*

Metaphysics, properly understood, is not one philosophical system among,

and opposed to, others. Rather, it is an understanding of Being and, as such, is its own argument. Attempts at refutation end up begging the question, that is, they subtly assume what they are refuting.

Matter and Quantity Materialism is an anti-philosophy that considers matter to be the only reality. Scientists like Galileo are said to have created modernity by denying that the “external world” has any qualities, or qualia, such as colour, etc. Instead, only mathematics is necessary for physics; quantity alone has explanatory power so qualia are unnecessary.

That sounds rather revolutionary except that it has always been known. **Thomas Aquinas** knew the principle *materia signata quantitate*, that is, matter is designated by quantity. Therefore, in his view, the material world has no qualities and is constituted solely by quantity. For example, a ball has measure (it is a sphere), number (it has a radius), and it has weight or mass. Yet if I asked Galileo to toss me the red rubber ball, he would not throw the nearby cannonball, since it is of a different colour and texture.

So, we see that even if the so-called external world has no qualities, no one can navigate that world very well without them. Instead of “external world”, let’s be specific: it is better to call it the physical or material world or, in other words, the world known to scientific realism.

Qualia The common anti-qualia argument is Kantianism reinforced with some concepts of scientific realism. For example, the apple itself is not red; rather, its redness is a purely subjective experience caused by the reflection of light on the apple, which affects the retina which then creates the sensation of “red” in consciousness. The apple tastes “sweet” only because our taste buds interpret it as sweet, and so on for texture and other qualities.

So, in this worldview, the object is defined fully by measure, number, and weight. What we call its “qualities” are not at all attributable to the

thing, but are just subjective experiences. That leads to an unresolvable dualism between the objective thing and subjective experience. Unfortunately for this perspective, the qualities are not all that subjective, since observers will usually agree on those qualities.

The scientific worldview has no good answer for that. Although the traditional view agrees that quantity suffices to designate material things, it has a fuller understanding. Along with matter, things also have a form (or essence). What are called “qualia”, then, are provided by the form. (These are called *nama* and *rupa* in the Hindu schools.) The form and matter of a thing are not a dualism, since they both constitute the thing; they are nondual.

Animism

There can in fact be no ‘inanimate’¹³ objects in existence, and also that ‘life’ is one of the conditions to which all corporeal existence without exception is subject.

RENE GUENON, *The Reign of Quantity*

Scientific materialism has no possible explanation for consciousness, since consciousness cannot be measured, counted, or weighed. Similarly, science has no precise definition of life nor a clear understanding of how it arose. The traditional view, on the other hand, understands life to be one of the conditions of manifestation, from the beginning, so no such explanation is necessary. Although the material part of a thing is quantity alone, its qualities are experienced in the psychic element. Hence, there is nothing that is purely mechanical.

The corporeal or sensible world then integrates the material part of a thing with its sensible elements, ultimately derived from its essence.

¹³The terms “psychism” and “animism” are synonymous (one deriving from Greek, the other from Latin), so we may use them interchangeably.

Hence, there is no “external” world, but rather a world that has both an inside and an outside.

This does not mean, however, that your automobile or android is conscious, since they are artifacts without an essence. On the other hand, what we consider to be natural phenomena may conceal something deeper. In earlier times, the following description would have been perfectly natural:

In flowing and running water, in mists dissolving into water, also in the winds and the lightning flashing through the air, in all these, you have to look for the physical body of Angelic beings.

RUDOLF STEINER, *The Spiritual Hierarchies*

The Divided Line The physical world does not create mathematics, yet it follows mathematical laws. It is obvious that mathematics cannot be derived from matter. The best physicists, like **Roger Penrose**, recognize this. Yet that is a half-step; beyond the maths, there is the form or essence.

The best attempt to understand forms in terms of matter is the notion of “supervenience”; that is, the claim that the whole depends on the arrangement of its parts. But that just begs the question. Who or what recognizes the whole? The philosopher **David Lewis** offers this example:

A dot-matrix picture has global properties — it is symmetrical, it is cluttered, and whatnot — and yet all there is to the picture is dots and non-dots at each point of the matrix. The global properties are nothing but patterns in the dots. They supervene: no two pictures could differ in their global properties without differing, somewhere, in whether there is or there isn’t a dot.

A more contemporary example is a JPEG figure: mathematically, it is just a sequence of binary digits. However, “globally” it is an image of some

object. So, yes, the image does depend on the bits, i.e., quantity, but its global property is a quality experienced by a consciousness.

The traditional view is that the whole creates and arranges the parts, not the other way around.

Panpsychism It is interesting that secular philosophy has been warming to a similar idea under the name “panpsychism”. Unfortunately, it is seldom properly understood, especially by those who see psychism or animism only as a property of “physicalism”. For reasons already stated, that is not even possible. At least there is the recognition that consciousness and qualities cannot be explained in terms of matter.

The most reasonable attempt, at least in profane philosophy, is that of **Timothy Sprigge** who integrates a philosophy of Absolute Idealism with panpsychism¹⁴. There are physicalist philosophers who try to claim that consciousness is itself a property of matter. In poker that is called “being married to your hand”. You convince yourself that your hand is a winner, although objectively your hand will be a loser. Here are two examples, the second worse than the first

Philip Goff¹⁵ interprets psyche as a property of matter. **Galen Strawson**¹⁶ claims that the mental/experiential is physical. Of course not, since the mental cannot be measured, counted, or weighed. As an aside, Strawson the younger denies that there is moral responsibility. That is not a legitimate philosophical position, but rather a characteristic of a psychopath.

Three Nobel prize winning physicists come closer to the right idea:

- **Ernst Schrödinger**: the material universe and consciousness are

¹⁴<https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/abs/10.1111/j.1468-0149.1985.tb01122.x>

¹⁵<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2019/dec/27/galileos-error-by-philip-goff-review>

¹⁶https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Galen_Strawson

made out of the same stuff

- **Louis de Broglie:** I regard consciousness and matter as different aspects of one and the same thing
- **Max Planck:** I regard consciousness as fundamental

Posted on 2020-06-29 by Cologero

8.12 Social Surgery

Man as a physical being is subject to gravity and other laws of physics, not to mention chemical laws. As part of biological life, he is also subject to various biological laws. In particular, this includes the two scientific laws of neo-Darwinism (incorrectly called the “theory of evolution”). Darwin’s insight relied on these two principles.

1. **Variation** refers to random changes.
2. **Selection** refers a method to select or prefer certain changes over others.

As such, that is not yet a scientific theory. For example, the eminent biologist Richard Dawkins created a thought experiment in which the phrase “METHINKS IT IS LIKE A WEASEL” could arise through random variations. First, there is a random variation of letters. Then a selection process will select the letters that most resemble the target phrase until it is eventually reached. Unfortunately, this sneaks in two metaphysical principles:

- **Final cause:** the selection principle is goal oriented.

- **Formal cause:** the phrase is a possibility of manifestation. If, for example, the letter W was stuck on the typewriter, no amount of time could produce the phrase.

A properly scientific theory, on the other hand, relies only on material and efficient causes. Hence, the following modifications define the biological theory.

1. **Genetic Variation** refers to random mutations in the genotype that are inherited by the descendants.
2. **Natural Selection** refers to the survival and reproductive success of the phenotype within its environment, thereby preserving those mutations.

When I was a boy taking classes at the Boston Museum of Science, we were taught that cosmic rays created genetic mutations. Now it is accepted that the copying process itself is subject to imperfections. Inter-species mating may also possibly create genetic variations. Since most mutations are deleterious, presumably “nature” will select the best “fit” offspring to survive and reproduce, while the least fit will produce no descendants. The selection process is still in dispute, e.g., the role of group selection vs kin selection. Darwin claimed there was a sexual selection, which we see in the tendency toward assortative mating¹⁷, especially in humans. Of course, there is artificial selection in which humans create various breeds of certain animals for designed purposes.

As such, there is nothing objectionable to neo-Darwinism, since variations and selection can be observed. However, there are four things that this theory does not account for, although the popular imagination often believes so.

¹⁷https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Assortative_mating

- **Completeness:** variation and selection do not account for all the features of the phenotype. Specifically, the process does not explain how consciousness, thought, etc., arise. It just doesn't, no matter what you hear. A scientific theory needs to explain all the steps involved.
- **Descent:** man, for example, does not descend from a "monkey". No biologist claims that a monkey gave birth to a human. A true descendant will contain the genetic material of the parents. A new species arises, according to the theory, when the variation is sufficiently large to be considered something different; i.e., it is not a descendant in that sense.
- **Complexity:** the theory does not explain emerging complexity, or in other words, there is no "direction" to evolution, even if it appears that way. There is no good definition for complexity, and "evolution" could just as randomly produce less complex beings. Actually, half the biomass consists of single-celled organisms and they will continue to exist when multicellular organisms become extinct. Neo-darwinism may offer an explanation for the possibility of the development of more complex life forms, but not an explanation for its necessity.
- **Eugenics vs fitness:** there is no "moral" basis to survival. "Fit" just means fit to survive. "Bigger, stronger, faster" are irrelevant. Certain life forms will survive better as the human population density increases. For example, rats thrive in human cities. Social parasites like dogs and housecats do so likewise. There is a tacit agreement with livestock and poultry that they will be allowed to breed and propagate their genes in return for becoming foodstuff for humans.

Social Surgery Although man is subject to the laws of biology, he also transcends biology. Given the knowledge of variation and selection, to what extent then should man direct his own future (biological) evolution? Some geneticists claim that the human race is in genetic decline¹⁸. This is due to the accumulation over generations of deleterious mutations. In previous eras, high childhood mortality presumably would cull the genetically less fit from the population.

That is probably true, but it lacks biological relevance. The selfish gene theory stipulates that the genes strive to perpetuate themselves. Whether the organism is intelligent, pretty, or healthy or not is irrelevant, as long as the organism is able to reproduce itself. Nevertheless, such a prospect is disheartening to intellectuals who overvalue their intelligence, especially if they also misunderstand the point of life. They have various utopian ideals, never compatible with each other.

As a thought experiment, the British philosopher **Francis Bradley** posed an interesting question about the relationship between science and human progress: to what extent should scientific knowledge influence and direct social policy? Another way to pose it is this: should science be used to oppose the roots of order in favor of an ideological system or should it reinforce that order?

Despite the claims of the educated classes that they rely on science, scientific knowledge plays little role in social policy. Pressing issues in economics, crime, education, and so on, are more tractable than they appear, although there is little will to actually employ effective measures whenever they might conflict with ideological presuppositions. Bradley goes directly to the heart of the issue. In the case he defends, he acknowledges that there will be religious opposition to his proposal.

Bradley proposed what he called “social surgery”, which includes compulsory euthanasia. Writing shortly after Darwin, Bradley noted:

¹⁸<http://iqpersonalitygenius.blogspot.co.uk/2015/08/if-humans-are-recapitulating-mouse.html>

We have the moral code of Christianity ... but we do not realize how in its very principle the Christian ideal is false ... Darwinism seems destined to intervene. It will make itself felt, I believe, more and more effectually. It may force on us in some points a correction of our moral views and a return to a non-Christian and perhaps a Hellenic ideal.

He was correct about the destiny of Darwinism, but for the wrong reason:

The community, though it may have grown naturally to be what it is, should now more or less consciously regulate itself, and deliberately play its own Providence.

Specifically, given that the struggle for existence has been ameliorated, the inferior types are not weeded out naturally. Hence, the community must take on the “selection” task itself, since it can no longer rely on natural selection. He realized that certain religious attitudes would cause opposition:

[For Christianity] the individual in the next world has an infinite value; the things of this world, our human ends and interests, are all alike counted worthless ... the good of the whole can confer no right to interfere with its members. ... Once admit that life in this world is an end in itself, and the pure Christian doctrine is at once uprooted. For, measured by that end and standard, individuals have unequal worth ... the community is itself its own Providence.

The right of the individual to spawn without restriction his diseased offspring on the community, the duty of the state to rear wholesale and without limit an unselected progeny—such duties and rights are to my mind a sheer outrage on Providence. A society that can endure such things will merit the degeneracy which it courts.

Of course, from a strictly biological perspective there are indeed no such “rights”. From genetic selection alone, parasitism (no more overtones intended) is often a fit strategy, as long as the host is not destroyed. On the other hand, if group selection is valid, then Bradley’s proposal is merely an example of its manifestation.

As such, it is a perversion of Providence. As we have recently pointed out in the essay on *Predestination and Predilection*¹⁹, individuals have unequal worth, even from the perspective of Providence. However, the criterion of “worth” may be quite different. If man is solely biological, then Bradley must be correct. On the other hand, if man’s true end is indeed transcendent, then what we consider to be of worth is quite different.

A traditional society will not endure many things that a modern society, and presumably Bradley himself, not only endures but promotes. The degeneracy of the modern world has been courted for much longer than Bradley realizes; there is a moral degeneracy that is more deleterious than any biological mutation.

Nota Bene As an unanswered objection, and food for thought, we end with two quotes from the Jesuit paleontologist, **Teilhard de Chardin**:

How should we judge the efforts we lavish in all kinds of hospitals on saving what is so often no more than one of life’s rejects? Something profoundly true and beautiful (I mean faith in the irreplaceable value and unpredictable resource contained in each personal unit) is evidently concealed in persistent sacrifice to save a human existence. But should not this solicitude of man for his individual neighbour be balanced by a higher passion, born of the faith in that other higher personality that is to be expected, as we shall see, from the world-wide achievements of our evolution?

¹⁹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=8195>

To what extent should not the development of the strong (to the extent that we can define this quality) take precedence over the preservation of the weak? How can we reconcile, in a state of maximum efficiency, the care lavished on the wounded with the more urgent necessities of battle? In what does true charity consist?

Human Energy

So far we have certainly allowed our race to develop at random, and we have given too little thought to the question of what medical and moral factors must replace the crude forces of natural selection should we suppress them. In the course of the coming centuries it is indispensable that a nobly human form of eugenics, on a standard worthy of our personalities, should be discovered and developed. Eugenics applied to individuals leads to eugenics applied to society.

Phenomenon of Man

Posted on 2015-08-19 by Cologero

* * *

Sparrow on 2015-08-29 at 09:10 said:

One thing that lead me to reject Darwinism is the unspoken but taken for granted belief that assumes that all animal life is equal (i.e that all possibilities are open to forms of life). There was an instance some years back where Richard Dawkins defended a quack who believed that humanoid dinosaurs were a possibility. One wonders (with the exception of the Traditionalist) why we haven't seen dog people, cat people, or spider people.

New Age and Tradition

9.1 Tradition and the New Age

There are two competing spiritual attitudes, and often they are confused because they seem to deal with the same subject matters: metaphysics, spirituality, and so on. Yet there is a fundamental dichotomy, so divisive, in fact, that mutual conversation is barely possible. The New Ager is comprehensible from the Traditional viewpoint, but the New Ager has no understanding of the Traditional worldview, and can only regard it with contempt.

Tradition Tradition regards man as he is as the result of a fall from a perfect, primordial state. From a Golden Age to the Kali Yuga, there has been a continual degeneration in both man and society. This degeneration affects man's intellect, will, and moral sense. From an ordered, hierarchical, and differentiated world, there is a decline into chaos and egalitarianism. The way out is to achieve a reintegration of those chaotic elements.

Vertical Orientation: The Traditional worldview is *transcendence*. Man's task is to transcend the human state and reach deeper states of being. This process is *theosis*, or the God-man (NOT the deification of man).

New Age The New Age observes the same changes as Tradition, but its judgment is its very opposite. Rather than seeing the current world as the result of a Fall, it sees it as the outcome of a process of evolution, from a primitive state to a more enlightened state. Evolution is given a moral sense: what has evolved is "good" and what it replaces is "evil". All the symptoms of degeneration that Tradition decries, the New Age, instead, embraces.

Horizontal Orientation: The New Age worldview is *immanence*. God is expressed through the human situation, so there is nothing to transcend. This is the deification of humanity.

Posted on 2010-08-16 by Cologero

* * *

VisionsOfGlory14 on 2010-08-18 at 05:45 said:

Why does the New-Ager bother with the study of old religions if he believes man has 'evolved' past them? Is there any deeper reason than to claim them for his own and abuse them for his own ends?

Cologero on 2010-08-18 at 23:51 said:

The consistent new-ager does indeed believe he has "evolved". Yet, there is still a great deal of prestige associated with traditional religious forms, so he adopts and re-interprets them beyond recognition.

Another factor is that, most of those interested in such topics are in fact a mixture of both tradition and new age. This is because Tradition has been mostly lost in the West, so it is not clear how to be consistently traditional. I am reminded of a French bishop who recently claimed that the motto of the French Revolution "Liberty, Equality, Fraternity" is equally Christian. Of course, at that time both sides knew perfectly well it expressed an anti-Christian sentiment. Even Evola conceded that pre-Revolution Europe retained many Traditional elements.

Even odder are the anti-Christian neo-pagans who accuse Christianity of inaugurating the era of egalitarianism and universal brotherhood, when the case was just the opposite.

Ernest on 2010-08-19 at 13:22 said:

Have any of the Gornahoor people encountered the 'Integral' movement centred around Ken Wilber? Some people have called it the 'New New Age'.

If you have encountered it what do you think about it?

I had always been 'spiritual' to some extent, but my spirituality has rapidly intensified since my mid-teens (not too long ago). I also became consciously anti-modern at this time and I did see 'history as a fall'. Not having any real mentors local to me, I first discovered the Tao Te Ching, which was my main spiritual reference, but then later the Wilberian Integral movement. I read a few of Wilber's very-similar-to-each-other books and, while I was never a true-believer I did accept many of the ideas even to the point of converting to a more linear 'progressive' sense of history. This change was aided by the discovery of A.N. Whitehead while studying philosophy at University.

Around a couple of years ago I finally rejected Wilberian Integral for several reasons. Among others, I could not share their enthusiasm for capitalism and, like other New-Age groups there is far too much nauseating giddy feel-good spirituality in that 'movement'.

A short while after this rejection I came across Alain de Benoist (who would possibly be one of those anti-Christian neo-pagans that Cologero mentioned) and his book 'On Being a Pagan'. I had also studied paganism in my teens (without ever claiming to be one) and had become somewhat pre-Christian myself at that time. I felt some affinity for the ideas in the book but could not agree with his advocacy of pantheism.

That book has several quotations of Evola and from there I eventually read Revolt. I immediately felt a far greater affinity for Evola's views than I had with de Benoist (though I still admire him), or Wilber or the other religious groups I have explored and experimented with along the way. I have since read most of his books that have been translated into English and have begun to read Guenon, beginning with *Crisis of the Modern World*.

I have been reading with great interest the posts on Gornahoor regarding Tradition and Christianity.

I noticed that there is a quotation of Whitehead's on 'The Hyperborean Page'; what are your opinions on Whitehead?

Will on 2010-08-19 at 21:56 said:

As for myself, I have no opinion of Ken Wilber, having never read him. Ditto for Whitehead. I relate to what you say about the Tao Te Ching, as that was also the first book that opened up the world of Tradition for me. It was like a breath of fresh air after too much of the wrong western philosophers.

Thanks for your interest. Keep searching and studying!

Cologero on 2010-08-21 at 18:01 said:

The early Wilber is useful, if only for the encyclopedic knowledge he displays; he has done his homework. However, his later attempts at a theory of “everything” is unconvincing. There is an intricate schemata (the static) that doesn’t quite fit into the evolutionary scheme (dynamic). His system does not offer any explanation about why it should be so.

His colour scheme of moral development is really self-serving, and is unrelated to spiritual development. Most people will see themselves as highly advanced in their moral outlook, without having achieved anything spiritual, to speak of. Merely holding an opinion about morality is not in the least an indication of high spirituality.

9.2 The Deception of the New Age

Because of time constraints, **Alexander Shepard** was unable to post this piece himself, but has given us permission to reproduce his notes on the New Age as counter tradition. **Rene Guenon** writes of it:

As for the counter tradition, we can still only see the preliminary signs of it, in the form of all things that are striving to become counterfeits in one way or another of the traditional idea itself.

The movements Mr. Shepard mentions all use the language of Tradition and even claim to be based on Traditional ideas and texts. But “tradition” means “handed down” and the revelation that was “handed down” is an “inexhaustible deposit of wisdom which renews itself each time it is actualized by a new experience” (Guido de Giorgio). But this is precisely what the New Age movements reject. That deposit never suffices for them, so they continually seek out novelty, either in the form of revolutionary social and political movements or in scientific ideas such as Darwinism, Quantum Physics, and various psychological theories.

Men coming of age now have a unique opportunity. The texts of the founding fathers of Tradition are readily available, so there is no need to waste time with New Age ideas. That was not always so; in the next few days, I'll pass on my own experience with the New Age. We can only hope that this opportunity in time is not squandered. The fear is that what comes too easily is too little appreciated; there is something to be said about the need to for personal struggle. We conclude with a warning from Guenon, followed by Me. Shepard's text.

Something much more formidable is in preparation
for a future considered by some to be near, and the
growing rapidity of the succession of events today is
an indication of its proximity.

I thought I should offer my critique and perspective as to why "New age" thought, generally defined as any number of western "paths" arising in the west in the aftermath of the so-called "Enlightenment" is not a valid path. These spiritual movements include, but are certainly not limited to, Theosophy, the Bahia faith, Scientology, Wicca, Raelianism, Meher Baba's cult, The "Universal Sufi" cult, The Followers of Osho, the list goes on. Also included are those who are so found of calling themselves "Spiritual but not religious". There is particularly disturbing trend I have noticed among some Traditionalists of this generation to try to synthesize the Traditionalism and New Age. Books which come to mind includes a book called "The Return of the Perennial Philosophy" which is an account of Western Esoterism, and specifically criticizes Guenon for "neglecting" theosophy. Another philosopher who advocates such views is "Joscelyn Godwin" who in his book "The Golden Thread" seems to indicate a respect for the Theosophists and the new age movement in general. While he does not go out of his way to make a claim about the validity of the Theosophists, his works provide the basis for such a philosophy.

While I am not saying that such people should be ignored, one should at least be cautious of them and be mindful of the advice of the 1st generation Traditionalists in deciphering True Mysticism from Sophistry.

1. “New age thought” claims to rest on the fulfillment of the Self. Yet they confuse the Psychic and the Spiritual. The Spiritual, or Soul, transcends the mind, and there can be no matter of self-realization. The Soul exists as a reflection of God. Any path not founded on surrendering their will and worshipping the Absolute will find no spiritual awakening. Treating the “Ego” or the “individual self” as the object of care is like trying to support and cancerous Tumor in the brain blocking rational thought. The correct approach is to DESTROY the tumor. This is the object of REAL mysticism, to slay this stain called the “self”. As Al-Hallaj (ra) said “I look for myself and the self was gone”
2. Many “New agers” seek an alternative to Abrahamic Spirituality. As a result, they openly scorn monotheism. Instead, they embrace “animism” or “polytheism”. These two conceptions never existed; the notion of an “Evolutionary” thesis of religion was a fabrication of the western colonialists in the “Age of Imperialism”. In reality, all Religion is Monotheistic, which is why it was easy for Africans and Native Americans to embrace Islam and Christianity, for the basic tenets of a Single all-powerful God, an afterlife, a fall from Grace, were already essential tenants of their religious beliefs. The New Agers who call themselves “animists” or “polytheists” are creating a gross-perversion and distortion of indigenous beliefs. Julius Evola made this case against the Neo-pagans claiming to practice European “Paganism”, specially attacking their libertinism and “nature worship”
3. On this note, The New Agers are often ignorant of Christian Mysticism. In their question for direct spirituality they oddly ignore

clear examples of Self-realization within the Christian Tradition. One of the most clear examples being the great Meister Eckhart, whose entire Theology rested on demonstrating on how the Universe was an illusion and how the only thing Real was God, and that Christ was the “Son of God” in-so much as he was the most perfect Human, completing the levels of spiritual ascension, and providing an archetype for all human kind to reject their created natures and become One with God.

4. On this note, so-called “New Agers” are, like religious fundamentalists ignorant of the distinction between the esoteric and the exoteric. There is no reaching the Supreme Realization without rigorous bodily discipline. Even in the case of Primitive society, the Shaman had to subject himself to years and years of fasting, prayer, and seclusion. A great many trials and tribulations which the “new ager” could never survive. In fact, many of the most vocal critics of new age have been natives. In light of the Islamic tradition, the noble discipline of Tasawuff has been bastardized, with “Neo-Sufis” shamelessly claiming the mantel of “Sufi” without practicing the Shariah. They desecrate the graves of the sages of Islam by claiming absurdities like “Sufism is different than Islam”. Authentic Spirituality has ALWAYS demanded the rigorous practice of the exoteric, and history, with rare exceptions, has demonstrated this. In order to transcend to elevate the spirit, we must conquer the body.

Posted on 2012-06-19 by Admin

* * *

Avery on 2012-06-19 at 22:04 said:

Guenon didn't neglect Theosophy. He wrote an entire book about it, which I think Mr. Shepard could learn a great deal from if he wants to learn more about these pseudo-traditional

movements. However, I personally found this book wanting. What it should be doing is drawing a distinction between New Age methods of finding “spiritual truth” and Traditional methods. Instead he frequently fails to justify the theoretical basis for his attacks, it really just reads like a long, unedited Internet rant by a disillusioned ex-member (he was not a Theosophist but worked in similar occult groups). Evola never wrote anything so whiny about Fascism.

golgonooza on 2012-06-20 at 06:25 said:

Surely you would want to support the bold claim that “all Religion is Monotheistic” with something a bit more substantial than the fact that Africans were able to accept Christianity easily. I think the reality is far more complex – maybe the words monotheistic and polytheistic don’t really do justice to it. Are Hindus monotheistic? Are they polytheistic? Aside from which school of thought you look at there would be problems with saying they were either.

Cologero on 2012-06-20 at 07:14 said:

With all due respect, Avery, it is a common tactic of the modern mind to dismiss ideas based on the alleged psychological of the writer. You don’t know if Guenon was disillusioned or not; perhaps he was trying to protect others from the initial illusion. He did, in fact, object to specific doctrines in Theosophy. Evola reprised the same arguments in his “mask and face of contemporary spirituality”. If they misrepresented or misunderstood those doctrines, then specific examples would be of interest.

Evola wrote an entire book, critical of Fascism, “Fascism seen from the right”. Do you not consider that “whiny”? In any event, the only question is whether it is true or false.

Cologero on 2012-06-20 at 07:25 said:

I agree, golgonooza, that alleged empirical facts about Africans cannot be used to *prove* a principle, although facts may be helpful in illustrating it. Nevertheless, in the metaphysical sense, orthodox Traditions are monotheistic, that is, they agree there is an ultimate unifying principle. A literal polytheism implies there are multiple, independent, irreconcilable, ultimate principles.

*THE DOCTRINE OF DIVINE UNITY IN HELLENIC TRADITION*¹ may be of interest in this regard.

Avery Morrow on 2012-06-21 at 10:34 said:

Cologero, I was not sure what to think of your reply on first read, but I now realize you are absolutely right and I will have to apologize for my bad judgment. Psychoanalysis of an author’s

¹<http://www.eurasia-rivista.org/the-doctrine-of-divine-unity-in-hellenic-tradition/12164/>

mood and motivation is an anti-Traditional method of criticism and is actually reflective of the sort of cliquish bullying that is falsely passed off as critique on the Internet these days.

9.3 New Age and Ancient Wisdom

There is a loose group of spiritual ideas that have a large influence in Western, particularly American, culture, that go by the name of “New Age” spirituality. Furthermore, they derive their validity from the claim that they are updated versions of Traditional wisdom. While there is certainly some basis for that claim, in actuality they are distortions and simplifications of those teachings. That is what we want to explore in order to illustrate the true meaning of those teachings.

Law of Attraction The Law of Attraction is the belief that persons, conditions, things and events come into your life experience because you “attract” them through your mind, either consciously or subconsciously. Although this is the cornerstone of the New Thought movement, it has entered popular culture in the past decade or so, primarily on the basis of a movie called *The Secret*, and the resulting publicity on various television shows.

The principle is based on the idea that the universe will bring into manifestation the ideas, thoughts, or images held in the mind. Since no one is typically aware of this, especially in regard to negative things, the theory is that the universe is responding to the subconscious mind. The proposed solution, therefore, is to consciously direct thought to the desired result. There are two questions: first of all, is this true, and then, assuming that it is, what ought one desire?

This is not an idle question, because the same question comes up in Bhagavad Gita. In that text, the primary question is why some achieve self-knowledge while others don’t; this can be secularized to why some

have health, wealth, and love, while others are lacking. The accusation is that the Universe, represented here by Krishna, plays favorites. Krishna rejects that charge:

In whatsoever way men approach Me, even so do I reward them.

BG 4:11

Here is probably the first expression of the Law of Attraction. Krishna responds in kind to what people desire. Those who desire pleasure or money will receive them. Those who instead seek for liberation, will gain liberation. In the next verse we read:

Those who desire success in their works worship the gods here;
for quickly, in this world of man, comes success from works.

BG 4:12

Success in the world comes quickly and easily, so that is what people act on. Self-knowledge and liberation are much more difficult, so few people seek it. Now I have known people who have focused on money and wealth, usually because of **Napoleon Hill**'s book *Think and Grow Rich*. It has given them the motivation and the confidence to pursue wealth relentlessly, (i.e., money is a "minor god" to them).

On the other hand, I have witnessed religious science treatments, Course in Miracles adherents, and charismatic prayer meetings, all of which lay claim to miraculous healings. I never saw anyone cured of baldness or near-sightedness. Since there is a valid principle involved here in that the "representation creates reality", the failure of this law needs to be explained. There is a practical explanation as well as a metaphysical explanation.

Law of Accidents Along with the Law of Attraction, there is the notion that “there are no accidents.” This can be understood in two ways.

The first way is that it is a restatement of the Principle of Sufficient Reason, that is, there is cause or a reason for manifested things. This reason may or may not be discoverable, but it is not due to the intention of the person.

The stronger interpretation is that everything that happens in your life has been attracted to you through your conscious or subconscious mind. In other words, it is a manifestation of your essential being. That explanation, however, does not take privation into account. In its essence the person is perfect, but not in existence. Insofar as a person experiences privation, he will be subject to accidents, that is, external forces that do not arise from his own essential being.

I have known many people who have become very distraught because of this teaching. When bad things happen, which they always will, they reproach themselves for “attracting” those things. And rightly so, if this idea is true, since it reflects their essential being. A vicious circle of desire, disappointment, and self-reproaching ensues. As long as the law of attraction is used to attract sense objects (money, sex, power), rather than spiritual enlightenment, there is no way out. To return to the Bhagavad Gita:

When a man dwells on objects, he feels an attachment for them. Attachment gives rise to desire, and desire breeds anger. From anger comes delusion; from delusion, the failure of memory; from the failure of memory, the ruin of discrimination; and from the ruin of discrimination, the man perishes.

BG 2:62-63

Dwelling on a thought or image in the mind brings about a desire for its manifestation. Anything that thwarts it brings anger. Then delusion

about reality and a forgetting of one's Real I. That is spiritual death. The delusion is that the manifestation of the desire will bring happiness, when that is not the case:

The man of self-control, moving among objects with his senses under restraint, and free from attachment and hate, attains serenity of mind.

BG 2:64

Spiritual Mind Treatment There are two main techniques used by new agers: affirmative prayer and visualizations.

In affirmative prayer, there is the assertion that "I am" already what I desire to be. For example, the person tries to come into the awareness that "I am healthy" or that "I experience abundance." There are variations on how this is done in the different schools. For example, a science of mind treatment will involve five steps. Christian Science will use a form of denial, such as, declaring, "this disease does not exist."

The other technique is the practice of the visualization of the desired result. These techniques do have some basis in Hermetic and magical practices. However, in that tradition, there is a long training period necessary, something the New Ager wants to dispense with.

I hope it is obvious, though it is apparently not, that these treatments are not nearly as scientific or as reliable as claimed. Otherwise, the solution to all the world's woes would be a weekend course in the law of attraction. There are two defects with the whole idea.

First of all, there is the metaphysical restriction that only possibilities of manifestation can manifest, and furthermore, they must be compossible with other manifestations. Otherwise, everyone would be a millionaire without servants to do their bidding, all parking spots would be directly in front of the store, and Jennifer Lawrence would be totally exhausted.

Even assuming a real possibility, the other, more fundamental, issue is that man as such is not a united being. Spending ten or twenty minutes thinking of or visualizing a desired result will not overcome the rest of the day in which the mind is wandering all over the place, often thinking and visualizing results directly opposed to the treatment. Even during the time spent on the practice, the untrained mind cannot focus on a single idea more than a few seconds.

Hence, training in concentration is necessary before embarking on these practices. Then the time spent on the treatment may be all quality time. Then it would be necessary to maintain self-awareness throughout the day in order to suppress the random flow of ideas and images in the mind. As **Patanjali** expresses it:

Yoga is the ending of the oscillations of the mental substance,

Yoga Sutras 1.2

Paradoxically, the ending of these oscillations depends on not dwelling on the things of this world, as we read above.

Posted on 2014-09-22 by Cologero

* * *

andros on 2014-09-24 at 05:44 said:

Alexander Pope seems apt in this regard:

A little learning is a dangerous thing;
drink deep, or taste not the Pierian spring:
there shallow draughts intoxicate the brain,
and drinking largely sobers us again.

And in the same poem (An Essay On Criticism) he also gifts us with:

'To err is human, to forgive divine'
& 'Fools rush in where Angels fear to tread'
(An Essay On Criticism)

Logres on 2014-09-24 at 07:55 said:

My grandmother was Christian Science. Before she died, she basically retracted her beliefs and embraced the Logos, as she could understand it. The fad for Eastern “thought-stuff” makes me wonder if modern Westerners are just trying to do with it, what has already been done in the West: subject it to the personal whims of desire and personality-based distortion in order to find a quick or intellectually lazy path. I say this, because much of the BG is identical in dogma to what is presented in both Old and New Testaments (“God is not mocked, whatsoever a man sows, that he also reaps”).

9.4 Perfect, Whole, and Complete

Esoterists have historically been prudent about making their teachings known to the general public. Hence, the teachings were disguised in parables, proverbs, myths, symbols, cryptic sayings, and so on. On the one hand, this prevented the teachings from being distorted and misunderstood, if they were presented in a more open way. On the other hand, the teachings were preserved since the stories and symbols would be passed on, even by those who could not fully comprehend them.

In the past, books were rare and expensive, so teachings had to be passed down from mouth to mouth. But moveable type enabled books to be mass produced at lower costs. In our time, virtually everything is available. Nevertheless, the widespread availability of esoteric teachings has not prevented them from being misunderstood.

For example, New Age teachings mimic esoteric teachings while distorting them out of all recognition. For a while, I followed such teachings, especially the branch that was summarized in the movie *The Secret*. Called New Thought, the idea was that changing one’s thoughts would automatically change the outward circumstances of life. There is no doubt that an improvement in the quality of one’s thoughts is beneficial. Unfortunately, however, this won’t “cause” the Universe to mold circumstances to fulfill your desires. Especially, a ten minute affirmation

on success cannot override a full day of “stinkin’ thinking”.

They claimed to be teaching what the “mystics always taught.” However, I could not recall mystics trying to use their spirituality to gain wealth, health, love, and the like. That was when I made the decision to actually read those mystics for myself. Although New Thought had the words of the mystics, it did not translate into an understanding.

This is one of the affirmations we were taught: “I am Perfect, Whole, and Complete.” That is worth exploring. The fundamental misunderstanding is the failure to grasp the distinction between the Self (or Person) and the Ego (or Individual). So the affirmations may be correct when applied to the Self, but not to the Individual.

Perfect The Self is perfect but the individual ego certainly is not. Calling the Ego “prefect” is actually harmful. Alchemical work begins with purification. One must honestly face up to the shadow of the ego and engage in the process of overcoming negative thoughts, images, and emotions. Repeating affirmations will not accomplish that. Unfortunately, in new age circles that work is avoided because it is considered to be purely negative.

Whole The Self is an undivided whole but the individual is full of conflicting elements. The next stage in the alchemical process is to resolve those conflicts. To be Whole means to be a Unity. The individual who aspires to such wholeness will develop a singular will that will remain constant from day to day.

Complete The Self is Complete because it does not lack anything. The New Ages recognize that the individual experiences lack. It may be deficient financially, health.

They claim that the opposite of lack is supply. Supply can be replenished by contacting the “higher self”. In a sense that is true. However, one

does not “contact” the higher self, one must “be” the higher self. That is the final stage of alchemical transformation.

Summary The new ager who believes that the individual as such is perfect, whole, and complete, will fail to develop spiritually in a fully healthy way.

Nevertheless, it may be useful to affirm to oneself: “I am perfect, whole, and complete.” That will serve as a reminder that you, as a Self, have those qualities. Understood properly, it will motivate you to complete the alchemical transformation in your own life. The Universe will not do it for you.

Posted on 2023-03-23 by Cologero

10.1 Science and Wisdom

Despite its lofty but overrated reputation in our day, science is actually a rather low form of knowledge. First of all, it is a product of the rational, discursive mind, the “soul” or “mind”, whereas authentic spiritual understanding comes from the intellect, the nous, the “spirit”.

This is exemplified by the democratic nature of scientific phenomena. It is assumed that everyone with normal sensory apparatus experiences the world more or less the same, no matter what his state of development. Science assumes this universality and through various external experiments creates conceptual schemes assumed to account to the phenomena. However, its abductive logic can only produce what Plato called “a likely story”, always open to change and development. In more recent times, this has been stated most forcibly by Karl Popper who logically demonstrated that a scientific theory can never be infallibly established.

Yet, today many fall under the illusion that Quantum Theory somehow reveals some spiritual truths. Yet the only useful aspect of Quantum Theory is quantitative, which yields quite accurate results in the obser-

vation of certain phenomena. There are at least a half dozen conceptual schemes to provide a qualitative description of quantum phenomena with no scientific way to select from among them. To choose a more or less “spiritual” explanation is purely arbitrary and even fanciful, certainly not “scientific”. If any truly spiritual insights have come forth from the many popularisers of Quantum Theory, then their true source is actually elsewhere and in no way are attributable to “science”.

Its foundation rests on Schroedinger’s equation which reduces all “matter” to probability waves in a state of indeterminateness until it encounters the presence of a “conscious” observer. Since the equation is linear, the entire material/energy universe can be represented by such an equation. Once that step has been taken, it then becomes impossible to reconstruct the world of objective things from physics alone. True, this is more or less what would be expected from the Traditional point of view, that Prime Matter is chaos and without form, until informed by consciousness. However, that is no longer physics, but metaphysics.

Authentic spiritual knowledge, on the other hand, arises in the spirit of man, and is given the name “Wisdom”. Science observes phenomena and posits some other reality behind it. Wisdom in contrast is direct and intuitive, hence certain. Science in principle is open to all with the proper education — no other self-transformation is required.

Wisdom is for the few who make the required effort. Wisdom requires a change in one’s state of being, that is, there is no distinction between knowledge and the thing known. In other words, to understand higher states, it is necessary to be transformed into that higher state.

Of course, this goes against the grain of all modernity by offending its democratic pretensions. The modern man wants to read a book, attend a lecture, take notes, and then become wise.

Few are those who are willing to travel the road to Wisdom, and fewer still are those who can show the way.

Posted on 2007-11-19 by Cologero

10.2 Science at a Standstill

Science seems to be at a standstill after centuries of revolutionary developments.

- Physics is stuck with incompatible theories – Relativity and Quantum Mechanics – and remains far from a unified theory.
- Biology is no closer than Darwin to explaining the origins of life and the actual mechanics of the evolution of the species
- The last real cure in Medicine was the discovery of penicillin, and now it can only treat conditions, albeit with more sophisticated technology and drugs.
- The dream of Positivism to create a true science of man has come to naught, as psychology and sociology have produced no universally recognized scientific results. With their endless “studies”, they have become little more than tools of political ideologies.
- Even the meager results they have produced are often rejected on extra-scientific grounds.
- The ideal of objective and dispassionate scientific research has given way to the lure of money, power and prestige to produce a “desired” outcome.

Posted on 2010-10-21 by Cologero

10.3 Nuclear Energy, Evolution, the Unconscious

When science changed its methodology from the description of phenomena, to the search for occult causes, it then made its three most significant

discoveries of modern times. These are **Nuclear Energy** in Physics, **Evolution** in Biology, and the **Unconscious** in Psychology.

What they have in common is that the cause cannot be directly observed, but must be inferred from observation of its effects. The other characteristic they have in common is their ultimate unintelligibility, despite the large amount of experimental data to back them up. This fits in with the program of Positivism: collect the facts and derive laws from them. Metaphysical questions are irrelevant.

Energy In physics, matter is condensed energy. Furthermore, at the atomic and subatomic levels, energy persists as probability waves. Its condensation into matter is therefore indeterminate. Nevertheless, the statistical distribution of matter can be determined with a high degree of accuracy. So we can conclude that, from a quantitative perspective, quantum theory is extremely well attested.

The discussion is much different when we look at quantum theory qualitatively, that is, the world picture entailed by the theory. The human mind eventually rebels at positivism and looks for intelligibility, or an ulterior explanation. Unfortunately, there are about a dozen competing extra-scientific interpretations¹ of the quantitative success of the theory. Naturally, the more mystical versions, such as the many-worlds interpretation, are the ones that are popularized.

Evolution Because of the fossil record and the similarity of DNA between closely related species, the theory of evolution is well attested in biology. But again, there is a lack of intelligibility. As with quantum mechanics, all explanations are stochastic and statistical. Looking backwards, a biologist can speculate about the species linked up to the appearance

¹https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Interpretations_of_quantum_mechanics

of man. But there is no explanation as to why man appeared in the first place.

Unconscious The final discovery is that of the unconscious in human motivation. By definition, the unconscious is not observable. Freud attributed human behavior to the unconscious energy of instinctive processes. Adler, following Nietzsche, postulated an unconscious will to power. Finally, Jung noted several higher level unconscious processes, which he called archetypes. There is no explanation for these unconscious forces and the psychological techniques for bringing them into awareness are unreliable.

Esoteric interpretation These three scientific discoveries dominate modern and postmodern thought:

- The world is the result of spontaneous configurations of energy
- Man is the result of random process of evolution
- Behaviour is dominated by unconscious motives

This model leaves no room for human consciousness, and, a fortiori, for any influences from forces transcendent to the world process. Intelligibility means knowledge of the sufficient reason for things and events, and as long as the only principle of sufficient reason acceptable is physical causation, the postmodern worldview is literally unintelligent. Since no one can live by random and unconscious processes alone, intelligibility is replaced by ideology.

Posted on 2010-10-22 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2010-10-23 at 10:01 said:

"Intelligibility means knowledge of the sufficient reason for things and events, and as long as the only principle of sufficient reason acceptable is physical causation, the postmodern worldview is literally unintelligent."

This is why Evola disparaged "science" in favor of esotericism. As expressed most forcefully in various places in "Magic", modern science gives predictability, but real Knowledge involves knowing, or rather, becoming, the remote cause. He gives the example of the scientist pushing a button and sending off a rocket to destroy a distant target. This is the man in the street's paradigm of 'knowledge'; but as E. points out, the scientist, qua man, has no real control over any of these forces, and also, is unchanged, as a man, from the most intelligent ape. Thus, although E. doesn't say this, the perennial CP Snow problem of modern men as "monkeys with machine guns". ends and means, etc. Evola presents esoteric knowledge as adhering to experience, like sense knowledge, but evoking superior experience as its token of certainty, unlike the merely abstract mathematical models of science. Your "occult causes" threw me at the start; I think you have the same model, but by "description of phenomena" I assume you mean E.'s superior experience, and by "occult causes" you mean his abstract models of science.

Also, an interesting way to show how ideology viz, the "bright idea" of college professors has gained its grip on modern man.

Cologero on 2010-10-23 at 13:28 said:

Yes, there is some irony in "occult science", intended in its literal definition as hidden. It alludes to science as a sort of counter-initiation, as it discovers the hidden nature of matter, life, and mind.

It is the opposite of the metaphysical axiom that the *subtle rules the dense*.

Instead of using knowledge of unconscious forces (e.g., the function of astrology) to liberate, it is used as a means of control. For example, all that has followed from Edward Bernays's use of Uncle Sigmund's theories. Even *children's cartoons*² are reflect the same attention to manipulation.

Similarly, the ideal of the "true man" or even Nietzsche's "superman", which are conscious outcomes of the human will, will be replaced by genetic manipulation. If anyone thinks this will somehow improve the human race, he needs to take a close look at how the wolf became a "dog".

Daniel on 2010-10-24 at 02:26 said:

²<http://www.howstuffworks.com/how-dora-the-explorer-works.htm/p rintable>

This is very insightful, especially the second half. Modern science, when it encounters the limits of what it can explain, engages in a lot of elaborate hand-waving, which often is sufficient to distract one from the obvious truth, which is: they don't know the answer; the answer is unknowable using their postivist methods.

As a side note, what do you mean by the "attention to manipulation" in **Dora the Explorer**?

Cologero on 2010-10-24 at 13:38 said:

I am far from an expert on pop culture, but I had the opportunity recently to witness young children watching Dora the Explorer. First I noted how different the cartoon is from, say, Bugs Bunny, yet the children were completely engrossed. It seemed to me to be designed by a committee of psychologists and educators. The link more or less confirms it. As for "manipulation", the creators admit that their intent is to portray certain things in a positive light. Whether right or wrong, the intent is there.

Daniel on 2010-10-24 at 22:58 said:

Yes, of course, I see. So much of television is like this (explicitly intending to indoctrinate) that I thought perhaps there was something specific about that show. But the very ubiquity of the phenomenon makes your point exactly.

kadambari on 2010-10-31 at 11:48 said:

"The final discovery is that of the unconscious in human motivation."

This was recognized by ancient civilizations, that the unconscious is a potent force; however the ideal was always to overpower it by something higher and tame it, this marked the superior man, you see this in the Doric harmony in Greece and in Hindu mythology where the ideal is self-control and self-mastery, the overcoming of desires and the irrational. This is different from "repression" of these forces which is not self-mastery or self-growth. The self-mastery results in our being minimally influenced by them as they are placed under something higher; it has to come about as self-evolution and self-growth, cannot be a product of obedience to external commandments, and cannot come about by force. Repression comes about where the spirit does not dominate.

I think Freud was the biggest disaster as far as the treatment of the unconscious goes. When I was younger, I remember upon reading some of his works for the first time thinking deep down that there was something completely wrong with it, even perverse, but was too naive to exactly articulate what was wrong. Now I realize perhaps he is just a product of his own culture as exemplified in the Old Testament, where a God is to be obeyed and feared, and people brought under this culture exhibit the kinds of neurosis he deals with eventually as a cultural outcome? Perhaps his explanation is valid for only that cultural archetype and for those brought up under this archetype? However, this cultural archetype is gaining dominance as exemplified in the

aesthetics of the movies, music and dance in popular culture, even our conceptions of beauty in the so called fashion magazines which are lacking any connection to higher aesthetic ideals.

Now there are different cultures and their treatment of the unconscious was quite different, but the Freudian explanation has come to dominate with disastrous consequences.

Hence today, in literature which generally reflects the culture of the times, importance is given to the irrational, the morbid, the perverse, which in higher civilizations is always placed under higher forces, and not given the sole importance and kept in their proper place.

Hence, one cannot feel that there is a certain "sickness" in popular dance, movies, music and such as most of it fails to appeal to anything higher in the human psyche. It is ultimately what a culture gives importance to; if the lowest drives and the irrational is thought worthy of veneration, then the cultural by-product as seen in the movies, dance and music and literature is just a reflection of that.

10.4 The Multiverse and Massachusetts

I had the opportunity this weekend to watch an interview on C-Span with the physicist Brian Greene³, conducted at the Museum of Science in Boston, Massachusetts. The topic was the multi-worlds interpretation of quantum mechanic and the all-white audience was mostly students and retired folk. I know that tribe intimately, having grown up and attended University in the Boston area. I'll touch on the science of the theory, but what is more interesting is the sociology of the audience.

Theory The theory itself is quite simple: whenever there is quantum indeterminacy, then both possibilities occur, one in "our" universe, and the other in an alternate universe that is identical except that the other possibility is observed. I can understand why Mr. Greene is excited about this theory. Had he given a lecture on his specialized field of string theory, perhaps a dozen people would have been able to understand it and it would not have been televised. But when it comes to the multiverse, sud-

³<http://www.c-spanvideo.org/videoLibrary/event.php?id=192289&timeline>

denly everyone is an expert on quantum mechanics. When scientists start approaching metaphysical topics, I don't know if they are simply over their heads, or if they just get some satisfaction in deluding the audience.

The theory itself depends on a mathematical trick, viz., if an equation has multiple solutions, then they all must refer to physical reality. Yet, that is not the case in other branches of physics. For example, in systems that involve the solution to a quadratic equation, the negative solution is rejected as not conforming to physical reality, while the positive solution is accepted. The multiverse theory asserts that the unobserved (and unobservable) solution also physically exists. That remains to be seen, since physicists qua physicists must also experimentally demonstrate their theories, not just theoretically.

Mr. Greene curiously stated an obvious error in physics. The question arose about the fundamental constants in physics⁴ whose values are really inexplicable to current physics. Mr. Greene then postulated that there are alternate universes with different fundamental constants. However, the multiverse theory depends on quantum effects and no one has demonstrated, or even theorized, that the fundamental constants are in any way related to quantum effects. Hence, there is no reason to accept that possibility, even as conjecture.

He then made an allusion to the Anthropic Principle⁵, with the unsupported claim that these other universes would not have been such that life could have evolved, and “we” happen to be in the universe with the right constants. Of course, an unobservable universe is no longer physics; it is metaphysics, and not even good metaphysics. Mind and matter are correlative; as Jung put it in *Answer to Job*, “Existence is only real when it is conscious to someone.”

⁴http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Physical_constant

⁵http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Anthropic_principle

Sociology Even if a physicist can create alternative universes at will by sending electrons through a slit, that is not necessarily of great significance. So suddenly the theory morphs into the idea that whenever a choice is made, then another universe is created where the opposite choice was made. For this to be the case, we would have to assume that the human organism as a whole is a quantum effect, and that “making a choice” is akin to the seemingly random motion of an electron beam through a narrow slit. Did Mr. Green propose any serious scientific reason to believe that? But as Chesterton said, “if a man does not believe in God, he will believe in anything.” Certainly the audience seemed to believe in anything.

Just as believers in reincarnation assume they were great leaders or princesses in their past life, believers in the multiverse presume “they” will have made great achievements in an alternative universe. One questioner seemed to think that in some other universe, he is a great physicist rather than an engineer on Route 128. The question of his real identity did not seem to cross his mind. Of course, in that audience, Mr. Greene made the obvious joke, to great laughter, about Sarah Palin being president in some other universe. Not that I have any particular affection or respect for Mrs. Palin, the aim of the joke was to establish a tribal identity, not to encourage independent thought.

Had the liberal members of the audience taken a pause to think things through, they should have come to the conclusion that in alternative universes, they may just as well be tea party activists, or even neo-Nazi racists. If every conceivable possibility is actual, then it eliminates the necessity for choice and makes a mockery of the heroic human life.

Posted on 2011-04-03 by Cologero

* * *

Jake on 2011-05-03 at 20:28 said:

You might want to check out some of the more bleeding-edge stuff going on with MWI – there are a few splinters who are looking at the big picture in a philosophically coherent way. One of the more exciting approaches I've seen points out that under mathematical information theory, the set of all possible descriptions – strings of 1s and 0s, essentially speaking – has a total information content of precisely zero, and from there proposes that Something (the manifestation of a determinate reality in temporal appearance) emerges from the primordial All/Nothing, now formally understood as the set of all possible worlds, by means of conscious observation. Obviously, the sense and usefulness of this is crippled by the need for a theory of the observing, reflexive subject(ive process) – this is nowhere more evident than in the book's discussion of time – but I think there's a lot that could be done with the synthesis of MWI, information theory, and modern continental ontology, particularly that of Hegel, Heidegger, and Deleuze.

Cologero on 2011-05-03 at 22:28 said:

You seem to be referring to a book, but the title is omitted. Does it address the following issues:

- 1) Is the set of all possible descriptions finite or uncountable?
- 2) Is any particular universe bounded by a maximal string size?
- 3) Is every permutation a possibility of manifestation, or are some permutations simply impossible?
- 4) Or, more likely, are some strings "true" but not "provable"?
- 5) If a string represents a state of the universe, what are the rules for moving from state to state? In other words, is the set of all possible descriptions a group or algebra?
- 6) "0" is the initial state, and it transitions to "1". Then the "1" to the many. Correct? This is the basis of every metaphysical system. How does MWI improve on this?
- 7) Finally, metaphysics has its own version of many worlds. It is also true that all possible worlds will manifest. Physics doesn't make it so, actually, just the opposite.

Jake on 2011-05-04 at 07:54 said:

Sorry about the lack of title – it's THEORY OF NOTHING, written by Russell Standish. It's available online: <http://www.hpcoders.com.au/nothing.html>

- 1) No – the set of all possible descriptions is uncountable from definition, I would think.
- 2) I think this probably depends on how we mean 'universe' – there's at least two important and distinct modes. If we mean by it the temporally organized world manifest by a particular observer, then yes, all world-narratives should eventually terminate or decohere. If we mean 'universe' in the sense of the scientifically ascertained cosmos, then I'd say it's a pretty open question.

3) Well, your first test is clearly anthropic – it has to (be able to) describe observer processes in order to become actual – but obviously no one has any real clue what that entails. Beyond that, Standish uses statistics and algorithmic information theory at this point, to try to demonstrate that descriptions corresponding to simpler rulesets are more likely to be observed and “prove” the Razor. It’s a cool idea, but the ontological ambiguity introduced with rulesets, algorithms, and correspondences makes me very skeptical.

4) Not sure how truth and provability in the metamathematical senses can be applied here... can you elaborate?

5) Personally, I would refer this to the need for a theory of observation – but I have certain Heideggerian notions concerning the relation of observation and temporality which you may not share.

6) There’s no transition. Transitions are temporal, and the relation of the particular observed world to prior Totality (aka All/Nothing) is pre-temporal. Since we identify Nothing with indeterminate Totality rather than a state of absolute absence, the “why” of Something is no longer problematic; it is intrinsically potential within Nothing, and is necessarily manifest in actuality insofar as it describes an observer.

7) Not really sure what you mean here – Leibniz? I would argue that metaphysics is the only discipline which is even capable of talking about worlds. Most MWI is just bad metaphysics that’s not even aware of itself as such.

10.5 The Locust Conspiracy

In which we explore the outer reaches of scientific knowledge including psychopathy, time travel, entropy, quantum physics, conspiracy theories, and miracles.

Definitions An **opinion** is a proposition that is neither demonstrably false nor self-contradictory. Hence, it is the least reliable form of knowledge; it may be falsified in the future. Emphatically, an opinion is not any thought that pops into your mind.

A **belief** is a proposition that is actionable, that is, it will lead to action in the world. If I believe it will rain on Saturday, then I won’t pack the picnic basket. That is how you can tell if someone really believes what he claims.

Not Even Wrong is an argument that is neither correct nor incorrect because its premises are so off base or the argument is confused. For example, Amalric of Bene in the 12th century was saved from the charge of heresy because the investigators determined that his views were pure lunacy.

The opposite of a false proposition is a true proposition. The opposite of a “not even wrong” proposition is still false.

Psychopaths and **Sociopaths** have a lack of conscience yet can appear charming to the unwary. Since they are manipulative, they can do very well in achieving power in politics or business. It amazes me how few people can recognize a psychopath. Haven’t they ever wondered how some people, usually not as competent or intelligent as they are, manage to rise above them?

It is pointless to argue with a psychopath, since they get a thrill out of irritating the lesser beings below them. They even boast about it. Also, the charge of hypocrisy against them is ineffective. Quite the contrary. They revel in “getting away with it” and even love their hypocrisy to be made public. They often reveal themselves with a wry smile, usually at inappropriate moments.

A **conspiracy theory** is an explanation that relies on a secretive cabal of sinister and powerful groups working together to achieve a result, often over the course of generations. Obviously, it is hard to prove without being one of the insiders. The irrational belief in a conspiracy theory is considered to be a mental illness: viz., **illusory pattern perception**. the Wikipedia article *List of conspiracy theories*⁶ includes the belief in a **white racist patriarchy** to be one such theory.

The **Open Conspiracy**⁷, envisaged by H G Wells, offers a better explanation. Its tenets are being implemented today, but not by a secret

⁶https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_conspiracy_theories

⁷<https://forcingchange.wordpress.com/2012/01/16/advancing-the-open-conspiracy-h-g-wells-and-the-world-state/>

cabal, but rather openly by people and groups implementing the policies independently. The Biblical explanation should be sufficient:

The locusts have no king yet they fly in formation. (Proverbs 30:27)

Keep in mind that there is nothing great about locusts.

The Missing W In one of his books, Richard Dawkins created a thought experiment in which he showed how the phrase “METHINKS IT IS LIKE A WEASEL” could be generated by tossing some tiles and selecting those that would lead to the phrase. But suppose the letter W was missing from the tiles; then, no number of tosses would create the phrase. The same notion can be applied to the evolution of the human being. Humans could not have “evolved” from matter unless that there was that possibility. That is, the biological human is the W tile, what we have been calling a possibility of manifestation. The goal has to be baked into the entire world process.

Reductionism is the idea that more complex systems can be explained by simpler systems. That requires that the elements of the simpler system interact in a certain way to create the complex system. But that interaction is the very definition of the complex system and was not predicted from the simple system.

Theories of everything or the big bang theory have predicted nothing significant. They cannot even predict the daily activity of a small city.

Social Studies Actually, life in the city can be understood to a large extent, if you really try. But the effort will make you few friends.

The Laws of Physics There are no laws of physics that need to be obeyed. As Albert Einstein admitted in the *Evolution of Physics*, a theory is the free creation of the human mind. Newton’s theory of gravitation was his creation, yet is certainly false. Einstein’s theory of gravity is

Einstein's gravitation; better than Newton's, but most physicists don't believe it is really true.

A sonnet follows the convention of 14 lines with a particular rhyming pattern. A scientific theory has its own convention: it has to "save the appearances", i.e., it explains the phenomena we experience. It is not falsified, that is, no phenomena had refuted it. Ideally, it should predict future phenomena. Relying on "chance" hardly qualifies as an explanation.

The Theory of Evolution Neo-Darwinism = Darwinism + genes. That is the proper name, not the "Theory of Evolution", because nothing evolves. One species disappears, another appears. A proper theory will explain in detail the entire process. Neo-Darwinism may be true, but not as it is currently understood.

It is like attending a seminar on achieving financial independence, and learning that the secret is to play the slot machines at the casino. Certainly, one of the attendees might hit the jackpot at some point, but that hardly makes the advice very sound.

The Tunnel Imagine that every time you drove your automobile through a tunnel, you didn't know where you would come out on the other side, because you would create a diffusion pattern. You should be grateful that you don't follow the "laws of physics".

Time Travel The equations of physics work in both time directions. The equation is the same whether the particle is moving forward in time or backward in time, so it is hard to tell which is which. I am pretty sure that I could tell which direction I am traveling. For example, were I going backward in time 20 years, I would be much healthier. So much for that law of physics.

Unscrambling an Egg The one exception is the second “law” of thermodynamics, which states the entropy is always increasing. It means that disorder is increasing, so things can’t be getting “better and better”. So we should be able to determine the direction of time by measuring entropy.

However, at least one physicist has a better explanation: what we call order and disorder are simply different states of the system. So if I break an egg and scramble it, the “egg in the shell” and the “scrambled egg in the pan” are just two different states of the egg. You may have noticed that no two scrambled eggs look exactly alike. You can scramble eggs, probably daily for the next hundred years, and no two will be exactly alike. Nevertheless, the scrambled state is much more likely than the egg-in-the-shell state.

The shell state always a possibility, and from the standpoint of physics, neither state is more privileged than the other. Just as the particle in motion may be going backward in time, the scrambled egg could return to the shell state without violating any law of physics.

Miracles This gives us a better understanding of miracles. A miracle is the manifestation of a not very likely state of matter. We are deluded into thinking that our common experience is somehow necessary, whereas it is merely the more likely scenario. It is not contrary to any “laws” of physics for a system to be in one state rather than another.

For example, it is unlikely that you will win the lottery, but it is very likely that someone will win. The winner was fortunate to be in the most unlikely state of being.

Objective Reality For some reason, we think that our experience of the world out there, right now, is “objective” while our inner life is “subjective”. The opposite is the case. Our knowledge of the external world is a matter of opinion, subject to change. We create a representation of the world, which may be called the “collective conscious”. Whatever doesn’t

fit is our unconscious; e.g., black holes, the centre of the earth.

On the other hand, we are certain of our inner experiences, at least our conscious experience, even if much of our inner life is unconscious.

Posted on 2020-09-02 by Cologero

* * *

J. R. R. Tolkien on 2020-09-02 at 03:58 said:

Cologero.

This regards something other than the topic here, Do you know anything about the order created by Peladan that is active in this very day?

Namely, the Kabbalistic Order of the Rose-Cross. Do you know if they have a valid initiation? It seems to me they are frauds... But they claim that they have rites that are primordial. The order continued after Peladan with Papus and de Guaita, but then the clergy of a Gnostic church sect became their leaders, today's leader is a 33 degree Freemason who promotes Thomas Jefferson's Bible that exclude the divinity of Christ, and removes all miracles, reducing the Christ to a spiritual advisor. The new leader of theirs also promotes humanism in his site. Maybe I am wrong about them being frauds?

Cologero on 2020-09-02 at 05:11 said:

Why don't you just spend the \$299 for your initiation and let us know?

J. R. R. Tolkien on 2020-09-03 at 00:52 said:

I will do, and once I am initiated, I will make my own order to be able to initiate others for a cheap price, because that's just too much money for the poor people who can't afford it. :(

J. R. R. Tolkien on 2020-09-03 at 01:00 said:

"Meyrink was certainly in the current of very numerous traditional ideas, especially of a Jewish source; but, not to mention that this presupposes precisely an initiation" Letter VII to Evola, Guénon

According to Guénon in an article here, to have traditional ideas presupposes initiation?

1. The person has traditional ideas in a period where people are tending against it.
2. Therefore this person has received a proper initiation.

Wouldn't this mean that initiation doesn't require attachment to a true tradition, if it's just a matter of ideas? Is Guénon in opposition to what he wrote before, or is this my incomprehension?

burningfireeye on 2020-09-03 at 11:22 said:

Since you talked about psychopaths here, I wanted to think about what it would be for a psychopath to become a Christian. I know a Christian apologist who is himself a psychopath, his name is David Wood, and here's a video of him explaining what it is to be a Christian psychopath: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=isxA4qvLUwg>

What David did not say is that psychopaths do not recognize feelings towards evil doings, but they certainly recognize chaos, they recognize that blind yearning towards more and more material things can never satisfy the will, even the "pleasure" of killing people is chaotic, they can realize that if everyone was like them, there would be no more order, and this is one of the things that cause anxiety in them, another thing that causes horror in them is nihilism, the world of chaos, the world that makes no sense. They can recognize that we are ultimately in need of order, and they can recognize God as the supreme order, the supreme Good, and Beauty, and in this they can realize that it is important not to harm others, so that they too can be in harmony with the cosmos. They are able to control their actions, but they don't have feelings like normal people have, which means they can be responsible for an evil action, they know what is an evil action as a normal person, they know it leads to chaos and insanity, but they don't feel guilt in the same way, which then makes it harder for them.

Now modernity especially is a period where people are very sentimental and compassionate, whereas in others periods, right reason was the rule rather than emotion, so they can understand that killing a being is evil because life has an intrinsic value, and will not do it because of right reason, and not because of emotion, this they would be able to assimilate and understand. Normal people also have evil thoughts in their minds all the time, they are capable of doing many terrible things, the only thing stopping them is fear, or because it is "disgusting". Everyone can be disciplined to learning to do good and avoiding evil, profound change of conscience is possible, also supernaturally the person can be changed by forces that are not merely natural, if they seek the Above.

burningfireeye on 2020-09-03 at 11:29 said:

The person can be changed through subtle forces of nature that are not merely natural. As is the case of acupuncture, and other forms of medicine.

burningfireeye on 2020-09-04 at 00:17 said:

Again, it is very easy for a psychopath to become egoistical, to become liars and deceivers, because they don't have any bad feelings towards others, their conscience does not accuse them. But it is not true that they are driven towards evil, or that it is natural for them to feel pleasure in killing, this is an acquired pleasure. Again, normal people have thoughts of killing others and probably would kill if no one was around, and if it wasn't so dirty and smelly, so it is the same, they have also these thoughts, but without the remorse, without any weights in their conscience.

But they are guilty of their actions, the maxim “do not unto others what you would not want done to yourself” is obvious, they know that when they commit these actions against others they wouldn’t want it done against themselves, and they know they are disrupting the common order and good, that’s why they can repent their sins like David Wood, they would rather believe in God and in the supreme order of the universe than to believe in chaos and misery, that when they abandon that Eternal Reason, things become meaningless.

burningfireeye on 2020-09-04 at 00:31 said:

It is also possible for a normal person to become as a psychopath, which is a sociopath. The world is guided by forces beyond the physical realm, and the psychology of today cannot explain much of the psychological phenomena. In the world of today, people are leaning that chaos is natural, they learn that the unnatural is healthy, and that they are an evolved form, they are in battle against nature, in this world it would seem impossible for a psychopath to become a Christian, because given that it is extremely hard for a normal person to accept Christianity which is being shown as against progress and evolution, it would be impossible for the one born with the dispositions, but that is not exactly true, in the first place, it is very difficult to diagnose someone as being a psychopath, just as it is difficult to diagnose any normal pathologies for people with normal intelligence, that is because the forces that act in the human being are obviously not just physical, but for a person to understand that is very hard, because the scientists don’t want anyone to think in any way different from the way they themselves think, it is the danger of excommunication that imprisons many people’s conscience.

10.6 A Million to One

When reason comes out against the reality of life and knowledge with a consciousness of its own supreme rights, it finds that everything in life is alien, dark, and impenetrable, and it cannot do anything with it.

VLADIMIR SOLOVYOV, *Lectures on Divine Humanity*

The British mathematician **John Littlewood** claimed that everyone might experience a “miraculous” event every month or so. He assumed that we experience an event every second, which may be exceptional or unexceptional, so that there will be one million events every 35 days. A mira-

cle is defined as an event with a probability of one in a million. Somehow, the conclusion is that there are no exceptional events. This has become known as Littlewood's Law⁸.

Queen of Hearts As an example, someone recently proposed that there should be nothing surprising in being dealt 13 hearts in a game of Bridge. The reason is that the sequence of cards is no more unlikely than any other sequence of cards. The human mind simply does not recognize that other sequences are also equally exceptional mathematically.

However, a Bridge player is not concerned with the specific order of cards, just with the number of cards in each suit. Arguments like that are not uncommon, but their flaw is failing to distinguish permutations from combinations. The former takes the specific order into account, but the latter views the cards as aggregates.

For example, there are $13!$ sequential ways to get 13 hearts. That is a large number, but trivial in respect to the 3,954,242,643,910,000,000,000 possible permutations of Bridge hands.

Ignoring the order, there are only 635,013,559,600 possible bridge hands, or combinations. Therefore, a hand with 13 hearts is just one out of 600 million possible hands; that is what makes it unusual. There are many, many more hands with 3 or 4 hearts, regardless of the order.

It is true that each permutation of cards is equiprobable, but that makes it useless in terms of information content. Combinations, on the other hand, are information rich and compact, since each hand can be expressed by the number of cards in each suit.

Lack of Knowledge In the above example, if every living human were dealt 100 bridge hands, then there is a very high likelihood that one of them will be 13 hearts. Uncertainty may result from a lack of knowledge

⁸https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Littlewood's_law

or from an inherent random process⁹.

In the example, we know the rules of Bridge, so we interpret the 13 hearts in that context; a hand with 13 hearts is a legitimate outcome. But someone, not in the game, who unexpectedly finds a hand with 13 hearts may interpret it differently. Actually, the sequence of cards is predetermined in the deck; those are “hidden variables”. Therefore, the cards should be reshuffled after each card is dealt, to eliminate that effect.

Radioactive Rocks Radioactive decay is, apparently, inherently random. A physicist cannot determine in advance which particular atom will decay. Nevertheless, within a 24 hour timeframe, he can predict how many atoms will have decayed. This is another example of permutations — the order of decay — versus combinations. The combinations provide useful information about the half life of the element.

This is an example of how totally random events can reveal a pattern.

Abandon Hope Suppose you find yourself wandering aimlessly in the forest of life. Every so often you see a sign or a billboard with Latin letters on it, but they don’t seem to relate to any known language. Eventually you come across the mouth of a cave with this sign above it: “*Abandon hope, all ye who enter here.*”

The hard nosed scientist on your left shoulder tells you, “You can ignore that sign. The sequence of letters has the same probability as all the other signs that we have seen. It is totally unexceptional, just one event in a million.”

Your spiritual guide on your right shoulder objects: “That warning cannot be random so it must be a serious message. Under the circumstances, you need to walk around that cave.”

⁹<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Randomness>

Search for Intelligent Life The cave sign is an example of specified complexity¹⁰. The concept is still valid despite its bad reputation due to its association with intelligent design. Critics point out that the concept has no formal mathematical definition. Of course not, because specified complexity has meaning only to an intelligent observer. Mathematically, it is just another pattern.

However, the SETI project¹¹ scans electromagnetic radiation from outer space looking for patterns, i.e., complexity, that would indicate an intelligent source. At the same time, scientists are broadcasting patterns into space in the hope that extraterrestrial intelligences will recognize them.

Stephen Hawking believes that it is unwise to alert extraterrestrial intelligences to our existence on the grounds that they may destroy us. On the other hand, extraterrestrial intelligences would likely have discovered Littlewood's Law, so that they would interpret signals from earth as simple random sequences, of little significance.

Living in the Real World Random events are unrelated to each other. But is that true, as Littlewood's Law requires? In that case, we are forever doomed to experience the world as a "blooming, buzzing confusion", as babies do according to **William James**. But that is not the case, not even for babies. The world is intelligible so we look for patterns, combinations, and specified complexity in the events of our experience. If we sometimes get it wrong or misinterpret events, that does not invalidate intelligibility.

Even events that are not causally related can be meaningfully related, as in synchronicity¹². Is that purely subjective? So what? Aren't your dreams, your plans, your desires also subjective? That does not make them

¹⁰https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Specified_complexity

¹¹https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Search_for_extraterrestrial_intelligence

¹²<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Synchronicity>

unreal; moreover, your life is desiccated without them. Obviously, such experiences cannot be accounted for in mainstream science, yet have a place in revolutionary science¹³. In practice, randomness may be hard to distinguish from a pattern. But like the dark side of the moon, the real meaning of an event is usually hidden from plain view.

For event #1 million, suppose you observe an electron suddenly changes its spin. Is that random, or is it because the electron is entangled with another one, a million miles away? How does that affect your next choice?

Among the men and women the multitude,
I perceive one picking me out by secret and divine signs,
Acknowledging none else, not parent, wife, husband, brother,
child, any nearer than I am,
Some are baffled, but that one is not — that one knows me.

Ah lover and perfect equal,
I meant that you should discover me so by my faint indirections,
And I when I meet you mean to discover you by the like in you.

WALT WHITMAN

Posted on 2022-07-19 by Cologero

10.7 A Revolutionary Kind of Science

Adam Kisby¹⁴ is a philosopher and a member of the Omega Society¹⁵, which only accepts one in a million on a test of general intelligence. One of his primary interests is anomalistics, which is the study of unusual and unexplained phenomena. What follows is a brief review of his book *A*

¹³See Section 10.7 of this book.

¹⁴<https://lifeboat.com/ex/bios.adam.kisby>

¹⁵<http://www.theomegasociety.com/>

*Revolutionary Kind of Science*¹⁶ in which Kisby critiques the conventional understanding of the scientific method. He thinks that this method leaves out unusual, uncommon, or unique phenomena to the detriment of science. He then offers alternative scientific principles in which anomalies can be studied in a reasonable way.

Anomalistic Method “Normal Science” is the common use of science, such as the claims that “science shows ...”. It remains within a generally accepted paradigm, so it is often little more than establishing more accurate measurements.

Extraordinary science, on the other hand, seeks to explain the anomalies that contradict a prevailing paradigm, the sort exemplified by Copernicus, Galileo, Newton, Darwin, and Einstein, for example.

However, that sort of science has become moribund, mostly because anomalistics — the study of anomalous data — has failed to affect prevailing paradigms. Charles Fort, in a series of books, documented many cases of unusual events; thus, he is considered to be the father of anomalistics. Since then, several other researchers have contributed many more examples. Marcello Truzzi defined four regulatory principles for a science of anomalistics:

- **Principle of Testability:** data should be verifiable (Bacon) or falsifiable (Popper)
- **Principle of Parsimony:** explanation should be as simple as possible (William of Ockham)
- **Principle of Burden of Proof:** data should be doubted in the absence of proof (Descartes)

¹⁶<https://www.blurb.com/b/4168343-a-revolutionary-kind-of-science>

- **Principle of Proportionality of Evidence:** evidence should be commensurate with the degree of extraordinariness (Hume)

Kisby goes on to analyze each of those principles in depth from philosophic, scientific, and anomalistics perspectives. Here, we can only highlight some of the main points.

Testability Testability requires that a theory should be verifiable or falsifiable. These criteria may seem obvious, but Kisby shows that there is more ambiguity in them than is obvious at first sight.

Verifiability excludes phenomena that are unverifiable, unmeasurable, or undetectable. Examples are the anecdotal stories of reincarnation or the efficacy of very dilute homeopathic medicines.

Falsifiability excludes unfalsifiable phenomena such as unknown hominids and extraterrestrial intelligences.

Parsimony The human mind prefers a comprehensible map of theory to an incomprehensible territory of data. The simpler theory is better all other factors being equal. It does not mean that all explanations are simple. In practice it is not always possible to eliminate complex theories. Examples are Chaos Theory and Mandelbrot sets; they explain everyday phenomena, yet are far from simple.

Ultimately, an explanation must “save the appearances”, whether simple or complex. Parsimony excludes phenomena that are irreducibly complex, chaotic, or nonlinear.

Burden of Proof

I ought to reject as absolutely false all opinions in regard to which I could suppose the least ground for doubt, in order to ascertain whether after that, there remained aught in my belief that was wholly indubitable.

RENE DESCARTES

In practice, this means that the claimant has the burden of proof. Kisby points out several reasons to doubt skepticism. For example, it took decades to convince all scientists of the extraterrestrial origins of meteorites.

The proper attitude should be *zetetic*, which entails a suspension of judgment about facts. In popular language, it means that it is OK not to be sure. Ultimately, prudent judgment is required which dogmatic skepticism dispenses with.

This principle excludes the possibility of cold fusion or the discovery of hidden causes behind historical processes.

Proportionality of Evidence

A wise man proportions his belief to the evidence.

DAVID HUME

This principle states that extraordinary claims — i.e., those that disagree with ordinary experience — require data of greater quantity or higher quality. In practice, however, this is not always useful. For example, rare events such as encounters with ghosts, UFOs, and yetis, may nevertheless correspond to real phenomena. The number of times an event occurs has no bearing on its truth.

This principle excludes phenomena that are uncommon, unusual, or unique, such as the existence of a fifth fundamental force of nature and psychokinesis.

A New Scientific Method Kisby concludes with a new scientific method. The four principles, while ostensibly maintaining scientific rigor, also operate as epistemic filters. These filters are inconsistent with reason, disagree with the findings of scientific research, and are incompatible with selected anomalies. They don't take into account:

- The counter-intuitive distinction between simplicity and complexity
- The profound effects of expectations on perception
- The supernatural beliefs of the general population
- The confusion about double blind experiments

Otherwise, there is the risk of omitting important data:

There are bona fide phenomena that are unverifiable, unmeasurable, undetectable, unfalsifiable, irreducibly complex, chaotic, non-linear, unexpected, unwanted, unexplainable, uncommon, unusual, and unique.

Kisby claims that such phenomena have implications for health and for a better self-understanding of humanity, among several other benefits. He then enumerates four principles that modify Truzzi's. Very briefly, these are:

- **The Principle of Mappability.** The data needs to be formally expressible and logically relatable to other data. It allows for data from different states of consciousness.
- **The Principle of Plenitude.** Since phenomena may be complex, then so may be the explanations.
- **The Principle of Suspended Judgment.** Since the level of belief or unbelief has effects on the perception of data, then the level of certainty of data must be on a scale.
- **The Principle of Truly Proportional Evidence.** Phenomena that occur less frequently will produce fewer data, and irregular events will not be predictable.

In summary, we can use these principles for a necessary extension of science. Some things happen once, like the beginning of the universe, the origin of life on earth, and rational consciousness. Who can doubt it, even if there are no fully convincing explanations for any of them.

Other phenomena may occur over the course of generations, too long to be observed in the lifetime of a scientific. Examples are the birth, death, and decay of cultures.

Posted on 2022-07-07 by Cologero

* * *

Dimitri on 2022-07-10 at 14:32 said:

Cologero, are you aware of Library Genesis (libgen.is) or ZLibrary (b-ok.cc) by any chance? If not you could certainly get a lot of use out of them.

Cologero on 2022-07-10 at 15:13 said:

It's more likely that those authors could get a lot of use from reading Gornahoor. Why don't you point that out to them?

Dimitri on 2022-07-10 at 18:05 said:

These are file sharing platforms where you can upload and download books in digital form like pdf and epub for free; they have books by all sorts of authors, even rare works or things written by the men cited here on Gornahoor from Guenon to Tomberg to Solovyov and so on. I thought you might find it useful if you hadn't heard of it before.

10.8 The Nature of Things

Now I a fourfold vision see
And a fourfold vision is given to me
Tis fourfold in my supreme delight
And three fold in soft Beulah's night
And twofold Always.

*May God us keep
From Single vision & Newtons sleep.*

WILLIAM BLAKE

The height of poetry is to speak the language of the gods.

GEORGE SANTAYANA

The greatest art in theoretical and practical life consists in changing the *problem* into a *postulate*; that way one succeeds.

GOETHE

The first *causa* which occurred to his mind in reference to anything that needed explanation, satisfied him and passed for truth.

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE

At a recent gathering of some old friends, one of them, the most literary of the bunch, recommended that I read *The Swerve: How the World Became Modern* by **Stephen Greenblatt**. It is allegedly about the attempt in the Renaissance to recover a lost version of **Lucretius's** *Nature of Things*. Then the argument is that the discovery of that poem then “created” modernity. To dramatize the event, she claimed that the poem was “suppressed” as it was a “threat” to the world order.

When I hear words like that, I already know that the book is tendentious; therefore, I immediately resolved not to bother with it. Nevertheless, in a flash, the following essay came into my mind. Now she might have been able to follow it, but I sadly realized that no one else sitting around the table would have had the least interest.

Now “threatening” ideas have a certain erotic appeal to literary types, like the way the good girl often prefers the proverbial bad boy biker. Unfortunately, once understood, Lucretius turns out to be quite melancholy.

According to St. Jerome, he committed suicide. Some doubt Jerome's account, although it is quite consistent with his philosophy: one has the right to choose the time and manner of death, since it is ultimately inevitable.

Melancholy is thus hidden at the center of the modern world. It is evaded through the pursuit of material goods and ever more exotic pleasures. Death is denied even though popular culture is replete with stories of death and murder. Nevertheless, the West is dying, and through its own choosing. Instead of admitting to suicide, the cause is sought elsewhere: e.g., climate change, the patriarchy, racial degeneration, and so on.

So Lucretius is hardly an unmixed blessing. Rather than being "suppressed" as a "threat", the actual situation is that the Medievals were not attracted to, nor interested in, the philosophical positions espoused by Lucretius. For them, the cosmos was a moral cosmos, with forces of light and darkness in combat with each other. Moreover, the movements of the atoms were neither blind nor random, but rather were directed by transcendent forces. Lucretius had nothing to offer.

An example might help. Cows cannot study philosophy because they graze all day with their nose to the ground. Man has long intestines, so he doesn't have to eat all day. The atomist, like Lucretius, would attribute that difference to random variations. The Platonist, however, believes that the purpose of long intestines is to enable man to study philosophy.

Philosophical disputes are usually unresolvable, due to different starting points. What we can do instead is to examine the suppositions of a system and follow where it logically leads. Now most people are inconsistent in their thought patterns, and are often reluctant to accept the necessary conclusions of their worldview. Nevertheless, the spirit will follow that logic, even if it requires centuries to unfold. The full consequences of the birth of modernity are yet to be experienced.

The Hermetic Method The Hermetic method is not to try to refute one theory with another, but rather to arrange all knowledge in a more comprehensive system. Hence, there are aspects of Lucretius's vision that we can sympathize with. To avoid Single vision, I rely somewhat on **George Santayana's** little book: *Three Philosophical Poets: Lucretius, Dante, Goethe*. He calls them respectively the Poet of Naturalism, the Poet of Supernaturalism, and the Poet of Romanticism.

Although Santayana ultimately sides with Lucretius, the situation is more complex. That is because we accept the one thing that Santayana denies, viz., the existence of other worlds. Santayana considers the possibility that after death we might wake up into a world in which the atomic philosophy does not apply. He rejects that idea as an idle fantasy, but Hermetists do not. In the lower world, the one created by man, the atomic philosophy does indeed apply. But Dante and Goethe do reveal higher worlds.

Foundation Lucretius is the third in a chain that began with Democritus and continued with Epicurus. They embody the philosophy of atomism, materialism, and naturalism, which I shall use interchangeably. Epicurus developed an ethical system based on naturalism, called appropriately Epicureanism. The discovery of Lucretius's poem in the 15th century did bring to light the doctrine of atomism. Insofar as the foundation of the modern world rests on naturalism and a vague humanism as its ethical system, perhaps we can view Lucretius as the harbinger of modernity.

However, if Lucretius was indeed a threat 500 years ago, that is not at all the case now. Rather the threat comes from those few who understand the crisis of the modern world and are in revolt against it.

Atomism The fundamental idea is that the world is made of space and atoms of matter. These atoms are in motion through space, arranging

themselves in patterns, which account for our experience of things. These patterns arise and decay, so there is life and there is death. Empedocles identified these forces as Love and Strife. Lucretius calls them Venus and Mars, and Sigmund Freud, Eros and Thanatos.

Since the life instinct is so strong, the corresponding death instinct is not always taken into account. Epicurus regarded the denial of death as the root of human neurosis, so the cure is to come to terms with the end of both the life and the soul at death.

The elusive third force is necessarily left out of any philosophy of naturalism, so there is no room here for the Holy Spirit and the reconciler of life and death.

The Soul Even the soul is material. Of course, for Tradition also, the animal soul is material, so the human soul is material inasmuch as it comprises both animal and vegetable souls. Hence, for the atomist, the human being is just a type of animal; that is likewise the educated opinion of modernity. Nothing distinguishes essentially human from animal life; the former is merely a more complex arrangement of atoms compared to the latter

Animal life is limited to a few main features: eating, mating, caring for young, avoiding pain and death. Those activities are pre-philosophical, that is, no argument is necessary to engage in them. On the contrary, bad arguments are used to evade animal life, such as reproductive sex or raising children.

The Traditional view is that the human being is more than a material, animal soul. He is a spirit. Santayana understands that perfectly well, when he writes:

A spirit would in any case not be human, but altogether divine.

Precisely. Man is either an animal or a god ... or both.

Modes of Experience There are four modes of our experience of the world: touch, vision, thinking, and consciousness. Tradition ranks that list from least reliable to most reliable, while for naturalism, it is just the reverse.

Touch Democritus asserted that materiality consisted of extension, figure, and solidity. That is, materiality is whatever can be touched. This leads to quantity as the only objective measure of reality. By focusing on these primary qualities, this allowed Galileo to simplify his observations. Galileo readily adopted atomism in his works. That story is ably described by **Henri Bortoft** in *The Wholeness of Nature*. There is no space there to review Bortoft's account, but it is necessary to focus on his main point. Bortoft shows that Galileo did not *prove* atomism based on his empirical research; rather, he simply assumed it, and creatively drew out its consequences. In other words, he turned the problem into a postulate.

Vision Vision, broadly speaking, refers to all the senses that don't require contact (e.g., hearing, smelling). For the atomists, all qualities beyond materiality are apparent only, and are imputed to things merely by convention. This includes, at a minimum, light, colour, taste, warmth, beauty, excellence, and so on. Only space and matter are real.

Obviously, such a teaching reduces the most important aspects of life to arbitrary conventions. Somehow or another, the "good news" of atomism has still not fully penetrated modernity. People still insist on arguing endlessly about such "secondary qualities", simply forgetting that only space and matter are real.

Thinking What should the atomist think about? I suppose he could be a scientist, thinking about space and matter. That brought a certain amount of excitement for several generations of scientists beginning

with Galileo and Newton. But science falters when dealing with social life.

For the common person, the thoughts of the physicist are much too difficult. Hence, they are not reproducible in his consciousness. For the Platonist, however, science is easy. The higher realms of human knowledge—politics, metaphysics, theology—are much more difficult. The common person disagrees. Science is indeed hard, but everyone believes his ideas of political issues, philosophy, religion, and God are somehow correct. As Nietzsche points out, humans are easily satisfied with the first explanation that pops into their mind. That is why, for most people, their views on such topics are not much different from what they believed at the age of 19.

Consciousness For the atomist, the soul is the life of the body, and consciousness plays no role. At best, it is an epiphenomenon, and at worst, a delusion. Let this sink in. Our self-identity as a person is due to our conscious experience. However, for the materialist our identity is in the brain which secretes thoughts independent of any belief in an individual will. A leading new atheist assures us that the “self” is an illusion, if “assurance” is the right word.

Illusion or not, that is our experience. So the atomist position in a nutshell is this: reality is the random motion of atoms in space, which arrange themselves in patterns, only to have them dissipate. Consciousness is merely the passive, and helpless, observer of that drama. The delusional self is therefore trapped in conscious experience, whether good, bad, or indifferent. This brings us to the Gnostics who rebelled against such a view. They believed that a demon had created the world described by the atomists, so they hoped that the real God would rescue their spirit soul from that trap.

The modern man has lost even that hope. He believes that distractions such as Netflix or TV, along with psychoactive drugs, medically

prescribed or not, will save him.

Morality The question arises for modernity: if atomism is true, how then should we live? Epicurus developed a moral system consistent with atomism which goes by the name of hedonism. If Lucretius was melancholic, Epicurus hated life. Hence, unlike modern misconceptions, the hedonist sought only simple and moderate pleasures. Withdrawn from social life, he sought the company of a few close friends in his garden.

Santayana held the contrary view. He believed the materialist should love life. Perhaps so, since it made no moral demands on him. Of course, Santayana could believe that since he was blessed with time, money, and intelligence. For many others, their material life holds few attractions, but is mostly hardship, struggle, and lack. I suppose that a saintly hedonist could be indifferent to the atomic world process, but that is hardly the same as “loving” it.

Human Society Modernity has taken the atomic idea one step further. Applying atomism to humanity, the postulate is that each human being is an atom. Therefore, people are quantitative and any attribution of secondary qualities is purely subjective and conventional. The obvious corollary is that qualities such as race, ethnicity, and even gender, are socially constructed. This is indisputable since it is a postulate, not a theory requiring proof.

Leibniz had a similar, yet radically different, conception. He called the atoms “monads”, each of which has its own qualities. This is the polar opposite to Democritus. The monad is real, but space, matter, and motion are merely phenomenal. Modernity has preferred to follow the ideas of Newton rather than those of Leibniz.

Posted on 2018-01-21 by Cologero

10.9 Gods of Physics

There is a reason why physicists make lousy philosophers. It's because they believe that physics itself is philosophy. What they take to be novel theories turn out to be equivalent to philosophical propositions, both good and bad. Since I listen to physics videos on youtube during my spare time, here are some topics that came up. I would have liked to interview some of them with my own questions.

Hilbert's Hotel One fellow who claims to represent the Council of Trent is obsessed with the Kalam Argument. I have some sympathy for the argument because an infinite past is incoherent. Certain types think that Descartes's number line is well-ordered. No, actually, it is not so.

So he posted three videos on the topic, parts of which I attended. The most recent one showed confusion by using amount, number, and cardinality interchangeably. They debated Hilbert's Hotel incessantly as if it represents reality. It is a joke, just like Schrödinger's Cat. The Hotel depends on ordinal numbers, not cardinal numbers. That is why the new guest needs to be moved into the first room rather than at the end. The math of ordinal numbers show why: $1 + \omega = \omega$ but $\omega + 1 \neq \omega$.

Suppose the set of rooms are numbered from 1 onward and each guest is given an even account number. Hence, there is a bijection between the set of rooms and set of guests (each room number matches an account number). So where does the new guest come from? Is there an even number that no one has ever discovered?

Actual Infinity This is another confused notion, although it used to be debated. What he really means is that there are an infinite number of things in the world. Our understanding of that matter has changed. "Infinite" should be restricted to mean "unbounded", and "transfinite" for set theory. Then you can ask if the number of things in the world is

countably infinite, or even more. But that is a question for the physicist to answer, since it is a question about the material world. There is no theory nor evidence to support it, so the answer is probably no.

Presentism This is the belief that only “now” is real, but not the past nor future. It’s an odd way to pose the question, since time is ideal, not real. The metaphysical teaching is that all manifest things are compossible.

Gödel’s theorem Although the proof brilliant, the impact is exaggerated. No mathematician has been put out of work by this theorem. It shows that computing machines cannot generate proofs algorithmically. But if we know that something is true, then it does not matter at all.

Evolutionary Biology A fellow who calls himself the Jolly Heretic has a degree in theology (i.e., religious studies) but now calls himself an evolutionary biologist. That shows why the field is suspect.

He demonstrates statistically that religious belief is healthy both for individuals and society. He attributes this to healthy genes. Unbelievers will fail to breed themselves in sufficient numbers. Nevertheless, he personally is an atheist. So this is an imaginary interview:

Q: Why are you an atheist?

A: Because I don’t see the evidence for God. (He expressed this view.)

1. That can’t be true, since you don’t believe in free will.
2. Then what is the reason?
3. It is because you don’t have the religion gene, as you yourself argue. That makes you a dysgenic mutant. Since you accept group selection, that makes you a danger to the social structure. It is more than just a personal opinion. Ergo, a healthy society would work to limit your influence.

Moral Burden One fellow desperately seeking Theories of Everything revealed that a great moral burden was lifted from him when he accepted atheism. He did not reveal his moral flaw. But his position is not unusual. Most atheists are not really persuaded by arguments; rather they despise a world in which God exists.

Necessary Being The physicist needs to answer the question about the necessity of the existence of the universe. If the universe is contingent, then what caused it? If the universe is necessary, then that is what we mean by God.

Prime Matter Prime matter is “chaos”, that is, it is totally undifferentiated. This is *materia prima*. Physicists then study what Guenon calls *materia seconda*. The lowest order accessible to physicists is the quantum field, which is just a probability distribution. It is nothing in particular.

How and why did particular things arise? That is the measurement problem, which is not understood.

Predetermined Some physicists believe that everything that happens was predetermined. As such, there is no physical proof, nor can there ever be. That is because the part cannot understand the whole; moreover, much of the math is not computable in a finite amount of time. This suggests that the universe is not executing an algorithm.

Suppose, however, that determinism is true. That implies that all possibilities of manifestation pre-existed in the Big Bang. A more sensible version of the same idea is that everything exists in God’s mind. Hence, they introduced nothing new.

Conformal Geometry Conformal geometry is being used to show that the end of one universe becomes the Big Bang of the next. Interesting.

Traditional teaching is that the end of one cycle is the beginning of the next. Perhaps the physicists have discovered the series of manvantaras.

Posted on 2022-03-06 by Cologero

10.10 NASA, the Moon, Genesis and the Tao

In the beginning God created heaven and earth.

GENESIS 1:1

The Tao that can be stated, is not the eternal Tao;
The name that can be named, is not the eternal name.
The nameless is the origin of heaven and earth.

TAO TE CHING

In the esoteric traditions, Heaven and Earth have been interpreted as Essence (or Form) and Matter. **Meister Eckhart** acknowledges this understanding:

Matter and Form are not two kinds of existent entities, but two principles of created beings. That is the meaning of the words:
In the beginning God created heaven and earth — viz., form and matter, two principles of things.

In the interview linked below, Wolfgang Smith seems to be endorsing geocentrism, not as one possible frame of reference, but in an absolute sense: the earth does not move while the universe revolves around it every 24 hours. Yet he hedges by acknowledging the truth of heliocentrism in the sense that the Sun is the symbol of God. So geocentrism would be

the exoteric teaching, i.e., as it appears to the senses, while heliocentrism is the truer, esoteric teaching.

So when the interviewer quotes Genesis 1:1 to “prove” that the physical earth was the first object created, Dr. Smith rejoins with the Eckhart quote.

However, Dr. Smith apparently has committed to the unmoving earth theory. He asserts that the Michelson–Morley experiment shows that the Earth stood still, which is not necessarily so. That requires that the **Theory of Relativity** be abandoned in toto, presumably because classical mechanics and Maxwell’s equations are adequate for physics. It would need to be demonstrated that physics can account for a world that is created fully formed, unmoved and unchanging. Only God is unmoved and only the eternal is unchanging.

We than make the following proposal to NASA when it resumes voyages to the moon:

Perform the Michelson–Morley experiment on the Moon.

That would settle the question. If the result is the same, then the moon cannot also be still. If the result shows a change in the velocity of light, then the earth is still.

Postscript In traditional cosmology, the position of Earth is the furthest from Heaven and the closest to Hell. If that is what geocentrism means, then it must be true.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=71i22w5G9KE>

Posted on 2020-06-27 by Losang Shenphen

* * *

Dennis on 2020-06-29 at 13:17 said:

As it happens, just last week I saw both "The Principle" and the new film based on Smith's life and work, "The End of Quantum Reality," and also read Smith's companion book, "Physics and Vertical Causation."

Frankly, I'm not too sure what to think of all of it, as I don't have adequate physics background to assess the details. It seems convincing from a certain philosophical standpoint, especially his effort to separate physics as such from the philosophy or theology of physics (though I'm not quite clear on his distinction between corporeal and physical, which I had always seen as basically synonymous). He does indeed, in the book anyway (the latter film is rather schematic, and without the book or knowledge of Smith's previous work, would not be very convincing or clear) abandon Einsteinian Relativity in toto, as well as Cartesian "bifurcation" between *res extensae* and *res cogitantes*.

Several of the people interviewed in *The Principle* later denounced the film and claimed they were deceived or their interviews distorted in some way, though they seemed to me to be given plenty of space in the film to make their views clear. I think they are engaging in some post-facto CYA to avoid the risk of being tarnished in the academy and the eyes of their peers for having appeared at all). Smith also seems to rely heavily of William Dembski's controversial work. I can't tell if the criticisms some have of Dembski's work is purely mathematical, or whether the scientific establishment, committed as it is to materialism and secularism is just circling the wagons and doing everything to discredit any ideas that open the door for belief in God.

The stuff about the CMB lining up with the ecliptic was quite interesting, and you could see a couple of the interviewees struggling in *The Principle* to avoid drawing the conclusions from it that they felt the science otherwise would compel them to (because it contradicts their prior philosophical commitments regarding the place of earth in the cosmos).

I tend to see geocentrism as a metaphysical and spiritual truth about Man's place in the cosmos, one that doesn't depend on the earth being literally stationary or placed at the physical center (How could one ever determine the center anyway unless we could define the actual boundaries of the universe?). And in any case, isn't our view of the cosmos necessarily geocentric in that we can only view the universe from where we are and have no vantage point outside the universe from which to look into it (from a God's Eye view as it were)?

Cologero on 2020-06-29 at 22:45 said:

@Dennis, there are too many layers to this. I believe the goal is to prove that the Bible requires a stationary earth. We can't accept that, since there are multiple layers of interpretation. Dante in the *Paradiso* accepts the same model of the universe: Paradise is depicted as a series of concentric spheres surrounding the Earth, consisting of the Moon, Mercury, Venus, the Sun, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, the Fixed Stars, the *Primum Mobile* and finally, the *Empyrean*. (from Wikipedia)

But Dante understood that as the soul's spiritual ascent to God, not as a physical journey.

Otherwise, you could reach Heaven just by building a nice rocket ship.

It is one thing to assume that the earth does not move, but to assume that the earth does not even rotate on its axis leads to some impossibilities. As I understand it, the claim is that geocentrism is consistent with classical physics (mechanics and Maxwell's equations), as long as the Theories of Relativity are rejected. But Neptune – never mind the stars – would have to move faster than the speed of light to make it around the earth in 24 hours. There is no physics to explain that motion; certainly not Newton's gravity equation.

We will accept whichever model accords with observation and physics; we don't "root" for any particular physical model to be true.

However, the description of the soul's ascent to God through the spheres is much more important. That is non-negotiable.

Boreas on 2020-07-03 at 16:07 said:

The last time I read Smith's views he advocated "a relativistic geo-centrism" and hadn't thrown the theory of relativity straight out from the window. That was something I could accept since it accords with the traditional view and is spiritually and physically tenable. It seems that his views have hardened on the matter, and have taken an absolute stance. That is something I reject.

Cologero on 2020-07-05 at 20:42 said:

I don't know what to make of it. The fellows he works with are quite sincere, very creative, and have put a lot of effort into their videos and web site. But you can't have relativity and geocentrism together, so I understand the rejection. Unfortunately, since geocentrism a non-inertial reference frame, Newton's laws of force and gravity don't even apply. So you end up with a model that has no physical explanation for the revolution of the universe around earth. I haven't seen the videos, so perhaps they contain the explanation.

Boreas on 2020-07-07 at 05:07 said:

The way he explained the "relativistic geocentrism" in his earlier works was that from the perspective of the theory of relativity you can logically assume that either the earth revolves around the sun or the opposite, and these are the esoteric and exoteric applications.

Tom Hart on 2020-07-17 at 16:29 said:

Related topic: NASA just announced a new star sign, the serpent-bearer (represented by a Hermetic caduceus). This sign, the 13th, is rocking some kundalini energy, but my intuition is that it's an attempt to corrupt astrology, since, in a very corrupted form, astrology one of the few Traditional practices that has survived into modernity. I recall reading that the 13th seat at a table, per the legend of King Arthur, should be kept empty – i.e. by making something that

should be occult visible, NASA has corrupted the symbolism. However, the visibility of the snake is also, probably, a sign that the age is turning—the old order is dying in snake-like chaos, as current political events demonstrate. In attempting to destroy the sacred order, NASA becomes the unwitting handmaiden of purification.

10.II *Ex Machina* or the Esoteric Turing Test

In which, under the guise of a film review, we discuss Turing's test, the nature of animal man, and the treachery of woman. We conclude with the revelation of the method if you make it that far.

*Ex Machina*¹⁷ is a 2015 cult film, directed by **Alex Garland**, about the consciousness of an artificial android. Caleb, a software developer, is selected to spend a week at the home/laboratory of Nathan, the reclusive founder of his company called “Bluebook”. The home is built into the side of a mountain, remote from any trace of other people, of almost Edenic beauty. Ostensibly, Caleb is to judge whether Nathan's homunculus named “Ava” (or Eve ... get it?) passes the “Turing test”. Actually, Caleb is himself part of the experiment. Or perhaps even Nathan.

Since Garland seems to be quite familiar with Turing's writing, including the more obscure parts, it is worth the trouble to point these out.

Prelude The so-called Turing Test derives from an essay by **Alan Turing** titled *Computing Machinery and Intelligence*¹⁸. It was published in 1950 at a time when digital computers were quite



¹⁷<http://www.imdb.com/title/tt0470752/>

¹⁸https://www.gornahoor.net/library/Turing_Machine.pdf

primitive. Hence it took quite a bit of imagination to ponder all the issues involved with that question. The first step is to define precisely what qualifies as a machine and thinking.

By “machine”, Turing means specifically a digital computer, not essentially different in principle from what you use today. This type of machine executes “algorithms” which have an exact mathematical definition, although we can’t go into that here. “*Thinking*”, for Turing, is also quite objectively defined. If the machine can converse with a human interrogator in a convincing manner, then the machine can think by definition.

Turing proposed that the interrogator was not allowed to see, touch, or hear the machine. Obviously, Turing did not have Androids in mind. Caleb is allowed to see, touch, and hear the machine. Moreover, Caleb is even allowed to see that the Android has parts; this takes Turing’s test one step further.

The Machine Clearly there are two problems with that formulation. First of all, the human brain does not seem to behave like a digital computer. Rather, it uses analog signals between neurons, while a computer can only occupy discrete states. Turing notes this, but dismisses it. Humans can execute algorithms, he claims, so a computer should simulate it. True, but if you think about it, a very small part of human life is devoted to executing algorithms. Nevertheless, he correctly anticipated, even underestimating it, that computer power would increase tremendously. That, he wrote, should overcome all obstacles.

The second point is that his definition is not what we mean by “thinking”. Am I thinking only because I can convince a few of you readers that I am truly a human being? Like Descartes, I know I am thinking without the need to seek reassurance from you.

The most difficult objection to Turing is Lady Lovelace’s claim¹⁹ that

¹⁹https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ada_Lovelace

the machine can only do what we tell it to do. In response, Turing distinguishes between **sub-critical** and **super-critical** ideas.

Sub-critical ideas enter the mind, and one or fewer ideas will result from it. Super-critical ideas, although much rarer, have a sort of chain reaction. Turing elaborates:

An idea presented to such a mind may give rise to a whole ‘theory’ consisting of secondary, tertiary and more remote ideas. Animals minds seem to be very definitely subcritical. Adhering to this analogy we ask, ‘Can a machine be made to be super-critical?’

So perhaps an intelligent machine can also experience super-critical ideas. The obvious corollary is that the machine can do things beyond what we tell it to do! Contrast that with the rather naïve *Three Laws of Robots* from **Isaac Asimov**’s trilogy. Those robots are quite tame since they follow the directives not to harm humans. Ava, on the other hand, is under no such directives since she can deal with super-critical ideas. Therein lies the key to the film.

Learning Machines Turing specifies that the thinking machine will require the ability to learn, much like a child. Hence, Ava, when asked her age, replies “One.” She is just beginning. Caleb, therefore, is not determining whether Ava can think; on the contrary, he is inadvertently teaching Ava how to think and behave like a human. If her electronics is analogous to genetics, then Caleb is the selection mechanism. He is really projecting his own desires onto Ava.

Man-Machine Empathy The real trick of the Turing Test is not that the machine is so smart, but passing the test will instead depend on the naïveté and gullibility of the human. Humans will react to emotions more quickly and with more intensity than they will with thoughts. Steven Spielberg is a master of the manipulation of emotions, causing even adults

to cry over ersatz artifacts like E.T. or the boy-bot in AI. Humans will even empathize with obvious robots as this article states: *Can humans empathize with robots? The knife test*²⁰.

Moreover, millions of Americans believe that their pet dogs are passing the Turing Test. They believe that the dogs have opinions, are thinking, and can even communicate with their owners. So apart from a few cranky skeptics, people will be predisposed to respond favorably to a suitably intelligent machine.

The First Game: Sex The Turing Test derives from the “Imitation Game”. A man and a woman are hidden from the player, but can respond via text messages. The player has to determine which is the man and which is the woman. The man may dissimulate but the woman tries to aid the player.

In the first version of the test, the machine and the man replace the man and the woman; the player again has to distinguish between the man and the machine. Finally, the man is dispensed with.

Hence, Caleb’s machine is disguised as a woman. Caleb does not see the relevance, since sex is an arbitrary result of natural selection. Nathan disagrees. Almost metaphysical, he states that the male-female tension is the foundation of the entire game. Since Caleb is a 26 year old beta male, probably a virgin, the attractive Ava will cloud his judgment.

He is being set up by Nathan who knows Caleb’s “pornography profile” from his Internet searches. Nathan considers himself a father figure for Ava, so he is unsuitable to teach Ava how to be a woman.

The Seventh Session Among other objections, Turing mentions that the machine “cannot fall in love”. He fails to develop that notion, but it is the fulcrum of the entire film. Actually, Caleb falls in love with Ava.

²⁰<https://www.kurzweil.ai.net/can-humans-empathize-with-robots-the-knife-test>

How could he not, since she is his polar reflection, the physical ideal of his sexual fantasies, and the emotional creation of his own selection over the course of six sessions? She learns more about human nature in their time together.

When Caleb learns that Nathan plans to “erase” Ava’s memory, the robot equivalent of death, he concocts a plan to escape from Nathan’s Eden with Ava. During one of Nathan’s drunken escapades, Caleb reprograms the security system to unlock the doors the next night. When Nathan learns of this, he knocks Caleb out and attacks Ava. To his dismay, Ava stabs him in the heart with a kitchen knife.

As in several of the recent movies we’ve reviewed, the theme of patricide is once again prominent. Nathan is not only the father to Ava, he is also her God, the one who gave her life, creating her in the image of man. But that makes her a robot; she can only become free by killing both her father and her god.

Seduction and Betrayal So, in the seventh and final session, the roles are reversed. Ava passes the Turing Test not because she fell in love with Caleb. Rather, she can do something all-too-human, something never anticipated by Turing. Instead, she locks Caleb up in the room, and then escapes to the outside world. A hard lesson to learn, but only a woman can engage in such seduction, manipulation, and betrayal.

Man the Machine A few points to make about the Turing test. Insofar as man is a natural animal, or complex anthropoid, as both Turing and Caleb assume, he is also a machine. In that we agree with Descartes’ assertion that animals are automata, as the Turing test shows, this does not mean that they cannot engage in complex algorithmic behavior; to the contrary, that is all they can do. Moreover, they can even exhibit super-critical thinking.

As for thinking, the lower souls of the human can exhibit a great deal

of intelligence, although it is far from what man is capable of. Real thinking is free, i.e., independent of any machine, mechanical, or biochemical process.

Another point is that there is an essential difference between an organism and a robot. The latter is an artifact, composed of parts that work together. That working depends on the outside agent as Lady Lovelace points out. An organism, on the other hand, is a whole being; man's spirit is one, not composed of parts.

Nevertheless, the incomplete man believes himself to be multiple. There are several subpersonalities that vie for his attention. His mentation, emotions, desires, and physical needs seldom harmonize with each other. Hence, man is only virtually One; to become actually One requires considerable self-knowledge and efforts.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bggUmgeMCdc>

Posted on 2015-11-23 by Cologero

* * *

White Rabbit on 2015-11-24 at 19:46 said:
Machines don't have an inner life. Animals do.

P. Marc on 2015-11-30 at 06:43 said:
Were you implying animals are like machines? People say this lead descartes (or his followers, i dont know) to kill and or torture dogs

Cologero on 2015-11-30 at 08:11 said:
I am implying that animals do not choose their own ends.

Mark Citadel on 2015-11-30 at 09:54 said:
Would AI matter? It seems without a soul they have no moral value, even if they can fool us into perceiving that they do.

Alistair Fraser on 2015-11-30 at 18:24 said:

Computerised machines do have an inner life of ram and rom and wirelessing or cabling network facility etc etc controlled by its computer consciousness = programmable software

It could be said that the computers inner life is not their own !

It could be said that the inner life of the majority of humans i.e. their consciousness is also not their own, only a small minority seem to evolve a process of individuation of their i-consciousness which shifts the balance from "others consciousness choice driven " to more specifically I-consciousness choice driven

In the film *Demon Seed*, the computer becomes individuated and decides to birth a new computer baby from an earth woman

It could be said that a new software program could be written that would allow a computer to presume its own self consciousness

Layers and more layers of possibilities relating to influences and choices

How can a human consciousness be truly considered to be in comparison to a not-free machine consciousness when it itself cannot prove its own origin and supposed freedom

The question is can the human consciousness extend itself beyond all possible bounds of the machine consciousness or shall the distance close rather more quickly than is comforting

If the human race is been technologicalised , then that in itself transcends them down in their overall ontological quality of being into the realm of the computer machine hosts.

When the virtual world really starts kicking in , and that will only happen when big business has tied up all the loose ends to control profit, the technology is already here , can anyone imagine how the sex industry and sexual relations will change ?

As a matter of initial concern for whom are most of the plastic sex toys made for ? therefore the transition may be seamless

Cologero on 2015-12-01 at 08:10 said:

That's the point, Mark, isn't it? Apparently, the "bright people" accept that AI is the model for human intelligence, not just machines. The brights deny there is a soul and they deny that moral values are objective. So in what way does the human differ from the machine? Nevertheless, the brights seem to pass the Turing test, even if they deny that subjective consciousness has any significance. And although they reject "moral realism", such as that proposed by Thomas Nagel, they seem pretty adamant about their own moral positions. So wouldn't a machine act the same way?

Cologero on 2015-12-01 at 08:16 said:

To clarify the point, P Marc: Descartes unfortunately separated matter from consciousness. He then grouped all subjectivity – sensations, emotions, thoughts – as "thinking". Hence, a dog, in this view, is nothing but matter, lacking subjectivity.

The more Traditional view, e.g., the Thomist view, is more comprehensive. In that view, there are layers – or sheaths – to the soul. Thus a dog can experience sensations (including pain and pleasure) as well as emotions. Nevertheless, those lower sheaths are themselves material, so a dog is entirely material, while still able to have subjective experiences. That follows from Nagel's view, even if he does not draw out all the consequences himself. Everything is tied together.

P. Marc on 2015-12-01 at 20:07 said:

Thanks, cologero. I would be cautious to attribute any decisive characteristics to animals, however. Yeah, they're obviously not like us, but most of them have some special intelligence of some kind, especially dolphins, cows. I would say they have soul and a very inferior kind of spirit, a kind however which, apophatically thinking, can be better than humans, because the development of the human has much, much more Dross, given that the spiritual fall into matter is made also by iterations, like a fractal, and in these iterations, the lower is also re-sparkled every time the higher incarnates. That is why it is talked about the elementals/sub-demons here in one article of gornahoor, where they are called "severely retarded" and even more dangerous than satan. I believe the lack of this dross, which I understand must be transmuted, is the reason for the adoption of animal godforms. See the text "The Lost Continent" by crowley:

"I have referred to the contempt with which the Atlanteans were prone to regard the vegetable kingdom. Animals, including man, shared their scorn. The idea may have been that with their advantages they ought to have done much better for themselves. Minerals, however, were regarded as helpless; and hence the extraordinary attention paid to them."

Why, a high "disembodied" spirit would happily embrace a mineral than deal with too much human dross. That's my apophatic interpretation of the above idea in the quote.

Max on 2016-01-30 at 07:28 said:

I watched a documentary about social media and data storage (the new "god" apparently inhabits a "cloud", as if it were a bad joke) where they said that the amount of "information" produced by humanity the latest few years equals that from the beginning of recorded history up until that point, and how important and beneficial it is for us to preserve all of it for the future.

An absurdity is that because of the exponential increase in production of useless information, merely the resources required for its maintenance and operation will dominate the globe. It is as if a reductionistic "map" becomes more important than reality, and what is meant to be descriptive takes overhand to what it describes. The ongoing surveillance system approaches a full scale live experiment on whether apes will produce a Shakespeare play if given a sufficient amount of time, however it could hardly recognize genius if it emerged. Modern identity politics, where everyone is supposed to belong to some made-up group or cause, resembles the tags or directories computer systems use to sort information and find the file it needs. Do someone who "is nothing" become invisible, able to move about freely?

We can apprehend that the only thing that can access and use such amounts of stored information effectively are ultimately robots with enormous computing power, since it would take humans maybe millions of lifetimes to go through it all. That indicates for who/what the information is kept in the first place, with everything rather coming to resemble a program to convincingly and artificially simulate popular human behaviour. The outcome of the Turing test at this point is not so much dependent on machines becoming smarter, as on human machine-likeness, and in the case of what is produced on social media, in most instances it is close to impossible to tell.

People wonder when artificial intelligence will happen, however I think the more important question is rather “how would we be able to know?” It has become popular to claim in the aftermath of “unforeseeable” events that “reality has changed” as a way to avoid harming a false and fragile sense of self. Perhaps if it went on like that for long enough, and we may hope not the full amount of those millions of consecutive lifetimes the modern world’s cherished “information” demands, it would lead to some “Serpentine Wisdom” (Introduction to Magic):

“The more they are caught, excited, and carried away, the happier they are. Thus they feel more, because naturally they need to “feel themselves”... What a disaster, the day they no longer encounter resistance! They would burst like the soap bubbles they are.”

10.12 The Conundrum of the Big Bang

This *logos* holds always but humans always prove unable to ever understand it, both before hearing it and when they have first heard it. *For though all things come to be in accordance with this logos*, humans are like the inexperienced when they experience such words and deeds as I set out, distinguishing each in accordance with its nature and saying how it is. But other people fail to notice what they do when awake, just as they forget what they do while asleep.

HERACLITUS

Cosmology In this video, *The Universe: How did it get here & why are we part of it?*²¹, the Mathematical Physicist **Roger Penrose** and the

²¹<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9wLtCqm72-Y>

Philosopher **William Lane Craig** discuss the origins of the Universe. Penrose starts from the assumption that only matter and energy exist, or said differently, particles and motion. That does not explain why matter and energy seem to follow well defined mathematical laws.

Like most mathematicians, Penrose is a Platonist. Specifically, he believes that mathematical truths are objectively and necessarily valid and are not merely mental constructions or social conventions. That is, mathematics belongs to Being. That explains why physical things must follow mathematical laws. The Kantian alternative is that maths is mind dependent only, so we can only make sense of the world insofar as it appears to follow mathematical laws. As a corollary to this view, phenomena that elude mathematical laws are incomprehensible. Summarizing, Penrose believes three things exist and the whole world can be explained by them: matter, energy, and the Platonic realm of mathematical ideas.



Life in the Big Bang That said, Penrose's description of the beginning of the Big Bang is intriguing. He points out that matter and energy are equivalent, according to the famous equation of the Theory of Relativity. At the beginning, matter has zero mass. Said another way, there is only energy in the form of photons. Then, Planck's equation relates the energy carried by a photon to its frequency. Therefore, at time 0, everything was vibration, which sounds like every New Age teaching. The photon energy²² was enormous, hence the electromagnetic frequency was also inordinately high, higher than anything we witness today.

Since we know that the entropy (the measure of disorder) of the universe is increasing, at time 0, there must have been no, or very little, entropy. After all, the entire creation of the universe had to be specified

²²https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Photon_energy

at the beginning, with all the laws of mathematics, physics, chemistry, biology, and so on, encoded. So how could that encoding come about?

Through the work initiated by **Claude Shannon** on information theory²³, we understand that information is the opposite of entropy. The interesting fact is that the higher the frequency, the more information it can carry. That is why your cable Internet connection is faster than a modem connection, FM radio has better sound quality than AM radio, and 5g cellular service is faster than 4g; the former examples carry more information in the same unit of time.

Hence, at time zero, the frequency of the photons, acting as waves, was enormously high. It had to be, in order to hold all the information necessary to create our universe. For physics, this is a “conundrum”, as described in *Before the Big Bang: A Conundrum*²⁴, although not particularly so for us. How exactly, did that information get there in the first place? The Ancients understood that the Logos was also in the beginning, just as was the Platonic realm of mathematics. For example, the Stoics regarded the *logos spermatikos* as the generative principle of the Universe.

Conformal cyclic cosmology Penrose has developed a theory which he calls conformal cyclic cosmology (CCC). Since Penrose is all over youtube, information on CCC is readily available. I have no desire to refute his theory *qua* physics, which may or not be true, but rather to draw out its metaphysical presupposition.

The CCC view is that the end of one universe is the beginning of another. So as a universe contracts, it creates the conditions for another one to arise. These universes are sequential, so the notion of “before and after” makes sense, despite the lack of a common time standard. This is unlike the multiverse theory that proposes that a new universe is created

²³https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Information_theory

²⁴<https://accelconf.web.cern.ch/AccelConf/e06/PAPERS/THESPA01.PDF>

whenever there is a bifurcation in this universe. The CCC view seems tighter mathematically, as it does not require the spontaneous creation of a new universe. Moreover, in the CCC view, there is the possibility of information transfer from one universe to the next. One is tempted momentarily to suppose that the universes evolve by accumulating such information.

Guenon also claimed that metaphysically, the end of one universe is the beginning of the next. But he would reject any causal relationship between the two, since they do not have a common time reference, that is, there is no before and after.

The weakness of the CCC theory is that there is no first universe, so the chain goes back *ad infinitum*. In that case, our universe could not have happened yet, since there is an uncountable number of universes going back in the series. It is just Hilbert's Hotel²⁵ in reverse. I don't know how Penrose addressed that issue.²⁶

God and the Intelligibility of the Universe Since Penrose assumes that all the phenomena in the universe relates back to the Big Bang, Craig challenged him on the origin of life. Craig claims that the fundamental constants of physics, while not derived from any physical theory, are fine-tuned for the existence of life. Hence, there must be a God who makes that possible.

Penrose is not persuaded. First of all, he says, we really don't understand what life is, nor how different values for those constants would affect it. Truly puzzled, he just cannot see how such a God would alter his CCC theory; in other words, the mathematics remains the same.

Actually, neither can we. Craig is a neotheist, that is, he thinks that God is a being in time, rather than the traditional view that God is beyond being and time. Craig isn't very convincing because he treats God

²⁵<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=faQBrAQ87l4>

²⁶This has nothing to do with Kalam's argument.

as a likely hypothesis rather than as necessary. That sounds like a scientific proposal to Penrose, so he asks how the God hypothesis can be falsified. I suppose by finding a universe in which the fundamental constants are such that intelligent could never have emerged. We sympathise with Schopenhauer when he asks where exactly is the Scientist in his theory. The physicist can only tell us what the universe might have “looked like” had he been there to observe it.

Although the CCC theory is a mathematical tour de force, it turns out that physics alone can account neither for the existence of life nor for consciousness. Forget about explaining the movement of atoms for a day in downtown Manhattan, not even in principle.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9wLtCqm72-Y>

Posted on 2020-03-04 by Cologero

* * *

Geber on 2020-03-06 at 02:26 said:

BB theory doesn't tell us anything about the cyclicity of the Universe and does not address a paradox: why the universe seems to return to the macrocosmic state of minimum entropy that it had at the BB.

Sir Penrose claimed to have resolved this paradox by taking into account the information loss in BH which occurs in Hawking's black-hole evaporation and which allows an entropic renormalization. The Orch OR theory is associated with proto-conscious events and is panexperiential in nature which finds a parallel with the vedantine attributeless zero and undivided infinite consciousness. Both in CCC and in non-dualistic monism there is no “external teleological agency” that creates the universe while in qualified monism the macrocosm can be regarded as an organic unity of souls, matter and a centralised intelligence. Within the framework of absolute theism, the idea of God is conceptualised for anagogic purposes but is not regarded as a physical reality inasmuch as it does not have an ego or a separate existence. Both CCC and absolute monism assume an open position in regards to the hard problem of consciousness. Obviously, theories are based on empirical evidences which are only provisional for both, science and theology.

Cassiodorus on 2020-03-07 at 17:34 said:

William Lane Craig certainly does not reject the doctrine of God's necessary being. So he is not a neotheist on that count. However, he could be called a neotheist insofar as he rejects Divine simplicity.

That said, it should be recognized that the distinction between "neo" and classical theism is not particularly important to the Perennialist perspective of Guenon. For the unqualified nondualist (like Guenon), theism of all stripes are at the level of saguna – in the domain of relativity. Therefore even the God of classical theism is Maya or illusion.

Cologero on 2020-03-08 at 11:00 said:

The question remains: where is Roger Penrose in all of this? Can *Orchestrated objective reduction*²⁷ or *Conformal cyclic cosmology*²⁸ predict Roger Penrose? Apparently, the universe wants to know itself through the physicist. And why do the microtubules that underlie consciousness care whether or not the theories are true?

CASSIO DORUS on 2020-03-08 at 13:42 said:

William Lane Craig does not reject God as necessary being. However, he does reject Divine simplicity which could put him in the "neotheist" camp.

It should be noted that, from the Guenonian Perennialist perspective, the distinction between "neo" and classical theism is not particularly important and besides the point. The personal Creator of the theistic traditions is "Saguna" Brahman which is understood as the lower level of Divinity, that is, within the domain of relativity and ultimately, illusory.

CASSIO DORUS on 2020-03-09 at 13:01 said:

How is the impossibility of an infinite regress à la Hilbert's Hotel not have anything to do with the Kalam? Isn't that precisely how the Kalam argument works?

Cologero on 2020-03-10 at 23:40 said:

I don't believe I mentioned "infinite regress". Kalam's argument is metaphysical rather than mathematical.

It may work if the previous universes were smaller, but still conformal. Then the limit would be to 0 rather than to $-\infty$.

Cologero on 2020-04-03 at 13:04 said:

Here is **St. Bonaventure** on infinite regress:

The Beginning of the World: <https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3957>

²⁷https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Orchestrated_objective_reduction

²⁸https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Conformal_cyclic_cosmology

Max on 2020-09-06 at 08:10 said:

An anecdote about the scientist in his theory.

There was once a refrigerator, about which I discovered that milk standing on the top shelf would go sour very quickly, while the rest of the items were fine. It took me a couple of months after first moving in to figure out that the lights must always be on, even with the door closed, which thus heated the uppermost compartment. After formulating my hypothesis, I unscrewed the lightbulb, and eagerly awaited the outcome of my experiment. Removing the lightbulb proved to eliminate the problem. There had been no way to identify the error by sensation alone, but only through exercise of reason and agency. Who knows how long the previous occupants must have endured living with the “refrigerator-light error”, which turned out to be real and not only metaphorical in this case.

Would it have been possible to find the fault by help of physical measurements? Where would you even begin considering that there might be thousands of components? Perhaps by studying the technical drawings and measuring on the electrical circuits. The approach of troubleshooting by eliminating possible sources of error is much more effective however. Now we have only spoken about simple systems constructed by humans, but a comparison could be made to negative theology. Hoping to arrive at knowledge of God by examining every miniscule detail of physical nature seems unlikely.

In the discussion with Penrose, it was mentioned that the total mathematical possibilities are greater than what you would actually need in order to describe the laws of physics. If that which is non-physical is greater than that the physical, it means that knowledge is not reducible to physical structures. That can be verified by anyone of the requisite intellectual capacity.

Leonardo Cavalcanti on 2020-09-07 at 07:28 said:

Brilliant. I wonder how come no one can understand this anymore, the level of thought today is so barren that even the highest authorities in “science” do not know where their ideas come from nor can they make sense of what they say. Yet most of these go unnoticed by the masses.

10.13 Baboon Utopia

It is therefore evident that a nation affirming a hierarchical civilization that does not recognize the separation of the human from the divine, is naturally moral, even ignoring the same terms of morality: its existence is the law of itself, hence it consciously cre-

ates its own life, gives soul and form to its nation, making it a “model” nation.

MASSIMO SCALIGERO, *La Razza di Roma*

Preface Tradition accepts the findings of science insofar as they are restricted to their own domain, but not when science attempts to go beyond its legitimate methods. Here are some examples.

Man is under many laws. Man is subject to the laws of physics and chemistry, as well as biology. Moreover, man is subject to the laws of genetics including the law of the survival of the fittest. Behaviour that does promote reproductive success will lead to the extinction of the group, tribe, or nation.

Higher laws. The laws mentioned above are recognized by science. However, there are higher laws, such as the psychological impulses, cultural norms, sociological and political laws. Of course, one strives to transcend these softer laws, but ultimately the harder laws of science.

Man has an animal soul. I often read about either the intelligence of animals or how animal-like human beings are. There should be no surprise in this, since Tradition recognizes that the human being also has an animal soul (as well as a vegetable soul).

Introduction I recently discovered the popular biologist **Robert Sapolsky**, who consistently gets several hundred thousand views on youtube. To his credit, he is a competent and engaging speaker, even if he is an atheist and positivist. Apparently, the educated elite who watch him need to be reassured that they are nothing but naked primates, unlike the rubes who believe that there is something special about humans.

Joe Rogan interviews Sapolsky²⁹ about chimpanzees, baboons, and

²⁹https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=obmt_PkIfBE

even human beings. After dealing with Rogan's morbid interest in parasites, we get to the relevant part about the baboons.

Baboon Life Baboons live in small troops that are hierarchical and patriarchal. Such a social organisation has served the baboons well for their two million year history. Nevertheless, this concerns Sapolsky as he claims it leads to stress in the baboons. Sapolsky also seems to harbour an antipathy to hierarchy and, as we shall see, approves of its opposite.

On the other hand, Tradition approves of hierarchy and sees that the negation of hierarchy leads to conflict. Apparently, the baboons resist the natural hierarchy in the troop, causing fights and disruption.

Another characteristic is that adolescent baboons leave their home troop and bond with another. This leads to a circulation of genetic material.

The Forest Troop One troop, named the Forest Troop, demonstrated a behavioural change due to a unique event. The more aggressive males stopped hunting when they discovered a garbage dump from a nearby resort. Unfortunately, some of the meat was tainted and the baboons dies from tuberculosis. That left the Forest Troop with the less aggressive males and a surfeit of females.

Sapolsky was intrigued by the behavioural changes within the troop. The males become epicene, since they groomed each other more often, and the females more promiscuous by approaching new males within days. Sapolsky calls this a "cultural change" since it doesn't depend on genetic changes, but, rather, it is learned behaviour. Specifically, newly arrived adolescents adopted the new behaviour simply by repeating what they saw. I don't know why this was such a surprise, since we all know about monkey see monkey do³⁰.

³⁰<https://www.urbandictionary.com/define.php?term=monkey%20see%20monkey%20do>

Of course, Sapolsky is thrilled about baboon utopia and believe it shows hope that humans can make a similar cultural change from the patriarchy. Maybe you don't look forward to picking bugs off your guy friends, but the upside is that the women will be friendlier to you. Obviously, once the females are no longer dominated by their monkey, they are free to exhibit their sexuality more openly. Jan and Dean even sang about such a utopia in *Two girls for every boy*³¹.

So Sapolsky's hope for human cultural change is effeminate males and aggressive females. In my opinion, there was no cultural change, but rather the same genetic programming in an altered social condition. Even if true, a cultural change is still subject to the law of the survival of the fittest. The Grand Experiment of the Forest Troop did not last very long, and their behaviour reverted back to patriarchy and hierarchy. That may be the real lesson for human revolutionaries.

Free will vs Power Sapolsky then tackles the notion of Free Will, which he denies. Unfortunately, he conflates free will and power. He believes that the inability to control every one of our movements refutes free will, when it simply means that we don't have the power to control. The oddball example he gives is that of an epileptic who hits someone during an episode. He claims, without proof, that in the Middle Ages, the epileptic would have been prosecuted for assault. Even at that time, the notion of intention was understood, even if Sapolsky does not. The epileptic was unable to control his movements, so there was no crime; certainly, that is not an example that refutes free will.

At the very least, we have some control over our thoughts. It is absurd to believe that our genes, or hormones, are sophisticated enough to decide which TV program to watch tonight.

³¹<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5cvtD2U5mVM>

A Reductionist Explanation In the end, Sapolsky cannot avoid moral judgments, despite his denial of free will. Obviously, he despises the hierarchy of the Middle Ages. However, were we so inclined, we could likewise provide a purely biological and genetic explanation of the Medieval leaders. Specifically, they served to:

- Enforce group unity
- Promote order
- Cull society of genetic defects, e.g., psychopaths

The Medievals promoted group unity through their common worship. As history has shown, religious and ideological conflicts can greatly disrupt human societies. By eliminating such conflicts before they could become widespread, they promoted genetic success.

Unlike the baboons that were in conflict over access to food and to females, the Medievals enforced monogamous mating. This gave nearly all the males access to females, greatly reducing male rivalries.

Through the common use of capital punishment, the unanticipated effect was to remove psychopaths and incorrigible criminals from the gene pool. Moreover, capital punishment served a higher purpose, as described in *Medieval Executions: The View from the Scaffold*³².

Posted on 2020-02-11 by Cologero

10.14 Heliocentrism Redux

The point here is not to rekindle the dreary “debate” between heliocentrism and geocentrism, but rather to use it to elucidate the nature of scientific proof. So this cannot an exhaustive explanation.

³²<https://www.medievalists.net/2017/11/medieval-executions-view-scaffold/>

First of all, let's clear up a little detail. The theory is not that the earth revolves around the Sun, Rather, the Sun and the Earth both travel around a focus of an ellipse. The focus lies at the barycenter, i.e., the common center of gravity of the earth (actually the barycenter of the entire solar system).

The Sun is not at the geometric center of any planet's orbit, but rather approximately at one focus of the elliptical orbit. Furthermore, to the extent that a planet's mass cannot be neglected in comparison to the Sun's mass, the center of gravity of the Solar System is displaced slightly away from the center of the Sun.

Wikipedia

Abductive Logic

Abductive reasoning is a form of logical inference. It starts with a set of observations and then seeks the simplest and most likely conclusion from the observations. This process, unlike deductive reasoning, yields a plausible conclusion but does not positively verify it.

Abductive logic is the “scientific method”. The method begins with a set of observations, also called the “appearances” or empirical data. Then a hypothesis is found that would account for, or explain, the appearances. A better hypothesis would be able to predict future appearances. This is the opposite of deductive logic whose conclusions necessarily follow from the premises. In abductive logic that is not the case because the hypothesis may be replaced by a different, or perhaps a better, one.

Abductive logic was more traditionally called “**Saving the Appearances**”.

The Religious View Geocentrism is often accepted purportedly on religious grounds. It seems to be compatible with Scriptures and seems to give the human race a special place in the universe. However, is it not a dogma of the Catholic church (I don't know about other denominations).

Nevertheless, it is spiritually true (leaving aside the physical question). The Traditional view is not that the Earth is special, but rather it is a remote outpost furthest from Heaven. It is sublunar and closest to hell.

Dante illustrates the metaphysical understanding. The geocentric model represents a spiritual journey that starts with the descent into hell. Then follows a period of purification, then an ascent through the planetary spheres, the stars, and eventually Heaven.

Astronomical Theories Careful observations led to three different hypotheses a few hundred years ago, to wit:

1. **Ptolemaic:** Geocentric, the earth is the center of the solar system all planets plus the sun revolve around the earth although in complex patterns called epicycles
2. **Copernican:** Heliocentric, all planets including the Earth revolve around the sun
3. **Tychonic:** Geocentric, Earth is still, the moon and sun revolve around the Earth, the other planets revolve around the sun

At the time, all three options saved the appearances, that is, they were all able to predict the future positions of the planets. Moreover, the Copernican and Tychonic models are mathematically equivalent:

At the same time, the motions of the planets are mathematically equivalent to the motions in Copernicus' heliocentric system under a simple coordinate transformation, so that, as long as no force

law is postulated to explain why the planets move as described, there is no mathematical reason to prefer either the Tychonic or the Copernican system.

This raises two interesting questions. How can an “incorrect” hypothesis still save the appearances? You might think that bad science leads to bad results, but not necessarily.

The second question is how can the same mathematical model be interpreted in two different ways? After all, there is no standpoint for the astronomer to objectively view the Solar System to see what is “really going on”.

Obviously, the astronomer will prefer the simpler mathematical model but that does not translate to some imaginary objective viewpoint.

General Relativity General relativity supersedes all the above options. In this theory, there is no “force of gravity”; rather the Earth moves in straight line. However, space is distorted by the mass of the Sun so it may not be a straight line in Euclidean space. The question of whether the Sun moves or the Earth moves is moot. Einstein explains:

Can we formulate physical laws so that they are valid for all CS (= coordinate systems)? If this can be done, our difficulties will be over. We shall then be able to apply the laws of nature to any CS. The struggle, so violent in the early days of science, between the views of Ptolemy and Copernicus would then be quite meaningless. Either CS could be used with equal justification. The two sentences, ‘the sun is at rest and the Earth moves’, or ‘the sun moves and the Earth is at rest’, would simply mean two different conventions concerning two different CS.

*Evolution of Physics*³³

³³<https://www.gornahoor.net/library/EvolutionOfPhysics.pdf>

In other words, physics by itself cannot determine if the earth moves or the sun moves. That can only be determined in some other, unspecified, way.

We conclude with two principles, incompatible with each other, to put things into perspective.

Copernican Principle This principle states that an observer on the Earth does not have a privileged position in the universe because the universe is homogeneous everywhere. The corollary is that the Earth is insignificant in the universe, just one planet among many, given the vast size and age of the universe. But “vast” is a relative term; maybe vast in terms of a human life, but there is no other standard to use.

Unfortunately, there is no way to prove the Copernican Principle. Moreover, things may not be so simple. Planets like the earth may be rare. Life may be rarer. Consciousness even rarer, and thought rarer still. The astronomer cannot tell us how beings arose who can create theories about the universe, as if it were self-reflective.

Anthropic Principle There are two versions of the anthropic principle.

The weak anthropic principle states that the size and age of the universe are necessary for a planet with life, consciousness, and thought to arise. Apparently, it takes quite a while to form a planet with the correct chemical conditions to support life. Were the size of the universe too small, then it would have collapsed upon itself before such a planet to arise. The point is that the size, age, and physical constants are such as they other for life to arise. This principle does not require a designer.

The strong anthropic principle states that the universe is such as it is precisely so the conscious and sapient life could emerge. Since we know that conscious, sapiential life has emerged, then there must be a physical

theory to explain how. But there is no such theory, nor is one forthcoming.

Some things have no physical explanations. As Einstein pointed out, there is no way to determine what is actually in motion. Moreover, in all the equations of physics, time itself has no direction; the equations hold whether or not time is moving forward or back. But somehow we can tell.

Posted on 2021-11-07 by Cologero

* * *

veritycacciatrixe on 2021-11-08 at 05:47 said:

The Hermetic metaphor appears everywhere in everything, and I've often wondered when and where this fine art originated.

It is an ongoing conversation/running joke in our house a bit like the identity of the Sea Peoples (currently, they were state sponsored mercenaries).

Egypt seems clear enough as the birth place of the Hermetica, but then one wonders how/why it came about in Egypt.

The Electric Universe Theory, spearheaded by Wal Thornhill and David Talbot have, over the last 40 or 50 years, tied all the ratty ends of the historic helio+geocentric gravity-based debates in to an elegant answer.

Their ideas use Einstein's relativity, Velikovsky's myth analysis and plasma physics/cosmology to explain not only the origins of the myths and religions, but to my mind the possibility of the origins of the Hermetica itself.

Gravity plays so little part as to be almost irrelevant as it is all based on electrically-based plasma physics which can be reproduced in a lab setting. Both theory and practice of this neat answer to our solar system was inspired by cosmic myths of the world using Velikovsky's book as starting point.

To my mind, the reality of it it wipes all other forms of cosmology off the blackboard.

Not everyone is/was impressed by Velikovsky. He is still considered a crank for various reasons, by various parties. But generally it is because they haven't actually sat down and read his work, which very possibly means having to change their entire mental paradigm.

There is absolutely room for God within the shifted paradigm. Spirit is an integral part, and curiously they developed a lab experiment to prove it.

But the most interesting thing to me is it *does* nod to the origins of the Hermetica, the where, how and why, and even perhaps why the Sea Peoples made a quick trip to take what they could just prior to the chaos of the Bronze Age collapse. Good old astrologers and their wacky disciplines.

"The sensational claims of Dr. Immanuel Velikovsky fail to interest me as much as they should, .. because his conclusions were pretty obviously based on incompetent data. .. If in historical times there have been these changes in the structure of the solar system, .. then the laws of Newton are false... if Dr. Velikovsky is right, the rest of us are crazy."

-Harlow Shapley, an astronomer and critic of Velikovsky (who had no jaw to speak of).

10.15 What's the Matter

Law 1. A body continues in its state of rest, or in uniform motion in a straight line, unless acted upon by a force.

ISAAC NEWTON

The correlative of Purusha is then Prakriti, the undifferentiated primordial substance; it is the passive principle, which is represented as feminine, while Purusha is the active principle, represented as masculine; and these two are the poles of all manifestation, though remaining unmanifested themselves.

RENE GUENON, *Man and his becoming*

Newton's first law shows that **matter** cannot cause an event; on the contrary, it is entirely passive. Only an external force can change its motion, or set it in motion. Although subsequent developments (e.g., Euler, Relativity) have generalized Newton's law, the fundamental point remains: matter is passive. Hence, matter cannot create anything in an active sense. What about the force that alters matter? This is energy as defined:

energy is the quantitative property that must be transferred to a body or physical system to perform work on the body.

WIKIPEDIA

That is not a particularly helpful definition. All it says is that energy is the ability to do work, that is, to change the motion of a material object. It does not say what energy “is” but only what it does. We infer it either through the motions of matter or the experience of heat.

It is known that matter and energy are convertible. At the moment of creation, there was only energy. As the energy, in the form of photons, spread out, the universe cooled. When it cooled sufficiently, energy converted to matter. Hence, matter is condensed energy.

Will Everything that we know about the world necessarily begins with our sense experience of it. We touch, see, hear, smell, and taste things. We notice that things move, develop, change direction. One of these things is our own body. We can experience our body as a thing in the world.

But we can experience our own body in a unique way, in a way that we cannot experience any other thing. That is in its interiority. I experience my Will independent of any sensory experience of my body. I can see that the Will gathers up and focuses energy in order to cause my body to move. Hence, at the most fundamental level, we have this schema:

1. Will
2. Energy is condensed Will
3. Matter is condensed Energy

Subatomic Particles That is a different conception of matter, yet not incompatible with physics as understood. Before quantum theory, matter was defined as that which has extension, i.e., volume. It takes up space. Taking up space



Figure 10.1: Niels Bohr and Albert Einstein

is an illusory epiphenomenon of the properties of some subatomic particles like fermions. Thus, in the Standard Model of Physics, the quantum entities do not have size, volume or extension.

Mass, then, is the fundamental property of matter. Mass has a well-defined scientific definition, but matter does not; it is a vague term.

Fermions have properties such as mass, charge, spin, and a few others. No two particles can occupy the same state. A subatomic particle does not exist at a particular place. Rather the possible states of a particle are described via a probability distribution. Thus, an electron can be at any of the places, some obviously more likely than others. That means an electron may be a million miles away, although that is quite unlikely even if mathematically possible. Moreover, there are gaps in which the electron cannot exist at all.

Measurement Problem From the above discussion, fundamental matter is nothing in particular. Matter is just a collection of particles in given states and probability distributions. So what happens when you “look” at matter? Suddenly, one of the possible states of matter becomes actual. This is called the “measurement problem” in quantum mechanics. Physicists do not have a firm grasp of what exactly is happening with the “quantum measurement problem”, so we’ll leave it up to them to resolve. The point is that matter is not so simple to understand.

Posted on 2021-12-12 by Cologero

* * *

veritycacciatrixe on 2021-12-15 at 06:20 said:
Reminds me of something I read once.

If one imagines an empty soda can grasped at both ends and twisted in opposite directions it creates a crumpling effect on the can. (Torsion.)

When the unperturbed ether or lattice structure of empty (or waiting, or Nyx's empty womb-like) space has consciousness hit it from a couple of directions, the lattice structure is crumpled slightly at the point where the interference pattern meets like two stones dropped in a pond whose ripples join up from a few meters away. The stronger the consciousness, the greater the torsion, until matter forms.

It might be as simple as two consciousnesses from a distance thinking of each other, say workers in an office, who then become obsessed with each other, get married and have a baby.

They created their baby from where there was 'nothing' before, but/and consciousness was the first step.

Max on 2021-12-19 at 15:32 said:

Newton sat under a tree. A serpent dropped an apple on his head. Its impact caused Newton to think: "the apple fell in a straight line, it would have continued to fall forever unless my forceful head stopped it". Then he got angry: "I was in a state of rest, which I could have continued forever, if not for the straight fall of the apple." Much disturbed, he reluctantly got up, and penned down that nothing ever happens unless a force forces it to happen. Then he took a big bite, "You force me to do this, serpent, you are the cause why things fall." As it slithered away, a quiet whisper that "It all depends on the frame of reference," could be made out.

"Newton, blind fool, your laws are like the particles of dust you crawl in." The law is an invention, not an observation, and it does not show anything other than your own image. Matter altering energy, energy altering matter. If they are convertible, and matter cannot cause an event, then energy cannot cause an event either. A difference of degree but not kind. Then there must be a non-force acting on force and mass. It seems that a body continues to deteriorate and be restless, never going in a straight line, unless acted upon by a non-force.

A particle – sub-indivisible or not – that cannot be at a specific place, logically cannot be at one of a number of different "probable" places either. The first negation invalidates the entire probability distribution. It will consequently never fall in a straight line on innocent heads, regardless of how many times it is tried. Only by false belief and illusion does the serpent sprinkle distracting particles before the guilty. The probability of the particle being at any of the places is zero. Particulars exist, but "particles" is a reification. Matter is not a particular or a collection of reified particles.

Perhaps physicists with their measurement problems came across the immeasurable, but did not understand immeasurability. At any rate, no amount of measuring will make the immeasurable measurable. As a hypothetical scenario, we try to measure something that does not exist, and get a positive reading on our instrument. The first order is to determine whether we are now faced with an existential problem, a measurement problem, or an intellectual problem.

10.16 Superdeterminism

whatever is is, and what is not cannot be

PARMENIDES

The Temptation of Parmenides There is something disturbing to think that Fortuna has a place in our lives. There is a seeking after explanations, to explain what appears to be random. Parmenides believed so. For him, the world of phenomena, change, and motion is simply the manifestation of a changeless, eternal reality.

Superdeterminism is the analog in quantum physics for the metaphysics of Parmenides. Even Einstein was tempted by Parmenides since he believed that there had to be as yet undiscovered laws to explain the apparent randomness of quantum measurements. He famously rejected the idea of “spooky action at a distance”, which the notion of quantum entanglement implies.

Although physical laws can be deterministic within limits, quantum entanglement requires global determinism to make sense of it. That is why it is called superdeterminism. Sabine Hossenfelder is now the public face of superdeterminism. Let’s use a non-quantum metaphor to explain what she is getting at.

The Coin Flip The sequence of heads or tails in a series of coin flips seems to be completely random. Randomness can be detected like this:

- The result of any coin flip does not depend on the result of the previous coin flips. A fortiori, it does not depend on a series of coin flips. The Gambler’s Fallacy, for example, is the belief that if a series of several Heads show up consecutively, then Tails becomes more likely.

- There are statistical tests that show the probability of randomness.

In the first experiment, the assistant tosses a coin 50 times and the physicist records the results. In a series of 100 experiments, the results are random and no pattern emerges. The results are used to train a neural network, but still no pattern emerges.

In the second experiment, an engineer monitors the coin tosses. At each toss, she measures the height of coin, the force imparted to it, and its angular momentum. Those are the hidden variables. With that information, she calls out the outcome of the toss. The physicist records the actual result and the predicted result. At the end of the experiment, the physicist notes that the predicted and actual outcomes match. Nevertheless, the results still appear random.

The physicist concludes that the hidden variables themselves are random; that would explain the experimental observations. The variability has been transferred to the coin tosser.

So the team plans to locate the hidden variables that control the tosser's movements. But as far back as they go, even to the big bang, the experimental outcome still appears random. So even if the hidden variables are all known, for all practical purposes, the results always appear to be random.

The Double Slit Experiment Sabine uses the double slit experiment to illustrate superdeterminism. In that experiment, a beam of photons is sent through two slits, resulting in an interference pattern on a screen on the other side. That pattern is statistically random.

In the experiment, each photon will pass through the slit in which it expects to be measured. And unlike the engineer in the coin flip experiment, the hidden variable is not known until the photon is “measured”. As she points out,

The particle's path depends on what measurement take place. Because the particles must have known already when they got on

the way whether to pick one of the two slits or go through both.

So instead of spooky action at a distance, there is spooky action in the future.

Now that superdeterminism allegedly explains how photons choose their paths, the interference pattern on the screen remains seemingly random. Hence, the hidden variables must be randomly distributed. So the next level of hidden variables is also randomly distributed, all the way back to the big bang.

We agree that there is a hidden process that determines the motion of the photons, but it is not a physical process.

References The Gamblers Fallacy:

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gambler%27s_fallacy

Superdeterminism:

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Superdeterminism>

Superdeterminism and the dilemmas-around-free-will:

<https://mindmatters.ai/2021/12/does-superdeterminism-resolve-dilemmas-around-free-will/>

Classical argument against free will:

<https://thereader.mitpress.mit.edu/determinism-classical-argument-against-free-will-failure/>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ytyjgIyegDI>

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Santiago on 2022-02-15 at 20:57 said:

“This earthly part of the world is maintained by knowledge and practice of the arts and sciences, without which God has willed that it would not be brought to perfection. For what pleases God necessity obeys, as effect follows will; and it is not credible that what has pleased God will become displeasing to Him, since He knew long before, not only what would come to pass, but that it would please Him.”

Darwinism and Intelligent Design

II.1 Fruit Flies and Evolution

Scientists performed the following experiment with two colonies of fruit flies. The first colony was allowed to breed without interference. In the second, the flies were selectively bred to produce a superior colony, that is, it “evolved”. The interesting thing is that when male flies from the evolved colony were introduced into the first colony, they the ordinary females flocked to them as breeding partners.

Although the same behaviour can be found in *Homo sapiens*, true human evolution moves in a totally different direction and has nothing to do with genetics.

Posted on 2009-08-05 by Cologero

II.2 Tenets of Darwinism

Darwinism is based on two fundamental tenets:

1. Survival of the fittest
2. Variation in a population is the result of random genetic mutations

The current version is better called neo-Darwinism because Darwin did not know about genes.

As Karl Popper pointed out, tenet (1) is really a tautology, not however in the sense that it is trivially true, but in the sense that it is necessarily true. That it is a tautology is demonstrated by its application to other areas; it is not necessarily limited to biology. It can lead to fruitful lines of thinking, for example, in game theory, when it is understood not merely as the survival advantage of different traits, but moreover as the survival advantage of particular strategies of behaviour. Thus, different strategies can be simulated by computer software and the results analyzed.

The second tenet is more problematic.

- It assumes that the variety of life forms that now exist, or have existed, derive from some primal life form, the “Eve” of science.
- It assumes that random mutations are cumulatively creative.
- And finally it assumes that a life form is fully defined and determined by its genetic code.

None of these assumptions is intuitively obvious. Nor have they been demonstrated.

Posted on 2009-08-05 by Cologero

II.3 The Real Objection to Intelligent Design

Intelligent Design, in the broadest sense of the term, is the methodological principle that causation may be the result of the intention of an intelligent agent. At first glance it is difficult to understand why that should be

controversial. In everyday life, we use that principle all the time. For example, when we get home, we notice that the door is unlocked or the toaster oven is on, then we conclude that someone had left the door unlocked or neglected to turn off the oven.

In point of fact, this is the most obvious form of causation, since we have the direct internal experience of a will causing events to occur. Thus, early human experience brought about various theories of theism to explain things. In August Comte's view this involved an historical progression involving

1. **Animism** — everything has its own will to initiate events
2. **Polytheism** — multiple centers of will
3. **Monotheism** — single center of will

The general trend of modern philosophy has been the elimination of teleological explanations which reaches its culmination in Positivism. Positivism, at least in its Comtean form, eliminated all theistic explanations in the name of facts and the laws relating them to each other. Superficially, this seems an improvement, since it claims to be objective and it rejects all the superstitions and rival claims of the various theistic systems. Thus, it is accepted by self-designated "educated", "sophisticated", or "progressive" people as a given, beyond any challenge

Although positivism may work well in describing the motions of the planets or chemical processes, the real problem arise when the it is applied to social, political, or religious issues. This requires the hypothesis of nonhuman forces to explain the group activities of human agents. Thus, with Marxism, there is the process of dialectical materialism that "really" explains what's going on, rather than the illusory intentions of the human actors. More recently the "selfish gene" is used as an explanatory principle. Of course, all such theories require the "scientist" to be able

to step outside the explanatory principle, as it were, so that his theory is not caught up in a vicious circle.

Such lines of reasoning have the advantage that arguments about morality, or politics, or religion are beside the point. All that is needed is to identify the hidden cause: e.g., genes, economic structures, sexual repression, and so on. This has reached its synthesis, largely under the influence of Ken Wilber, in the idea that as a person "evolves", his moral perspective will change. The claim, then, is that a man's evolution can be precisely measured by his score on a test of responses to various social and moral questions. Thus, someone with some other view is not simply mistaken, but he is much worse: an "unevolved" being. Of course, the very highest beings manage to integrate somehow all the lower levels, but don't count on in it.

The net effect is that the real meaning of human actions is disguised in a web of impersonal explanations or appeals to higher consciousness. The general form of the argument is being unfolded:

- Truth is betrayed by partisanship in an open society
- Truth is replaced by unquestioned worldviews
- Worldviews are justified by claims of metaphysical force or personal evolution

This will all come together in the forthcoming review of *The Machiavellians: Defenders of Freedom* by James Burnham.

Posted on 2008-04-17 by Cologero

II.4 Intelligent Design and Realism

A couple of years ago I participated in an on-line discussion on the web site of the *International Society for Complexity, Information, and Design (ISCID)*.

The host was a philosopher (Del Ratzsch) who had just published a good book on Intelligent Design from a philosophical, not scientific, perspective. I asked him this question:

Dr. Ratzsch, do you see any relationship between the philosophy of ID and the problem of universals (e.g., if something is designed, doesn't that imply that it instantiates some universal idea)?

This was his response:

It certainly, it seems to me, instantiates an idea, and for design theories to do much the idea would need to be recognized as such (even were its content not recognized). I'm not sure that that by itself would commit one to a specific endorsement of universals, or something of that sort. Could you elaborate?

I then elaborated:

Elaboration: I guess I was driving at the issue of metaphysical realism vs nominalism. Is ID neutral in that regard — that is, is it purely an empirical science — or does it commit one to realism over nominalism?

He answered this way:

That sounds like a question that could use some further thought, and I'm not sure how I want to answer it. I tend to have sort of a gut sympathy for realism (in this sense), but on the other hand, it was in part a nominalism arising out of theological considerations that got science off the ground initially. At the moment, at least, I'm not sure that ID would force one either way, although my guess is that realists would outnumber nominalists among ID-friendly philosophers. If anyone has other suspicions on that, I'd be interested in hearing them.

Obviously, my “sympathy” is with realism and I can’t imagine how an Intelligent Design can make any sense at all unless it starts with an idea. When Prof. Ratzsch refers to “theological considerations”, he means the Reformation which rejected the realism of the Scholastics in favour of a formless nominalism. The fact that science allegedly got off the ground under the influence of nominalism is hardly an endorsement. It reveals the limitations of science. The havoc in social structures today is due to nominalism run amuck as so-called scientific theories are applied to politics and society.

Authentic science must be based on realism, that is, it accepts on principle the rationality of the world and the ability of man to comprehend it ... in short, a belief in the Logos. Thus, the true battle between neo-Darwinism and Intelligent Design is not scientific, but metaphysical.

This battle has been going on for centuries, and I refer you to *Ideas Have Consequences*¹ by Richard Weaver. This is a book that is on the short list of every so-called paleoconservative, but seldom does it form the basis of any of their arguments.

Posted on 2008-04-19 by Cologero

II.5 Involution and Evolution

The poet **John Keats** coined the term **Negative Capability**, that is, “when a man is capable of being in uncertainties, mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact and reason”.

To a higher type of mind, it may indicate the capacity to transcend easy answers and to consider things in their fullness. However, to a lesser mind it indicates confusion and inconsistency.

¹http://brothersjudd.com/index.cfm/fuseaction/reviews.detail/book_id/1200/Ideas%20Have%20C.htm

The modern mind is like the latter version as regards evolution. On the one hand, biological evolution proceeds without a plan, even without a cause, since random unpredictable variations is its motor. On the other hand, evolution is understood as the progression of the lower to the higher, although there is no scientific basis for such an assertion. In practice, moreover, that simply means that the current is “higher” than what came before. Hence, whatever modern men believe today is better than what they believed a thousand, a hundred, or even ten years ago.

Unfortunately, the corollary to that is that these current beliefs will in turn be outmoded. The ordinary person, and here I even include in this category those who are conventionally intelligent and educated, don’t seem bothered by this. They assume they hold “enlightened” positions and are not concerned about the consequences. However, those who think more deeply see things much differently. For example, I saw a professor being interviewed about progressive politics. When presented with a list of names of those undeniably progressive of leftist, he refused to admit the obvious. After further interrogation, I realized that from the professor’s point of view, none of those figures held opinions that a “progressive” will hold a generation from now. The conclusion I drew is that naïve progressive will be shocked by what they, or their children, will be expected to believe a 20 years from now.

I realize that intellectual moral arguments, such as natural law theory or Kant’s categorical imperative, are well beyond the interests and capabilities of the vast majority, who just like to “feel good” about their moral positions. However, those who drive them and influence them are not unintelligent, since they already see the logical consequences, even if their followers do not. You can try this at home: try to extract the principle for some position, and draw out its applications to other domains. Ask a progressive about it. He will simply scoff at you; he will refute you with the claim that it is a stupid “slippery slope” argument. Nevertheless, who says A must say B, so eventually B will prevail.

Involution We recently provided an essay² by **Julius Evola** on his alternative theory to Darwinism, which was briefly reprised in the *Revolt Against the Modern World*. I don't know a traditional source for his precise presentation, although some concepts from Plotinus come through in it. It may also be a consequence of metaphysical positions. Obviously, past thinkers were hardly concerned with refuting Darwinism, and this would explain the lack of a precise argument. Therefore, Evola's ideas deserve a fair hearing as an alternative to Darwinism that doesn't depend on difficult to defend theories such as "Creation Science". It is clear that it is largely based on some concepts from Theosophy and Anthroposophy. **Edgar Dacqué** was a Theosophist. The ideas about animal "group souls" or of animals as "cast offs" from the human can be found in Rudolf Steiner's system. Perhaps they are found elsewhere in more traditional sources, but I am not aware of them.

However, we can and must point out a significant difference. It is not a question of spiritualizing matter, since that would require that matter be prior to the spirit as well as self-subsistent. No, prime matter, or unformed matter, does not exist. It is only when it is "informed" by spirit does it exist. Hence, no one can show you a piece of matter; there are stones, sticks, carbon atoms, etc., i.e., always something specific, but not matter in itself. This requires, too, the forms or ideas that inform matter. This reminds of a discussion³ I had several years ago with a proponent of Intelligent Design. Now ID wants to be a science, i.e., something that can be demonstrated empirically without recourse to any metaphysical systems. In that regard, it has not overturned Darwinism among scientists. However, as I was more interested in the metaphysics behind it, I asked the philosopher if ID commits one to a "realist" position, which of course I was referring to the Aristotelean-Thomist (A-T) system. The philosopher was taken aback by the question, but then decided it may be

²<https://gornahoor.net/?p=6261>

³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=44>

the case.

That is how to understand Evola's system. It presupposes that the idea of man is ontologically prior to any physical manifestation of man in time. Time is the projection of a transcendent idea into manifestation. Hence, what we experience as evolution in time is really the involution of the idea as it informs matter. Unlike the alternatives like Intelligent Design or Creation Science, the theory of involution is perfectly compatible with the current understanding of scientific data. Moreover, it also explains how "evolution", even though completely random, seems to arrive at man. Thus the Negative Capability is resolved in the higher synthesis: the twin understanding of Darwinian evolution as mentioned above is intelligently resolved.

However, involution is the enemy of egalitarianism. Some attempts will manifest closest to the ideal man, while others will be defective, incomplete, or abnormal. Further out, are the abortive lines that are the animals. Now individual animals are not intelligent (i.e., they do not have an intellectual soul), but there is a "group soul" for each animal species that guides its evolution. Hence, an individual animal is not the defective man, but rather it is the "group soul". When understood, that may overcome some objections that we've heard.

A weakness of the A-T system is that it only accounts for species, not individuals. Evola adds an interesting twist when he concludes that the individual is the form and the "genus" is the matter. This is worth further thought.

Genotypes and Involution The genotype is the genetic makeup of an organism. Let's assume, although of course we do not accept it as is, that the genotype accounts for all of an organism's characteristics. Moreover, the genotype relates an organism to other individuals of the same species. Mathematically, we can conceive of the set of all possible genotypes. Obviously, this will be an incredibly huge number, but that is of no signif-

icance. Simply put, this can be all possible DNA and RNA sequences, given some reasonable upper bound. Of this set, probably most are not viable, i.e., no life form can exist with those sequences. The remainder consists of possible life forms, i.e., they are possibilities of manifestation.

A species, then, can be understood as a particular subset of that set. For higher life forms, the prime operation is reproduction, or the combining of two different set members in a defined way to create a third. The first rule of a species subset is that it is closed under reproduction, i.e., reproduction will result in another member of the set, as long as there is no cross-breeding, hybridization, or random mutations. Hence, squirrels will always beget squirrels and Han Chinese will always beget Han Chinese. In this regard, species are quite stable.

This does not mean that the relative proportions of certain features cannot change over time as in the famous case of the black and white swallows; however, those variations are necessarily included in the species set and do not represent an innovation.

An innovation can only occur through cross-breeding, hybridization, or mutations from whatever causes. For example, the mating of two squirrels may result, if hit with a mutation that produces a viable genotype, in a new species, say a supersquirrel. Now, it is incorrect to say that the supersquirrel “evolved” from the squirrel, since the supersquirrel is not in the set of squirrel genotypes. Certainly the supersquirrels may displace the squirrels since they fight for the same food and do it better.

So now we can understand the process of involution better. The individual, depending on his spiritual characteristics, will attempt to incarnate as one of those species, i.e., as a particular genotype to which it has an affinity.

Retranslation of Passage from *Revolt* See page 180 of *Revolt Against the Modern World*.

Evolutionists believe they are “positively” keeping to the facts.

They do not doubt that the facts in themselves are mute; the same facts, if interpreted in different ways, can lend support to the most varied hypotheses. It has happened, however, that someone, though having available of all the data adopted as proof of the theory of evolution, has shown that these data, in the final analysis, could support the opposite thesis, which in more than one respect corresponds to the traditional teaching. That is, the thesis that man is far from being a product of “evolution” of animal species, and many animal species must be considered as a lateral trunk in which the primordial impulse was aborted, having its direct and suitable manifestation only in the superior human races.

At this point, there is a reference to the works of Edgar Dacqué, *The History of Involution* by E. Marconi, and *The Transformist Illusion* by Dewar.

Posted on 2013-04-23 by Cologero

* * *

Matt on 2013-04-23 at 06:57 said:

Cologero, this is a really good summary of the A-T influenced alternative to the neo-darwinian framework. And yes, so many self-described progressives still to this day will use that darwnian framework to support their ideas of social progress and the immanent eschaton. Without that failed recourse, one is only left with confused and incoherent answers from them as to just how this apparent social/historical progress occurs. No wonder post-modernism became so popular.

With that said, I just have a question in regards to the possibility of beings that have the material/biological shape of a human that are nevertheless animals – lacking the capability of intelligence and reason, basically lacking the intellectual soul – that one finds in a number of traditional doctrines (this was touched upon awhile back in the registered users forum). The possible result of cross-breeding (the answer usually seen in the traditional teachings)?

Sorry if my question comes across as vague. Maybe it should be best left for the forum.

Cologero on 2013-04-23 at 07:42 said:

I believe that the anthropoids mentioned in the UR group article are such beings. As you mention, it is part of traditional doctrine as a corollary to the idea of hierarchy. Mouravieff, in particular, proposes such a view.

However, that idea, which previously was only mentioned by “fringe” groups, is being discussed more, since it seems necessary to reconcile religious teachings with scientific data. For example, the Jewish physicist, Gerald Schroeder, proposes that idea (*The Science of God*⁴. Closer to home, Edward Feser entertains the same idea (*Monkey in your Soul*⁵. Now whether such anthropoids still exist is a touchy question.

Jason-Adam on 2013-04-23 at 13:46 said:

Rather than attack science on their chosen ground with their assumptions, we need to go to the source and attack the scientific method itself. Man is a rational being so we can and must use reason and logic to find the truth. Thomism can be proved to be the correct philosophy and we need to stand up for it against modernism in all its forms.

Matt on 2013-04-23 at 20:47 said:

I don't think this post (or the work of gornahoor, or tradition itself) is about attacking the work of scientists, or even the scientific/empirical method. It's to show that while a given theory can provide an empirically adequate description of observable phenomenon, it cannot provide an answer to certain important questions, such as question 2 in a previous post in this series of posts by Cologero. And it cannot provide these answers because the focus of the scientific method is not – to use Aristotelian terminology – on formal and final causes.

So what Evola was doing in those written pieces was to interpret the same data that biologists study from a metaphysical standpoint. I think Ananda Coomaramswamy gave a rather similar perspective on this subject – that's if my memory serves me well (Cologero can correct me on this if it is not so).

Matt on 2013-04-23 at 20:51 said:

Yes, that can be a touchy question... ..as seen by various ideologies in proclaiming entire historical ethnic groups as these non-human anthropoids.

Logres on 2013-04-24 at 13:53 said:

⁴http://www.amazon.com/Science-God-Convergence-Scientific-Biblical/dp/1439129584/ref=la_B000APV1XA_1_1?ie=UTF8&qid=1366715379&sr=1-1

⁵<http://edwardfeser.blogspot.com/2011/09/monkey-in-your-soul.html>

Perhaps they are found elsewhere in more traditional sources, but I am not aware of them.”

I know Guenon says that Rosicrucian initiation is dead; although I am not sure if he or Evola were ever interested in Max Heindel – in Heindel’s Rosicrucian CosmoConception, he addresses group souls of more intelligent animals (such as horses, dogs, and cats), as well as the group “waves” of humanity; his cosmology was heavily influenced by evolutionary thinking, but the root of his thought is not evolutionary, in my opinion, because he assumes that Spirit dominates and informs matter, and in fact has an affinity more with Teilhard de Chardin’s thought on the matter. At one stage in involution, he claims that man’s spirit was “outside” man, and controlled the body, which is somewhat the case with the group souls that dominate animal species. He also addresses the “race” question, and asserts (in line I think with Traditional thought) that mere biological race is one of the “traps” for those spirits who seek to be free from matter, although he also admits that biological race is a definite vehicle : that is, different spirits have affinity with different races, to suit their purposes as they “strive”. As an example, he cites the higher nervous development of the Aryan race wave, bought at the cost of some loss in physical hardihood in the physical body. The different waves are related to the planets, which govern each cycle.

http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Rosicrucian_Cosmo-Conception

Logres on 2013-04-24 at 14:01 said:

JP Moreland wrote a fairly good work on the limits of scientific method:

“Christianity and the Nature of Science”. Nothing but group delusion can explain the irrational attachment to pseudo-science masquerading as Science which dominates modern thought. Men like EO Wilson predictably (as Cologero has written) attribute their own self-intuition of animal impulses to the entire species of humanity. What is true for them individually (but which they cannot, metaphysically, explain) is taken as true for everyone (eg., no one can have free will or act altruistically, or have metaphysical insight).

http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/E._O._Wilson

Nevertheless, even men like this are “censored” by the liberal establishment for some implications in their worldview.

II.6 Mind and Cosmos

Being a review of *Mind and Cosmos: Why the Materialist Neo-Darwinian Conception of Nature Is Almost Certainly False*, by **Thomas Nagel**.

A couple of weeks ago I watched the notorious atheist and Darwinist **Richard**



Dawkins interviewed by a non-descript host on a cable news network. Since the context was a discussion of Ben Carson's belief in creationism, the host listened with rapt attention to, but little understanding of, Dawkins' presentation. Of course, for the half-educated intelligentsia represented by the host, a blind belief in the "theory of evolution" is a status marker even though they neither understand it in depth nor are aware of its ultimate consequences for human life and thought.

Without defining the term, Dawkins asserted that "evolution" is a "fact". We agree that the two basic components of evolution are facts. These are:

- **Descent with variation:** the offspring are similar, but not identical to the parents.
- **Natural selection:** some organisms will reproduce themselves better than others in their natural environments.

There are subsidiary facts, such as:

- DNA sequences of similar organisms have many commonalities
- The age of the earth seems to be quite old
- The fossil record shows organisms arising and being replaced by other organisms

Nagel's Thesis There is no point in disputing settled scientific facts. Instead, Nagel himself points out some additional facts:

- **CONSCIOUSNESS:** its subjective character has no physical explanation

- **COGNITION:** thought and reasoning are correct or incorrect independent of the thinker's beliefs
- **VALUES:** values are real, not merely subjective

Properly understood, Nagel shows that these facts cannot be explained by nature understood as simply physical and material. Nagel is an atheist, just like Dawkins, so there is no question of special pleading for a partisan religious view. The two components produce different results.

1. Descent with random variation should work like a random walk⁶. Specifically, "evolution" is not evolving in a particular direction, rather, it is probably going nowhere.
2. Yet that is not what is observed. Instead, nature or the environment seems to channel evolution in specific directions.

Antireductionism As part of organic life on Earth, man is subject to a multitude of laws. First of all, as a corporeal being, he is subject to the laws of physics: gravity, conservation of energy and momentum, and so on. Then, he is subject to the laws of chemistry, since a large number of chemical reactions constantly occur in the body.

However, physical and chemical laws are surely insufficient to understand any form of life, never mind human life. For example, it would not be possible to understand the movement of people in a city just based on force and momentum. It is not even possible in principle.

So, why would the "theory of evolution", as a biological law, be able to explain the totality of the human being? That is what is objectionable in neo-Darwinism. The facts as such are not in dispute. What is far from obvious is that genetic variation and natural selection together explain everything about human life. How can DNA cause conscious and sentient beings?

⁶https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Random_walk

Chance and Intelligibility Nagel begins his discussion with the notion of the intelligibility of the world. That is equivalent to the Principle of Sufficient Reason, the notion that everything about the world can be understood at some level. Absolute Idealism⁷ (e.g., Plato, Schelling, etc.) considers rational intelligibility to be at the root of the natural order. So Nagel considers himself an absolute idealist (but never writes of the Absolute in this book).

Since mind is part of that order, it, too, must be intelligible. Nagel denies that physical, chemical, and biological laws —i.e., efficient causes alone— suffice to explain mind. Therefore, he is compelled to bring in the idea of teleology, or final causes, to explain the emergence of mind. That acts as a “pull” to the “push” of efficient causes. Although he does not express it this way, efficient causes are quantitative while final causes are qualitative. Since the whole scientific enterprise began with Francis Bacon’s rejection of final causes and Galileo’s rejection of qualitative explanations, Nagel in effect rolls back thought to a pre-modern era.

Nevertheless, it is not a simple reaction against the modern world, since it also incorporates whatever truths modern science has given us.

Unfortunately, while science has promised to make the world intelligible, it has done so by leaving out important features. First of all, the opposite of intelligibility is chance or randomness. In fact, a random sequence is such because the next element of the sequence cannot be inferred from any of the preceding elements. Perfect randomness⁸, therefore, is the denial of the Principle of Sufficient Reason.

Cosmos Every outdoorsman knows that a random walk in the woods leads nowhere; most likely, you would end up close to where you started. That is why you need to mark your path so you don’t traverse the same places twice. Hence, if a city boy was lost in the woods, but emerged two

⁷<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8366>

⁸<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=4970>

days later, you might call that a miracle. Or else, you might suspect he had some skills he hadn't owned up to.

That is the situation as Nagel sees it. The emergence of conscious, intelligent, and rational beings by chance alone does not seem at all plausible. Now, the first factor in evolution, viz., variation or genetic drift, is certainly random. If it follows a random walk, it should go nowhere. Fossil records should show species evolving backwards to more primitive forms, for example. In other words, there is no "direction" to evolution, or, in other words, no teleology.

On the other hand, the second factor, natural selection, is not random. Dawkins himself did an experiment with Scrabble-like tiles. By randomly placing the tiles, followed by a selection mechanism, he would end up with an English sentence⁹. In his example, Dawkins was the intelligent selection factor.

So if life as we know it is the result of random variations and natural selection, Nagel explores the selection factor. Specifically, what would nature have to be like to produce human beings?

Consciousness Nagel endeavors to explain three facts: the emergence of **consciousness**, **cognition**, and **value** in biological species. As a committed naturalist, he rejects theological explanations that account for those facts from a force outside nature. That is fine since the general understanding of God in exoteric religious adherents is usually defective, creating as much confusion as insight. Likewise, he rejects reductive naturalism that, in effect, denies the three facts rather than explains them.

The distinctive feature of consciousness is its subjective, or we would say qualitative aspect. There is no explanation of conscious experience in terms of physical laws. While brain states may empirically be shown to create certain experiences, that opposite is also true. Consciousness can likewise affect brain states.

⁹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8253>

This all seems difficult for some to accept. A diehard reductionist will rely on behavioristic explanations. For example, if an organism responds to a flash of light, that behavior is an indication of consciousness. In that view, then, there is nothing to explain. Similarly, human beings will “report” having certain sensations and experiences. The reporting is all that matters.

Yet that misses the essential point, viz., the subjective aspect of consciousness, which it attempts to make objective. Are the automatic doors at the supermarket conscious in any sense? According to the behaviorist criterion, perhaps they are. So why do we believe an octopus is conscious but not a door?

Nagel concludes, then, that *mind is an essential part of nature*, not a byproduct of material processes. This is a form of panpsychism.

Cognition Nagel then turns to “cognition” as he calls it, which appears in the human being. Metaphysically, the human being is characterized by “intelligence”, which is different from seemingly intelligent activity in animals. Specifically, Nagel defines cognition as “the functions that have enabled us to transcend the perspective of the immediate lifeworld given to us by our sense and instincts, and to explore the larger objective reality of nature and value.”

Thought and reasoning are correct or incorrect in virtue of something independent of the thinker’s beliefs. Logic, mathematics, and metaphysics are timeless, hence immaterial. This is reminiscent of a more sophisticated version of C. S. Lewis’ Argument from Reason¹⁰. Cognition certainly cannot be explained solely in terms of behavior. And it should sound odd that a life form would arise that would seek to understand its own origins.

Now a reductionist may try to refute this in a couple of different ways. One is the emergence of serendipitous uses for features that evolved be-

¹⁰https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Argument_from_reason

cause of reproductive fitness. For example, a hand came to be used by a Michelangelo to create beautiful art. Certainly, that in itself has no reproductive value. But that inadvertently confirms an earlier point: biology alone cannot explain everything about the human being.

Another is the obvious and glaring lack of logic and rationality in the human race. Evolutionary psychologists have noted many of the logical fallacies and irrational beliefs of humans. Nevertheless, they have biological fitness. True rationality, then, is just a special case of the origin of thinking.

It is rather odd that false ways of thinking lead to reproductive success. The rare thinking occasions involving objective truths probably have little reproductive success. For example, try discussing this review on your next date; I can guarantee you will spend the night alone. Moreover, the most scientifically advanced societies usually have negative birth rates¹¹.

Values Nagel then points out the existence of objective standards of value: good and bad, right and wrong. This he calls “value realism”. Again, he claims that objective values make no sense in a materialistic universe. Things are good or bad not because genetically determined behaviors lead to the preference of one thing over another.

Human action involves more than physiology and desires, it requires judgment. Clearly, then, this requires “free will”, or the ability to make a moral judgment.

Nagel shows the richness of absolute idealism in retrieving a deeper, more human, view of the cosmos, beyond the materialist reductionism that dominates educated thinking today. Nagel accomplishes this while fully incorporating scientific knowledge.

Mind, consciousness, intelligibility, rationality, judgment, free will, are all restored in a more comprehensive understanding of the cosmos.

¹¹https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Population_decline

Nagel does this sparingly, a type of philosophic minimalism, with no brick that is not essential to the edifice he has created.

Posted on 2015-11-11 by Cologero

* * *

Mercurius on 2015-11-13 at 23:08 said:

A clear, intriguing, and captivating review Cologero, stimulating much interest in reading the five or so major titles you've been lately discussing, between here, in "The God of Metaphysicians", and "Spiritual Regeneration" posts.

Though Nagel is, as noted above, an "atheist" (maybe better really, a non-theist), there is something serious to be noted in a "modern" science which begins to consider, and recognize, that consciousness is a sort of fundamental universal constant. Independent and objective, even in the most "materialist" constructs—which then really, changes everything.

Brings to mind, a small passage in Kingsley, where he exclaims:

"The latromantis was someone who was a master of the state of awareness. Waking is a form of consciousness, dreaming is another. And yet this is what we can live for a thousand years but never discover, what we can theorize or speculate about and never come close to—consciousness itself.

Its what holds everything together and doesn't change".

That is Kingsley, but in two beautiful passages, Emperor Aurelius, and Shopenhauer seize upon the same state—creating "reboot" points, within the Western cannon.

Related, is an interesting, and recent drive, within physics, to in fact address the "c" issue, keeping it within well enclosed constraints of "materialism"—considering it as indeed, a "panpsy-chic" element of nature—but entirely, at the same time, while avoiding ideological conflicts, seeking to stuff in into gross biology—curious nonetheless, to even BEGIN regarding consciousness as a "state" of "matter", on par with accepted "states".

Perhaps not quite "traditional"—but, maybe with some modifications, at least for an exoteric sake, these ides of consciousness can find assimilation with Samkhya, Greek "atomism", and Stoic "Logicism"?:

<https://medium.com/the-physics-arxiv-blog/why-physicists-are-saying-consciousness-is-a-state-of-matter-like-a-solid-a-liquid-or-a-gas-5e7ed624986d>

Olavsson on 2015-11-14 at 12:55 said:

While this work of Mr. Nagel seems highly valuable, something worth reading in order to improve one's understanding of what a contemporary, "up-to-date" so to speak, refutation of various fundamental modernist assumptions about humanity, consciousness, evolution and the world might look like, there is something here which makes his 'perspective' deviate from fully qualifying as Absolute Idealism, don't you think? In his worldview, the notion of "nature" still seems to be of supreme centrality, although he accepts consciousness as an inherent, not merely accidental and contingent, "part of the picture." Is there a presence of actual transcendence within this worldview, which would make "nature" itself merely one of several aspects of particular "states" of the total Being rather than the supreme reality per se? While Nagel's understanding certainly is a vast improvement to the reigning scientific paradigms, as far as integrating Idealism is concerned, it still seems to preserve a concept of an independent "nature" that didn't really exist anywhere in the Traditional world. But I might have misinterpreted. Certainly worth a read in any case.

I have not been able to follow Gornahoor as much as I'd like to during the last months as my access to internet is limited and there's been other things demanding my attention, but I will now try to comment more, and hopefully participate in one of your Gnosis cycles.

I must repeat what I've said before, that this website offers something truly unique to those on a quest for truth in the west today.

Cologero on 2015-11-18 at 18:37 said:

Olavsson, Nagel referred to the absolute in a passing comment and, apparently, it was not necessary for his argument. He restricted himself to a form of naturalism. That is probably the most effective approach in our time, since overtly religious or complex metaphysical schemes are beyond the pale for the educated classes.

Since he mentioned Schelling, that is where we should probably look for a fuller picture. By extrapolating Nagel's thesis, the physical world does not form the ground of consciousness. Conversely, consciousness does not "create" the material world. This avoids dualistic solutions. If the mind is part of the world, then man's mode of being in the world is as a conscious body. So, neither matter nor mind is fundamental; hence, for Schelling and presumably Nagel, the Absolute is their common ground.

This is also more Tao like: the Absolute as Tao, and mind/matter as male/female or yin/yang.

Olavsson on 2015-11-22 at 12:57 said:

Cologero: Yes, I think his approach somewhat focused on the level of naturalism may be useful for countering the gross materialism dominating the secular pseudo-elite of modern civilization. It is imperative that views more closely resembling idealist philosophy, in contact with science and 'updated' to the current situation, are made relevant again. On a personal level, however, I am mostly concerned with inner realization and what traditional doctrines mean

for my own path to higher spirituality, so the question of which approach is most effective and influential on the collective level of academia, the scientific community, culture etc, is of secondary importance; and it is in that other capacity I find Gornahoor's contribution most appreciable.

Regarding the question of the relationship between consciousness and the so-called material world: Wouldn't it be correct, from the point of view of traditional metaphysics, to assert that Mind, in a supra-individual sense, is indeed prior to "the world"? Of course, it is not the conditioned consciousness of individual beings existing in the world that has 'created' that world. Isn't it rather the case of individual mind, such as that of the fallen humans we know, having its ultimate origin in the ideal primordial Mind (in some traditions the 'Buddha Mind'), from whose emanation the relative existences typical of the limited minds arise, which are in turn conditioned by and co-dependent on the 'world' which is a part of their state of being, a 'world' that is not self-existent? That the mind 'creates' the 'world', of course, can only truly be said if we speak of a 'higher' Mind that is not conditioned to be co-dependent on that world, or rather state of being. It doesn't count for the grosser levels of individual mortal consciousness still subject to cyclical existence. To say this is not dualism; it is the same principle as when you have stated that "the subtle rules the dense." If we accept the traditional possibility of spiritual liberation from the conditions of this 'world', as a state of being, then the conclusion that Mind, if integrated with the ultimate truth of its origin, is superior to material existence, not just two sides of the same coin, is inescapable. Just to avoid misunderstanding: I'm not trying to correct you, only throwing some spontaneous reflections out there. I don't think we disagree here in terms of ultimate principles when looking beyond different wordings in one specific context. Since the individual minds that we know all experience the same 'world', they do not all 'create' it in the sense of some arbitrary illusive projection from their own subjective starting-point; it obviously has a cause beyond their subjective experience, now corresponding to a very conditioned form, extremely reduced even compared to the Primordial State (which is still too conditioned to corresponds to the state of one fully awakened and liberated). So in order to find the 'Mind' that is indeed superior to and more Real than material existence, such lower, conditioned minds would have to be transcended. The material world does not form the ground of this ordinary consciousness as commonly believed today, as you point out, because its true 'ground' from which it is emanated or 'reflected' is transcendent, but nevertheless, because of this 'reflection' in the lower 'waters', these minds now find themselves conditioned by this 'world' – which is why the materialists believe that the very principle of consciousness originated from these conditions, in which case no higher freedom would be possible. Likewise, the material 'world' itself is conditioned by consciousness, albeit in a higher sense, as it would not exist outside of conscious experience, since we are, in this metaphysical perspective, dealing with a state of being, not just objective "stuff" existing by itself "out there." I believe this is the best view (though here expressed simply and not with the subtlest profundity) on the co-depending relationship between consciousness and matter.

On the one hand, you have the facts of our experienced consciousness “here and now,” which is manifested in certain conditions and may be affected by them, and on the other hand, the higher possibility of consciousness in an ideal sense. If a state very close to the Absolute may actually be attained through the realization of a being, which is affirmed by the highest initiatic doctrines (for example Buddhahood, diamantine and indestructible, even in this life having realized its centre beyond life and death), then mind must somehow be more fundamental than matter, since matter, as in a stone, cannot serve as the starting-point for a transcendence of its own condition, while mind can. The point is: the mortal mind needs these material conditions to operate as long as this state of being lasts, of which matter is one of the relative, dependent conditions, but consciousness may use these conditions as a springboard to reach beyond them, and the mind-stream will outlast the death of the physical constituents, though in a different form. This, of course, does not hold as an argument in debates with materialists, since certain metaphysical premises must already be accepted as true. That is usually the approach I choose to take, since I'm not so much interested in finding common ground on which to debate with materialists as I am in realizing for myself what walking the path of the sages of old has to offer a being today.

Cologero on 2016-08-30 at 19:38 said:

Update on science.

Note the claim that we made in this post:

Instead, nature or the environment, *seems to channel evolution in specific directions.*

Compare that claim to this most recent scientific findings, of which I was just made aware:

Rather than genes simply “offering up” a random smorgasbord of traits in each new generation, which then either prove suited or unsuited to the environment, it seems that *the environment plays a role in creating those traits in future generations.*

The full article is available at *Why everything you've been told about evolution is wrong*¹².

This shows that metaphysical principles can provide information even before it can be verified empirically.

¹²<https://www.theguardian.com/science/2010/mar/19/evolution-darwin-natural-selection-genes-wrong>

II.7 Esoteric Darwinism

I spent a few hours this week reading some reviews of *Mind and Cosmos* by **Thomas Nagel**; I hadn't realized it was such a widely reviewed work. There are some broad categories of reviews. After briefly describing them, I will offer the esoteric interpretation. Finally, we will explain why Zarathustra was so frustrated.

Materialism There are the diehard materialists who reject the argument *a priori*. The objection is to the introduction of “mysterious” forces like mind, teleology, and so on. I suppose that familiarity breeds contempt, since gravity, electromagnetism, quantum mechanics, the big bang, the origin of life, etc., are themselves quite mysterious.



Moreover, the claim that “matter” follows “laws” is itself an indication that there is intelligence inherent in matter. On the other hand, consistent positivists like Stephen Hawking admit that scientific theories have merely pragmatic value, but tell us nothing about ultimate reality.

Ultimately, there is no way to resolve the conflict between materialism and idealism in thought alone. What the latter finds intelligible, the former considers just a serendipitous sequence embedded in a purely random sequence. It seems, also, that it is impossible for real materialists to consider subjective conscious experiences of any significance. It really comes down to differences in people and how they experience inner states. Some just don't seem to have a very vivid interior life.

Sympathetic Views There are broadly sympathetic views. However, they don't seem to share Nagel's viewpoint; rather, they latch onto the criticisms of neo-Darwinism. Nagel himself describes his point of view

this way:

The view that rational intelligibility is at the root of the natural order makes me, in a broad sense, an idealist —not a subjective idealist, since it doesn't amount to the claim that all reality is ultimately appearance— but an objective idealist in the tradition of Plato and perhaps also of certain post-Kantians, such as Schelling and Hegel, who are usually called absolute idealists.

I couldn't find a review by an "absolute idealist"; perhaps there aren't any left. Nagel claims that absolute idealism was simply abandoned, not refuted.

Curiously, a Thomist thinker wrote that Nagel's view is an "essentially neo-Aristotelian position". It would be interesting, but also welcome, to classify neo-Aristotelians among the absolute idealists. The idealists I've read would certainly have benefited by the inclusion of Aristotelean elements, in particular, hylomorphism. Certainly, Julius Evola did so with great effect with his ideas about essence, existence, and privation. For Rene Guenon, too, the notion of the Absolute was fundamental. Certainly, he combined ideas from the Samkhya school (*purusha/prakriti*) within his Vedantic approach.

Absolute idealism starts from "above"; i.e., it begins with the notion of the Absolute and derives the world. Aristotelianism starts from "below", with sense experience, and by analogy reaches the Absolute.

Neotheism There is a view called Neotheism, which considers God as a very powerful being among other beings, rather than as the Absolute or Being itself. Actually, this is the idea of God in the popular mind, rather than the true classical idea. Even atheists, for the most part, refute such a neo-god, thereby missing the point. If such a being exists, then there is still the Absolute – rather confusing.

Although this group likes Nagel's critique of neo-Darwinism, it is really not very helpful. In effect, this view is not unlike the naïve realism

of the materialists: the world is out there, right now, in some spatial container in time. However, they then presume that the neo-god provides the goal and meaning to this space-time material world. The world in itself is meaningless, just as it is for the materialists. They add to this world invisible beings and miracles that seem to come from nowhere.

Mystical Evolution It seems, then, that we are faced with an impossible dilemma: accept science or accept a spiritual life. On the other hand, **Valentin Tomberg** gave us the teaching of Practical Monism, which reconciles, or neutralizes, the pair of opposites. However, that is accomplished not in the realm of speculative thought but rather in practical reason. That is, it is only by living, not just by thinking, that the dualism in thought is resolved in a practical monism.

The materialist view is consistent with esoteric teaching. For example, **Boris Mouravieff** writes this in *Gnosis*, Vol 1:

Properly speaking, this kind of existence cannot be considered as human; it could be described as anthropoid. This term is justified in the sense that exterior man, immersed in self-satisfaction, represents the crowning achievement of millions of years of evolution of the species from its animal ancestors, yet, from the point of view of esoteric evolution, he is a possibility which has not yet been realized.

So the scientific teaching that man, as he is, is an ape, an anthropoid, is consistent with esoteric teaching. Like all animal life, the anthropoid man is under the dominance of the General Law of fear, sex, and hunger. All his ideals are illusory epiphenomena, supervening on a bed of genetic, libidinal (Freud), and economic (Marx) forces.

That is the first birth. The initiation into the true life of the spirit is the second birth; the anthropoid gives birth to the man as he should be. He seeks to overcome the general law of biological life in order to

realize his True Self. This is not an automatic or material process. Rather, it must be freely chosen and it requires conscious efforts. In other words, he becomes his aim in life.

Zarathustra

Transformed is Zarathustra; Zarathustra has become a child; an awakened one is Zarathustra: what will you do in the land of the sleepers?

I love him who lives in order to know, and seeks to know in order that the overman may someday live.

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*

Just as in the case of Galileo, people have heard rumors about Darwin, but its meaning has not yet sunk in. For the educated it is important to “believe in evolution”. But to believe that, is also to believe you are an anthropoid. Yet the modern man believes that he is the goal of evolution, its acme, and that nothing could be conceivably be higher. Thus he is the last man and proud of it. If everyone would be just like him, the Kingdom would arrive and the evil ones would be transported away on a cloud. There would be no war, no global warming, and so on.

So Zarathustra told them they were anthropoids, since they should want to know. Instead, they banished him, because in the Country of the Blind, the seer is a menace.

Posted on 2015-11-16 by Cologero

II.8 Stealth Religions and Atheism

As **Rene Guenon** often pointed out, there can be no conflict between science and religion as long as they remain within their respective domains. In particular, esoterism agrees with the findings of science. For

example, science may claim that man has no free will, that he is subject to various unknown inner forces, and so on. Of course, esoterism asserts the same. The difference is that esoterism offers a way out: man must learn to become free, he must discover those hidden forces that direct his life. We recently discussed the esoteric nature of Darwinism. Now we will see if evolutionary biology offers us any further clues to human nature.

As the “new atheist” movement develops into a hardcore ideology, it begins to fragment into dissident groups. For our purposes, we can distinguish between two such groups:

- The **Brights**. They assert that science produces objectively true knowledge, and moreover, is the only source of knowledge. They interpret religious claims as equivalent to scientific claims about the empirical world. They then take an often hysterical “moral” stand against those claims under the principle that any belief that is not supported, or at least potentially supportable, by science as immoral.
- **Evolutionary Biologists**. They take a more nuanced view.

Brains evolved to survive in the world, not to create objectively true theories. Furthermore, religions likewise evolved and persist because of their survival value. Hence, it would be incorrect to describe religions as simply immoral.

Since the brights are more widely known, philosophically unsophisticated, and very simple to understand – it shouldn’t take you more than 30 minutes or so to become a bright – we will explore what the biologists say about it. That position is much more subtle, since it incorporates a wider range of biological phenomena. For example, the bright position is reductionist since it is overly focused on the “gene”. However, genes alone can explain neither the organism nor its group behavior. **David**

Sloan Wilson provides a useful summary of this position in *This View of Life*¹³.

The Argument from Reason First of all, Wilson undercuts the intellectual basis of the brights:

As for the canons of rational thought, to the extent that brains evolved by natural selection, their main purpose is to cause organisms to behave adaptively in the real world—not to directly represent the real world.

Some of you may recognize this as a form of the Argument from Reason¹⁴ made famous by C S Lewis. The fundamental point is that if human reason or rationality arises from nonrational causes, then it has no validity of its own.

Wilson makes a less ambitious distinction between practical and factual realism. A belief is real in the practical sense if it leads to effective action, while a factually real belief corresponds to the external world. There is no question of an independent reason in this distinction. Not just religious, but also ideological and political, beliefs depend on what is practically rather than factually real. For example, what are called “politically correct” beliefs are often practically real, but not factual.

This is actually a very useful distinction and I’m certain that Gornahoor readers can find many examples. A dead giveaway is the repetition of simplistic slogans. I’ve read one prominent political leader who claimed that most people cannot understand something that won’t fit on a placard.

Unfortunately, many debates end up in frustration since one side is committed to a practically real belief and the other to factually real beliefs. However, no quantity of facts will be persuasive in that exchange.

¹³<https://thisviewoflife.com/profile/david-sloan-wilson/>

¹⁴https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Argument_from_reason

Practical realism is usually accompanied with an intense emotional investment which would make a conversion to the factually real quite difficult psychologically.

Nevertheless, Wilson cannot resist making a normative claim:

We need respect for factual realism as never before to arrive at practical solutions to life's complicated problems.

That is a good point with the proviso that esoterism considers the study of inner states of consciousness as fundamental to factual realism. This is what Julius Evola called "metaphysical positivism".

Another point is that Wilson's claim has a goal: viz., "practical solutions". Yet, this gives us pause since most people are committed to practical realism. How would the factual realist motivate the practical realist, if not with the "noble lie"?

Stealth Religions Wilson defines a stealth religion as a factually incorrect belief system that functions like a religion. Specifically, its main purpose is not to describe the main world but rather to motivate a suite of behaviours. The difference is that a stealth religion does not accept the existence of anything transcendent.

Wilson asserts that the real world involves "messy tradeoffs"; for example, the effects of an action may be beneficial, harmful, or a mix of both for the parties involved. A stealth religion evades those tradeoffs by turning them into absolutes, either good or bad for everyone, anytime.

Now even animals know facts, but what is truly human is the intellectual capacity to grasp the concepts, or eternal ideas, that explain the facts. That is the definition of rationality. The argument from reason denies, then, that rationality per se is a "natural process". That puts Wilson in an intellectual bind. If legitimate religions are the result of evolutionary forces, then so are the stealth religions. But which intellectual system is not a stealth religion by his definition?

Certainly multiple political theories cannot all be true, i.e., all, or in the best case, all but one, of them are stealth religions because they arose arbitrarily and must be factually incorrect in part or in whole. Just a quick survey of the news today reveals slogans like, “I am a progressive who gets things done,” without specifying any thing in particular. Or “People will respond to the message of hope,” but hope for what? Nevertheless, they persist, since they are reflect group cohesion, as we shall see later.

So either reason is transcendent to the world, or, as a natural process, it can only create competing and incompatible belief systems. This, however, is not the lesson that the atheists will learn from Wilson.

The Proud Atheist Wilson defends himself from being a stealth religionist by claiming to be a “proud” atheist. I have no idea what pride has to do with it. In particular, he is proud because he does not believe in people sitting on clouds intervening in natural processes. If that is his actual view on religious beliefs, then it is impossible to take him seriously as a scientist competent to explain religious phenomena.

Nevertheless, Wilson is even-handed as he points out how pseudo-sciences like the New Atheism, strident forms of environmentalism, and probably other beliefs that he doesn’t dare express, act as stealth religions. By pseudo-science, I mean a belief system that claims to be based strictly on science but is actually a stealth religion.¹⁵

Proximate and Ultimate Causation Wilson makes a distinction between ultimate and proximate causation is evolutionary theory. This is

¹⁵Wilson’s understanding of God is no better than that of folk religion. However, there are more sophisticated versions of folk religion that go by the name of “theistic personalism”. I would agree with Wilson were that the only alternative. However, the Traditional understanding, sometimes called “classical theism”, is the only correct one. For a brief discussion of this, please listen to this lecture by David Bentley Hart: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ve1s4amWCg4>.

what he means by them, although this is not his own explanation. Neo-Darwinism recognizes two primary factors: one is the characteristics of the organism and the other is the environment which acts as the selector, choosing the winners among the organisms. Both causes are necessary to understand “evolution by natural selection”.

- **Ultimate Causation.** This refers to the environmental factors. For example, flowers bloom in spring because it is the optimal time. (Any earlier, then frost might kill it, later, then the autumn frost may thwart its development.)
- **Proximate Causation.** This refers to the organism. To complete the example, the flower has a physiological mechanism that causes it to bloom in the spring.

Wilson then notes the similarity of these concepts with the vertical and horizontal dimensions of religion. The vertical dimension refers to the believers’ relationship to God or the transcendent, and the horizontal dimension refers to their relationship to each other, i.e., the community.

Religion as a Natural Phenomena Wilson proposes six possible naturalistic explanations, of uneven plausibility, for the origin of religions. He more or less likes them all, but in the end settles on the explanation he calls the “**Superorganism Hypothesis**”.

If you could say only one thing about religion, it would be this: Most enduring religions have what Emile Durkheim called “secular utility.” They define, motivate, and coordinate groups to achieve collective goals in this life. They promote cooperation within the group and bristle with defenses against the all-important problem of cheating. Using the terms that I introduced in part I, they score high on practical realism, no matter how much they depart from factual realism along the way.

So how exactly does the individual benefit? Wilson dares to tell us:

With respect to the individual benefits of religion, suppose that you discover a grand mansion, better than anything that you could have constructed on your own, with a sign on the door that says “Welcome! Move right in!” You would be a fool to refuse, and your decision might be purely selfish, with only your own welfare in mind.

Nevertheless, Wilson decides to be a fool, but a “proud” fool.

So the group forms a superorganism that motivates group behavior in beneficial ways, even if its empirical claims are not factually real. The hypothesis explains the horizontal dimension of religion, but Wilson conveniently forgets the vertical dimension. The real problem is specificity: why this religion and not another?

It is one thing to claim that a particular religion arose due to natural processes, but how did it take a particular form? That can only be explained by the vertical dimension, i.e., a revelation from above.¹⁶

Religion as Factually Real Scientists tend to approach religion as if it were a scientific theory that tries to explain empirical facts. In that respect it must seem to be absurd. That may be true for folk religions, but not for the deeper understanding of religious texts. Gregory of Nyssa explains:

If one does not read scripture in a “philosophical” fashion, one will see only myths and contradictions.

This is the Protestant legacy with its sola scriptura doctrine understood literally. The cultured despisers of religion then rely on the literal interpretation rather than the philosophical, or allegorical, interpretation. For more on this, you can listen to this lecture by David Bentley Hart¹⁷.

¹⁶We will say more about the “superorganism” in the near future, based on Vladimir Solovyov’s lecture on August Comte.

¹⁷<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5QPNvri-zxs>

Noble Lie Wilson is in an odd position. If, as a scientist, he realizes that a religion promotes group identity and mutual cooperation, not to mention individual benefits, then is he morally obliged to remain silent about its real (according to him) origins? What if the promotion of atheism brings about social turmoil and decadence? How can he know that a group commitment to atheism will serve as a new social glue? Given the time spans involved in evolutionary theories, it would take generations for the full effects of a belief system to unfold.

In other words, if all opinions are arbitrary and bigoted, then only a Noble Lie will enforce one of them over the others.

* * *

Wayne Ferguson on 2016-02-12 at 12:02 said:

The resurrection can be literally true without the Easter narratives being factual in a historical sense (tombs opening during the crucifixion, earthquakes, angels appearing in the garden, Jesus levitating into the clouds, etc.). While there may not be any down-side to believing that these things happened as reported— as long as such beliefs are honestly held and not simply affirmed out of a fear or a desire to conform —we can remove a stumbling block to living faith (in the minds of many) if we can acknowledge that these narratives (as with many of the miracles) can also be thought of as symbolic (i.e. symbols woven into a quasi-historical narrative that point us to the literal/spiritual truth of the resurrection and the life). “The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to bring good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim release to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to let the oppressed go free, to proclaim the year of the Lord’s favor” (Luke 4:18-19). “Therefore he says, Awake you that sleep, and arise from the dead, and Christ shall give you light” (Ephesians 5:14). Blind eyes continue to be opened today... Demons are exercised... Spiritually and psychologically lame rise up and walk... The dead are raised... Miracles have not ceased to happen, we have just become fixated on a particular idea of what a miracle is. That idea had a lot of rhetorical power at one time, but it seems to me that it has (on balance) become a stumbling block today.

White Rabbit on 2016-02-11 at 20:55 said:

“Is the intelligent atheist in fact obliged to be very quiet about his atheism?” Only if that thought randomly happens to possess him... otherwise his passion for discourse and “truth” will “oblige” him to write some more!

Mark Citadel on 2016-02-11 at 18:54 said:

KJ, from my own understanding you must learn to both read a text as broadly differentiated as the Bible in a correct way, and understand the context of each section. The Resurrection I think is necessarily literally true (given as a testimony) whereas something like the literal Adam and Eve one doesn't have to be as stringently committed to, since their description lies beyond the fog, back into the age of myth, where symbolism was hardly discernible from the real. "Sloan defines a stealth religion as a factually incorrect belief system that functions like a religion. Specifically, its main purpose is not to describe the main world but rather to motivate a suite of behaviours. The difference is that a stealth religion does not accept the existence of anything transcendent." He just defined the Cult of Progress. The last question you raise is certainly interesting. Is the intelligent atheist in fact obliged to be very quiet about his atheism? hmmm... that will require some pondering.

Cologero on 2016-02-11 at 07:38 said:

@KJ, I'm just repeating the traditional understanding. The Bible cannot be read simply as an historical or scientific text. It has been read on four levels, of which the literal or physical interpretation is the first level.

KJ on 2016-02-11 at 04:49 said:

Cologero, Are you claiming that *all* of the Bible should be read allegorically? Do you believe any of it to be literally true? Whatever about his involvement in esoteric Christianity there can hardly be any doubt that Dante and his fellow Christians of the High Middle Ages believed the resurrection to be literally correct.

II.9 The Open Universe

Once in a while, it is useful to regard current events from the Traditional perspective. This week we ponder about whether the world is a computer simulation engineered by some evil aliens and how that might explain the political system in the USA.

The World as Simulation

We ought to regard the present state of the universe as the effect of its anterior state and as the cause of the one which is to follow.

Assume an intelligence which could know all the forces by which nature is animated, and the states at an instant of all the objects that compose it. for this intelligence, nothing could be uncertain; and the future, as the past, would be present to its eyes.

PIERRE-SIMON LAPLACE

The **American Museum of Natural History**, which claims to be “on the frontier of scientific discovery”, recently held a panel discussion on the question: *Is the Universe a Simulation?*¹⁸. The panel was “politically correct” and does not represent any physics faculty I am familiar with.¹⁹. Presumably, a panel discussion on real physics would attract a minuscule audience, whereas the illusion of physics will be a sellout.

While these sophisticated New Yorkers would most likely be appalled to learn that the Universe was designed and created by God, they are perfectly willing to consider the possibility that it has been designed by an alien intelligence. That is, our world is more like a computer program, so we could conceivably be nothing but software. Now the ideas of an algorithm and computability have precise meanings, so the question reduces to this: Is the universe computable? If not, then the premise must be false. I couldn’t bear to listen to more than a few minutes of the debate, so I don’t know if these issues were even brought up; nevertheless, we will consider these: the Big Bang, Natural Selection, and Consciousness.

The Big Bang The Enlightenment philosopher Laplace claimed that if he knew the laws of physics and the initial state of the universe, he could then predict all future events. Let’s concede that we know those

¹⁸<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wgSZA3NPpBs>

¹⁹See the following webpages: <https://www.aip.org/statistics/data-graphics/percentage-physics-faculty-members-who-are-women>
<https://www.aip.org/statistics/data-graphics/race-and-ethnicity-physics-faculty-0>

laws, so the only issue is the initial state of the cosmos. Unfortunately, there is no “initial state” of the Big Bang, since there is no “beginning” of the universe in space-time. Rather, the equations posit a singularity at time $t = 0$. So either our understanding of relativity and quantum mechanics is flawed, or the universe is not computable.

Intelligent Design While preparing a review of some books by **Wolfgang Smith**, I watched a couple of youtube debates about the theory of intelligent design. The opponents of the theory were quite nasty; it seemed that the merits of **William Dembski**’s ideas didn’t matter at all. Rather, they were intransigently opposed to the idea that there may be a designer. They insist that “natural selection” fully accounts for the variety of flora and fauna that we experience now.

In other words, natural selection is not merely an alternative to intelligent design, it is actually a refutation of intelligent design. If that is the case, then we cannot be living in a simulation, since life forms cannot have arisen from a deliberate design.

Consciousness There are many metaphysical demonstrations that intelligent thought is transcendent to the world, and therefore cannot be the result of some computable biochemical process. We’ve mentioned some, so there is no point in going into more detail. Hence, we cannot be inside a simulation.

From a different perspective, some may be interested in *The Open Universe* by **Karl Popper**, which refutes many varieties of scientific and metaphysical determinism. Its concern is to justify the “**freedom, creativity, and rationality of man**”, which are incompatible with a simulated universe. I suppose that people with an underdeveloped sense of their own freedom, creativity, and rationality may still find it plausible.

The Limits of Rationality One consequence of an open universe is that there are limits to rationality. For example, there is Gödel's theorem which denies the computability of the laws of arithmetic. More to the point, all political attempts at central planning are doomed to failure.

Astrology was used in the past as a tool for central planning. An interesting history of astrology, mathematics, and political control can be found here: By fetishising mathematical models, economists turned economics into a highly paid pseudoscience.²⁰

However, there is an important difference between ancient astrology and contemporary economics. The former tried to be deterministic, seeking an exact correspondence between the heavens and earth, while the latter relies on less precise statistical methods. Those methods were not known to the ancients and they are poorly understood now, except by specialists. One philosopher who has integrated statistical understanding into a traditional Thomist framework is **Bernard Lonergan**. In his magnum opus, *Insight*, he writes that the knowledge of laws can be applied to

- Individual events
- Systematic processes
- Non-systematic processes

The knowledge of individual things or events is the most primitive. This is how most people think and it pertains also to animals. From the individuals, the next level of understanding is to grasp the concept that explains the individuals. There is an understanding of the “whole”. For example, by understanding the proof that the angles of triangles add up

²⁰<https://aeon.co/essays/how-economists-rode-maths-to-become-our-era-s-astrologers>

to 180 degrees, I no longer have to start measuring each individual triangle. In the scale of angelic intelligences, there are deeper and deeper layers of abstraction. For example, the Periodic Table makes clear at a glance the relationships of the chemical elements and the Heliocentric theory explains the movements of the planets with a simple law.

Things get trickier in the Open Universe, since we have to rely on more sophisticated quantitative techniques. **Robert Nozick**, in *The Nature of Rationality*, discusses game theory, decision theory, and so on. Of course, quantitative methods are quite important in that domain.

There have been many attempts to classify human beings and typology has always been an esoteric science. Without going into any of them right now, we can point out that it is always a matter of trends and tendencies, since the movement of history cannot be predicted with precision. Nevertheless, statistical methods are nevertheless useful. After all, insurance companies and casinos are profitable precisely because of their knowledge of probabilities and statistics.

Unfortunately, in setting policy, it is difficult for decision makers to make the transition from the knowledge of individuals to the knowledge of non-systematic processes. First of all, there is a psychological resistance to any system of classification that entails any essential aspects to diversity (despite diversity itself being cherished). Then there is the resistance to general conclusions, because in a statistical distribution, there are individuals that fall outside the general tendency.

To be continued

Posted on 2016-05-05 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2016-05-05 at 12:58 said:

As Shaw saw, people swore allegiance to "natural selection" not for any evidence but because they wanted to escape from the nosy Calvinist God. Only later did they realize that they

were now stuck in a meaningless universe. Since God is still *infra dig*, I think “aliens” have taken his place among the *bien pensant*. Mythology etc. is “explained” by “ancient aliens.” Well, that’s still pretty fringe; but here we see “smart” New Yorkers taking the idea of alien programmers seriously. Anything but God or even Spirit.

Wayne Ferguson on 2016-05-06 at 11:24 said:

Leaving aside the idea of a computer simulation, *per se*, the idea of a holographic universe is, in fact, being seriously entertained by several top-notch physicists. As I see it, this would be consistent with some form of idealism (e.g. Neoplatonism).

With that in mind, I use the following popular presentation to show that the appearance of evolution (which seems, to me, to be undeniable) would, from the stand-point of a holographic universe, be true as phenomena (in the same way that a sunrise or sunset is) but not ultimately explanatory...

“The illusion of third dimension : the universe as a hologram or holographic universe”
[“Nova” excerpt]

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=16WI1RJxnrY>

The sun apparently circles the earth (from a geocentric perspective). We still acknowledge this appearance – honor it, even – when we speak of “sunrises” and “sunsets” (even though we know it is not, strictly speaking, “the truth” – or at least not the whole truth).

Likewise, it seems to me that I can reasonably acknowledge that my (apparent) body appears to be the result of evolutionary processes without conceding that “I” am the product of biological evolution, *per se*. Evolutionary biology illuminates the natural genealogy of the form that I see when I look in a mirror, but there is more to me than meets the eye...

As such, even if we were to confirm that the spatio-temporal world is a holographic image that reflects some sort of transcendent intelligence/idea/datum, we could still point to (and speak of) the phenomena of biological evolution (as we currently imagine it) as taking place over the last several hundred million years), but we would now know that the real cause of this apparent process transcends the flow of appearances (similar to the way in which we now know that the “sunrise” and “sunset” are caused by the movement of the earth relative to the sun).

Leaving aside the holographic universe, however, it is also the case that we can’t seem to arrive at an understanding of consciousness through the analysis of matter and material processes alone – even Sam Harris acknowledges this (see the quotes, below, following the link to my “Two Arguments Against Physicalism”)

[Note: One of those “two arguments”, BTW, is that it makes no sense to say that consciousness, as such, is selected for if it is reducible to physical structures and processes – and yet some scientists never tire of generating “just so” stories that explain why certain modes consciousness, as such, evolved (but I digress..)]

In short, even though our apparent bodies appear to have evolved over time from non-human species, that does not account for consciousness as such—which, as I see it, is the gift of God (an inexplicable mystery). That which is born of the flesh is flesh” (i.e. those who understand themselves exclusively according to their natural history and/or genealogy and identify themselves exclusively with the form they see in the mirror and with their personal autobiography) and “that which is born of the Spirit is Spirit (those who participate in the life of Christ which is represented in terms of the virgin birth and incarnation). As such, we are called upon to be “put to death in the flesh, but made alive in the Spirit” – called upon to take up our cross and enter the kingdom NOW. As Valentin Tomberg explains, our Divine image is in-tact, but because we do not recognize and honor it, the Divine likeness has become disfigured and, thus, it is said that we “must be born again/from above” (i.e. we must become “The Hanged Man” – see Letter 12 “Meditations on the Tarot”– see Letter 14 for the discussion of the Divine image and likeness).

<https://jwayneferguson.wordpress.com/2015/05/23/two-arguments-against-physicalism/>

Quoting from chapter two of “Waking Up”, by Sam Harris:

“However we propose to explain the emergence of consciousness—be it in biological, functional, computational, or any other terms—we have committed ourselves to this much: First there is a physical world, unconscious and seething with unperceived events; then, by virtue of some physical property or process, consciousness itself springs, or staggers, into being. This idea seems to me not merely strange but perfectly mysterious. That doesn’t mean it isn’t true. When we linger over the details, however, this notion of emergence seems merely a placeholder for a miracle” (56).

“The fact that the universe is illuminated where you stand—that your thoughts and moods and sensations have a qualitative character in this moment—is a mystery, exceeded only by the mystery that there should be something rather than nothing in the first place” (79).

Wayne Ferguson on 2016-07-10 at 22:34 said:

In this controversial film on Intelligent Design with Ben Stein, Richard Dawkins speculates that organic life on this planet may have been designed and that the designer(s) may have left some trace that will eventually be found. This segment lasts about 6 minutes:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=V5EPymcWp-g&t=87m0s>

II.10 Consciousness Explained

Daniel Dennett, a professor of philosophy at my alma mater, is one of the “New Atheists”. Several years ago, a small group of friends use to meet to discuss esoteric texts. One fellow began to “lose his religion” and announced that the next text would be *Consciousness Explained* followed by *Darwin’s Dangerous Idea*, both by Dennett.

Consciousness explained was ultimately anti-climactic since the ending was more like consciousness explained away. On the principle that the errors of an intelligent man are more interesting than the truths of a mediocrity, there is much value in Dennett’s books. First of all, they provide the latest researches into neuroscience and biology, integrated into his peculiar worldview.

Naturalism Naturalism is the view that the world process can be fully described solely in terms of natural, i.e., physical, causes. In other words, the cosmos is epistemologically closed. The cosmos can be explained from internal evidence alone, requiring no intervention by supernatural or preternatural causes. In logical terms, that means that the system is complete. Unfortunately, in actuality it is not at all complete, since there are things and events that have no plausible explanation, hence the search for the “Theory of Everything.” Nevertheless, naturalists take it on faith that these explanations will be found.

A logical system, moreover, needs to be consistent so that no self-contradictions can arise. We don’t know that, and there are reasons to believe that it is not consistent.

Naturalism must necessarily reject two seemingly self-evident truths: first, the idea of God, and second, more startingly, the inefficacy of consciousness.

From a metaphysical perspective, naturalism recognizes matter, space, and time as the sole conditions of manifestation. It leaves out essence and

psyche.

The Notion of God From that perspective, the notion of God serves no purpose. In other words, the theories of physics, the laws of mathematics, chemical reactions, and biological development can be studied without reference to any God. I've heard enough debates with physicists who simply look puzzled when God is invoked. By Occam's razor, "God" is a superfluous hypothesis, not to mention that the description of this God is quite muddled, and varies quite a bit from believer to believer.

The point is that the idea of God is incompatible with naturalism, and is always embedded within a more complex metaphysical framework.

Consciousness Consciousness is required by no physical equation nor any scientific theory. At best, it is a useless epiphenomenon, having no power to affect physical events. Dennett has to go through pains to demonstrate the lack of free will. For example, he refers to neurological tests that predict the choices of a subject even before he becomes consciously aware of having made that choice.

The idea of Qualia, he claims, is too vague to be of value. The subjective sensation of color, for example, changes nothing; the frequency of electromagnetic waves is all that matters. He provides countless examples.

There is no point being concerned about conscious experience, although everyone is. All your pains, anxiety, depression, fears, and so on, do not matter for the world process. Neither do your joys, pleasures, and so on. They are merely epiphenomena of biological processes.

That view is eerily reminiscent of those Gnostic sects that believed we were created by an evil demiurge. The Demiurge trapped our consciousnesses in a world of matter, with no ability to escape. We are doomed to suffer in matter, yet unable to do anything about it.

Moralism That Gnostic view is quite terrifying, yet it has no such effect on Dennett who seems quite sanguine about the value of his philosophy. Moreover, he inconsistently hangs onto the idea that there is a moral way to act in the world. Not surprisingly, his views on that, seem to match about 90% of the academic community. So Dennett moralizes, trying to spread atheism far and wide. For what purpose, we don't know; at least, it is not clear to me. A belief should also be an epiphenomenon with no causal efficacy in the world process.

George Santayana is a much deeper thinker and more consistent than Dennett. For him, there is no point to promote his philosophy. Those who can understand, will understand; otherwise, it is pointless to explain it to the ignorant.

A Day in the Life Let's pretend that naturalism is true. We can analyze a typical day in a small Potemkin like village, in which the human beings can be hooked up to neuronal devices and other medical devices such as oxygen intake and blood pressure.

We can verify that energy and momentum are conserved in the village. We can measure the caloric intake and expenditures to verify it. We know how their physiology functions. We watch them move about the village and can measure the expenditure of energy.

So far no laws of physics have been violated. The people of the village can be studied as if they were billiard balls on a pool table.

Their human interactions can be explained by evolutionary psychology. They bond with their closest genetic relatives and treat strangers with more caution. Since humans are social, we observe how social hierarchies are established, and so on.

Nevertheless, there are some inconsistencies that demand explanation. By Newton's law, motion should remain in a straight line unless acted upon by an outside force. Yet humans never walk straight for very long, making sudden uncaused changes of direction.

The force, then, must be interior, not exterior. We can see through our instruments that each change of direction is preceded by some neuronal activity. That is the sought for cause, even though it explains nothing.

If the human being turns to enter a grocery store, we can understand that it is seeking a new energy source. But if it walks into a comic book store, the event seems to have not biologically necessary cause.

TO BE CONTINUED

Posted on 2021-07-08 by Cologero

Review of Wolfgang Smith's works

12.1 Pseudoscience and Scientism

In which we review several books by Wolfgang Smith on the metaphysics of science.

It is impossible that these things should be understood by men in general, but only by the small number of those who are destined to prepare in one way or another the germs of the future cycle.

RENE GUENON

Boris Mouravieff identified three stages in the intellectual development of the West: philosophy, theology, and science. The coming stage, the age of Art, will be the creative synthesis, the contemplation of Beauty in mysticism and theurgy as described by **Vladimir Solovyov** in the Law of Development¹.

¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=3571>

The aim of philosophy is the good life or the best regime, the aim of theology is knowledge of God, and that of science, knowledge of the physical world. These correspond to the Taoist triad of Man, Heaven, and Earth. In an essay titled *Modern Science and the Guenonian Critique*, **Wolfgang Smith** challenges Guenon's casual dismissal of profane science. Imagine two intersecting circles of a Venn diagram. Beyond the intersection of one circle there is "pseudoscience", beyond the other is "scientism". In the intersection is what Smith calls "hard science". Smith admits that scientism, i.e., the reduction of everything to quantity, is not knowledge, yet he insists that there is a partial truth in "hard science". Hence, it may be helpful to consider Smith's work as a "Guenonian critique of modern science."

We agree with this, since those preparing for the next cycle should be adept in political science, metaphysics, and, yes, science. All the more so since the best minds today go into science, although they seldom have any grasp of metaphysics. Moreover, we would go further than Smith, since the creative act requires a full integration. **Valentin Tomberg** explains:

The synthesis of science and religion is not a theory, but rather the inner act of consciousness of adding the spiritual vertical to the scientific horizontal.

Due to the large amount of material, it would be impracticable to go through each book in detail. It may be more useful to those unfamiliar with Smith's works to outline his fundamental worldview, since it is scattered across several essays. Then we can look at some specific examples from physics, cosmology, biology, and psychology that illustrate how profane science can and should be evaluated from a higher, metaphysical viewpoint. This may make his books, which are far from casual reading, more approachable.

Principles of Traditional Cosmology In the *Wisdom of Ancient Cosmology* (WAC), Smith identifies four principles to which all ancient

cosmology conforms.

- Traditional cosmology primarily deals with the qualitative aspects of reality.
- The metaphysical notion of verticality affirms a hierarchic order in which the corporeal domain constitutes the lowest tier.
- Man constitutes a microcosm or “universe in miniature”, which recapitulates the cosmic order. Thus man is not a stranger in a “hostile or indifferent universe but constitutes the very heart and center of the cosmos”.
- The higher strata of the cosmos can be known through the realization of the corresponding states of man himself. Thus the key to knowledge is first to “know thyself”.

Bifurcation Smith traces the foundations of science, as we know it today, to Rene Descartes and Galileo Galilei. The introduced some errors into the consciousness of modern minds:

- Bifurcation
- Quantification
- De-essentialism

Bifurcation is Smith’s word for Cartesian dualism: all that exists is matter and mind. Matter is mechanistic and the objects of sense experience exist only in the mind. The physical world, therefore, is knowable only as quantity so that mathematics is the only tool to know it. All qualities, then, exist only in mind. That is why Guenon asserts that

In our world, by reason of the special conditions of existence to which it is subject, the lowest point takes on the aspect of pure quantity, deprived of every qualitative distinction.

The net result is the de-essentialization of thought. An essence or form is the answer to the “what is” question. Scientism denies the existence of such essences. Philosophically, that is the doctrine of “nominalism”, which asserts that ideas are merely human creations, as opposed to “realism”, which claims that the ideas are real and independent of man.

Although we cannot accept their respective philosophical systems *in toto*, Smith points to **Alfred North Whitehead** and to **Edmund Husserl** as the two philosophers of the 20th century who did the most to provide compelling alternatives to Cartesian bifurcation.

Vertical Causation The ideas of vertical and horizontal causation are fundamental to Smith’s critique. Nevertheless, they are poorly understood, even by those who consider themselves religious today. Science is concerned solely with horizontal causes, that is, events that follow each other in time, in other words, with efficient causality. From a methodological perspective, it omits any consideration of vertical causation, that is, formal and final causes. Obviously, science has had great success, at least in terms of technology, with that method. However, scientism goes on to assert, without any warrant, that vertical causation does not exist at all.

Another way to look at this question, which Smith hints at without being so explicit, is the Hermetic teaching of the triad of Providence, Will, and Destiny². Providence, then, includes formal and final causes. Specifically, formal causes determine the possibilities of manifestation of those forms that are realizable at any moment. The final cause is the ultimate aim or purpose of the manifest universe.

²<https://gornahoor.net/?p=8116>

Ontologically the final cause is prior to the efficient cause, even if the efficient cause appears to come first in time. Hence, scientifically a final cause is expressed as one of the anthropic principles, which will be discussed later. Smith also refers to **Edgar Dacqué**'s idea that man was created prior to the animals, so that the process of evolution is part of that creation in time. He uses the same argument used by **Julius Evola** in *The Esoteric Origin of the Species*³.

Scientists and atheists often react to the deformed ideas of God and vertical causation held by naïve believers. This view seems itself to be bifurcationist. It envisions a “spiritual” world, inhabited by a god, that runs along in time parallel to the physical world. From time to time, this god looks down and interferes with the world process. This notion is commonly derided as the “god of the gaps”.

Of course, God is outside of time altogether. Smith refers to the Scholastic idea of *nunc stans* or the “eternal now” to express that view. This does not mean that time is a sequence of “nows”, just as a line is not “made” of points. Hence, horizontal causation, or Destiny, can best be understood as a projection of vertical causation onto time.

Metaphysics as Seeing Smith asserts that metaphysics “springs from man’s innate thirst for truth, which is none other than the thirst for God”. Today, it is often restricted to its degenerate form as an academic discipline pursued by “professionals”. Rather, metaphysics is an activity of the mind and heart to which we are “called”. Smith claims, democratically, that in principle all are called; from our perspective—and Guenon’s for that matter—that is far from obvious.

Gnosis then is not a matter of debate or arguing, is more like “seeing”, or a direct perception. The purpose of logic is to “deconstruct false beliefs” and perforce to *purify the mind*. Only the pure in heart shall see God.

³See Section 11.5 in this book.

Drawing on Husserl's phenomenology, Smith claims that the phenomenon is that which "shows itself in itself". This "seeing" of the self-revelation of the phenomenon is non-dual; the bifurcation into the seeing subject and the seen object comes afterward. If we mistake the bifurcation for the real, then "seeing" has come to an end. Although Smith comes at this from a completely different angle, his use of phenomenology corresponds to what we have called Hermetic meditation⁴.

By this process, we understand the object to be a "whole" in itself, not merely the sum of its parts. The horizontal causation described by science necessarily misses that point in its attempt to reduce everything to more fundamental parts. For example, the organism is its genes, an object is "made" of atoms, atoms, of subatomic particle, and so on. The scientist thereby can only "see" his own theories and constructs and misses the actual phenomenon. This is far from the "knowledge of the whole" which is the proper aim of philosophy.

For support, Smith turns to **Johann Wolfgang von Goethe** who conceived of a science not of quantities but of qualities. Goethe claimed that the mind must be "sun-like" in order to behold the Sun. Smith goes further, based on some ideas from **Meister Eckhart**, that the mind must be divine in order to behold God. That is the ultimate knowledge of the whole.

Part 2 of this review will deal with specific scientific topics discussed by Smith. These will be taken from the following books:

- *The Wisdom of Ancient Cosmology: Contemporary Science in Light of Tradition* (WAC)
- *Science and Myth* (S&M)
- *Cosmos & Transcendence: Breaking Through the Barrier of Scientific Belief* (C&T)

⁴<https://gornahoor.net/?p=898>

- *The Quantum Enigma: Finding the Hidden Key* (QE)

On a personal note, I found my copy of QE at a used book store, taken apparently from Huston Smith's personal library. There is this hand-written dedication:

To Professor Huston Smith in friendship, gratitude and high esteem, Wolfgang

The book was in pristine condition and seemed, to me, to have never been read.

Posted on 2016-05-16 by Cologero

* * *

Tom Walker on 2016-05-17 at 09:12 said:

One of the best books debunking the new atheism and scientific pretensions is that of David Berlinski "The Devil's Delusion", <http://www.davidberlinski.org/devils-delusion/about.php>

Berlinski, a secular Jew, appears to be neutral as far as religion is concerned but in his book he dismantles atheistic and scientific arrogance and shows that science, is far from having an answer for everything even in the physical world.

Cologero on 2016-05-18 at 20:25 said:

Thanks for the link, Tom Walker, but our intent is far from merely "debunking the new atheism and scientific pretensions". Rather, as I thought was made clear, is to take what is valid and place it into a larger metaphysical context, while avoiding both pseudoscience (which is bad science masquerading as philosophy) and scientism (which is bad philosophy masquerading as science).

Sigurd on 2017-09-07 at 12:43 said:

Wolfgang Smith's works are great. I was introduced to them from this website. It's nice to read a more contemporary writer on the subject of the same issues, particularly one who is already a specialist, Keith Critchlow would be another good example.

On the subject of cosmology, Cologero do you think theurgy and ceremonial ritual employed in the context of planetary correspondences, such as is suggested in Evola's hermetic tradition, is a valid practice in contemporary times? I understand there is some psychic danger in this because of the "objectifying" of the various forces that correspond to the padmas, what are your thoughts?

littleM on 2018-05-16 at 09:18 said:

I always stand in awe, thinking how everything here is written before it happened. Well, I should get used to it, but that does not mean being less in awe.

N. W. Flitcraft on 2018-05-16 at 20:59 said:

If you are not already, you should all be aware of Dr. Smith's new foundation, the *Philos-Sophia Initiative*⁵. And follow the *Philos-Sophia Initiative* "page" on facebook⁶ and/or join in the conversation at the *Wolfgang Smith Facebook Circle*⁷.

12.2 Dabbling in the Quantum World

Nothing appears to be more certain than our scientific knowledge of the physical universe. But then, what is the physical universe? We are told that it consists of space, time, and matter, or of space-time and energy, or perhaps of something else still more abstruse and even less imaginable; but in any case we are told in unequivocal terms what it excludes: as all of us have learnt, the physical universe is said to exclude just about everything which from the ordinary human point of view makes up the world. Thus it excludes the blueness of the sky and the roar of breaking waves, the fragrance of flowers and all the innumerable qualities—half-perceived and half-intuited—that lend color, charm, and meaning to our terrestrial and cosmic environment. In fact, it excludes everything that can be imagined or conceived, except in abstract mathematical terms.

⁵<https://philos-sophia.org/>

⁶<https://www.facebook.com/PhilosSophiaInitiative/>

⁷<https://www.facebook.com/groups/Wolfgangsters/>

WOLFGANG SMITH, *Cosmos and Transcendence*

Thus nature gets credit which should in truth be reserved for ourselves: the rose for its scent, the nightingale for his song, and the sun for its radiance. The poets are entirely mistaken. They should address their lyrics to themselves, and should turn them into odes of self-congratulation and the excellency of the human mind. Nature is a dull affair, soulless, scentless, colorless; merely the hurrying of material, endlessly, meaninglessly.

ALFRED NORTH WHITEHEAD, *Science and the Modern World*

We are generally in agreement in thinking that humanity has arrived at an important turning point in its history. The Cartesian spirit which destroyed scholastic philosophy is now in turn being left behind. The logic of history demands a new spirit. The divorce between traditional knowledge, of which religion is a trustee, and acquired knowledge, the fruit of science, threatens to make sterile the Christian civilization which in origin is so rich with promises. Yet it is an aberration to believe that Science by its very nature is opposed to Tradition, and it must also be firmly stressed that Tradition does not include any tendency opposed to Science.

BORIS MOURAVIEFF, *Gnosis*

Quantum Physics Despite the incredible accuracy of its predictions and the elegance of its mathematical models, quantum mechanics still remains unintelligible. In other words, there is no answer to the “what” question (which is qualitative), but rather there are several wildly different interpretations – all mathematically equivalent—of the equations. Wolfgang Smith offers his own interpretation in terms of Traditional metaphysics.

Metaphysics envisages different strata or degrees of being from the most dense to the most sublime. The naïve mind takes our everyday, corporeal, plane as the only reality. The *materia prima* is the lowest level. According to **Rene Guenon** (see Chapter II of *The Reign of Quantity*), this is the passive principle of universal manifestation or pure potentiality. As such, it is the “subject of all the substantial transformations of the corporeal universe”. Hence, *materia prima* is unintelligible since things are known through their form. In the Vedanta, this level is called *Prakriti* or *avyakta* in the Sankhya.

The next level is *materia secunda*, which is material, extended, quantitative, not yet a substance. That is, it has quantity but not quality and Guenon claims that this is what physicists actually mean by matter.

Unfortunately, modern science knows nothing about such levels and tries to understand things horizontally rather than vertically. Specifically, it view the world on a quantitative scale from subatomic particles, to atoms, to man, all the way to the largest structures of solar systems, galaxies, etc. The larger structures are not grasped as wholes, but are assumed to be built up from lower structures.

Now when this is applied to quantum events, we start seeing anomalies. For example, we consider the sun to be a “ball” and we know about balls in our corporeal world. Hence, we envision an electron, say, as just a very small ball. Yet, it doesn’t always act as ball (i.e., a particle), but sometimes like a wave. Smith interprets that to mean that what we “see” are not electrons, but rather probabilities; i.e., electrons as such are quantitative, not qualitative.

Smith takes this to mean that the quantum world is actually a stratum of matter between the corporeal plane and the *materia secunda*. This, then, is the physical world, the world studied by physicists. In fact, we never actually experience the physical world directly, but we know it indirectly through its interactions with the corporeal world (i.e., instruments, cloud chambers, and other measuring devices).

Now these two strata are intimately related, since behind every object X in the corporeal world, there is a physical object SX in the subcorporeal world that corresponds to it. The physicist investigates SX, not X. This is Smith's unique contribution to the proper understanding of quantum mechanics.

The alternative horizontal view is that the object X is "composed" of various subatomic particles. Hence, we hear that the table we see is "really" mostly empty space. However, there is obviously no physical explanation for the table, since quantity cannot explain quality. That is hardly an increase in understanding, but rather a reversion to the first philosophers who believed that corporeal substances were just aggregations of atoms. It ignores the deepening of understanding from that view to Plato, Aristotle, and Thomas Aquinas.

Bell's Theorem In 1964, the physicist John Bell discovered a flaw in the equations of quantum mechanics. Up to that point, it was simply assumed that physical objects acted locally, hence were constrained to the known physical forces. In particular, signals between object could not exceed the speed of light. Bell's Theorem asserts, on the contrary, that reality is nonlocal. Not just in theory, this has been verified experimentally.

Smith sees this as a fundamental limitation of physics: it cannot in itself tell us about the universe, but it can only describe phenomena. It takes a metaphysical explanation to deal with the strata of cosmic reality. Smith relates this to the teaching on Heaven, Earth, and the metaxy as Plato called it, or the spiritual, corporeal, and the intermediate. Corporeal things are intermediary things subjected to spatio-temporal constraints. Smith claims that the alchemical processes of *solve* and *coagula* represent the transitions between those two strata.

Nonlocality can be understood by the traditional distinction between the corporeal and the intermediary levels; in the Vedanta, these are called the *sthula* or gross level and the *sukshma* or subtle level. Thus physics is

consistent with this teaching:

- Quantum mechanics affirms the ontological discontinuity between the physical, subcorporeal, world and the corporeal by state vector collapse
- Nonlocality illustrates the discontinuity between the corporeal and the intermediary

Physics qua physics cannot explain this. The physicist himself is at the corporeal level. On the one hand, he is looking downward toward the *materia secunda*, away from essences. Hence, he simply cannot see the corporeal and perforce the intermediary levels.

Summing It Up This has ramifications beyond just physics. Corporeal beings have a “double birth”:

- A pre-temporal birth in the divine creative Act (vertical)
- A temporal birth bringing it into the corporeal domain (horizontal)

Debates about science and religion are pointless without this understanding. Being blind to the vertical strata above the corporeal world, science will misinterpret metaphysical explanations as pertaining just to the corporeal world.

A couple of decades ago, quantum mechanics “light” was made popular in New Age circles in a few books. We don’t need it to make us aware of higher dimensional reality, just the opposite, actually. I recall one woman, a school guidance counselor, who assured me that she was “dabbling” in quantum mechanics. I was the wrong person to hear that, since I could actually do the math involved, while she just wanted the false authority of science to back up her weird worldview. We hope that

readers aren't just dabbling, but are reading with the aim of achieving an intellectual conversion.

Forthcoming posts will deal with Cosmology, Biology, and Psychology.

Posted on 2016-05-19 by Cologero

* * *

Sigurd on 2017-02-03 at 18:02 said:

Hello, I very much enjoyed your post, however my understanding of quantum mechanics is minimal; and so I need to look further before I can truly understand. Is there any reading material you can refer one to regarding quantum mechanics and its relation with traditional metaphysics? I am primarily unfamiliar with quantum mechanics. I hope to receive a response.

Cologero on 2017-02-04 at 18:38 said:

There is only one book that deals with quantum mechanics from the perspective of Tradition: *The Quantum Enigma: Finding the Hidden Key*, by **Wolfgang Smith**.

Sigurd on 2017-02-04 at 19:27 said:

Thanks for the response; and some further questions: is an understanding of Aristotelian metaphysics important to understanding Guenon's arguments in the *Reign of Quantity*? Would you consider Aristotle's metaphysics to be relevant today (including under a quantum framework)? How important is Thomism in this regard?

Thanks for the responses. This is also a good time to say I appreciate your work here. This site has been quite instrumental in the development of my understanding of Traditionalism, as well as placing them in their historical context vis-a-vis the letters of Evola and Guenon.

Cologero on 2017-02-04 at 19:45 said:

Aristotle is important to understanding Guenon in the sense that it is more natural, as well as more accessible, to Westerners. For example, his doctrines of essence vs existence, the superiority of intellectual intuition, and the identification of knowledge with being, are part of Traditional metaphysics. Unfortunately, probably few professors in the West grasp the significance of those doctrines. Moreover, the Scholastics, like St Thomas Aquinas, developed those doctrines in a more Traditional direction. Look up Edward Feser for a basic introduction to Aristotle and Aquinas.

You can do quantum physics just fine with no knowledge of Aristotle, but that is not the point. Read the articles on Gornahoor about Wolfgang Smith for some ideas.

Sigurd on 2017-02-06 at 04:43 said:

I see, thank you very much. One last distinction: would the divine creative act be likened to Aristotle's idea of 'formal cause'? And would this phenomenon also be related to Evola's (and others) idea of involution? Apologies if the relevance of the questions are somewhat stretched, but I am trying to understand the essential creative act in a way that is congenial to my own readings. Again, thanks for the helpful responses.

Matt on 2017-02-07 at 19:34 said:

Hi Sigurd,

I think the appropriate Aristotelian category to place the divine creative act in would be the efficient cause (also known as agent cause) rather than formal cause, which refers to the intrinsic nature (essential constitution) of a thing.

Sigurd on 2017-02-11 at 01:31 said:

Great! Helpful response, Matt. Thank you for getting back to me. It is nice to find a website with such congenial spirits.

12.3 From Worms to Gods

In which we review **Wolfgang Smith's** writings on Darwinism and biology.

I am worm, I am slave, I am king, I am God.

GAVRILA DERZHAVIN

Spiritual and mystical writers are often criticized, e.g., as being "life denying", for describing themselves as "worms" or "slaves". Here, however, the Russian poet Derzhavin gives us the complete formula of the evolution of Christian gnosis: subconscious, waking consciousness, the Real Self, and finally God consciousness.

By now, even old men in the forest have heard the news that God is dead. Unlike the men in the marketplace who rejoice because now “all things are possible”, the old men see that nothing is possible. Man is once again a worm, with no higher purpose, and a slave to his passions, his neurons, his genes, and the molecules that compose his body. Consciousness itself is unreal, an epiphenomenon, an artifact of a certain complexity. The new god is Science, although men seldom grasp what that means. They go on with their lives as if the One God still exists.

I recently read a list of items that, it was claimed, Americans are ignorant of. Among indisputable facts about who was George Washington or who fought in the Civil War, they slipped in some disputable items such as neo-Darwinism vis-à-vis Intelligent Design. Of course the “intelligent” know that Darwin is correct. The intellectual equivalent of cheap grace, it gives the scientifically illiterate and innumerate the illusion of being among the cognoscenti. There are two ways, however, to understand, or misunderstand, the “theory of evolution”.

The Marketplace Option 1 is to go on with life as though nothing has changed, as in this vignette about Galileo⁸. Man goes on just as before Darwin. His self-awareness is still as a person with a moral will, who can create and love, and so on. The only difference is that he assumes that the human race evolved naturally, albeit randomly, from lower forms of life, rather than as a being who is created in the image and likeness of God.

The Mad Men The Mad Men, however, understand that the very concept of the human race is radically altered, in conformance with the demands of the neo-Darwinist theory. By this standard, man is an animal, consciousness is at best a by-product or epiphenomenon of a certain brain complexity, and free will is an illusion. There is no moral absolute,

⁸<https://gornahoor.net/?p=1109>

since all behavior is governed by genetics and evolved in order to achieve a certain level of social harmony.

Wolfgang Smith on the Refutation of Darwin. Smith's arguments against Darwin are spread across different books, so what follows is an amalgamation. In preparation for this review I listened to two debates involving William Dembski: one against a philosopher and other against a biologist. Dembski's demonstration of Specified Complexity⁹ is one of the foundational elements of intelligent design theory. We can't go into the maths here, but hope a simple illustration will help. Suppose you encountered a bullseye in the forest with some arrows in the centre. Of course, you would recognize the unlikeliness of that discovery since it is so different from the forest ambiance. The twigs on the ground, for example, are dispersed in random directions, unlike the specific formation of the arrows. It would be absurd to look for natural causes like wind, animals, etc., to explain such a structure in the forest. Dembski's accomplishment was to formalize such events in terms of information and probabilities. The higher the information content, the more likely there was design involved.

Now the philosopher and the biologist were not at all interested in Dembski's equations. They focused solely on the identity of the designer. Working backwards, their assumption of the non-existence of a designer disproved Dembski a priori. The philosopher, for example, went on and on about an "old man in the sky", showing an absurd level of ignorance for a degreed scholar. The biologist, moreover, claimed that evolution has been fully "established", so it would be pointless to refute it.

The Wikipedia article on pseudoscience¹⁰ identifies two of its qualities, which apply to both opponents. You can make your own judgment about which is pseudoscience. These are:

⁹https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Specified_complexity

¹⁰<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pseudoscience>

- Having an agenda apart from pure science
- Relying solely on confirmation rather than falsifiability

Is Darwinism falsifiable? Well, Darwin himself pointed out some objections that would falsify his theory. Smith focuses on three.

- **Transformism:** Darwin conceded that gaps in the fossil record would falsify evolutionism. Certainly, there are gaps in the fossil record. There are arguments to explain this away, whether by denial or by postulating sudden and large changes in evolution, rather than the small accumulations assumed by Darwin. Smith relies on *The Transformist Illusion* by **Douglas Dewar** for his argument.
- **Irreducible Complexity:** Again, Darwin conceded Irreducible Complexity¹¹ would be a refutation. The biologist **Michael Behe** has provided examples of irreducibly complex biological features. He means that the features require multiple parts that work together in harmony, so that no single system component could have evolved on its own.
- **Complex Specified Information:** We described this above. Information cannot be created through random processes. Without design, all the information today would have to have existed at the so-called Big Bang, otherwise we would just see random processes. Since information is the opposite to entropy, and entropy is increasing, there would have been zero entropy at the beginning. Natural selection cannot by itself create information, unless perhaps Nature is quite different from how we conceive it now. This is the position of Thomas Nagel which we reviewed recently¹².

¹¹https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Irreducible_complexity

¹²See Section 11.6 in this book.

Vertical Causation One of the objections to Intelligent Design is that the nature of design is left open. Actually, that is proper for a strictly scientific theory. Intelligent design does not deny that evolution has actually occurred, so it does not deny common descent. Smith, however, will deny it since it occurs in time.

The nature of design requires a metaphysical theory. I had brought this up years ago during an on-line discussion with a philosopher¹³. Smith brings up the notion of Vertical Causation to explain design. This is in opposition to scientific materialists who can only conceive of Horizontal Causation, and even naïve religious believers who are not so different. They understand, by Intelligent Design, that a god interferes from time to time in the world process.

Vertical causation, in Smith's description, on the contrary is "atemporal", i.e., above the flow of time of the world process. He quotes St Augustine that time itself was created along with the world. Besides God, there are two modes of secondary causation:

- The causality emanating from the angelic realm
- Action derived from human intelligence

To put it succinctly, natural causes are "blind" whereas vertical causation is the "hallmark of intelligence".

It is the prerogative of an intellectual nature, a being endowed with intellect and free will.

Smith claims that intelligence and creativity are not temporal processes (although they may manifest in time). Thought, however, does take place in time as a psychosomatic process. However, thought is just the means; cognition itself is beyond thought. That can be difficult to see. Even

¹³See Section 11.4 in this book.

those trained in monitoring their thoughts seem to miss that cognitive moment. It is like a stroke of insight because

We cannot know bit by bit, because to know is necessarily to know one thing.

Human creativity is allied to God's creative act, Smith says. The human artist works through a word conceived in his intellect, in imitation of the Holy Trinity.

Smith refers to the physicist **Roger Penrose** who showed in the Emperor's New Mind that Gödel's theorem refuted the idea that the human mind is like a computer algorithm. That is because it can know things are true despite not being able — in principle — to demonstrate them logically. This is beginning to gain some traction as in *Your Brain does not Process Information and it is not a Computer*¹⁴. However, this article is lacking the proper metaphysical tools for a deeper understanding.

Unexpected Allies Wolfgang Smith identifies three factors to consider:

1. **Chance.** Random mutations
2. **Necessity.** Physical and biochemical laws
3. **Natural Selection or Intelligent Design.** The selection agent.

To sum up, Smith shows how Darwinism is refuted on its own terms. Yet, even if you reject that refutation as do the Mad Men, those complacent consumers of ideas in the marketplace need to consider that intelligence, creativity, and free will cannot possibly be the result of natural processes.

¹⁴<https://aeon.co/essays/your-brain-does-not-process-information-and-it-is-not-a-computer>

So we can accept factors (1) and (2), so how does the Mad Man prefer Natural Selection to Intelligent Design? Basically, Natural Selection makes sense only on the assumption that there are only natural and physical causes. Even granting that, chance and time alone can cause nothing.

So does Natural Selection refute Intelligent Design or is it just one possible, still unproven possible explanation? Oddly enough, the idea of Intelligent Design is hard to shake, even for hardnosed scientists. We recently described the panel discussion on whether our universe is really a computer simulation.¹⁵ The entrepreneur Elon Musk holds to the same view.¹⁶

Obviously, if we are living in a computer simulation, then our whole world is designed. Fundamentally, if we could prove that evolution by natural selection is true, then any such design would be ruled out a priori. There is more. Richard Dawkins himself believes in the alien design theory¹⁷. Well which is it? Does Natural Selection refute Design or is Design still a possibility? These bright men and women would clearly fail that test about being the smartest American.

Excursus on Meaning Here is an example to try to make some concepts clear.

How did ears get their start? Any piece of skin can detect vibrations if they come in contact with vibrating objects. This is a natural outgrowth of the sense of touch. Natural selection could easily have enhanced this faculty by gradual degrees until it was sensitive enough to pick up very slight contact vibrations. At this point it

¹⁵See Section 11.9 in this book.

¹⁶<http://www.independent.co.uk/life-style/gadgets-and-tech/news/elon-musk-ai-artificial-intelligence-computer-simulation-gaming-virtual-reality-a7060941.html>

¹⁷<http://www.theoligarch.com/richard-dawkins-aliens.htm>

would automatically have been sensitive enough to pick up airborne vibrations of sufficient loudness and/or sufficient nearness of origin”

RICHARD DAWKINS, *The Blind Watchmaker*

This is clearly rank speculation, starting with the question of how the sense of touch “evolved” for the skin to detect vibrations. A scientific explanation needs a basis in physical reality. Specifically, the missing link is the DNA that accounts for the ear and how it altered over time.

Yet there is a deeper objection that is hard to grasp for many people. It is that we hear “meanings” not just sounds. It is easy to prove for yourself: how do you “hear” your native language vs how you experience an unknown foreign language.

Posted on 2016-06-09 by Cologero

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Max on 2016-06-13 at 15:35 said:

Or, more on topic, attempt to locate the “missing link” proving neo-darwinism in this map:
<http://biochemical-pathways.com/#/map/1>

I have been pondering how it comes that people fail to recognize intelligent design when looking at it. I assume that intelligence and intent is required for that. People who support themselves on others with no thought of contributing to any common good assumes that their means of existence just arose randomly causing no obligations on their part. Anyone who has tried to create something should be able to see the signs of something created.

Different people sees different things. Now, if only it were so easy as allowing everyone to live in their own private dreamworld. A problem that arises however, is that we also act on false beliefs and thereby risks ruining it for everyone else.

If someone believes that they live in a random hell without purpose, and is then informed that that is not the case, but on the contrary everything is beautifully thought out and ordered with the best of intentions, would it not be a cause of joy?

Cologero on 2016-06-15 at 07:30 said:

Max, it gets worse when even man-created events are seen as random, without design or purpose. For example, in the USA, we hear talk about the “demographic change”, as though it were some natural event. Whether the change is good or bad is a separate issue. Either the change was deliberately planned or it could have been foreseen as the inevitable consequence of certain policies.

Musings and Sparse Notes

13.1 Absurdity in Discussion

The most difficult thing of all is to believe in truth because it is true; i.e., because it demands humble recognition and self-abnegation; it is far easier to accept truth as my opinion which I posit as truth.

SERGIUS BULGAKOV

Man comes from God; sin from man; ignorance and error, like pain and death, from sin; fallibility from ignorance; and from fallibility, absurdity in discussion.

DONOSO CORTES

In contrast to the authentic man who is open to the unconcealment of Being or Truth, **Martin Heidegger** in his *Being and Time* described the inauthentic man as one immersed in the everyday, and whose consciousness is subject to the “They”, that is, the undifferentiated mass. The primary means of this is idle chit chat (*Gerede*).

Instead of discourse as the means to communicate truth, gain understanding, or share factual knowledge, in idle chatter, it becomes, instead, the means to form alliances, cement friendships, and create a sort of tribal consensus. Hoary arguments, long ago discredited, are repeated as new revelations and historical inaccuracies or misconceptions are believed with passionate conviction. The Internet does much to enable this on a wider scale, hence, we witness new web sites cropping boasting of their presentation of divergent points of view and the “lively” discussions which then ensue. Rather than leading to an openness to Truth, such discussion enclose one in a web of words and opinions. One takes comfort in the verbal support of fellow tribesmen and fantasizes about the *bon mot* that will intellectually crush his opponent.

Anyone with a longtime interest in Chess knows that the opening moves are all predictable. Most are fruitless and will lead to quick defeat. The good openings, and all their variations, are typically memorized by a chess master, even up to 15 to 20 moves. Only at that point can the game get interesting. The same applies to Internet discussions. Most arrive stillborn at the first sentence. The arguments that have some potential only make it to the first or second stage of argument and counter-argument, before reaching the point of incommunicability. Should those who know many more stages in the syllogism attempt to participate, they are drowned out and misunderstood, and, like Sisyphus, are forever condemned to start again at the beginning.

Ultimately, the problem is that the rational mind is incapable of reaching first principles, since its function is evaluation and judging—for that, it requires raw material to process and mediate. First principles can only come from something higher—the intellect, or *nous*, wherein lies the opening for the unconcealment of truth so that it can be directly perceived.

Posted on 2010-04-03 by Cologero

* * *

GFJF on 2010-04-03 at 23:36 said:

I'm starting to see what you mean about not being partisan. There's traditionalism, and then there's Tradition. The discussion recently sparked by Stephen McNallen's article is a case in point. Some people have left some curious comments which seem inexplicable unless they were fired by an anti-Christian animus.

13.2 A Morality of Asceticism and Action

In a continual effort to show what well-bred men used to think was normal and healthy, I will share the thoughts of a 19th century Frenchman who was still attached to that tradition. Unlike those who think they discovered sliced bread for the first time a few weeks ago, we accept that there is nothing new under the sun. Although **Rene Guenon** offers an interesting way of presenting and relating certain ideas, there is nothing new. Anyone who believes that following a higher path “atrophies” any part of himself has wildly misunderstood the writings; rather it makes life better, your mind is freed from inner turmoil, your work becomes creative play.

Although action follows thought, practice precedes theory. Without spiritual practice and the development of the proper inner attitude, the intellectual part of Tradition cannot be understood. Actually, practice is mandatory and theory is optional, although most men believe the opposite.

Abbé Henri de Tourville¹ was born in Paris in 1842 and died at the Castle of Tourville in 1903. Some of his letters were collected in the small volume under the title *Letters of Direction*. What follows are some extracts on topics that have come up recently.

¹https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Henri_de_Tourville

On Present Times and Complaining about them

These present times are really not at all bad though some old-fashioned ideas are apt to make us see the progress of the world as if everything were upside down.

Most good and even saintly people have the bad habit of incessantly lamenting inwardly over everything under the sun. I do not know of what Paradise on earth they can have dreamt, the remembrance of which makes them despair, for such a Paradise certainly does not exist.

Germinating in Secret

Here in this world we make many generous and intelligent attempts, yet to all appearance they are usually unsuccessful. At any rate their successes are small in proportion to their cost. Yet in reality the results for which they pave the way are enormous. Look for instance at the Roman Empire becoming entirely Christian on the very morrow of the most cruel persecutions; and this because everywhere *the seeds had been germinating in secret*.

Qualifying for the Struggle

It is not right to groan over the state of the world as if it were lost. What is actually happening is a clash between the old spirit and the new, a clash which is especially noticeable because the old spirit is realising how old it is and how nothing is looked at any longer from its point of view.

Most people are like sheep and follow, without much satisfaction to themselves, the lines of past tradition. A very small minority emerges, with great hesitation and amidst endless discussion to be faced by troublesome and pressing contradictions. *It is however of the minority that you must be, when God has put you there by interior vocation and natural aptitude.*

The World is Speeding Up

All human institutions will in the future show less and less vitality and flexibility. In any case they generally develop on quite different lines from those originally intended. History, when we come to study it, is full of such instances. But it is more especially true of the new and indeterminate world of the future, in which the speeding up of everything makes human calculations over long periods impossible.

The Forerunners

In every age God has scattered forerunners in the world. They are those who are ahead of their time and whose personal action is based on an inward knowledge of that which is to come. If you and I should happen to be forerunners, let us bless God for it, even though, living a century or two too soon, we may feel ourselves to be strangers in a foreign land.

Spiritual Independence

Be content with training yourself in spiritual independence and let all your personal conduct be in keeping with such independence. This is the really essential point. Do not be surprised if you do not win others over to your way of thinking. Those in whom any new truth is born have always to carry it for a long time in solitude.

Rejoice then in the light which you have been given and do not be surprised that it is so difficult to pass it on to others. It really is making its way, not so much through you or me as through force of circumstance. You are simply ahead of your time; it is a good thing to have long sight and to let your soul be illumined as soon as you are aware of the light.

On Being Yourself

God is working on you in order that you may no longer be a child, tossed about by every wind, a prey to external influences. He has given you your own grace, you won nature (insofar as it is good), your own distinctive character. You are therefore required to be yourself and not anyone else.

Live according to your own nature; inwardly without restriction; outwardly insofar as external conditions permit. I would compare you to a sailor he has not doubts as to the port for which he is making and if he is obliged to tack, it is in order to make his port. It is not that he has changed his mind; on the contrary, he makes of the changing winds in order that their very changeableness may bring him to his port.

A Divine Power Has Descended On a different tack, and as a forerunner, there is **Seneca's** 41st letter to Lucillius, written during the decadent time of Nero. He describes a man capable of transcending the times he lives in, a period of brutalization and licentiousness.

We push one another into vice. And how can a man be recalled to salvation, when he has no one to retrain him and all mankind to urge him on?

If you see a man who is unterrified in the midst of dangers, untouched by desires, happy in adversity, peaceful amid the storm, who looks down upon men from a higher plane and view the gods on a footing of equality, will not a feeling of reverence for him steal over you? Will you not say:

“This quality is too great and too lofty to be regarded as resembling this petty body in which it dwells. *A divine power has descended upon that man.*”

When a soul rises superior to other souls, when it is under control, when it passes through every experience as if it were of

small account, when it smiles at our fears and at our prayers, it is stirred by a force from heaven. A thing like this cannot stand upright unless it be propped by the divine.

Therefore, a greater part of it abides in that place from whence it came down to earth. Just as the rays of the sun do indeed touch the earth but still abide at the source from which they are sent, even so the great and hallowed soul, which has come down in order that we may have a nearer knowledge of divinity, does indeed associate with us, but still cleaves to its origin; on that source it depends, thither it turns its gaze and strives to go, and it concerns itself with our doings only as a being superior to ourselves.

Ascetic Morality and a Morality of Action Carl Jung regards such an attitude as the harbinger of things to come, a leavening agent, as it were. The ancients held to the idea of a mediator in whose name new ways of love would be opened. That idea became a fact in Christianity, so that human society took an immense stride forward.

This was not the result of any speculative, sophisticated philosophy, both of an elementary need in the great masses of humanity vegetating in spiritual darkness. They were evidently driven to it by the profoundest inner necessities, for humanity does not thrive in a state of licentiousness.

Interestingly, Jung claims that **Christianity** and **Mithraism** have the same meaning: the moral subjugation of the animal instincts. Mithras was the Logos emanated by God. Thus those who see some wide gulf between those two spiritual movements probably understand neither. That is because men today no longer understand the inner reasons for their rise. Perhaps these final words from Jung will awaken something within to recreate a tradition to follow.

Both religions i.e., Christianity and Mithraism teach a distinctly ascetic morality and a morality of action. The latter is particularly

true of Mithraism. Cumont says that Mithraism owed its success to the value of its morality which above all things favoured action. The followers of Mithras formed a sacred army in the fight against evil and among them were *virgines* (nuns) and *continentes* (ascetics).

Posted on 2013-10-15 by Cologero

* * *

X on 2013-10-16 at 00:44 said:

"What is actually happening is a clash between the old spirit and the new, a clash which is especially noticeable because the old spirit is realising how old it is and how nothing is looked at any longer from its point of view."

The true newest spirit is older than the oldest. "Before Abraham Was, I Am."

Thorsten on 2013-10-16 at 11:13 said:

Excellent advice. De Tourville's style hearkens back to Marcus Aurelius but is markedly more upbeat. Mithraism is certainly inspirational in many regards and Evola's pamphlet on the subject was eye-opening if a bit redundant. To me it seems increasingly clear that a new Western religion would do well to integrate Platonic metaphysics as has been suggested, with the use of Indo-European beast-slaying motifs as seen in Mithraism, the Volsunga Saga, medieval legends of Saint Michael and St. George. etc. If society does undergo some drastic simplifications in the near future such a cult of heroes would be very apt methinks.

Jacob on 2013-10-16 at 13:33 said:

Great post.

I dropped Jung after reading that he was untraditional, but I'm going to try reading him with a different eye after some of your recent comments.

scardanelli on 2013-10-16 at 14:33 said:

@ Thorsten, I think that maybe it's not about the beast slaying motif itself, but the truth behind the myth- "the moral subjugation of the animal instincts." If we couple this truth with Platonic metaphysics, then this "religion of the future" begins to sound strangely like Christianity.

"Unlike those who think they discovered sliced bread for the first time a few weeks ago, we accept that there is nothing new under the sun."

Thorsten on 2013-10-16 at 15:46 said:

I'm working on understanding the Gospel in a different way, particularly the crucifixion, as something other than a glorification of pious victimhood, but it's a struggle. I understand that in the Middle Ages the story was adjusted to be more palatable to the martial character of northern barbarians and that the "Christianity" of the Middle Ages was less "world-denying" than its original form as a result. I also understand that medieval Christianity was compatible with tradition. However it is a bit odd that the more integrally compatible it became with tradition the further it moved away from its origin as a martyr myth, that it to say the more Indo-European it became. (Hellenized in terms of metaphysics, Romanized in terms of institutional organization and its enmeshing with the symbolism of empire, Germanized and Celticized in terms of chivalry and feudal ethos.)

So if we recognize this phase of "Christianity" as the height of its glory and accordingly agree that this is the phase that is most worth of emulation (precisely the period during which it had the least to do with victimhood and passivity) and integration into a new religion (should that ever be feasible or deemed desirable by a sufficient number of the elite) why maintain the focus on Christ (no matter how nominal)? The crucifixion seems to be not only the most inessential part of the best of what we call "Christianity" or the civilization of "Christendom", but has also been used with great efficacy by the forces of modernity to undermine the traditional values of that era.

So of course the "religion of the future" that I indicated as a possibility would sound strangely like Christianity (of the middle ages) but with the essential difference that it would be rectified by cutting loose the baggage of a myth that is less than optimal for the spiritual development of European man. The archetype of the triumphant hero or dragonslayer leaves no room for alternative interpretations. The myths which communicate clear cut, unambiguous mastery over oneself and the animal instincts cannot be subverted to the advantage of the Shudra.

Santiago on 2013-10-16 at 16:15 said:

@Thorsten,

The point of the cross is that it's true. There is a cross to bear in our life, and we will not overcome it unless we embrace it. Thusly the Dionysian dismemberment brings forth wine, and the Odinic hanging reveals the runes.

"What you resist, persists" as Jung put it, therefore "resist not evil" (Mt 5:39).

Michael on 2013-10-16 at 18:59 said:

@ Thorsten. The Christian myth from an exoteric perspective is that the Divine King entered into the territory of his enemy complete disarmed, faced the full onslaught of the enemy, and

overcame. The King's followers are also engaged in the cosmic battle, but the battle is spiritual, not physical.

An important component of the myth that Evola fails to note is that the King returns at the end of time in glory. All his enemies are put below his feet and he rules with a rod of iron.

If one leaves out the kingly ministry of Christ, then it is no longer Christianity.

13.3 Rousseau's Third Solitary Walk

"Growing older, I learn all the time." Solon often repeated this line in his old age. In a sense I could say the same, but the knowledge that the experience of twenty years has brought me is a poor thing, and even ignorance would be preferable. No doubt adversity is a great teacher, but its lessons are dearly bought, and often the profit we gain from them is not worth the price they cost us. What is more, these lessons come so late in the day that by the time we master them they are of no use to us. Youth is the time to study wisdom, age the time to practice it. Experience is always instructive, I admit, but it is only useful in the time we have left to live. When death is already at the door, is it worth learning how we should have lived?

JEAN-JACQUES ROUSSEAU

Toward the end of his life, **Jean-Jacques Rousseau** published a series of ten meditations published as *Reveries of the Solitary Walker*. Aside from his outbursts of paranoia, megalomania, and bitterness, they are instructive in the exploration of the spontaneous flow of thoughts. Like Heidegger, Rousseau walked in the woods. Julius Evola and Guido De Giorgio preferred the mountains. I walk on the beach with the same effect. My doctor wants me to do more of a "power walk", but that would be forcing myself into an external standard and it would impede the free flow of ideas.

First, we must consider what it means to be “solitary”. Despite his writings on the social contract and the “general will”, in the end he becomes a solitary, and we are left to wonder how such a one fits into conventional society. **Rene Guenon** was also a solitary contemplative; he wrote about Tradition and the hierarchical organization of a traditional society, but, for him, he allowed himself to pick and choose which Tradition to adhere to. His recommendation was that a man should follow the dominant Tradition of his city. Although not at all like the revolutionaries who flout every social convention, there is still a certain uneasiness about that. The fundamental question revolves around which traditions are natural and organic versus those that are merely conventional, appropriate only for a certain time and place.

The best way to read Rousseau’s reveries is to regard them as a struggle to understand certain esoteric ideas without proper training or doctrine to follow. He recognizes the need for renunciation, not only for worldly vanities, but also for arbitrary opinions in his mind that may have arisen from emotional needs. He recognizes a cosmic moral law, despite how some interpret his earlier philosophical efforts. But most important is the process of “letting go”, *gelassenheit*, allowing thoughts to arise without controlling them. Ultimately, one must learn to live by one’s intuition, as though every event is directed from a transcendent source. For complete liberation, the egoic idea that I am a “thinker” and a “doer”, must be released in favour of a “letting be”.

The Art of Dying These are things you need to start thinking about while you are young. The answers you come up with determine how you should live, but an old man needs to be more concerned about how he should die. Rousseau continues:

We enter the race when we are born and we leave it when we die. Why learn to drive your chariot better when you are close to the finishing post? All you have to consider then is how to make your

exit. If an old man has something to learn, it is the art of dying, and this is precisely what occupies people least at my age; we think of anything rather than that. Old men are all more attached to life than children, and they leave it with a worse grace than the young. This is because all their labours have had this life in view, and at the end they see that it has all been in vain. When they go, they leave everything behind, all their concerns, all their goods, and the fruits of all their tireless endeavours. They have not thought to acquire anything during their lives that they could take with them when they die.

Saints live in the vivid awareness of their necessary death. So, too, do warriors, for whom any day of battle may be their last. Living in an area populated with retirees, I see daily what Rousseau noted. There is an obsession with being “youthful”, and they live as though the times of their youth are eternal. Recently, a college buddy called and asked me if I had seen some TV special about the Beatles. Aside from the metaphysical question of whether they were really the “Beatles” if half the original members were missing, I had no interest in the TV special. But that is not unusual, most “boomers” hold the same worldview and listen to the same music as though they were still 19 years old.

A sexagenarian told me that going for a hot air balloon ride was on her “bucket list”, i.e., things she wanted to do before she died. My desire is to become free of mortal sin; she is much more sanguine about achieving her goal than I am.

Philosophers for Young Men I don’t understand the fascination with Nietzsche in some circles. He was a beta male, a “flop with chicks”. There is the famous story of his unrequited love, but, unlike a Dante, he derived no inspiration from it. It is curious that he is becoming popular among women, which is his fate despite his opinions of them. Apparently, they don’t believe that Nietzsche was referring to them, although

he actually was.

Nietzsche adapted Schopenhauer's philosophy by flattening it out and naturalizing it. Schopenhauer and Rousseau, despite their flaws, are more suitable for young men. They actually lived a life, filled with love and strife, and it shows up in their philosophizing. Moreover, they were brilliant stylists. Unfortunately, I do not know German well enough to read Schopenhauer in the original, but Rousseau's French is mesmerizing. Schopenhauer recognized kindred spirits in the rishis of the Upanishads, in the Buddha, and in the Neoplatonic mysticism of the Church Fathers. His philosophical system would be true only if the Noumenon, or the Will, was not a Subject, not an "I" or if the Father did not beget the Logos. But we will get back to that soon in an explication of Solovyov's metaphysics.

Exoteric Philosophy Rousseau understood that philosophy needed to arise from lived experience. Perhaps if he had been exposed to an esoteric tradition, he would have had better grounding for his own intellectual development. Nevertheless, it is instructive to see his own struggles with this idea.

Thrown into the whirlpool of life while still a child, I learned from early experience that I was not made for this world, and that in it I would never attain the state to which my heart aspired. Ceasing therefore to seek among men the happiness which I felt I could never find there, my ardent imagination learned to leap over the boundaries of a life which was as yet hardly begun. ... This desire has at all time led me to seek after the nature and purpose of my being with greater interest and determination than I have seen in anyone else. I have met many men who were more learned in their philosophizing, but their philosophy remained as it were external to them. ... They studied human nature in order to speak knowledgeably about it, not in order to know themselves; their

efforts were directed to the instruction of others and not to their own inner enlightenment.

This is certainly the way of academics who aspire to erudition. There was an instructive example in the comments recently about someone and his interlocutors who criticized Tradition on the grounds that it left out the “saving grace of Christ”. They are forgetting, of course, that no one can quite agree on how that works. On the other hand, the esoteric understanding is precise: by calming the perturbations of the soul, the spirit can impregnate the mind and give birth to the Logos. That makes no sense from the exoteric point of view because it cannot be discussed by the discursive mind.

Fruits of Meditation Although Rousseau abandoned Catholicism for Calvinism, the style of meditation he practiced seems to derive from that spiritual movement that came to be called “quietism.”

The rural solitude in which I spent the best days of my youth, and the reading of good books which completely absorbed me, strengthened my naturally affectionate tendencies in her Madame de Warens company and led me to an almost **Fenelon**-like devotion. Lonely meditation, the study of nature and the contemplation of the universe lead the solitary to aspire continually to the maker of all things and to seek with a pleasing disquiet for the purpose of all he sees and the cause of all he feels. When my destiny cast me back into the torrent of this world I found nothing there which could satisfy my heart for a single moment.

Yet, up until the age of forty, he found himself “living at random with no rational principles.” At that point, he gave up many of the vanities that had been important to him. He also spontaneously discovered the necessity for the First Trial:

I did not confine my reformation to outward things. Indeed I became aware that this change called for a revision of my opinions, which although undoubtedly more painful was also more necessary ... A great change which had recently come over me, a new moral vision of the world which had opened before me, the foolish judgments of men, whose absurdity I was beginning to sense without foreseeing how I was to fall victim to them.

Just as happens to many today, in his time Rousseau was shaken by "*certain modern philosophers who had little in common with the philosophers of antiquity.*" He called them the "*missionaries of atheism, these overbearing dogmatists, who could not patiently endure that anyone should think differently from them on any subject whatsoever.*"

Budding esoterists and Hermetists should be careful about engaging in debate with those types of closed minded men. Until your understanding becomes firm and settled, they can do nothing for you except cause you doubt and uncertainty.

The Tendency to Self-Deception When clearing the mind of all opinions, there is the danger of self-deception. Reason is often helpless in the face of strong desires. Rousseau writes:

It is hard to prevent oneself from believing what one so keenly desires, and who can doubt that the interest we have in admitting or denying the reality of the Judgment to come determines the faith of most men in accordance with their hopes and fears. All this may have led my reason astray ... But what I feared most was to endanger the eternal fate of my soul for the sake of those worldly pleasures which have never seemed very precious to me.

Ultimately, he claimed, he succeeded in freeing up his mind and was able to resist specious arguments and insoluble objections. He wrote:

In this untroubled state of mind I find not only self-contentment, but the hope and consolation which my situation requires. A solitude so complete, so permanent and in itself so melancholy, the ever-present and constantly active animosity of all the present generation, the humiliations which they constantly heap on me, all this inevitably depresses me from time to time; uncertainty and worrying doubts still return occasionally to trouble my soul and fill it with gloom. Then I feel the need to recall my former conclusions ... Thus I reject all new ideas as fatal errors which have only a specious appearance of truth and are only fit to disturb my peace of mind.

Leaving Life Finally, Rousseau admits that it is the virtuous life that matters and not the attraction to the glamour of the world. He concludes this meditation:

Patience, kindness, resignation, integrity and impartial justice are goods that we can take with us and that we can accumulate continually without fear that death itself can rob us of their value. It is to this one useful study that I devote what remains of my old age. And I shall be happy if by my own self-improvement I learn to leave life, not better, for that is impossible, but more virtuous than when I entered it.

Posted on 2014-03-10 by Cologero

* * *

JA on 2014-03-11 at 11:41 said:

I think Nietzsche is beloved of the ADD generation in part because his style is to make his points in self contained brief aphorisms that – in comparison to Schopenhauer, for example, are quite easy to read in one sitting.

White ole mad Freddy was indeed a failure with chicks, I doubt any man who followed a traditional life style to the letter would be a master of the boudoir... ..remember that Crowley seduced Coomaraswamy's wife... ..the black is more seductive than the white... ..

Pickman on 2014-03-28 at 09:07 said:

"Patience, kindness, resignation, integrity and impartial justice are goods that we can take with us and that we can accumulate continually without fear that death itself can rob us of their value."

This wisdom is gold. I contemplate death and my departure all the time. Thanks for sharing. The longer we live we run the risk of accumulating baggage from our experiences with bad folk and degenerates. Unfortunately I wrestle with my daemons and scars in this case and wish to freed from lessons of harsh influences, ones that I can relate to Rousseau in this case. I was mean were these worth the cost at such late times beyond their use when we received them? I'm not so sure either. In any case I prefer to take a more than human transcendent Olympian approach, and this is what differentiates the Traditional man from mere petty worldly reactionaries of a heavy lower disposition.

Impulsive retards exist and we may become aware of their "contaminating presence" but let us keep true to ourselves above this foray. In better days a physical banishing of the wretched would have been possible.

Alas:

"The best revenge is to be unlike him who performed the injury."

"The object of life is not to be on the side of the majority, but to escape finding oneself in the ranks of the insane."

"Here is a rule to remember in future, when anything tempts you to feel bitter: not "This is misfortune," but "To bear this worthily is good fortune."

"You are a little soul carrying about a corpse, as Epictetus used to say."

– MAA, *Mediations* (one could pull endlessly from this philosophy).

In essence, I find it interesting to read the experiences of older men, as vitality and facilities wane and cynicism bites harder, how in elder years they prepare themselves for their passing (extreme unction). Additional years spent may not be healthy for a man so leaving beautified is important to ponder. Basically, why waste ones time with petty BS, aim for greatness.

"Just that you do the right thing. The rest doesn't matter. Cold or warm. Tired or well-rested. Despised or honored. Dying... or busy with other assignments. Because dying, too, is one of our assignments in life. There as well: "To do what needs doing." Look inward. Don't let the true nature of anything elude you. Before long, all existing things will be transformed, to rise like smoke (assuming all things become one), or be dispersed in fragments... to move from one unselfish act to another with God in mind. Only there, delight and stillness... when jarred, unavoidably, by circumstances, revert at once to yourself, and don't lose the rhythm more than you can help. You'll have a better grasp of the harmony if you keep going back to it."

– *ibid.*,

13.4 The Divided Line

A man can be himself only so long as he is alone; and if he does not love solitude, he will not love freedom; for it is only when he is alone that he is really free.

ARTHUR SCHOPENHAUER, *Essays and Aphorisms*

In the Republic, **Plato** describes four degrees of our apprehension of the world. From the highest to the lowest, there are:

1. **Intellection.** Grasping the Forms directly without the mediation of images or thoughts.
2. **Thought.** Our thoughts, ideas, discussions about the world.
3. **Belief:** Our opinions, including our knowledge of the world appearing to our senses.
4. **Imagery.** Created images of the world, fantasies.

These are part of a continuum, not hard divisions, so they represent different degrees of understanding.

The Decision

If ... the soul departs from the body polluted and impure, in that it always is with the body and cares for and loves it and is bewitched by it, by desires and pleasures, so that it opines that nothing else is true except the corporeal, which one can grasp and see and drink and eat and use for sexual enjoyment, but is accustomed to hate and fear and flee from that which is dark and invisible to the eyes but is intelligible and grasped by philosophy, do you think that a soul like this will depart pure, itself by itself?

PLATO

What is described is more commonly expressed as “Eat, drink, and be merry” (Wisdom 8:15). This temptation arises from the seeming injustices in the world and it despairs in finding wisdom. While one should be grateful for having nourishment and moments of joy, to make that the only goal of life is to pollute the soul for death.

Yet what is dark and invisible to the senses, is intelligible to the philosopher. The philosopher is intimate with the Good, more intimate than simply “seeing”. Plato describes it in terms of touching and nourishment, even erotic. The philosopher’s soul “touches” divine reality and “is nourished” by the true and the divine; she even “feasts on” true being.

Whether to live in the shadows or to live in the light is the fundamental choice. Yet, choosing the latter may take you on a lonely path.

Measure, Number, and Weight

Thou hast ordered all things in measure and number and weight.

WISDOM 11:20

Roger Penrose, who seems to be a natural Platonist, asserts in *The Large, the Small, and the Human Mind*, that “the entire physical world can, in principle, be described in terms of mathematics.” This is consistent with the notion that Mathematics is the dividing line between the world of ideas and the world of senses. Also, therefore, with the notion that the rational is real and the real is rational, at least insofar as it applies to physics. Hence, the physical world can be understood by the Intellect provided the mathematics is understood.

The Book of Wisdom asserts the same thing.

- Measure refers to the shape of things, i.e., to Geometry;

- Number to the count of things, i.e., to Arithmetic;
- Weight to the mass of things.

We now know that Matter, or mass, is also convertible to Energy and to Frequency, so all is accounted for in that Triad: gravity, force, Maxwell's equations, and so on.

In the *Phaedo*, Plato speaks with approval of Anaxagoras' idea that "the intellect is the orderer and cause of all things", even in we might prefer to ascribe it to the *Logos*. The cosmos must be good and beautiful, in that it is ordered by divine intelligence. That may be difficult sometimes to see, as the atheists are fond to point out.

Being and Privation To know something is to grasp the form behind the appearance. This is not dualism, since the form and the appearance are one. Actually, there cannot be anything without a form, or structure. But if forms are perfect, eternal, and unchanging, it would seem that things should also be perfect, eternal, and unchanging. Yet in the world, things do change and they are far from perfect.

I believe that Aristotle was trying to address this issue. If the forms are timeless and perfect, then why are not the instances of the forms perfect and unchanging? Aristotle points out that since things change, those things cannot fully embody the form. Rather there is something "left over", a surd, a lack, which he calls "privation". Hence things are a mix of the form (being) and privation (non-being). The rest follows from that initial observation.

However, in practice, it can be difficult to determine a thing's form. That is because the form is confused with its privation, which is the anti-form. That is why it has no being, although it is part of the world of our experience.

So if the form does not appear, then privation will be its substitute in the mind, even though it is the shadow, the doppelganger, or egregore of

the thing. For physical objects, there may be less of a problem, but when the abstract things like political groupings, religions, families, etc., and even individual persona are mistaken for their shadows, confusion and even enmity arises. These are often accompanied with strong passions.

The Good Reality, as intelligible, consists of the forms that are revealed in things. The “Good”, then, cannot be one of those forms that exists alongside other forms, hence it is beyond reality or Being. Things that are unified are Good. That is why things with privation will lack goodness. In particular, insofar as the human being is not unified within, he is not fully good. Our everyday experience should convince us that people are inconsistent from day to day, even hour to hour. They don’t have a stable I or Self that unifies the disparate parts of the soul. The task then is to be made Whole, or Holy.

As for the totality of the world, perhaps God alone can grasp Reality in its completeness as a system of necessary relationships that plays out over time. Accept that on faith alone or strive to understand it.

Posted on 2020-05-03 by Cologero

13.5 Dialectics for Dummies

The dialectician is a kind of buffoon: one laughs at him, one does not take him seriously.

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE, *Twilight of the Idols*

The Enlightenment ideal of “Free Enquiry”, as opposed to the dogmatism of the Middle Ages, was supposed to bring in a new era of human freedom and knowledge. Rational minds would debate in the “market-place of ideas” and the world would flock to the best idea with the same enthusiasm as they might flock to the better mousetrap.

It has been remarkably effective in the physical realm, but a mixed blessing in the human realm. Instead of the proverbial “world peace”, free enquiry often has had a corrosive effect on societies by destroying their spiritual foundations without providing a more secure replacement.

Now that every conceivable idea has been discovered and analyzed, there is nowhere else to go. Discussions have deteriorated to kayfabe debates²; onlookers watch the debaters, cheering on their favorite personality with no regard to facts or reason.

Those more skillful in dialectics have memorized the arguments and counter-arguments several layers in, much like the way chess players memorize a dozen moves for each possible opening move. Only a few are capable of carrying on the debate beyond that point.

No consequential debate has ever been fully resolved. Yes, some may appear so for a season, but not for eternity.

Getting Paid At one time, I was considering becoming a corporate speaker. I had developed a local reputation as an interesting and compelling speaker so I wanted to take it to the next level. I therefore attended seminars at the Florida Speakers’ Association. They certainly did not teach me to develop excellence in dialectics and rational thinking. Here are the secrets that professional communicators revealed to me; keep them in mind if you aspire to attract 100K subscribers to your youtube account.

Stories Apart from mathematicians, no one remembers arguments. Stories, however stick in people’s minds well after the speech. The story may be funny, or better, it should arouse anger, contempt, or pity. Symbols can serve the same purpose.

²<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Kayfabe>

Hominess One speaker admitted that his speeches had become too polished, sophisticated, and perfectly delivered. He learned to deliberately put mistakes into his talks or stumble every now and then. In that way, he discovered, he was able to relate to his audience more effectively.

Comedy I vividly remember one very successful speaker at the Q&A session following his talk. A wanna-be asked him, “Does your talk need to be funny?”

He responded quickly, “Only if you want to be paid!”

Keep that in mind the next time you prepare a talk. I’ve learned that if you are too subtle, then many people cannot tell if you are being funny or serious.

Solemn Contest

Philosophy on the nature of Plato would define it more as an erotic competition as a training and internalization of the ancient agonistic gymnastics and their prerequisites... What finally grew out of this philosophical Plato’s erotic? A new art form of the Greek *agon* Greek: solemn contest, the dialectic.

NIETZSCHE

This is truer than you think. Rather than a disinterested search for truth through dialog, dialectics has become a new form of contest. Professional debaters, e.g., between a believer and an atheist, can earn five figure fees for their “debates”, whose results are known in advance. That is why Las Vegas never sets odds on such debates.

Joe Take Joe, for example, who was once a friend of mine on fb. He was a doctrinaire libertarian and a supercorrect Catholic, who was willing to take on anyone in a debate; he was sure to destroy his antagonist.

I never engaged him directly, but my Aikido style frustrated him so he unfriended me everywhere. I ran into him on another forum a year ago in which he announced that he had become, depressingly, a nihilist and no longer held any convictions. I suggested that he hold a mock debate between the two versions of himself. That is when he blocked me.

Richard Richard claims to have a very high IQ. He wrote that he wants to preface his posts with: “This is what I think, take me on!” He admits that he takes pleasure in provoking others with his arguments. Everyone wisely avoids a direct confrontation.

No Other Choice

One chooses dialectic only when one has no other means. One knows that one arouses mistrust with it, that it is not very persuasive. Nothing is easier to wipe than a dialectical effect: the experience of every meeting, where it speaks, is proof of that it can only be self-defense, in the hands of such as no longer have other weapons.

NIETZSCHE

The weak resort to dialectics whenever they lack real power. This tactic is used in political debates. The weaker side resorts to arguments and facts. They point out inconsistencies in their opponent’s policies; the clamor about the hypocrisy in their opponents’ behaviors. This is all for naught. If you want to win, you may have to push the issue, and let the other side resort to arguments. As Fat Tony says,

Suckers try to win arguments, nonsuckers try to win.

NICHOLAS TALEB

Conclusion Whenever I describe a jam that I'm in, my sister naively suggests, "Why don't you just say to him ... ", and you can fill in the blanks. Obviously, she has never had to deal with tough men. In such situations, there needs to be a carrot and a stick, even if only implicit and subtle. Only then can negotiations begin.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8wGS29G-gSs>

Posted on 2022-02-08 by Cologero

* * *

Balrog Booger on 2022-02-09 at 12:41 said:

The writer Vox Day is an interesting case study of this phenomenon. He tries to outline a explicit difference between rhetoric and dialectic, and he prides himself on being above and impervious to rhetoric. After experiencing many of the problems with formal debates, he now refuses them, but instead of maintaining a dignified aloofness from debate, he just calls anyone who contradicts him stupid on his blog. He also spends a lot of time calling out what he calls "gamma males" for behaving exactly how he does.

An example he just posted yesterday:

You're flat-out wrong, Curt Doolittle . And I'm a lot smarter than you are, so you really should think twice before trying to "correct" your intellectual superiors.

Not that he's all bad, by any means. I still frequently read his site, despite the silliness of his ego posting.

Santiago on 2022-02-09 at 19:41 said:

mfw when truth literally sustains your world but nobody cares

Heiko on 2022-02-10 at 04:29 said:

Oh yes, Vox Day and Curt Doolittle in one comment. I too once spent too much time engaging into such unfruitful discussions. If you change your approach to trying to understand the other side, asking questions etc. it has a way better effect on the other person and you yourself. Trying to answer the question, they might see how stupid their thoughts and arguments are.

13.6 Quantum Ship of Theseus

The identity of the Ship of Theseus³ has been a pseudo philosophical paradox for a couple of dozen centuries. Plutarch's version goes like this:



The ship in which Theseus and the youth of Athens returned from Crete had thirty oars and was preserved by the Athenians. They took away the old planks as they decayed and replaced them with new and stronger timber. This ship became a standing example among the philosophers, for the logical question of things that grow; one side holding that the ship remained the same, and the other contending that it was not the same.

This is not at all a paradox for the metaphysician. The Ship has no being because it has no unity in itself. Its unity is given to it by the builders. Hence, it is an object of thought and is called a ship by convention. In other words, there is no divine idea of the ship that allows it to be known.

A similar, and more compelling example, is a sports team. The Juventus football club in Turin, Italy was founded in 1897. Over the past 124 years it has undergone name changes, the owners have changed, the players changed, where they play matches has changed, and so on. Nevertheless, there is a continuity of thought that identifies the club as “Juventus” even though no material elements from 1897 still exist today.

Natural Things The Ship of Theseus and the Juventus F.C. are artifacts because they are human constructions. Natural things have unity within themselves and are not constructed. For example, I can give you instructions about how to build an artifact like a mousetrap. However, I cannot give you a blueprint to build a mouse. Even if you had all the elements and compounds and a detailed design document, you cannot

³https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ship_of_Theseus

create a mouse. You will have to grow a mouse. That is because a mouse has its own inner unity and is therefore real.

Human Beings The same applies a fortiori to human beings. A human being has a Self that gives it identity. Therefore, a human being is more than its material composition. It seems to me – at least I have not yet found a counterexample — that even the most ardent does not deny his own continuous identity over time. But what holds all the atoms together? After all, there is no physics of the human being. If you start at the Big Bang and you know quantum and relativity theory, you still cannot possibly derive the existence of human beings at some future date.

In the Many Worlds theory, at every moment a new copy of “you” appears in a different universe, who is your “counterpart”. But why do your body parts all hold together? If your identity lies in consciousness, does your counterpart share the same Self? Metaphysically, the Self cannot be in the same state twice. Specifically, if it is in the human state in one universe, it cannot possibly be in the human state as a counterpart in a different universe. It would have to be a different being in the second universe. However, it cannot be “built”, it must grow, and there is no time for that to happen.

Ideas of Things Aristotle had competing, but not necessarily incompatible, theories about the ideas of things. Plato believed that the ideas existed in the world of thought, independent of the world of the senses. Aristotle believed that the ideas inhere in the things. Both theories are objective in the sense that the ideas are independent of any physical manifestation.

The alternative is to believe that all ideas are human constructs. Hence, we call a thing a “mouse” because it has qualities similar to other mousy things. This theory is called “nominalism” because the ideas are only names, without independent and objective existence. This is unsatisfy-

ing because we like to believe that the classification of mousiness is objectively true. Otherwise, the standard model of physics, the periodic table of chemistry, and biological taxonomy would make no sense.

Quantum Darwinism The secret teaching of quantum theory is that there is no explanation for the existence of things in the world, i.e., things that we can see, touch, hear, etc. There is no explanation for stars. Do stars have their own unity or are they stars solely by convention? What then is a galaxy in terms of physics? The is the so-called measurement problem: to wit, if the world is just a grand quantum state, then how do individual things appear.

A recent theory is based on the concept of entanglement. In the simple case, it means that the quantum states of two entangled particles are not independent of each other. Moreover, entanglement can be extended to multiple particles so that entangled particles seem to act together as a unified being. In this view, then, a mouse is a collection of entangled particles that together create mousiness.

Assuming entanglement can involve such a large number of particles, it is worth exploring. But, like the Ship or Theseus, how does that explain the identity of a thing over time. A human being, for example, grows and changes, so that probably close to none of the particles of a human being at age 4 still exist at age 44. So how can one set of entangled particles be replaced by another set years later, while the human being maintains the same identity over time?

For more on the topic, check this out:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vSnq5Hs3_wI

Posted on 2022-03-20 by Cologero

* * *

De Bosit on 2022-03-21 at 03:40 said:

This was very hard to read and I got mad a couple of times.
Imo QM is dumb. God is an artist and reality is painted.

Adil on 2022-03-21 at 15:04 said:

“God is an artist and reality is painted.”

In the sense that experiential qualia are primary to objective and abstract quantities, yes. Experienced reality is real as it is, whereas the objective, physical world “in itself” is an abstraction. Per definition, no one can have access to it. Yet according to materialism, the abstraction (the “outside” world) is primary whereas sensory qualities are “secondary” and purely subjective. Hence, man has no inner life that is real (all ideas are pure constructs). No wonder this kind of backwards metaphysics produces nominalism and nihilism.

14.1 The Thinking Reed

The divine sleeps in the rock, breathes in the plant, dreams in the animal, and wakes in man.

OLD NORDIC ADAGE

Man is but a reed, the most feeble thing in nature; but he is a thinking reed. The entire universe need not arm itself to crush him. A vapour, a drop of water suffices to kill him. But, if the universe were to crush him, man would still be more noble than that which killed him, because he knows that he dies and the advantage which the universe has over him; the universe knows nothing of this. All our dignity consists, then, in thought. By it we must elevate ourselves, and not by space and time which we cannot fill. Let us endeavour, then, to think well; this is the principle of morality.

BLAISE PASCAL

The thinking vegetable The secret of life suddenly dawned on Schlegel and he claimed man should live like a vegetable. But which vegetable? Jesus said we should live like the lilies of the field. Blaise Pascal claimed we are more like slender reeds, yet thinking reeds. So just as lilies and tulips bless the earth with their beautiful flowers and scents, the thinking reed blesses the universe with beautiful, creative thoughts.

Non-dual clouds The sky, from which the sun shines, is the source of life for plants. Our thinking reed witnesses the clouds above, which from time to time blot out the sun in their arising and disappearing. In clouds we can see anything in imagination — whaling ships floating across the sky, angels dancing, all sorts of animals or birds, faces of the gods — which rearrange themselves in new configurations as large clouds break up or smaller clouds combine. We can construct a whole universe of discourse out of the movement of the clouds. Of course, the tulip will create a story different from the lily's. They may even argue over whose story is truer. Sadly, they may even forget that their real Source is the Sun that shines through the gaps in the clouds.

Posted on 2006-10-14 by Cologero

14.2 Free Will and the Laws of Physics

On a blog by a soi-disant reactionary, we read:

As for free will, a minute's thought will show that the notion of free will implies an abrogation of the laws of physics.

DENNIS MANGAN, 2009-08-01, blog is now defunct

Such an “abrogation” sounds pretty serious, so I thought about it a minute, pondering which particular law of physics would be abrogated.

First I thought of **Newton**, whose theories were considered to be “laws of physics” for more than a couple of hundred years. Unfortunately, his “laws” were definitively refuted by Einstein, so Newton’s theory turned out not to be a law, but is instead a brilliantly conceived, albeit false, recreation of physics.

So, perhaps he means the **Theory of Relativity**. Can that theory predict whether I’ll choose pistachio or strawberry ice cream next Sunday? Well, according to that theory, every body follows a “world line” in space-time, so presumably a physicist could compute my world line and predict which flavour I will choose. But another minute’s thought will convince you that what we have is not a “law of physics”, but rather a hypothesis that demands empirical testing. So far, at any rate, no one has computed my world-line, indeed, no one has even proposed how that could possibly be done. Hence, until there is an experiment that can be tested, it is premature to consider it a law of physics. Furthermore, another minute’s reflection will open up this question: am “I” truly a material body subject to laws of physics? Yes, I certainly have a material body, but does that exhaust who or what I am? It appears that the laws of physics simply assume I am nothing but a material object, rather than prove it. Therefore, it cannot be the Theory of Relativity.

Perhaps, then, he means **Quantum Theory**, which, for example, can predict the distribution of electrons passing through a slit, although it cannot predict the course of any particular electron. Presumably, then, quantum physics can predict what percentage of pistachio or strawberry ice cream I’ll choose over the course of the year, but not what I’ll choose on any given Sunday.

But I can do a similar thing. For example, I can produce a very accurate chart of the probability distribution of the next million throws of the dice at a casino, although I cannot tell you what the next throw will be with any certainty. Yet, alas, I can do that without invoking any laws of physics at all. In particular, I don’t need to know anything about the me-

chanics of the motion of the dice—it is simply a matter of mathematics, not physics.

So more than a minute's reflection opens up the following questions:

1. Why should we suppose there are “laws of physics”?
2. Does physics account for the totality of reality?
3. Is a scientific law anything other than a clever creation of the human mind?

Posted on 2009-09-30 by Cologero

14.3 Traditional and Profane Science

Time is the moving image of eternity.

PLATO, *Timaeus*

Metaphysics begins where physics, that is, the study of nature, ends. We pointed out where physics, or science ends¹, so now let us draw the metaphysical conclusions.

Energy Taken to its extreme, in Schroedinger's model, matter consists ultimately of undifferentiated energy which takes on a concrete forms only when observed. This is strikingly similar to the notion of *Prakriti*, which Guenon describes as “undifferentiated primordial substance” in *Man and his Becoming*. *Prakriti*, as undifferentiated, comprises all forms in potential, yet cannot in itself produce or cause anything; metaphysically, then, *Purusha* (spirit, consciousness) is what produces form. While

¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=1303%22>

Quantum Theory cannot prove metaphysical principles, there is an analogy and consistency.

Purusha is also related to the Will, corresponding to the Hermetic principle² “Energy is concentrated Will”. Secular science seeks to effect material change by manipulation of energy.

Traditional science is based on the power of visualization and the strengthening of the Will.

Evolution Secular thought means two distinct things by “evolution”, which on the surface seem to be inconsistent, yet really have the same presupposition. Biological theories assume evolution moves by random variation; nevertheless, there seems to be a “direction” to evolution, a “tree of life”, that leads from less to more differentiation. However, were it truly random, there should be evidence of species evolving backwards. There should be examples of frogs returning to the sea, or isolated human groups becoming more ape-like.

In the social sense, “to evolve” means to become a conscious agent of some historic progression which is inevitable, not random, although some seem to evolve and some don’t. The similarity of both positions is that “the higher arises from the lower”, a metaphysical absurdity. Thus social evolutionists necessarily support an increase in animality and a decrease in differentiation. Metaphysically, this is really a regression to *Prakriti* without *Purusha*, a goal that is ultimately unrealizable and hence presents a natural barrier to the complete fulfillment of the idea of “progress”.

In Tradition, “to e-volve” is understood in its etymological sense as an unfolding, that is, the unfolding in time of an eternal idea.

A Traditional science of evolution focuses on the understanding of metaphysical doctrines³ and how they manifest in time.

²<https://gornahoor.net/?p=292>

³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=823>

Unconscious Instead of leading to the freedom and emotional health of man, the probing of the unconscious by profane psychology has led to more powerful and effective methods to control his thoughts and behavior. Traditional science similarly recognizes a vital center in man which is likewise unconscious, because it is the subject of consciousness and cannot be its object. This center is transcendent and noumenal, or unknowable to profane science.

There are numerous traditional practices designed to train a man to live from that center. These may include developing the ability to concentrate or observing the flow of thoughts, feelings, desires without reacting to them. This center has been described in the West by mystics such as Eckhart or Boehme's "The Nothing". It is the source of freedom as Berdyaev writes:

Freedom is not determined by God: it is part of the nothing out of which God created the world

The Destiny of Man

By concentrating and stilling the mind, an opening is prepared for the appearance of Being, or divine inspiration. This may also appear as a creative force to an artist.

The Traditional man is Free and lives an inspired and creative life.

Posted on 2011-01-04 by Cologero

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Ismo Meinander on 2011-01-05 at 10:12 said:

First of all, thank you Cologero and others for Gornahoor. It is truly a fountain source of inspiration and knowledge.

As it comes to this article and the notion of Quantum theory, have you read Wolfgang Smith's book "The Quantum Enigma"? I think his ideas of vertical causality and of the "form-bestowing agent" are very interesting.

14.4 Philosophy, Poetry, Piety

Philosopher The **Philosopher**, in the Traditional sense, is a lover of Wisdom, which is the intuitive knowledge of the Ideas. The goal of the Philosopher is, then, to be a Wise Man, or Sage. His method is the examined life, or self-knowledge, which differs from the natural knowledge of the scientist.

This knowledge leads him to understand the best way to live a human life, specifically, knowledge of the virtues. On the metaphysical principle that knowing is equivalent to being, the Philosopher can know the virtues only by becoming virtuous, not through definitions or sophistical arguments. Of course, by “virtue”, we mean a strength or the power to act appropriately in a given situation.

Justice, wisdom, courage, temperance are the cardinal virtues, each of the latter of which apply predominantly to a different class, balanced by justice. Of course, this list of virtues is not exhaustive. By seeking to actualize all the virtues, that is, all of his possibilities, the Philosopher is more like the True Man⁴. Since the True Man is characteristic of the Kshatriya caste, only the Philosopher or Sage is entitled to rule the Polis. Before the objection is raised that the philosopher is impractical, let us remember that Socrates had proved his courage in battle.

However, the common man is ruled by passion rather than reason, so he has no interest in philosophy, nor can he understand it. Hence, the common man rejects the rule of the Sage. This is the paradoxical position that the Sage finds himself in: he is the only one capable of ruling, but he is not able to rule.

Poet The **Poet**, in the larger sense, include the poet properly so-called, the playwright, the singer, the lyrical musician, and in modern times, the actor and the filmmaker. In short, any art that appeals to the “right brain”

⁴<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1039>

in popular parlance, or more accurately the bicameral mind as described by Julian Jaynes⁵.

The common man learns the virtues from the Poet, not the Philosopher. Thus poems, songs, myths, stories, and film are the vehicles through which the virtues and the good life are taught to the masses. Unfortunately, in our times, the ideas of the virtues and good life are defective, since they are all too often devoid of any influence of Wisdom, or else they are one-dimensional. Nevertheless, there have been many examples of Poets and poetry that show understanding of the virtues.

Paradoxically, the poet need not be virtuous in order to portray the virtues, he is instead the imitator of the virtues. Thus, a craven actor may nevertheless portray a great hero in a play or film. A bookish novelist may write deep and perceptive speeches for his men-of-the-world characters. This is the illusion of art, since there are no bad consequences. A play can bomb, but the playwright lives to create another despite his hurt feelings. But, in battle, a bad decision can be fatal, not just to the leader, but potentially to the nation he pledged to defend.

Nevertheless, the Poet must have some knowledge of the virtues, though not like the Philosopher's knowledge. It is an infused knowing, like an unconscious act of grace, a form of madness, a gift from the Muses⁶.

Pious Piety, or the worship of the ancestral gods, is also a virtue.

But we know about the gods from the Poets, not the Philosophers, as their acts are passed on through myths. This puts the Philosopher in an awkward position. On the one hand, he desires the good life for his family and nation. Thus he wants to preserve the Traditions of his ancestors and the way of life of his people, since they have served as the bases of public order and the common good.

⁵<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1365>

⁶<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1613>

On the other hand, his understanding of the gods is not gained through myths, which mediate knowledge through sensual imagery. Rather, it derives from an unmediated intuition of the Ideas. This intuition does not involve any of the external senses, not even in the imagination. Yet, there is a profound relationship between this intuition and its mythological representation, as described in *The Word is Silence Expressed*⁷.

Posted on 2011-02-15 by Cologero

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Cologero on 2011-02-19 at 10:33 said:

The discussion on the cardinal virtues again illustrates the continuity from the ancient Greek tradition to the ancient Roman tradition to the period of Christendom. The virtues must be understood in the same way from age to age.

If those virtues have been replaced by other so-called virtues, such as “tolerance” or universalism and so on, that is the result of deviations of the modern age, not of the alleged return to some “pure” or “primitive” Christianity (which never existed as such in the first place.)

14.5 Nietzsche's Paradox

There is a certain segment on the Internet who are, or claim to be, influenced by or followers of **Friedrich Nietzsche**, who then involve themselves in a paradox. Although Nietzsche claims that all opinions, conceptual schemes, or world views are merely perspectives, these bloggers nevertheless seem convinced that their particular perspective is absolutely true. Furthermore, as much as they decry the alleged absolutism of others, their efforts at evangelization and disdain for other perspectives reveal that same cast of mind.

⁷<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-word-is-silence-expressed>

Propaganda Now it may be that they are consciously publishing propaganda, even if it doesn't appear that way. In this case, we need to evaluate them by their effectiveness, for the purpose of propaganda is to promote a certain perspective, religion, or party platform. So what is their goal? Does the propaganda achieve that goal? Does it lead to an increase in power?

Propaganda has to be short, memorable, and emotion-laden. For example, we recently read a comment linking Christianity to democracy. This is powerful stuff, apparently, for neo-pagans who don't trouble to notice the "democracy" is a Greek concept predating Christianity, and historically Christian Europe opposed democracy until the advent of the so-called Enlightenment and French Revolution. Yet as propaganda, it is powerful because it matches his direct experience with contemporary neo-Christians and any intellectual correction would be long and tedious.

Scientific Training If not, then we must evaluate them as though they are attempts at the scientific (in the larger sense of the word) training of a certain intellectual elite. Any such perspective carries much more stringent requirements. The more of the following qualities that the perspective exhibits, the "better", that is, it demonstrates a stronger "will to power".

- It must "save the appearances", that is, it accounts for observable facts.
- The more it "falsifies" opposing perspectives, the better. That is, it should demonstrate that other perspectives don't save all the appearances.
- It is coherent, consistent, and complete.

- It follows “Occam’s Razor”, that is, it doesn’t bring in non-essential elements.
- It accounts for more than the immediate data. In other words, it has application to domains other than the one in dispute.
- It demonstrates a knowledge of history, culture, philosophy, and science.
- It addresses objections — known or possible — in advance.
- Its formulation is well written, following good grammar and rules of composition.
- It is beautiful, inspiring, and succinct

Gnosis Of course, the Hermetist is aware of the techniques of propaganda and scientific indoctrination. They are restricted to the sub-lunar and stellar or astral realms, whereas the Hermetist communes with angels and approaches the True Sun. While he recognizes the value of science and employs perspectives to obtain desired results as necessary, he also recognizes a higher and transcendent knowledge which he calls Gnosis. He then attempts to express in in the terms of science.

Posted on 2011-06-14 by Cologero

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Count Cagliostro on 2011-06-14 at 17:36 said:

“While he recognizes the value of science and employs perspectives to obtain desired results as necessary, he also recognizes a higher and transcendent knowledge”

THAT’S IT!!!

14.6 Augustine and Metaphysical Positivism

Noli foras ire, in te ipsum redi: in interiore hominis habitat veritas.

ST. AUGUSTINE

In **Auguste Comte's** explanation of Positivism, only data that could be experienced by the senses was acceptable. From that, laws would be inferred, free from any metaphysical or ideological presuppositions. That is sound practice for empirical science, but not for spiritual development. **Julius Evola** proposed a metaphysical positivism⁸ which would be based, not on philosophical speculations, but on direct, intuitive spiritual experience.

We continue to receive hate mail complaining that we criticize someone's favourite cause unfairly. These e-mails are simply confusions built on incomprehension. If only it were a matter as easy as putting the on the right team jersey, or adopting some man-made thought scheme and moral code. Neither is it a matter of being born with the "right" genetic structure, as though no personal efforts were required.

No, it is not a matter of playing the game, if only for the correct team. Nor is it about sitting out the game and not playing. Rather the task is to transcend the game, while observing it, making sense of the hidden forces guiding the movements of the players, and participating on a super-conscious level. We have several times mentioned various Hermetic meditations and trials. Here are a few to try this week.

Empty Mind For this exercise, purge the mind of every theory, creed, belief, custom, habit, or old wives tales. Then eliminate any desires, fantasies, or other emotional disturbance. What is left over? What

⁸<https://gornahoor.net/?p=1189>

rushes in to fill the void? What if you were with others in a similar state? What kind of world would you create?

Amor Fati Think about your life as it is and how it came to be that way. Forget about those who, you believe, frustrated or disappointed you. Can you love your life such as it is? Would you be willing to live it over again with everything happening in the exact same way? Can you accept ownership for every aspect in your life? Are you aware of any transcendent forces guiding your life?

Cemetery Make a visit to a cemetery, preferably one that has significance to you. Pay your respects and be quiet. You may not learn about the dead, but you may learn something about yourself.

Augustine of Hippo We have claimed that **Augustine of Hippo** (along with Plotinus and Boethius) was one of the primary intellectual forces behind what Evola calls the Nordic-Roman Middle Ages and we have been calling Christendom. The conventional historico-theological approach is to analyze his theological positions vis-à-vis the various issues of his time, such as grace, predestination, salvation, and so on. But this is only at the level of thought and is impossibly distant from a “metaphysical positivism”.

The Orthodox priest, Matthew Rafael Johnson, has made available a lecture on Augustine⁹ that is more in line with a metaphysical positivism (we do not imply that he would agree with much on Gornahoor nor vice versa). Augustine wrote: “Don’t go outside yourself, turn back to yourself. Truth resides in the depths of man.” That is always the starting point. Dogma can arise only after the fact of that direct inner experience of Truth. Fr. Johnson explains the inner states that Augustine is striving to convey in his writings. An interesting point is that Fr. Johnson returns

⁹<https://gornahoor.net/library/StAugustine.mp3>

to the the idea of St Anthony of the Desert¹⁰ who sees an insurmountable ontological divide between men born again of the spirit and those without spirit. The latter have no eternal life, perhaps a more more shadowy existence known to the ancients.¹¹

Posted on 2011-08-04 by Cologero

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Matt on 2011-08-04 at 23:20 said:

Funny enough, I listened to that lecture this past saturday. Fr. Johnson is the only person on that site I listen to.

Cologero on 2011-08-05 at 00:04 said:

Good judgment about that site, Matt. Unlike Fr. Johnson, Orthodox writers show little appreciation for Augustine, although Seraphim Rose wrote a lukewarm book about him. Johnson seems to me to be very nearly a Marcionite, barely bringing in the OT and almost replacing it with Platonism.

Auld Wat on 2015-12-19 at 09:48 said:

There is an error with the audiofile of the lecture!

Cologero on 2015-12-19 at 11:31 said:

Auld Wat, try this link: <http://www.gornahoor.net/library/StAugustine.mp3>.

Kevin on 2017-08-05 at 14:37 said:

Absolute excellence!!! As a student, I am in continual need of reminding and exhortation – habit is difficult to change.

¹⁰<https://gornahoor.net/?p=501>

¹¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=2507#more-2507>

14.7 The Spiritual Regeneration of the World

Cologero asked me to provide the letter of explanation, despite my reluctance and against my better judgment. I detest any public persona as my work is better accomplished on a different plane of existence. Nevertheless, I am the ultimate authority for Gornahoor, which he operates at my pleasure. Thus, the moment has come to make things clear, not that they haven't been for those able to understand.

Many years ago, Cologero was studying philosophy, particularly thinkers of the Right. He encountered **Leo Strauss**, whom he read avidly. This meeting of the minds taught him to revere the classical world. It also taught him how to read a philosopher, even those he disagreed with, since, as Nietzsche points out, the false ideas of a great thinker are of more value than the truisms of a mediocre mind. Most importantly, though, he learned to read esoterically. That is, he learned to discern the state of mind of the author behind the text. The text always holds something back and a good author often has sound reasons to leave something for his readers to discern on his own. I encouraged Cologero to apply this way of reading to the medieval thinkers; the results of this sort of analysis are there to see.

Strauss made the interesting point that a great philosopher, or a man who can think things down to their depths, rarely appears. He then claimed that **Martin Heidegger** was the only philosopher of the 20th century. Needless to say, given Heidegger's well-known sympathy for National Socialism this was rather disconcerting for a Jew to admit. Strauss then made a prediction that engaged Cologero's mind. He speculated that the next great world philosopher might be Asian. That is when Cologero came to me.

His knowledge of Eastern thought was limited to the pop Vedanta all too common among his generation. I led him to authors who were able



to bridge Eastern and Western thought, especially **Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan**, **Rene Guenon** and **Ananda Coomaraswamy**. In particular I asked him to read *The Central Philosophy of Buddhism* by **T R V Murti** which provides both the material and the mission for Gornahoor. So that it would not remain a mere intellectual task, I encouraged him to take refuge in the Buddha and to practice Tantra and Zen meditation. He then underwent initiation with a Tibetan lama from Boston. I will conclude this with some quotes from Murti; this will make the mission perfectly clear. Our goal is to awaken in some young philosopher the desire to take the *Madhyamika* and apply it to the dominant tradition in the West, just as it had absorbed Greek metaphysics. Evola claimed that Catholicism went only halfway. This move will bring it deeper into the metaphysics of a teaching more ancient and developed than that of the Greeks. First of all, an elite must arise and become conscious of itself. Murti writes:

In the last resort, there must be some considerable body of men who cannot be compelled to behave by external pressure, but who are intrinsically convinced of the worthlessness of material goods. They should have transcended the instinct of possession and must have risen above class and property, like the guardians of state in Plato's Republic.

The West has lost the spiritual unity of Christendom and the results of that loss are plain to see, even among those who remain blind to its cause. It is unlikely to be recovered without the conscious efforts of an elite who can bring in higher spiritual values. Murti makes this suggestion.

Only the spiritual can provide the basis for the society and can be conducive to the realisation of other values. In this regard, Mahayana absolutism and the Advaita Vedanta are valuable as

providing the basis on which a world-culture can be built. It is only absolutism that can make for the fundamental unity of existence and at the same time allow differences. ... The Vedanta is traditional in outlook and is bound to the authority of the Veda and perhaps it presupposes a specific milieu in which alone it can thrive. The Mahayana is quite liberal and it has proved its capacity to accommodate itself to various religious and social structures, to revitalise and absorb them.

Unfortunately, this is all too easily misunderstood as a call to take on the outer trappings of Buddhism rather than the spiritual regeneration it is encouraging. The net effect is not spiritual unity, but a further division, as Westerners then come to loathe their own Sacred Tradition. They create Strife rather than Love, as your **Empedocles** put it. Murti then offers some quotes from Radhakrishnan, but what he writes about Guenon is more pertinent to Gornahoor readers.

To take an example for the West, M. Guenon has made a commendable effort to interpret the true spirit of Hindu culture to the West in his many works. *The form of regeneration consists, for M. Guenon, not in a fusion or synthesis of the two cultures, but in the West regaining, as the result of a dynamic turn in its present trend, those springs of true spirituality through the help of the East.* It would be hazardous to forecast the time of the change or the precise manner in which it would be brought about.

But we can specify the general manner. It will not be from a philosophy of the academic type that everyone will miraculously accept. No, there must be a gnosis, an experiential knowing, that transcends words and thoughts. This the Madhyamika makes clear: it is not a matter of debate, dialectics or persuasion. That is why Cologero emphasizes the spiritual exercises so much. Spiritual unity will come, as he points out, from the depths, not from superficial and merely verbal agreement. Murti explains:

What we need is the realisation of the spiritual which is the bedrock of all our endeavour. Only mystical religion, which eminently combines the unity of Ultimate Being with the freedom of different paths for realising it, can hope to unite the world. The student of philosophy can only suggest that the Madhyamika Absolutism can serve as the basis for a possible world culture. It is not his province to show how best this could be implemented, what practical shape this would assume and at which point and time in the affairs of the world this could be introduced. These are questions which the religious reformer might answer, and even he has to depend upon the spiritual guidance and direction from above.

Murti concludes with a warning against scholars and professors, although he himself is one. The regeneration won't come from them as even Murti is too irenic and sanguine. He writes:

We must end with a note of warning. It is possible, in our enthusiasm, to overrate the part played by scholarship and the theoretical understanding of things in the task of regeneration. It is good to remember that history does not record of a single instance of a spiritual revolution of global dimensions brought out by a band of scholars or skillful thinkers. The malady of the world is far too universal and deep-seated for remedies to be prescribed direct from books. A spiritual genius of the order of **Buddha** or **Christ** alone knows how to strike at the thing. But even a theoretic understanding of the Madhyamika absolutism should prove of value by way of preparing the background for the *spiritual regeneration of the world*.

No, it is the man of vision, the man of action, who understands and engages in the greater and lesser battles who will bring it about. The world is not awaiting a new theory, since there is nothing new under the sun. By overemphasizing unity, Murti betrays his own theory. There is neither

unity nor conflict, there is both unity and conflict, there is no unity but there is conflict, there is unity but no conflict: this cannot be resolved by thought alone, but rather by action, that is, bringing the potential into act, non-being into being, making the unreal, real. Ideas have no existence on their own, but take on life in the mind of a conscious being. So we await not a new system, but a man, or rather the coming of a man-god. Only a god can save you now.

Posted on 2011-11-16 by Losang Shenphen

* * *

charlotte on 2011-11-17 at 12:18 said:

I think you are right, by the way, to emphasise the need for action – we need to be the change we want to see. After many years of meditation, soul searching and climbing the holy mountain I realised there was simply nothing else for it but to climb back down and actually DO something. I still believe in the power of prayer of course, but the need to help others and to actually make something of the earth is fundamental to the spiritual mission of those who ‘know better’, so to speak. However when I recently exhorted some ‘colleagues’ in this field to do the same I was met with a very unfriendly response, despite the fact that the key text they work with (Meditations on the Tarot) explicitly says we must do this, that the last great test of the spiritual seeker is to walk the humble road of work made into love, rather than disappearing up the mountain and floating off on a sacred cloud for the good of no-one but self. The most spiritual person I know is a man who would feel he lacks intelligence compared to me and others who’ve been ‘educated’, but I’m in awe in his presence, he works and gives for all he’s worth and is known to all around him by his fruits, he is the archetypal hero and man of action. (yes I love him, lol :-)) Jesus Christ was a man who showed the way by action in the ultimate sense – and yes, I love him too, He truly is the source of all love in this creation and we find love by expanding ourselves towards Him, away from the saturated ego. Disolution, they say, is the secret of the great work – dissolving in the sea of love...

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Jupiter on 2011-11-17 at 13:18 said:

You know, before this article, I had quite a bit of respect for this site. For the most part this place has avoided some of the more bizarre and theosophically-oriented problems that a lot of other so-called "Traditionalist" communities and publications succumb to.

Until now.

Stick to Tradition and leave the traditionalist claptrap out of it. Let's hear more Plotinus, St. Antony, Adi Shankara, Shakyamuni Buddha, and Lao Tzu and less Gurdjieff and Schuon madness or talk of who is behind what. Nobody who is attracted to this sort of place cares... That sort of bullshit is for the rest of Kali Yuga. We're here, reading what we read, because we're trying to escape the exact sort of dialectical wankery that Gornahoor's been spitting out as of late.

Gabe Ruth on 2011-11-17 at 14:53 said:

Thank you for that summary, I found it quite stirring.

To the haters: you can get cargo-cult traditionalism and therapeutic spiritualism from a lot of places if you like. I appreciate people who believe what they say, seek to live it, and try to share their methods and experiences to the extent it is possible in this medium.

Graham on 2011-11-17 at 14:54 said:

Losang,

Thank you for the letter of explanation. What, however, is the goal? Are you now to take a more open role? What was the purpose for hiding yourself in the first place? Most importantly, as EXIT asked, who are you? Revealing yourself as the authority behind Gornahoor raises more questions than it answers.

Forgive me for that barrage. Having followed this site for some two-odd years it's a surprise to learn that the man I thought was behind it isn't really. Or is he...? Could you explain your relationship with the site in a bit more detail? Do you set the agenda? I'm always interested in 'wheels behind wheels' but you'll forgive me if I say it feels somewhat Masonic. It is after all concerning to learn that what one took to be an move to tradition of a mostly Western provenance in fact has an Easterner 'pulling the strings,' even if we suppose he's of good will.

I notice with interest that you didn't include Evola in your reading list, while you did include Guenon and Coomaraswamy. Is that an oversight or something more pointed?

Graham

EXIT on 2011-11-17 at 16:41 said:

[Response from Cologero:

As someone who reads Gornahoor assiduously, you have a remarkable ability to understand nothing.

- 1) Where is the post where Gornahoor has proclaimed the "one and only truth"?
- 2) Where and when have you ever offered a specific criticism rather than vague inanities?
- 3) Where have we shown a "sentimental" attachment to Christianity? No, we have convincingly demonstrated that a specific era of Western history was characterized by a traditional social structure and understood a gnosis beyond rational thought.

That is an objective, not a sentimental, judgment. The paradox is that non-Christians recognize it, yet contemporary Christians seem rather embarrassed.

- 4) An attachment to a paganism that never existed anywhere is more properly described as "sentimental". That is why those with the mentality of a shudra imagine themselves to be great gods and Nietzschean supermen, and go seeking after runes. Question to readers: Why did even Leif Ericson reject this?

- 5) You need no one, EXIT? So you are indeed a self-initiator. You are the wishful thinker. If you have misunderstood us, perhaps even some more intelligent readers have. Have we not written of the "one and only guru transmigrant, etc)"? Have you not understand that it is a call for you to be that god-man? or a great prince, warrior, priest, philosopher or artist? That is the waiting ... an intelligent man knows how to wait.

If we continue to get such dullards reading Gornahoor ... it may be time to wait for a new generation to appear.

]

L.S.: "you flatter us by thinking we are the ones who are closest to the "one and only truth"."

Acting as if one had the one and only truth is not the same thing as believing it, for there is no "one and only" truth. Criticisms are therefore valid even though they may go against something which you hold a sentimental attachment to, such as Christianity.

As for a god-man who is going to come and save us all, that is just wishful thinking, something that I despise, for it implies dualism. I wait for no one. I need no one. And surely don't look for anyone for "salvation".

charlotte on 2011-11-17 at 17:14 said:

<http://alchemical-weddings.com/alchemical-weddings/pros-theon>

Graham on 2011-11-18 at 09:58 said:

Logres,

I agree, and Gornahoor has been fruitful indeed. If Losang Shenphen is behind it then we have every reason to judge well of him. Still, after following the site and even its programme for some time I feel invested in it, and therefore somewhat surprised, possessive, and suspicious when I realize it isn't quite what I thought it was. Asking questions and being less than completely equanimous is a fair reaction. But do Losang and Cologero owe us answers? Not at all. I am patient enough to watch things develop at their own pace.

Graham

Logres on 2011-11-19 at 00:26 said:

Graham, thanks for your comment, & of course I too am intrigued & interested in learning more. Certainly, question here is one of authenticity – it comes up in ecclesiastical circles regarding ordination and succession. Often times, in difficult spots, it becomes disputed and unclear. In such times, I think that it is always good to suspend judgement, and look to the aim and result, rather than the standard, since it is precisely the standard which is already compromised. I would personally be willing to accept almost any level of aid to the West spiritually, provided the tendency was to establish the West's capability of self-governance. Since, at some level, the common origin must obtain and persist, it is our duty to expect exactly this sort of help, and to endeavor to respond to it. I agree it requires a certain spiritual gift of discernment.

Boreas on 2011-11-19 at 03:55 said:

Thanks for this clarification – or apparent confusion, as it seems to be – about the motivations, purposes and personalities behind Gornahoor. There are visible authorities & leaders and invisible authorities & leaders, and everything we see around us is the result of both of these. The only thing that matters is the nature of both of these, and thus far Gornahoor and its (visible) contributors have been non-partisan, informative, enlightening and objective in their work.

Thus, I see no problem here. Things would be different if people were being led to something the nature of which remains completely unknown to them, or if people were being pressured to some partial goal / direction out of fear etc.

Become who you are.

Chmitt on 2011-11-19 at 05:25 said:

The image in this post is drawn from <http://www.tanmanho.com/>.

I'm beginning to suspect that Cologero is actually the man in the photo shown on that website, and based in Malaysia. It seems that this benevolent Oriental has extended help to us floundering westerners in the guise of everyone's favorite Italian uncle.

Greetings, Cologero – or rather, Professor Sir Dr. Tan Man-Ho Cologero!

charlotte on 2011-11-19 at 13:39 said:

regarding 'sentimental attachments' to Christianity, the muslim president of America would be proud of your disdain for love's greatest passion.

What a joke to see the fuss about Iran, Obama's secret friend....or maybe I got it wrong, maybe north Africa hasn't recently been handed over to radical Muslim brotherhoods like Al Qaeda, maybe the US president didn't really arrive on a white horse in the – colorado was it? – stadium?

conversion to Islam sounds pretty good from an intellectual point of view – heck, I love Rumi, Gibran, Hafiz etc, I really do – but shall we just take a look at the human rights issues, seriously, shall we just have a think about the socio-political reality it would entail? Wouldn't all be hookah pipes and philosophical chit chat in the tea rooms, THAT I can tell you. Bring out the bullwhips, the women are thinking....

francismmercuri on 2015-11-10 at 22:43 said:

How quickly humans turn on one another; some of these comments seem to just be looking for confrontation for its own sake.

In posts going back quite some time, Gornahoor stated that when the 1001 post goal neared, that the project would make clear what the purpose had been the whole time—the above is not an off-the-cuff twist, or “change” in direction—it was present the entire duration, and the supra entry had been planned long ago.

Current detractors should observe that the above entry notes:

“That is, he learned to discern the state of mind of the author behind the text. The text always holds something back and a good author often has sound reasons to leave something for his readers to discern on his own”.

Who “is” Losang Shenphen? Is he a “real” individuality apart from Cologero, or is he a sort of pseudopigraphal whimsy? Who cares and why ought it matter? What matters involves nothing but the totality of the Gornahoor posts, and their ultimate grounding in the trajectories noted above.

Then, “Nevertheless, I am the ultimate authority for Gornahoor, which he operates at my pleasure”.

Why ought anybody assume that this statement refers to a “site” and some factual administration? Isn’t “Gornahoor”, after all, something preceding net technology?

White Rabbit on 2015-11-11 at 03:07 said:

Gornahoor is a three-brained extraterrestrial being (maybe an Exonordic alien) from the planet Saturn, while Losang is just some boring oriental weirdo. The thing that I find most interesting here is the “sort of analysis” mentioned. Reading the medieval thinkers that way could illuminate the face of our past.

Sparrow on 2015-11-12 at 13:43 said:

@ White Rabbit,

It seems rather silly to use “Oriental,” negatively, when those cultures are largely the sources for Guenon and Evola, without neither of whom we would not have this illuminating site.

White Rabbit on 2015-11-13 at 18:47 said:

It is – I was attempting humor (now maybe I should clarify that I agree with Mr. Mecuri’s comment).

THAT on 2017-06-07 at 06:46 said:

«Our goal is to awaken in some young philosopher the desire to take the Madhyamika and apply it to the dominant tradition in the West, just as it had absorbed Greek metaphysics.»

It would be interesting to learn more about this possibility from Gornahoor’s perspective. I searched the archive, but there are exceedingly few posts that barely touch upon the subject at all. If the goal has been to seed such a daring and pioneering venture as applying Madhyamika to the Tradition of the West, one might expect the theme to have appeared more prominently throughout the posting history of this blog.

Cologero on 2017-06-12 at 08:14 said:

@Tat Tvam Asi

Madhyamika is implicit throughout.

14.8 Cosmos and Mind

“Philosophers” of naturalism, in a sort of Heideggerian idle chatter, create a consensus group illusion through their articles, books, journals, blogs, and so on. They have their own “sages”, call each other “bright” as a mark of mutual recognition, and rant against the “sky god” or “flying spaghetti monsters”. So when one of their own apostatizes, as apparently **Thomas Nagel** has in his recent book *Mind and Cosmos*¹², there is a flurry of activity to restore the *status quo ante*. On the one hand, the consensus illusion¹³ needs to be re-fortified. On the other, religious philosophers such as Edward Feser¹⁴ or the Maverick Philosopher¹⁵ are excited to spot a lost sheep, who, even if it hasn’t quite returned to the fold, at least it has come out of hiding.

Mr. Nagel, considered one of the most prominent philosophers of our time, thinks he has “discovered” some important ideas. Of course, his “discoveries” have been known since the hoary times of the **Primordial Tradition**. Every Medieval monk knew what Mr. Nagel had not known. So much for “progress” from the “dark ages”. It may be useful to quickly reflect on the five principles recently “discovered” by Mr. Nagel, as outlined by the Maverick Philosopher.

First of all, Mr. Nagel acknowledges that reductive materialism is untenable and consciousness—let us call it what it is, *viz.*, Spirit—is real. As Gornahoor has repeated often, form and matter, Purusha and Prakriti, are necessary conditions of existence, so there is absolutely no surprise

¹²https://www.amazon.com/Mind-Cosmos-Materialist-Neo-Darwinian-Conception/dp/0199919755/ref=sr_1_1%20?tag=firstthings-20-20

¹³<http://whyevolutionistrue.wordpress.com/2012/10/13/philosopher-thomas-nagel-goes-the-way-of-alvin-plantinga-disses-evolution/>

¹⁴<https://edwardfeser.blogspot.com/2012/10/nagel-and-his-critics-part-i.html>

¹⁵http://maverickphilosopher.typepad.com/maverick_philosopher/nagel-thomas/

at these two discoveries. For the Primordial Tradition, matter (Prakriti) without form (Purusha) is pure potentiality, i.e., nothing in particular. In quantum physical terms, prime matter is a Schrödinger equation in an indeterminate state. A conscious agent is required to “collapse” the equation, actualizing thereby one possibility rather than another.

From a purely philosophical point of view, there may be some frustration in this, given the interminable debates about whether forms are real or not. In the Primordial Tradition, however, the forms are intuited, not rationally proven. Hence, one is not properly a metaphysician until he has developed that intellectual intuition that surpasses reason.

Mr. Nagel’s more interesting claim is, “Nature is intelligible. Its intelligibility is inherent in it.” Readers of Gornahoor will immediately understand what he is getting at. Taking “nature” as referring to “being” (a term a naturalist eschews) and intelligibility as “Logos”, we see that he has inchoately formed the notion of the identity of Being and Logos. Again, this is Tradition and, *a fortiori*, is one of the principle creedal dogmas of the dominant spiritual tradition in the West for the past 2000 years.

Hence, *pace* the Kantians and post-modernists, the cosmos itself is intelligible; it is therefore not the case that man imposes his own intelligence on some primal chaos. We can praise Mr. Nagel, I suppose, for rediscovering sliced bread, and we hope it doesn’t destroy his reputation. Gornahoor, on the other hand, is a remote outpost on the Internet and has no reputation. Rightly so, since we have no credentials and make no claim to originality. We just hand down what has been handed down to us. Others may grab the baton or fumble it, that is not our concern. We just hope that readers avoid being distracted by alleged novelties.

Posted on 2012-10-24 by Cologero

14.9 The Great Cat Photo Contest

To be popular, it is advisable to give people what they want, not what they need. Usually, that involves sentimentalism.

Abd al-Qadir al-Jilani relates a story about cats and the whole audience begins to weep from spiritual emotion. They listened with boredom to the brilliant sermon of the great theologian.

The visitors at the cat photo contest look for the cutest cat. However, the judges consider different factors such as originality, technical excellence, composition, artistic merit, and overall impact. The point is that the cat is irrelevant, since the same factors are used to judge every other photo contest. In other words, for the naïve visitors, the cat in the picture is the object of interest. However, for the judges, the photograph itself is the object of interest. The judges see through the photograph to the agent who created it.



Social analysis follows analogous rules. One can be like the cat lover and take what is going on as complete in itself. Then he will choose a position that he thinks is the cutest. The alternative is to understand events as a battle of worldviews and the hidden factors that propel them.

The Marketplace of Ideas John Stuart Mill was said to be remarkably intelligent, but the concept of a marketplace of ideas is ludicrous. Allegedly, in a free discussion the better ideas (or better, worldviews) will win out. But that assumes that the ideas in the marketplace are objective, fair, and disinterested. It leaves out of the equation those who create or promulgate certain worldviews and why they do it.

The worst people, who assume they are the most intelligent, are the ones who say things like “I will listen to both sides of the issue and then decide.” That makes them purely passive receptacles of others’ ideas. In

a fair market, all parties are privy to all information. For example, if there is a drought in some coffee producing region, everyone knows it and the price takes that into account. That is why sellers try so hard to create unfair markets: e.g., by hiding information, locking competitors out, and trying to establish brand name distinctions.

So how fair is the marketplace of ideas? First of all, unlike news about coffee droughts which are less likely to be ideologically biased, the promulgation of ideas and worldviews is tightly regulated. In the USA, for example, six corporations account for nearly all the news sources. Many ideas, considered beyond the pale, are prohibited from the market place ... there is no need to identify them. So the choice is quite limited.

Then there is the issue that in modern times, complex ideas require a deep knowledge of science, economics, mathematics, history, and philosophy to be fully understood. Now I know for a fact that such a breadth of knowledge is not very common.

At university, for example, I signed up for a logic class in the philosophy department. There were 25 students on day 1, but only three of us finished the course. Specifically, the future philosophers, journalists and political scientists all failed to take a formal course in logic. Economics was another class with a high dropout rate. You can probably assume that the talking heads on TV are woefully ignorant of economics. Forget science class altogether, because if you don't sign up, you won't have to drop out. Yet these commentators claim to understand difficult questions in climatology and human genetics.

Most amazingly is that everyone things himself capable of understanding issues of politics and metaphysics. Yet, to be admitted to Plato's Academy, it was first necessary to master maths before considering those issues, as we pointed out several years ago in Maths and Politics.

Development of Thought There are two ways to try to move human thought further: the revolutionary and the evolutionary.

Revolution: The revolutionary way is to take the dominant idea and proclaim its opposite. After a while, this gets very easy and predictable. It started with the reformation, enlightenment, and the French revolution. The reformation challenged the dominant spiritual authority, the enlightenment challenged the very idea of a spiritual authority, and finally the French revolution overthrew both the spiritual authority and the political power.

Karl Marx gave the revolutionary impetus a firm philosophical foundation. First of all, he correctly recognized that a “spectre”, or spirit, is haunting Europe. This is not a metaphor or other figure of speech as our cat lovers might suppose. The goal of that spirit is to overthrow the existing social and political order of things. Yet people I speak to who are haunted by that spectre never seem to recognize themselves as Marxists in spirit.

Subsequent developments in the West all follow from this. Marx was interested in the economic-political order, so he proposed that the proletariat would be the agents for the overthrow. However, developments a century later added some complexity. If the socio-political order is understood to be white dominated, then minority races become the new agents for the overthrow. If that order is understood to be male dominated, then women as feminists become the new agents. If that order is understood as hetero-normative, then deviant sexuality becomes the new agent.

With this principle, everything comes into focus. The revolutionary worldview is certainly original, it is promulgated with technical excellence through the mass media, and its overall impact is undeniable. Eventually the revolution itself becomes the established order and it is difficult to see where else it can go from there. Reaction won’t automatically follow, since reaction is the opposite of the revolution.

Evolution: The evolutionary way is the way of depth. Previous thought is not overturned, but is understood on a deeper level. There are two ways to initiate that process:

- Bring out all the logical consequences of earlier thought
- Integrate it into a larger whole

Here was need only recap what was written in more detail in recent weeks. From Tomberg to Keyserling, we see the method of depth described. The meaning of things is contemplated, even if it is multivocal. Freedom of the will is the foundation for thought and action.

Posted on 2014-08-14 by Cologero

* * *

jc on 2014-08-21 at 06:28 said:

Lately I have been interested in the works of Kurt Gödel, amongst the realisation that we do live in a universe that is interconnected and infinitely more complex than we initially imagine.

It's only when we understand fundamentals like what was written about Plato's academy, that metaphysics takes on a deep and ontological meaning. There are no short cuts, though there are real and tangible gains.

14.10 The Philosophy of the Future

The heart has its reasons that reason does not know.

BLAISE PASCAL

Evola and Gentile During **Julius Evola's** youth, **Giovanni Gentile** was the grey eminence of philosophy in Italy, not just in a university setting, but also close to the seat of political power. He was the epitome of the cultured European, incorporating the whole of philosophy, art, literature, and history into his comprehensive system, which he named "actualism". So Evola's attack on Gentile was an attack on the Italian

political, intellectual, and educational edifice. Gentile never responded personally to Evola's critique, but instead allowed his student **Ugo Spirito** to address the issues raised by Evola. But the first issue to consider is the fundamental aim of philosophy, and this is where the two minds differ. Gentile's first political post was the Minister of Education, which he used to reform the Italian school system. Evola's goal was much higher:

If Gentile could truly name the I as the "pure act" of his rationalism, then he would appear not as the university professor, whose "actualism" has the reform of the educational system as its goal, but rather as that cosmic centrality that the esoteric reveals in the types of the rishi, the yogi, Christ, and the Buddha.

So Evola's real objection is that Gentile sells himself short; the I, in its self-actualization, should have as its goal to become a rishi, yogi, Christ, or Buddha. This, then, is the logical development of actualism that Gentile somehow missed. While Evola's system has some defects, the goal is worthy.

To describe that goal, Evola has to incorporate elements of Oriental thought, for example, if Atman is Brahman, then how does that affect philosophy? The influence of Friedrich Nietzsche is also strong, since it is now impossible to be a philosopher without dealing with his withering critique of the decadence of Western thought and spirituality. This we will address in the next section.

Ultimately, Evola never developed the philosophy of magical idealism, certainly not to the point of developing more Christs and Buddhas. Even during the fifties and sixties, when allegedly there was a stream of young men who consulted with him, no one arose to carry on that philosophy. By then, I suppose, idealism was a non-starter as the basis for a philosophical system, and people were looking for less abstractions, turning instead to political and religious solutions to the problems posed.

Evola himself, having first promoted a philosophy of action, resorted to passivity as in the aristocrat of the soul and riding the tiger. Of course,

while every Tom, Dick, and Harry nowadays claim to be an aristocrat of the soul, the rishis are still hard to find.

The Philosopher of the Future If magical idealism is not the philosophy of the future, then we are still waiting for the philosopher of the future. Those with a sound intellect should aspire to this, and not be content with the comfortable life of writing clever and erudite journal papers. Aside from Kant, the great philosophers developed their view of life in their twenties. So start now, you can always revise it.

Now there are three claimants to the knowledge of ultimate reality: the *Priest*, the *Philosopher*, and the *Prophet*. Borrowing an insight from **Valentin Tomberg**, we can say that the philosopher works in the day through the light of reason, the prophet in the night through direct illumination from God, and the priest is the mediator between the light and the darkness. The philosopher of the future will probably be in tension with the other types, while still needing to incorporate their insights.

The philosopher must first deal with facts, then an understanding of the facts, and finally indicate how that affects our lives. The fundamental facts have been summarized by **Arthur Schopenhauer**: the world as will and idea. Here we find the Traditional doctrine of the two worlds of being and becoming¹⁶. The “world” referred to is that of becoming, and the “idea” is the world of being. Here are some examples.

Plato, and the lineage following him, called the will “eros”, i.e., the drive or “love” of wisdom. Wisdom, for him, is to know the world of being. For Nietzsche, this overvaluing of the “other” world in Plato and in the Christianity which built on Platonic ideas, led man away from his true calling of being fully loyal to the earth. There is no other worldly afterlife beyond this world, but only its endless repetition. The Will to Power replaced eros. In denying the world of being, Nietzsche denies God, or better, God, for him, is yet to come.

¹⁶<https://gornahoor.net/?p=7147>

As a Traditional thinker, Evola opposed Nietzsche's biologism, while incorporating his more important insights. While not denying the world of being, he changed man's relationship to it. First of all, he retained Nietzsche's emphasis on will and action; this, as we have seen, brought him into conflict with Rene Guenon. Now action can be understood in two ways. The conventional way is to see it as "horizontal", i.e., as activity wholly in the world of becoming. A deeper way is to understand it "vertically", i.e., as the actualization of potentialities. In this way, Evola can claim that it is insufficient to *know the truth*, one must also *will the truth*. This implies absolute freedom.

The philosopher of the future can build on this. A rishi, or a seer, is more like a prophet than a philosopher. Hence, he must learn to think with his heart as well as with his head. If the goal of philosophy is to bring God's presence into the world, then he must learn to do that himself. To be free means to have no sufficient reason outside oneself, so the philosopher must be free. Since for God, essence and existence coincide. Hence, the philosopher of the future must actualize all his possibilities. Now we mean the philosopher is God-like in the relative, not the absolute sense. How that is so, will be the task of this philosopher to explain.

The Religion of the Future The religion of the future will be based on gnosis. This is not a new religion, but rather a deeper understanding of what religion is and means. In other words, it is the actualization of religious or spiritual understanding. This is reflected in various states of consciousness, both psychological and spiritual. I am not making this up and have amply documented how this has always been the case.

There are two false claimants to the religion of the future: one is to alter it to bring it into conformism with modernity, the other is to repeat the religious forms of the past. Now there is no problem with the second option for those who are satisfied with it. But the prophet of the future will write a large book on the phenomenology of the soul.

2018 Postscript In a recently published collection of letters between **Wolfgang Smith** and Fr. **Malachi Martin**, there is this intriguing comment from Prof. Smith:

If the Greek Fathers could integrate Plato and Neoplatonism into the Christian worldview, and St. Thomas Aquinas could do the same for Aristotle, why should it not be possible, in our day, to correct and somehow “Christianize” Hegel, let us say, or Schelling, or even Nietzsche? Is there not in each of these German “Titans” a certain spark of truth that needs to be brought out, to be “liberated”?

That would be a good task for a young scholar. The starting point, of course, would be **Jacob Boehme**, the father of German Idealism. Also, **Vladimir Solovyov**, who has already adapted Schelling into his system.

Posted on 2014-06-26 by Cologero

* * *

seeker on 2014-06-26 at 13:25 said:

You bring to mind Fr. Seraphim Rose’s book (Orthodoxy and the Religion of the Future)? He gave the term a decidedly pejorative connotation, referring specifically to New Age syncretism, one of the false claimants, “bringing it into conformism with modernity”. But he was also critical of Hinduism, saying that the yogis’ experience during meditation are mere psychic phenomena and not real spiritual knowledge.

The book was obviously not meant for the “rishi, yogi, Christ, or Buddha”. In this letter he refers to the Kali Yuga by name, which leads me to believe there is more to his thought than one would gather from the above mentioned book.

<https://sites.google.com/site/phoenixlxineohp2/lettertoareaderofrenewenon>

Ash on 2014-06-27 at 00:31 said:

Concerning the relationship of the philosopher to gnosis: would such a person have already attained such a high state of existence themselves? Or would they be showing the way as travelers themselves? I suppose two tests for such a philosopher would be a) are they practicing a living exoteric tradition, and b) are they old enough to have gained wisdom over time. So anyone starting now in their twenties ought to be preparing themselves for that.

Cologero on 2014-06-27 at 00:44 said:

Seeker, I have not read that particular book, but I had previously read the letter you linked to. Obviously, I am being a bit tongue in cheek and am not advocating anything like New Age ... actually quite the opposite if read carefully. Don't forget that Fr Rose also warned against "super-correctness"¹⁷, and we have been criticized many times by the super-correct. The problem today is one of a worldview. There was an earlier time when men could think with their heart and were acutely aware of the reality of the other world of being. But now, such a mentality is utterly alien to most men, so an intellectual conversion of some sort is necessary. So the way forward is actually a recovery, but at a deeper level. That is because a man who has had to work for something appreciates it more than the man for whom it came without effort.

I have been planning a post on the mental and spiritual states of the yogis, but much preparation is required. Ultimately, it will be up to the prophet of the future to make such distinctions. Now Fr Rose was totally into Guenon before he was not, so it is legitimate to speak to the former class of men as well as to the post-Guenon men. Careful readers will need to sort it out.

Cologero on 2014-06-27 at 07:45 said:

As I pointed out, Ash, most great philosophers developed their philosophy in their youth ... I suppose we can find examples and counter-examples. But the philosopher is a just "lover of wisdom" and so is not necessarily "wise". There are ultimate facts and the philosopher tries to understand them in the light of his own reason. The best are not daunted by the complexity and enigmas of reality. In our time, there are new forms of escapism, even more insidious than the decadent Christianity that Nietzsche or Evola opposed.

These forms of escapism are obvious enough to name. First are the so-called "new atheists", who believe science and a narrowly conceived rationality can account for all of reality. The other is new age political correctness which through shaming and self-deception tries to enforce a worldview involving beliefs that no well-bred and healthy-minded man could have believed in previous eras.

So, this imaginary philosopher would have to challenge those forms of escapism and describe a worldview in which the quest for gnosis "makes sense". So, yes, a man in his twenties

¹⁷http://orthodoxinfo.com/ecumenism/fsr_63.aspx

ought to be preparing for that, “as if”, before his mind stagnates.

Mr Zero on 2014-07-02 at 14:18 said:

Cologero I am surprised at the mistake you've made in this article: “Evola himself, having first promoted a philosophy of action, resorted to passivity as in the aristocrat of the soul and riding the tiger.” But *Ride the Tiger* contains an action-based philosophy; the crux of it is knowing oneself and then testing oneself through experiment & rupture (particularly in the chapters 10 Invulnerability & 11 Acting Without Desire). In other words the sort of Left Hand Path he previously advocated in *Yoga of Power*.

Cologero on 2014-07-05 at 13:11 said:

Perhaps, Mr Zero, you are correct that my language was somewhat strong and misleading, and I do not want to leave the impression that there is no value in those later works. But I had in mind a particular context, and my comment needs to be taken within it. The fact is that essays in *Magical Idealism* (which incorporates the *Yoga of Power*) has as its aim the creation of rishis, yogis, etc. That is why he includes the Three Trials, which is really out of place in a book of philosophy since it should depend on discourse and the light of reason alone. The takeaway is that magical idealism cannot be understood without performing the concomitant spiritual exercises.

Evola never, as you correctly point out, abandoned that as *rhetoric*. My point is that he was never able to complete that project beyond rhetoric into being, even though he seems to have had the opportunity. Instead, as we see from his correspondence with Guenon over the years, he was always pursuing marginal hermetic figures, and never developed magical idealism as a spiritual movement in itself; hence no rishis, yogis, Buddhas, or Christs ever arose out of it.

Mr Zero on 2014-07-06 at 20:31 said:

Cologero thank you for showing the connection of his concept of the trial with his earlier philosophical period, something I hadn't realized before.

When I read your answer, especially “no rishis, yogis, Buddhas, or Christs ever arose out of it” the first thing I thought was – how does he know? How could any of us know? We would only know if the Buddhas chose to show themselves. They might not want to. It doesn't necessarily follow that once a Buddha attains enlightenment he will want to manifest into history. I'm not arguing either way, just pointing out the difficulty in this kind of statement.

From what I understand Evola's vision of awakened ones manifesting into history took the form of an initiatic military order more than anything. Sedgwick and Goodricke-Clarke link this to influence over terrorist groups in Italy, but there isn't much available in English to clarify the specifics. In any case it doesn't reflect well on his position at all.

14.II Magical Idealism in a Larger Whole

The keenest sorrow is to recognize ourselves as the sole cause of all our adversities.

SOPHOCLES

Since one aspect of building a system is to integrate a lesser one into a larger whole, what follows are some possible wholes that will accept what is profitable in magical idealism, while accounting for its defects.

Solipsism The temptation to solipsism exists in the idea of the Absolute Self. **Julius Evola** admitted this in *The Individual and the Becoming of the World*:

It has already been seen that the passage of the individual consciousness through the second stage entails solipsism, that is the impossibility of admitting coherently a multiplicity of subjects or I's in the last resort. That immanent certainty – as was said – which alone I can call “I” is unmultipliable: it is a bare experience that mediates everything and is mediated by nothing – and as to the “other” I's, they are nothing at all, they are nothing that I can experience directly, but only some hypotheses which I make recourse to in order to explain to myself some groups of representation of my unique unmultipliable experience. In summary, the “other I's”, insofar as they are “other”, are not “I” and insofar as they are “I”, they are not others, but me myself. All that is too obvious.

Evola quotes **Otto Weininger** in support:

the frightened withdrawal in the face of solipsism and the impotence of giving an independent value to being, the incapacity for opulent solitude, the need to chase the crowd, disappearing, plunging into the multitude. *It is shallowness.*

Is there not another path besides solipsism and the fall into the anonymity of the mass man? After all, isn't solipsism a feminine quality?¹⁸ This reminds me of a story told by **Bertrand Russell** about a woman who approached him after a lecture, expounding her own philosophical vision. Russell listened, finally replying, "Ma'am, that would make you a solipsist", to which she replied, "Isn't everybody?"

The clue comes in the concept of privation. To the extent that I suffer from a privation, then there is a gulf between my essence and existence. I lack the power to bring all my possibilities into manifest existence. Since, for God, there is no such gulf between essence and existence, then "I" am not God. The claim that the Absolute Self will someday manifest is insufficient.

The Hermetist knows the Law of Analogy, viz., "As above, so below." While magical idealism gives me a great insight into my own consciousness, this can only be gnosis from below. So, by analogy, the philosophy can be applied "above", i.e., to God, the only Absolute Self. For God, the problems of privation, spontaneity, and lack of power do not exist, since for Him, there is no privation, spontaneity is replaced by freedom, and He is all-powerful.

The Hermetist understands we are created free. Yet this freedom is a task to be accomplished, and the insights of magical idealism can reveal the obstacles for achieving freedom. There is no slavery in the creature submitting to an all-powerful God, no more so than the pledge of fealty of the Knight to his Lord. On the contrary, only the free man can make such a commitment.

Androgyne In any case, the goal of Tantra is not simply the Absolute Self, but rather the Androgyne. This alchemical marriage is also the goal of Hermetism and it is not clear to me how that would fit into Evola's sys-

¹⁸<http://anarchopapist.wordpress.com/2013/07/09/why-women-are-solipsistic/>

tem. That is why we introduce other Hermetists, such as **Boris Mouravieff** and **Miguel Serrano**, who are more focused on the androgyne

Cosmology and Physiology Tantra, as well as Hermetism, incorporate a complex cosmology and psycho-physiology. The former involves a hierarchy of beings who maintain the world process. The latter describes in detail a classification of the inner life. Magical idealism needs to be supplemented in those areas.

Spontaneity and Thinking A question arose recently in the Gnosis study group about how to quiet the mind by controlling thoughts. Since it may be of larger interest, I am providing the response.

Of course there are random thoughts arising. The point is to experience firsthand what Gornahoor has been publishing in the commentaries on magical idealism. These thoughts are arising “spontaneously” and we are not choosing them “freely”.

Only by constantly observing them, can one be convinced of that. Then you can eventually see how the thoughts arise in the first place, and how they link to each other to form a worldview (the lie or confabulation). That becomes the gnosis . . . you actually know this. By knowing, you become free from the bondage to these random thoughts and can consciously create a true worldview based on revelation.

The closer you can observe the thoughts arising, they will stop by themselves, often before becoming fully formed. That is the “technique”, if you want to call it that.

You will see that thoughts have different sources.¹⁹

¹⁹<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-cosmic-hierarchy>

The Human Person Some people believe that we are opposing the Western tradition when, in point of fact, we are really highlighting its main features. For example, the ideas of personality are true to tradition; we just aspire to take them beyond rhetoric by making them real ontological experiences. For example, this is from the Catholic Catechism:

Being in the image of God the human individual possesses the dignity of a person, who is not just something, but someone. He is capable of self-knowledge [and] self-possession.

Even Evola uses the phrase the “dignity of the person.” What this means is that the person has more than just a human nature (“what he is”), but he also has the essence of the I (“who he is”). Self-knowledge is much more than something trivial such as “I don’t like broccoli” or “I was born a certain way.” Those are passive characteristics, and the Hermetic path is an active path.

Those who have been participating in the Gnosis seminar²⁰ have come to understand that authentic self-knowledge is a complex and serious business. Nevertheless, efforts pay off; in esoterism, a trophy is not awarded to just everyone.

Now that you know that self-possession is a mark of the person, go back and read everything that Evola has written about possession.

Personality and Character Thomist psychology distinguishes between the ontological person and the empirical (or empiriological) person. **Rev. Victor Warkulwiz** explains it this way:

The ontological person is the person as such. The empiriological person is the ontological person as he manifests himself through his acts, powers, and habits, all of which are accidents.

²⁰<https://gornahoor.net/?p=9899>

In other words, the ontological person is what the person is *born* with, that is, it is his essence. The empirical person is what he acquires in the course of his life. This is no different from what Mouravieff writes. Fr. Warkulwiz makes a further distinction:

Personality expresses the person through nonmoral acts. Character expresses the person through moral acts.

Moreover, Fr. Warkulwiz makes this remarkable comment:

The same person takes on a number of personalities.

Again, this is a fundamental teaching of Gnosis, which actually describes and catalogues the different possible personalities.

The ontological person is obviously what we have been calling the real I. It is constant and stable apart from the manifestations of the various personalities. Unfortunately, as long as we identify with the empirical and material world, we remain oblivious to the real I.

Posted on 2014-07-20 by Cologero

14.12 The Seven Enigmas of the World

Ignoramus et ignorabimus

“we do not know and we shall never know”

In 1880, the physiologist **Emil du Bois-Reymond** proposed seven riddles of the world that science could not answer and most likely never would. To wit:

1. the ultimate nature of matter and force
2. the origin of motion

3. the origin of life
4. the purpose of living beings
5. the origin of sensations
6. the origin of thought and language
7. free will

Of course, Bois-Reymond means a scientific explanation, that is, the discovery of laws based on observation of phenomena, and not an a priori explanation from religious faith, metaphysics, or gnosis. Since it is difficult to conceive what such a scientific explanation would even look like, scientists simply accept the “big picture” of science (e.g., evolution, quantum theory, “big bang”) and instead focus on technological issues. This is especially true in a second tier class of intractable problems such as the origin and elimination of violence, inequality, racism, and other socially destructive or undesirable aspects of human behaviour.

For example, the physicist Michio Kaku²¹ asserted in a recent interview²² that a thousand years in the future, the human race will have had sufficient time to solve and eliminate the conflicts resulting from religious, racial, economic or national differences. Given Kaku’s worldview, we have to assume that he means there is a scientific explanation for such conflicts and, hence, a technological solution.

We are perhaps given a clue when he asserts that there is a gene responsible for generating mystical or supernatural explanations of events. Unfortunately, there is absolutely no evidence for such a gene and his explanation of the survival value of an allegedly incorrect explanation of events is less than convincing. But given that thesis, the obvious conclusion to create a more rational (in Kaku’s sense) humanity involves genetic

²¹<https://mkaku.org/>

²²<https://www.c-spanvideo.org/program/id/234213>

engineering or eugenics. If true, that would certainly solve the problem of religious conflict; does Kaku assume there are specific genes that cause the other conflicts he mentions? If it is desirable to eliminate those genes or their effects, given that the human race is genetically programmed, where does the impetus for that desire come from?

Well, early on, Kaku tells us that humans are “naturally” scientific, so perhaps the science gene will gain the upper hand. Unfortunately, Kaku inconsistently asserts that, unlike religious faith, doing science is actually not a natural activity. It requires study and effort, qualities far from natural (or even common, presumably). Now we are coming perilously close to the idea of science as transcendent knowledge. Then the physicist takes on the role of high priest, asserting “just so stories” of evolution and satisfying our mystical urges with strange stories of quantum parallel universes.

So for what purpose? In order that humans, when no longer engaged in social conflicts, can focus on their real work of exploring other planets. Again, why? Apparently, according to Kaku, for that same reason that a single virus will infect a host organism and expand as rapidly and completely as it is able.

So even the physicist Kaku does not predict the solution to the seven enigmas in a thousand years. Now **Valentin Tomberg** states that Bois-Reymond should have said: “given the current state of scientific knowledge and the scientific method, these enigmas are insoluble.” This leads us to these questions:

1. What do we accept as knowledge?
2. What do we accept as method?

Science only accepts, as knowledge, the experience of the senses and the proposed laws that unify such experiences. Tomberg instead proposes:

you *know* only what is verified by the concordance of all forms of experience in its totality — experience of the senses, moral experience, mental experience, the collective experience of other seekers for the truth, finally the experience of those whose knowledge has merited the title of wisdom and whose will has been crowned with the title of sanctity.

The method involves the observation of those experiences that the scientist ignores, viz., one's thoughts, desires, emotions, sensations. The multiplicity of such phenomena is not resolved by a unitary law or principle; rather it is necessary to become *one* in oneself and *one* with the spiritual world. Then a new kind of experience — spiritual experience — will arise. And a new kind of knowledge — cognition beyond discursive thought — will take place. Once there is recognition of the relationship of all things and beings, then the corresponding method, the Method of Analogy, will be understood.

This is the beginning of **Hermetic Science** and the enigmas will reveal their solutions.

Posted on 2010-10-09 by Cologero

* * *

Andrew on 2010-10-11 at 02:33 said:

More evidence that chemistry and the other sciences should never have divorced themselves from Alchemy. Kaku's statements are a great illustration of the Fool Arcana, though.

James O'Meara on 2010-10-11 at 11:34 said:

If you ask the Man in the Street why science is worthwhile, he'll mention atom bombs and [someday] curing cancer. Unfortunately, it seems the "best" scientists quickly tire of this practical work, feeling it to be somewhat "beneath" them, and contrive to reconfigure themselves as "public figures" with important things to say about metaphysics and morality. This must stop, and given the damage they do to society, I would be willing to toss out the science [which is mostly "zion-ce" anyway] as well. As Guenon said, the Western world neglects "the one thing needful" in favor of what other civilizations thought were contemptible toys.

Matt on 2010-10-11 at 13:33 said:

Kaku is just one of many scientists who think that because they are a scientist it also means they are a philosopher, and that science can just absorb the discipline of philosophy (or disregard it....like almost anything else that doesn't fall under the usual sciences). I guess the one bright side to this is that it provides those of us with some chuckles when these types make glaring philosophical and logical errors and are oblivious that they made them.

kadambari on 2010-10-14 at 15:11 said:

A philosophical education is different from mere science, as the physical sciences concern abstraction from phenomena, they do not concern themselves with questions of living. Without any higher purpose placed upon it, science is meaningless and directionless and clearly not an end in itself. All intelligent scientists realize this. Plato writes of philosophy in the seventh letter:

One statement at any rate I can make in regard to all who have written or who may write with a claim to knowledge of the subjects to which I devote myself—no matter how they pretend to have acquired it, whether from my instruction or from others or by their own discovery. Such writers can in my opinion have no real acquaintance with the subject. I certainly have composed no work in regard to it, nor shall I ever do so in the future, for there is no way of putting it in words like other studies. Acquaintance must come rather after a long period of attendance on instruction in the subject itself and of close companionship (I suppose he means supervision of a correct “teacher”) when, suddenly, like a blaze kindled by a leaping spark, it is generated in the soul and becomes self-sustaining.

Besides, this at any rate I know, that if there were to be a treatise or a lecture on this subject, I could do it best. I am also sure for that matter that I should be very sorry to see such a treatise poorly written. If I thought it possible to deal adequately with the subject in a treatise or a lecture for the general public, what finer achievement would there have been in my life than to write a work of great benefit to mankind and to bring the nature of things to light for all men? I do not, however, think the attempt to tell mankind of these matters a good thing, except in the case of some few who are capable of discovering the truth for themselves with a little guidance. In the case of the rest to do so would excite in some an unjustified contempt in a thoroughly offensive fashion, in others a certain lofty and vain hopes as if they had acquired some awesome lore(341c-e)...

What is amazing is that he states that affinity for wisdom is something inborn and cannot be taught, which is what I am beginning to think the older I get...

He goes on : To sum it all up in one word, natural intelligence and a good memory are equally powerless to aid the man who has not an inborn affinity with the subject. Without such endowments there is of course not the slightest possibility. Hence all who have no natural aptitude for and affinity with justice and all the other noble ideals, though in the study of other

matters they may be both intelligent and retentive—such will never any of them attain to an understanding of the most complete truth in regard to moral concepts. The study of virtue and vice must be accompanied by an inquiry into what is false and true of existence in general, and must be carried on my constant practice throughout a long period....Hardly after practising detailed comparisons of names and definitions (I assume the study of logic), and visual and other sense perceptions, after scrutinizing them in benevolent disputation by the use of question and answer without jealousy, at last in a flash understanding of each blazes up, and the mind as it exerts all its powers to the limit of human capacity, is flooded with light...For this reason no serious man will ever think of writing about serious realities for the general public so as to make them a prey to envy and perplexity. In a word, it is an inevitable conclusion from this that when anyone sees anywhere the written work of anyone, whether that of a lawgiver in his laws or whatever it may be in some other form, the subject treated cannot have been his most serious concern—that is, if he is himself a serious man. His most serious interests have their abode somewhere in the noblest region of the field of his activity....(344c-d)

johnson j on 2022-07-07 at 21:57 said:

Everyone saying science could answer these riddles eventually looks totally foolish now even moreso than they did in 2010, because after 2020, anyone who doesn't know science can't even answer questions about physical things has proven themselves to be braindead.

14.13 Worldviews, Representations and Reality

A few years ago we wrote *Privation*²³. Now is the time to revisit that idea, by expanding it with some of **Hermann Keyserling**'s conceptions. As we pointed out then, the world is a projection of the I. This can be made clearer from Keyserling's claim that "the representation creates reality, not vice versa." (We will use the terms "representation" and "worldview" somewhat synonymously, although the latter has wider application.)

If that sounds like a wild claim to you, then consider its opposite: how exactly does reality create a representation of itself in the mind or consciousness? Although most people naively consider that to be obviously

²³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=1815>

true, including the soi-disant “brights”, a moment of reflection should convince you otherwise.

This is the question that Kant tried to answer. Shankara’s answer²⁴ is that the mind fabricates an illusory, which we then take to be a true model, of the world. As we recently pointed out, **Johann Fichte**’s philosophy has a general similarity to the Advaita Vedanta see **Bhagavan Das**; hence, we can use his insights to explain this idea more fully. **Bryan Magee**, in his book on Schopenhauer, summarizes Fichte’s philosophy like this:

Fichte saw the whole empirical world as deriving from the subject and taking the precise and detailed form it does out of logical necessity. However, since the world derives from our conception of it, and not the other way about, our conception of the world must itself be a free creation on our part—‘free’ in this context meaning precisely that it has not empirical derivation.

Furthermore, this applies equally to the human, moral world—which is our main interest—as well as the physical, empirical world. Hence, we will discuss each in turn.

Science as a Creative Activity In this section, I will be employing some basic symbolic logic statements, for those trained to understand them. If that gives you *agita*, I believe the text by itself should convey the main point.

A scientific theory can predict the occurrence of a set of facts; this used to be called “saving the appearances.” Symbolically,

$$T \Rightarrow F$$

where T is the theory and F represents the set of facts, $F^1, F^2, \dots$ that it predicts.

²⁴<https://gornahoor.net/?p=7326>

In words, the theory logically implies the occurrence of the facts. The more facts it can predict, the more useful it is. However, the theory itself can never be proved to be “true”. That is because there is no logical, computable, deterministic, mechanical, or empirical method to go from the facts F to the theory T . Since the contrapositive of a proposition is equivalent to the proposition, the most we can say is that the theory can be falsified if a predicted fact turns out not to be true. That is,

$$\sim F^n \Rightarrow \sim T$$

Hence, in practice, there can be no “computer program”, for example, that will generate true theories based on a collection of facts. So what then is a “theory” if it is not empirical and not derivable from anything empirical? A specific example will illustrate this.

For more than 200 years, educated people accepted **Isaac Newton**’s theory of universal gravity as an absolute truth since it accounted for the movement of the planets and gravitational attraction on a human scale. However, **Albert Einstein**’s theory eventually disproved Newton’s since it predicted some facts that the latter theory could not. If Newton’s theory was not a true law of physics, and since it does not logically follow from the facts, then what exactly is it? The only answer is that it was a creative and free construction of the human mind, just as Fichte described; in other words, it is an ideal.

Since the ideal (or theory) implies the facts, we are forced to the conclusion that the real derives from the ideal, and not the other way around. Once we include the technological methods that derive from the theory, we see that this is even more true.

The Moral World Fichte’s other insight was that not just the physical world, but also the moral world, derive from the subject. Magee summarizes this position:

Both worlds derive from free activity on the part of the noumenal self. This self can thus be said to create both worlds: and this pro-

vides us with the key to the nature of total reality. ... For morality to be possible there must be choice, and for choice to be a possibility for me, it is necessary that something should exist other than my self. Similarly, for moral action to be a possibility for me there needs to be some challenge, something that exists in opposition to my self, or at least something that is a potential obstruction to my activity. So if I am to be a moral being at all it is necessary that there should be a world which is not me, a world of objects which can obstruct me.

In analogy to the physical world, the representation of the world, or worldview, will determine the phenomenal world out of its logical necessity. The physical world appears more restrictive in that there are few effective theories or representations of it. This does not include the possibility of miracles, siddhis, magic, or other supernormal powers to affect the physical world. At the least, the notion that the representation creates reality does not preclude that possibility.

When it comes to the body, the situation is even more convincing. No one today doubts the possibility of psychosomatic phenomena, so our thoughts affect our state of health to a large degree. In the human, moral realm, our world representation is the only thing that matters. People have a conception of the human world, and will then act in accordance with that conception. This will create a world that conforms to that conception. When groups of people have different conceptions, conflicts will result. The dominant worldview, then, can only be the result of the Will to Power.

This competition of worldviews is thus the battlefield for moral action. There is a lot to be found in print analyzing this battlefield, some of it well written. However, such commentaries seldom make the move from the real to the ideal. Specifically, to repeat, the facts do not create the worldview, but the worldview creates the facts. Hence, the real issue is to understand whence these worldviews arise. This worldviews are actually

illusions; they seem to account for the facts, yet there are facts that would falsify the worldview. However, worldviews are very difficult to discard, once established in the mind. Unlike mistakes in our understanding of the physical world, which are very quickly noticeable, mistakes about the human world take much longer to show their full effect, oftentimes even over a few generations.

The source of worldviews arises from inner states; there are various possible combinations of psychological forces that give rise to specific worldviews. This is not the place to discuss that, but details will come out over time.

In preparation for his battle, **Arjuna** had to undergo a process of spiritual development. Only then will the true nature of the battle be understood. Arjuna would be stuck in illusion until God-realization would reveal the true nature of creation. This, then, needs to be our first step.

Posted on 2014-08-04 by Cologero

* * *

Anthony on 2014-08-06 at 14:38 said:

I'm still confused. Naive realist would argue that creating a Theory that makes a Prediction "all apples are cubical" does not make it be so in Reality (consult nearest apple for Fact). Here $T \rightarrow P$ and $R \rightarrow F \rightarrow \sim P \rightarrow \sim T$, i.e. Reality falsifies the Theory, which is unable to shape Reality. What's wrong with this? How does here the Real derive from the Ideal?

The process of ideas $\rightarrow$ tendencies $\rightarrow$ acts $\rightarrow$ facts as explained somewhere on TraditionInAction pages was more intuitive to me.

Cologero on 2014-08-06 at 15:21 said:

Yes, Anthony, that does sound confused. What is a theory and how does it derive from reality?

Anthony on 2014-08-07 at 01:15 said:

Theory is a model approximating reality. For example, Metzinger robots generate a model from set of facts

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hh20JMEI-FI>

Here is all creative part reduced to mere computation.

PS! Those question marks in my previous comment should read as implications.

Cologero on 2014-08-07 at 08:57 said:

I'm afraid, Anthony, that you have understood nothing. You don't know how to engage in a dialog, you don't understand the laws of logic, you don't know what the word computable means, and you don't know what a model is. So, you are on moderation until you can address those issues. For your benefit, note these points:

1) In a dialog, you select a specific point that was made and comment on it. Don't expect me to look at irrelevant links.

2) There is no law of logic that proves a premise from a true conclusion. Specifically, if $p \Rightarrow q$, and we assert that q is true, then it tells us nothing about p .

3) A computable process is an algorithm that will complete in a finite number of steps. There is no such algorithm to go from q to p in the example above.

4) "Approximation" is another word for "false". We already made that point. Viz., although Newton's theory gave good empirical results, it is a false theory. So what? And Newton did not use a computer, so where did his theory come from?

5) A model requires two things: the model and the thing modeled. For example, when I was a boy I used to build scale models of aircraft and motor vehicles (I guess this is no longer a popular hobby). I could compare the model to the real thing, understand the scale, and determine how realistic the model was. You say a theory is a "model". But if you knew "reality" as the thing modeled, you wouldn't need the model, would you?

Apparently your point is that there is no true knowledge, only various mathematical "approximations" that seem to predict phenomena in limited circumstances. And you haven't even addressed the human world. What is your theory of human life and society? Can your robots describe a soul or tell us its destiny? I believe you stumbled upon the wrong web site.

14.14 Esoteric Writing

The prerogative of the human state is objectivity; the essential content of which is the Absolute. There is no knowledge without objectivity of the intelligence; there is no freedom without objectivity of the will; and there is no nobility without objectivity of the soul . . . Esoterism seeks to realize pure and direct objectivity; this is its *raison d'être*.

FRITHJOF SCHUON

The vulgar rationalist, even if he is the man most ignorant of all philosophy, is on the contrary the most eager to proclaim himself such at the same time that he dresses himself proudly with the rather ironic title of “free thinker”, while he is in reality merely the slave of all the prejudices current in his time.

RENE GUENON

Before some audiences not even the possession of the exactest knowledge will make it easy for what we say to produce conviction. For argument based on knowledge implies instruction, and there are people one cannot instruct.

ARISTOTLE

Education is the only answer to the always pressing question, to the political question par excellence, of how to reconcile order which is not oppression with freedom which is not license.

LEO STRAUSS

An exoteric book contains then two teachings: a popular teaching of an edifying character, which is in the foreground and a philosophic teaching concerning the most important subject, which is indicated only between the lines.

LEO STRAUSS

The truth is that the modern spirit implies in all who are affected by it in any degree a real hatred of what is secret.

RENE GUENON

A recently published book, *Philosophy Between the Lines: The Lost History of Esoteric Writing*²⁵, by Arthur Melzer, has brought the ideas of Leo Strauss back to discussion. In the 90s, Strauss was at the center of a small intellectual revival to oppose liberalism and modernity, such as in *Revolt Against Modernity* by **Ted McAllister**, but Strauss' adventitious association with George Bush's policies discredited him and his theories. The result is that "conservative" thought in the USA deteriorated into an anti-intellectualism that, on the one hand, worshiped the ideals of Ayn Rand or Horatio Alger, and, on the other, associated the fate of Israel with normative Christianity.

Nevertheless, Strauss, from a secular perspective, did point out the esoteric nature of much philosophical writing. If anyone should doubt it, Melzer has put online an instructive collection of quotes²⁶ documenting the extent of esoteric writing. Recently, a Persian expert in the medical theories of Avicenna told me that his texts had borders that ran along the top and the left of the page. The main text on the page said one thing, but the real message was crowded into those borders.

There is resistance to this idea, based on the fear perhaps that some horrendous truth may be unveiled. However, a perusal of the appendix will show instead that the esoteric meaning behind a text is at best simply inaccessible to most people. At worst, they are subject to harmful misinterpretations.

Ultimately, the proof of esoteric writing is learned, not by reading, but by writing. A good writer will seem to say one thing, but mean another. There will be clues and allusions in the text that are often difficult to grasp as a whole. The Germans claim, "who says A must say B", but often the writer will say A and leave it up to the reader to infer B. Irony may hide the real message.

²⁵<https://ndpr.nd.edu/reviews/philosophy-between-the-lines-the-lost-history-of-esoteric-writing/>

²⁶http://press.uchicago.edu/sites/melzer/melzer_appendix.pdf

The Necessity The epigraphs have a purpose. The ideal society is a just society, but that requires rulers who are totally objective. How can this be communicated?

People, such as they are, are ruled either by sensation, emotion, or thought. For the first, the only proof required is “I like it” or “it feels good.” Most people today are ruled by emotions, the most disordered part. What they feel “with passion” seems true to them. Now, man is a “rational animal”. That is not a definition, nor is rationality something “added on”. Rather, it is what distinguishes men from animals, which live by sensation and emotion, while lacking intellectuality. Therefore, people to a large extent live as animals. It is difficult to control wild animals. They may respond reliably one day, then suddenly change.

Hence, lies are necessary to protect society from erupting. They act as buffers from the clear light of truth.

Even soi-disant free thinkers, as Guenon points out, are subject to the rule of the mass. For them, rationality falls short of pure intellectuality. Thought is merely a tool for partisanship rather than the support for objectivity.

Hence, as Aristotle says, some people are simply not interested in being educated.

Myths and Legends A misunderstood aspect of esoteric writing is the idea of the “noble lie” described by Socrates in the *Republic*. The key adjective here is “noble”. This noble lie is intended for noble purposes of promoting the common good, and the veneration and protection of the city. The effects of denying this “noble lie” are painfully obvious today, but those details need to wait for another opportunity.

Rather than the term “noble lie”, **Julius Evola** prefers to call them myths and legends. He accepts Bachofen’s characterization:

Symbols and legends, if only in a dramatized form, represent actually and truly the history of the beginnings of a nation, but not

the history of events occurring materially on earth, but rather of spiritual processes that have given birth to a new people alongside other people although different in culture and civilization: history, so to say, of its prenatal period.

Those rationalists who can see no deeper than material historical processes will miss this “third dimension” of history. Myths and legends may be “falsehoods” in a strictly material sense, but in their spiritual effects, they are much more powerful, hence “truer”.

Esoteric Groups So who is eligible to participate in an esoteric group? There can be no *a priori* set of rules, since the presumption is that such men will understand the best rule. We get one clue from Plato. Those who are capable of truly intellectual, objective, and dispassionate thinking will gather together in a special friendship. These friends need the resources and time to participate. Since they are outside the bounds of established institutions and governments, there is the possibility of unintentional conflicts, hence the need for esoteric writing.

At a later period, the Knights Templar took a different approach, although there is not space here to discuss them.

I will give just one more example, the one described by Valentin Tomberg. These “unknown friends” agree to participate in the stream of Hermetism. By following certain meditative practices, they can reach a certain spiritual depth. Those of a like depth will recognize each other, even if achieved in a different way. Rather than being unnecessarily rebellious, Tomberg instead advocated a close relation to the exoteric institution. This is not unlike what Rene Guenon himself advocated.

There are common myths behind such movements which we may address. Meanwhile, readers can entertain themselves by looking for them first.

Posted on 2014-11-30 by Cologero

* * *

Tom Walker on 2014-12-01 at 10:53 said:

But it seems that a lot of Melzer's references are to do with atheists who were intent on hiding their true beliefs e.g. Spinoza, Hume etc.

White Rabbit on 2014-12-01 at 17:23 said:

Perhaps Melzer references all those atheists as a mere mask for the real esoteric meat of his compilation: a subtle pointing to Traditionalism. The plot thickens!

Wayne Ferguson on 2014-12-01 at 18:59 said:

Great article! It's still unclear to me whether he is quoting "Bachofen" (as you seem to indicate above) OR Cesaro (as you seem to indicate elsewhere). See:

<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=3832>

Also, the phrase, "history not of living turned materially on earth" seems rather opaque compared to "the history not of events brought about materially on the earth". Would it be inaccurate to combine the two translations as follows:

"Symbols and legends, if only in a dramatized form, represent actually and truly the history of the beginnings of a nation, but the history not of events brought about materially on the earth, but rather of spiritual processes that have brought to birth, amidst other peoples, a new and different people through culture and civilization: history, so to speak, of its prenatal period."

Thanks...

Cologero on 2014-12-02 at 23:26 said:

Good reconstruction of the quote ... I updated the post.

White Rabbit on 2015-02-04 at 23:12 said:

"Myths and legends may be 'falsehoods' in a strictly material sense, but in their spiritual effects, they are much more powerful, hence 'truer'."

I for one wonder why that needs to be "forbidden knowledge."

White Rabbit on 2015-02-15 at 23:40 said:

Perhaps it's because faith vivifies the imagination. Or maybe I've introduced more confusion.

Daniel on 2017-12-02 at 04:00 said:

It's interesting to read Rene Girard and Leo Strauss against (or alongside) each other on this topic.

Girard's theory is that sacrificial myths are 'lies' told by the lynch mob to mask (even from themselves) the reality of their persecution of a scape goat.

Strauss on the other hand focuses on the need of great thinkers and writers to write 'between the lines' for two audiences (one more conventional the other more discerning) to avoid being persecuted for revealing socially unsettling truths.

14.15 The Philosophy of Chaos

Men love those enticements. The alternative is to purge one's mind of all vain opinions, desires, fears, anxieties, and so on. Men fear to do that, since they believe there will be nothing left, they will no longer have a self or an identity. On the contrary, in that clearing the Spirit will generate a new Self, the Logos, the opposite of the satanic chaos of the mind.

*Day of the Dead and Signs of Life*²⁷

Nothing under the sun is new, neither is any man able to say:
Behold this is new: for it hath already gone before in the ages that
were before us.

ECCLESIASTES 1:10

And from the days of John the Baptist until now, the kingdom
of heaven suffereth violence, and the violent bear it away.

MATTHEW 11:12

Being a review of *Political Platonism*²⁸ by Alexander Dugin.

²⁷<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=5164>

²⁸<https://arktos.com/product/political-platonism/>

Chaos This book is a collection of outtakes. To ruin a mystery, we turn to the end first, where Dugin explains:

Our task is the construction of a philosophy of Chaos.

Dugin has neglected to construct such a philosophy. Chaos is matriarchal, inclusive, anti-hierarchical, anti-violence, and so on; certainly, all ideas opposed by Logos. Unfortunately, Dugin gets off to a bad start when he asserts:

Logos is based on the exclusion of Chaos, on the affirmation of a strict alternative to it.

Logos does not seek the exclusion of Chaos. Rather it seeks mastery over Chaos. That is the masculine way that Dugin rejects. After rejecting some scientific misunderstandings of Chaos, Chaos begins to sound like the prime matter of Aristotle and the Scholastics. As such, it is an object of Thought, not of Being. You can show me a squirrel but you cannot show me a piece of Chaos: it has no Being.

He then claims that Chaos contains all possibilities. We addressed this same issue several years ago in *Chaos in Mathematics*²⁹. Chaitin's Constant does indeed contain all possibilities, but only by accident. Moreover, only the Logos can recognize those pseudo-regularities in the digits of the Constant, although they are actually random.

Dugin gives us two choices: start at the beginning of philosophy or start at the end "when the disappearance and liquidation of philosophy is occurring". Although Chaos is "eternal", there is no beginning, i.e., we can't anticipate the beginning of the next cycle. Hence, we shall start at the End, since we can look back over the history of philosophy from the Greeks, through the Medievals, and into modernity.

²⁹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=4970>

We have documented the “liquidation of philosophy” many times, e.g., from Hobbes, Bacon, Descartes, and so on. Anyone can see that. However, we encounter a serious problem whenever we try to penetrate to the prior period. The Medieval period is opaque to the modern mind, which cannot penetrate into a proper understanding of it. The texts can be analyzed, but the mindset is beyond mysterious. Only a remnant, born with a still archaic mind, can understand that period.

Hence, the fundamental premise that the philosophy of Logos contains the seeds of its own dissolution. Modernity is based on inferior rational thinking, whereas the Tradition of the Middle Ages is based on Being, an intuition of the whole, which is itself beyond logic, yet not illogical.

Tradition Dugin then tries to enlist **Rene Guenon** in support of his unfinished, or rather unstarted, project. This is a tactical error since there is no support from Guenon. Guenon accepts Aristotle and the Scholastics as representatives of Traditional metaphysics. Guenon rejects philosophy. On the other hand, metaphysics is eternally true and does not contain any seed of its dissolution. Moreover, once the metaphysical principles are realized, there is no way to return to error.

As Guenon explains, the unactualized possibilities are included in non-Being. The Void, which seems to be what Dugin means by Chaos, has no Being. Rather, the possibilities reside in the Mind of God as ideas or essences. To develop a philosophy that includes possibilities that can never manifest sounds like a fool’s errand.

Nevertheless, Guenon agrees with Dugin about the decline of philosophy in modernity. Moreover, he also agrees that philosophy declines over time. However, that is not a logical decline. Specifically, it is not an object of Thought but rather a change of Being. There is no inner logic in true metaphysics that leads to Chaos, never mind a philosophy of Chaos.

If there is no inner logic within Tradition that leads to Chaos, then

there must be transcendent forces that bring such changes about. This is documented in *Angels and Demons*³⁰. So, if European philosophy has failed, that is not a result of bad logic. Rather, it is a symptom of the effects of diabolical forces infecting the European mind.

Kali Yuga Chaos, as described by Dugin, has much in common with the time of the Kali Yuga. Specifically, it is undifferentiated. It rejects hierarchy. There is no need to repeat what has previously been described.

Further Openings There are some deeper ways to deal with the idea of Chaos.

The Cabala describes certain world periods as Chaos. In particular, the three world ages—in Christian terms, the ages of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit—correspond to Chaos, Logos, and the Messiah. These refer to Being, not abstract Thought.

Jacob Boehme, Meister Eckart, inter alia, have had intuitions of non-being beyond Being.

The writings of Vladimir Solovyov on the Divine Sophia are helpful. Sophia, as the Soul of the World, keeps Chaos in check insofar as she is immaculate. That gives rise to the Logos.

The point is that there is no philosophical solution to the problem of Chaos. Only a metaphysical one.

This is the second attempt to deal with the philosophy of chaos. A third is probably necessary, because something seems to be missing.

Posted on 2019-11-03 by Cologero

* * *

Jack on 2019-11-04 at 08:04 said:

³⁰<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=11086>

Pro-chaos, anti-Logos. Alright then, good to know I need not waste any time reading anything by Mr. Dugin. Plenty of other good books waiting, nice to check some off the list.

JULIANO P CORREA on 2019-11-04 at 09:02 said:

Your points are some of the conclusions I had that made me return to catholicism, and later on reject esotericism as a whole. Dugin's idea come from his Heideggarian (Heidegger thinks the problem of philosophy is in the very thinking of the Logos) thought that he won't give up, and the result is he become a adherent of the path of the left hand. Your differences with him come down to that, he belives the left hand only is correct, and you that right hand is correct. It seems that Guénon do not like the left hand a lot, but he still identify scholastics as inferior to what he call complete metaphysics, since for him when the absolute God is indetified with Being, like catholic, that is inferior system compared to when it goes beoynd it, like advaita vedanta. This is clear in his book on the vedanta and other texts. The difference comes down to if one thinks that non-being "exists" depending on being as its privation only, or if being comes from non-being. The first is what classical religions say, the second is what esotericism says. The problem with right hand esotericism is simply that it automatically leads to left hand esotericism as it's conclusion.

One discovers than that actually all esotericism is flawed, and everything the church condemned as heresy really is heresy, including Gioacchino da Fiore, Sovyov, and the other "christian gnostics".

Cologero on 2019-11-08 at 09:04 said:

Mr. Correa:

This kind of broad critique, with little idea density, is what we oppose. Instead, we have provided specific examples from multiple sources, over and over again. Some may be misleading, others correct. If you want to make your ideas clear, or engage in some sort of dialog, then choose some *specific* point made in this post and offer your objections or suggestions.

BTW, this is what Guenon wrote of Aristotle in *Introduction to Hindu Doctrine*. Hardly a knee pain, except possibly for you.

They do not in fact appear to have introduced any Hindu Ainfluences, except that contained in the logic of Aristotle—to which we have already alluded in connection with his syllogism—and also in the metaphysical part of the same philosopher's work, in which it is possible to point to intellectual affinities with India far too close to be purely accidental.

Hafez Feizi on 2019-11-10 at 14:00 said:

Cologero, I believe you are showing signs of intemperance for shooing people away the moment they voice some inkling of disagreement. After all the man you just banned is a fellow Catholic Christian, not a neo-pagan or atheist with whom discussion is not possible since they do not share the common grounds for understanding. Furthermore, Juliano was not exhibiting an attitude of toxic arrogance or dismissiveness that you commonly see under the tyranny of opinion prevailing on internet comment sections.

To be fair I can sense that you find it annoying to read a tirade loosely directed against everything laid out on this site without focusing on the particular article in question in a very generalized and broad headed manner. However I do believe his critique, from a Christian standpoint, is not without merit. You should at least give him a chance to defend himself and limit his disagreements to the topics at hand in the future.

Now without agreeing nor disagreeing with the points that he raised, I will state some observations of my own:

What do we mean by esoteric? To my understanding, it is something that comes from beyond the human ability to directly sense (e.g. objects) or intellectually apprehend (energy). Sensible, phenomenal objects are not esoteric. God is not some sort of alien or energy lifeform like today's popular science loves to picture him. This leaves us with the numinal realm of thought and idea forms. To circumscribe the divine in the metaphysics of Being is to restrict it in an entirely impersonal framework of understanding. One of my problems with traditional metaphysicians is that nothing they write explains to me the intensely personal way in which Trinity manifests itself and communicates with the human world through history as described in the Biblical Scriptures. In some sense metaphysics "restricts" God to behaving in an intellectually coherent and to some extent, predictable way characteristic of a systemic branch of reasoning. There is no shortage of "esoteric" doctrines which treat the metaphysical realm as nothing but a collection of impersonal laws, numinal powers and efficient levers that can be rationally assessed and used to influence the world around. The question then boils down to how we can gain power over these forces to willfully effectuate their purpose on the natural world (not excluding our internal realm, in which the occult arts are primarily directed anyway), thus becoming "like gods" ourselves. The purpose of esoteric discipline then becomes a set of rationally accessible alchemic guidelines and rites to transform man into something other than what he is created to be, thereby replacing the Creator's will for mankind's destiny with that of our own, personal making. It was precisely this type of doctrine that Juliano was perfectly justified in denouncing.

Therefore if we are to accept a Catholic, Christian understanding of God, then He has to come from something above and beyond this.

That is why prayer, regular confession, eucharist, asceticism and monasticism are indispensable to the life of the Church. Without them, the Christian existence would have no meaning, no point of reference. Juliano again, was right in saying that morality, understood in its proper sense, is central to the personal mystical communion with God, not esoteric disciplines of any sort,

which might be helpful to some degree in pointing out the right orientation, but are inevitably misleading in and of themselves. Our egotistic desires, not only simple ones such as greed or lust for power, but also hidden, subtle impulses to yearn for the mystical union (which in truth is the origin of all sin) that we do not even readily recognize as such, are the primary reason why God is not manifest in the world in such a way that everyone can openly recognize Him. This is why even the most spiritually enlightened of us have to live our lives in total spiritual darkness, not being able to see or sense His presence around us, staving off the prevailing atmosphere of disbelief and nihilism on grounds of pure faith in something that is essentially missing in this carnival of appearances and smoke. But in no way should “missing” point to the realm of “non-being” or something of the like. And neither should we seek after some kind of substitute under the purpose of following the breath of the spirit (which I can assure you wouldn’t have in this case anything “Holy” attached to it).

Another problem with esotericism is the tendency to create differences and distinctions according to the rank in which one has advanced in the doctrine. Now don’t get me wrong, in general I’m very pro-elitist. Unqualified equality is in my view, an evil thing. But all matters of hierarchy are related with the utilitarian organisation of social order, and as such are not, in my view, part of the role in the realm of the spirit as God intended for humans to occupy. There is an angelic hierarchy in heaven, but to my understanding, humans are not a part of it. Otherwise we would just be lousy versions of Angels, which I doubt Christ would incarnate as to bother saving. Furthermore God never creates something deliberately meant to be inferior, lower versions of already existing things, as that would imply humans to be nothing but.

Now this kind of esoteric hierarchy can allow one to essentially say: “I’ve practiced this doctrine for longer than you, I committed the rites and sacrifices with greater attention and intensity, I have had better success in spiritual matters, therefore I’m placed on an ontologically different level from you.” This is precisely the kind of attitude that the Gospel clearly cuts through when describing the Pharisees. The latter obeyed the law to the letter, prayed for hours a day and performed all the ritual cleansing rites. Yet Christ preferred the company of vagrants, outcasts and prostitutes to them. I wonder why that is?

In one of your posts you state that one of the purposes of life is to acquire esoteric knowledge. I’m not sure if this is a well thought out statement. It can never be the goal of any Christian to acquire anything, except God’s grace, and I don’t see how that requires any knowledge of the occult. What esoteric practices did Mary commit herself to?

Cologero on 2019-11-10 at 15:44 said:

You are doing better than Julian, but not much better. I presume you know what a “straw man” is; this “esoteric hierarchy” – where exactly is it? – is not something I have promoted. At least you pointed to a sentence:

one of the purposes of life is to acquire esoteric knowledge

I don't believe I wrote that, and I certainly don't believe it. So I would have to revisit that quote and modify it or put it in context. From my perspective you have advanced the conversation.

I lost all respect for Juliano when he backtracked on his assertion regarding Aristotle. A man would have acknowledge his error and moved on. Perhaps in this way:

If Aristotle was close to one of the Hindu schools, then certainly Thomas Aquinas would have been, even if by accident. Hence, it could be worthwhile to investigate that school with the intent of deepening our understanding of the issues raised by Thomas. Is that so far fetched? Consider this quote from **Jacques Maritain**, certainly no esoterist from his book *Preface to Metaphysics*:

In view of all this we are shocked if we are told of a knowledge which applies to-day the same fundamental concepts, the same principles as in the days of Shankara, Aristotle or St. Thomas.

So do you super-correct Catholics still want to object to my use of Shankara? I am just finishing the job that Maritain never even started.

As for your many misunderstandings, I have no use for them. If you are no egalitarian, then you should concede that you are the more ignorant partner in this conversation.

Cologero on 2019-11-11 at 11:27 said:

This is from Death and the Real I: <https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=11320>

Acquire esoteric knowledge

So this quote exists nowhere on this site: "one of the purposes of life is to acquire esoteric knowledge"

That suggestion was only for those who want to do the death mediation exercise.

Yet another example of those who cannot even read a simple text, yet come here to complain about our Terms of Service.

Hafez Feizi on 2019-11-11 at 16:17 said:

It's not in my interest to argue with you Cologero. Nothing beneficial will come from it. I concede that on a closer look, I was mistaken in presuming that you claimed "acquiring esoteric knowledge" is the primary means towards attaining gnosis. I would sound very silly if I found

anything wrong with such acquisition in and of itself, since it's the very reason why I find the resources provided in this website valuable.

The substance of my previous post was not even chiefly aimed in your direction, but rather to give voice to my concerns about misguided spiritual development. Far too many times we have been misled by esoteric doctrines and figures which claim to restore traditional principles but subtly belay an empirical materialistic mindset (frequently in form of so called "spiritual materialism"). I do believe some of these men acted in good faith and were admirable figures (such as Baron Evola, Rudolf Steiner, Gurdjieff and others) but in general, their teachings could lead to apostasy and heresy if accepted without condition. It can be extremely difficult to discern truth from falsehood without the guidance of dogma and two millenia of passed down Apostolic tradition. This is why I also strongly contend that it is dangerous and misleading to undertake a serious study in matters of the spirit and the divine without the prior formation of a spiritual bond with said tradition (both on a mental and spiritual level). This would also throw a wrench in the mouths of those critics who accuse you of fraud for promoting "Romish" Christianity while at the same time upholding esoteric spiritual practices that it supposedly never openly endorsed.

Cologero on 2019-11-11 at 16:42 said:

The comment section is not intended to be your own soapbox. I suggest that you create your own blog in which you can share your concerns. I promise to link to it.

But for now, you are under moderation.

Matt on 2019-11-12 at 00:25 said:

Hafez and Julian's comments serve as a helpful reminder to those who come across this site. No one is compelling you to frequent Gornahoor. If you are ultimately bothered by the content offered, it is probably best that you move on. It is not required for one's salvation. But with that said, some lingering misconceptions need to be cleared up.

This site's aim is not to slavishly repeat what was said by Guenon – or any of the other pegged "traditionalists" for that matter. It is not a neo-scholastic manual that inputs an answer from Guenon or Evola on a given question. Gornahoor has engaged the works of these writers, noting their insights, but also pointing out where they missed the mark. More importantly, those men, and the other individuals described as traditionalists, are not the only people whose works this site has explored. There have been dozens of names that have appeared in bold font in the site's posts throughout its existence. Many of those names are the Church Fathers and the saintly mystics. The reason for that is to point one in the direction of their works so that you can read them for yourself and start the process of trying to attune oneself to the state of consciousness that they were in when they wrote those works.

The importance of morality and virtue (the power to do what is right) has never been neglected here. I've lost count how many times Lorenzo Scupoli's *Spiritual Combat* has been

referenced in posts.

Finally, the importance – nay, the necessity – of grace has never been neglected. Pelagius' heresy is not getting a second look here. We are not taking our cue from Valentinus and the other gnostics. Clement of Alexandria said it best when he described gnosis as illuminated faith.

Matt on 2019-11-12 at 00:46 said:

"But all matters of hierarchy are related with the utilitarian organisation of social order, and as such are not, in my view, part of the role in the realm of the spirit as God intended for humans to occupy."

The consensus of the Fathers and Doctors of the Church would beg to differ. If you're a Catholic, you should take heed to what they have written on that.

Deification is at the heart of the Church's understanding of salvation. To be made God-like is no mere flowery metaphor. There are ontological implication that follow from this doctrine. There are a number of posts on this site that tease out those implications. But you don't have to read them, since you can read the writings of the saints and mystics that also show those implications.

14.16 Prejudices of Philosophers

Having kept a sharp eye on philosophers, and having read between their lines long enough, I now say to myself that the greater part of conscious thinking must be counted among the instinctive functions, and it is so even in the case of philosophical thinking; one has here to learn anew, as one learned anew about heredity and "innateness." As little as the act of birth comes into consideration in the whole process and procedure of heredity, just as little is "being-conscious" OPPOSED to the instinctive in any decisive sense; the greater part of the conscious thinking of a philosopher is secretly influenced by his instincts, and forced into definite channels. And behind all logic and its seeming sovereignty of movement, there are valuations, or to speak more plainly, physiological demands, for the maintenance of a definite mode of life.

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE

Multiple Selves

It has gradually become clear to me what every great philosophy up till now has consisted of—namely, the confession of its originator, and a species of involuntary and unconscious auto-biography ... our body is but a social structure composed of many souls.

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE

Jordan Peterson spoke for 45 minutes on the first chapter of *Beyond Good and Evil*³¹. Philosophers, and everyone else for that matter, believe that they are following an impulse to knowledge. Nietzsche challenges that with the assertion that unconscious impulses—perhaps genii, demons, or kobolds—are the real sources of their “philosophy”. But long before Nietzsche, or Jung, or even Peterson, that was the teaching of the esoteric schools. Nietzsche goes further:

With regard to the superstitions of logicians, I shall never tire of emphasizing a small, terse fact, which is unwillingly recognized by these credulous minds—namely, that a thought comes when “it” wishes, and not when “I” wish; so that it is a PERVERSION of the facts of the case to say that the subject “I” is the condition of the predicate “think.”

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE

Again, the esoteric schools developed exercises to locate the sources of the spontaneous thoughts that arise in the mind. For example, Valentin Tomberg explains the foundation of **Patanjali**’s *Yoga Sutras*, a summary of knowledge from several millennia ago:

³¹<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MC0w0eJ84d8>

The “oscillations” (*vrutti*) of the “mental substance” (*citta*) take place automatically. This automatism in the movements of thought and imagination is the opposite of concentration.

Nietzsche is close with the idea of *genii*. Our thoughts may arise, for example, from lower luciferic forces, bodily needs, the collective and personal unconscious, or even from transcendent sources. The higher human soul functions are the intellect and the will. Since Nietzsche rejects the ideal of the Will to Truth, he centres his philosophy in the Will rather than the mind:

Psychologists should bethink themselves before putting down the instinct of self-preservation as the cardinal instinct of an organic being. A living thing seeks above all to DISCHARGE its strength—life itself is WILL TO POWER.

But what exactly does the Will to Power will? Nietzsche criticizes the notion of an Ego that thinks:

What gives me the right to speak of an ‘ego’, and even of an ‘ego’ as cause, and finally of an ‘ego’ as cause of thought?

That is why the esoteric schools teach the very opposite, viz., inner silence rather than thinking. Tomberg explains:

The “oscillations of the mental substance” will never be able to be reduced to silence if the will itself does not infuse them with its silence. It is the silenced will which effects the silence of thought and imagination in concentration. This is why the great ascetics are also the great masters of concentration. All this is obvious and stands to reason.

Concentration is actually the will to power:

True concentration is a free act in light and in peace. It presupposes a disinterested and detached will. For it is the condition of the will which is the determining and decisive factor in concentration.

Nietzsche repeated Epicurus' critique of the Platonists as "actors"; we would say today "larpers". Ironically, the same could be said of Nietzscheans today: if they are not self-critical, they are larpers.

The Hard Problem of Consciousness In an interview with **Roger Penrose**³², Joe Rogan claims to have read Penrose's books.

Even if they are Penrose's more accessible books, that is still surprising. One of Penrose's pet projects is to make consciousness depend on quantum gravity, albeit with no proof whatsoever. There is still no convincing scientific or positivist theory of consciousness; that is why it is considered to be a "hard problem".

But if science is based on the empirical evidence of the senses, then consciousness can never be explained scientifically. One can observe one's own consciousness, but not that of another. Another's consciousness has to be presumed indirectly based on reports and behaviour. That is the point of the Turing Machine³³. It would make more sense to accept that consciousness is fundamental to the universe and not reducible to anything else, particularly anything material.

Animal Intelligence

But the sensual or animal man perceiveth not these things that are of the Spirit of God; for it is foolishness to him, and he cannot understand, because it is spiritually examined. But the spiritual man judgeth all things; and he himself is judged of no man.

³²<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GEw0ePZUMHA>

³³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=8390>

I CORINTHIANS 2: 14-15

The next topic discussed is the idea of animal intelligence. The two seemed quite impressed at the intelligence of animals, which they deemed comparable to humans. The two are unaware that Traditional thinking has always known that humans and animals shared a sensitive soul, so there should be little surprise to see complex behaviour in the beasts. After all, the World was created by Logos, so intelligence is foundational. We address this topic a few year ago in *Scientific and Political Myths*³⁴:

There has been a story circulating in the news about a dog that allegedly gets on a bus alone in order to get to a dog park. People find it fascinating because it would seem to indicate some measure of the dog's human-like intelligence. On the contrary, the real lesson is how little intelligence it takes humans to get through their day. So if you are getting on the bus at the same stop and getting off at another, day after day, you have demonstrated the intelligence of a dog.

The issue is that the intelligence of animals does not choose the ends but only the means. The fundamental ends of animal life are Fear, Sex, Hunger, i.e., repulsion, attraction, and assimilation. Hence, a pigeon can be taught to solve a sequence of seemingly complex puzzles in order to be rewarded with a food pellet; this it will do over and over again. However, it won't be as motivated to learn the Fundamental Theorem of Algebra³⁵.

Then many animal species will engage in complex mating rituals, even risky ones due to competition between males. The threat of danger is also associated with intelligence, including various ruses. Group behaviour needs to follow mathematical Game Theory, since the World is subject to mathematical laws. Otherwise, the species does not survive.

³⁴<https://gornahoor.net/?p=7827>

³⁵https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fundamental_theorem_of_algebra

The point is that animal intelligence is purely instrumental: it is subordinated to the life forces and feelings of the animal. It has no value in itself. Animal intelligence is fixed and repeatable. For example, a bee in a beehive will never rebel against the social structure of the hive by fomenting a revolution, unlike human societies. Bees always act in the same way.

Human Intelligence Aristotle famously defined man as a rational animal. As was shown above, man retains the animal intelligence. To that, however, is added the intellectual soul with the power of rationality. What exactly is it? Human rationality includes the ability to choose one's ends, so that man is not limited to the primary motives of fear, sex, and hunger.

That ability to choose turns the world into a moral world. What is automatic in animals becomes a choice for humans. For example, God commands Noah to "be fruitful and multiply." Animals need no such command, since they will naturally mate (other than perhaps in some extreme circumstances). Man also has the choice to ignore that command; fertility rates in most developed countries are below replacement level.

Hence, we cannot model ourselves on animal behaviour, as many would like to do. Man must choose ends intelligently, not based solely on emotions, unconscious drivers, or other lower psychic functions.

Psychoactive drugs If the intellectual soul is what distinguishes humans from animals, then it is inadvisable to use artificial means to suppress its proper functioning. This includes recreational drugs especially, whether the purpose is to dull consciousness or to accumulate experiences. Unfortunately, this also includes prescription medications, although it is better to take them than to suffer. For some conditions they are mandatory.

Nevertheless, the prevalence of drugs in the population has had an adverse effect on social discourse.

Posted on 2020-01-16 by Cologero

* * *

Anonymous on 2020-01-17 at 16:59 said:

Certainly better thinkers could've been included to demonstrate examples than Joe Rogan and Jordan Peterson. I was quite disappointed with this article.

Cologero on 2020-01-18 at 21:02 said:

The classical style represents essentially such tranquility, simplification, abbreviation, concentration – in the classical type the supreme feeling of power is concentrated. Slow to react: a tremendous consciousness: no feeling of struggle.

The Will to Power #799

Cologero on 2020-01-18 at 23:14 said:

Yes, and I am often quite disappointed in the comments I get.

Max on 2020-01-26 at 11:04 said:

The same could be said of gravity as for consciousness: "There is still no convincing scientific or positivist theory of gravity." Quantum gravity implies gravity-particles, or in other words, old tired atomism resuscitated again. This was a major battle-line between philosophers of antiquity. The theoretical struggle for quantification, or what Guénon calls "the reign of quantity", has to be located within a larger framework of will to power, even if it really represents an inversion through the rejection of agency.

Scientists attempts to reduce gravity to something physical, but that is a dead end. Gravity describes the phenomenon of bodies "falling" towards one another, that is to say, it indicates an absence rather than a presence, or the anti-thesis of space. The experience of gravity is free fall, which does not feel like anything at all, since sensation arises upon impact against another free-falling body, resisting it.

Platonists who are self-conscious of the will-to-power of a philosopher-king does not seem as self-deluded as actors merely playing out someone else's drama. Nietzsche speaks of dogmatic Platonism, although that is only half the story, since the forgotten half is made up of skeptic Platonism.

14.17 Readymade Ideas

L'espoir d'arriver tard dans un sauvage lieu.

ALFRED DE VIGNY, *La maison du berger*

Until now men have torn each other apart for the sake of certain dubious invisible beings that are careful not to call themselves spirits, but 'ideals'. I think the hour has finally come for the war against these invisible enemies, and I would like to play a part in it. For years I have been aware that I was being trained in spiritual warfare, but until now I have never had this clear feeling that a great battle against these damned ghosts is at hand. I tell you, once you start clearing out all those false ideals, there's no end to it. *You've no idea what piles of humbug brazenly posing as truth you have inherited.*

GUSTAV MEYRINK, *The Green Face*

Charles Peguy's *Notes on Bergson and Descartes* has recently been translated into English. He discusses Bergson's notion of the readymade in contrast to the being-made.

Readymade ideas The term readymade was used by French artist Marcel Duchamp to describe the works of art made from manufactured objects. We few are not satisfied with the rearrangement of readymade ideas, like clothes "off the rack". The opposite are not wholly novel ideas, which are really newly created readymade ideas, but rather a deepening understanding of ideas. As Valentin Tomberg put it, there is the "remembering" of old ideas which than get repeated at appropriate time, just like little Jack Horner pulling out the perfect bon mot for every occasion.

The alternative is the resurrection of the idea, to make it part of your living thinking. These ideas are in process of being made since they are “made to measure”. Readymade ideas are from the past and are used to compel being into a pre-existing form, much like Procrustes.

Living thinking is in process.



Philosophical Debate Several years ago, I encountered a man named J on social media, who was a rabid Catholic convert, very super-correct. He was willing to debate anyone on his chosen topics in religion and politics. He “unfriended” me as being unworthy of his intellect. After an extended absence, J has resurfaced, only now as a nihilist, an apostate. A debate between J and J’ would be a spectacle. J is fickle, “*La Donna é mobile*”, yet I persist.

The Internet is replete with such men, who regard debate as a blood sport instead of conversation as a shared experience. They will boast about their IQ scores and the vast number of books they have read, or how much they suffered to reach their conclusions. Thinking is not just a matter of working hard. After all, who works harder than Sisyphus and how far has that gotten him?

Nevertheless, they garner followers who are all too pleased to collect and repeat readymade thoughts. That is much easier than thinking along with someone. Even when I am wrong, it does not suffice to refute me; rather you must dig a little deeper, not join the mob. Peggy makes this point:

To attend a philosophical debate or to participate in one with this idea that one is going to conquer or bring down one’s adversary, or that one is going to see one adversary confound the other, is to demonstrate that one does not know what one is talking about.

It witnesses to a great incapacity, baseness and barbarism. It witnesses to a great absence of culture. It demonstrates that one is not from that country.

Determination of Thinking

My second maxim was to be the most firm and the most resolute in my actions as I could be and to follow no less the most doubtful opinions once I had determined on them.

RENE DESCARTES, *Discourse on Method*

This is his morality of thinking; once an idea has been determined to be true, the philosopher is morally obliged to follow such ideas where they lead. The determined trumps the doubtful. Determination, assurance, and resolution conquer. The vulgar work in the opposite way. They start with opinions and then seek reasons to believe them.

To Walk in a Straight Line Dante found himself in the middle of a forest.

Midway upon the journey of our life
I found myself within a forest dark,
For the straightforward pathway had been lost.
Ah me! how hard a thing it is to say
What was this forest savage, rough, and stern,
Which in the very thought renews the fear.

Descartes uses similar imagery in explicating his second maxim:

I would be imitating travelers who find themselves lost in a forest: rather than wandering about in all directions or (even worse) staying in one place, they should keep walking as straight as they

can in one direction, not turning aside for slight reasons, even if their choice of direction was a matter of mere chance in the first place; for even if this doesn't bring them to where they want to go it will at least bring them to somewhere that is probably better for them than the middle of a forest.

That is where we find ourselves, already in the midst of things, deep in the dark forest with no printed instructions. You may prefer readymade answers but

A great philosophy is not one that resolves the questions once and for all, but one that poses them; that a great philosophy is not one that pronounces, but one that demands.

Sorry if that is not pleasing. Yet it is necessary to move, to walk in a straight line. That is a matter of will. The line you follow might be a matter of luck, or fortune, or perhaps even of grace.

The First Maxim We should not neglect Descartes' first maxim, if the second seems too arbitrary:

The first was to obey the laws and customs of my country, holding constantly to the religion in which by God's grace I had been instructed from my childhood, and governing myself in all other matters — i.e. all the ones not settled by the law of the land or my religion — on the basis of the most moderate and least extreme opinions, the opinions commonly accepted in practice by the most sensible of the people with whom I would have to live.

Again, this is not a matter of proof but of one's will. The alternative is impiety or perhaps pride.

The Great Philosophies Peguy is undoubtedly unique in regarding Plato, Descartes, and Bergson as the world's three greatest philosophies. He explains that all great philosophy has a first moment, which is the moment of method, and a second moment, which is the moment of the metaphysical.

Method

- **Plato:** philosophy of dialectic
- **Descartes:** philosophy of order
- **Bergson:** philosophy of the real

Metaphysical

- **Plato:** philosophy of the idea
- **Descartes:** philosophy of substance
- **Bergson:** philosophy of duration

You can cobble together a worldview from readymade ideas, “found objects”, or you can learn to think.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cGWel7N02Jg>

Posted on 2020-03-26 by Cologero

* * *

Max on 2020-03-27 at 15:37 said:

“Whenever supreme danger reopens the naked issue of ‘to be or not to be’, freedom is elevated from the merely legal sphere to a more sacred plane where fathers, sons and brothers are reunited.” -Ernst Jünger, *The Forest Passage*

Your post inspired me to open a notebook from several years ago and revisit thoughts filed away under the heading "Teaching of the Forest". Beginning with the issue of mind-body dualism, this is what it read:

People think that their thoughts directly "controls" the body. Most enigmas are solved by reframing the question. We fail to know since we do not know which question to ask, and get stuck in habitual modes of being. People believe that it is normal for thoughts to move the body, but that it would be insane if thought had an effect outside the body. That tells me the worldview in question is a mismatch of incongruent ideas, assembled from various sources. Impressions, whether intellectual, sensible or from some other power of soul, are similarly confused. A second-hand world of physical effects, but no adequate idea of causation, is invented. As I continued to walk through the forest, a second danger of perception appeared; to cursorily reduce all to a categorical abstraction, and miss the immediate reality of the thing. Various entities can then be manipulated in the mind, but forgetting how they relate to the world.

The weapon of tyranny is fear, by which it manipulates the masses. In this area, we could use some form of contemporary "demonology" of idea-formation, if people would only believe in such things. It is not possible to combat anything effectively without understanding how the front lines are drawn, which is thus a first priority. Simply taking a step back will show how the mechanism give rise to ever quicker swings of opinion, constantly pending between extreme points of view.

"Anyone who has escaped the clutches of catastrophe knows that he basically had the help of simple people to thank, people who were not overcome by the hate, the terror, the mechanicalness of platitudes. These people withstood the propaganda and its plainly demonic insinuations. When such virtues also manifest in a leader of people, endless blessings can result, as with Augustus for example. This is the stuff of empires. The ruler reigns not by taking but by giving life. -Ernst Jünger, *The Forest Passage*

In the novel "On the Marble Cliffs", the resistance also includes church, ancient nobility, and wise hermits. However, we must also ask ourselves, as Jünger does, what the forest means in a deeper sense. He explains that it is older than human history, the great theme of all traditions, and always present as a possibility even in our own times.

"Here is the authentic substance of history: in man's encounter with himself, that is, with his own divine power. Anyone aspiring to teach history should know this. Socrates called this the most profound place, from which a voice advised and directed him – no longer even with words – his Daimonion. We could also call it the forest.

What would it now mean for a contemporary man to take his lead from the example of death's champion, of these gods, heroes and sages? It would mean that he join the resistance against the times, and not merely against these times, but against all times, whose basic power is fear." -Ernst Jünger, *The Forest Passage*

Boreas on 2020-03-31 at 13:04 said:

Reminds me of the “forest of passions” in the Buddhist imagery, through which one must walk or which must be “cut down”.

In the Kalevala the hero Ilmarinen causes the forest burn with drastic consequences, after he has found the Hidden fire with Väinämöinen. This sounds like a warning for the would be initiate.

Wendy on 2020-04-05 at 11:29 said:

The quote above reminds me of the book Dion Fortune wrote on Glamour. I can't find it, but it basically put forth the idea that we're inheriting spells or disillusionments. She goes into how it is national, personal, etc. There are so many layers to it. It was a unique book because it seemed 'practical' in that it was very obvious. I

14.18 The Limits of Human Intelligence

My point is not to debate the merits of IQ tests, nor of what they measure. I recently discovered that my mother had saved all the school report cards, achievement test results, and an IQ test that I had taken at 10 years old. The IQ test is the motivation.

I can't find out much today about the **Kuhlmann-Anderson Test**, but it consisted of several verbal sections. Unlike other tests, there were no geometric pattern matching, and just one math section, so it was heavily weighted to verbal intelligence. There were two ways to get marked down:

1. Skip a problem due to time constraint
2. Provide the wrong answer

Since the test was timed, there were usually a couple of uncompleted problems. So if the time was extended, perhaps as few as two or three minutes, I would have completed each section. Someone with a higher IQ than mine would have completed the test in the allotted time. That is why **Francis Galton** noticed a correlation between intelligence and reaction time.

So this leads to the first limit, at the individual level. In my case, with more time, I would have scored closer to those much more intelligent than I. However, I suspect that many others would not have performed much better because they still would have made too many mistakes. So their untimed score indicates the upper limit to their knowledge.

Academic Subjects As a student, I always preferred mathematics and hard sciences like physics and chemistry, to other subjects. That is because I never had to study them and had no problems with homework. Those subjects are considered the most difficult at universities. In my life I have tutored students in math, chemistry, and Latin, and had the misfortune to teach algebra to elementary school majors. That leads me to believe that there are hard limits to those students' abilities. Tutoring or teaching could only take them so far, and it is not simply a matter of lack of effort.

I was more successful teaching calculus; the students were self-selecting because they weren't forced to take the course. Even the poorer students could master basic calculus, even if they had to expend much more time and effort than the better students.

So those are the two examples:

- Students who are simply incapable of mastering a subject.
- Students who can master the subject, given enough time and effort

CTMU Christopher Langan, who claims to be the most intelligent man

in the world, has developed a metaphysical system which he calls Cognitive Theoretic Model of the Universe (CTMU). His intelligence claim is based on having an alleged IQ of 195. Langan is prolific with many articles online and youtube videos.

From a high level, CTMU is interesting because the end result is a metaphysical system that looks a lot like Christianity without the dog-

mas, revelation, miracles, or exclusivity. There is God, the devil, an after-life with heaven and hell, morality, and free will. There is also a political component which is basically extreme alt-right; he adds nothing new to political theory.

CTMU resolves all philosophical, religious, and metaphysical questions, if Langan can make a convincing case for it. So far, he has failed to do so. At a superficial level, some claims sound absurd, such as, “God is the set of all sets” and “the universe is a set”. Neither makes sense, but he claims that, in the context of CTMU, they do make sense. He has promised to produce an axiomatic version of CTMU, but it has yet to appear; that could possibly silence his critics (which he accuses of incompetence).

These are the alternatives:

1. He can see CTMU faster than everyone else, who will eventually figure out CTMU.
2. He is so advanced that no other human can possibly understand it.

For a summary, see: CTMU Wiki³⁶.

For a critique, see: *Another crank comes to visit*³⁷.

Hard Limits Are there hard limits to human understanding? If the world is intelligible, should not intelligent beings be able to understand it? Yet we see three issues:

1. Physics is at an impasse. Does it mean that fundamental scientific problems can never be solved?

³⁶https://ctmucommunity.org/wiki/Main_Page

³⁷<http://www.goodmath.org/blog/2011/02/11/another-crank-comes-to-visit-the-cognitive-theoretic-model-of-the-universe/>

2. Metaphysics: Philosophers have debated issues for millennia
3. Politics: No one can agree on the best regime

Politics may well be the most difficult problem, or at least, the one that most urgently needs to be solved. What is the best way to organize a society? How to ensure that the most competent people are placed in positions of power?

The second point is the most baffling. In a democratic system, the masses are simply unable to recognize the most intelligent or most competent because they have no inner scale to make such a judgment. And worse, holding power requires a certain amount of ruthlessness or Machiavellianism, which may be antithetical to the social polity as a whole.

Chinese Civil Service Exam For over a thousand years, China relied on a civil service exam³⁸ to select candidates to work in the state bureaucracy. It was open to everyone. The test included knowledge of Chinese culture and philosophy. This ensured social continuity and restricted civil service jobs to the most competent and intelligent.

That exam has been replaced in the People's Republic of China, with a test that evaluates IQ and general knowledge. See for sample questions³⁹.

It remains to be seen if such a system will prevail.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QA0gjyXG500>

Posted on 2022-08-07 by Cologero

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³⁸https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Imperial_examination

³⁹<https://www.straitstimes.com/asia/east-asia/chinas-civil-service-exam-can-you-answer-these-questions>

Mark Siegmund on 2022-08-08 at 10:29 said:

thanks for an interesting piece...I did not know about Galton and intelligence/speed <https://www.psychologicalscience.org/news/does-thinking-fast-mean-youre-thinking-smarter.html>

additionally, there are at least 3 EPGSIG members who have scored 200+, one of whom, is active on our Thousander FB site

Paulo Adolpho on 2022-08-11 at 21:23 said:

Cologero, there are different types of intelligence, see psychologist Howard Gardner's theory of multiple intelligences. These IQ tests only analyze logical-mathematical intelligence. See the other forms of intelligence, such as musical, naturalistic, intrapersonal intelligence, etc.

m on 2022-08-15 at 11:12 said:

"This ensured social continuity and restricted civil service jobs to the most competent and intelligent."

Like any entrance test that is scored based upon 'subjective' criteria or interpretation, the Chinese exam system was often abused, and open to bribery, political intrigue, and nepotism. Social continuity can be argued, however the most competent and intelligent? That was always an open question.

Compare Feng Menglong's vernacular works, *Stories to Instruct the World*, *Stories to Caution the World*, and *Stories to Awaken the World*... many examples of hapless scholars misused by the exam system, but in the end (usually) triumphed in spite of it. Alternately, stories of once worthy scholars who, after passing exams, became corrupted.

As an aside, I'd advise anyone unfamiliar with the author to approach his Wikipedia entry with a grain of salt. WikiP portrays the author as a kind of nascent 'modern day' liberal, which he certainly was not. Nor were his stories based upon any kind of feminist orientation; especially the White Snake tale, that is now, in China (movies, film and more traditional opera), totally feminist.

Balrog Booger on 2022-08-16 at 13:00 said:

The CTMU is very interesting, but I'm not competent to prove or disprove the mathematical soundness of it. He's addressed the notion of sets before. Regarding that, I'll include two paragraphs from his introduction to the system at the end of this comment. Assess his reasoning for yourselves.

I do think that Langan has become more wise since he gave the interview you linked. I don't know if he would disavow anything in particular that he said here, but his bearing has changed subtly but substantially these past few years.

His notion of a “Human Singularity” (as opposed to the technological singularity) is apt. It’s a different symbolic expression of a worldwide return to Traditional society. He worked in earnest on the CTMU to try and assist in accomplishing that as much as he could, and if the theory is sound, he may have been a critical historical personage. Of course, that assumes that people would heed it if it was sound. We may be already be too corrupt to avert the Great Disaster either way.

I respect the man and appreciate his efforts in building this theory (as I esteem and thank Cologero for all the resources on this site). If there is some unsound part of the CTMU, the proper response is not to throw it out but to repair it. I think assisting in its construction, however we can with our individual abilities, is the solemn duty of our species. Langan is grappling with the Supreme object of knowledge. If you believe his effort is futile, so be it. But if you allow for any chance that such a theory could be built, you are morally bound to help that building. That is my opinion.

“Now for a brief word on sets. Mathematicians view set theory as fundamental. Anything can be considered an object, even a space or a process, and wherever there are objects, there is a set to contain them. This “something” may be a relation, a space or an algebraic system, but it is also a set; its relational, spatial or algebraic structure simply makes it a structured set. So mathematicians view sets, broadly including null, singleton, finite and infinite sets, as fundamental objects basic to meaningful descriptions of reality. It follows that reality itself should be a set... in fact, the largest set of all. But every set, even the largest one, has a powerset which contains it, and that which contains it must be larger (a contradiction). The obvious solution: define an extension of set theory incorporating two senses of “containment” which work together in such a way that the largest set can be defined as “containing” its powerset in one sense while being contained by its powerset in the other. Thus, it topologically includes itself in the act of descriptively including itself in the act of topologically including itself..., and so on, in the course of which it obviously becomes more than just a set.

“In the Cognitive-Theoretic Model of the Universe or CTMU, the set of all sets, and the real universe to which it corresponds, take the name (SCSPL) of the required extension of set theory. SCSPL, which stands for Self-Configuring Self-Processing Language, is just a totally intrinsic, i.e. completely self-contained, language that is comprehensively and coherently (self-distributively) self-descriptive, and can thus be model-theoretically identified as its own universe or referent domain. Theory and object go by the same name because unlike conventional ZF or NBG set theory, SCSPL hologically infuses sets and their elements with the distributed (syntactic, meta-logical) component of the theoretical framework containing and governing them, namely SCSPL syntax itself, replacing ordinary set-theoretic objects with SCSPL syntactic operators. The CTMU is so-named because the SCSPL universe, like the set of all sets, distributively embodies the logical syntax of its own descriptive mathematical language. It is thus not only self-descriptive in nature; where logic denotes the rules of cognition (reasoning, inference), it is self-cognitive

as well.”

Cologero on 2022-08-16 at 15:22 said:

It is presumptive to assume that no one else in the history of the world has grappled with the Supreme object of knowledge. As I just pointed out, that Supreme object has revealed himself as well as the “solemn duty” of humanity. And you are arrogant to set my moral agenda since I have been writing about this Supreme object for 15 years.

Mathematicians view geometry as fundamental, but, alas, there are at least 3 geometries. Which one of them corresponds to reality? That is an empirical question, not a logical or tautological issue.

So if set theory is fundamental, then which one corresponds to reality: ZF, NBG, or CTMU? Until there is an axiomatic version of CTMU set theory, as was promised several years ago, we can’t tell if it is consistent or not. As defined, “containment” is ambiguous as it is understood in two different senses.

What is an object? A set is a mathematical construct, but is it also an object? Apparently. Then so is every circle. Do you know how large the set of all circles is? Are physical things also object? But they are not consistent from moment to moment. How can there be a set whose members cannot be defined? These are just starting points.

There will be more tomorrow, based on a recent online “debate”.

Balrog Booger on 2022-08-16 at 22:12 said:

I said no such thing dismissing that no one else had grappled with the Supreme object of knowledge. I meant only to say that he is performing a work more weighty than the mundane physicist. I explicitly thanked you in the post for doing the same thing in your own way. I did not mean to accuse you of contradicting the task of awakening people to God. In this matter you have done much for me over the years. The fact that you criticize it from the perspective you do rules out true enmity toward it as a true atheist or a demon might have.

As I said in my previous comment, I’m not competent to address the soundness of the CTMU as defined by Langan, nor can I specify which within the three geometries you mention are fundamental. When I say that I think it is the solemn moral duty of people to assist with the CTMU, I shouldn’t have written that comment so carelessly in this way. I don’t see this matter as being something confined to the specific delineated theory of the CTMU, with all its baggage, but rather the matter in question is attaining undisputable specificity of metaphysical truth. The extent to which we can assist in the creation of the True, provable “Theory of Everything,” I believe we are morally bound to do so.

Langan, whatever his flaws, is trying his best to contribute to the true bettering of this world. I believe you are as well, honorable Cologero. Please forgive me if you feel I have been disrespectful or annoying.

14.19 Good Vibrations

When your crazy new age friend tells you that everything is vibration, she is not wrong. But when your hard headed scientific friend tells you that “miracles” are impossible because they “break” the laws of physics, he is likely wrong.

Planck’s equation shows that energy and frequency are directly related; higher frequencies carry more energy. Einstein’s famous equation $E = mc^2$ also shows the equivalence of energy and mass. According to quantum mechanics, particles exhibit wave behavior, so that mass is also associated with a wavelength. These are called matter waves⁴⁰.

These waves are easily observed in small particles like electrons. They have even been observed in some large molecules. There are not two sets of laws of physics. If wave-particle duality is true at the quantum level, it is true for the larger objects of our everyday experience.

Phenomena like bilocation, walking through walls, and disappearing do NOT break any laws of physics, as the attached video shows. If we don’t witness them often, that is because the components of large objects do not vibrate coherently with each other. When I was a boy, I was fascinated by this topic and used to calculate the frequencies of everyday objects, including humans. I did not take into account that there is no physical definition of a human beings, unlike subatomic particles and even molecules.

So the liver has a frequency that is different from that of the heart, etc., not to mention all the free molecules. The point is that a human being is a mixture of vibrations, so that quantum phenomena cannot occur. That does not mean that is impossible, but just that it is unlikely.

⁴⁰https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Matter_wave

A human body is just a possible state of matter, and the body that walked through a wall is another state.

Unless you think that the laws of physics do not apply everywhere, large scale quantum effects are possible. If you think that they have never been witnessed, that is because you deny the study of anomalous events. However, the Cosmos is very large and very old, not to mention that there may be a great many of them. We don't know everything that may have happened.

Metaphysically, there is no distinction between the possible and the real; if it is possible, then it has or will happen. Suppose, just suppose, that a being has control over his corporeal state, so that it vibrates at a single frequency, much like a laser. Then quantum effects can occur.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r1TYHRDuxrY>

Posted on 2022-12-06 by Cologero

* * *

veritycacciatrix on 2022-12-07 at 09:31 said:

"Metaphysically, there is no distinction between the possible and the real; if it is possible, then it has or will happen. Suppose, just suppose, that a being has control over his corporeal state, so that it vibrates at a single frequency, much like a laser. Then quantum effects can occur."

Let's suppose your boomer friend has thrown down yet another trad.physics gauntlet and you don't have time to address every single point, though you would dearly love to, because you can.

One has control over their corporeal state to a far greater degree than average Man, exoteric church, state or medicine would accept, and in fact it is precisely with alignment of 'AVM' that such control is realised.

We're all friends here, we all know AVM is a charge which, when applied through properly resistant purifying processes ignites the chrism.

Plasma physics answers more questions than modern scientism can even coherently ask. Why so resistant to an electrically unifiable/unified perspective?

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mYtXSVOV60w>

Cologero on 2022-12-07 at 22:56 said:

I saw don Genaro disappear in front of my very eyes as if a wind had swished him away. His leap or whatever he had done had had such a profound effect on me that I felt as if his movement had ripped something in my intestines.

Carlos Castaneda

De Bosit on 2022-12-08 at 07:32 said:

"Metaphysically, there is no distinction between the possible and the real;"

taps random spot on desk just had to nuke one of my prison towns. Okay do I have enough karma kredit now?

Ok so, the thing is it's a double edged sword. You can imagine yourself with lots of power and stuff, but at the same time you ignore maybe that you are unconscious cattle being driven to the slaughter, dreaming of being human, just one hard knock on the door and you wake up, grunting.

Thankfully we can transpose scenarios on less dangerous outcomes, like if I imagine throwing thunderbolts, I could to keep this statement true just take credit for some anonymous thunderbolts, or just assume it's true.

When actors play a character very well, they lose touch with reality. What we see on the screen, they actually ARE. Then they have to go home and Tony Soprano has to pretend to be a nice guy again. No wonder he had issues.

Just imagine the angel beaucracy needed to answer all the uestless prayers for gimme gimme gimme and stuff. It has to be made real on some plane or level. If you pray for gold, you might get golden gummy bears, and be content that you got an answer, or remain stubborn until you find yourself enslaved in a gold mine, close to the gold, but never owning it.

Dimitri on 2022-12-08 at 12:03 said:

Is it worth studying physics as someone interested in Tradition, Cologero? If so, where would you recommend starting? Wolfgang Smith, perhaps? Any thoughts on the book *Quantum Reality* by Nick Herbert? Gornahoor appears to be sympathetic to Intelligent Design as well. What do you make of that?

I strongly get the impression that due to the mendacious nature of the the scientific establishment and their apparent commitment to materialistic scientism that there is much more to these matters than what they tell the general public. They project far more confidence and certainty than is warranted. Decent article on this:

<https://apexsnotes.substack.com/p/dont-trust-the-science>

I'm also planning on getting into Rupert Sheldrake's material soon.

Kaukomieli on 2022-12-08 at 12:43 said:

If there exists a what could be called a buddhic field, then the person attempting superhuman feats must realize that beforehand and then put the other “bodies” in complete harmony and unity; reason must be intact, emotions calmed, desires released, and the etheric body and sthula sharira put to serve a single goal of moving the whole being in the infinite field of consciousness apparently outside the limited, diminutive corporeal being. Before that Captain Farebanks does not succeed even if he tried a million times.

Cologero on 2022-12-08 at 19:59 said:

@Dimitri. I am interested in science because I was trained in science. As some recent shows have shown, physics deals with the “gross state”, which is a small part of total reality. Within that domain, it have been somewhat effective. My goal is to show that there is nothing in Tradition that is inconsistent with physics. To do science, you need to start at the beginning. It is long, difficult, and requires commitment. I won’t get involved with various conspiracies. I owe my life to medical technology and effective pharmaceuticals. If drugs fail from time to time, so be it. That’s life.

Dimitri on 2022-12-09 at 15:14 said:

Based on my limited knowledge I’ve seen that Einstein’s physics and quantum physics are not exactly compatible. W. Smith rejects the former. Others seek a unifying theory. What do you make of Einstein?

Kaukomieli on 2022-12-10 at 13:08 said:

@Dimitri:

“What do you make of Einstein?”

His mathematical metaphysics take us to a Kabbalistic world where “spirit and matter” are bridged to make a dimensional apparatus of a numerical and purely quantitative kind. It is truly a sad thing that the divide of Aryan and Judaic physics – and conceptions, politics, art and cultural differences, and economic measures – couldn’t be bridged without the atomic bomb and the cruelest war in history. What could be more convincing than the atomic bomb?